Power to Strive

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A group of Scouts become trapped in a room for twelve hours and are forced to watch Attack on Titan. [No Pairings]

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Introduction
Episode - Fall of Shinganshina Part I
Episode - Fall of Shinganshina Part II
Episode - Humanity's Comeback Part I
Episode - Humanity's Comeback Part II
Episode - First Battle
Episode - The World The Girl Saw
Episode - Small Blade
Episode - Heartbeat
Episode - Left Arm
Episode - Response
Episode - Idol
Episode - Wound
Episode - Primitive Desire
Episode - Eyes Yet to Be Seen
Episode - The Special Ops Squad
Episode - What Needs To Be Done
Episode - The Female Titan
Episode - Forest of Giant Trees
Episode - Bite
Episode - Erwin Smith
Episode - Crushing Blow
Episode - The Defeated
Episode - Smile
Episode - Mercy
Episode - Wall
Episode - No Regrets Part I

Episode - No Regrets Part II
Ymir Speaks
Episode - Ilse's Notebook
Episode - Distress
Episode - The Torturous Curse of Youth

Episode - Fall of Shinganshina Part I

Chapter 1: Fall of Shinganshina Part I

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin or Bleach

Summary : A group of Scouts become trapped in a room for twelve hours and are forced to watch Attack on Titan.

IMPORTANT! PLEASE READ!

This story will contain manga-related SPOILERS and is NOT for ANIME watchers! It was originally posted under the SnK section of FF, but that section has been merged with the anime one. References to things from the manga are mixed in MANY of the chapters! So don't think it's safe because they're only reacting to season 1! **Don't read if you're not caught up with the plot!**

"What do you think this means?" Eren frowned at the note in his hands. "Why would Commander Erwin summon us all of a sudden like this? And what's with all the secrecy?"

"I'm not sure," Petra replied as they walked. "But it must be something important." When they reached the top floor of the castle, they saw Levi and Hange standing before their destination.

"What are you guys doing here?" Hange asked, exchanging a look with Levi.

"We got a note from Commander Erwin saying to come to this room as soon as possible, and not to tell anyone else," Petra explained, holding up her note. "But I saw Eren holding one, too, and we came here together."

Levi frowned. He didn't understand why Erwin would suddenly ask them all to be present. It had to do with the upcoming expedition, he was sure. What else could it be? But hadn't they already decided to keep the info about Sonny and Bean's killer being a fellow soldier between only a trusted few? *What changed his mind?*

"Eren!" Mikasa's voice turned heads.

"What? Were you guys invited, too?" Eren asked, eyes skipping to their faces in surprise.

Levi couldn't keep the incredulous look off his face. *Telling my squad is one thing, they're veterans. Eren, hotheaded as he is, is part of the team, but the newest recruits?*

Hange seemed to be having similar thoughts next to him. "Why did he suddenly think they should be in on it?" She whispered to him. "Erwin never said anything about this at yesterday's meeting. Something must have happened."

"Why are we here?" Jean spoke up. Mikasa and Armin he could understand. They were Eren's friends and maybe they'd been allowed to hang out with Eren and his team. *But what do we have to do with this?*

"Only Erwin knows that," Levi answered him.

"Let's go in and find out," Hange suggested, opening the door.

The room, the last one in the hall, had been cleaned out. Three large couches were placed in a crescent shape in the middle. They were facing a table covered with food, utensils, and pitchers of water as well as a notebook, a pen, and a pencil. Warm sunlight shone

through the high windows and the ceiling light. There was also a door on the right side of the room. What grabbed their attention was the rectangular object in the front.

"What's that?" Hange immediately made way for it. She halted when she reached the table. "There's a note here." She held up the half-folded piece of paper. On it, in black, bold letters were two words: **READ ME!**

"What's going on?"

They collectively turned to see Erwin, the last one to arrive.

"What do you mean, sir? We got your note to come here at this time." Petra displayed the piece of paper and the others followed suit.

"What? I didn't write any note." Erwin was taken back and held up a note of his own. "I got one from Hange saying she figured out—something about tomorrow's objective." Only the other two ranking members caught the near slip. "And to come here only after I couldn't find her and Levi."

"Someone wanted you to show up last so they could trick us into staying," Armin concluded.

"Is someone playing a joke?" Erwin said, frowning.

"They left us food and water and arranged all this. They must want something. Let's see what the note says." Hange unfolded the paper.

Everyone gathered around her.

"Greetings, I have gathered you all here today because I think watching this will help you better understand your situation. I mean, you guys are all about helping humanity and all that dull stuff, right?"

"Dull stuff?!" Eren repeated heatedly.

Hange ignored him. "While I would have loved to stay and watch it with you, I have somewhere else I need to be."

"Watch what?" Connie whispered to Sasha, who shrugged.

"Unfortunately, I can't be in two places at once. I've left you provisions—don't worry, you won't run out—and there's a restroom, too. You'll be able to leave the room in twelve hours. I made sure your absences will not be noted so don't worry about that."

That sent Levi to the door. Try as he might, it wouldn't budge. Armin stood next to him and placed his hand on the wooden surface. "It seems almost new."

Jean came up to him and knocked on it. "Yeah, you're right. It's sturdier than most of the doors here." He tried to push. "Something's not right."

"It might be blocked from the other side," Petra said.

"How could they do that without alerting us?" Christa wondered.

"Hange, finish the note," Erwin said. "It might tell us."

Of course, the next line was: "Don't bother trying to escape. You can't. And why would you want to? You wanna know more about Titans and increase your chances of survival, right? Well, I'm going to serve the answers to you on a silver platter. Or a black TV, I guess."

"So that thing's called a TV," Armin muttered, eyeing the mysterious object.

Hange kept reading. "There was a limit of twelve and I chose all of you."

"Why us, though?" Jean couldn't figure it out. "I mean, we don't have ranks and we only joined the Corps about a month ago."

"Now settle down and turn it on. The remote's on the table. You only have to point it at the TV and hit the power button. It's all pretty self-explanatory. So, have fun! And remember, nothing is set in stone. But actions have consequences. Peace out, Candy."

Ymir raised an eyebrow. "Candy?"

"That's what it says." Hange showed it to them. On the bottom of the note was a cartoonish drawing of a girl making the peace sign.

"What do you think, Erwin?" Levi turned to him.

"I'll be honest, I'm intrigued. Let's watch it." Erwin was eager to see the answers Candy promised. And it wasn't like they could go anywhere. They all quickly settled into their assigned seats, a little surprised Jean, Armin, Mikasa, and Eren got the middle. On the couch to their left sat Ymir, Christa, Connie, and Sasha. The right couch seated Petra, Levi, Hange, and Erwin.

The commander picked up the innocuous remote and studied it. It was black in color and had little buttons with white markings and numbers. At the top, a red button with "Power" written under it caught his attention. Erwin pointed the remote at the TV and pressed it.

Gasps came from around the room as the screen lit up.

Eren flanked by Armin and Mikasa took up the frame with other members of the 104th class in the background, lit up by an explosion.

"I guess we know who the main characters are," Ymir said. It explained the seating, too.

Hange let out a shrill noise in excitement. "Hurry up and start it!"

Erwin didn't need her to tell him twice.

On the black screen, words appeared along with a feminine voice. ***"Hello, I'm Candy, and I'll be the narrator!"***

"She sounds young," Petra said.

Candy cleared her throat and began ominously. *"Humanity was suddenly reminded that day..."*

"Holy shit," Jean said with wide eyes at the sight of the Colossal Titan looking over the wall, the shocked little humans, the young trio included, stood frozen in horror.

"...of the terror of being at their mercy."

Silence fell over the room, mouths falling open.

Hearing about the Colossal Titan was one thing, seeing it was a whole 'nother matter. Eren, Mikasa, and Armin tensed, knowing where it was headed and mentally braced themselves for what was to come.

"The humiliation of being caged is what triggers them to fight back."

The screen cut to the image of horses racing through a forest in a storm. "All soldiers, prepare for battle!" The commander yelled.

The members of the 104th class couldn't help but feel a sense of familiarity from the man.

"We have one target! We will slay it and claim this spot as humanity's first stronghold beyond the Walls!"

"This is so amazing," Christa said while they all stared in awe.

"Target approaching!"

"Erwin, that's you!"

"Way to state the obvious, Four-Eyes." But even Levi didn't deny the excitement and amazement he felt.

" **Split into five groups just as we practiced!" The commander ordered. "We'll act as the bait! All assault squads, switch to 3D Maneuver Gear! Strike from all directions at once!"**

A young man was the first to approach the Titan. He attacked from behind, blades swirling. "Taste the power of humanity!"

The sun shining on flowers was disrupted by images of blood, a Titan's teeth, a stone building with a windmill that became overrun by Titans, a red uniform, children's toys, a bee in a human eye, a close-up of a creepy Titan smile, and someone being plucked from the ground.

The images zoomed by quickly and then a young Eren woke with a gasp.

"Did you dream that?" Armin asked Eren.

"I...don't know. I can't remember." Shock and confusion coursed through him. Had he seen the future? Was that even possible? Then again, he could turn into a 15-meter behemoth and had crazy regeneration abilities.

"I'm sure it'll explain," Mikasa whispered softly from next to him. She was the only other person who could have recognized that haunting sight of Carla being killed.

"Mikasa?"

"We should be heading back."

"What are we doing here?"

"You were that deep asleep that you're still only half-awake?"

"No," Eren replied. "It just feels like I had this really long dream or something."

"What was it about?"

"I can't remember."

Mikasa went to grab her firewood, then looked at him in surprise. "Eren, why are you crying?"

"Huh?" Eren touched his face in confusion.

"If I saw that I'd cry, too," Connie muttered. "Creepy!"

[Year 845 - Shinganshina District]

The atmosphere was peaceful. People moved about without worry, going on with their lives. Children ran around, laughing and playing.

"Listen! It was by the goddesses' great wisdom that the Walls were built! The Walls are their divine work! No one must be allowed to defile the Walls!"

The preaching got the frowns and eye-rolls it deserved.

"Don't tell anyone. About me crying." Eren sulked a little, head down as he walked.

"Too bad for you," Jean said, smirking. "Now we all know."

That earned him a glare from Eren.

"I won't," Mikasa said. "But crying for no real reason, you should have your dad give you a checkup."

"Don't be stupid! I can't tell him!"

"What are you cryin' about, Eren?" A tall man, a Garrison soldier, walked up to them.

"Hannes!"

"Did you get scolded by Mikasa?" Hannes's cheeks were pink and his words a little slurred.

"He's drunk," Levi said in disapproval.

"Huh?! What makes you think I was crying?! Whoa," Eren said and jerked way, hand over his nose, "you reek of booze!"

"Come on, it's cool." A voice came from behind Hannes. Three Garrison soldiers were playing cards, a bottle of alcohol in plain sight, laughing without a care.

"How undisciplined." Although Petra was not the least bit surprised.

"You're drinking again?" Eren stared at the scene with wide eyes.

"Why don't you two join us?" Hannes teased.

"Well, uh...don't you have work to do?"

"Yup! We're guardin' the gate today!" Hannes said proudly. "We're stuck here all day, so we end up getting hungry and if some booze happens to get into our drinks, so what? It's no big deal."

"If I find any of you slacking and drinking while on duty, you'll get my boot up your ass," Levi barked at the teens, making them shrink.

"And will you be able to fight if something happens?!" Eren demanded.

"And when would that be?" Hannes looked honestly confused.

"Isn't it obvious?! When *they* break the Walls and storm the city!"

"Damn, Eren." Hannes touched his forehead. "Don't start yelling so suddenly."

One of the Garrison soldiers stood and walked up to them, laughing, just as drunk as his comrade. "You're lively, doctor's son! If they do bust down the Walls, we'll take care of business, don't you worry. It's never happened, not once in the last one hundred years."

***"Not* quite *true,"* Candy said.**

"Whoa! What does that mean?" Connie yelled, whipping his head left and right.

"How come we've never heard about this?" Mikasa asked.

Christa stared at the veteran Scouts. "Have Titans broken in before?"

They were just as shocked by that revelation. "But...if Titans came inside the Walls before, shouldn't we know?" Petra said. "Something like that isn't easily forgotten."

Erwin pressed his lips at that, mind racing.

"Hey, Candy, what does that mean?" Jean asked the TV, on the off chance she might answer.

No reply came.

"She's the narrator, remember? If it's like a story in a book, it's pre-recorded," Armin pointed out.

"Let's hope it's revealed later on," Hange said. "Now shush! I wanna get to the Colossal Titan part."

"Still, my dad says there's nothing more dangerous than being complacent like that!"

Levi nodded. "Smart man."

"Dr. Yeager, huh?" Hannes looked reminisce. "Yeah, he's got a point. He once saved this town from an epidemic. I can't argue with him."

"Really?" Sasha asked. "He did?"

Mikasa nodded. "It was before we were born. Not surprising you don't know since it affected only our town."

"So," Ymir said, "this hero thing runs in the family, huh?"

"Still," Hannes said, " *they're* another story. When you're a soldier, you get to see those things roaming around outside while you're on Wall reinforcement duty and stuff. The Walls are fifty meters tall, though. I can't see 'em do anything about it."

"All this talk about the Wall being impenetrable, it's like you jinxed it," Ymir said.

"Ymir," Christa said, tone lightly scolding.

"What? I'm just saying."

"W-Wait... So you're saying you don't even have the resolve to fight them to begin with?" Eren demanded.

"Pretty much!" Came a cheerful reply from Hannes.

"Wh-What?!" Eren said indignantly. "Then drop the 'Garrison Regimen' name for 'Wall Construction Squad' instead!"

Laughter came at that remark.

"Good one, Eren!"

The other Garrison soldier thought it was funny, too. "That doesn't sound half bad."

"But you gotta understand, Eren, if a soldier's doing his job, things have seriously gone to hell. It's better when everyone's calling us useless freeloaders. It means peaceful times for us all."

"You know, in a weird way, I can kinda see his point," Hange admitted. "Of course, it would only hold merit if Wall Maria wasn't breached."

"Sure, we can stay inside the Walls our entire lives and do nothing but eat and sleep! But that basically makes us cattle!" Eren yelled, scowling.

The words seemed to strike a chord with Hannes, although the other soldiers laughed. "Man, you're one plucky kid! For someone who's totally helpless! Right, Hannes?!"

"Huh? Y-Yeah."

Eren kept his head down and walked away, Mikasa right beside him.

"Hey, Eren," Hannes called out, but he was ignored.

"What a strange kid," one of the soldiers commented.

"Don't tell me...does he wants to join the Survey Corps?" Hannes stared after him.

"I'm honestly impressed, you've known exactly what you wanted since you were a kid," Petra said.

"Most were against my decision from the start," Eren replied, shooting Mikasa a look.

The two children continued to walk in silence, until Mikasa finally spoke, "Eren, I'd forget about the Survey Corps if I were you."

"See?" Eren nodded.

Mikasa only shrugged.

"What? You're gonna look down on them, too?"

"It doesn't have anything to do with how I see them—"

Bells began ringing in the distances. "The Survey Corps is back! They're gonna open the front gate!" Eren grabbed Mikasa's hand. "Let's go see the heroes return, Mikasa!"

"Oh, I can just tell this is not gonna be good," Sasha said nervously.

"Ohm! Damn! I can't see!" Eren spotted some crates and they ran toward them.

A defeated Erwin caught sight of Eren's hopeful, bright-eyed smile and looked away, confusing the child.

"Hey, do you remember that?" Hange asked him.

"No. My mind was... That expedition was a massive failure," Erwin said with a shake of the head.

Almost every single soldier walked broken, bloodied, and bandaged. It finally seemed to hit little Eren.

"They're the only ones who made it back?"

"Everyone else must've gotten eaten."

"This is what they get for going outside the Walls."

"Moses! Moses!" A frantic feminine cry came from the crowd.

Erwin sighed. "This I remember."

"Yeah..." Eren agreed, Mikasa nodding next to him.

"Excuse me, I don't see my son, Moses, anywhere. Do you know where he is?" The woman walked up to the commander.

"This is Moses' mother. Go get it," he ordered.

The viewers shifted uncomfortably, apprehensive at what was about to happen.

She stared down at the bloodied sheet, unsure. Carefully, she began to unwrap it—then gasped, trying to quickly cover up the appendage. Pain filled whimpers escaped her as she sank to her knees, clutching what was left of her son.

"That's awful." Christa covered her mouth.

"It's all we could retrieve." The commander knelt before her.

"But my son...he carried out his duty, right? Even if he didn't achieve direct greatness, surely my son's death helped humanity to fight back, didn't it?!"

"Of course!" Then he faltered, looking dejected. "No… On this latest scouting mission, we…" He gritted his teeth and screamed, eyes shut. "No! Just like all the other missions we achieved nothing at all!" Tears streamed down his face. "My incompetence has done nothing but needlessly send soldiers to their deaths! We haven't found out anything about them!"

"Oh, man," Connie said, wincing.

"That's not something you say to a grieving parent." Petra shook her head. "Saying that their child died in vain."

"Yes," Erwin agreed. "Keith should have kept it together." It was simply not how a commander should act, especially in public.

Realization dawned on Ymir's face. "I knew he looked familiar!"

"Wait a minute!" Sasha gasped. "Keith? As in Keith Shadis? As in our *instructor* ? He was the Survey Corps' commander?"

"That's him," Erwin replied. "After this, he resigns from the position and starts instructing the trainees."

"Didn't recognize him with the hair," Jean muttered.

"No wonder he has such crazy eyes," Connie said.

It made more sense now, how strict and ruthless he was in training them, so they'd have the skills they needed to survive.

"The poor man." Christa felt bad for him.

That expedition really did a number on him. Armin thought.

"What a mess," a civilian said.

They could tell from the tone it wasn't going to be good.

"You can say that again."

"Our taxes are basically going to feeding and fattening those *things* up now."

Looks of disgust were shot at the TV.

The judgmental jerk let out a squawk, holding his head. "What the hell, you little punk?!" He turned to see an angry Eren holding a stick.

"Good job, Eren." Hange gave him a thumbs-up.

"Serves him right," Petra said.

Levi didn't say anything but silently agreed.

A hand reached from around the building and yanked him back. "H-Hey!" Eren cried out. "What are you doing, Mikasa?!"

"Get your ass back here!" The man yelled while Eren was dragged away.

"Mikasa, this is far enough, isn't it?!"

Without a word, she launched him into the wall.

Levi raised an eyebrow at the impressive display of strength. His couchmates sent the girl curious looks as well. *Maybe rumors of her skills equaling a hundred soldiers weren't exaggerated after all.*

"What was that for? Now the firewood's all over the place." Eren began collecting the firewood.

"Eren, have you changed your mind about joining the Survey Corps?"

Eren ignored her question. "Help me pick this up."

"There isn't much to begin with." Mikasa knelt and started picking up the firewood.

Nostalgia welled in Eren and Mikasa at the sight of their home. Emotions closed up in their throats as they leaned forward.

"We're home."

"Welcome back," Carla greeted and smiled, looking over her shoulder.

Tears welled up in Eren's eyes but he forced them back. He did not want to waste a second of this, a chance to see his mother again.

"My, Eren, I see you've worked harder than usual!" Carla remarked.

Guilt squirmed in his stomach. That wasn't quite how he remembered her face. *How could I forget my own mother's face?*

Eren emptied out the firewood into a wooden box. "Yeah."

Petra giggled. "She knows you're lying."

Carla pulled his ear for a second. "Your ear's red, that shows that you're lying. You had Mikasa help you, didn't you?"

"Busted." Connie laughed.

"My mom always goes on about her mother's intuition and all that when she catches me lying," Jean said, smiling.

Eren sat at the table with Mikasa and Grisha, stuffing his face. "Oh? You're leaving, Dad? Is it for work?"

"Yes. Some checkups in the interior. It'll take a couple of days."

"Wait," Hange interrupted, "if your father had connections there, and a good reputation from when he saved the town, surely he could have taken you two to the interior. If he's half as good as you claim, his skills would have been highly valuable." Doctors were in high demand, after all.

Eren exchanged a look with Mikasa and shrugged. "We don't know. I hope this tells me what happened to him."

"Eren says he wants to join the Survey Corps," Mikasa said, eyes downcast.

"Subtle," Ymir snorted.

The atmosphere changed immediately.

It had felt like the right thing at the time. Now, watching it, Mikasa couldn't help but think maybe Ymir was right, she should have had a little more tact.

At the same time, Eren couldn't help but notice the expression on little Mikasa's face. He'd been too shocked and annoyed before to really notice the emotion shining in her eyes.

"M-Mikasa! I told you not to say anything!"

"Eren! What are you thinking?!" Carla walked over to him, grabbing his shoulders. "Do you have any idea how many people have died outside the Walls?!"

"I do!" The little boy said.

She was just worried about me because she loved me. The only reason he'd survived was that he turned out to be a Titan-Shifter. He'd been so arrogant. If he hadn't had those extraordinary abilities and Wall Maria hadn't been destroyed, was that how his first expedition would have ended? Suddenly, the scene with Moses' mother came back and hit Eren harder.

"Then why—"

"Eren," Grisha interrupted his wife, "why do you want to go out there?"

"I want to know what the outside world is like!" Eren replied passionately. "I don't want to live my entire life in ignorance inside the Walls! Plus if no one else is willing to take their place, then the lives of all who've died will be for nothing!"

"Hm, not bad," Levi commented.

"Meaning he's very impressed," Petra said.

Eren felt a rush of pride at that.

"I see." Grisha stood and walked away. "The boat's about to leave. I better get going."

"Hold on, dear!" Carla followed after him. "Talk some sense into Eren!"

"Carla, words can't hold back human curiosity."

"Wise words," Hange said in agreement.

"Eren, when I get back, I'll show you the basement that I've kept secret all this time." Grisha pulled out the key hanging from his neck.

Eren smiled excitedly. "R-Really?!"

Grisha tucked the key back under his shirt.

"When exactly does he give you the key?" Erwin asked Eren.

"It's...my memories are a little messed up. I don't really know."

Hange groaned. "We're gonna have to wait forever before we get to the really good part!" If this really was focused on the trio, there were still their training years to go through before they got to the Battle for Trost.

"Take care!" Eren waved happily.

"Just forget it," Carla said. "Joining the Survey Corps is a stupid idea!"

"Huh?! Stupid?! People who don't mind living like livestock are the stupid ones if you ask me!" With that, Eren took off running.

"I'm an idiot." Eren groaned. *Why did I have to be such an asshole to her?* He wanted to reach into the TV and hit his younger-self.

"Eren!" Carla called out. He rounded the corner, out of sight. She turned to the little girl with hopeful, expectant eyes. "Mikasa, he gets himself into trouble so easily. If anything ever happens, you need to be there for each other!"

"Okay," Mikasa said and nodded.

Eren stiffened. *Is that why she always obsesses over me? Because it was the last thing she promised my mom?* More guilt swirled in him, recalling all the times he'd snapped at her for her needless fussing. All because she was fulfilling the promise she made to his mother. But he, too, wanted to honor his words to his mother about protecting Mikasa, and it had made him angry that she'd try to take care of him instead of the other way around. They were both trying to do the same thing and it always caused fights. *I really am an idiot.*

"What's the matter, heretic?!" A bully pushed Armin into a wall. "If you don't like it, let's see you hit back!"

"Y-Yeah, right! That would be stooping to your level!"

"What was that?"

"You know I'm right! That's why you have to resort to violence! Because you can't argue back! Which means you concede defeat to me, does it not?!" Armin said angrily.

Ymir rolled her eyes. "He's too stupid for that."

"He's a bully," Jean said. "Saying that will only get you more beat up."

"Shut up, smart-ass!" He raised his hand to strike Armin.

"Told you."

"Stop that!"

"It's Eren!"

The bullies got excited.

"That idiot's back for more?!"

"Does he want his ass kicked?!"

"We'll tear you a new one!"

"Ever the Suicidal Bastard, I see." Jean snorted.

One of them squinted and said, "M-Mikasa's with him!"

"We're screwed! Run!"

Laughter broke out as just the sight of her made them run with their tails between their legs.

"One look at me and they ran off!" Eren said arrogantly.

Everyone, except an embarrassed Eren, continued to laugh.

Even Levi seemed amused by the scene.

"No, it was Mikasa they saw—ow!" Armin winced.

"Hey! You okay, Armin?" Eren offered him a hand.

Armin looked at his friend's outstretched hand and hid his emotional face by looking at the ground. "I can get up on my own."

"Oh, alright."

Armin shifted in his seat, uncomfortable with his comrades seeing him so weak.

Golden-orange rays highlighted the houses as the three friends sat near the water. "I said humanity needs to venture into the outside world at some point and then they beat me up and called me a heretic," Armin told them.

"Damn, why does everyone look down on people just for wanting to go outside?!" Eren tossed a pebble in the water.

"Well, because we've had a hundred years of peace by staying inside the Walls. They're worried that going outside carelessly will invite them in."

"Hmm…"

"Was that Candy?" Connie asked.

"It sounded like her," Christa said. "What could it mean?"

"I'm sure we'll find out." Hange waved at them to shut up. They were almost there. She could feel it.

Eren, Mikasa, and Armin shifted in their seats.

"The Royal Government's policies have made having any interest in the outside world a taboo," Armin said.

"It's our lives! We can risk 'em if we want!" Eren said angrily.

"I won't let you. You can't." Mikasa looked over her shoulder.

"Oh yeah!" Eren remembered. "I can't believe you told my parents!"

Armin looked lost. "Huh?"

"I never agreed to help."

"Heh, sneaky," Sasha said, grinning.

"So, what did they say?" Armin asked.

"They're less than pleased."

"It figures."

The wind began to blow softly, clouds moved lazily in the sky.

The trio's faces took on guarded expressions.

"Indeed, I think people are crazy if they think we'll be safe inside these walls forever," Armin said.

"Mommy!" A little kid ran into his mother's arms, happy.

"Just because the Walls haven't fallen for a hundred years doesn't guarantee that they won't fall today..."

Children laughed and played in the background.

"...not one bit."

"Here it comes," Ymir muttered too softly for anyone to hear.

A woman stood on the roof, baby in her arms. Thick silence filled the screen.

They tensed, waiting for the inevitable explosion.

Seconds passed by, a shot of the Wall appeared, peaceful and undisturbed.

Then lighting struck, loud and fast, making their hearts jump.

Most people were knocked off their feet by the sheer force. They looked at the smoke coming from the other side.

"Wh-What was that?" Armin said.

"An explosion?" Eren turned.

"That way!" Someone behind them pointed.

"Did something fall?!" Someone said.

"I'm not really sure." Another answered.

Armin ran after them and Eren called out to him. "Hey, Armin!" They followed him into the plaza. "Just what are you staring at?" He followed their gazes. Ominous music began playing in the background as a massive red hand clutched the Wall, creating cracks.

"The moment I've been waiting for." Hange clicked the pen, ready to take notes while her eyes stayed glued to the TV.

"It can't be! Th-That wall is fifty-meters high!" Armin stared fearfully.

"It's one of them." Eren gasped. A large shadow fell over them as a mammoth face stared down at them. "A Titan!"

Hange began scribbling like crazy, watching how it kicked Wall Maria.

The strong gales shattered windows and sent people flying, ripping off parts of homes. Debris flew and crushed some humans trying to flee.

Wasn't that one of the boys bullying Armin? Christa thought, feeling a mixture of sadness, glee, and guilt.

"Th-They b-blew a hole in the W-Wall," Armin stuttered, on his knees.

The first Titan entered, a wide grin on its face.

"They're inside!" People panicked and ran.

"The Titans have gotten inside!"

"We need to run, too—Eren!"

Eren staggered away. "My house is…my mom is…"

Mikasa chased after him, ignoring Armin's call.

That must be so terrifying . Ymir thought somberly.

Jean swallowed with difficulty. It had been hard enough experiencing a Titan invasion in Trost at their age and after having received training. He couldn't even imagine how much more intense the fear he would have felt in Eren, Armin, and Mikasa's situation.

Armin stared at his shaking hand, clutching it to stop the trembling. "It's all over. Countless Titans are going to overrun the city!"

There's no way our home got hit **. Eren stared in fear at the chaos around him as he ran. People screaming, children crying, blood, boulders, and destruction, everywhere he looked it was a nightmare.** ***Just around this corner, our house is standing there, like always!***

Eren and Mikasa became distressed at the sight before them.

Mikasa pulled up the scarf, squeezing Eren's hand, who already had tears streaming down his face, not caring who saw.

But everyone was staring at the scene in silent horror, unable to look away.

"Mom!" Eren ran over to the destroyed house. "Mom!"

Carla weakly opened her eyes, lower half of her body buried under the rubble. "Eren."

"Mikasa! Grab that end!" Eren grabbed a piece of the rubble. "We gotta move this pillar!" Footsteps boomed around them. They looked up to see many giants over the roofs of the houses, wandering around.

"Hurry, Mikasa!"

"I know!"

"The Titans have gotten inside, haven't they?" Carla began fearfully. "Eren, take Mikasa and run away! Hurry!"

"I want to!" Eren grunted, trying to force the wreckage to move. "I want to run away! Get up already!"

"The debris has crushed my legs," Carla continued, almost dazed. "Even if I could get out, I wouldn't be able to run. You understand what that means."

Christa sniffed and Ymir put a comforting arm around her.

Connie and Sasha—the only two who had not been so awed by the TV that they forgot about the food and had helped themselves—pushed their plates away, suddenly losing their appetite.

"I'll run away carrying you, then!" Eren screamed, tears in his eyes.

"Why don't you ever listen to your mother?!" Carla yelled back. "You can at least do this one last thing! Mikasa!"

The young girl bowed her head, crying, too. "No, No!" A pair of legs was seen.

"If you don't go, all three of us will—" A familiar sound of wires was heard. "—Hannes!"

Relief surged in most of the viewers.

"Take the children and get out of here!"

"I can't have you thinking I'm a small man, Carla. I'm gonna slaughter the Titan and save all three of ya!" Hannes declared confidently.

It was dumb, what she was feeling. Petra knew Eren's mother was going to die. He'd told her so himself. Still, a glimmer of hope survived.

Levi, ever the pessimist, had to dash everyone's hopes. "He's never fought a Titan before, hasn't even seen one up close. And after years

of neglect and laziness, he's out of shape. I wouldn't hold my breath."

"Wait! Don't fight them!" Carla begged.

Hannes pulled out his blades, running toward the Titan. *She's right, I could save those two for now for sure. But I'm finally going to repay the favor I owe!*

"Favor?" Petra wondered.

"When my dad saved the town from the plague, Hannes's family was among them," Eren said.

Hannes came to a grinding halt, staring at the looming mass that grinned creepily down at him, terror clear on his face, feeling suffocated as if it were just him and the Titan. Quickly, he sheathed his swords and turned back.

I knew it. Levi was not the least bit happy about being right.

Some were disappointed, even if they understood it.

"Hey! Hannes!" Eren screamed when the older man grabbed him, then moved to Mikasa. "What are you doing?!"

At least he saved the children. That was more than Petra could expect from someone who had never intended to fight Titans, especially in the most catastrophic event in known human history. *He'd only have gotten himself killed. This way, at least he was able to do some good.*

"Thank you." Carla smiled, relieved.

"Hey! Mom's still!" Eren reached out for her, sobbing.

Carla mimicked the action, holding out her arm. "Eren! Mikasa! You have to survive!" A happy image of her family flashed

through her mind. She retracted her arm, trembling, covering her mouth to smother her words. "Don't go."

Strangled gasps escaped Eren and Mikasa.

Armin's stomach dropped.

The Titan stood firmly behind her. Reaching down, it moved the rubble aside with ease and picked her up. "Stop!" Carla struggled to break free.

It brought its other hand up and snapped her spine, a horrified Eren still watching.

The soldiers were agitated, itching to jump into action, knowing it was futile. It was all already said and done.

Putting the limp body in its mouth, it chomped down. A fountain of blood exploded in the air.

Jean, Sasha, and Connie immediately thought of their own mothers, of what it would have been like to be in Eren's place and watch the nightmare unfold before their very eyes.

Petra was grateful her mother had died when she was too young to remember, and not in such a violent manner.

All Levi could think about was how silently his own mother had passed away, not at all like the loud, bloody, and visceral death he'd just witnessed.

"Humanity was suddenly reminded that day…"

The Titan swallowed, looking gleeful.

"…of the terror of being at their mercy. Of the humiliation of being trapped inside a cage."

The screen faded out to black before the play button on a new thumbnail showed up.

"Eren?" Petra knocked on the door and waited for a response.

On the other side, Eren splashed cold water on his face and dried it with a towel. Taking a deep breath and looking in the mirror, he morphed his face into the expression he wanted: neutral. He opened the door and spoke before she could. "I'm okay."

"I doubt that," she said, a knowing look on her face. "Here, have some water."

Grateful, he gulped it down. Looking over her head, Eren saw his comrades sitting nervously while his superiors talked quietly among themselves. Armin was consoling a grief-stricken Mikasa in the corner. Sensing his eyes on them, they looked up and made their way toward him. Petra silently rejoined her captain, giving them some privacy.

Eren cleared his throat. "Sorry about that."

"There's nothing to be sorry about." Armin shook his head. His eyes were red and puffy from crying.

"Are you okay?" Eren asked Mikasa, and she nodded mutely, scarf no longer concealing half her face. "Alright, let's not keep everyone waiting then." With another deep breath, they took their seats.

Erwin hit play and started the second episode.

Please Review~

Episode - Fall of Shinganshina Part II

Chapter 2: The Fall of Shinganshina Part II

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : A groups of 12 Scouts are tricked into a locked room for 12 hours by a girl named Candy. She tells them they can learn about the Titans' secrets and they begin watching *Attack on Titan* .

"Over a century ago, humanity faced a new enemy."

Humans armed with spears stood against numerous Titans.

The Scouts leaned forward, interested in seeing the first people to face the giants.

"The difference of power between humanity and the new enemy was overwhelming."

They watched with wide eyes at the sheer number of Titans crawling everywhere, like ants on a piece of cake that had been left out.

"Holy shit." Jean was the first to voice their thoughts.

"They're so many," Christa said in terror.

"I don't recognize that place." Petra eyed the large, rocky land formation she couldn't name with a large chasm filled with Titans.

A sense of hopelessness filled the room.

Was that what was waiting for them out there, further than they'd ever traveled?

Even with Eren's abilities, there was simply no way for them to win. Not against those odds.

Connie swallowed nervously. "Who knows? Maybe they've thinned out since then."

"Or it's just for effect," Armin put it. "She's telling a story and we're seeing it happen as she talks."

"Let's hope so." For once, Hange was subdued, despite seeing so many of her beloved babies.

"Soon, humanity was driven to the brink of extinction."

An entire sea of Titans walked around.

The screen rotated, showing where all the Titans were headed.

"The surviving humans built three Walls: Maria, Rose, and Sina. They then lived the next century in peace, under their protection."

"Well, there we have it, the Walls were built by humans. No deities involved what-so-ever." Hange felt the need to lighten up the mood a little. They were all feeling the pressure of seeing not just how many enemies they were surrounded by right outside the Walls, but further out in the land.

"However..."

A mouse scurried across a boulder with a bloodied arm crushed underneath it. A crow flew in and began picking at the hand. It let out a caw, echoing across the town. Smoke rose from

multiple sources and buildings stood with fissures and broken windows.

"Until that time a wretched soul and parted." A long-faced man preached, eyes wide, a book in one hand and a broom in the other.

A light-haired Titan came toward him.

Levi sneered. "Idiot."

"That's not gonna help, buddy," Connie muttered.

"Now as you see, I am punished for it!"

Titans wandered around, looking for prey, shaking the ground. A mother and daughter clutched each other, hiding. A crowd of panicking humans tried to run away while the preacher walked toward the danger they were running from.

"What avarice does manifest here?"

"I hope he gets eaten," Ymir said.

"In purgation of these souls converted, and no more bitter pain the Mountain has."

Sasha shook her head. "I don't even understand what he's saying."

A woman ran, huffing, ending up at a dead end. Turning, she clapped her hands over her mouth, eyes glued to the way she came from. A large shadow covered her and she looked up to see a Titan smiling creepily down at her. It grabbed her by the head and pulled her up. "Stop! Let go!" She struggled so hard her shoe fell, but the effort was futile.

"What more, O Avarice, can you do to us, since you my blood so to thyself hast drawn…"

Petra frowned. "Oh, shut up already."

Everywhere, people screamed, running for their lives as Titans snatched them up left and right.

"…it careth not for its own flesh?"

A shadow fell over him and he looked to his left to see a 15-meter staring down at him.

"What more, O Avarice—"

It opened its mouth. The book slipped from his hand, landing in a puddle of blood.

For once, no one was too terribly upset at seeing someone get eaten.

In a quieter part of town, Hannes ran, Eren over his shoulder and Mikasa tucked under one arm. Suddenly, Eren broke out of his stupor. He turned and began hitting the older man.

"Eren! What are you doing?!"

"We were so close to saving Mom! Why the hell would you do that?!" Eren slammed his elbow on Hannes's head.

"Ouch." Connie rubbed his head.

"We were so close to saving her!"

"Cut it out!" Hannes grabbed Eren by the arm and threw him to the ground.

"Eren!" Mikasa struggled out of the grasp and ran to him, kneeling beside him.

"Eren…" Hannes walked up to them, kneeling as well. "You couldn't save your mother because you're weak."

"He just lost his mother." Christa thought he was being too harsh.

"That's harsh, man," Connie said.

"It's the truth," Levi said, cutting any more replies. All eyes turned to Eren.

"Captain Levi's right," Eren spoke up. "I needed to hear that."

Eren glared and threw his fist. Without meaning to, Hannes caught the punch with ease, proving his point. Eren struggled but couldn't free his arm. "And I…I couldn't stand up to the Titan because I lacked the courage!" Tears were running down both their faces. Hannes's free hand took hold of Mikasa and led the two children away. "I'm sorry."

"It's happened again." Mikasa touched her head, images of a bloodied woman on the ground and a man slumped against the wall flashing through her mind. *This is familiar…*

Mikasa stiffened. *No* . There was no way it would show her...that. Would it? Her hands curled into fists.

Eren felt the tension coming off her and worried. He was the only one there who was able to understand what she was going through. Having both been there that day and just seeing his mother die once again.

Everyone was watching her.

"It'll be okay," Eren said too softly for anyone to overhear. "It has nothing to do with Titans."

Mikasa's expression spoke volumes and the others didn't ask, resuming watching the episode.

Titans continued to terrorize the fleeing citizens.

"Hurry to the inner gate!" A Garrison soldier was waving a crowd toward the ships. "Escape aboard the ships there! Use them to escape! Before you get eaten!" One of the ships began moving, leaving only one behind.

"City districts like Shiganshina that stick out in vital spots along the Wall serve to attract the Titans and streamline security costs and troop numbers. Performing true to its role as a Titan target, Shiganshina had but one inner gate through which its citizens could flee."

"I wonder if she'll keep providing commentary and tell us something important," Petra said. "Like that thing with the Walls having been breached once before."

"I hope so!" Hange said enthusiastically.

"Discard your belongings! Let as many people on as possible!"

A bag went flying and landed next to other people's discarded luggage. Armin stared at the large crowd of people waiting to be let on, trying to find his friends.

"Armin, sit down."

"Grandpa." Armin's voice quavered, emotional from hearing that soothing, familiar voice after so long. Would the TV allow him a glimpse of his parents, too? He hoped so.

"But Eren and Mikasa aren't here yet," Armin replied and looked out again. Then he spotted them, happy to see Hannes leading them through the masses so they could get on immediately.

"There they are!" His relief ended as quickly as it began. His friends looked traumatized. "Eren…"

"Just let him be for now." Armin's grandfather looked down sadly. "Those poor souls. You can tell what happened by looking at them."

"Huh?" Armin turned to him, unsure.

"Don't just stand there! Hurry the hell up!"

"The music's starting to pick up," Petra noted. The others sat up straighter at her words.

Hange let out a loud shriek of excitement, making Levi flinch.

"Is it the Colossal Titan?" Christa asked curiously.

"No." Eren's jaw clenched. "It's the Armored bastard," he spat out.

A 15-meter Titan approached, knocking a structure down, completely ignorant of the destruction of its actions.

"Get those cannons loaded! Hurry! They're closing in!"

Cannons were set into position and Hannes watched for a second before running somewhere.

Eren and Mikasa sat silently, horror clear on their faces.

"This can't be for real!"

"Please, god… Please, god…Please, god…"

"H-Hey!"

The plank connecting the people to the ship was removed.

"Hey! What are you doing?!"

Sasha squirmed uncomfortably in her seat. She cringed, recalling her words to her father about leaving the refugees to fend for themselves. Just imagining herself in their situation caused her to feel sick.

People began to push against the line of Garrison soldiers.

"It's at full capacity! It has to leave!"

"No! Please! At least let our children on!"

"I'm sorry, but we can't!" The soldier yelled in the direction of the ship, "Get going!"

A man shot forward and tried to get on, managing to catch the ledge. Two other men followed suit, one slipping and crashing.

"Selfish idiots," Levi grumbled.

Jean frowned. "You can't really blame them."

"Actually, you can." Hange then explained, "The ship's at full capacity. Too much weight and it could lose buoyancy and then *everyone's* screwed."

"I don't understand. Why not have more ships created so more people can be evacuated?" Connie asked.

"Did you forget?" Ymir snorted. "The Walls are impenetrable. They've stood strong for over a hundred years," she said in a mocking tone. "No one believed something of this scale could actually happen."

"There's also the problem with the limited amount of supplies," Petra added. "It takes a lot of trees to build a ship. They can't go cutting down too many. After all, they serve as home to animals and some bear fruit. We need that. And we need them for furniture, firewood, and other such items, too."

"Also," Erwin said, "Wall Maria had the largest population—nearly half of humanity—and it was the biggest territory we had. With such a great loss of resources and a flood of people, the Royal Government couldn't afford too many mouths to feed."

A few who had their suspicions about the government ordered culling being true were unsurprised at the confirmation, but they were still chilled by the words.

"Despite their planning, there were still too many people who managed to get away." Armin's head fell. *And so came the exodus.*

Cannonballs flew to the left and right of a 15-meter Titan.

"You idiot! What are you aiming at?!"

"B-But, sir, these aren't accurate enough to aim at moving targets!"

Another Titan, also a 15-meter, was coming behind the first.

"I don't give a shit! Get 'em reloaded at once!"

"I can't!"

The sounds of chains and grinding bricks were heard. "The gate's closing! They're... We're gonna get left behind!" The Garrison soldier abandoned his station and ran toward the gate.

"Hey!" His superior called after him.

Inside, Hannes was arguing with a fellow Garrison soldier. "Don't shut it! Hold on a little longer! There are still lots of

people in there!"

"I can't believe they'd just abandon their fellow soldiers like that," Christa said in disgust and anger.

"It's a necessary evil," Erwin told her.

"If the Titans get through, the town being overrun will be the least of our worries! All of humankind will be forced to withdraw behind the next Wall!"

"But that's no reason to leave these people to die!" Hannes argued.

The trio felt pride at Hannes for refusing to abandon his comrades.

Two soldiers ran up to them. "Shut the gate! Hurry!"

"The Titans are coming!"

"Close the gate at once!" The Garrison soldier ordered. It quickly began to slide down.

"Stop!" Hannes yelled. "Hey!" The two men grabbed his arms, restraining him. "What the?"

Thundering footsteps pierced through the noise. They froze.

Eren and Mikasa finally broke out of their shock and looked up.

Here it comes! Hange was tempted to yell. But she squashed the urge, choosing instead to focus on the screen, pen at the ready. She wasn't so tactless to verbalize her glee considering exactly what they were watching. Especially since two of the people who'd lived through the worst of the nightmare were sitting on the adjacent

couch. Not wanting to be disrespectful of what they'd suffered, she mostly kept her excitement to herself.

A large red foot with yellow outlines smashed through the street. Slowly, his armored body came into full view.

"Damn, look at that fucker," Jean said, gaping.

"He's so buff," Sasha muttered.

"How're we going to defeat that?" Petra said in worry.

"We'll find a weak spot." Levi narrowed his eyes. "There's *always* a weak spot."

One leg moving back, crouching, one arm front and one back, the Armored Titan got into position. The force of the push off cracked the ground and shattered the buildings closest to him.

"What the hell's it doing?" Suddenly, the Garrison soldier came to his senses. "Fire!" Cannonballs flew through the air and one met the target true. But it was obliterated the moment it came in contact with the skin. The Armored Titan ducked and the other cannonballs missed.

"They're ineffective against him," Petra said. "But they must hurt."

"Not enough to stop him or even make him flinch," Levi said. Maybe they could serve as a distraction? *An annoyance, more likely.*

"What?!"

"No effect?!"

"Shit! Run!"

"It's coming! Retreat!" They turned and ran. Behind them, the Armored Titan charged like a raging bull. "A Titan's coming! Hurry! Close the gate!"

The Armored Titan broke through the gate, sending bricks and boulders and soldiers flying everywhere. Skidding, it came to a halt. Hannes looked at the massive hole in shock. "The Wall's…"

A part of the armor slid down, and he opened his mouth, growling, letting out a cloud of steam.

Ymir summed the scene up with a succinct: "Well, fuck."

Hange continued to scribble furiously, making a special note about the steam and the sliding armor.

"Within a few hours after Walls Maria had fallen in the southern district of Shiganshina, news of the incident had reached every city inside human territory."

[South of Wall Rose - Trost District]

A group of men was talking.

"Is it true the Titans have overrun Shiganshina?!" One man said. "I can't believe this! The Walls have held strong for a century! Why now?!"

"Whether we believe it or not, the fact is that refugees have fled here by boat! Reports say there are five hundred on board."

"Who are they?" Eren asked.

"Merchants," Erwin answered, having recognized some of the men.

"The question is if Shiganshina is all that was affected."

"But, surely they couldn't have gotten through Wall Maria as well?"

"In any event, we must contact the Royal Government and request instructions."

"This crisis is far too much for us to handle on our own."

"I'm sorry to interrupt!" A Garrison soldier came in. "A courier horse has just arrived! Titans have breached Wall Maria and entered its interior!"

"It's over…" Hannes stared as countless Titans wandered around.

On the ship, the refugees were having similar thoughts. "It's all over…"

"The Titans are going to devour humanity again."

"This is the end?" Eren muttered, eyes full of tears, mind going back to his family, sitting at the table, enjoying their meal. "I'll never see that house ever again."

The memory of Carla pulling his ear came back.

"Why?!" He remembered his mother, trying to stop him from joining the Survey Corps. "Why'd I argue for no reason like that?!" Of him running away now. "Why was that all I could do?!" Her smiling face came to him. "And now Mom's gone! She's never coming back! Why?!"

Eren could feel the same rage and hate burning.

The people around him now began to truly comprehend his unyielding desire to join the Survey Corps and slaughter all the Titans.

***"It's because you're weak."* Hannes' words came to him.**

It's because…I'm weak. Because humans are weak. **Tears fell freely from Eren's eyes, and into his trembling hand. *Is crying the only thing the weak can do?!* Curling his hand into a fist, he got up and walked toward the edge. Mikasa stood, watching him.**

"What's gotten into you, Eren?" Armin walked up to him, hand on his arm. The boy shoved it off. "Eren…"

"I'll kill them all!" He grabbed the edge. "Not even a single one will be left!"

"Eren…"

Jean and Connie were sorely tempted to make fun, needing to lighten the mood, but held their tongues.

"Kid, you're like a volcano. Always boiling with lava, ready to blow your top off."

Eren wasn't sure whether to be insulted or not.

"Volcano?"

"Lava?"

"What does that mean?"

Candy cleared her throat. *"The same year, the Royal Government made the decision to withdraw all of humanity's domain behind Wall Rose. An estimated 10,000 people were eaten by Titans during this time."*

"Eren, Carla, Mikasa, please be all right!" Grisha was driving a carriage, crying.

"Dad!" Eren gasped.

"Where is he?" Mikasa wondered.

"At least we know he survived the invasion," Armin said.

"Eren! Eren!" An ember hovered in the darkness. "Eren! Eren!"

"Dad! Please, stop, Dad!"

A syringe. A determined Grisha.

Erwin's eyes widened. Were they about to see it...?

"What are you trying to do?!"

The ember again.

"Just give me your arm!"

"No! Mom's death has made you go crazy!"

The yellow ember became a red key.

No one talked, watching intently.

Hange trembled in excitement. Were they about to learn the process of creating a Titan-Shifter?

"Eren!"

"Let go, Dad!"

"It's for your own sake!"

Eren's fingers dug into the ground, his body convulsing. "What are you talking about?!"

"Listen! Don't forget the key!" A rush of distorted images, Grisha likely injecting his son. "You must reach it! Until you

learn the truth someday!"

Bells rang in the distance and Eren's eyes snapped open, he let out a gasp.

"Why do I not remember that either?" Eren scowled in frustration.

"More importantly, where did you father get that...serum that turned you into a Titan-Shifter?" Hange asked. "From what he said, that had to be it. Did he make it? How? Why not share it?"

"Maybe it was an experiment," Christa added.

Hange nodded. "Could be."

Grisha Yeager. Erwin narrowed his eyes. *Who are you?*

Mikasa joined him. "Eren, are you okay? You were crying in your sleep."

Eren sat up. "I felt like I just saw Dad."

"No, you were dreaming."

"I see…" Eren stared at the bronze key before tucking it underneath his shirt.

"Let's go," Mikasa said and stood. "They're handing out rations." The two wandered outside. "Apparently this was their food storehouse. They've gathered all the ship refugees here."

The place was overflowing with people.

A blonde-haired girl went up to get her bread.

Eren leaned in. "Hey, is that Annie?"

"She looks so young!" Sasha giggled.

"So she was at the same camp as you guys?" Christa asked.

"We never saw her." Mikasa pressed her lips. No one commented. They knew the two weren't exactly on friendly terms.

"You know how Annie is." Armin shrugged. "She's not much of a talker."

"Hey! Get in line, will ya?!"

"Shut up! I ain't eaten anything since last night!"

Hunger will make you do crazy things. Levi thought. He knew all too well the power it had over people. How it warped your mind, controlling your thoughts.

"We will still struggle for survival," Mikasa said, watching the two men grabbing each other's collars.

"Eren! Mikasa!" Armin ran up to them, loaves of bread in his arms.

"Armin…"

"Here! Just in time!" Armin gave them each one loaf. "My grandpa got us some by saying it was for children!"

"Whoever was handing out the rations wasn't very smart," Levi said.

Jean nodded. "He would have no way of knowing if they really were for kids."

"Thank you," Mikasa said.

A Garrison soldier came up behind Armin, making a face before moving on. "What's his problem?" Eren stared after him.

"You can't blame him. There's probably not enough food to go around," Armin explained. "And this is an entire day's worth."

That's for an entire *day?* Connie gaped. Even if food had a been a little shaky at times in his village, things had never been that bad.

"There are just too many refugees," Armin said. Eren stared at the loaf of bread in his hand. "There was already a food shortage going on, plus the people here aren't treated as well as citizens on the outer wall."

Two more had joined and now four men were struggling and arguing with one another.

"This is mine!"

"Shut up!"

The two Garrison soldiers looked on at the scene with scorn.

"They should be stepping in, trying to keep the peace," Petra said.

"Does it really surprise you to see them standing around doing nothing?" Eren glared at the TV.

"Unfortunately, I can't say that it does."

"Why should we hafta give our food to some lousy outsiders?" The soldier wasn't keeping his voice down and it was clear the trio had heard him. "If the Titans got through the Wall, they could've at least eaten some more people, if you ask me."

More than one person wanted to reach in and punch his lights out.

"Eren!" Armin called out as his best friend started walking purposefully toward the arrogant Garrison soldier.

Petra sighed. "Oh dear."

Christa seemed to agree. "I have a feeling this is going to end badly."

"This is just gonna make the food shortage even worse." Too busy whining, he didn't notice Eren coming up to him until he kicked the man in the shin. "Oww! What the hell?!"

"Seriously dude?" Connie groaned. "Why do you always gotta pick fights?"

"He started it!" Eren said, annoyed.

"You didn't think you'd seriously win against him, did you?" Ymir asked.

"That's not the—"

Jean folded his arms. "Typical Suicidal Bastard, doesn't think before jumping in head-first."

"Can it, Horse-Face."

"Who're you calling—"

"Shut up," Levi said, silencing them both.

"You damn brat!" He hit Eren. The other Garrison soldier stepped in, kicking the young boy and knocking him down.

"You don't know what it's like! You've never even seen it! You've never seen what the Titans do to people!" Eren yelled.

The older man quickly changed his reaction from surprise to anger. "Shut up!"

"Using aggression to mask his own short-comings." Petra rolled her eyes. "Like every other loser bully ever."

Armin quickly stepped in. "We're sorry! He's just hungry and irritable! That's why he so rudely lashed out at an adult. I'm very sorry!"

"That was very smart," Hange said in approval.

"You got them to back off just by raising your voice and being agreeable," Erwin said.

Murmurs picked up as a large crowd formed around them, now watching the spectacle unfold openly.

"Sure, *now* they notice when they can't ignore it any longer." Christa frowned. What was wrong with these people?

The Garrison soldier glanced around. "Whatever... You would've been dead without us!" He turned and started to walk away. "You kids ought to show some gratitude!"

"Of course!"

"Damn," Eren cursed. "I refuse to let them take care of me."

"You don't have a choice." Ymir scoffed. "What can you do? You're just a brat."

"And a stupid one at that," Jean added.

Eren gritted his teeth, unwilling to get into it with his rival and incurring Levi's wrath.

"I'm going back to Wall Maria! I'm going to destroy every last Titan!" Eren vowed.

"Eren, you're not being serious, are you?" Armin asked.

"I'm serious! I'm not like those guys who do nothing but act tough inside the Walls!" He threw the bread angrily and Armin fumbled with it, trying not to drop it. "I don't need this crap!"

"Eren!" Sasha gasped. "What did that poor bread do to deserve that kind of treatment?!"

"You shouldn't look a gift horse in the mouth," Connie said, nodding.

"Just when I thought you couldn't get any stupider," Jean said. "You go and do that."

Ymir snorted. "You plan to 'kill them all' on an empty stomach?"

"Enough," Mikasa said sharply, stopping all but one person from talking.

"Ungrateful little shit," Levi said.

"In his defense, he is only a little kid who just lost his mother," Petra said.

"I feel like such a dumbass watching that," Eren grumbled, arms crossed, sulking.

"Still, they don't need to gang up on you like that."

"It's fine, Mikasa."

"Eren! You'll starve to death!" Armin said.

"Doesn't it piss you off?!" Eren demanded. "It's because we take everyone's charity that we can't beat the Titans!"

"That doesn't make any sense," Ymir said. "How does relying on other people so you don't starve cause you to lose to the Titans?"

"It's impossible!" Armin yelled. "There is no beating them! All we can do is live inside the Walls! If we try anything, we'll die! Just like my mom and dad!"

"Yet here you are." Eren nudged his best friend with his elbow, smiling.

"I know." Armin shook his head. "Sometimes even I can't believe it." He touched the Wings of Freedom on his jacket pocket.

"So you're just gonna grovel to them then?! That's not shameful to you?!" Eren continued furiously.

"You're such a dramatic kid," Petra said.

"Trust me, he still is," Mikasa said, amused.

"Hey," Eren protested weakly. What happened to not picking on him?

"Don't deny it." Armin grinned. "We all know it."

"There's nothing we can do for now!" Armin argued.

"That's just an excuse! If you wanna live like livestock forever, go ahead! You weak piece of shit!"

"You're one to talk," Levi said, annoyed at his impudent behavior. "You've been absolutely useless so far. Worse still, you've been a *burden* to everyone."

"And he calls *me* an asshole," Jean said.

"Eren," Petra said in disapproval, "that was very rude of you."

"I know, Petra." Eren's shoulders slumped. "I can't believe I said that." He turned to Armin. "Especially after you just saved me from a beating, too. Can you forgive me?" Had he really been such an ignorant, ungrateful brat?

"There's nothing to forgive," Armin said immediately. "You weren't in your right mind."

"When is he ever?" Ymir muttered to herself.

Mikasa stepped forward and punched Eren, knocking him to the ground.

"Never thought I'd ever see that," Jean said with wide eyes.

"He deserved it," Mikasa said plainly.

"I did."

"Mikasa?" Armin said softly.

"If Armin's a wimp, then so are we. Whether it was running from the Titans or fleeing the town, we didn't manage anything on our own."

"If it hadn't been for your Garrison friend, you wouldn't have survived," Hange said.

"We even had help finding food today. There's no way such powerless people can defeat even a single one of those Titans," Mikasa continued. Eren sat up and made a face, too stubborn to admit she was right. "Staying alive is what matters most. Just like your mother said." She took the bread from Armin and walked over to Eren.

Then she tried to force him to eat it. "Mikasa!" Armin gasped.

"You have to eat and stay alive."

Tears were in his eyes.

"Now that's tough love," Sasha declared.

"I think he's suffocating," Armin said.

"You nearly made me gag." Eren grinned and Mikasa refused to meet his gaze. "What if it had gone down the wrong pipe?"

"I won't let you starve to death."

"Yeah, you'll almost choke me to death instead."

Mikasa appeared almost upset, shoulders slumping.

"Relax, Mikasa, sheesh. I'm only teasing."

"Several days later, the throngs of refugees were tasked with cultivating the wastelands to secure food."

Men and women worked the fields under the supervision of Garrison soldiers. The trio, alongside Armin's grandfather, worked among the group.

"However, a food shortage was unavoidable. So, in the following year of 846, the Royal Government sent a multitude of refugees on a mission in the name of retaking Wall Maria."

Armin's grandfather gave him his hat.

Armin clenched his hands into fists. "It was a suicide mission."

"The government wouldn't really do that, right?" Connie asked nervously. "Purposefully send people to their deaths."

"Unfortunately, that was definitely the case here," Erwin said. "There were simply too many people and not enough food. A war would have broken out amongst the refugees. The simplest solution to them was to send untrained civilians into hostile territory in hopes of improving the food storage, just a little, and incurring a large number of casualties."

"250,000 were sent, nearly a fifth of the population."

With dead eyes, the refugees followed the Survey Corps soldiers on foot.

Christa couldn't believe it. "They weren't given horses?"

"Like the commander said." Ymir folded her arms. "They weren't expected to survive. The Royal Government was counting on that, in fact. And the refugees knew it, too."

"They'd already resigned themselves to their fate," Petra said sadly.

"Like lambs to a slaughter," Levi said.

" *Not even 200 survived."*

On the bloodied battlefield, only the Titans remained standing.

Armin released the breath he didn't know he was holding.

Eren and Mikasa were grateful he'd been spared the horror of watching his family die. *I hope it's the same for Mikasa.* Eren thought worriedly. What reason could there be for watching that, though? No, he was sure the TV wouldn't show that. *We're way past that point.*

" ***Although it wasn't much, their sacrifices did improve the food shortage situation for the rest of the population."***

Armin sat against a wall, clutching his grandfather's hat, crying.

His hands twitched. Armin wanted to hold that familiar, comforting article of clothing in his hands right then and there. But he always kept it carefully stored away. It was the last thing he had left of his grandfather.

"It's all the Titans' fault." Eren stood next to him, Mikasa a couple of feet in front of them. "If we could just subdue them, our place in the world could be ours again. Armin." He sat with his best friend. "I'm going to apply for the military next year." Mikasa let out a resigned sigh. "I'm going to gain the strength to fight the Titans!"

"Me, too."

"Armin?!"

"I will join you, too."

"Mikasa, you don't need to! You said yourself staying alive is what's important!"

"Yes, that's why I'm doing it. So you won't die," Mikasa said plainly.

Eren stood. "Alright. The three of us, then."

"You're all crazy kids," Connie declared loudly. "Normal, sane children would be scared and run the opposite direction. You don't even look scared." His could still remember the distinct, metallic taste in his mouth and the churning in his stomach when he had made the decision to join the Survey Corps.

"You are now officially members of the 104th Training Corps," Keith said loudly.

"Here we go." Sasha grinned excitedly. She was glad the depressing, emotional, and not to mention intrusive, scenes were over.

"You have the misfortune of having me, Keith Shadis, as your commandant!"

"Damn, he looks so different compared to the last episode," Jean said.

"How did his hair fall off so fast?" Connie snorted.

Hange glared at him. "You're one to talk, Chrome Dome."

Connie shrank back. "I was just saying."

"What's with Four-Eyes?" Levi said, not expecting the defensive annoyance.

Petra leaned in and whispered, "I heard rumors she used to have a huge crush on Commander Shadis."

Levi wrinkled his nose. "Gross."

"I do not welcome you warmly! In your current state, you'd be nothing but food for the Titans! You're mere livestock!"

"Look, Connie, that's you," Sasha said, pointing.

"This is weird." Connie shivered. "It's kinda creepy, watching yourself." He shot the trio a sympathetic look. He was grateful they all wouldn't be seeing his most personal or traumatic experiences.

"You're less than livestock!"

"There's Bert and Reiner," Eren said, grinning.

"Over the next three years, we're going to train you worthless nothings and teach you how to fight Titans!"

"My beautiful Christa," Ymir cooed.

Christa blushed. "Stop teasing me, Ymir."

"Sasha, you're right behind her," Connie said.

"I know!"

Jean rolled his eyes. "Will you two stop pointing out the obvious?"

"Three years from now, when you come face-to-face with the Titans, will you still be fodder for them?!"

"There's Armin!"

"Will you serve as an honorable barrier that protects the king?!"

"Mikasa! I forgot you had long hair!"

Jean forgot about groaning and sulked instead. He understood the problem with long hair during battle. Still, the circumstances under which the beautiful and luscious black hair was cut stabbed at his heart. His froze. *Please, please don't show that scene.* He cringed, remembering his first, awkward encounter with the girl.

"Or will you be a glorious soldier for humanity that drives the Titans out! It's up to you to decide!"

Yeah, don't worry. **Eren stared intently.**

"Wow, you sure matured a lot in one year," Petra said.

"Only physically, mind you." Mikasa smiled a little, making the teenage boy in question roll his eyes.

Eren glared. ***I'll kill every last one of them.***

"Well, that's episode number two." Hange massaged her hand, slightly cramped from the hard use. If the coming episode was training years, she could take a break. She placed the notebook and the pen back on the table.

"Any thoughts?" Erwin asked.

"Plenty." She gave him a knowing look.

"If anyone wants to use the facilities or grab some food, please do so now, before we begin the next episode," the commander said. While

the others were gathered around the food or made a line outside the bathroom, they picked up their conversation.

"First off, I want to begin by saying everyone here is trustworthy," Hange said. "Totally and utterly trustworthy."

"What do you mean?" Levi asked. "How would you know that?"

"Think about it," she explained, "Candy said watching this will help humanity, right?" They nodded. "She wouldn't say that and then invite the wrong people to watch this 'Attack on Titan.' We've already established that there are humans capable of transforming into Titans, it's why we're closely guarding the truth about the 57th Expedition."

"Because Sonny and Bean's killers are still at large," Levi said. "We have to flush them out."

"I see." Erwin nodded, catching on. "Candy brought us all together to understand the threat and help fight it, which means everyone present in this room is a friend to humanity."

"The only thing I don't get is why the new recruits?" Hange wondered. "Why not Mike and Nanaba? They're ranking officers, and we know they're clean."

"Can you imagine if so many highest ranking officers disappeared for twelve hours?" Levi asked. "It'd be more than a little suspicious."

"True," Erwin agreed. "And this does help us expand the circle of trust."

"Hmm." Hange folded her arms, thinking. She looked at the screen. "It says three out of twenty-seven. Which means there are twenty-seven total episodes. Each is about twenty minutes, multiply that by twenty-seven episodes, we have five hundred forty minutes. Divide that by sixty minutes an hour, we have nine hours."

"What's your point, Four-Eyes?"

"According to this note." Hange held up the evidence. "We're stuck here for twelve hours."

"Maybe the extra time is to help us plan in peace," Erwin theorized. "It's clear we're all friendlies here. We can strategize without worry of anyone betraying us or overhearing."

"I guess," Hange said reluctantly. The scientist in her really wanted to know why specifically twelve hours. Was it one hour per person? They didn't know how this, whatever it was, worked. Mentally, she shook her head. *Stop looking a gift-horse in the mouth.* Candy, whoever or whatever she was, was doing them a great favor.

Soon, everyone was settled and they began.

Please Review~

Episode - Humanity's Comeback Part I

Chapter 3: Humanity's Comeback Part I

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Hange, Levi, and Erwin decide the people watching 'Attack on Titan' are trustworthy.

"Hey, you!"

"Sir!" Armin saluted Keith.

"Who the hell are you?!"

"Armin Arlert, from Shiganshina District!"

"I see! That's a ridiculous name! Did your parents give it to you?!"

Hange sighed, smiling fondly. "Brings back memories."

"My grandfather did, sir!"

"Arlert! Why are you here?!"

Armin closed his eyes and replied loudly. "To help humanity achieve victory!"

"How very admirable of you! We can feed you to the Titans!"

"I was seriously having heart palpitations," Armin said, heart almost feeling faint thinking about it.

"Third row, about face!" Keith turned Armin's head and moved on. "Who the hell are you?!"

"Sir! Thomas Wagner, from Trost District!"

"I can't hear you!" Keith got in his face.

Thomas flinched and repeated. "Thomas Wagner!"

"Can't hear you!"

"Man, he could be so irritating," Jean complained. Then he shot Hange a wide-eyed look and quickly clamped down.

"Look at them go." A young man walked with his silver-haired superior.

"Go practice in a barn!" Keith yelled.

"You went through the same thing when you started as a trainee, didn't you?" The elder man said. "It takes me back."

"No! You're from a pigsty!" Keith said to Mina. "You're less than livestock!"

"Hey, that's the line I got," Petra giggled.

"Yes, sir! I am less than livestock!" Mina blurted, panicked.

"But what's all that intimidation for?" The young man asked.

"It's a rite of passage. We revert them to a blank slate through the use of self-denial, after which we mold them into proper soldiers."

"Was that the point?" Sasha asked. "I thought he was just mean."

"Same," Christa replied, nodding.

"Hmm, that does make sense," Armin said.

Keith picked on another poor soul. "Why the hell are you here?!"

The silver-haired man nodded. "This is one step in that process."

"To devote myself to humankind!"

"Fourth row, about face!" Keith passed by Annie.

"There are some he's not talking to."

"I see," Connie said grimly. "Annie was at the same place as you guys because she lost her home to the Titans, too. It's why Shadis skipped her."

"It's unnecessary for those who've already been through their rites of passage. They most likely witnessed the hell that took place two years ago. They have a different look on their faces."

Shots of Mikasa, Bert, Reiner, Eren, and Ymir were shown.

"Let's go."

"Who the hell are you?!"

"Jean Kirstein, from Trost District!"

"Why are you here?!"

Jean smiled slightly. "To join the Military Police and live in the interior!"

They giggled.

I can't believe he said outright. Christa thought. You could always trust Jean to speak his mind and be honest. He was the opposite of her in that sense.

"Wow, Jean." Eren shook his head.

"Why did you join the Survey Corps then?" Petra asked curiously.

"Because Yeager's insanity is contagious."

Levi had to admit. "At least you had the balls to say it. Unlike the wimps that give some bullshit pretty little excuse about serving the king."

Jean preened at the praise while Eren sulked at how easily he'd impressed the older man.

"I still can't believe you just blurted that out." Sasha giggled.

"You're one to talk." Jean gave her a pointed look. " *Potato Girl* ."

The rest of the 104th class laughed.

"What? What's that mean?" Hange was burning to know, to be in on the joke.

Ymir snickered. "You'll find out in a minute."

"Oh. You wanna live in the interior, do you?" Keith asked.

"My favorite part's coming up," Eren said gleefully.

"Shut up."

"Yes!" Jean smiled.

And he was immediately head-butted, knocking him to his knees.

That drew some laughter from the group.

"Who said you could sit?! If you can't handle this, you can forget about the Military Police!"

"Asshole," Jean grumbled quietly to himself.

"Who the hell are you?!" Keith rounded on his next victim. "Why are you here?!"

"Marco Bott of Jinae, on the south side of Wall Rose!" Marco smiled naively. "I want to join the Military Police and give life and limb to the king!"

Shoulders slumped in sadness at the familiar, freckled face. The veteran Scouts knew better than to ask, recognizing the expressions all too well.

Jean looked at the TV, resolute. *Maybe we'll know. Maybe we'll know what happened to Marco.* It seemed morbid. Still, he couldn't help but think how quietly his friend had passed away. Without anyone knowing. All by himself. Jean needed to know what had happened.

"I see. That's a fine goal, indeed. Go ahead and strive for it. But, just so you know," Keith said, getting into Marco's face, "the king doesn't want your lousy life or limbs."

Marco stared, shaken.

"You're next! Who the hell are you?!"

"Connie Springer! I'm from Ragako Village on the south side of Wall Rose!" Connie was saluting with the wrong hand.

"You have it backwards, Connie Springer!" Keith grabbed his head and squeezed.

Jean laughed extra hard to rub it in Connie's face for laughing too much when his younger-self was head-butted.

"It was the first thing you were taught! This salute expresses your resolve to give your heart to the people!"

Two rows behind and to the left was Sasha.

"Oh wow." Petra gaped while Levi's eyebrows rose at the bold act.

Hange was shaking in laughter.

"Potato Girl, indeed," Erwin said with a wide, amused smile.

"Is your heart on your right side?!" Keith demanded.

"Maybe it was." Connie folded his arms.

Then a crunch was heard. And Keith saw it.

"I could not believe my eyes." Christa giggled at the sight of her, Keith, and the other trainees watching Sasha with open mouths.

The ominous music had disappeared, the only sounds being Sasha chewing and swallowing. Keith dropped Connie. "Hey, you. What do you think you're doing?"

Sasha didn't seem to have heard him.

"How did you miss that?" Mikasa asked. "It was dead silent. *Everyone* could hear you eating."

"It was a good potato," Sasha replied defensively.

Sasha took another bite.

Keith was suddenly in her face, yelling. "I'm talking to you! Who the hell are you?!"

She chewed quickly, swallowed, and saluted. "Sasha Braus from Dauper Village, on the south side of Wall Rose!"

"At least you didn't talk with your mouth full and spit potato bits in his face," Christa said, unable to stop giggling.

They all chuckled at that image.

"Shadis would have burst a blood vessel." Jean grinned.

"Sasha Braus." Keith towered over her. "What is that you're holding in your right hand?"

"A steamed potato, sir! I found one in the cookhouse that was ready to eat so I couldn't help myself!"

"You stole it? Why? Why did you decide to eat it now?"

"I felt it would be a waste to let it get cold, so I elected to eat it now."

The group began to laugh.

Even Levi couldn't keep the amusement off his face.

"No, I don't understand. Why did you eat the potato?" Keith was so genuinely confused.

It made the whole scene even funnier.

"Are you asking me why people eat potatoes, sir?"

"I can't believe you really said that!" Petra laughed.

"Wait for it." Eren snickered.

"Here's half of it for you." Sasha held it out almost reluctantly.

More uncontrollable laughter came from around the room.

"I'm no genius but that's not half," Connie pointed out. "Barely a third."

"Half?"

"Maybe that's why he got mad. Because you gave him the smaller piece," Armin mused, smiling.

"Whoa, he still has Potato Girl running," Connie observed.

"Man, she's been at it for five solid hours." Marco was impressed. "She's really something. Still, being told to run until she's on the verge of death didn't seem to bother her quite as much as being told she has to skip dinner."

"Dauper's a small hunting village in the mountains, isn't it?" Connie said to himself.

"What's that?" Eren asked, noticing a carriage.

"They're dropouts," Mina answered. "They asked to work in the fields instead."

"What?" Armin said. "It's only the first day, too.

"That's just how it is here," Eren said. "The powerless have no choice but to leave."

"You're pretty arrogant for someone who hasn't even started training yet," Levi said. He did not need a big-headed brat on his team.

"Eren placed 5th in our class," Mikasa replied icily. Why was he being so unnecessarily rude to him?

The two glared at each other.

Eren leaned to the side, blocking her view of the corporal. "You gotta admit, I was being kind of egotistical and snobbish for no reason."

"Graduating in the top ten is very impressive," Petra said to her captain.

The two dark-haired soldiers crossed their arms, grunting.

"Man, the way they act sometimes, you'd think they were related or something," Sasha whispered.

Connie nodded along with Christa, and even Ymir had to admit it.

"Now that we're all friends again," Hange interrupted. "Let's keep watching."

"I can't believe anyone would want to pick up rocks and pull plants again."

"That reminds me." Marco straightened. "You weren't asked to state your name and birthplace or anything."

"I'm from Shiganshina, same as him." Eren smiled at his best friend.

"Oh. That means..."

"You were there that day, weren't you?" Connie asked.

"H-Hey!" Marco said.

"Did you see the Colossal Titan?"

"Connie! Have some tact!"

"It's already done, I can't go back and fix it, Christa."

"Y-Yeah."

Inside the mess hall, a group had surrounded Eren's table. "Like I said, I saw it."

"Really?" Thomas asked.

"How big is it really?" Samuel asked.

"Big enough to look over the Wall."

"What?! I heard it stepped over the Wall!"

"Me, too!" Hannah said.

"That's what they said in my village, too!" Franz jumped in.

Armin shook his head. "It's crazy how stories get warped and exaggerated."

"Did people seriously think it was big enough to step over the Wall?" Mikasa said.

"They may have seen it themselves if it really was that humungous." But Ymir supposed that was too much common sense for people. "Not to mention it could have easily walked to the heart of Wall Sina with ease."

Eren took a sip of his soup. "No, it wasn't that big."

"What did it look like?" Mina asked.

"It had a huge mouth, and almost no skin."

"What about the Armored Titan that broke Wall Maria?!"

"That's what people call it, but it looked like an ordinary Titan to me," Eren said.

Reiner was drinking from his mug at a nearby table.

"What are you, blind, Yeager?" Jean said incredulously. "How did that fucker look like 'an ordinary Titan' to you? Oh, wait, never mind. I guess you were just trying to show off, weren't you?"

Eren turned red. "Shut up, Horse-Face!"

Jean didn't reply, looking smug, knowing he'd won that round.

"Th-Then, what are ordinary Titans like?!" Samuel looked eager and a little scared.

The memory of the Smiling Titan came back, eating his mother. Eren dropped his spoon and covered his mouth. His fellow trainees fell silent.

Marco spoke up, "Let's spare him the questions, everyone. I'm sure there are things he doesn't want to remember."

"Sorry for asking—" Connie began.

"It's not like that!" Eren took a bite out of his bread. "Titans aren't actually that big of a deal! Once we've mastered the 3D gear, they'll be nothing to us!"

"Says the guy who got eaten almost immediately at the start of the battle," Jean snarked.

"It's because he had to save Armin!" Mikasa snapped. Then she turned to her left. "I wasn't implying—"

"Don't worry, I know you didn't mean anything negative." Although Armin still blamed himself for being so weak that it had almost gotten his best friend killed.

"Was I really that arrogant?" Eren slinked back in his seat, cringing at the replies.

"Yeah."

"Yes."

"Yup."

"Uh-huh."

"Do you want examples?"

"Just a little..."

Mikasa wisely kept silent.

"It was a rhetorical question," Eren said sulkily.

Jean was listening to the conversation in disinterest.

"We finally get to train as soldiers. I was just overcome with emotion, that's all. I'm going to join the Survey Corps and drive the Titans out of this world! I'm gonna slaughter—"

"Whoa, what are you, crazy?" Jean called out. "Did you just say you're gonna join the Survey Corps?"

"Yeah, that's right. Aren't you the one who wants to join the Military Police and live the easy life?" Eren said.

"I'm all about being honest, you see."

"And that's why he's my favorite!"

"Did you hear that?" Jean beamed. "I'm Candy's favorite!"

"Horse-Face!"

Eren started to laugh. "She calls you Horse-Face, too!"

"At least I'm not a Suicidal Bastard!" Jean glared.

"You two are such children," Petra said. "Always squabbling about something."

"It's much nicer than being, say," Jean said, smiling, face in palm, "a loser who acts tough but is actually scared shitless."

Eren stood, knocking his chair back. "Are you implying something?"

"S-Stop!" Marco held up his hands. "Come on now."

Jean met Eren halfway. "I wasn't really…"

A bell rang outside, breaking the tension.

Jean sighed. "Whatever, I'm sorry. I don't mean to dismiss your ideas. Let's call it even with this." He held out his hand.

"That was the fakest apology ever," Sasha declared.

"Yeah, I'm sorry, too." Eren slapped his hand against Jean's.

"Followed by the other fakest apology," Connie said.

Eren walked away.

Kill me now. Jean winced at what was about to happen.

Jean was looking at Eren's retreating back when Mikasa walked by. It was as if time seemed to slow.

Jean wanted to disappear into the sofa.

Then Candy stepped in—so to speak. *"L'Oreal,"* she giggled. *"From Paris!"*

It was quiet for a second before the laughter came. Although not from Candy's joke that no one understood. The embarrassed teen

crossed his arms and refused to meet anyone's gaze. But he unconsciously picked up his crush's bland voice amongst the gaggle.

"I don't even know how to react to that."

"We all knew he was a pervert." Eren shot him a distrustful look.

"H-Hey, you!" Jean blushed hard when she looked at him. "Uhh, err, I've just never seen anyone who looks like you before. S-Sorry! You have very pretty black hair."

"Thanks." That said, Mikasa walked away.

Jean paused for a second before chasing after her. Looking around, he saw her fall in step with Eren.

What a cruel twist of fate . Ymir thought, amused.

"It's no big deal. Get off my back," Eren complained.

"You never think things through when you get worked up," Mikasa chided.

"That again? Anyway, don't you think your hair's too long?" Eren casually flipped her hair with the back of his hand.

"Oh no." Petra covered her mouth, trying to hide her smile. No wonder the two butted heads so much.

That explains it . Hange giggled.

Christa shot Jean a sympathetic look.

Levi rolled his eyes. *Children* .

"It could cause an accident during 3D gear training, you know."

"He does make a valid point," Erwin said.

"Alright." Mikasa pinched a few strands between her fingers. "I'll cut it."

Jean looked like someone had sucked the life out of him.

Some of the viewers laughed a little. Although they felt kind of guilty about it. Still, they chuckled.

"But how short should I make it?" Mikasa asked.

Christa let out a little gasp while Ymir snickered at the little twist of the knife already stuck in the poor boy's chest.

Connie was walking by, humming cheerily to himself when Jean wiped his hand on his back. "H-Hey! Don't mess with other people's clothes! What did you wipe on me?!"

"My faith in humanity."

No one was able to smother their laughter this time.

Even Erwin couldn't help the chuckle that escaped him.

"I'm so sorry, Jean," Christa apologized, wiping off any traces of amusement from her face.

"Whatever." Jean sunk deeper into the sofa, red-faced.

"Finally…done…" Sasha collapsed on the ground. A figure came from the shadows. Her nose twitched. *This is...* Wild-eyed, she attacked the newcomer, knocking her to the ground. "Bread!"

"What an animal," Connie said.

"Amazing! Your olfactory senses must be higher than average like Mike's," Hange said.

"It's not much, but I saved it for you." Christa held up a waterskin. "Oh, but you really ought to drink some water first."

"Are you a goddess?!"

"A common and completely understandable mistake," Ymir said.

Christa looked confused. "Huh?!"

"Are you?!"

"Uhh…"

"Goddess!" Sasha cried out again.

"Hey, what are you two doing?" Ymir came up to them.

Sasha, looking like she was afraid Ymir was going to take the bread from her, began eating it in a frenzy.

Sasha felt a little embarrassed seeing her on-screen self acting so mannerless when everyone else acted so properly. Except for Eren and Jean. But they were impulsive and hot-headed so they didn't count.

"Umm, she's been running non-stop all this time," Christa began, "so—"

"So you're trying to do something *nice* , huh?"

"Huh?"

Sasha passed out in Christa's lap.

"Lucky," Connie said jealously, earning nods from Jean and Armin.

"Did you do it for Potato Girl's sake? Was what you gained worth the effort it took?" Ymir asked. Christa didn't know how to reply. "Well, whatever. Let's just get her to her bed now." She picked up the unconscious girl.

"Are you trying to be nice, too?"

"I'm doing this so that she'll owe me. Her stupidity will come in very handy."

"Liar," Sasha said teasingly, "we both know you love me but you're just too closed off from your feelings to admit it."

It earned her an eye-roll from Ymir.

"We'll begin by determining your aptitude!" Keith began. "If you can't do this, you're not even fit to be bait! You'll be sent off to the fields!"

Across the training field, trainees hovered, balancing using the wires.

"These are only just the bare fundamentals." The silver-haired superior of the Training Corps approached. "Still, you can determine a person's knack for 3D gear-mobility at this stage." Something caught his attention. "Observe." Mikasa was balancing with ease. "Completely steady. She knows exactly what to do and how to do it. That's what aptitude is all about."

"That's very impressive," Erwin said.

Petra agreed, "To get it on your first try, that's amazing!"

"Thank you," Mikasa replied politely.

"How long'd it take you?" Hange asked Levi.

"Never did it, remember?" He didn't give out any details.

"Oh, yeah, you learned how to use the gear without practicing on the stationary version."

The others wondered how that was possible. But they didn't ask, either not having the courage to or knowing he wouldn't answer.

"It looks like we have many talented trainees this year."

Connie, Sasha, and Jean were doing fairly well themselves.

"Umm, what about him?" The younger man asked.

"Now that's another definition of aptitude," his superior replied. "Some people might have plenty of motivation yet turn out to be less than capable."

Eren was hanging completely upside-down.

His former classmates laughed.

Petra frowned, puzzled. "What's wrong?"

"Defective gear?" Hange guessed.

"Yes!" Eren nodded. "It's shitty machinery."

"Thought so."

Keith knelt next to him. "What are you doing, Eren Yeager?! Straighten yourself up!"

What is this? How am I supposed to… **Eren was horrified.** ***This can't be for real.***

Later that evening, Mikasa instructed him. "Just follow the basics and you'll be able to do it. Don't think about being fancy or anything. Focus on your front and back balance, then slowly place your weight into the belts on your waist and feet."

"You can do it if you stay calm," Armin continued. "Even I did it, after all."

"Alright, I feel like I've got it this time. Lift me up, Armin." Eren was still for a second before face-planting into the dirt.

"Serves you right for being so arrogant. Yes, I'm not deaf," Levi interrupted Mikasa, "the machine was broken. Still, mouthing off like that before he even began, he had it coming in."

"Don't." Eren touched her arm to keep her from snapping at Levi. "It was a lesson in humility."

In the mess hall, two trainees spoke, highly amused.

"Hey, Daz, isn't he the one who said he was gonna slaughter all the Titans yesterday? I guess it's off to the fields for him tomorrow."

"Yeah, we can't afford to feed the useless."

"Do you guys not notice he's steaming from the head?" Hange addressed the recruits.

"It's dinnertime, I was focused on the food." Sasha shrugged, and Connie nodded.

"When you're sitting with friends, especially in the mess hall, you don't really pay attention or notice other people unless they do

something loud. Like picking a fight." Ymir gestured toward the middle couch where Jean and Eren sat.

"If I, or anyone really, saw that, I'd most likely dismiss it as my imagination or think it was coming up from the food," Petra thought out loud.

"True," Hange said.

"And this was before anyone thought humans could turn into Titans and had impossible healing abilities," Armin added. "It just wouldn't stand out unless we saw the wound heal up before our very own eyes. But the bandage was covering it and the next day, we dismissed the injury thinking it was probably nothing."

That gave Hange an idea.

"Eren." Mikasa gripped his shoulder, causing him to flinch in pain. "There's no point worrying about it."

"You can just learn to do it tomorrow," Armin said.

"How pathetic. There's no way I can wipe them out like this."

"You should just forget about that altogether."

"So, Mikasa's still trying to convince him to quit," Connie said. "You're pretty stubborn."

"Good thing he's stubborn, too," Erwin said.

Eren took that as a compliment. Had he heeded Mikasa's words, where would humanity be now?

Reluctant as she as to admit it, even to herself, Mikasa was glad Eren hadn't listened to her.

"What did you say?" Eren turned to her.

"I'm saying you should give up trying to be a soldier. Fighting isn't about simply throwing your life away."

"Hey, now! I saw what happened that day! Do you really think you can just convince me to quit?!"

"Still," Mikasa said, "it doesn't matter how determined you are."

"Huh? Why not?!" Eren demanded.

"Because you don't get to decide if you're fit to be a soldier or not."

"Ouch," Sasha said. "That's gotta hurt."

The bell rang, signaling the end of the meal.

"I'm not saying you should return—"

"Let's go, Armin.

"O-Okay."

"—to the fields by yourself. You don't need to worry," Mikasa continued as they stood and walked away without her noticing. "Because wherever you go, I'll go with you." She turned to see Sasha in Eren's recently vacated spot, the mess hall empty.

Some laughter escaped the viewers.

"So, umm… What you're saying is that I can have that?" Sasha pointed to the food.

Mikasa held up the bread. Then took a bite out of it. Sasha's face fell.

"So mean." Sasha pouted while the others laughed.

"The trick to posture control? Sorry," Connie said, "but I'm gifted. All I can tell you is to 'feel' it."

"If anything," Jean mocked, "I'd like to hear your trick for staying sane after putting on such a pathetic spectacle."

"I'd have died of humiliation from such a public failure after all that boasting and claiming the weak should just quit." Jean was met with nods of agreement.

"Good thing you're so shameless," Hange said.

"I'm not sure if I should take that as a compliment."

"C'mon, guys! I'm begging you here," Eren said desperately.

"But didn't you say yesterday, 'If you can't cut it here, you have to leave?'" Connie paused. "Or, wait. Was it, 'If you don't got talent, you have to leave?' Which was it again?"

"Way to kick a guy when he's down," Eren grumbled, earning himself a shrug and a grin from the short boy.

"Please! I heard you're both really good at it, Bertolt, Reiner!" Eren begged.

Reiner crossed his arms. " Sorry, but I don't think there are any tricks to just hanging there. I can't think of any especially helpful advice, either."

"Oh." Eren looked down.

"I guess we'll just have to hope for the best tomorrow." Armin began to get up.

Bert stopped him with a question. "You two are, umm, from Shiganshina, aren't you?"

"Yes, we are," Armin answered.

"Then you know how terrifying the Titans are. So why do you want to be soldiers?"

"Unlike Eren, I didn't witness the Titan threat firsthand," Armin answered. "It's just I decided I couldn't sit there and do nothing after the Royal Government forced people into that absolutely awful retrieval operation."

They all grimaced, remembering that disaster.

"I see."

"Where are you two from?" Armin asked.

"Reiner and I are from a mountain village on the southeast side of Wall Maria.

"Hey, wasn't that…?"

"Yeah," Bert said, "unlike the prosperous towns along the river, we didn't receive word right away. The Titans showed up well before the information did. It happened at dawn. The livestock was acting up, and these strange rumblings kept getting louder and louder. At some point, I realized they were footfalls of some sort. And then, when I hurriedly opened the window… After that I, umm, don't really remember."

"Who'd want to?" Connie shivered. "Opening the window and seeing a big creepy face staring at you."

"It's pretty horrifying," Petra agreed.

Bert was lost in his thoughts. "Everyone was in such a panic—"

"Hey, now," Reiner interrupted. "What are you suddenly bringin' that up for?"

"I can't blame him for not wanting to remember such a horrible day," Christa said.

"Sorry. Basically, what I was trying to say is that you guys probably aren't like *them* ."

"Them?" Armin asked.

"The others here who don't know the horror of the Titans," Bert said.

"Hey." Reiner put his hand on his friend's shoulder.

"It's true, it's why you didn't get screamed at." Jean nodded.

Around the barrack, boys laughed and smiled, sitting in groups on their beds.

Outside, Bert and Reiner led them, lanterns in hand.

"They're mostly here for show. To live up to society's expectations. You're seen as a coward if you choose production work when you turn twelve. Society has pushed them into becoming trainees."

They hiked through a forest.

"That said," Bert continued, "I'm no different than them. I chose to be a soldier in the hopes of joining the Military Police so I could work in the safety of the interior."

"Breaking the rules and sneaking off after dark, don't think you can get away with that here," Levi warned.

"C'mon, Captain, we've all done it once or twice."

"Is that so?"

Petra didn't say another word, choosing to focus solely on the TV.

"If that doesn't work out, I might give up entirely. I don't have any will to call my own, you see."

"There's nothing to be ashamed of for valuing your life," Armin assured Bert.

"As for me, I'm going to return to the hometown we lost. That's all I care about now. I will do it, no matter what," Reiner promised.

Eren nodded. He, too, wanted that. To reclaim his home from the invaders.

"What about you?" Bert asked Eren. "Why do you want to be a soldier?"

"I…" His mother's death flashed through Eren's mind. "I decided I have to kill them. I decided I have to slaughter all the Titans with my own two hands."

"So, your encounter with the Titans didn't break your will?" Bert asked.

Hardship either makes you or breaks you . Levi thought.

"That's right. But now it's a question of whether or not I'm actually cut out to be a soldier."

Overhead, the clouds parted, revealing a full moon. Its silvery beams highlighted the forest and the river, making it sparkle like a diamond. "Check your equipment, starting with your belt adjustment," Reiner advised.

"How come it occurred to no one to check the machinery?" Petra asked and got shrugs.

"Apparently, they didn't know the part that was defective was capable of breaking," Armin answered.

"You'll do just fine tomorrow. I'm certain of it. Eren Yeager, was it?"

"Yeah, thanks," Eren replied, smiling, "Reiner Braun, right?"

"Eren Yeager, are you ready?" Keith stared him down.

"Yes, sir!" Eren nodded. *I'm going to do it! I am! I might not have raw aptitude, but no one has more guts than I do!*

"Begin!"

***To hell with logic! I know it's completely baseless but guts are all I got!* The wires lifted Eren. *They're my weapon!* He was hanging steady. Around him, the other trainees let out whoops.**

"Being stationary on faulty equipment, even for a few seconds, is really something," Hange complimented.

***I did it! I'm doing it!* Then Eren began to lose his balance. And he crashed. "N-Not yet! I can still do it!"**

"Let him down," Keith said.

"I-I'm—!" He sat on the ground, ready to cry.

Eren winced. *I look so weak. I should have asked to try at a different station earlier!* Then again, it was that failure that led him to befriend Bert and Reiner, so he figured it was worth it in the end.

"Wagner, switch belts with Yeager."

"Y-Yes, sir!"

This time, Eren easily hung in there. "Your equipment was defective. The belt you were using had a broken clasp. I've never heard of this part breaking before." Keith held the defective piece in his hands. "I guess we'll have to add it to the maintenance checklist."

"Then, even with broken equipment, he still managed to hang in there for a few seconds?"

"Whoa!"

Eren puffed at the crowd's awe. He had been too relieved the first time to notice.

"Th-Then, what about my aptitude evaluation?"

"You pass. Train hard!" With that, Keith walked away.

I did it! I did it! **Eren threw his hands into the air, grinning.** ***Whadya think of that, Mikasa?! I can do it!***

Mikasa stared, mouth open.

Eren relished in shocking her and showing her that he could become a soldier.

I can fight the Titans! There's no need for me to depend on you anymore. **Eren thought.**

Mikasa fiddled with her scarf, eyes downcast.

"Looks like things worked out for him," Reiner said.

Armin smiled. "His eyes say, 'What do you think of that?'"

"No," Mikasa said. "He feels relieved that he doesn't have to leave me now."

Silence

"Um..."

"You're so cute." Petra was the first to start laughing.

***Grisha, today your son has become a soldier.* Keith thought.**

Abruptly, the laughter stopped.

"He knows Dad?!"

"How?" Mikasa asked.

"Why didn't he say anything?" Armin wondered.

"We have to talk to him," Erwin said. *If they were friends, Keith might have an idea where Dr. Yeager is.*

Please Review~

Episode - Humanity's Comeback Part II

Chapter 4: Humanity's Comeback Part II

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Eren, Mikasa, and Armin become soldiers. The viewers learn Keith Shadis knew Grisha.

"In the year 845, the Colossal Titan and the Armored Titan suddenly appeared and destroyed one of humanity's Walls and everyday life with it. And then, finally freed from their century-long hunger, the Titans overran humankind once again. Humanity abandoned Wall Maria, lost twenty percent of its population and one-third of its territory, and was forced to retreat behind Wall Rose."

[Two Years After Enlistment]

Rain came down heavily, soaking everything beneath it. In a forest, a horse galloped. "Too slow! Pick up the pace! Run, you lead-footed laggards!"

The trainees ran, carrying large packs.

Lead-footed laggards, maggots, barn animals, he sure had a way with words . Hange smiled, reminisce.

Keith slowed. "What's your problem, Arlert?! You're dragging your feet! Too heavy for you? Maybe you'd prefer I let you drop your gear? If this were a real mission, you'd be Titan food by now!" He galloped ahead.

"Damn." Armin gasped.

"Give it here!" Reiner grabbed his pack. "You're gonna fail out at this rate! We're being graded today!"

The recruits shot Armin curious looks. Had Reiner helped him pass?

Armin kept his eyes forward, unwilling to see their expressions.

"But you'll get points marked off, too, if you do that, Reiner."

"Then make an effort not to get caught. Don't make me change my mind."

Reiner Braun. **Keith watched them sneakily.**

He knew? Armin's eyes widened.

"Oh shit," Connie muttered. Were they going to get in trouble? He couldn't remember that happening, though.

He has both a robust physique and mental strength. **Keith continued his evaluation.** ***His comrades also have great trust in him.***

The veteran Scouts saw the recruits nodding along with Keith's words.

"I refuse to be a burden!" With determination, Armin shot forward. "Even if it costs me my life!" He snatched back his pack. Breathing heavily, he raced ahead.

Eren and Mikasa smiled proudly. They never had any doubts.

Armin Arlert **. Keith thought.** ***Although lacking in physical strength, his aptitude in the classroom is extraordinary.***

Ahead, a Titan dummy was raised. Jean, Bert, and Annie sliced through the nape. ***Annie Leonhart. Her slice attacks are***

absolutely flawless, but her reclusive tendencies make her a poor fit for coordinated efforts.

It was then they realized what they were watching. The recruits sat straighter. They'd seen the scores but the evaluation was for their superiors' eyes only. They were eager to know how they were rated.

Bertolt Hoover. He possesses remarkable potential but lacks assertiveness. **Keith noted.** ***Jean Kirschtein.***

Jean perked up at his name.

Top-class 3D mobility.

Jean beamed.

But his volatile personality tends to cause friction with others.

Eren and Connie laughed the loudest.

"I can't slice as good as those two! I'll just have to find the Titans before them!" With great ease, Jean navigated through the forest. "If anyone gets into the Military Police it'll be me!

"Thanks for the help, Jean!" Connie passed him by. "Following you was a good idea!"

"Cheater!" Jean glared. "Piggy-backing off me, find your own Titan!"

"Hooray!" Sasha cheered, having gotten the kill before Connie.

Sasha Braus. She has unconventionally good intuition but also demonstrates poor teamwork as a result. **Keith noted before moving to his next student.** ***Connie Springer. He excels at executing quick turns but is also a bit dim-witted.***

Jean pointed and laughed.

"Here they come," one of the helpers said. The other one pulled the lever, setting up two Titan dummies.

Mikasa zipped by and cut both deeply.

"Wow, she moves like you, Captain." Petra turned to him.

Levi was studying the TV curiously.

Erwin looked between him and the teenage girl with interest, mind filling with possibilities.

"Damn!" Eren cursed. "Shallower than Mikasa again!"

"Why do you constantly compare yourself to her?" Ymir said, shaking her head. "She's totally on another level. Just accept it and move on."

Mikasa Ackerman* . Keith observed his best student. *Completely proficient in every area. It's apt to say she's an unmatched, unprecedented genius.

"See?"

Eren Yeager. He has no real specialties, but he's improved his grades with his unparalleled effort. And he possesses twice the sense of purpose than anyone else.

Thus, the evaluations ended.

"I'm very interested to see you fighting in the Battle for Trost," Petra said excitedly, looking to her left, catching Mikasa's eye.

"Me, too." Eren turned to face Petra. "I don't remember transforming and fighting at all." He was itching to see it happen.

"Uh, yeah."

"She was talking about Ackerman," Levi added unnecessarily.

"I meant Eren, too!" Petra didn't want to hurt his feelings. Clearly he had a bit of an inferiority complex when it came to her. While Petra understood the benefits of competition, if Mikasa truly was someone on Levi's level, and a hard worker as well, there was really nothing Eren could do. The whole one-sided rivalry would only hurt him if he couldn't accept she would always be better than him.

"I wanna watch Eren go crazy in his Titan form!" Hange declared.

Christa pouted. "I can't believe I missed it."

"It was pretty epic," Connie admitted.

"It was." Armin nodded. "We were as good as dead until he showed up."

Even Jean agreed, crossing his arms and grunting.

Now Eren and Hange were even more pumped. "I wonder how long we'll have to wait," she said impatiently.

Reiner charged. Eren slammed him into the dirt. "Ow!" Reiner winced.

"Sorry." Eren offered him a hand. "I'm not good at holding back."

"Now it's your turn to be the criminal." Reiner held out the wooden knife. "What's the matter?"

"I don't get this training." Eren accepted the knife. "Why would soldiers fight other people? Only an idiot would take on a target barehanded."

"Sometimes there is no other choice," Levi said. He'd killed his fair share of people with his bare hands.

A grainy image of little Eren standing looking down with a spear embedded in something flashed on the screen.

"Wow!" Connie yelled.

"What was that?" Christa's eyes widened.

Was that a body? Jean wracked his brain. It had appeared only for a split second. *It couldn't be...*

"Did you kill someone?" Ymir blurted out.

"What happened?" Sasha asked.

"It doesn't matter." Mikasa's tone, paired with the deadly look in her eyes, shut them down. But not their imaginations. They looked to the far right couch. Based on their carefully neutral expressions, it was clear their superiors obviously knew what that was about.

"That's irresponsible thinking," Reiner scolded. "We're soldiers. There are times we can't run away, no matter how bad the situation is."

Around them, the trainees continued to spar.

"No matter what the enemy is, we have to be ready for it, whether it means using cannons or combat techniques. I believe that's the responsibility of a strong soldier."

"He's a fine young man." Erwin nodded in approval. "We're lucky to have such an asset on our side."

"Anyway, look there," Reiner said.

"Oh, it's Annie," Eren said. "She's slacking off without the commandant noticing again."

"Alright, Eren. That slacker needs a lecture, too. Let's teach her how a soldier's supposed to act."

"Huh?"

Eren groaned.

"What's up?" Petra asked.

"You'll see."

Annie was looking behind her and ended up almost running into Reiner's chest. He smirked down at her,. "Not fond of the commandant's head-butts? If you don't wanna end up any shorter, think back to why you enlisted in the first place and start taking things seriously."

"Idiot," Ymir said.

"Hey, now, what'd you say that for?" Eren came up to them, then he saw Annie's murderous expression. *Man, she's pissed. I thought she looked scary before. You couldn't pay me enough to be on her bad side.*

"Oh, this is gonna be good." Jean grinned.

"Alright!" Reiner came up behind Eren and grabbed his shoulders. "Get started, Eren!"

"Me?!"

"Coward," Eren huffed. "Talking big about teaching her a lesson and forcing me into becoming her punching bag."

"Reiner's too smart to fight Annie himself," Armin said.

Annie got into position.

"You know the drill, right, Annie? Here I come!" Eren charged. Seconds later, he was down. "Wh-What the?! She kicked my leg?!" He tried to stand and fell.

"Can I go now?" Annie asked Reiner.

"No!" He placed his hands on his hips. "The drill's not over until you take the dagger!"

She sighed in irritation and turned back to Eren.

"Wait, Annie! There's a method to this!"

Annie took the dagger without effort and kicked his legs out from under him, knocking him down.

"She kicked your ass." Jean snickered.

"Totally one way," Connie agreed.

"I'd like to see the two of you fight her once and then we'll talk," Eren shot back.

That promptly shut the two up.

"There." Annie tossed the dagger to Reiner. "Now it's your turn to attack me."

"Turnabout is fair play." Christa giggled.

"He's so screwed," Armin said.

"N-No, I'm—"

"Do it, Reiner," Eren said. "I thought you wanted to teach her about a soldier's responsibility?"

The viewers laughed at Eren's silly position on the ground.

"Yeah. Sometimes a soldier can't back down. This is one of those times!" Reiner was immediately knocked down.

Causing more laughter.

"That's an amazing technique. Who did you learn it from?" Eren asked.

"My father."

"Your dad came up with that move?"

"What does it matter?" Annie said harshly. "There's no point to any of this."

"You mean this training?"

"The training does have merit, though. It teaches self-defense. And it's an especially important skill for future MP soldiers, who have to take on human opponents," Petra explained.

"We aren't graded on our hand-to-hand combat skills. Most people brush it off, like them, because only the top ten trainees are allowed to join the Military Police and serve in the interior."

Jean fought Marco while Christa took on Mikasa.

Annie kept talking. "The only ones who take it seriously are naive idiots like you or just ordinary idiots."

"I kinda wanna know what category of idiot she put me in," Connie said.

"Why?" Christa asked.

"Eh." He shrugged. "Just curious."

"You have your own special category of idiot, Connie," Jean said jokingly.

Connie and Sasha were fooling around. "Shit! The commandant!" Eren said.

Keith walked up to the duo goofing off and squeezed Connie's head.

"Why does he always pick on me?" Connie whined.

Annie took the initiative, attacking Eren. "For some reason, in this world, the better you are at fighting Titans the further you can get from them. How do you think this farce came about?"

"I never thought about that." Christa frowned, thinking.

"It does seem pretty backwards," Jean admitted. He didn't always care about that. His thoughts turned to the Battle for Trost. Amazing what a difference one day could make in the view of a person.

"I don't know." Eren yanked her arm, pulling her close. "That's a good question."

Annie crouched and swept her leg under his. Straddling him, she held the knife above his throat. "Maybe because it's human nature? Anyway." She stood, tapping the knife against her chest. "I refuse to be stupid enough to play 'soldier' in this inane world."

"Looks like you're not much of a soldier at all," Reiner said as she passed by.

I was so caught up in getting stronger that I never realized it. It's such a clear contradiction.* Eren thought. *They're honing their Titan-killing skills just to get away from the Titans!

Sasha shook her head. "That just doesn't seem right."

"That's the way it's always been," Erwin answered.

"Can't the system be changed?" Christa asked.

"The only ones who have the power to do that like it how it is."

"It can't be helped," Armin said later that evening in the mess hall. "Before Wall Maria fell, only the Scouts needed 3D gear, and they're a small regiment."

"Give it a strong blast for just a second." Jean was talking to Marco.

"So this was a way to prevent its decline," Armin continued.

"Relying on inertia will save you gas."

"You figured that out while you were still a trainee?" Hange asked Jean. Most trainees were scared used the gas excessively, wanting complete control.

"Well, I don't like to brag—"

"Yes, you do," several voices rang at once.

"You make it sound so simple," Marco said.

"Yeah, maybe not everyone can pull it off but there's no harm in knowing about it, if you wanna join the Military Police."

"Yeah! I'd love to get in! Working near the king, there's no greater honor than that!"

He actually believes that? That's rare. Levi thought.

"C'mon on, Marco!" Jean slapped his back, making him spill his drink over his face. "Quit talkin' like a goody-two-shoes and say what you really think! You wanna join the Military Police 'cause it means a safe, comfy life in the interior!"

"No! I really do want to—"

"It's comfy in the interior?" Eren interrupted. "Until five years ago, this used to be the interior, too."

"Didn't anyone ever teach you not to eavesdrop on other people's conversations?" Ymir said.

"I wasn't eavesdropping," Eren said it a little too quickly and defensively to be believable.

"What's your point, Eren?"

"Jean, you don't need to go to the interior. I'd say your head is nice and spacious enough as it is."

Connie, Reiner, and many other trainees chuckled.

The viewers chuckled, too.

Jean scowled. "The hell was your problem, Yeager? No one asked for your opinion."

"I was annoyed and I wanted to pick a fight."

"Prick."

"Asshole."

"You little—"

"Honing your Titan-killing skills to get away from the Titans," Eren said. "Doesn't that seem like a weird system to you?"

"You only say that now?" Jean stood up. "I want that stupid system to stay in place, for my sake."

"You piece of trash!" Eren got up.

"I see," Jean said suddenly. "You got pissed because I already figured that out and you only found out after Annie told you."

Eren refused to say anything.

"Shut up!" Jean yelled and Eren grabbed his collar. "This is the real world!"

"Eren, calm down!" Armin said.

"Stop that." Mikasa came up to them. She grabbed Eren's hand and removed it from Jean's collar. The two stared at each other in front of Jean. Mikasa was still holding his arm, and Eren gave in.

"Don't screw with me, you bastard!" Jean grabbed his collar.

"Jealously is an ugly thing, Jean."

"Fuck you, Springer."

"Huh?! Let go! You're gonna rip it!"

"I don't give a damn about your clothes! I'm jealous!"

"Did you just admit it?" Hange raised an eyebrow.

"That's very bold of you," Petra said.

When will this teenage drama end? Levi sighed. The first two episodes were interesting. They had seen the Colossal Titan and the Armored Titan and how they attacked. The last episode had been dull, without much to see. It had been mostly the recruits reliving the first days of their training years.

Levi really hoped things would pick up already. He failed to see how watching the love triangle was going to help humanity. He wanted Erwin to try skipping it but the commander seemed to be enjoying himself. *Ugh* .

"Huh?! What are you talking about?!" Suddenly, it hit Eren. The trainees were all watching them. *I see now. He always has to*

take his feelings out on others. Just like I always do.

"That's part of it," Petra said. "How did you miss the jealously bit?"

"Eren doesn't understand the concept of romance," Armin said. "It really isn't his forte."

" *That* would be being a hothead and bitching non-stop about killing Titans," Ymir piped in.

"I'm sitting right here, you know."

But not this time! **Eren grabbed Jean's arm.** ***I'm going to use that move to take control of the situation!*** **He knocked Jean off his feet with Annie's signature move.**

Annie's eyes widened at the sight.

"Whoa."

"Wow!"

Mikasa gritted her teeth. It irked her that Eren had purposefully chosen something he picked up from Annie and used it to not just defend himself but make his point. Annie constantly beat him into the dirt and made insulting remarks. Mikasa didn't understand why Eren never got mad at Annie but always snapped at her.

"What the hell was that?!" Jean sat up.

"A combat technique I learned the hard way while you were screwing around," Eren answered. "A carefree, capricious life is your idea of the real world? And you honestly call yourself a soldier?"

No one spoke, watching the scene, waiting to see what would happen next.

The door creaked open. Surprised, they all turned to see half of Keith looking in, appearing slightly unhinged.

"That's creepy." Christa shivered.

Erwin sighed. "I see he hasn't lost that habit." It used to scare the shit out of the new recruits.

"I heard a loud sound just now. Would anyone care to explain?"

None spoke up. Jean and Eren quietly returned to their seats. Mikasa suddenly raised her hand and said in a deadpan, "Sasha just ripped a giant fart."

Everyone began laughing loudly and Sasha turned red.

Sasha was horrified. The trainees trembled as they tried to muffle their laughter. "Huh?! You again?" Keith covered his nose. "Learn some decency, will you?!" He closed the door behind him.

They laughed even more, causing her to cover her face in embarrassment.

Mikasa gave the harassed girl her bread to quiet her down while Jean and Eren continued to glare at each other.

"I can't remember the last time I laughed so hard." Hange took a deep breath.

"Me, too." Petra's cheeks were flushed.

Connie grinned. "Ah, good times."

"Man, I needed that," Jean said.

"Glad you all feel better at my expense." Sasha sulked, arms crossed, pouting.

"I'm sorry," Christa said. The big smile on her face took away from it, though.

"And so, two-hundred and eighteen trainees made it to graduation."

"Give your hearts!"

"Yes, sir!"

"You have three options after you graduate from the Trainee Corps today! The Garrisons, which reinforces the Walls and protects each city! The Survey Corps, which risks life and limb to venture into Titan territory outside the Walls! And the Military Police, which serves under the king by policing the people and preserving order! Of course, the only ones allowed to join the Military Police are the top ten trainees who were previously named!"

The top ten stood side-by-side in order of their ranking: Mikasa, Reiner, Bert, Annie, Eren, Jean, Marco, Connie, Sasha, and Christa.

"So almost all of the top graduates from your class joined?" Petra asked.

"Everyone aside from Annie," Eren replied. "And Marco..."

We've finally made it here. Now it's our turn to devour the Titans! **Eren promised.**

"Yes!" Connie grinned. "Now I'm gonna be in the Military Police!"

Connie sighed. *Mom and Dad would have been so happy if I'd gone ahead with that* . He winced, he still hadn't told his parents about joining the Survey Corps.

"No more worrying about food!" Sasha cheered.

"I can't believe I gave that up."

"How'd I get ranked under Eren?! Damn!" Jean took a deep swig from his mug.

"Don't even," Jean said when Eren opened his mouth.

"Are you seriously not gonna join the Military Police, Eren?" Thomas asked.

"Even after you got into the top ten and all?" Samuel said.

"My mind was set from the very start. I didn't train all this time to live in the interior. I did it to fight the Titans."

"We can't beat them!" Thomas yelled.

The room instantly quieted.

"We can." Eren clenched his hand.

We have a real shot now. Erwin thought to himself.

"You know how many tens of thousands of people have been eaten so far? The answer was clear after we lost twenty percent of our population. Humanity can't beat the Titans."

"So? You're gonna give up because you think we can't win?" Eren retorted.

"Well…"

"Yes, humanity has lost so far. That's because we were clueless about the Titans! Material warfare is useless against them. We lost, but the information we gained in battle will lead to further hope! Are we just going to throw away all the advances in fighting techniques that cost us tens of thousands of lives so we can be Titan fodder?!"

Every pair of eyes was on him.

"To hell with that! I'm going to drive out every last Titan and leave these cramped Walls! That's my dream! Humanity hasn't truly been defeated yet!" Gritting his teeth, Eren left.

They were feeling pumped up just by listening to him on TV.

"That was a truly passionate speech," Erwin praised.

"Nicely said," Hange said.

Eren ducked his head in embarrassment.

"Wait, Eren!" Armin and Mikasa went after him.

If you wanna go outside the Walls, be my guest! I'm gonna join the Military Police! **Jean thought.**

So much for that dream. Jean sighed. Sometimes he wished he could go back to that.

"Eren," Armin said, "that stuff about your dream just now…"

"Yeah, I borrowed those ideas of yours about going outside instead of staying inside."

More than a few surprised looks were sent toward Armin. Hot-headed and brash Eren rushing outside made sense. Somehow, they couldn't imagine the idea had originated from the quiet, almost-shy boy.

"I'm going to join the Survey Corps!"

"Are you serious, Armin?! You were the top in classroom studies! You should put that to use!" Eren said.

"I won't be a burden. Even if it costs me my life."

But I was *a burden, and it almost cost Eren* his *life.* Armin's eyes stung.

"I'll join the Scouts, too," Mikasa said.

"Hey! You graduated top of the class! You should join the Military Police!"

"If you join the Military Police, then I will, too. If you join the Garrisons, then I will, too. Because you'll die an early death unless I'm around."

Remember, she's only keeping her promise to Mom. She's not trying to be condescending. Eren gritted his teeth. "Thanks for the vote of confidence."

"You did get eaten," Petra pointed out. He shot her a look of betrayal while Mikasa nodded at the support. *Oops* , Petra covered her mouth.

"I never asked for your protection."

"I don't want to lose any more of my family."

Well, I can't argue with that. Eren thought.

"It's here! The main unit of the Survey Corps!"

"Commander Erwin! Give those Titans a real thrashing for me!"

"Maybe we'll see us soon!" Hange's eyes gleamed. "There I am!"

"Look! It's Captain Levi! They say he's as mighty as an entire brigade!"

"Ugh, shut up already," Levi grumbled.

"Levi! There you are!"

"I know, I'm not the one who needs glasses to see."

"This is nothing like five years ago!" Eren smiled. "People actually feel hopeful about the Survey Corps!"

They frowned, remembering the negative comments. Then smiled, recalling little Eren hitting the man with a stick.

"Yeah," Hannah said, "everyone's cheered up since then. Nothing's happened in five years."

"They've upgraded the mounted cannons, too. I doubt the Colossal Titan will show up anymore," Franz said.

"Yeah!"

Levi rolled his eyes.

"Wishful thinking will never get you anywhere," Jean said.

"Seriously?" Ymir said. "Do they think just because there was peace for five years that Titans were suddenly no longer a threat?"

"I think they were just messing around," Armin told her.

"But there are many idiots that actually believe that," Eren said.

"That's a load of crap, you idiotic couple!" Eren glared.

"Wh-What? Us, a married couple?"

"You're getting ahead of yourself, Eren!"

"Hey, guys!" A masculine voice called out.

"Hey, it's your Garrison friend," Connie said. "I was wondering what happened to him."

"Hannes!"

"I heard you graduated yesterday. You squirts really shaped up."

"You too, Hannes!" Eren said. "You used to be a drunk, but now you're chief of the Corps of Engineers."

"He became a captain? Good for him!" Christa smiled.

"You little." Hannes flicked Eren's forehead playfully. He looked down and said sadly. "I'm sorry I couldn't save your mom."

"It wasn't your fault," Eren replied calmly, surprising the older man. "We're not ignorant anymore. We won't let another tragedy like that happen. We will defeat the Titans!"

"And you led humanity to our first victory," Petra said, making him smile.

***I don't know if I should be happy that you've grown up or not. Don't go dyin', now.* Hannes thought.**

Eren almost groaned. He had almost died just a couple of hours later.

On top of the Wall, the newly graduated trainees were performing maintenance work. "Huh?" Eren gaped. "You're joining the Scouts, Connie? You were so set on the Military Police!"

"Yeah, I was." Connie didn't look at him. He kept polishing the cannon.

"But sounds like your speech yesterday won him over." Mina came up to him.

"Huh?"

"Shut up." Connie turned to them, a little pink. "I decided it on my own!"

"Of course you did," Sasha said playfully.

"Don't be so embarrassed. You're not the only one," Thomas said.

"Thomas, you…"

"If you were able to get so many to change their minds and join us by delivering a powerful and passionate speech, maybe we should have you do the recruiting," Hange said, winking.

"Umm, everyone?" Sasha grabbed their attention. "I brought some meat from the officers' storehouse!"

Oh great, she's a klepto. Levi made a face. *She can't keep her grubby hands to herself.*

"Sasha! Do you want to end up in solitary confinement?!"

"You really are crazy!"

"So much that it's scary."

"We can all share it later. All sliced up, and between some bread." Sasha drooled, cheeks red. She let out a guttural sound in delight.

Jean shuddered at that. "I didn't know humans were capable of making such a noise."

"Go put it back!"

"Yeah. After we lost all that land, meat's become really valuable."

"It'll be fine!" Sasha went to the wooden ice-box. "We can just raise more cattle and sheep once we retake our land."

They smiled at that dream, which suddenly seemed within the realm of possibility.

Samuel gulped. "I'll have some of the meat!"

"M-Me too!" Connie said. "Save me some!"

"I'll have some too, of course!" Mina smiled.

"Guys…" Eren trailed off.

"Why are you just standing there, Eren?" Samuel asked. "We'll get found out if we don't get back to work! Lunch isn't for a while!"

Five years have passed since then.* Eren looked out at the city. *Humanity is finally regaining its dignity.* Cannons lined the Wall. *We can win!* He clenched his hand. *Humanity's retaliation is just beginning!

"Jinx."

"Ymir!"

Lightning struck. A mammoth face appeared behind Eren. They were frozen for a few seconds.

"Called it. You know, I think humanity would be a lot safer if you three stopped trying to predict horrific scenarios or be so overly confident that the universe has no choice but to screw you over," Ymir said.

Steam blew and the gate exploded. Debris flew and the winds ripped apart homes. The group on the Wall was knocked off as well. *Oww! Hot!* Eren quickly worked his 3D gear. *Wh-What the?!*

***"* Samuel!" Connie yelled, watching their comrade fall.**

"Sasha!" Mina called out.

Sasha ran down the Wall, one hook in the Wall, and shot the other hook Samuel's calf, stopping him from plummeting to his death. "Samuel, stay still!"

"How did you get him down?" Christa asked curiously.

"A group of Garrison soldiers came and helped."

That was close!* Then Eren saw it. *The Wall, it's broken!

"It's happening again! The Titans are going to get in!" Connie panicked.

His mother's death and the promise he made filled his mind. *"I'm going to kill every last one!"*

***Every…last…one…* Eren snapped out of his daze. "Mounted Cannon Maintenance Squad 4!" He readied his swords. "Prepare for battle! The target is the Colossal Titan dead ahead!" He swung up. "This is our chance! Don't let it get**

away!" Eren landed in a crouch and stared at the Colossal Titan. "Hey, there. It's been five years."

"Charging without even a second of hesitation, you really are something else," Petra said.

"Finally!" Hange threw her hands in the air. "We're getting to the battle!" She readied her pencil. "Gah! I wish Moblit was here! He's the artist."

"Did you notice anything or anyone out of the ordinary before he showed up?" Erwin asked. "Or immediately afterwards?"

"No, sir." Eren shook his head. "Everything was fine. And after he appeared, well, it got pretty crazy."

"Where did Thomas go?" Hange asked suddenly.

"Thomas? Uh, I'm not sure. Luckily though, he was off the Wall before the Colossal Titan appeared." Eren's face fell. "His luck didn't hold for long though."

"What do you mean?"

"He got eaten, right in front of us," Armin said. "Eren went totally berserk when he saw the Titan that ate him and killed it." Suddenly, something occurred to him.

"Really?" While she'd known about the mass killings, Hange hadn't known seeing the Titan that had eaten his comrade had sent Eren into even more rage. *Interesting, so he retained something of his human-self while in his Titan-form.*

"That's what I was told." Eren shrugged. From his comrades' descriptions, he was on total a rampage. And it frustrated him, not being able to remember. *But I'll get to watch it!*

Armin's mind was racing. He went over Erwin and Hange's questions. Pieces began to fall into place. "You think the Colossal

Titan, in his human form, was there. And he might even be someone we know."

"What?"

"How's that possible?"

"Why?"

"You really—"

Erwin spoke over the voices. "What makes you say that?"

"We know now that humans are capable of turning into Titans. Eren doesn't look anything like the other Titans when he transforms. Neither do the Colossal or the Armored. You asked if Eren saw anything or any *one* suspicious. The guards would have noticed something approaching from the opposite side. This person had to sneak from our side of the Wall. And you asked about Thomas, who leaves just before the Colossal Titan shows up. Meaning someone on our side, someone we might know, is the Colossal Titan."

"That's correct." Erwin was impressed with the boy's deduction. "It's the only thing that makes sense."

"But...why?" Christa said, dismayed.

"I'm hoping the TV will give us all the answers. So far, everything shown has been one-hundred percent accurate based on your reactions."

They didn't speak, choosing to digest his words.

I'm sure it's not someone we know . Eren's jaw clenched. They'd have noticed, wouldn't they? No way could someone pretending to be human live with them for years and not raise a hint of suspicion. "Let's keep watching. We'll find out the truth soon enough."

"Greetings! I have an announcement to make. "

"Candy?" Petra said in surprise. "That's new."

"She's never commented after an episode, only occasionally during one," Mikasa said.

Knowing it must be important, they leaned in to listen closely.

"The episode count has been upped from twenty-seven to thirty. There'll now be five extra episodes added in at the end instead of two. I wasn't going to at first, but then I figured, what the hell? Why not go all in? It'll help you all understand each other a little better at least."

"So that means three new episodes were added. Why?" Armin asked.

"And how?" Christa wondered. "She's not even here."

"Those questions are better left unsaid, I doubt we'll ever get the answers," Ymir pointed out.

"And why look a gift horse in the mouth?" Sasha agreed.

"True," Connie said. If a goddess, or whatever Candy was, was helping them by making such miracles happen, why waste the brain power on something likely beyond their comprehension?

Levi ended up verbalizing Connie's next thought. "If she wanted to tell us how she made all this happen, she'd have done it in the beginning. I doubt we'll ever know. Maybe at the end, but I'm not counting on it."

"You're probably right." Hange's shoulders dropped. Erwin and Armin mirrored her dejected expression. They, too, had really wanted to know how it was all possible.

"I suppose we'll just have to resign ourselves to the fact we'll never know," Erwin said.

"To be honest," Eren spoke up, "I don't really give a shit. As far as I'm concerned, Candy's helping us gain the knowledge to win the war. That makes her golden in my book, the rest I really couldn't care less about."

Because you're simple that way. Jean rolled his eyes. "I can't believe I'm saying this, but Yeager's right. No point in talking about something out of our control."

"If everyone's in agreement, then?" All heads nodded. "Alright," Erwin said, "I'll start the next episode now."

Please Review~

Episode - First Battle

Chapter 5: First Battle

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The 104th graduates learn that the Colossal Titan might be someone they know. Candy announces three new episodes were added.

"In the year 845, the Colossal Titan and the Armored Titan suddenly appeared, blah blah blah."

"Blah blah blah?" Jean parroted.

"Destroyed a Wall, etc, etc, etc, twenty percent of the population and one-third of territory gone, and so on and so forth, and finally year 850, the Giant Turd is back."

"How dare she make light of everything we've been through!" Eren was pissed. To think less than a minute ago, he thought so highly of her.

"Well, she promised answers and considering we're sitting around watching our past because of her, she must be some otherworldly deity or something." Armin shrugged. "The constant battles of us little humans to her mustn't be such a big deal."

"She's still a bitch for being so casual about our loss."

"Eren, that's enough!" Mikasa reprimanded, fearful of Candy smiting him.

"She can't be that bad since she's going to help us win, right?" Petra said.

"Good point," Christa agreed.

"Okay," Hange said quickly, not giving anyone else a chance to speak up, "now that we've established Candy is a magnanimous goddess, let's get back to the episode."

"She called him a 'Giant Turd.' What's that?" Connie whispered to Sasha.

Sasha shrugged. "I don't know."

The Colossal Titan used his massive right arm to scrape the top part of the Wall. *He went for the cannons!* Eren thought. *He didn't take out the gate by accident then, either! He does have intelligence!* The Colossal turned toward him.

His eyes were only shown briefly, but they didn't have the same look in them that all other Titans did. An eerie, empty gaze that changed into anger or greed in the presence of a human. No, the Colossal's eyes held another kind of emotion. The group shifted uncomfortably at the word Eren had used.

Intelligent.

A word not used for the carnivorous giants, but for their smaller prey.

The Colossal Titan reached out for Eren. Too slow. *Still, this is the perfect chance!* He swung around and landed on the large arm. *He's the only one who can destroy the Wall! If I can just take him out!* He began running up the arm.

The Colossal Titan his shoulder, causing Eren to lose his balance. With a quick maneuver, he tried to go for the nape. His target was directly in front of him. *Got you!* He dove for the kill.

A cloud of steam burst out before he could slice the skin. *It burns!*

Eren held on. He let out a battle cry and pushed forward, swinging his swords. They cut through steam, revealing nothing.

"Damn!"

"Ahh!"

"Really?"

"So close!"

"Fuck, are you kidding me?"

"You almost had him!" Petra said.

"Almost," Eren said, scowling.

Hange's pencil was flying across the notebook.

I missed? **Eren began to fall and shot a hook into the Wall. *No, the Colossal Titan disappeared!***

"Eren!" Thomas appeared above him. "Did you beat it?"

He showed up on the Wall, right after the Colossal Titan disappeared. Armin thought. If he hadn't died—been eaten right in front of them, undeniable—he'd think Thomas was the Colossal, too.

"No! It's just like five years ago! He disappeared just as suddenly as he appeared!"

He must be one of the trainees . Erwin frowned, deep in thought. *It's why he was able to blend in and hide so easily* .

Back on the Wall, Eren walked toward his comrades with slumped shoulders. "I'm sorry. I let him get away."

"You didn't step aside and let him waltz out of there." Petra shook her head. "Don't be so hard on yourself."

"Yeah, you almost had him. In fact, he was forced to run because you were so close to taking him down," Sasha pointed out.

"That's...true." He'd never thought of it that way.

"What are you apologizing for? We were so scared—"

"Hey!" Connie snapped. "There's no time for that! The Wall's been broken! We have to hurry and seal it before the Titans get in again!"

"What are you doing?!" A Garrison soldier appeared and they saluted him. "The Colossal Titan Response Operation is already underway! Return to HQ at once! Anyone who's come into contact with it, remember to give a report!"

"Yes, sir!" Eren replied.

"We pray for the advance team's success!" Connie said.

A bell rang, signaling the danger. People panicked, flooding the streets, rushing away from the oncoming danger. A little girl being carried over her father's shoulder dropped her doll. She watched with tearful eyes as it was stomped on by the crowd.

"Lucky that's the only casualty so far in the human stampede," Ymir said.

"Take only the absolute bare necessities! Please evacuate in a calm manner!"

"Those practice drills really helped," Hange said. "I haven't seen anyone get trampled." There was a possibility someone probably was killed off-screen. Still, they'd yet to see one person get accidentally killed by a fearful mob on the screen so she was hopeful it hadn't happened. Or at least that the casualties were minimal.

Back at the Wall, Garrison soldiers were preparing for battle. "If they break through here, we'll have another tragedy just like five years ago on our hands! We must hold the Titans off here!"

Soldiers worked the cannons. "Prepare to intercept!"

Titans wandered toward the hole. "Fire!" The aims met true, obliterating bodies.

Connie and Sasha cheered the loudest.

While the Titans were distracted and temporarily immobilized, the soldiers attacked. "Charge!"

At the HQ, a Garrison soldier was giving orders. "You trainees have successfully graduated! You are now proper soldiers! I have high hopes for you in this operation!"

"Don't worry, Hannah. I promise I'll keep you safe." Franz hugged her.

Armin swallowed roughly, knowing his fate.

"Franz…"

Mikasa ran by, looking around.

"Are you okay, Armin?" Eren knelt beside him.

Armin's hands were shaking badly as he tried to fill up his canister from the gas pipes attached to the wall. "I-I'm fine! I'll calm down soon enough. Still, this is bad!"

Mikasa came up behind them.

"We don't have the technology to quickly seal an 8-meter-high hole. And we never did manage to unearth that big rock near Zemo. Unless we seal the hole, this city's as good as lost."

"How did you plan on moving that rock, sir?" Jean asked.

"That was the Garrisons' responsibility so I don't know," Erwin replied. But he didn't think they'd figured a way yet.

Cannons fired at the Titans. One lost its legs and crawled forward, glaring.

Levi scowled. "Persistent little shit."

Another one sat up, its face healing. A Garrison soldier stared at the scene in horror. The bodies were scattered everywhere.

"It's only a matter of time until Wall Rose is breached!" Armin babbled. "In fact, if they ever feel like it, they can pretty much wipe out humanity anytime they want!"

Armin felt embarrassed for shaking like a twig and rambling foolishly while the others kept their cool.

"Armin." Eren grabbed his arm. "Calm down. This isn't like last time. Humanity won't give in to the Titans anymore!"

"I'm sorry," he said, calmer now. "I'm alright."

More and more Titans crawled through the hole.

"Like insects," Jean said in disgust.

Elsewhere, a beautiful castle stood near the water. A wild patch of white, pink, and yellow flowers grew by the shore, attracting butterflies. It was peaceful, completely different than the chaos at Trost.

"It's so beautiful," Christa said in awe. Forced to grow up alone and hidden from the rest of the world, she wouldn't have minded at all if that was where she had lived. She rubbed her arm absent-mindedly, recalling the children she had attempted to befriend throwing rocks at her, shouting hurtful things.

In an open hall, two men played chess.

"Are you playing seriously? There, I win again," the nobleman said.

Two Garrison soldiers and another man were present as well.

"We square off once a month, yet you never seem to improve at all, Pixis."

"Or you're just too dumb to catch onto the fact you're being played," Hange retorted.

"Oh, no, I am just no match for you, Lord Wald." Pixis touched his head, smiling sheepishly.

"Wald the Fat Flower," Levi scoffed.

" *I am just no match for you,* " Wald imitated him and shoved a fistful of cookies in his mouth. He laughed. "And you're the top officer in charge of the entire southern territory. How do you hope to triumph over the Titans with such paltry skill and intellect?"

"Fucking moron," Eren said angrily. He held great respect for the Garrison commander. He couldn't stand the jerk insulting the man's intelligence.

"Commander Pixis! I bring a message!" A soldier ran in, followed by a harassed-looking butler.

"How uncouth!" Wald made a face.

Petra rolled her eyes. "You're one to talk."

"Who are you?" Wald asked.

The soldier ignored him. "The Colossal Titan has appeared in Trost! The gate has been destroyed!"

Wald dropped his glass of wine in shock.

Not so tough, are you now? Eren smiled smugly.

The red liquid spilled everywhere. Standing, Pixis reached over and grabbed the bottle, swallowing deeply. "Mm, this is a fine drink, indeed. As your fellow on the field of battle, I will humbly accept it." He walked away.

"H-Hey! Wait, Pixis!"

Pixis's subordinates bowed to the nobleman and began to follow their commander.

"Pixis! Hey! Wait just a minute!" Wald and his associate chased after him. "I forbid you to leave! Assemble your troops immediately and defend my castle! That is your duty!"

"His duty is to people, not pigs," Levi said, sneering.

"Lord Wald, as we speak, soldiers in Trost are literally risking their lives in battle."

"Commander," Anka said, "I will ready the horses."

He nodded to her and continued, "I presume many lives are being lost as well. Right now, at this very moment."

"Hmp, insignificant lives," Wald said, "I'm sure. Forget about them. Your presence there won't change anything anyway. You continually lose to me in our tabletop skirmishes!"

"Fear not, Your Lordship," a Garrison soldier said. "Should he face the Titans on a real battlefield, the commander will not need to hold back."

"Ooooh!" Connie grinned.

"Take that," Eren said.

"Enough," Pixis said. "Lord Wald, please have another pleasant and peaceful day as always."

Smart of Pixis not to let his subordinate insult the man further, offending him and making an enemy of him later . Erwin thought.

"H-Hey! Pixis! Come back! Pixis! Pixis! "

"He squeals like a pig, too," Levi grumbled.

The HQ came into view.

"As practiced, you will now split into your squads and perform resupply, message relay, and Titan-clearing duties under the command of the Garrisons!"

"I know that voice." Mikasa's face pinched. "That foolish and cowardly Garrison captain that ordered we be blown to pieces."

"If Eren had reacted a second late..." Armin shivered.

Eren nodded. "Good thing Commander Pixis showed up when he did."

In the courtyard, soldiers stood. At the front was a brown-haired man with a beard and sunken eyes.

"Kitz Weilman." Erwin gave them a name to the face.

"The Garrison intercept squad will take the vanguard. The trainees, led by the support squad, will take the middle guard. And the Garrison's elite squads will take the rearguard. Additionally, I've received word that the advance team has been wiped out!"

They expected us to go out and fight when they looked like they'd already given up themselves. It was one of the main reasons Jean had lost his cool, feeling vulnerable and giving into his fear. As much as he disliked to admit it, even to himself, seeing Eren so confident had restored some faith in himself. And it had helped him get his emotions under control.

Eren gasped. The other trainees looked equally shocked.

"The outer gate has been breached, and the Titans have been allowed inside. In other words, the Armored Titan could very well appear again and demolish the inner gate at any time!"

"Look at them, Weilman and his subordinates look utterly terrified, not exactly a good way to inspire confidence in the rookies," Petra said.

"Commanding officers are *never* supposed to lose their cool," Levi said matter-of-factly.

Hange nodded. "Everyone is looking at them for guidance, seeing fear and uncertainty only makes the situation worse."

"You can't be serious."

"You gotta be kidding me!"

"If they end up breaching Rose—"

"Case-in-point."

"Quiet!" Weilman ordered. "The vanguard is currently engaged with the enemy. This defense operation has but one objective: Defend Wall Rose until the citizens have finished evacuating. Also, as I'm sure you're well aware desertion is punishable by death! Be prepared to lay down your lives! Dismissed!"

"Sir!"

Soldiers ran around, getting ready. "Why today?" Jean covered his face with one hand. "I would've been on my way to the interior tomorrow."

"Talk about bad luck," Ymir said.

A few feet over, Daz puked. "Are you okay?" Christa rubbed his back. In response, he threw up again.

"Gross," Sasha said.

"Ew." Connie made a face.

Both still continued to eat.

Jean moved past a few trainees who looked like they had completely given up and were now wallowing in self-pity.

"No, no, no…" One of them whimpered.

Not paying attention, Jean ended up running into Eren. They both looked at each other, startled. "Fuck off!" He tried to move past him.

"Hey, Jean!" Eren grabbed his arm. "What's wrong with you?"

"What's wrong? **That's easy for you to say, Suicidal Bastard!" Jean stepped in. "You wanted to join the Survey Corps!" His yelling attracted Mikasa's attention. "You're ready to be Titan chow anytime! But I was headed for the interior tomorrow!"**

Jean felt embarrassed, watching himself lose control. *And in front of Eren and Mikasa of all people.*

"Calm down!" Eren said as Mikasa walked closer.

"You expect me to calm down and accept death?!"

"No!" Eren forced him back against a pillar. "Think back! Think back to the three years of sweat and blood we endured!"

"You should've used the head-butt, unconsciously making him remember Keith and all your training," Hange said.

"I know!" Eren slapped his forehead.

"So many times we came close to dying during those three years! Some people did die. Some ran off. Others were kicked out. But we survived. Right?!" Eren demanded.

The trainees who had thrown in the towel straightened up, listening to him.

"I'm sure we can survive today, too! You can just survive today and leave for the interior tomorrow!"

There's that empowering speech ability of his again. Petra smiled.

Jean blinked, stunned. "Damn!" He turned and walked away. "Let's go, Daz! Quit your damn cryin'!"

"R-Right."

Petra leaned over and ruffled Eren's hair. "See? You were giving people hope even before you could turn into a Titan. And they, in turn, helped others to get back up on their feet." He smiled brightly at her, happiness spreading in his chest. *There* , she thought. Hopefully he would stop being at least *a little* less critical about himself. The whole obsessively comparing himself to Mikasa all the time was going to take a while, though.

"Eren," Mikasa said, "if the battle gets chaotic, come find me."

She's keeping her promise to Mom. Eren thought repeatedly, trying not to get irritated.

"Huh? We're in different squads!"

"In amidst the fray, things won't go according to plan. I'll protect you!"

Levi rolled his eyes. "Obsessive much."

"What the hell are you—"

"Trainee Ackerman," a Garrison soldier, Ian, interrupted, "you're in the rearguard. Special orders, come with me."

"I-I'm not skilled enough!" Mikasa protested. "I'll only be a burden!"

"I am not asking for your opinion. The citizens' evacuation is behind schedule. We need as many elite soldiers near them as possible."

"B-But—"

"Hey!" Eren stepped in and head-butted her.

"So you did use the Head-Butt." Hange grinned.

"Cut the crap, Mikasa!" Eren scolded her. "Quit freaking out like everyone else. Humanity's on the verge of extinction here. This is no time to go and impose your own selfish rules."

"I'm sorry. I wasn't thinking clearly." Mikasa grabbed Eren's sleeve as he turned away, head slightly bowed. "I do have one thing to ask. Please don't die."

He snatched his sleeve and walked away without a word.

Several mouths opened but Eren quickly cut in, "Yes, yes, dick move, I know."

For the longest time, he felt justified at his attitude toward Mikasa. But watching it on screen, without the heat of the situation clouding his mind, made him feel like an asshole. He hoped Mikasa, too, at least understood how overbearing she tended to be and ease up a little.

I won't die.* Eren thought. *I can't die yet! Because I still don't know what this world is really like!

Eren winced, considering what was going to happen soon.

Squad 34, Eren, Armin, Mina, Thomas, Nic, and Milieus stood upon the rooftops, waiting.

"Surviving historical documents say nothing about the origin of the Titans. Most everything remains unknown."

A flashback of the trainees learning about the Titans began.

The teacher explained, "The things we do know about them now, including Titan ecology, are based entirely on the latest reports from the Survey Corps. We've been unable to determine

if the Titans possess human-like intelligence. As such, there've been no cases to date of mutual communication."

Candy coughed.

"What was that?" Christa asked.

"Hey, who knows, maybe deities need to cough, too," Connie said.

"I don't know," Petra said uncertainly. "Seemed to me like it was done on purpose."

Levi, Hange, and Erwin shared a look. They, along with Mike and Nanaba, were the only ones who knew what was written in Ilse's journal, about a Titan that talked.

A drawing of a Titan healing while calmly walking past two deer appeared.

"Titan physiology is fundamentally different from that of other living beings. They lack reproductive organs, and it is unclear how they reproduce, but they primarily possess male-like physiques."

The deer ignored the gigantic foot just a few feet from them.

"They have extremely high body temperatures, and, perplexingly enough, they show no interest in anything but humans. Consuming people is the Titans' sole principle of behavior, but given that they've existed for over a century in a human-less environment, we can surmise that their purpose is not predation, but annihilation."

"Hm-hm."

"That cough was no accident," Ymir said. "She's making comments on purpose on humanity's knowledge of Titans."

"We already know everything the teacher is saying to be true, the evidence is overwhelming," Armin said. "How will agreeing with it help? It has to mean something more."

"And, most of all, the Titans' tremendous vitality is the primary reason that humankind has been so greatly overwhelmed. Humanity has long possessed cannon technology, but that alone wasn't enough to combat them." Titans walked toward a castle, arms outstretched.

"They look like giant, naked zombies—the slow, stupid kind—walking like that."

"What are zombies?" Sasha wondered.

"Hm, apparently, they're a smaller version of Titans, but with clothes," Hange said. Could the two be related? Did these zombies exist in the outside world? Did they have sexual organs, unlike the Titans? How did they reproduce? Could figuring it out help solve some riddles about the Titans?

So many questions... She really hoped Candy would provide lots of answers. She really preferred to figure it out herself—it was more fun that way—rather than to have the answers handed to her on a silver platter. But considering they'd been losing the war for over a hundred years, maybe it was better to take the shortcut.

"Even when their heads are blown off, Titans don't die. Additionally, although there is some variability, their heads will fully regenerate in only a minute or two."

"You can't be serious."

"Their size is bad enough as it is."

"Sir!" Marco stood up. "Does that mean the Titans are immortal?"

"As a wise man once said: Nothing is infinite, except maybe for human stupidity."

No one could argue with that, even if it did feel a little insulting.

"They are not immortal. There is one way to defeat a Titan." The teacher drew a Titan with its back turned. "You target here." He circled the nape. "When severely damaged here, a Titan will die without regenerating. That's where these two flesh-paring blades come in." He gestured to the swords on the table. "A successful strike to a Titan's weak spot with these will cause its immediate death, with no time to regenerate whatsoever."

"Hm…"

No one knew what to make of that.

"Can't she use complete sentences?" Eren grumbled quietly. She proved she could when she was insulting humans.

Mikasa gave him a suspicious look, unsure if he was insulting Candy.

"Hey, Armin, this is the perfect chance, don't you think? If we prove ourselves in this first battle before we've even joined the Scouts, we rookies will shoot up the ranks for sure!" Eren grinned.

I was so full of myself. Eren's shoulders slumped. *And look what happens not five minutes later.*

Armin had picked up on his best friend's confidence. "Yeah. No question about it."

"Just so you know," Mina said, "quite a few of us wanna join the Scouts this year."

Most of them won't live for much longer. Eren thought gloomily.

"You beat us to the punch earlier, but you won't outdo us this time!"

"Sounds like a challenge, Thomas!" Eren said.

"Whoever takes out the most Titans wins!" Thomas replied.

"Don't go fudging your numbers!"

"What's that?" Jean asked. White words had appeared at the bottom of the screen.

"Squad 34, move out! Bolster the vanguard!"

"My mistake." Erwin paused the episode, studying the remote in his hands. "I accidentally pushed a button."

"What button?" Hange asked.

"It's called 'Subtitles.' I assume it adds the dialogue for us to read."

"It does, but we don't need it," Levi said. "Unless someone is hard of hearing here?"

Everyone shook their heads.

"It's a little distracting," Christa said.

"Let me see." Erwin pressed the button again before hitting play.

"Alright! Let's go!" Eren led the squad, flying toward the breach.

"There we go."

"That many Titans got in already?" Mina observed the giants walking around.

"The vanguard's been totally routed!" Thomas noted.

That should have been our first clue. Armin sighed. *If the veterans had been so easily killed, we should have proceeded with more caution instead of just running ahead without scouting.*

"What are our glory-hound seniors doing?"

I figured things would be bad, but this… **Then Eren noticed it, a Titan leaping from building to building. "An Abnormal! Look out!" They quickly moved out of dodge. It slammed into a tower. Eren watched, hanging from the edge of the building.**

Thomas gasped, upside down, the lower half of his body inside the Titan's mouth.

"Thomas..." Sasha stared, wide-eyed.

"Oh man..."

"Poor Thomas," Christa said.

"Shit," Jean muttered.

Squad 34 stared in shock and horror. The Titan threw its head back and swallowed. It started to walk away. Eren became enraged. "Where the hell are you going, motherfucker?!"

"Eren, don't go off on your own!" Armin yelled.

"What were you thinking?" Mikasa rounded on him. "Why did you go chasing after an Abnormal by yourself?!"

"I can't change the past," he told her. "And I wasn't thinking, I was feeling—angry."

"Get back here, damn it!" Eren flew after it, furious.

"Eren!" Armin went after him. Mina followed and so did the other two members of their squad.

"You're gonna pay for killing Thomas! I won't let you get away! I won't!" Eren shot forward, ignoring oncoming Titan. It jumped up and took a bite out of him, sending him crashing on many roofs before coming to a stop, still.

"Are you soft in the head?" Levi asked. "What made you think it was a good idea to charge in like a moron and ignore the 15-meter dead ahead? You didn't think it was gonna stand there and let you pass, did you?"

Eren wilted under the reprimanding tone and harsh look.

Mikasa clutched his arm tightly, staring at the screen with wide eyes.

"Eren!" Armin dropped on a roof.

"Eren!" Mina yelled. A Titan grabbed another trainee's wire, yanking him. Distracted, she didn't notice another Titan plucking her wire, sending her crashing into a building, almost knocking her unconscious. It peered down at her. Armin trembled, watching the scene.

It's all my fault. They died because they were chasing after me. Eren could barely hold back his tears.

"Stop! Please stop!" Nic cried, but it fell on deaf ears.

Armin collapsed onto his knees, staring at Eren's bleeding body across the roof. *Why? Why am I…watching as my friends get eaten?*

Why am I so weak? Armin gritted his teeth.

I should've been there! Mikasa felt so angry with herself. Screw the orders, Eren and Armin came first.

The ground shook. Armin's eyes shifted to the left. A 15-meter with a white beard stood there, smiling.

***"No Santa!"* Candy cried out.**

They nearly jumped in surprise.

"What is she talking about?" Connie looked around.

"Who's Santa?" Eren asked while trying to get Mikasa to loosen up. His arm was starting to grow numb.

"I'm not entirely sure what's going on," Erwin said, puzzled.

"Why did you have to become…SanTitan?!"

"Uh..." Jean scratched his head.

"What?" Christa was confused while Ymir looked thoughtful.

"San...Titan?" Petra furrowed her eyebrow. "As in, Santa and Titan? So, this 'Santa' became a Titan?"

"Maybe it'll shows who this 'Santa' is and how a Titan is born." Hange perked up.

Who the hell cares who Santa is? Levi scowled. He just wanted to move forward with the battle. First the teenage drama and now Candy's drama, he could not for the life of him understand just how it was helping humanity. They'd yet to see anything that could be useful for the upcoming expedition.

"I get the feeling she's not serious," Ymir said. "She's being theatrical."

Why won't…my body…move? **Armin was like a limp puppet. SanTitan picked him up and opened its mouth. It dropped him in its mouth. He panicked, struggling not to slip down.**

"Armin!" Mikasa gasped, clutching him with her other hand.

Levi looked revolted. "Disgusting."

Armin cried out. On the roof, Eren began to stir. "A-Armin…"

A voice echoed in his head. *"Eren! Eren!"*

"Eren!"

"What is it, Armin?" Eren sat on the ground, lazily watching the clouds move.

"My grandpa was hiding this book." He held up a brown book with gold detail. "It's a book about the outside world!"

"Really?" Erwin turned to him. "Do you still have that book?"

"No." Armin shook his head sadly. "Unfortunately, it was left behind when we escaped."

"That's too bad," Erwin said, disappointed.

"We can look for it when we go back to my house," Eren said, cheering him up.

"A book about the outside world? Isn't it illegal to have those? What if the Military Police find out?" Eren asked.

"Who cares about that now?" Armin said excitedly. "According to this book, most of the world is covered in water called an 'ocean!'"

"So we're surrounded by a large body of water called the ocean," Petra said. She tried imagining water as far as the eye could see. *It must be so beautiful.*

"And this 'ocean' is entirely saltwater!" Armin said excitedly.

"Really? No way!" Connie gasped.

Meanwhile Sasha drooled at the thought. Meat and salt made such a good combination.

"Salt?! Y-You're lying!" Eren replied disbelievingly. "Salt is a treasure trove! I'm sure merchants would've snatched it all up!"

"You can't, though! The ocean is that big!"

"Yeah, right."

"There's a lot more than mountains of salt, too!"

They leaned in, trying to take a closer look at the drawings in the notebook.

"Fiery water! Lands of ice! Sandy snowfields! The outside world must be many times larger than the inside of these Walls!"

Eren was in awe. "The outside world…"

"And," Armin whispered, "this is still a secret, but my mom and dad are planning to venture into the outside world."

"What?" Christa gasped.

"Really?" Jean asked him.

"That's crazy!" Connie said.

"How?" Sasha asked.

"What happened?" Hange was blind to Petra subtly shaking her head. "Did they make it? How did they prepare? What—"

"Hange." Erwin stopped her, hand on her shoulder. "He doesn't want to talk about it."

"Oh, right, I forgot." Her face fell. "I'm sorry, Armin." The others chimed in with their apologies as well, remembering his argument with Eren the day after Wall Maria had fallen, about him saying his parents had been killed by Titans.

"It's alright." Armin forced a smile, knowing they'd only been taken by surprise at his younger self's words.

"The outside world, huh."

"Hey, Eren, I hope we can explore the outside world, too, someday."

Eren sat up, determined.

The intense music and emotion behind the scene had the viewers sitting straight, not wanting to miss a second.

Armin screamed, slipping down.

Mikasa's grip on him tightened as if it would stop him.

Eren grabbed his best friend's hand. Gritting his teeth, he used one hand to grip SanTitian's teeth and threw Armin outside its mouth.

"Eren!" Armin cried out.

Eren struggled to keep SanTitan's mouth open. "You think I'm… going to die here? Listen, Armin…you told me about it… So, I

have to…see it…the outside world…" He reached out.

"Stubborn idiot." Connie grinned. That pigheadedness would be his saving grace.

"Eren!" Armin moved forward, arm outstretched. "Hurry!"

SanTitan chomped down, sending Eren's arm flying out. Armin screamed, crying, as SanTitan swallowed with a smile.

Everyone collectively turned to see Eren, to check to see he was there. Petra actually pinched his cheek to make sure he was real.

Elsewhere, Mikasa turned, looking behind her.

"I knew it!" Mikasa grabbed him, voice quavering slightly. "I knew something had happened! I could feel it!"

Eren could feel her trembling and tried to shake out of her death grip. It was of no use. Sighing, he grabbed one of her hands and pressed it to his chest. "See? You can feel my heart, I'm alive."

Jean excused himself to the restroom, unable to swallow his jealousy. Splashing cold water on his face, he looked at his miserable reflection. *Fucking Yeager... I bet he doesn't even realize what that looks like, the dense idiot, and what kind of wrong messages he's sending* . Taking a calming breath, he stepped out.

"...can't feel my arm anymore."

Jean went straight to his seat, sitting completely pressed against the side, looking everywhere but at his two couchmates. The others had broken into groups, doing the same thing, pointedly not looking at the two, trying to give them privacy. Jean crossed his arms, ignoring the pitying looks Connie and his couchmates were sending him.

Were they all talking about him? Pitying him over his unrequited love? Armin and Petra were in a corner, talking, and the teen was

shaking his head. Jean tried to subtly eavesdrop on his superiors, focus on their voices, but they were talking too quietly.

"...cough wasn't a coincidence," Hange said. "It can't be. For the first time in human history, a Titan spoke. Said a name at that. What are the chances someone named Ymir is here? Someone who looks a lot like Ilse Langnar."

"We should look into her," Levi said. "I know you think she's trustworthy because Candy brought her here, but still."

"Levi's right," Erwin said. "We need to investigate her."

"Should we confront her? She can't go anywhere, obviously," Levi said.

"No, we don't have enough information. Besides, we don't know how Candy will react to that."

"But she's not here, remember?" Hange pointed out.

Erwin shook his head. "Doesn't mean she won't be back later. And let's not forget she added more episodes without being present. Anyway, the TV might give us the answers without antagonizing anyone. For now, let's wait and see." He then addressed the room. "Is everyone ready?"

Armin and Petra were the last to return to their seats.

"Let's watch episode 6, then."

Please review~

Episode - The World The Girl Saw

Chapter 6: The World The Girl Saw

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Levi, Hange, and Erwin discuss Ymir and the talking Titan.

"Hey!" A blurry figure said. "Hey!" Connie's face became clearer. "What's wrong, Armin? Pull yourself together! Hey, Armin!" He shook him.

Armin finally came to.

"Hey, Armin! You with me? Are you alright?" A group of trainees stood nearby. "Where's your squad?"

"Squad?" Armin repeated.

"Oh, man, pull yourself together. Why are you all by yourself?" Connie looked at this hand. "You're all wet and slimy."

"Ugh." Connie shuddered, wiping his hand on the couch. "Titan drool!"

"What the hell happened?"

Armin gasped, remembering. "You're so useless!" He clutched his head, yelling at himself. "Just die already!"

"Whoa! Calm down, Armin!"

"Damn it!"

"Where is everyone?" Connie's words made him freeze.

"Give it a rest, Connie," Ymir said, not looking at them. "They've been wiped out. All but him."

Levi, Hange, and Erwin watched her intently.

"Shut up! Armin hasn't said anything!"

Ymir looked over her shoulder. "Just look around. It's obvious. We don't got any more time to waste on him."

"Why is he the only one who's survived?" Connie asked.

"Hell if I know."

"Wait a minute," Jean interrupted. "How *did* he survive?"

"Yeah, why didn't the Titan eat him, too? Not that I'm not happy it didn't," Christa said.

"And where did SanTitan go?"

"Really, Petra, you're calling it that?" Levi looked down at her and she shrugged.

"Maybe they thought he was a corpse?" Ymir continued.

"That's probably it," Hange said.

"It sucks that they ran into multiple Titans and that only this incompetent made it out alive."

"That wasn't very nice," Christa said.

Ymir ignored Mikasa and Eren's furious looks.

"You bitch. Want me to make it so you never talk again?" Connie threatened, glaring.

"I'd like to see you try," Ymir snorted.

Despite the fact he graduated in the top ten and she didn't, Connie knew she could easily kick his ass if she wanted.

"Stop it, you two!" Christa ran between them, arms out. "We're all shaken up here. All our friends are suddenly dying left and right. It's natural we're upset."

Ymir threw an arm around her. "That's my Christa! Marry me when this is over!" She laughed loudly. It sounded forced.

"Yeah," Connie said, "she is clowning around more than usual."

So she does care about her comrades somewhat. Erwin thought. The ill attempt at distracting them was for their sake so they wouldn't fall into a hole of misery and despair like Armin had.

Connie knelt before Armin. "Anyway, we can't stay here. Can you stand, Armin?"

"I'm sorry for the trouble." Armin stood and walked away. "I'll rendezvous with the rearguard."

"Hey, Armin!"

"Let's go, Connie!"

"We've been ordered to advance!"

Connie watched Armin for another second before turning.

This is hell. **Armin stared at the blood splatters on the ground as he flew.** ***No, it hasn't become hell. I was just mistaken until now. This world has always been hell, from the very beginning.*** **He remembered his childhood, being picked on by bullies.** ***The strong prey on the weak.***

Armin looked at his lap. Why did they have to watch him be so pathetic? See his insecurities and weaknesses. His friends wouldn't hold it against him, he knew. But he didn't want to face them and see the pity in their eyes.

It's such a simple, straightforward world. **Little Eren and Mikasa ran toward him.** ***It's just, my friends…*** **Eren punched one of the bullies and Mikasa threw another into a wall.** ***They tried to be strong in this world…*** **Little Armin looked up at Eren's extended hand.** ***They helped me, someone who was weak*** **.**

"Armin, that's—"

"Don't." His voice didn't shake, much to his relief. "I don't need your pity." He finally looked at them, eyes wet. Eren and Mikasa were watching him with concern in their eyes. "Please." To his relief, they didn't say anything and looked away.

I couldn't bear it! **Armin glanced up to Eren and Mikasa, looking at him with protective gazes.** ***They saw me as someone who needed to be protected.***

Eren wanted to deny it. But he knew it was the truth. He did want to protect his friends. But it didn't mean anything demeaning. It was just who he was.

Tears ran down Armin's face ***. I wanted to live in this world like them… I wanted to be strong and stand shoulder-to-shoulder with them.*** **The hook failed to lodge into the wall. Armin crashed. He cried, holding his ankle.** ***And this is the result. Because of me, Eren wound up…***

Hearing sniffles, Armin opened his eyes. He walked over to the young woman. "Hannah, what are you doing?"

"Armin! Help!" Hannah was crying. "Franz isn't breathing! I've tried resuscitating him over and over and over but it's not working!"

"It's dangerous down here, Hannah, so we have to—"

"I can't just leave Franz like this!"

"You don't understand, Hannah. Franz is…" Armin touched his face, horrified. "Please stop this… You can't do anything for him anymore."

Silence filled the room. They shifted uncomfortably, anxious to get to a less emotional and intrusive scene.

"H-Hey, now!"

"Don't you guys realize how bad the situation is?!"

A massive crowd had formed, waiting to be let through the gate.

They relaxed, knowing it was a safe scene.

"Yeah! That's why we're doin' this! And if you guys wanna live, you'll give us some damn help!" Reeves yelled.

"The hell with that!"

"It's gonna get stuck!"

"Letting people through comes first!"

"We're all gonna get eaten standing here!"

Mikasa glared. If it hadn't been for them blocking the civilians' escape route, the order to retreat would have gone out sooner and many soldiers could have lived.

"What are you doing, soldier?!" Someone pushed a Garrison soldier forward. "Go and arrest them!"

"B-But—"

"Just try it, small fry!" Reeves dared him. "I'm the boss of this town's merchant association!"

"Asshole." Eren snarled.

"Uh, err—"

"Who do you think pays for the meals you soldiers shit out? Do you have the money to provide for the soldiers in this town? Push, all of you!" Reeves yelled. "This cargo's worth more than you can earn in your entire measly lives! Help, and you'll be rewarded!"

"People's lives are at stake here." Christa glared. "He's endangering everyone for his own greed."

"Not entirely," Erwin said, surprising them. "Do you remember the last time a Wall was breached and refugees were sent to places that were already having a food shortage?"

"He could still have at least let the children pass first," Petra said. They were humanity's future, after all.

If he had just worded his sentiments properly he could gotten through faster. Hange thought.

"It'll be okay," a mother assured her daughter. "Your dad's going to use his cannons to make the Titans go away."

"Mom," the little girl said over her mother's shoulder. "Look." She pointed behind her.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud. A 15-meter ran around the corner, crashing into a building and sending a soldier flying. The crowd panicked.

Connie clenched his jaw, trying not to laugh. Morbid as it was, seeing the man, who had clearly given up, be sent flying was funny. He didn't want to piss the others off and have them think he was being insensitive.

"Push! Push if you don't wanna die!" Reeves ordered and the crowd surged forward in a panic.

"Stop, my child is…"

"Damn!" A Garrison soldier cursed, chasing after the Titan. "Why is it ignoring us?"

"It's an Abnormal! No point trying to figure it out!"

"It's fast! Not even we elites can catch up to it!"

"At this rate—"

Mikasa flew past them. Sinking a hook into the neck, she moved in for the kill. The 15-meter went down right in front of the crowd.

Her comrades cheered.

"Hm, not bad," Levi said.

"Nice one!"

"That was so badass!"

"Mikasa, you're such a beast!"

"You make it look so easy!"

Armin smiled. "I can't say I'm surprised."

"Same here," Eren said.

Petra looked impressed. "You're every bit as good as the rumors claim you are."

Mikasa studied her blades. Then she noticed the crowd staring at her. "What are you doing?"

"Oh, perfect timing!" Reeves said. "Get these guys to help me! I'll make it worth your while!"

"Fat chance," Jean muttered.

"My comrades are dying as we speak," she spoke, pointing her sword back in their direction, looking traumatized.

The deaths of Squad 34, Franz, and countless others flashed through their minds.

"They're fighting and dying because the citizens haven't finished evacuating."

"Of course they are! It's your duty to give your hearts to defend the lives and property of the people! Don't go gettin' a big head now that you freeloaders have somethin' to do after a century of uselessness!"

Furious looks were shot at the TV.

Mikasa's face closed off. She jumped down from the Titan's corpse and the crowd parted for her. "If you feel people dying for other people is a matter of course, then I'm sure you'll understand that a single, precious life can sometimes save the lives of many as well."

"Just you try it! Your boss and I go way back! One word from me and he'll be all over your sorry ass!" Reeves threatened her.

Jean rolled his eyes. "He's all talk."

Mikasa easily knocked out his goons. "How can a corpse talk, I wonder?"

The viewers laughed.

"Wait!" Reeves begged.

"S-Sir?" His underling spluttered next to him.

"Pull the cart out," he said defeatedly.

Mikasa watched as the civilians finished evacuating. "Thanks, lady!" A young girl said.

"You really saved the day." Her mother smiled. "You have our gratitude." Mikasa saluted, making the girl smile, awed. She turned and walked away.

Erwin and Levi stared at her calculatingly while the others gushed.

Grey clouds parted, soaking the earth in a shower. A Titan steamed. On a rooftop, Ian looked at Mikasa and said, "Good work taking it down, Ackerman. Very impressive."

"Thank you, sir. However, I'm afraid I inadvertently dulled my blades during the attack. I will be more careful next time."

"Just what have you had to live through?" Ian wondered, and she looked over. "No, never mind."

Mikasa's mind turned to the smiling mother-daughter duo, remembering her own family. She pulled up her scarf. *Why am I reminded of it at a time like this?*

Please don't, please don't, please... Mikasa clutched Eren tighter. She felt him tense, and, much to her relief, pulled her close.

Rain poured heavily. A brown, wooden house came into view. Inside, a family of three talked. "Finished! Look, Mom!"

"Wow! Little Mikasa!" Connie grinned.

"You're so cute!" Sasha cooed.

Mikasa's stomach dropped.

"Oh, you did a great job, Mikasa!" Mrs. Ackerman complimented. "It's very nice!"

Christa felt a burning in her chest. Was that how a loving mother and daughter acted? Why couldn't her mother have loved her and cared for her like that? *What's wrong with me?*

"This style of embroidery has been passed down in our clan from generation to generation. When you have a child, it'll be your turn to pass it on, too!"

"How can I have a child?" Mikasa asked innocently.

"The question every parent dreads." Petra giggled.

"Err, why don't you ask your father that?"

"Well, Dad?"

"Oh, uh, I don't really know, either!" Mr. Ackerman laughed nervously. "Oh, I know! Dr. Yeager will be here any minute! Why don't we ask him?"

"Smart move, dad!" Connie laughed.

Mrs. Ackerman smothered her laughter. There was a knock at the door. "Oh, that must be him!" Another knock. "Coming!"

I can't do this. Mikasa thought.

The rain continued to pour outside. Grisha knocked on the door.

Mikasa relaxed a little. They'd skipped that scene. If it only focused on Grisha and Eren, she'd be okay.

"Mikasa?" Eren said.

"Yes. She's about your age. There aren't many children in these parts, so try to get along."

"That depends on how she acts."

"You're such a picky child," Petra said. Something about the little kid needled at her. She couldn't quite put her finger on it, though.

"Eren, that attitude is why you've only made one friend."

"And he's the best," Eren said. "So I'm okay with having only one friend." Armin smiled, loosening the muscles in Eren's shoulders. Then he saw the screen and tensed again.

"Maybe they're not home." Grisha knocked again. "Mr. Ackerman, it's Dr. Yeager. Is anyone home?" There was blood on the other side of the door.

The atmosphere changed immediately.

Eyes widened and some mouths opened in shock.

It was then Petra realized why the image of little Eren bugged her. He was wearing that familiar red scarf. The one Mikasa always wore. She turned to her couchmates. They knew the details of the event better than she did. *No wonder they look so grim* . Biting her lip, she glanced at Mikasa but was unable to see her face. *This will not be not good.*

Grisha turned the knob, finding it unlocked, and opened the door. "Excuse me." He looked in and let out a gasp, staring horrified.

Thick, awkward silence filled the room. First the scene with Armin and now this. It felt wrong to watch it, something so personal and private.

"What's wrong?" Eren asked. "What is it, Dad?"

Grisha was kneeling over Mikasa's mother. "Too late." He turned to see his son in the doorway. "Eren, have you seen the girl, Mikasa, anywhere nearby?"

Where's Mikasa? Jean panicked along with Sasha and Connie. *What happened? Did they kidnap her?* He had to look over to make sure she was okay, not caring she was practically buried into Eren's side, his arms around her and Armin's hand on her shoulder. *What the hell's going on?*

"No," Eren replied.

"I see. I'll get the Military Police and have them conduct a search. You'll wait at the foot of the mountain. Is that clear,

Eren?" The young boy continued to stare at the scene with wide, dark eyes. "Eren!"

Another house in the mountains came into view.

Mikasa had had enough. "No!" She jumped up, eyes zeroed in on Erwin's remote. "No more!" She looked rabid. Absolutely no one had the right to watch her personal tragedy play out without her permission. "You are not watching this! Skip it!"

Levi stood, blocking her view of Erwin. Mikasa looked ready to kill. Erwin stood as well. "I am sorry you have to go through this," the commander began, "but there must be a reason why we're watching this."

Hange stood next and said not unkindly. "We already know what will happen. It came out at the trial—"

"I don't care! It's still none of your business!"

"Sit down, Ackerman," Levi said.

Eren and Armin were flanking her now. Suddenly, everyone was on their feet. Jean was standing with Sasha's group. They were watching the argument with unsure expressions.

"The last thing any of us want is to overstep anyone's boundaries," Petra said calmly, standing between the two groups. "We'll sit down and talk about this—"

"There's nothing to talk about!" Eren yelled.

"Lower your voice, brat, before I—"

"Before you what? Hit us?" Mikasa turned her rage onto him, recalling the trial. "We all know how fond you are of beating up

defenseless children."

Petra inhaled sharply. The recruits huddled together and began whispering.

Levi clenched his jaw, furious.

"It's the reason why Eren's not being dissected right now!" Hange glared. "We had no choice!"

"But there is a choice now," Armin jumped in, "and it's not yours to make."

"They're right," Jean spoke up. "This is none of our business. If Mikasa doesn't want us watching, then we aren't going to. Majority vote wins." He crossed his arms and the others behind him nodded.

"You can take your majority vote and shove it—"

"You're right," Petra said quickly. "It's an invasion of privacy."

"Petra, you—" Levi began.

"I know the entire point of this is to help humanity. It's why we were brought here. But we've watched an entire episode that contributed nothing to help us in our fight against the Titans. I distinctly recall you, Captain Levi, making faces at the Trainee Corps episode, grumbling about the teenage drama. Clearly we don't have to watch everything."

No one was brisling anymore. They were tense, but not looking ready to start a brawl at the drop of a pin. That was good.

Petra continued. "You're both right. So, how about a compromise? We'll mute the TV and only you," she said to Mikasa, "can watch. If it's something important, you *have* to un-mute it."

"And what if Candy says something important?" Erwin asked. "You can't hear them talking if it's on mute."

"Turn on the subtitles, then," Jean suggested. "I'll bet Candy's dialogue will be written, too. Mikasa can read what she says."

"Everyone's in agreement then?" Petra asked.

"I just have one addition," Hange said. "You—"

"Hello!"

They jumped at the voice.

"This message has been triggered because you are not watching or attempting to skip an important part."

Mikasa's shoulders slumped in defeat. Candy was about to have the last word, and in that room, her word was law.

"If it is a private moment, I'm terribly sorry everyone is being made to watch, but it is important. The episode will resume automatically in fifteen seconds."

Petra shot Mikasa an apologetic look and sat alongside the other veterans in silence.

"I guess that settles it." Ymir took a seat.

Christa looked at her, hurt.

"I'm not thrilled about it," she said, clearly unhappy, "but you heard Candy."

Christa, Sasha, Connie, and Jean followed reluctantly.

Eren hadn't given up quite yet if the stormy look on his face was anything to go by. "Don't," Mikasa said, tugging his sleeve. She didn't think it was worth upsetting Candy. She knew Eren had little control over his mouth—and fists—once his temper took over. She took a seat, pulling him down, not letting go, clutching Armin with her other hand.

The video started just as everyone was settling down.

"Hey, are you sure she'll actually sell?"

They stiffened at once, horror seeping in. Human traffickers.

"We even went and killed her parents before running off with her."

"Take a look at her face." The one in charge sat in a chair, arms crossed.

Using his foot, the lanky rolled the little girl over.

They bristled at the act.

"Looks nice, but she's still just a kid. Doesn't strike my fancy."

"I'm not asking about your tastes," the boss said. "She's an Asian. There used to be different types of humans, you see. Long ago, some of those people fled and sought refuge inside the Walls. She's the last descendant of that clan. We're gonna take her to the Underground market in the capital and auction her off to those old perverts."

Levi shoved down his fury, knowing exactly what the man was talking about, remembering a gang that had wanted to make a deal with him and hand Isabel over. Satisfaction coursed through him as he remembered the result of that "deal." He'd made sure the thugs were not able to walk, or breathe in some cases, ever again.

"All the other Asians have died out so she'll go for a pretty hefty price."

Just the thought of some old man putting his hands on little Mikasa had their blood boiling.

"Her old man didn't look Asian to me," the lanky said sourly. "She ain't pureblooded."

She's a human being, not a horse . Petra tried to keep her temper in check.

"That's right!" His boss stomped his foot on the ground. "The mom was the really valuable one! But you had to freak out and kill her!"

She'd been so afraid at the time. The fear and shock had paralyzed her. Now, listening to them talk about her mother like she was some object meant to be bought and sold for some freak's sick pleasure made Mikasa furious.

"I-I couldn't help it! She put up a fight!"

Christa felt so low. She fantasized about what it would have been like to have Mikasa's mother, loving her so much she was willing to throw her life away for her. Her mother would have happily handed her over to the men, she knew.

"That all you got to say for yourself, huh?!"

Mikasa stared at the scene before her, despondent, mind stuck on what had happened.

"Dr. Yeager! We've been expecting—" Mr. Ackerman stared at the bloodied knife just pulled out of his gut and staggered back, falling.

"Hello." The thug entered the house. "Pardon the intrusion."

Rage at how casually he murdered her father and stepped into her home had Mikasa trembling. What she wouldn't give to jump in and

kill them with her bare hands.

Mrs. Ackerman stared at the knife in horror, hand inching toward the scissors.

"Just take it nice and easy, unless you want your head split open with this—"

She ran at him, screaming.

"This woman—"

"Mikasa! Run!" Her mother screamed.

Mikasa's eyes watered. She pulled up the scarf, a torrent of emotions raging inside her.

"M-Mom?"

"Hurry, Mikasa!"

"Uh, Dad?"

Half the viewers were waiting for the little girl to jump into action and beat the intruders before remembering she was just a terrified and sheltered child, not the trained, deadly soldier they all knew.

"Damn it! I've had enough of your crap!" He brought the axe down, sinking it into the woman's shoulder.

"What the hell?! I said only kill the dad!" The boss yelled.

"Don't look at me! She's the one who—"

"Save your excuses! Go get the kid!"

"Hey." He walked up to Mikasa, grabbing her shoulder. "You better behave yourself. Or…I'll do this." He punched her.

"Son of a bitch!" Jean growled.

Many hands had become fists, dying to reach into the TV and punch the assholes black and blue.

Mikasa's mind came back to the present. She stared out the window. *It's cold…* The two sex traffickers were talking when the door cracked open, startling them both.

"Excuse me," Eren said in a soft voice.

"Hold it, kid!" The thug stomped over to him. "How did you find this place?!"

Where's the third one? Levi thought immediately.

"Er, uh, I got lost in the forest." Eren looked scared and nervous. "And then, umm, I saw a cabin, so…"

The thug looked at his boss, who made a gesture with his arm. Disposal.

Petra and the recruits looked between him and the TV with wide eyes. One little boy against two grown men. The odds were not good.

"You know kids shouldn't wander around the forest all alone," he said in a sickly sweet voice, kneeling. "Scary wolves live in the forest, you know." He patted the kid's head and the knife behind Eren's back came into view.

Suddenly, they remembered Eren's words about how stupid it was to approach an enemy without a weapon.

Wide eyes became filled with incredulousness. He wasn't going to do what they were thinking, was he?

"But there's nothing to worry about now. We'll be happy to take you—"

Stab. Before the kid, the thug's shirt began to darken. "Thanks, mister." Eren casually removed the man's hand from his head. "I already know that. So die, you bastard!"

He stabbed him...with the intention to kill. Jean gaped, mouth open, along with his fellow recruits.

Sasha felt goosebumps break out across her skin. *What kind of a kid kills so casually?*

"Huh? What the hell?!" The boss jumped up from his chair and Eren shut the door on him with a frightening look on his face.

The look scared even some of them. Just a child but he appeared intimidating still.

"G-Get back here, kid!" He threw the door open, axe in hand. Eren charged at him, knife taped to the end of a broomstick, a makeshift spear.

I knew they were going to die, but. Petra thought. She'd assumed Eren had stumbled upon Mikasa and the sex traffickers by accident, and when they tried to kidnap him, too, he'd acted in self-defense. Clearly that wasn't the case. Eren had actively gone out to hunt them down.

"You damn animal! Die! Die!" Eren continued to stab him. Mikasa's eyes widened, now focused, and stared at the scene. "This is what you get! This is what you deserve! Never get up again!"

Armin was staring in pure shock. His friends had never gone into detail about what had happened the day Mikasa's parents had been murdered and Eren had saved her. *Eren...*

He's insane. Jean thought.

Christa, Sasha, and Connie were giving Eren nervous looks.

Even Ymir was looking at him strangely as well.

Petra couldn't help comparing the merciless child to the awkwardly sweet teen she knew. Were they really the same person?

Even Levi, Hange, and Erwin were taken by surprise by the sheer brutality of it. They knew Eren and Mikasa had stabbed their attackers but never imagined it was so vicious.

How could a nine-year-old child be so ruthless and bloodthirsty? They all wondered.

Eren sat, breathing loudly, while Mikasa stared. He wiped the blood off his cheek. "You're safe now," he said in a calm voice. "You can relax."

Levi knew how much effort and power it took, stabbing a human in the chest. The breastbone was there to protect the heart and it wasn't easy to pierce through it. And to do so multiple times... *He's not normal.* No kid had that kind of strength. It took an uncontrollable amount of rage to do what he did. But rage was something Eren seemed to have in abundance.

Eren cut the restraints. "You're Mikasa, right? I'm Eren." He began untying the rope. "I'm Dr. Yeager's son. I'm sure you've met my dad before. I was tagging along when he visited your house for a checkup. But then—"

Mikasa remembered the thugs at her doorstep. "There were three of them."

I knew it. Levi thought, tensed.

Where's the third one? They thought, panicked.

Footsteps came from behind them and the children turned, startled. Eren dove for the knife and was kicked, sending him rolling back. "Was it you?" The man grabbed Eren and held him up by the collar. "Was it you who killed 'em?! Was it?!"

Mikasa watched in horror, trembling.

"I'm gonna kill you! You're fucking dead!"

"F-Fight…" Eren gasped, looking Mikasa in the eye. "Fight! Fight or die!" The hold on his neck began to tighten. The knife lay on the floor, forgotten. "Win and live!"

You and your stupid speeches, Yeager. Jean watched nervously. *You're about to get killed!*

"What the hell are you thinking, brat?!"

"Rip his face with your nails!"

"Claw his eyes!"

"The only way to win is to fight!"

Are you crazy? You're being strangled! Connie thought. "Stop babbling and try to escape!"

Mikasa picked up the knife, still shaking.

They tensed, waiting.

"No, I can't do it!" Then she felt a shock in her body. It hit her like a bolt of lightning. *Just then, I remembered…* Eren's arms fell by his sides.

Has he stopped breathing?! Petra panicked. *Does she know CPR?!*

***"I had seen this same thing over and over all my life…"* Mikasa narrated.**

She and her mother sat in their garden, picking vegetables. *" I'd seen it everywhere I went …"* A grasshopper had a butterfly in its clutches. *" But I always looked the other way. That's right…"* Her father came up to them, grinning, holding a goose by the neck. *" We live in a cruel world."*

Mikasa's body stilled and the knife became steady in her hands. *" At that moment, my body stopped shaking. I was in full control of myself after that. I thought I could do anything."*

***Fight.* Sparks exploded in little Mikasa's brain, reaching every muscle in her body from the top of her head down to her feet.**

Levi's eyes widened. He knew that feeling being displayed all too well. Something his mentor, Kenny, had once told him about experiencing himself. He looked at Mikasa, watching the TV with a neutral expression. Was she the same as him? As Kenny? Were they all connected somehow? *This has to be it* . What Candy had wanted them—wanted him—to see. And make the connection.

"Fight!"* Knife clutched firmly, feet digging into the floor, Mikasa charged. *"Fight!"

"His heart was pierced through the back in a single strike," an MP soldier said as he held up a lantern to the corpse in the corner of the room.

"Those kids did this?"

They could understand what the two men were feeling, having watched the mess go down just a few seconds ago.

Outside, the two children and Eren's father stood around a small fire. "Eren." Grisha knelt before his son, holding his shoulders. "I told you to wait at the foot of the mountain. Do you have any idea what you've done?!"

"I got rid of some dangerous animals!" Eren glared, convinced. "They were beasts in human form!"

This kid... Petra thought. *He has such a strong sense of justice* . Or would vengeance be a better word? Even if he hadn't seen the men as human, he'd still killed them without a hint of remorse.

"Eren!"

"They would've been long gone by the time the Military Police arrived! It would've been too late!"

"Even so, you were just lucky, Eren!" Grisha looked pissed off. "The way you casually threw your life away is what I'm angry about!"

If you really cared so much, why did you leave? Eren stared him, hurt. *Where are you, Dad?*

"But," Eren's said, voice shaking, "I wanted to save her as fast as I could." He looked at his father sadly, sounding like the child he was.

He switches between naive little kid and angry psycho so fast. Ymir thought.

"Mikasa, do you remember me?" Grisha asked. "We've met several times before when you were little."

"Dr. Yeager, how do I get home from here?" Mikasa asked, a hollow expression on her face. They were silent. "I'm cold." She

tugged at the jacket Grisha had wrapped around her tiny shoulders. "I have nowhere to go now."

Eren began to remove his scarf.

They sat straighter.

So, this is it, huh? Jean thought, slouching in resignation.

He started wrapping it around her. "You can keep this." Eren tossed the last bit over her face.

"Um..." Connie cleared his throat, and Hange giggled despite herself, finally breaking the silence. "That's not really how it's done."

"Warm, isn't it?" Eren asked gently.

Is he blushing? Petra could feel a smile stretching on her face.

"It's warm," she said quietly as she touched the soft fabric.

Grisha came up to them, smiling slightly. "Mikasa, come live with us."

"Huh?"

"You've been through a lot. You need plenty of rest."

Mikasa turned to Eren, looking at him with her big silver eyes, and he asked her. "What is it?" Reaching into the large coat she had on, Eren grabbed her sleeve. "C'mon, let's go already. To our home."

Christa grinned. *He said* our *home* .

More happy smiles went in their direction. Eren and Mikasa didn't notice, too lost in the scene, feeling nostalgic.

"Okay." Tears spilled from her eyes.

How am I supposed to compete with that? Jean sighed, feeling defeated. Eren had saved her from a life as a sex slave and gave her a home when she was cold and alone and had nowhere to go. All that for a girl he didn't even know. A girl he hadn't even heard of until earlier that day. *I got beat by a stab-happy nine-year-old who doesn't even know how to put on a scarf properly.*

Mikasa sliced the nape of another Titan, landing gracefully on the roof. Rain continued to pour around her. *A cruel world…* Two bodies were steaming around the building she stood on. ... *i n which only the victors are allowed to live.*

She's another Levi, without a doubt. Erwin's eyes gleamed. *So much raw talent and power.*

Bells rang in the distance, the gate was sliding shut. "Let's go," Ian said. "Time to withdraw, Ackerman. Let's scale the Wall."

"I'll go assist the vanguard's retreat." She turned and left.

"H-Hey, Ackerman!" Ian called after her.

Is it any wonder she's so devoted to him? Hange thought.

But I do have a place to call home in this world now.* Mikasa flew. *Eren, as long as I have you, I can do anything.

Warmth bubbled in his chest at the words. Was that how she really felt? Eren had felt like he was a burden to her, ever since it became apparent who was the stronger soldier between the two. *Like I was some weak kid she had to protect* . He turned to Armin, now understanding how he'd felt at that time. Maybe all the time.

"You're crazy, Eren," Connie declared. "Batshit insane."

Jean snorted. "Can't say I'm surprised you were a Suicidal Bastard since you were a kid."

"That was so sweet!" Christa smiled brightly.

"And in the next episode she finds out he's dead," Ymir deadpanned.

"Oh, Ymir." Christa sighed.

"That must've been so awful, I can't even imagine," Petra said sympathetically.

"But it's okay!" Hange said loudly. "She'll see he's still alive and everything will be hunky-dory again!"

"What was the point?" Armin wondered, annoyed on behalf of his friend. "Of watching that scene I mean. Anyone get it?" He wanted to know if it had really been worth causing his friends to relive that horror again. And having others watch as well.

The mood turned from happy to serious. Eren growled.

"What do you know about your father?"

All eyes turned to Levi.

"Why do you want to know?" Mikasa asked suspiciously.

"Just wondering." Levi shrugged. They waited for him to explain further. He wasn't quite ready to share his observations, so he decided to lie. "Just curious to know how they found out about your family."

"We came to town often enough for the merchants to recognize us enough." While it was mostly her father and her because people tended to gawk at her mother. Nothing hostile, just curious stares. It had made her mother uncomfortable so most of the time she opted to stay at home.

Unable to say what was on their minds, Hange and Erwin gave Levi pointed stares. He nodded in reply, promising to explain later when the others' attention was diverted and the trio could talk in private.

The rest of them quieted their grumblings about being made to watch the scene yet learning nothing important from it, not daring to criticize Candy too much lest she becomes wrathful.

Please Review~

Episode - Small Blade

Chapter 7: Small Blade

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Levi finds a connection between him, Mikasa, and Kenny, and wonders if they're related somehow.

"Over a century ago, beings that prey on humans suddenly appeared. Their absolutely overwhelming—you know what? You already know all this and don't need me wasting your time saying it over and over. Let's skip ahead, shall we?"

"Candy's not very patient, is she?" Jean said.

Shrugs came as a response.

A building appeared and loud footsteps were heard. Inside, a trio of trainees was standing before a group of Garrisons. "Please wait, Captain! Should the Titans attack, we supply soldiers won't be able to hold this position on our own!"

"Why didn't they close the doors?" Christa wondered. "That could've stopped more Titans from coming in and they could have taken care of the ones already inside."

"Fear tends to screw with a person's mind," Ymir said.

"Not everyone's as brave as you, Christa." Connie shot her a smile.

That's not the exact word I'd used. Ymir thought. *Close though.*

"Please, sir! You have to stay here!"

"Step aside," Weilman ordered. "I must reorganize the reinforcements now."

"Sure you do," Ymir said sarcastically.

"Bastard." Eren glared.

"Behind the safety of the inner gate, you mean?"

"Oooh," Connie snickered.

"What the hell are you trying to say? I'll have you know I'm following regulations! Obeying established regulations is a soldier's duty!"

Funny, I don't recall running away in the middle of battle a rule. Hange thought.

"Didn't he say in the other episode fleeing would be considered treason?" Jean pointed out.

"He's a hypocrite and a coward." Christa rolled her eyes.

"B-But, sir! If we lose this position—"

"Enough of your talk." Weilman pointed his blade at her. "Open your mouth again and I'll be forced to punish you for treason where you stand!"

Petra wrinkled her nose. "What a dick."

Mikasa swung onto a roof. She noticed three trainees standing atop a nearby building, talking. She was too far to hear them. ***Why isn't anyone going over the Wall? I'm sure they heard the***

bell signaling us to withdraw **. Something caught her eye in the distance. The building was completely surrounded by Titans.**

Inside, four trainees were huddled behind a desk. "It's all over. We're done for…"

"Cowards." Jean sneered. It was because of their weakness he and the other squads were left with little gas to get over the Wall to make it to safety.

"There." One of the trainees smiled, finishing preparing his rifle.

The recruits watched curiously. Did he have an idea similar to Armin's, perhaps?

The veteran Scouts knew better.

He's at the end of his rope . Levi thought.

"What good is that going to do?"

The boy stuck the rifle in his mouth and pulled the trigger. The other trainees cried out in horror.

"Holy shit." Connie gaped.

Sasha and Christa stared with mouths open.

"That's not at all uncommon," Hange muttered. She'd known many people who'd chosen to end their lives by their own hands rather than be eaten alive. She couldn't fault them for wanting to leave the world on their own terms.

"C'mon, Jean! What are we gonna do?!" Connie asked.

"Ain't anything we can do." Jean sat, face in hand, defeated. "They finally gave the order to withdraw, but we don't have enough gas to scale the Wall. We're all gonna die now. All 'cause of those cowards."

"You mean the supply soldiers?! What's happened to them?" Connie demanded. "Were they wiped out?"

"They probably lost the will to fight."

The suicide was still fresh in their minds. As upsetting as it was, the recruits were still mad at them for not doing their jobs.

Jean continued, "I can understand the feeling, but abandoning their duty to supply us so they can barricade themselves inside headquarters?"

Two trainees were sitting next to the gas tanks, knees drawn up, faces hidden in their arms.

Eren gripped his teeth, frustrated at their lack of action. How was that going to solve *anything* ? It infuriated him to see them just give up. If they'd run for their lives, that at least he could've understood, valuing one's life over duty. But to see them sitting around waiting to die and dragging others down with them left him utterly dismayed.

"I'm guessing the Titans have swarmed the place," Jean said, "meaning we can't even get gas for ourselves."

"That doesn't mean you should just give up. They owed it to the rest of their comrades," Eren insisted. He felt surprised at himself for sticking Jean in the same category as the cowards and not liking it. *He's practically my rival* , he reassured himself, *if he's a weakling and a coward, what does that make me?*

Mikasa hummed in agreement. "It was a matter of life and death and their choice also affected others." Internally, she winced as the full

force of her words hit her. *What a hypocrite I am. Criticizing others when I'm about to do the same thing* .

"Not everyone has your mentality or mental strength," Petra said.

Erwin grunted. "Most people choose to take the easy way and hide from their fears instead of confronting them head-on."

"That doesn't mean they had the right to condemn their comrades," Sasha said, frowning lightly.

"You're right." Hange nodded. "They gave up, but their decision also condemned you. It wasn't fair of them."

But life isn't fair. Levi thought.

"In that case, it's sink or swim! We'll just have to take out the Titans there! Hanging around here's no different! The Titans will just gather here, too! We'll only use up what little gas we have left if we keep running aimlessly! Once we lose our mobility, we're really done for!"

"I never thought I'd ever hear you make an intelligent comment, Connie," Jean said humorlessly.

Many heads nodded.

"You're all assholes," Connie grumbled.

His friends grinned in reply.

Jean looked at the others. "But do you really think we have the manpower to pull that off? Most of the veteran members of the vanguard have been wiped out."

The others were standing around looking helpless, unsure of what to do with themselves. Or like they'd also given up.

"We're just trainees. Who can possibly take charge of a suicide mission like that? Even if someone could, it's not like we'd stand a chance against the Titans anyway. And the supply room's probably got some that are three or four meters high."

True to Jean's words, multiple Titans were inside the building, eating their comrades who weren't putting up a fight at all.

He seems to have a good head on his shoulders. Erwin observed. *He easily figured out what the problem was and predicted a future obstacle. But he needs to take the initiative* . Did Jean have what it took to make the difficult decisions? To bear the burden of all the lives under him? To discard some of those lives so the majority could survive?

"There's no way we could get anything done in there."

He lacks conviction. Erwin thought.

Connie's face fell. "It's hopeless?"

"What a dull life this was." Jean scratched his hair. "If I'd known this would happen…"

"Come on, guys!" Sasha tried to raise their spirits. "Let's do it! Get up! If we all work together, we're sure to succeed! I'll take the lead!"

Levi was surprised. *So Potato Girl and Baldy are only ones who didn't throw in the towel, color me impressed.*

No one reacted to her words.

"So much for that." Sasha sighed.

"At least you tried," Armin offered. "I just sat there uselessly like most of them."

"He's right," Jean said, albeit a little grudgingly. "You're the only one who kept a cool head."

"What about me?" Connie asked indignantly.

Jean shrugged. "Eh, you gave up three seconds later, you don't count."

Connie huffed, folding his arms, a sour look on his face while Sasha giggled.

"Armin! Let's go ahead and—"

Armin was in too much shock to register her words. Sasha's shoulders slumped.

"Reiner, what now?" Annie asked.

"It's not time yet. We must regroup first," he told her.

Does he have a plan? Erwin perked up. Would he step up and take the position of leader? He was eager to see how Reiner would react. Keith's evaluations were spot on. Erwin had seen so himself, the vast potential possessed by the young man. Reiner seemed to be a natural-born leader: charismatic, calm, strong, confident, and decisive.

Reiner turned when Marco spoke . "It's no use. However you look at it, we're not getting out of this city. We're all dead. I mean, I'm ready to die and everything… It's just what am I dying for?"

What happened to you, Marco? Jean wondered.

"Mikasa!"

"Weren't you with the rearguard?"

"Annie." Mikasa ignored them and quickly walked up to the short girl. "I understand the gist of the situation. So I'm sorry for letting my personal matters interfere but have you seen Eren's squad?"

Eren was annoyed at Mikasa blatantly ignoring the tense situation and being selfish, prioritizing him over her own safety as well as the safety of others. "You should be more concerned about your own safety."

"Would you prioritize your own safety if you were in my position and Armin or I were missing?" Mikasa countered, already knowing the answer.

She didn't say anything about him putting his life at his risk and his squad's, too, by chasing after the Titan that had eaten Thomas. It made him feel uncomfortable wondering if the situation was reversed, would he have called her out on the hypocrisy?

"I haven't," Annie replied. "And I haven't seen any squads make it over the Wall either."

"Actually, we did find Armin over there." Reiner jerked his thumb to the side.

"Armin!" Mikasa ran over to him.

He was only watching it but much like the first time, Armin felt like crawling under a rock.

Mikasa!* Armin froze. *No! I can't bring myself to face her! All I did was survive for no good reason. If I'd known this would happen, I would rather have died with him then instead!

"I wouldn't," his best friends said simultaneously.

"Armin, you're not hurt, are you? Feeling okay?"

He didn't reply.

Mikasa stood and looked around. "Where's Eren? Armin?"

Poor girl, it's going to kill her. Petra watched in sympathy.

Gritting his teeth, Armin lifted his head, tears in his eyes. "We… The trainees of Squad 34: Thomas Wagner, Nic Tierce, Milieus Zeremski, Mina Carolina, Eren Yeager…these five members fulfilled their duties and died valiantly on the field of battle!"

"No way…" Sasha said.

"So Squad 34 is basically gone."

"The same thing'll happen to us if we try to take the Titans on."

"It'll definitely happen if you sit around and do nothing," Ymir said, getting several nods in agreements.

"I'm sorry, Mikasa. It should've been me, not Eren. I wasn't able to do anything! I'm sorry."

Mikasa touched his hand, making him look up into her dead gaze. " Armin, calm down."

Those eyes... I haven't seen those eyes since that day. Eren thought somberly. *What did my 'death' do to you?* He shivered, unable to imagine what her death, or Armin's, would've done to him. It just felt impossible. She was Mikasa. The idea she would be defeated and killed seemed insane. *But she's also human, and mortal* .

"Poor Mikasa," Sasha whispered. "She looks..."

Dead inside. Petra thought. Like someone just reached into her soul and pulled it out, leaving an empty shell behind.

"Now isn't the time to be emotional. Now get up." Mikasa helped Armin to his feet. "Marco, if we eliminate the Titans swarming around HQ, we can replenish our gas supplies and get over the Wall. Correct?"

"Well, yeah… But even with your help, there's just too many—"

"I can handle them. I'm strong." She pulled out her swords, holding one arm up. "Stronger than all of you. I'm very strong. As such, I am capable of annihilating the Titans there! Even if I have to do it alone."

I say that and then I go and waste the gas. Almost giving in after only killing two Titans, abandoning my comrades without a care. Mikasa thought bitterly. *Their deaths are on me.*

"As for all of you, you're not only unskilled, you're also cowards and wimps. You're real pathetic. You can just stay here and twiddle your thumbs. Twiddle and watch."

"That was..." Hange couldn't find the right word.

"Lame?" Levi provided.

"I swear it sounds better when I remember it but now..." Connie said.

"Yeah," Sasha agreed.

"Passionate, empowering speeches are Eren's thing, apparently," Petra said, amused.

"Whoa, Mikasa! What's gotten into you?"

"You're seriously gonna take on all those Titans by yourself?"

"There's no way you can beat them!"

"If I can't, then I'll die. It's that simple." Mikasa turned her back to them. "But if I win, I'll live. And the only way to win is to fight!" With that, she took off.

They watched her in silence.

"What's pathetic is your way with words," Jean spoke up.

Jean glanced at Mikasa as the others laughed, hoping she wasn't offended.

"You actually considered that motivational?" Jean readied his blades. "I blame you for this, Eren!"

"What did I do, Horse-Face?"

"Shut up." He folded his arms.

Jean glared at his fellow graduates and yelled. "Hey! Since when were we taught to let our comrades fight alone?! Or do you guys want to end up as actual cowards?!" Then he took off, Connie following right behind.

Grudgingly, Eren's degree of respect rose a few notches for the long-faced boy. *Who'd have thought Horse-Face would step up to the challenge?*

"Never thought I'd hear him say that." Reiner led Bert and Annie forward.

Armin wiped his tears and went next. Marco sighed, also following.

"Come on." Sasha threw insults at the others. "You cowards, weaklings, and morons!"

They're insane… **One trainee thought. "Damn it. Alright, let's do it!"**

They let out battle cries and went forward.

"You're all really amazing, you know that?" Petra smiled. They perked up at her words.

"Don't stroke their egos." Levi crossed his arm. "They'll get big-headed."

"They're certainly something, you gotta admit." Hange grinned. "I'm feeling pumped just watching them!"

"We're lucky," Erwin said. "We got a lot of talented ones from this stock of trainees."

Many egos were definitely expanding around the room.

Mikasa led them, cutting down a 15-meter in her path.

"Hurry! Follow Mikasa," Jean ordered. "Fight as little as possible! Get to HQ before you run out of gas!"

"Man, Mikasa's incredible," Connie said. "How can she move so fast?"

Levi frowned. *Letting her emotions cloud her better judgment and moving with reckless abandon.* She was also putting her comrades at risk and that was unacceptable. Despite her cold exterior, she was not so stoic internally.

Idiot , Mikasa chided her herself, feeling upset.

No. She's using up too much gas. **Armin looked at her gear.** ***She's going to run out right away. Regardless of our skill, once we lose our mobility, we're completely helpless.***

Using more gas, she took out another 15-meter.

There's no hesitation and no movement is wasted . Petra noted. *She kills whatever gets in her way and keeps moving.*

S*he's not her usual, composed self at all . She's trying to distract herself from her anguish. It's only a matter of time until she*— On cue, the canister ran out of gas and she crashed. "Mikasa!" Armin went after her.

"What the hell were you were thinking?" Eren hissed angrily. He wanted to tell her she could have gotten herself killed but her next

words stopped him.

"I wasn't. I was feeling—anguish." She repeated his words, slightly different.

They'd both let their emotions get the best of them and had almost died as a result.

Mikasa was secretly pleased with Eren's fretting and worrying but tried not to show it lest he stopped.

"Damn," Connie cursed. "Jean, you take the lead! I'll help Armin!"

"No, I will, too!"

"Don't be stupid! There are still Titans everywhere! Your skills are needed!"

Gritting his teeth, Jean led the trainees forward.

Good, he kept his emotions in check and went where he was needed most, not where he most wanted to be . Erwin noted happily.

Again… It happened again. **Mikasa held up her arm robotically, looking at the blade. She got off the dumpster.** ***I've lost my family again…*** **She fell to her knees.** ***Do I have to revisit this pain and start all over from here again?***

"I won't ever leave you," Eren said suddenly. "I promise."

She smiled at him, choked with emotion. It had been such a long time since he'd ever said something like that to her. "Thank you."

Thud.

Thud.

Thud.

A 15-meter came around the corner. Mikasa sat, unmoving.

So she lost the Yeager brat and decided to call it quits permanently . Levi sighed quietly. As skilled as she was, she was a liability, too. If she was willing to throw away her life and the lives of those who depended on her, just for her own selfish reasons, she wasn't fit to lead.

It's no use. We can't even get near headquarters. Unless we're prepared to sacrifice lives. **Jean watched the Titans roam below. Then he heard the terrified whimpers. A trainee on the street was panicking, trying to get his gear to work.** ***Damn! He's out of gas!*** **Just as Jean prepared to move, two Titans were almost upon him.**

"Stay back!" Tom moved back weakly.

"Tom! I'll save you!" A male voice yelled. He and a female soldier ran toward their friend.

There are too many. You can't. Petra watched sadly. *You'll only get yourselves killed.*

"No! It's too late!" Jean yelled.

"Stop!" The boy cried out, blades ready, not noticing the Titan and getting caught in its hand.

Jean watched in horror. Tom was hyperventilating, watching the mouth get closer. He screamed in pain and terror.

I should've been there . Mikasa continued to agonize over her decision to give up right after leading them charging blindly. *I was the number one graduate, it was my idea, they were my responsibility* .

Why couldn't I stop them? **Jean thought. A pool of blood soaked the Titan's hands.** ***Why didn't I stop them? If I'd made them stop, this wouldn't have happened.*** **The second trainee whimpered, both of her arms were held by the Titan.** ***Am I really cut out for this? Am I really fit to have a position of such responsibility?***

"They were moving before you knew it, you can't blame yourself, they made their decision." Surprisingly, it was Ymir who said it.

Christa nodded. "That was their friend down there, surrounded by Titans. Yet they still jumped in, you couldn't have stopped them even if you had tried."

"They're right, Jean," Eren agreed. "It was too late."

"Still..." His shoulders slumped.

It doesn't matter . Erwin knew what was going through the teen's mind. He'd agreed to take the position of leader without fully understanding the consequences. He was in charge of their lives and failed to take that into account. As such, their deaths were on him.

It's something he's just going to have to learn to live with . Hange thought.

Marco, Sasha, and the others watched Jean and the scene.

"Stop!" The girl screamed. "I don't want to die!"

Jean sighed, closing his eyes.

Can you do it? Erwin wondered. *Use their deaths to your advantage and lead the ones still alive to safety?*

This world is cruel. **The image of Eren wrapping his scarf around her flashed through her mind.** ***And very beautiful.*** **The Titan came closer. Mikasa looked up, eyes lost.** ***It's been a nice life.***

Eren eyed her in distress, knowing she would make it but unable to push back his anxiety. He was horrified and angry she had given up, not wanting to live anymore, not without him.

"It's okay, don't worry." Mikasa smiled. "I found out I was stronger than I thought."

The Titan's hand reached forward. Mikasa's instincts screamed. It came closer. Suddenly, she sliced the fingers and jumped back. ***Huh?***

Up until that moment, she didn't think she'd have the will to move forward without Eren. Mikasa had proved herself wrong. And she was glad for it. Not only because Eren had turned out to be alive, but also for herself. It was proof of her inner strength.

The Titan brought its hand down, she barely dodged, the force sending her back into a wall. ***Why?*** **Mikasa dodged another swipe and went rolling on the ground.** ***I was sure I'd given up.***

Not a lot of people, even veterans, have the courage to fight Titans without 3D gear. And to survive so many attacks, too, is nothing short of astounding. Petra looked at the teenage girl. She really was on another level of her own. Just like her captain.

So, she was able to get back up on her feet and fight in her darkest moment after all . Levi was pleased. Maybe there was hope for her yet.

Why am I standing up? **Coughing, Mikasa sat up straight. *Why am I struggling? What for? After all…* She got to her feet, looking up at the sun. *There's no point in living anymore.* The Titan came forward, blocking the light. *So what's driving me?***

Mikasa turned, ready to run. A 15-meter rounded the corner.

Of course. Jean sighed. *Again, Yeager shows up when she's in trouble. Typical.*

"Is that who I think it is?!" Hange shrieked.

Eren watched with great interest.

"Fight! Fight! Fight!" **Realization dawned on her face. "Eren…"**

And then she realized what was driving her forward. *"Fight! You have to fight! Fight! Fight!"*

Wait, what? Me? Eren was stunned. *She really relies that much on me mentally and emotionally?* He felt lower than dirt for all the times he'd snapped at her. It must have really hurt. He had just felt so upset at having to be saved by her, relying on her strength, he hadn't even considered how much his friend also relied on him.

Mikasa gasped, eyes watering. *I'm sorry, Eren.* The two Titans stepped toward her. *I won't give up anymore.* His peaceful sleeping face came to her. *I'll never give up again. If I die I'll lose my memories of you, too, on top of everything else.*

Eyes were subtly wiped and throated quietly cleared around the room.

So I'll do whatever it takes to win! **Mikasa gripped the blade. *Whatever it takes to live!* With a cry, she crouched, ready to attack.**

Just then, a massive foot slammed into the ground next to her. The Rogue Titan threw a powerful punch, knocking the Titan

back and sending Mikasa skidding.

She opened her eyes, arms wrapped around her head. "What just happened?"

Cheers broke out.

"Whooo!" Connie grinned.

"That was so awesome!" Sasha nodded.

"I can't believe you literally just punched his head off!" Petra exclaimed.

So much power! Erwin's eyes gleamed in excitement.

Christa had a hand pressed to her chest. "I was actually worried she wasn't going to make it!"

Ymir just studied the Rogue Titan quietly.

Unsurprisingly, Hange was the loudest. "Finally! What I've been waiting for! You're so beautiful!"

Mikasa looked up at her savior. 15 meters high and pure muscle, he opened his mouth and let out a hiss.

Hange was practically salivating.

Levi leaned away from her. "Wanna switch seats?"

"Sorry, Captain Levi, but no." Petra's eyes were glued to the screen, her hand making a shushing motion.

Throwing his head back, the Titan roared, making Mikasa cover her ears, and charged.

Hange screamed along with him, making her couchmates cover their ears.

"Fuck's sake, Four-Eyes, sit down and shut up," Levi growled, yanking her down by the back of her jacket.

The ground shook as the Rogue Titan brought his foot down over and over. *A Titan…* Mikasa thought as h e roared, stomping the other Titan and making its head fly. … *is killing…* Finally, the nape was nothing more than a wet, sloppy mess. … *another Titan.*

The Rogue Titan looked up.

"I did that?" Eren gaped. It was...epic. How the hell could he not remember being so badass? His heart began pumping very fast, he was thrilled.

"Just you wait," Connie said giddily. "We're just getting started!"

***Please, Mikasa!* Armin flew over the rooftop. *Be alright.* A roar grabbed his attention. And he noticed her. "Mikasa!" Swinging, he came in and grabbed her, bringing her up and sending them both rolling on the roof. "Mikasa, are you hurt?"**

"You two okay?" Connie slid to a stop next to them.

"Nice entrance, Connie," Christa said.

"Thank you!"

"Yeah!" Armin replied.

"We gotta get out of here." Connie looked to the side. "Shit, this is bad, two 15-meter ones!"

"No, that Titan is…" Mikasa stared at the Rogue Titan.

"Huh?" Armin noticed the steaming skeleton.

Standing across from each other, the two Titans roared.

"His mouth is different, the shape of it," Petra noted. "And it's larger."

"Uglier, too," Levi muttered.

Hm, the other one roared back. Hange wrote down. *It knew it was being challenged and answered the call.*

Were they instincts of some sort? Titans were stupid, but something about the Rogue Titan had triggered a response, a reaction, from the normal Titan. Maybe there was something special about Eren. And the same was with the Colossal and the Armored Titan, too, possibly.

Bringing its arms up, the Rogue Titan assumed an offensive position. The trio on the roof gaped.

"So you have some human instincts, even when you're not in control." Hange nodded to herself, continuing writing furiously.

The other Titan just roared and charged, while the Rogue Titan kept his stance and threw a punch, decapitating his opponent. The head flew until it hit a tower.

Eren's eyes with big and bright, a huge grin on his face.

The others laughed at the stupid expression on the Titan's face, smashed into a window.

The headless Titan began to push up off the ground and Rogue, not looking at him and watching his hand heal instead, brought his foot down, crushing his nape.

"What a magnificent sexy beast you are!" Hange yelled.

Eren was mortified, causing his fellow recruits to snicker.

From the look on some of their faces, he knew they weren't going to forget it.

"H-He finished it off?" Armin said. "He was actually aware of its weak spot?"

"Retains some intelligence, too." Hange wrote it down, still beaming.

"We gotta get out of here! Before it comes this way!" Connie said.

"No," Armin replied, "it's not reacting to us. Any other one would attack us for sure."

"It seemed to grasp the concept of hand-to-hand combat, too," Mikasa said. "Just what was that?"

Some sort of muscle memory, maybe? Hange thought. Physiologically the bodies were very different. But from what she knew, Eren's human body resided in his Titan's nape. His subconscious was controlling the Titan body and maybe the muscle memory was linked somehow. Was that even possible? It intrigued her greatly.

"All we can do is chalk it up as an Abnormal," Connie said. "We barely know anything about 'em, after all. Now let's just hurry to HQ!"

"Wait! Mikasa's completely out of gas!"

"Whoa, are you fucking kidding me? What're we gonna do without you?"

"The answer's obvious!" Armin got on his knees and pulled out his canister. "I don't have much left but hurry and switch yours with mine!"

"Armin!" Mikasa said.

"This is our only option." He replaced it with her canister. "It'll amount to nothing if I keep it. Just…use it carefully this time. Everyone's lives are riding on it."

Mikasa clenched her jaw. Never again. She would never again jump into the role of leadership then leave those depending on her to fend for themselves.

I took charge without any sense of responsibility for their lives. For a short time, I had even thrown away my own life. **Mikasa looked down.** ***All for my own personal reasons. I…***

She acknowledged her mistakes, at least *. Let's see if she can keep from repeating them.* Levi thought.

"There! Your mobility gear still works, and I've given you all my blades. All I ask is that you leave me with this one. I'd rather not get eaten alive if I can help it."

Mikasa took the blade and casually tossed it off the roof.

Armin's face fell. "B-But…"

They giggled.

"Armin." Mikasa took his hand, making him look at her. This time, her eyes were filled with life and light.

Eren smiled at the change from the previous time. That was how it should be, how Mikasa should look. Alive and full of hope and life.

"I'm not leaving you here." Mikasa brought Armin up to his feet. ***Back there I was completely confused. I'd never heard of a Titan killing another Titan. I also felt a faint glimmer of elation.*** **The Rogue Titan roared.** ***Because what I saw looked like the manifestation of humankind's anger.***

Emotions closed up several throats and caused many eyes to water.

"The biggest advantage your Titan form has are the martial arts skills," Petra said, sitting on the arm of the middle couch.

"You can be sure it's going to be a big part of your training," Levi added, standing next to her. He ignored Mikasa's frown. No doubt worrying about what kind of hellish training he intended to put Eren through.

"What about 3D maneuver gear training?" Eren was trying not to sound whiny and childish. As much as he loved the thought of being able to control and fight in his titanic form, watching his fellow graduates work together to fight and kill the Titans reminded him of his childhood dreams of doing the very same. His mother's death had turned that determination into bloodlust.

"Of course you'll be doing a lot of that training, too," Petra answered. "In technical skills, you're not bad. But the thing that makes Squad Levi the very best isn't just high 3D gear skills, it's teamwork."

On the other couch, Erwin and Hange talked quietly. "I see you took a lot of notes." Erwin looked to the notebook.

"Just the similarities but mostly differences between Eren and the normal Titans. And my thoughts and observations on his behavior."

Levi joined them, seeing that they were alone and everyone else was nicely distracted. "We're talking about what we saw," Erwin informed him. "Did you see anything that stuck out to you?"

"Nothing that really stood out," Levi said. "But that previous episode..." They perked up, waiting patiently for him to gather his thoughts. "When Ackerman was describing that feeling of suddenly knowing how to perfectly control her body, it sounded very familiar. Something...my old mentor once told me about."

"Go on," Hange encouraged.

"It's something I myself experienced once."

"Your old mentor, was he as good as you?" Erwin figured if the man had trained Levi, he had to be.

"No, he was better."

They were startled at that. It was hard imagining someone outclassing Levi in terms of physical abilities.

"Do you know where he is right now?" Erwin asked.

"Probably lying dead in some back alley."

Erwin seemed disappointed. Levi had a good idea why. But they were better off without a serial killer. And he was fairly certain Kenny was dead. Else why hadn't the man ever reached out to be him? And Levi hadn't heard any stories or rumors about him in a long time.

Hange had been glancing between Levi and Mikasa. "You two could be related."

"How?" Levi said skeptically. The thought had crossed his mind a few times. "I was born and lived in the Underground up until five years ago. She's from Shinganshina."

"There has to be a connection," Hange said. "Based on what I've seen and what you said about your mentor, you three have inhumane physical capabilities. I mean, what kind of little girl has the strength to pick a boy her size with a single hand and toss him around like a pillow?"

Recalling the first episode, Levi glanced at Mikasa with an odd look crossing his face. Were they family? Could he possibly have been related to Kenny as well? It would explain a lot, he realized. Why Kenny had shown up out of the blue when his mother had died and taken him in, teaching him how to survive. *Why did he leave, then?*

"I mean, you and Mikasa don't need to have been born and raised in the same area to be related."

Levi was silent, trying to sort out his feelings. Suddenly, it didn't seem as far-fetched as he had initially thought. Hange and Erwin didn't poke and prod at him to try to get him to talk. For someone who had experienced constant loss all his life, it would take some time to wrap his head around the fact he had a blood relative so close.

"Ahhh," Connie said loudly in relief, grabbing everyone's attention as he stretched. "Okay, I'm ready."

The others nodded in agreement, finding their seats. Not used to sitting around doing nothing, they'd needed the break after two hours to stretch their muscles and shake off the stiffness.

Levi glanced at Mikasa again, this time catching her eye by accident. A look of pure anger and hate twisted her normally stoic features. He looked away, feeling slightly uneasy. Of course, he would find family then manage to make his—niece? cousin?—loathe him. *She thinks I'm despicable* . While he didn't think it was the end of the world that she didn't like him, Levi felt a little bitter at his fate when it came to family and friends. *I'm cursed* .

Erwin started episode eight and Levi pushed the personal thoughts out of his head, impassiveness firmly back in place.

Please Review~

Episode - Heartbeat

Chapter 8: Heartbeat

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Eren sees his Titan-self in action for the first time. Levi tells him martial arts will play a big part in his training. Erwin, Hange, and Levi have a talk about Mikasa, Levi, and Kenny.

"In the year 850, the Giant Turd reappeared, demolished another Wall, yadder yadder yadder, Titans got in, ate people—why do I even bother? It's not like you don't already know this."

"So tell us something we don't already know," Levi huffed.

Mikasa hoped Candy would strike him down with lightning for being so disrespectful. *It would serve the pipsqueak right.* She smirked.

"B-But the place is swarming with Titans! You can't possibly carry someone while jumping!"

"Let's go!" Connie grabbed Armin.

No… Please don't… **Armin watched them run** ***. I'll only…I'll only get more of my friends killed!*** **Behind them, the Rogue Titan roared. And an idea came to him. "Wait!" He snatched his arm back. "Listen, I have a suggestion!"**

So, he came up with the idea to use the Rogue Titan right on the spot and it ended up saving their lives. Erwin studied him. *That out-of-the-box style of thinking is a great asset. He has much potential.*

"A suggestion?" Connie said.

"Only you two can do it, so I leave the choice to you. I know it sounds crazy, but could we use that Titan to our advantage?" Armin proposed.

"That Titan?"

"It attacks other Titans and doesn't show any interest in us. So I'm wondering if we could lead it to the supply building. If it takes out the other Titans for us, we just might all survive!" Armin explained.

"And we did," Jean said, "all thanks to you."

"And Eren," Sasha added.

"Lead it?" Connie gaped. "How do you hope to lead that thing?"

"My guess is it's fighting on instinct. If you two take out the Titans around it, it'll go and look for other Titans. That'll naturally lead it toward Headquarters."

Which makes you wonder , Petra thought, *why didn't it go there immediately after he transformed?* Surely after it had killed all the Titans in the vicinity, it would have headed for HQ. The building was crawling with Titans and on a hilly area, making it visible from a distance. *Maybe I'm overthinking this and it simply went after those that were the closest.*

"So we should risk our necks for some hopeful guess?" Connie demanded.

"But if it works, we could eliminate all the Titans attacking HQ in one fell swoop!" Armin argued.

The will to make an executive decision, he's definitely someone to keep an eye out for. Erwin thought.

"It seems worth trying," Mikasa finally put in.

"Are you serious?" Connie turned to her.

"It's better to take a gamble than wait for our inevitable deaths."

"It's similar to what you said about going to the HQ the first time around," Ymir said. "I'm surprised you forgot already."

"I knew that moment of intelligence was a fluke," Jean scoffed.

"Shut up, jerks!" Connie folded his arms defensively. "This involved relying on a Titan. A Titan! Excuse me for being cautious!"

"Let's go with Armin's suggestion," Mikasa said.

"You want us to fight Titans with a Titan?" Connie asked.

"Yes, exactly."

We fought fire with fire. Armin thought. *And it worked.* For the first time in over a hundred years, humans had won against the Titans.

Connie smiled nervously. "If we fail, we'll be laughingstocks."

"If you'd failed, you'd be dead," Levi said bluntly.

"But if we succeed, everyone survives." Armin smiled.

"As usual, your plan succeeded and saved countless lives," Mikasa said.

"It all comes down to resolve." Mikasa ran.

"Alright! Fine!" Connie chased after them.

Am I really cut out for this? Am I really fit to have a position of responsibility? **Jean closed his eyes.**

Do you have the will to make an executive decision as well? Erwin wondered.

Suddenly, he came to a realization. *No! No, now is the time.* Jean noticed the Titans all gathered in one place, their backs turned.

Erwin smiled in satisfaction.

"Now is our chance," Jean yelled, "while the Titans are preoccupied over there! Now! Make for HQ while we have the chance!" He ordered and took off running. Marco and Sasha followed first. Reiner, Bert, and Annie went next.

Hm, based on the training episode, I really thought Reiner would have been the one to take charge and lead everyone to safety. Erwin knew there was a big difference between scenarios created in the safety behind the Walls vs. out on the actual battlefield, but he really thought the boy had it in him.

Instead, the guy who'd been all about taking care of number one first and hiding behind the secure interior had stepped up to the plate.

Now is our only chance. If we run out of gas, it's all over anyway. **Jean continued to run, jumping from roof to roof. "Everyone, charge!" They followed without hesitation.**

"Very smart." Petra nodded. "Minimizing usage and saving the gas until absolutely necessary."

Mikasa sliced the nape and killed the Titan in her path, clearing the way for Connie, who was carrying Armin in his arms.

"I did not know that was possible." Hange snickered. "Looks comfy."

Armin ducked his head in embarrassment.

The Rogue Titan pushed a smaller Titan back. Finishing it, he turned toward HQ, noticing the Titans.

"Your plans always work." Eren grinned proudly at his best friend, getting a modest smile in return.

Jean, Marco, and Sasha maneuvered between three Titans. One caught Jean's leg.

Inadvertently, they tensed.

Cutting off the finger, Jean shot the hooks and moved forward. He landed on the roof and ran.

"Jean!" Marco ran next to him. "Thanks! You helped us get away!"

"Huh?"

"It's all thanks to you! It's like I said before! You make a good leader!"

Indeed, there's potential in this one, too. Erwin agreed.

Marco's death had hurt, but Eren realized Jean must have felt the worst out of their group. Marco had been his best friend. To Eren, it would have been like losing Armin.

Grinning briefly, Jean said, "I'm not so sure about that!" He successfully dodged more Titans. One trainee was not so lucky. He screamed and drops of blood flew in the air. "Damn!" Jean forced himself to look ahead.

Good, don't let your emotions cloud your judgment . Levi nodded internally.

Angling his body 45 degrees to the vertical sheet of glass, Jean crashed through the HQ's window. *How many made it?* He looked around. Marco, Reiner, and Annie were the first to arrive

after him. Others soon joined them. *How many comrades' deaths did I use? How many people died because of my orders?*

It's the price you pay for leadership . Hange grimaced, recalling the countless soldiers she'd sent to their deaths.

Then, Jean noticed two trainees hiding under a desk next to him. "You're with the supply team...aren't you?"

"Yeah."

They knew what was going to happen before it happened. And frankly, they were happy to see it.

Jean grabbed one boy by the collar and dragged him out. He punched the boy, knocking him down.

Eren nodded. "Serves him right."

"Stop, Jean!" Marco came up and restrained him.

"These are the ones who abandoned us! People are dead because of you guys!" Jean hurled the accusation at the weeping soldiers.

"The Titans overran the supply room." One trainee knelt beside her comrade, crying. "There was nothing we could do!"

There was! Christa was annoyed by her words.

"Excuses." Levi glared.

"It's your job to deal with it anyway!" Jean snapped.

Reiner watched the scene with a grimace. Suddenly, he noticed a whistling sound. "Get down!" A young woman was sent flying. Outside, two Titans sat on their hands and knees. One had punched the wall with its face. They were now looking inside.

So creepy . Connie thought. The thing about Titans that got to him most wasn't their size and regeneration, but their eerie facial expressions. They looked so much like humans sometimes that it was disturbing to see them act so...animalistic.

"Shit," Jean cursed. "There are too many people!"

The trainees panicked and rushed back.

"Hurry!"

"Get further inside!"

"Stop!"

Jean was rooted in his spot in horror.

"We can't all go at once!"

"Where'd Mikasa go?"

"She ran out of gas! She's long gone by now!"

This is normal.* Jean stared at the giant faces smiling creepily at him. *This must be what the real world is like.

Connie winced. "Dude, that is freaky."

"I still have nightmares about that." Sasha shivered at the eerie image on the TV.

Was I trying to delude myself up until now?* Jean's swords were slack in his hands. *Surely I knew what the real world was like. It's so obvious when you think about it. There's no way we stand a chance against these monstrosities.

Just when all hope seemed lost…

A giant fist appeared, crushing one Titan's face.

Hope rushed through them, seeing their newest weapon, their newest ally, who would make the difference in the war.

The Rogue Titan knocked the two down, roaring.

"That was awesome," Ymir said.

They watched with wide, triumphant grins.

Humanity can win. Humanity *will* win. Their hearts soared at those thoughts.

"That was amazing!" Christa beamed, watching eagerly.

"What was that?" Jean stared. A window broke to his right and Mikasa came in, followed by Connie and Armin. "Huh? What the hell? Mikasa!"

"Man, that was close." Connie knocked on his canister, not believing this luck. "It's completely empty. We did it! We managed to make it!"

"I nearly fainted in relief," Connie said. "I couldn't believe it!"

"Y-You're alive." Jean came up to them.

"We did it, Armin." Connie slapped his back.

"O-Ouch!"

"You didn't have to hit me so hard, you know."

"I was excited."

"Your plan worked! Guys," Connie yelled, grinning, and pointed, "that Titan's an Abnormal! It's killin' all the other Titans! And it has no interest in us! We can use it to our advantage to escape from here!"

"Use a…Titan?" Someone said.

"A Titan helping us?" Jean asked. "What kind of nonsensical dream—"

"It's no dream," Mikasa interrupted. "Whether it's an Abnormal or not, I don't care. We're going to let it rampage here for as long as possible."

Yes , Levi thought, *be abnormal yourself. That's how you survive.* It was how he survived.

The Rogue Titan sent another Titan crashing back, screaming, drawing the attention of more around him.

His roar seems to work as a battle cry of some sorts, attracting the enemies to him. Hange thought. Could that work for the other Shifters as well? Were they capable of attracting Titans to them by roaring?

"Because," Mikasa said, "realistically, that's our best strategy for survival now."

Eyes glinting in anger, the Rogue Titan grabbed his opponent's arm and locked his hands together, twisting the appendage out of the socket and sending the Titan sliding, crushing the smaller ones.

"Nice move," Ymir said.

"It's okay," Connie assured as Rogue charged at more Titans. "That Titan's tougher than ordinary ones."

Hange made a note of that.

Rogue kicked the smaller ones, sending them flying.

***"Goal!"* Candy yelled.**

It had been a while and they'd nearly forgotten she tended to provide her own commentary here and there.

They weren't entirely sure what she meant but they could get behind the sentiment, and chuckled.

***"I doubt they'll take down this building while that one's rampaging like crazy."* Connie's voice narrated.**

Inside the HQ, a wooden elevator came up to the level the former trainees were at.

"How much do you know about that Titan?" Reiner asked, sitting in front of Connie, Annie behind him.

"We can worry about that after we're safe," Connie said.

"Yeah." Reiner smiled. "Let's survive first."

"We found some." Jean stepped out of the elevator, holding a long box, others following behind him. "They belong to the Military Police. Damn things are all covered in dust."

Levi wrinkled his nose, feeling the urge to pull out a handkerchief and wipe the dust off the box.

Jean quickly loaded the gun. "Are you sure three bullets are enough? I mean, seriously… Will guns even work against Titans?"

"If the bullets were made of ultrahard steel, or iron bamboo," Petra said absent-mindedly. "However, because of their size, they'd be visually useless against Titans as far as killing them went."

Around them, their comrades readied their guns. Armin had the floor plans before him. "They're far better than nothing, I feel. If there are still seven Titans in the supply room that are three or four meters tall, this much firepower should be capable of blinding them all simultaneously."

Genius. Erwin thought. *Normally they would be ineffective against Titans, but using them this way...*

"Wait, how were the bullets able to blind them?" Sasha asked. She hadn't thought about it when it had happened—she'd been too busy beating herself up. "I doubt they were made from ultrahard steel." The MP wouldn't have left them lying around considering how precious the material was.

"Great question." Hange perked up. "I can understand your confusion. But only the Titans' skin is extremely hard to pierce."

"Okay," Sasha said thoughtfully. "I guess that makes sense. Skin and eyes are very different."

"First," Armin began, "we'll use the lift to lower a group of people from the center ceiling. They'll then simultaneously fire at the faces of each of the seven Titans, thereby blinding them."

Taking out the Titans' eyes would seriously increase the odds in the kids' favor . Levi was all for the plan. "Titans are too dumb to use their other senses and tend to flounder when they can't see, making for easier targets . "

"Then comes the moment of truth. Seven people hiding up top will strike the Titans' vitals just after the guns fire. In other words...this plan will put everything, everyone's lives on the line for a single attack." As Armin finished, the screen split seven ways to show Mikasa, Sasha, Bert, Reiner, Jean, Annie, and Connie's faces.

Sasha and Connie grimaced, feeling disappointed with themselves. They did not want to see themselves fail again. In front of their comrades and superiors no less.

"Seven people will have to slay seven Titans at the same time in a single blow. It'll be up to the seven most physically fit and adept soldiers we have here. So, um, I'm sorry for placing everyone's lives on your shoulders."

"No worries," Reiner said.

"If we fail, we die. The risk's the same regardless of who goes," Annie said.

"Still, is this shabby idea of mine really our best strategy?" Armin second-guessed himself.

"It's not shabby if it works," Hange said.

"We got no other choice. We're out of time and options. All we can do now is give it our all!" Armin said.

"It'll be fine," Mikasa assured. "You have a knack for figuring out correct solutions."

"Yeah, you managed to defuse the situation with the Garrison soldiers at the refugee camp easily," Petra said, recalling Armin saving Eren from getting a beating.

"You even used it to save my life and Eren's life before."

"I did?" Armin addressed Mikasa. "When?"

"The lift's ready!" Jean yelled. "The guns, too! They're all loaded!"

"You just don't realize it," Mikasa said. "We can talk about it later."

"Okay." Armin nodded.

Connie frowned. "Still, can we really take out all the Titans without our 3D gear?"

"Of course we can!" Reiner replied confidently. "These Titans are only three or four meters tall. Targeting their vitals will be a cinch."

"Yeah," Jean agreed, "regardless of size, their vitals go from the head to the nape of the neck."

"One meter high and ten centimeters across!" Sasha put in.

"You can also shove one of these up their asses." Reiner held up his sword.

The entire room burst out laughing.

"It could work!" Hange said suddenly. "Maybe we should try it!"

The laughter died suddenly and was replaced by weirded-out faces.

"You're a freak, Four-Eyes." Levi made a face. "That's disgusting."

"It could be true, I'm just saying..."

"I want no part in it," Levi declared.

"But I'll need your squad's help!" Hange looked to Petra.

"Sorry," she said quickly, "Captain's already made up his mind."

"Erwin, tell her no," Levi demanded.

"Hange, there's no basis for that theory," the commander said.

"That's right," Levi said. "We're not wasting resources so you can prod Titans' butts."

The recruits giggled at their interaction.

"Those are their only two weak spots!" Reiner declared.

"I never knew about that one!" Connie sounded amazed.

"This is the first I've heard of it, too," Sasha said to herself.

"You two actually believed him? No wait, of course you did," Ymir said.

"Reiner," Jean said, "those could end up being your last words, you know."

"He just seems too cool to die quickly," Connie spoke more to himself.

The elevator lowered to the supply room. "Good," Marco said, "their numbers haven't increased."

We had luck on our side for once . Jean thought.

Marco and the others cocked their guns. "Proceeding with the operation." A Titan passing by stopped, and suddenly turned its head toward them. One trainee freaked. "Stay calm! We need to lure them all the way in."

Atop the beams, the seven were ready. *We can't afford to lose our advantage.* Reiner stared at his swords.

If you don't want anyone to die then make this attack count! **Bert focused on his target.**

We'll decide it with a single blow. **Jean thought.**

"Steady…" Marco said.

The viewers tensed in anticipation. Even the ones who'd lived through it couldn't help but be caught up in the scene.

The Titans were a couple of feet from them.

"Ready…" Marco's finger curled around the trigger.

It was about a foot away now.

"Fire!"

Steam began rising out of their eyes. The seven charged at once. Mikasa sliced the nape of her target and landed in a crouch. *I got mine. And the others?* Sasha and Connie missed their marks, the latter landing on his back.

The Peering Titan turned, eyes locking on its attacker. "U-Umm," Sasha stuttered as she backed up. "I'm s-sorry for suddenly sneaking up and—"

Sasha clenched her fists, mortified. It was bad enough the first time. Now without any pressing matters distracting them and officers of the Survey Corps watching as well, it was unbearable.

"C-Crap," Connie said.

"—I'm very sorry!"

"Sasha and Connie need help!" Bert yelled.

"Hurry!" Jean barked. "Lend them backup!"

"I'm…" Sasha shook, watching the Titan scowling in front of her. It lunged for her and she dove away, abandoning her swords. "—very sorry!"

Sasha tensed. Waiting for the jeers and insults. *I deserve it, too!* Eren was the only one making a disgusted face but no one said a word.

Sasha looked over her shoulder just in time to see Mikasa appear out of nowhere, followed by the flashing of her blades

and blood splatter. At the same time, Annie took out the Titan that had Connie backed against a pillar.

"Mikasa!" Sasha cried, grabbing her waist. "You saved me!"

She never fails to impress . Petra smiled, eager to see the teenage girl fight more.

"Are you alright?" Mikasa asked.

"Thanks to you!"

"Then get up."

Straight-forward, like Levi . Erwin smiled.

"I owe you one," Connie said.

"No problem," Annie replied.

Reiner came up behind her, Bert next to him. "Hey now, that was a close call, Annie. I'm really glad you didn't end up hurt."

"Hey." Connie perked up. "Reiner sounds worried about Annie." He grinned impishly. "Maybe he *likes* her!"

"That's ridiculous," Eren snorted at the notion. "He does not like Annie. And he's not her type anyway."

"How would you know what her type is?" Connie teased.

"I can't believe he even knows what that means." Ymir smirked.

"Shut up," Eren grumbled.

"They've all been slain!" Jean said. "Switch to resupply work!"

"We did it!" Armin grinned. Marco sighed in relief next to him. Then he almost fainted.

"Nicely done," Erwin told Armin, making him feel embarrassed. "They all survived because of you."

"It was because of Mikasa and the others. They're the ones who did the hard part."

"Only because you came up with the idea first," Eren said. He almost felt jealous. As thrilled as he was about killing all the Titans while in his transformed state, he really wished he could have been a part of the operation he just saw. Side-by-side with comrades, life-and-death stakes, overcoming the odds, he was a little saddened he had missed out on that.

"Alright!"

"We're gonna survive!"

"And no more Titans are coming inside! All thanks to that berserk Titan out there!"

"You did play a part in the operation," Mikasa said with a knowing look on her face.

"Yeah." Eren smiled slowly. "Guess you're right."

"I surrendered to a Titan." Sasha clutched her hair, tears in her eyes. "I'm too ashamed to face the others!"

"Don't worry," Petra assured. "We've all had our...ah, un-dignifying moments."

"You, too?"

"Oh yeah."

Sasha felt a little better after that. If even an elite Survey Corps soldier had a moment of weakness, then she could be forgiven for her offense.

"There'll be plenty of time to sneer at you later," Connie scolded. "For now, we gotta escape."

"I can't see myself as much of a leader." Jean kept his eyes down, filling up his canister, Marco sitting next to him. "Don't talk like that anymore."

"Don't be stupid, Horse-Face." Eren rolled his eyes. "You stepped up and led most of them to safety, so you aren't a complete failure at being a leader."

Jean was too shocked by the fact that Eren had just complimented him to complain about the nickname.

"I don't mean any offense by this," Marco began, "but I think the fact you aren't strong really lets you understand how the weak feel. And your skill at recognizing a situation as it unfolds gives you a clear grasp of what needs to be done now, you know?" Jean finally looked at him, a little surprised. "You made the right call. It's what got me moving. It's why I'm alive now."

Not for long . Jean thought morbidly.

"Everyone ready?! It's time to scram!"

"Let's move!"

"Scale the Wall!"

"Rendezvous with the main forces!"

Armin ran out. A figure on the roof grabbed his attention. "Mikasa?"

"You came to check on me instead of fleeing like the others?" Eren asked.

Mikasa shrugged. "I couldn't hear you anymore and got curious."

Reiner and Bert stood next to Armin. Armin took off toward his frozen friend. "Mikasa, we have to get out of here!"

"That Titan…" She kept staring ahead, stunned.

Armin followed her gaze and jerked in surprise. Five Titans of various sizes had the Rogue Titan pinned to a building and were tearing into it. "Cannibalism?"

That's a first. Hange had already known that from the reports but recorded it anyway. Getting data from the TV, basically a primary source, was better than people's memories. It presented less bias and more accuracy. And there could be significance to the event. Hopefully they'd find out what it was later.

The Rogue Titan let out a cry. "It can't regenerate its body?" Armin said.

"I thought that if we could somehow figure out what's up with that Titan, it could've helped us break free from this hopeless situation," Mikasa said.

"I agree." Reiner's voice pulled their attention. Annie, Bert, and Jean stood next to him.

Of course you do . Ymir thought.

"We'll learn nothing at all if it ends up getting eaten. For now, we have to get rid of the ones clinging to it and help keep it alive."

So now he steps in. Erwin was a little disappointed. He'd had really high hopes for Reiner.

"Are you insane, Reiner?" Jean demanded. "We can finally get our asses out of here!"

"And here I thought you might be braver than I gave you credit for," Eren teased.

"I'm surprised you didn't see the benefits of helping the Titan," Armin said.

"I'd already had too many comrades slaughtered by Titans and left some to their deaths to risk hanging around just to satisfy my curiosity."

No one had anything to say about that.

"But what if there's a chance that Titan could become our ally? It'd be a more powerful weapon than any cannon, wouldn't you agree?" Annie stated.

"Ally?" Jean echoed. "Do you hear what you're saying?"

"I'm surprised Annie said that. I didn't think she'd agree with Mikasa and Reiner," Eren admitted.

"She doesn't seem like the type to take risks." Christa nodded.

"You guys think so, too, huh?" Ymir said oddly.

"But she saved me," Connie argued. "She talked like she was all about taking care of number one but when it came down to it, Annie saved me when she didn't have to. She's a good person."

"Guess she's not the outsider she likes to pretend she is," Jean muttered.

Armin noticed something in his peripheral vision. He gasped. "That one…" A surprisingly thin 15-meter was walking down the street. "That's the Abnormal that ate Thomas!"

Instantly the Rogue Titan roared, surging forward, slamming one foot in front of the other, ignoring those clinging to him.

He doesn't have his memories. Hange thought. *But strong emotions stayed.* It was Thomas' death that had triggered Eren's mad run,

screaming profanities at the Titan that ate his comrade. *Makes sense, considering he was running wild on instincts.*

The Rogue Titan lost his right arm, then his left. He didn't seem to have noticed. The Abnormal noticed it too late and Rogue chomped down on its neck.

Some of the viewers watched with open mouths, much like the teens on TV.

Throwing his head back, the Rogue Titan lifted the body up.

Is that his normal strength or are his emotions giving him a boost? Hange wondered.

The bones jutted back into place, flesh began to stretch over them as he healed. Green eyes shifted, and with a muffled growl, the Rogue Titan swung the Abnormal one down, causing decapitation. Then he threw the body into the oncoming fat 15-meter, sending it crashing back into a building.

"Hey…" Jean stared at the scene in shock.

The Rogue Titan roared.

If I can learn to control that... Countless possibilities ran through Eren's mind. *I'd be unstoppable! I could finally fulfill my dream of killing all the Titans!* No one would be able to laugh at him anymore, telling him it was impossible. Then, the image of thousands of Titans crawling around while Candy was doing the intro came back. *No!* He would not allow himself to be seized with doubt. No matter how many there were, they'd do it, humanity would triumph in the end no matter how long it took. A year, or even ten years.

It's a real possibility! And who knows what we'll find in my house's basement? Maybe a way to share the Titan-Shifting powers with others? Eren didn't want to admit the idea stung a little. He viciously

shoved the idea of not being the only special one out of his mind. *That doesn't matter!* Humanity's victory was the number one priority.

"What was it you wanted to save again?" Jean asked them.

The Titan fell to the ground. Armin and Mikasa watched with wide eyes and slightly worried expressions. Steam began to rise out of the fallen body.

"Looks like it's finished for good." Jean turned to leave. "We're done here, right? Let's get going!" He looked down. "As if that monster would ever be our ally. A Titan's a Titan."

"You need to have an open mind, Jean," Connie began. "A leader needs to have some imagination."

"I don't want to hear that from you. Weren't you against the idea of using a Titan to fight Titans at first, too?" Jean shot back.

Jean noticed no one was moving. Or speaking. He rejoined them, annoyed. "What's with you guys?"

On the ground, steam continued to pour from the corpse, hissing loudly. It was centered on the back of the Titan's neck. Flesh parted and a human shape came into view. Red muscles stuck to his arms and face as the body pulled up, revealing it to be none other than Eren.

"Wow," Hange summed up what viewers watching the boy emerge for the first time felt.

Mikasa's eyes grew wider. She gasped, taking in his peaceful, unconscious expression on Eren's face. Without another thought, she went down.

"Mikasa!" Armin called out.

As soon as her feet hit the ground, she took off running, gasping as she ran.

You can literally see the desperation and hopefulness. Christa thought.

Her expression was a mix of fear and hope, eyes focused on his face. Mikasa threw her arms around him. Eren's body slumped against hers. Quickly, with a gasp, she placed her head on his chest, listening to his heartbeat.

Mikasa's throat tightened, overcome with emotions, reliving that miraculous moment.

Eren blushed, unable to formulate a sentence. He was feeling strangely embarrassed.

I feel like I'm intruding on something private. Petra shifted in her seat, uncomfortable. She wasn't the only one. The sentiment was shared by many others.

Mikasa's eyes overflowed with tears, hearing the soft thudding.

Some felt their eyes sting and blinked rapidly to clear them.

Mikasa began to cry, not caring who saw her or heard her.

I don't remember it feeling so awkward the first time around. Sasha fidgeted. Then again, she was shocked at the revelation Eren was a Titan and there was no soft music playing in the background, intensifying the scene.

We're so used to seeing Mikasa as an invincible figure, to see her break down and cry goes so far against that image it's uncomfortable. Even for Eren it's weird. Jean thought.

Armin joined them, followed by others.

More than a few throats were cleared.

Armin, Sasha, Connie, and Christa subtly wiped their eyes.

Even though they were tears of relief, of happiness, Eren felt uneasy watching Mikasa cry.

Armin smiled, reliving the relief he had felt, realizing Eren hadn't died because of his cowardice.

On Wall Rose, a group of Garrison soldiers watched the steam and smoke rising in the distance. On a large roof, the graduates stood silent, watching the scene in shock.

Armin stared at the sleeping teen's face. *It's Eren.* His eyes fell to the Shifter's limbs. *His severed arm and leg are back. He'd been swallowed by a Titan back then. Back then…* The image of his best friend reaching out for him flashed through his mind.

Armin cried, taking Eren's hand and weaving his fingers through it. "What…in the world…?"

Their comrades continued to watch. Jean turned, the others followed. "Does this mean Eren did all this?" Three 15-meter corpses looking like charred meat lay near the Rogue's blackened body. Steam flew from other bodies hidden by the buildings.

Silence filled the room.

Finally, Ymir cleared her throat. "Well, that was pretty epic."

"If you can learn to control your Titan form we'll have Wall Maria back in no time," Connie said confidently.

"I promise I'll do my best." Eren mirrored his expression of determination and delight.

"And the TV will help us achieve victory," Christa said, getting nods of agreement.

"Let's start the next episode. I have a good feeling about it," Hange said gleefully.

Please Review~

Episode - Left Arm

Chapter 9: Left Arm

Disclaimer: I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin or Pokemon

Previously: The viewers are impressed with Eren's Titan form and hopeful for the future, expecting a great deal of help from the TV.

"The Titan assault on Trost District resulted in heavy soldier casualties, owing, in part, to the fact that the elite Survey Corps was absent at the time."

Titans roamed around. Houses were destroyed.

They perked up. It was nice to be acknowledged and valued for once.

"They had just left that morning on an exterior scouting mission."

The scene changed and the chaos disappeared, showing what the gate and the surrounding area had looked earlier that day.

The difference was astounding. It had taken the Titans only a few hours to destroy what had taken years and years for humans to build.

"It's here! The main unit of the Survey Corps!"

"Commander Erwin! Give those Titans a real thrashing for me!"

"Wait, didn't we already see this?" Connie wasn't the only one confused.

Hange quickly explained. "We originally saw this scene from Eren and Armin's perspective. Now it's showing us what we Scouts were doing when the Colossal Titan showed up and the Battle for Trost began."

"Oh! Okay! Thanks."

"Look!" A man yelled, pointing. Eren, Armin, and Hannah were standing behind him. They watched the scene with wide, wondrous eyes. Mike, Hange, and Levi came after Erwin. "It's Captain Levi!"

The teens straightened. They were eager to see Humanity's Strongest Soldier on the field of battle. It was hard to for them to imagine someone surpassing Mikasa's battle skills and they were feeling hyped to see it.

"They say he's as mighty as an entire brigade!"

"Shut up already," Levi muttered.

What a prickly guy. Jean wasn't the only one surprised with the man. After joining the Survey Corps, rumors and seeing him act from a distance had quickly changed their opinions about their most famous soldier. Levi hadn't quite lived up to their expectations of Humanity's Strongest Soldier being charming and awe-inspiring. And tall.

"I bet they wouldn't worship you so much if they found out what an obsessive clean freak you are," Hange said.

The new recruits looked on curiously. They'd heard many stories about his cleaning obsession, but they didn't know the full extent of it.

The gate was pulled up, allowing the Scouts access.

"There are so many Titans out there." Hange brought her hands together, looking dreamy. "I wonder what kinds of Titans I'll see this time. I hope we find some Abnormals! That'd be great!"

The recruits had heard about her obsession as well. The stories didn't do her love of Titans justice, they could tell just by the scene before them.

What an oddball . Ymir thought.

"I see an Abnormal right here," Levi said.

They knew what was coming before the words were out of his mouth.

"Huh?!" Hange looked around. "Where?!"

Levi reached over and grabbed her ponytail, turning her head to face him. "Here."

Hange stuck her tongue out at him while the others laughed.

"Real mature, Shitty-Glasses."

"Says the name-caller."

"Move out!"

"Exterior scouting and establishing bases for expansion, entrusted with these duties, the Survey Corps stands at the apex of humankind's knowledge."

Erwin hoped to learn more from Candy.

"Survival rates have increased dramatically thanks to the resourcefulness of some members, but excursions into Titan territory still always result in casualties exceeding 30%."

Exceeding 30%. Armin grimaced. There had to be a way to reduce that number.

A 15-meter was chewing a Survey Corps soldier. *"That's simply how overwhelmingly powerful the Titans are compared to humans."*

"Just... Just you watch... You bastards... Humanity will survive...we'll win!" Using the last of his strength, he stabbed it in the cheek with his broken sword. The Titan eyed him and clenched its teeth. He screamed, blood squirting in the air. "You'll all fall...to Captain Levi!"

Five seconds earlier and Levi could have saved him. He didn't let it bother him. He'd accepted long ago that the past couldn't be changed, there was no point in dwelling about it.

Petra didn't share the sentiment. *So close...just a few seconds earlier and we could have saved him* .

A hook shot past the Titan and Levi flew behind it, landing on a roof after cutting off the flesh from the nape. Looking around, he spotted more Titans. "One on the right. Two on the left."

"Captain." Petra joined him, Erd and Gunther behind her. "I've gathered reinforcements!"

"Look, Petra, there you are!"

"Yes." She smiled at Hange's enthusiasm. It was strange to watch her on the TV but also exciting.

"Petra, tend to the soldier below. The rest of you, take the one on the right. I'll handle the ones on the left."

"Captain!"

A Titan dove after two Scouts. "Yahoo!" Hange flew, grinning, and landed on a roof behind a Titan.

Hange squealed, pointing to the TV. "I remember that!"

"Don't worry! I won't hurt you!" It turned and glared down at her, bringing its hand down on her. "Nice try!" Hange dodged and came up behind it. "Now it's my turn!" A chunk of flesh flew and Hange landed on the ground.

The recruits were impressed. She was kind of crazy but she was a capable soldier.

"See? That didn't hurt." The ground shook as the Titan collapsed.

She makes it look so fun and easy. Christa thought.

"Every single one of you has such a funny face." Levi walked toward the 15-meter, hook shooting to the left and embedding into a brick building The Titan opened its mouth wide and Levi flew to the side. Spinning, he took it out quickly and used the momentum to jump off a ledge and head toward a second Titan.

Approaching Titans without hesitation, killing with minimal effort, and the ease with which they use the momentum to propel forward, they fight alike, Mikasa and Captain Levi. Petra noted curiously. As if they both figured out the same way to perfectly control their movements to best utilize the 3D gear.

Levi used the blades to blind the second 15-meter. It covered its eyes and screamed. "Whoa, just stay still." He straightened, on the Titan's head, pulling out fresh blades. "I have to get a clean cut of your flesh."

He's so badass. Connie stared in awe.

So cool. Eren grinned.

Damn, that was awesome . Sasha thought.

Even Mikasa had to admit he was impressive, albeit grudgingly.

Killing the Titan with ease, Levi landed on a roof. He stood and checked his sword, coated in blood. "Hmph, how filthy." He pulled out a cloth and began cleaning.

He really is a clean freak. Ymir thought. All the blood would have evaporated within ten seconds, but he just couldn't wait.

No one else can afford to stand around in enemy territory cleaning their swords. Jean thought. *He's not the best soldier for nothing.*

Levi walked toward Petra, who was holding a cloth to the soldier's wound. "Captain," she said, "I can't get the bleeding to stop."

"Captain..." The soldier on the ground rasped.

Levi knelt. "Yes?"

"W-Was I...helpful to...humanity at all?" He weakly raised his hand. "Or will I die...uselessly like this?"

Without hesitation, Levi grabbed his hand.

A minute ago he couldn't wait for the blood to evaporate off his swords fast enough and cleaned them himself . *Now he takes the bloodied hand of a dying soldier without a single thought.* Jean felt his respect for the man grow. *Maybe he's not a completely heartless bastard, after all.*

"You did great things. And you'll continue to. The resolve you leave behind will give me strength, I promise you! I will exterminate the Titans!" Levi vowed.

Christa had initially picked up dangerous vibes from him. He wasn't the type of person she'd be comfortable being alone with. *He's a*

surprisingly emotional guy .

"Proof that Levi secretly does have a heart," Hange declared. "No matter how much he tries to hide it behind that cold exterior."

"Shut up."

"Don't worry, I still don't believe it," Mikasa said, earning herself a glare from the short man and sighs from Eren and Armin.

"Wow, that girl can hold a grudge," Petra muttered.

Erwin frowned at her words. Something needed to be done about the dislike and distrust between the two if he wanted them to work together. Their collective efforts could cause a lot of damage to the Titans.

"Captain, he's already..."

Levi blinked, staring down at the dead man before turning to her. "Did he hear it all?"

"Yes," Petra assured him, "I'm sure he heard you. He's resting with a peaceful look on his face."

"That's good," he said and stood.

"Levi!" Erwin's horse stopped before them. "We're pulling out!"

Petra stood and Levi turned to the commander. "Pulling out? But we can still go further! My men will have died for nothing!"

"I wonder if it was all planned," Armin said suddenly.

"What?"

"What're you talking about?"

"What was planned?"

"The Colossal showed up the same day the Survey Corps was out on an expedition. What are the chances?" Armin said skeptically.

"It further proves the theory about the Colossal Titan in his human form being present near the Wall," Petra said. "If he was a soldier, he'd have known when we were scheduled to leave."

"A swarm of Titans has begun moving northward, toward the city."

Petra gasped and Levi tensed.

"This is just like five years ago. Something's happened in the city. It's possible the Wall's been destroyed."

Damn...

Titans were everywhere, eating humans and tearing apart buildings.

Damn...

Armin cried, reaching out for him. Large white teeth came together and his left arm separated from his body. The darkness engulfed him.

"Is this what happened when you were eaten?" Erwin asked, getting a grimace in return from Eren.

They watched eagerly.

"We'll see the inside of a Titan!" Hange squealed. A look inside a Titan from the inside, she couldn't believe it!

Redness surrounded Eren. The walls were circular. Looking around, he saw a corpse as well as several different body parts

from multiple people floating in blood.

Armin let out a strangled gasp.

Connie paled.

Disgust rolled though Ymir at the scene, making her lean back.

"Sure gives bloodbath a new meaning," Levi said without humor.

Suddenly, Eren felt light-headed, claustrophobic. He swallowed and took comfort in Mikasa and Armin by his sides, grateful Mikasa's horror-filled eyes weren't on him and seeing his blood-drained face. Her panic would have made him feel worse, he knew it.

Eren gasped, backing away. Half his body was under the red sludge. He screamed, terrified, surrounded by dead humans.

"This is..." Sasha clutched her head.

I'd go insane if I had lived through that . Christa tried to swallow, mouth dry.

Petra felt goosebumps breaking out across her skin, feeling Levi shuddering silently next to her.

Erwin and Hange were observing quietly, faces closed.

Eren bumped into something, someone, behind him, and turned. The floater's body twisted, revealing a chalky face with completely grey eyes. "This...this can't be happening."

Jean's mouth tingled and he took a deep breath, trying not to gag. He could almost imagine himself in the Titan's stomach. The heat from the skin, the metallic stench of blood, claustrophobic from all the red, and the slimy— *Enough!* He forced those thoughts out of his head.

We're nothing like we were five years ago **. The top ten stood side-by-side.** ***We trained so hard*** **.**

SanTitan stared at Armin, who was frozen in place, looking traumatized. ***We studied so hard... To beat these things… To survive against them...***

"It's hot..." A feminine voice came from behind him. "Help me, Mom..."

Exactly how many people survive being eaten? What happens to them if a Titan is cut down while someone is still alive inside it? Hange wondered curiously. Would it be possible to save someone by immediately cutting the Titan's stomach open? *No* , she mentally shook her head, *they'll likely be too injured to survive.*

But what if a Titan swallowed a person whole? Would the pressure not break bones? *And most of the time they'll have lost a limb or two first before being eaten* . Rarely had she seen someone get swallowed whole. *If the blood loss doesn't kill them, the infection certainly will.* She didn't think a Titan's stomach was the most sanitary place in the world.

If only she had a few specimens to test her theories. They could try to use dummies to see if it was possible to save soldiers who weren't too badly hurt before they were swallowed.

There were still many issues to consider. Such as the person's mental strength, the hostile environment, the material difference between real humans and dummy humans, and not to mention actually getting the Titans to eat the dummies. And what if they had a gag relax? So many questions, but such a thing had never been done before. No one had even thought it possible. It was new—even without much of a guarantee they could only maybe save one soldier in battle—but it was rejuvenating.

"Mom..." **Eren's mind flashed to her smiling face, putting a white bed sheet on the line to dry. Little Eren snuck from the**

other side, making a goofy face and causing her to start laughing. *"Mom..."* He beamed with pride, watching her laugh.

"Mom..." The female soldier began to drown. "Help me."

***Why must this happen? Why has everything been taken from us?* His mother's death came back to him. *Our lives… Our dreams…* Little Armin was excitedly showing Eren his grandfather's book.**

"Why?" Tears began pouring from his eyes. "Damn it! Damn it!" He began to sink.

Mikasa captured Eren in a death grip, as if it would prevent his onscreen version from drowning, wide-eyes glued to the scene with the same look of horror on her face as the others.

"I refuse to give up!" Only Eren's head remained afloat, and the stump of a left arm raised up. "I'll kill you! Every last one! I'll destroy you with my own hands! All of you!"

Still refusing to give up, huh? Levi was impressed with his iron will.

So much rage and hate. Petra thought sadly. *Is that all you know after your mother was killed?* Revenge completely dominated his mind. His entire existence was based on it. Every thought, every action, every breath he took, it was in the name of vengeance.

A hand shot out of SanTitan's mouth, making it stumble and fall.

"I'm surprised it didn't explode outright," Ymir muttered.

Bones broke and skin stretched and twisted, exploding, sending a large quantity of blood against the buildings. The

Rogue Titan rose from the steaming pile of flesh, his skin and hair stained red. He threw his head back and roared.

He was already injured and bleeding from when his limps were bitten off, and then he focused purely on annihilating all the Titans, thus meeting the transformation requirements. Hange thought.

Noticing a Titan down the street, he scowled, moving toward it. SanTitan's skin squelched beneath the 15-meter's feet as he walked right through the body.

They winced.

"I'll exterminate you all!"* Eren's voice, distant, rang through the Titan's mind. *"I'll kill every single one of you!"

A 3-meter lunged at him. The Rogue Titan threw a punch, fist going through the smaller Titan's mouth and destroying its nape.

Just how much anger does he have? Jean frowned. *I'm surprised the idiot hasn't exploded from all that rage he has bottled up inside .*

"More!"* He began stomping on the fallen Titan. *"More! Kill more!"* He continued stomping. *"I want to kill!"* Finally, the Rogue Titan stood straight. *"Kill 'em all..."

Then the image froze on the Rogue Titan's face.

They thought Erwin had paused the episode by accident until the song started.

"I wanna be the very best, that no one ever was~"

"Um, is Candy singing?" Christa asked rhetorically.

"To take them down is my real test, I'll slaughter them all~"

Silence.

"I will travel from land to sea, searching far and wide, to rip Titans apart and see, the blood and gore inside~" Abruptly she stopped. "That's all I have right now," Candy declared.

"Well, that was...interesting," Petra said.

Connie started to clap, silenced by a withering look from Levi. "I thought it was good, too," Sasha whispered.

Eren wasn't sure what to think. Somehow, he got the feeling he was being made fun of.

"I'll kill you," Eren said, barely lucid.

"Dude, that's creepy." Connie's chuckle, stemming more from nervousness than amusement, broke the last of the tension and started a chain reaction. Soon, most were laughing.

"That's scary Eren!"

"You look like a pervert!"

"What a weirdo."

"Screw you guys!"

Armin gaped at his best friend, supporting him. "Eren?" The last of the fog disappeared and he finally came to his senses.

Mikasa looked over her shoulder. "Eren!" Around them, all eyes of the Garrisons were on the trio.

"Where did Reiner, Annie, Bert, and Jean go?" Sasha asked.

"As soon as the lift came down, they ordered us to get away from Eren," Jean answered. "Armin and Mikasa chose to stay."

"Eren! Can you move on your own?" Armin asked. "Are you yourself again? Tell them everything you know! I'm sure they'll understand!"

Those terrified, close-minded idiots? Unlikely. Petra thought.

Eren turned to him. "Armin?"

"Did you hear him? He said he's gonna kill us!"

"How did they hear Eren from so far away?" Christa asked.

"It was dead quiet," Mikasa said. "And everyone was completely focused on us."

"Yeah, I heard it, too."

"He's planning on eating us!"

"They'd probably give you indigestion if you ate them," Sasha said, getting some laughs.

"What're they talking about?" Eren eyed the blades. *Why're they pointing those swords at us? They're meant for killing Titans. Why are they glowering at me like that?*

Weilman, in particular, was looking very terrified.

"He looks like he's ready to shit his pants," Levi snorted.

***What's going on here?* Eren thought.**

On the other side of Wall Rose, a man's voice was heard as he addressed the trainees. "You trainees will prepare your equipment and remain on standby!"

"...and that's how we got ahold of some gas and got out of Trost." Connie sat, surrounded by his friends.

"You went through all that? I'm sorry..." Christa said sympathetically. "We kept volunteering to help supply you guys, but." Her shoulders slumped.

"We'd even managed to secure some gas, too," Ymir said.

"Really?"

"Don't look so surprised, Jean."

She doesn't seem the type. Erwin observed Ymir. *But when it came down to it, she was willing to lend her comrades a hand when she could have stayed safe behind Wall Rose.* That earned her a few points in his book.

"D-Does that mean everyone who isn't here is...?" Christa trailed off.

"Yeah."

"Even Mikasa?" Ymir was surprised.

"No," Connie said, "I'm pretty sure she came after us, with Jean and the rest."

"Jean," Ymir called out. He was sitting at a table with Annie, Reiner, and Bert. "Don't tell me Mikasa got hurt or something?"

"Hey, what's wrong?" Connie asked.

Jean took large sips from the waterskin and wiped his mouth with the sleeve of his arm. "I can't tell you. We've been slapped with a confidentiality order."

"How could they think they'd possibly be able to keep that a secret?" Christa shook her head.

"You saw the Garrisons just now when they confronted Eren," Jean said. "If the soldiers were overcome with panic and started being so irrational, no way could the civilians be expected to think straight and not do anything rash and crazy."

"A confidentiality order?"

"What the hell?"

"There's no way it's staying under wraps though." Jean recalled the lift ride down the Wall, finding Garrison soldiers everywhere. "The news is gonna spread across humanity like wildfire. Assuming humanity lasts long enough, anyway."

Atop the Wall, Hannes looked down. A metal gate covered the hole, blocking the Titans' way. A large group had piled up against it. "That's pretty smart of the Corps of Engineers, using the Titans themselves as a defensive wall of flesh. But we can't afford to let our guard down."

"He's so different compared to the first episode, talking about keeping their guard up," Hange said.

"He really stepped up as a soldier," Eren said with pride.

"After all, this is the front line between humanity and the Titans. We're at the edge of a cliff." Hannes then noticed his comrade's odd expression. "What's the matter?"

"Oh, no... Nothing's wrong with our mission. I'm just worried about my friends assigned to the vanguard. I just saw a messenger headed for HQ with a pale look on his face."

"Yeah, but our only focus should be on fending them off, just as we were originally trained."

"I heard you helped three children escape five years ago and that they're trainees now."

"But he only saved Eren and Mikasa," Sasha pointed out.

Eren shrugged. "Probably a misunderstanding since the three of us are always together."

"Were they part of the vanguard, too?"

"Yes..."

"I apologize, sir. I shouldn't have brought it up."

"They're fine. They're tough kids," Hannes said, convinced.

Armin cringed. *I was so weak. Crying and being a burden to my squad and getting my friends killed.*

I lost the will to live and my comrades got killed because of my irresponsibility. Mikasa thought unhappily.

All that time I looked down on Hannes, thinking I'd make a better soldier, and I was almost killed right off the bat. Eren felt embarrassed and guilty. *I got my squadmates killed, too, trying to save my ass.*

"They each have what it takes to survive," Hannes continued. "One's a proficient fighter. Another has immense inner strength. And the other is extremely intelligent. I know they're alright. They're alive for sure."

The trio felt a rush of affection for the older man for his absolute faith in them and their individual talents.

Eren glanced between his best friends. *We were dumb, we made mistakes. But we continued to fight. And won.* And they would continue to do so. And with Candy help, their victory was assured.

"Trainees Yeager, Ackerman, and Arlert!" Weilman yelled. "Your present behavior is an act of high treason!"

"And you'd know all about treason, wouldn't you?" Petra huffed.

"What do you have to say in defense?" Weilman demanded while Eren continued to be puzzled. "Should you try anything funny or attempt to move from where you are, we'll blast you to bits immediately and without hesitation! This is a direct question! What are you really?! Human?! Or Titan?!"

"Why bother asking if you're just gonna kill us all anyway?" Mikasa glared.

Wh-What kind of question is that? What's with that look?! It's almost like they're looking at some kind of monster. Is that what they think of me? **Eren answered the Garrison captain honestly, "I...I don't understand the question, sir!"**

"Playing innocent, huh?! Just try that again, monster!" Weilman pointed angrily. "We'll blast you into pieces in the blink of an eye before you can reveal your true form!"

"How did this moron make it to the rank of captain?" Ymir thought out loud.

"The main job of the Garrisons is to mend the walls," Erwin explained. "It's not something that requires courage or battle skills, and he had some political pull."

"True form?" Eren parroted.

"Everyone saw it! You emerged from the carcass of a Titan! We've allowed an unknown being— you—to infiltrate Wall Rose! Even if you are a member of the Training Corps as sanctioned

by the king, it is well within reason for me to eliminate any risk as quickly as possible! I'm not wrong!"

Who're are you trying to convince? Jean rolled his eyes.

"Sounds like he's just trying to make excuses," Sasha said.

"The Armored Titan that took down Wall Maria could appear at any moment now!"

Levi made a face. *And standing around wasting time bitching at three trainees will help against its attack how?*

"As we speak, the very survival of humanity is at stake! Understand?! We can't afford to waste any further manpower or time on you! I will bombard you with high explosives if I have to!" Weilman was trying for bravado but shaking like a leaf in the wind.

Rico stood behind him, calm. "Indeed, their defiance is obvious."

"What defiance?" Christ said, dismayed. "They're not doing anything."

"It's unlikely we'll get any beneficial information from them. As you said, this is a waste of time and resources."

"Sir! Now is our best chance!"

"We should destroy him while he's still in human form!"

"They're so stupid!" Sasha complained. "How do they know they can't get any info out of them? He asked one question and then decided Eren's a monster!"

"They did just see Eren emerge from a Titan's body and not give a clear answer and say he's gonna 'kill them all' not 'kill all the Titans,'"

Armin stated rationally. "I can understand how they'd get the wrong impression."

"Well, he'd be a really pathetic spy if he blew his cover like that," Ymir said.

Mikasa stepped forward, swords at the ready. "My specialty is slicing up flesh. I'll gladly demonstrate it, if need be. " She glared with a murderous look on her face. "If anyone wants to experience my technique then please, by all means, step this way."

That sent them into laughter.

"Damn girl," Hange giggled. "There's no competing with you."

"Sir," Ian said, "Mikasa Ackerman was assigned to escort duty with us elite soldiers. Her prowess is equal to that of a hundred ordinary soldiers. Losing her would be a great setback for humanity."

Eren was, without a doubt, humanity's greatest asset. *And she's the third, right after Levi.* Erwin thought. And he planned to have her match Humanity's Strongest Soldier in terms of battle skill, soon.

"Hey, Mikasa! Armin! What is all this?!"

"Mikasa," Armin ignored Eren and tried to reason with her, "attacking people won't help! There's nowhere to run inside these cramped Walls!"

"I don't care who my opponents are. I won't let anyone kill Eren. I couldn't care less about anything else!"

A deep inhale. Then exhale. There, Eren was getting better at not letting Mikasa's extreme protectiveness get to him. Much.

Having watched the sixth episode, they could—mostly—understand where she was coming from.

"We need to talk with them! None of them understand the situation! That's why fear's spreading among them!"

Am I the only one who doesn't think I'm a Titan? **Eren gritted his teeth, eyes closed.** ***Damn! I have no memory of how I got here! I'm too weak to stand, and I could end up dead if I say the wrong thing.***

Petra crossed her arms. "You'll end up dead regardless of what you say with this crowd."

A cannon was pointed straight at them. Soldiers on the ground held up their blades, glaring.

Being killed by humans? **Eren thought.** ***That's absurd! What is this about me coming out of a Titan's body, anyway?! What the hell are they talking about?! How is that possible?!***

So he really, truly doesn't remember. Hange noted. It wasn't memory loss from a traumatic experience or fear. She hadn't thought that was a high possibility. Still, it was good to have confirmation.

Does that mean that wasn't a dream?! **A memory of him losing his arms came back to him.** ***If that's the case that means I grew an arm where my sleeve is gone!*** **Eren stared at his hand.** ***That makes me practically like a Titan! That's impossible. How could I? How...?***

What can he heal from? What would it take for him to— Hange immediately slammed the brakes on those thoughts. Experimenting on Titans was one thing, and she hated it, necessary as it was. But she could never inflict pain on a human being for the sake of science. Besides, Mikasa would kill her slowly and painfully if she dared.

"I'll ask one more time! What are you really?!" Weilman screamed.

Jean found the man very irritating. *Why bother asking again if you've already decided?*

Armin looked back at the Garrison captain, scared. The silence was thick in the air. Everyone stood still, waiting for Eren's answer.

I can't answer this wrong. I won't be the only one who'll die. **The trio, as children, ran in the street, looking happy.** ***Yeah, I've always been the same as you…***

"I'm human!"

The wind blew gently, its whistling the only sound audible, cutting the silence.

"I see. Don't take this personally." Weilman's hand began to rise and Armin gasped.

"Shocker," Ymir deadpanned.

"Ass," Sasha said.

"This is just how it has to be. Because no one can prove that they aren't a monster." He held his arm up high. On the Wall, a soldier raised her hand in reply.

"Eren! Armin!" Mikasa ran back, abandoning her swords. "We're going up the Wall!" She picked him up in one swoop.

"Wait!" Eren said.

"There goes my dignity." Eren sighed, causing a few chuckles.

I was trying to save your life . Mikasa wanted to argue. Dignity or pride has nothing to do with anything as far as she was concerned.

The bronze key danced around his neck, triggering memories.

"Eren, when I get back, I'll show you the basement that I've kept secret all this time. Keep this key on you at all times," Grisha said as a young Eren stared at the metal object in his hands. "And every time you see it, remember. Remember that you must visit that basement!"

Eren grunted at the onslaught of images.

That's how he knew. Erwin narrowed his eyes. *Some of his memories came back in a rush and somewhere in there was a memory on how to transform* . Only it had been temporary and Eren had forgotten after the situation was brought back under control thanks to Pixis.

"This injection will make you forget all of this," Grisha said with tears running down his cheeks, "so there's no use explaining now. Just remember this. You must retake Wall Maria and reach the basement!"

Little Eren backed up, nervous and scared, holding his hand.

"I'm certain this ability will help when that time comes! Their memories will tell you how to use it!"

Their memories? Whose memories? Hange's eyes became round. *His ancestors? The people who helped make the serum?* Who was Grisha talking about?

"Eren!"

More quickly the flashes ran through his mind.

"You'll understand the truth someday if you visit the basement!"

Eren struggled, throwing off Mikasa's balance, dragging her by the arm back toward Armin, a look of pure determination on his face. Weilman's arm began to rise.

The viewers held their breaths, watching the slowed scene in high anticipation.

"It will be a harsh, painful journey but you must reach it!"

Weilman's hand came down. Fire flashed around the cannon as it was fired. A charcoal, iron sphere raced toward the trio.

They're going to die! Such thoughts popped into many of their heads in sheer disbelief.

"If you want to save Mikasa and Armin, and everyone else..."* Eren had an arm wrapped around his two friends. *"...you must learn to control this ability!"

Eren bit his hand. A golden-orange sphere encircled them and lightning flew. A spine erupted among the smoke and a skeletal arm. Red muscles wrapped around the bones of the hand, catching the iron ball.

Hange was wiggling around in her spot, unable to sit still.

The explosion caught the attention of Hannes and his fellow soldiers on the Wall. On the other side of it, Jean and the rest were watching the smoke rise in shock.

Weilman gazed at the steam and smoke clearing up. "Did we get him?"

Mikasa and Armin were staring in pure shock and fear at the bones wrapped around them.

Rico's eyes widened in horror. Weilman was frozen, unable to wrap his head around the sight before him. "It's not possible..."

The soldiers cried out in panic and fear at the half-skeletal half-muscular Titan that had appeared before them.

Finally, the viewers released the breaths they didn't know they'd been holding, hearts pounding fast in their chests.

"That was fucking awesome." Connie was, as usual, the first to react.

Christa nodded. "My heart's still beating like crazy!"

Petra exhaled. "That was so close. Too close."

"It was a nice save," Jean said and Levi grunted, nodding.

"Just a second too late and you'd have been blown to pieces. Nice reflexes," Ymir commented.

"Thanks," Eren said. It had all happened pretty fast, especially with half his mind racing from the memories of his father injecting him with the serum.

"It certainly was exciting," Erwin said.

"I think it was almost more exciting than when we actually experienced it," Armin said.

Mikasa nodded. "We were in shock then, now with the music and all, it was very...intense."

"Guagh!" Hange held up one hand, supported by the other one. "Cramp!" Her cry and sudden pose made them smile in amusement.

Erwin leaned in to look at her notes. "That's a lot."

"We can't miss a single detail. It could make all the difference!" Hange declared.

After giving her a few minutes to rest her hand, Erwin hit play on episode ten.

Please Review~

Episode - Response

Chapter 10: Response

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The group concurs the Colossal Titan Shifter is in the military and the attack was executed while the Scouts were away. Candy sings.

I) The characters will not watch parody videos. It doesn't fit. The purpose of them watching AoT is to learn and be prepared. And as fantastical as the plot is (Candy, TV, unlimited food/water and all) I still want to make it as realistic as I can.

II) There are no pairings in this story. Any personal moments between characters have and will stem from friendship or camaraderie, not romance.

" **I'll ask one more time! Just what are you really?!" Weilman screamed.**

" **I'm human!" Eren yelled back.**

Armin and Mikasa watched, tension clear on their faces.

" **I see." Weilman's arm began to rise. "Don't take this personally."**

"Now why am I not surprised?" Petra rolled her eyes. "He just saw Eren transform, what makes him think he can't do it again?" Or that it

might piss him off that he was being cooperative yet still being shot at thus pushing him into attacking instead of only defending?

"You're overestimating the idiot's intelligence," Levi said.

On the other side of the Wall, things were much more peaceful.

" **Marco, I can't do this anymore. I can't fight Titans anymore!" Daz cried.**

" **What's gotten into you?" Marco questioned.**

" **My friends got eaten right in front of me! My friends got killed, yet I didn't feel any sadness or hate at all!"**

A few feet over, Sasha sat, head down, with a plate full of loaves of bread. Untouched.

"Wow, you must really not be feeling well," Hange said, getting several nods in agreement.

" **Deep down, I just felt glad it wasn't me!"**

Sasha was listening, shaken.

" **But it's my turn next." Daz clutched his head. "I've realized what our job is! It's basically fighting and fighting until we eventually get eaten!"A cart with five injured and mutilated soldiers was passing by on the street. "Well, screw that!" He reached for his blade. "I'd rather end things—"**

"But you already survived!" Eren couldn't understand the logic of surviving, then killing yourself so you wouldn't have to die. His death wasn't a guarantee. And the longer you survived, the better your chances were.

" **Stop!" Marco grabbed him. "Pull yourself together! You aren't the only one, you know! We're all fighting back fear! Just look at**

Sasha! Even after what she went through, she's still an upstanding soldier!"

Sasha cried out suddenly. "Um, my stomach hurts. Could you please consider me one of the wounded?"

Daz tried to pull out his sword again. "I can't go on!"

The viewers laughed. They knew they shouldn't but they couldn't help themselves.

"I can't believe you did that," Hange said, laughing.

Armin smiled. "Poor Marco, he was trying so hard."

" **Stop! Stop it!"**

Jean, Reiner, Bert, and Annie were silent. "That gag order is definitely warranted," Jean finally said. "With the way things are if they found out about Eren…"

Crazy mobs. Petra thought immediately. People in a large group, frightened beyond belief, would look for a target, someone to blame. *And Eren would have been the perfect scapegoat.*

An explosive sound came from the other side of Wall Rose, startling the soldiers. "Cannon fire?" Jean looked around. "Why only one shot?!"

" **Look over there! Smoke! It's inside the Wall!"**

" **Hey! What's happening?!"**

" **What's going on?!"**

" **Did they break through the water gate?!"**

" **Impossible! That's the sturdiest place of all!"**

" **They must've just set off a shell by accident!"**

" **Still, why's there so much smoke?!"**

Reiner was shocked and horrified. He took out his blades.

So now he takes the initiative. Better late than never, I suppose. Although Erwin wondered what Reiner thought he could possibly do in this situation.

" **No way. Is it Titan steam?" Jean wondered.**

Reiner immediately took off on his 3D gear, followed by Annie and Bert. Jean wasted no time chasing after them.

For a self-proclaimed weak-willed person and a loner looking out for herself, Bert and Annie sure didn't act that way just now . Jean hadn't really noticed at the time who exactly had run toward the explosion. Reiner made sense, he was the heroic knight-type. The other two? Not so much. *Guess you don't really know yourself until you're in a life-and-death situation* .

Red muscles steamed and bushes burned around them. Armin shook while Mikasa eyed their surroundings carefully. The Garrisons watched in stunned disbelief, trembling. Jean, Annie, Reiner, and Bert gaped at the scene from a rooftop in the distance.

" **What the hell's going on here?" Reiner said.**

Inside the steam, a half-muscular, half-skeletal Titan stood. Mikasa gripped her blade, looking around while Armin was frozen in his spot. Three violet flowers swayed gently in the wind.

Hange wrote that down. There had to be significance to the shot since it had been placed to bring the viewer's attention to it. The same way the shot had been placed when steam had risen from Eren in the mess hall while his wounds healed.

The sound of cracking and deteriorating bones finally snapped Armin out of it. He looked up, seeing the massive head swaying through the ribcage.

The Garrisons continued to stand around uselessly. "It's alive!"

" ***It's aliiiiiive!"*** **Candy laughed.**

"I really want to know all the references she makes!" Christa said longingly.

"It's probably super clever," Jean said.

Eren grunted. "You're only saying that because she said you're her favorite."

"I don't know." Ymir smirked. "That song from the last episode seemed pretty funny to me."

" **Captain Weilman!" Rico walked up to him.**

The bearded man whimpered, seeing the Titan's face and stepping back. "We're on standby! We can't risk getting near it!" He yelled, spit flying. "Stay on alert, everyone! Remain on standby! Artillerymen, reload the cannon!"

Levi frowned. In a way, he could understand why the man would want to be on the offensive. He had a right to be wary. *Confronted with an unknown foe, carelessness will get you killed* . But Weilman made decisions based *purely* on fear. He was illogical and acting crazy, a complete opposite on how an officer in the military should behave during such a critical situation.

The Titan's eye twitched. Inside, Eren began to wake. He gasped, noticing the muscles and the bones, struggling to break free. The skin behind the Titan's neck moved and steam exploded out. Eren hung there, almost parallel to the ground. He grunted, trying to rip his left arm out of the body. Finally, he broke free and noticed it.

" **What is this?" He stared at the back of the giant red head.**

" **I-I remember hearing the cannon go off," Armin said. "After that came a tremendous crash, shock, and heat! And now we're inside a giant skeleton—"**

" **Eren protected us," Mikasa said calmly. "That's all we need to understand for now."**

Eren mentally sighed. *She's so unsurprised* . He wasn't happy to admit, even only to himself, that he was the only one keeping score on who saved whom how many times. Mikasa didn't care about the quantity or felt bitter she hadn't save Armin but Eren had.

Armin noticed the flowers by Mikasa's foot. *Flowers, only on the inside?*

Hange smiled triumphantly. There really was something to the visual presentation, clues with hints that would help in some way if she could figure them out. It was a good thing she kept detailed notes and had eleven other brains to pick for things they may have subconsciously picked up but hadn't realized what they meant.

" **Hey." Eren ran around the ribcage. "You guys okay?" Mikasa stared at him with wide eyes, still unable to wrap her head around the miracle.**

" **Eren, what is this?" Armin asked.**

" **I don't know! But it's already starting to vaporize, just like a Titan's corpse! Let's get away from it!" He stepped out into the steam. "Whether they're watching and waiting or if they're in a daze, the Garrisons aren't showing any signs of activity for now." Eren shifted to where the cannons were mounted on the wall. Mikasa stood and he turned to her. "But I'm sure they'll start attacking again soon enough."**

The decaying Titan body loomed over them.

Why did it start decaying while Eren was still attached to it? Petra thought suddenly. The answer came a second later. Probably because the body had served its purpose. He had formed it with the intent to cover his friends and take that cannonball. Once its purpose was fulfilled, the body began to wither and die.

" **I doubt there's any chance of reasoning with them now, after seeing this." Eren grabbed the key around his neck. "But there is one thing I remember now. The basement. The basement of my house."**

Armin and Mikasa stood silent, listening. An image of the collapsed house flashed on the screen.

Eren and Mikasa flinched. Years had passed but the feeling of hopelessness at seeing one's home, a symbol of safety, security, and happiness, utterly destroyed still ran deep.

" **My dad said it'd all make sense if I go there!" Eren clutched the key, staring at it intently. "He's also the reason this has happened to me. If I go to the basement, I might figure out what the Titans are too!" Images of his father injecting him came to him.**

Eren recalled the Armored Titan running and the Colossal Titan peering over the Wall.

" **Damn it!" He punched a bone of the skeleton in frustration, causing more cracks. "Why did he keep it a secret?! Thousands of Scouts have died trying to get that information! It's the only hope humanity has!"**

" ***Well…"***

"What does that mean?" Jean asked, troubled.

Christa frowned. "She sounded uncertain."

"What if it means the key is a useless lead?" Connie said suddenly.

"Shut up, Springer," Eren snapped.

"Questioning is a good thing," Ymir said to Eren. "You can't just accept things at face value."

"But there has to be something there. Eren's abilities give us probable cause," Armin pointed out.

"Connie has a point though," Hange said. "Candy says weird things and many are clues, I believe. We can't exclude the possibility it's a dead end."

"We could be misinterpreting," Petra said. "Perceptions influence how we see the world, what Candy means might be different from what we're imagining because she knows the whole truth."

"We don't have all the info." Hange nodded. "So we can't jump to conclusions based on what we have so far."

"Is the basement completely underground?" Levi addressed Eren and Mikasa. "The house collapsed on itself so it's possible the wreckage could have gone through the door and buried or destroyed whatever answer you're meant to find." That was one plausible explanation for why Candy sounded disagreeing about humanity's survival depending on whatever they found in the basement.

"I don't think so," Mikasa answered. "The door's very sturdy and it was always locked to keep us from snooping." By us, everyone knew it meant Eren. "From the way the house collapsed, I'm sure whatever is inside survived."

"We should just see what happens," Sasha said diplomatically.

"She's right, Candy promised answers so the wise thing to do is wait and watch," Erwin said after listening to everyone's opinions. No one objected and he un-paused the episode.

Armin stood a little straighter.

" **And he just kept it tucked away in our basement all this time?! What the hell was he thinking?!" Eren gritted his teeth, eyes wild. Mikasa then noticed something. "And where the hell has he been these last five years?"**

Mikasa placed a hand on his shoulder, breaking him out of his rage. " **Eren, w e have other things to attend to right now."**

" **Yeah."**

The trio moved quickly.

Ymir paid full attention, interested to see how they'd managed not to get shot at a second time. She knew Pixis had arrived at the last second but how had they stalled the panicking soldiers in the meantime?

" **The smoke's clearing!" A soldier said.**

Weilman looked around, listening to them.

" **Attack on sight!"**

" **Let's finish it off quick!"**

" Hold your positions!" Weilman yelled. They all flinched when the Titan's body fell apart. Bones shattered and turned to dust as they hit the ground, forcing the soldiers to cover their faces as a mixture of dust, steam, and crushed bone particles kicked up.

Inside the cover, the trio was kneeling on the ground. "I'm getting out of here," Eren said, making his friends gasp.

" Where to? How?" Armin asked.

" Anywhere will do for now. Then I'll go over the Wall and make for the basement." He clenched his fist. "After I've changed into a Titan again."

"They'll shoot you down when you try to climb the Wall, idiot," Levi said. Turning his back would make him vulnerable. Armin and Mikasa especially, since they'd have to travel on the Titan's shoulders with Armin's gear without gas and Mikasa's not far behind.

" Can you really do that?" Armin asked again.

" I'm not too sure how to do it myself, but I think I can. It's just like how people can't really explain how they move their arms." Eren replayed the attack in his mind. "Just now, my mind unconsciously focused on stopping the cannonball. That's why it decayed. It only had the capabilities and endurance for that." He was out of breath. "This time, I'm gonna be an even stronger one. I'm gonna be a 15-meter high one that can slaughter other Titans, like before!"

" Eren," Mikasa said in worry. "Your nose is bleeding."

He wiped his nose, staring at the red staining his fingers. "You look really pale," Armin began, "and your breathing is rough. It's taking a toll on your body. You're not well!"

The more he transforms the more toll it takes on his body. Hange wrote that down, wondering what Eren's limitations were.

" **My health doesn't matter right now." He wiped all the blood from his face. "I have two ideas in mind. You guys can get through this alive if you stop trying to protect me. I've already caused you two enough trouble as it is, so I'm gonna go it alone from here on out."**

" **No, I—" Armin started to object.**

" **Eren, I'm coming with you," Mikasa stated plainly.**

" **You can't."**

" **If I can't keep up, you can abandon me. But I won't have to do what you say, either."**

"I'd never abandon you and Armin, don't either of you ever doubt that," Eren said, earning warm smiles from his two friends.

If you were on the run, it'd be you who has to be abandoned cause you can't keep up with Mikasa. Jean thought.

" **I'm serious here!" Eren said. "Just forget about it! I'm not your little brother or your kid!"**

Armin was lost in his thoughts as they argued.

" **Sir, the high explosive shell is almost reloaded. What are your next attack orders?" Rico asked.**

" **Await my signal!"**

" **Yes, sir!"**

Still hidden, Mikasa and Eren continued to argue. *For now, the Garrison isn't showing any signs of launching a close-quarters assault.* Armin thought. *If they were, Mikasa would've sensed it faster than a stray cat. Assuming they reload in the shortest time possible, it'll take them about twenty more seconds,* h e deduced. *Eren will spring into action and be gone before then.*

Erwin had heard it was Armin who had really saved the day by convincing Pixis they weren't a threat, but allies. The Garrison commander had spoken briefly but highly of the boy. Erwin had seen with his own eyes what had impressed Pixis and agreed completely.

The memory of little Eren and Mikasa beating up the bullies came to Armin.

***Why am I reminded of that at a time like this?* Armin became downcast. *Is it because this is the end for us?* He remembered his younger-self, cowering in the corner, watching his friends. *In the very end, I never amounted to anything more than a coward.* The smiling Eren and Mikasa offered him a hand. *They were there to help me so many times but not once did I ever manage to help them.* Little Armin watched the two, protecting him.**

"Don't be silly, you saved Eren from a nasty beating at the refugee camp," Christa pointed out.

"And a whole lot more at the HQ with your plan to clear the supply room of the Titans," Petra added.

"Okay, yes, thank you," Armin said quickly, face red from the attention.

Rain poured heavily and Armin ran, carrying his pack in training. *How can I possibly call myself an equal friend? How can I possibly offer to go with them?* The trio was sitting on stone steps, discussing their future. *I'm not even confident I*

can keep up. **Armin watched the others trainees running ahead of him, leaving him behind as he struggled to keep up.**

Armin sat back down, resigned. *I guess…* The three children sat on the rooftop of Eren's house with the sun shining brightly and the sheets blowing in the wind, pouring over Armin's book. *This is the last time the three of us will ever be together.*

" **Eren, I am—"**

" **Wait, Mikasa, I said I had two ideas, remember? Armin, I leave the decision to you."**

"Have faith in yourself," Mikasa said to him quietly, "we always do."

Armin snapped his head up in surprise.

" **I know how unrealistic this plan is," Eren admitted. 'The best option would be to use this Titan ability in a systematic way, under the military's direction. I know this sounds crazy, but if you think you can convince the Garrison that I'm not a threat, I'll trust in you and go with that option. That's my second idea. If you don't think you can do it, I'll go with the other idea as a last resort."**

Atop the Wall, the soldiers began readying the cannons.

" **Decide in fifteen seconds," Eren said. "Can you do it or not? I'll respect your opinion, whichever it is."**

The soldier signaled he was ready.

" **Eren, why are you entrusting such an important decision to me?" Armin was staring in disbelief.**

" **Even when things get ugly, you always make the right call, y'know? I figure that's worth relying on," Eren answered with a tense smile.**

" **When did I ever do that?"**

" **All the time. Like that time five years ago." Tiny Armin ran to Hannes, grabbing his arm and yelling. "If you hadn't gone and gotten Hannes for us, Mikasa and I would've been devoured by a Titan."**

"Oh," Armin said. That was what Mikasa had been referring to back at the HQ in the supply room, when she'd said he had saved both and her and Eren's lives. *I'd totally forgotten about that.*

Behind Armin, the last of the body fell apart as the realization hit him. *It was all in my head. I convinced myself that's how I was. I convinced myself I was helpless and a burden.* Eren and Mikasa didn't have a hint of doubt in their expressions. *But they never felt that way at all!*

And it's up to you not to ever let them down. Levi thought about two others who had unshakable faith in him and had died as a result of his arrogance.

" **Armin, we're out of time," Eren said.**

The soldier nodded, wire in hand. His companion held up her arm to signal the others on the ground. "They've finished reloading, sir!" Rico reported. "We can fire at any time!"

***These two who are willing to place their lives in my hands are the people I trust more than anyone in this world.* Armin thought, filled with determination. *What more convincing do I need than that?* Without hesitation, he got to his feet. "I will persuade them, without fail. I'll need you to act as nonaggressive as possible."**

The two nodded and Armin marched forward confidently. *Something's been bugging me ever since Eren started fighting as a Titan. I haven't collected my thoughts yet, but I'll do this! I'll*

have to think as I talk! **He ditched his gear and ran out. The noise startled some of the soldiers.**

" **Halt!" Weilman held his arms out ahead of him.**

One of the soldiers pointed a gun at Armin. He slid to a stop and held up his arms.

" **You've finally revealed your true form, monster! I'll do it! I'll give the signal to fire!" Weilman said aggressively.**

Is he blind too now? On top of being stupid? Jean shook her head. Sure Eren transformed but they already knew he could. *It doesn't make Armin the monster* .

" **He is not an enemy of humanity! We're willing to disclose everything we've learned!"**

" **Begging for your lives won't help you! He's revealed his true form for all to see! What more is there to say?" The Garrison captain disagreed stubbornly. "If you insist he's not our enemy, then show me proof! If you can't, then we'll simply eliminate the threat he poses!"**

" **There's no need for proof!" Armin yelled back. Then it struck him *. That's right! There is no need!* He continued, "In fact, this isn't about what we perceive him to be!"**

" **What?! I hear that countless people saw him!"**

" **In which case, they surely saw him fighting Titans as well!" Armin looked at the soldiers, surprising them. "And they must've seen the Titans swarming around him, too!"**

They outnumber the chicken-shit captain, smart to get them on your side. Ymir thought.

They all remembered the Rogue Titan charging at the other Titans.

" In other words, the Titans saw him as prey—just like they see us! That's an irrefutable fact, however hard you look at it!" Armin continued without stopping. Then the whispers began.

" He has a point."

" A Titan, on our side?"

" That's crazy."

" *Reasonable doubt goes a long way."*

Candy sounds impressed . Armin thought proudly.

The soldiers had lowered their weapons.

Weilman looked around in a panic. " Prepare to attack!" He threw his arm out. "Don't be taken in by their clever ruses!" Armin gasped. "Their behavior has always been beyond our understanding! It's entirely possible they'd take on human form and use human language to deceive us all!"

"What?!" Christ was flabbergasted.

"That doesn't even make any sense." Sasha couldn't believe the stupidity. She wasn't smart like Armin and Jean and even she knew what Weilman was sprouting was total nonsense.

"What was a bunch of horseshit," Levi grumbled.

Many of the soldiers seemed to believe him.

"Those dumbasses are actually buying it." Hange almost felt pained by the idiocy.

Eren and Mikasa tensed.

"We can't let them have their way anymore!"

The soldiers were once again ready to attack, glaring.

" *Seriously?* " Sasha gaped. "But...but Armin had proof! That guy's just sprouting nonsense!"

"Fear turns people into idiots." Christa sighed.

It's no use **. Armin stood completely stunned.** ***He's abandoned all logic. He's afraid to think.*** **Armin looked over his shoulder at his friends.** ***Eren! Mikasa!*** **The duo still looked at him with conviction. Eren nodded.**

Gritting his teeth, Armin brought his fist forward and saluted, screaming with determination. "As a soldier, I have long sworn to give my heart for the restoration of humankind!" Weilman was blank-faced. "Nothing would make me happier than to die for that cause!" Eren and Mikasa kept quiet and still. "If we combine his Titan ability with our own remaining manpower, we can retake this city!"

Rico, Ian, and the rest of the soldiers were impacted by his words. Jean, Annie, Reiner, and Bert watched tensely from the rooftop.

Erwin still couldn't figure out why Reiner had run off to see this. Maybe he felt he had to after it had been Jean and Armin who'd taken charge to save their comrades.

" **For humanity's glory, in what little time I have left to live, I will continue to advocate his strategic value!" Armin screamed with the last of his breath.**

" **Captain Weilman," Ian began, "I believe his words are worth consid—"**

"They should put him in charge," Connie said, pointing.

"He's dead," Mikasa told him.

"Oh. That's too bad."

" **Silence!" Weilman yelled at him.** ***However much they beg for their lives, they're still traitors.*** **His arm began to rise and Armin's eyes widened.** ***To dispose of those who violate the rules, that is the duty of a soldier!*** **Mikasa's hand inched over her sword and Eren brought his hand toward his mouth.**

The cannon loomed menacingly and Weilman was about to bring his arm down.

" **That's enough." A hand gripped the Garrison captain's arm. "I see you're still as delicate as a young deer despite your size."**

The group snickered.

The Garrison commander brought the arm down. "Commander Pixis?" Weilman gasped.

Cheers broke out.

" **Can you not see that soldier's splendid salute?" Pixis walked forward. Armin had his eyes closed, face scrunched up. "I've only just arrived, but I've been filled in on the situation. You're in charge of the reinforcements now. I think it'd be best to hear what they have to say."**

Armin dropped to the ground in relief, tearful, his friends sitting in surprise behind him. The three violet flowers moved gently near Eren and Mikasa.

An outline of the three Walls over a compass appeared. ***"According to the Survey Corp's reports, it was believed that the Titans would appear from the south. Indeed, it was Shinganshina District, on the south side of Wall Maria, that the Titans attacked."***

In red, the number 845 appeared with Titans. Shinganshina and Wall Maria were x-ed out. The red Titan figures moved forward and onto to year 850. *"As a result, the fortified city of Trost on the south side of Wall Rose was deemed their next most likely target."*

[Trost District - Inner Gate]

Titans were clawing at the gate. Up on Wall Rose, the Garrison commander studied them, taking a sip from his flask.

"Dot Pixis—who names their kid Dot?"

"What?! Dot? I bet he got picked on as a kid," Connie snickered.

***"I bet his grandma called him Dotty,"* Candy declared.**

The recruits and Hange and Petra giggled.

"Dotty," Jean snorted.

"Dotty is the top officer in charge of Trost and the entire southern territory* ." Pixis watched the city burn and smoke rise. " *And the man given full authority for the defense of humanity's most vital region."

" **I guess I won't find one after all." Pixis looked down at the Titans. "I certainly wouldn't mind being gobbled up by a beautiful lady Titan." He straightened and smiled.**

"Me too! I wouldn't mind being gobbled by a sexy Titan either!" Hange declared to no one's surprise.

"Would you mind being eaten by Eren's Titan?" Connie asked.

"As a matter of fact, I would not."

"Hear that Eren? Hange thinks you're sexy." Ymir wagged her eyebrows at him.

"Please stop," Eren begged, cheeks pink, feeling very awkward about this topic.

" ***And he's also known for being a full-blown eccentric,"*** **Candy finished introducing Pixis.**

" **What is the commander thinking?" Weilman bitched to himself. "Taking those freaks up there without a single bodyguard!"**

" **Well, the commander's thoughts are beyond the comprehension of average people," Rico answered.**

"I see what she did there," Christa giggled.

"Bet he's too stupid to realize she just insulted him," Mikasa said.

" **Captain, we've finished reassembling the troops," Ian said.**

" **Right. Good work." Weilman noticed all the soldiers had nervous, fearful expressions.**

" **I see." Pixis stood ramrod straight, hands behind his back, gazing at the destruction before him. "And visiting this basement will make everything clear?"**

" **Yes. Do you believe me?" Eren asked.**

" **Seeing as you yourself are unable to provide validation, for now, I'm simply keeping it all in mind." Pixis turned and tapped his forehead. "But I do believe I can tell when someone is being sincere or not. I will personally guarantee your safety."**

Their shoulders sagged in relief.

" **Trainee Arlert, was it?"**

" **Sir!"**

" **Earlier, you mentioned that with this so-called 'Titan ability' it would be possible to retake this city. Do you truly believe that? Or was that just a desperate plea for your life?"**

" **It was...both," Armin answered honestly. "I was going to suggest that Eren, in Titan form, could take that giant rock and use it to block the wrecked entrance."**

A massive rock and the hole in the Wall appeared on the screen.

Connie whistled. "Look at the size of that thing."

"You carried *that* ?" Christa said, amazed.

"It felt like I was carrying the weight of the world on my shoulders," Eren said, remembering the heaviness crushing his shoulders.

" **It was just an idea I came up with on the spot. I just wanted them to see the possibilities of Eren's ability and how it could help solve the situation we're in. Of course, I was desperate to survive, too!"**

'" **Desperate to survive,'" Pixis repeated, smiling. "There's nothing more credible than those words." He pulled out the flask again and took a swig.**

Not sure I'd ever be able to berate Hannes for drinking on the job if even the commander does it. Eren thought. Then again, he was Pixis.

The trio waited in silence. Pixis walked over to Eren and knelt in front of the boy sitting on the ground. "What do you say, Trainee Yeager?"

" Sir?"

" Can you seal that gate?" Pixis asked casually.

" I… Well… I'm not sure. Right now, I don't really understand any more than the rest of you," Eren admitted. Armin was quiet. Mikasa looked unsure. "Maybe I can. Maybe I can't. I don't know. I don't feel I can risk giving an irresponsible answer."

" Ah, yes. My apologies," Pixis said cheerfully. "I asked the wrong question." The smile dropped and his tone became more authoritative. "Will you do it or not?" He leveled the boy with a stern look. His gaze shifted behind the Titan-Shifter.

Eren turned his head, following the man's field of vision across the land. Determined, he was quiet for a few seconds. "I'll do it. I'll do it! I don't know if I can plug the hole or not but I'll do it!"

" *Yeah, Eren, go plug that hole!"* Candy snickered.

Connie choked on his apple slice.

Christa and Sasha slapped his back, trying to help, while Ymir laughed.

"Wow..." Jean said.

"What?" Eren asked, confused. He glanced between a blank-faced Mikasa and a blushing Armin.

"You seriously don't know?" Levi raised an eyebrow.

"What does it mean?" Eren asked Petra.

"Uh..." Petra tried to find an appropriate way to tell him. "It—"

"I'll explain," Hange said. "What she—"

"Candy made a sex joke," Erwin said before Hange began a technical explanation that would scar the new recruits for life.

"Oh. Oh!" Eren's face turned red.

" ***Hello, lovely viewers! This message was triggered because the episode count went up to thirty. You are now one-third of the way done."***

"It kind of doesn't feel like three hours have passed," Christa said. "Time's been flying by."

"Counting the ten-minute break, we've been watching TV for three and a half hours now," Hange calculated.

" ***You have twenty episodes left. That means you have around seven hours of TV ahead of you, not counting any breaks you may take."***

Erwin paused the TV. "Is everyone okay with taking a break every five episodes or so?" They nodded in agreement.

"Yes!"

"Yeah."

"Sounds good."

The commander nodded and let the message play.

" ***At the end of episode twenty-five, you will hear another message from me. Then, as a group, have a very important decision to make."***

"Important decision?" Armin echoed.

"What could she have in mind?" Sasha wondered.

" ***In the meantime, enjoy and pay close attention. I'm not just rambling like a lunatic when I comment during an episode. At least, not every time. Well, you're over halfway to the 'future' episodes, only two more hours left to go, have fun!"***

"The future!" Christa gushed. "We're going to see the future!"

"How far do you think it goes?" Connie said, trying to imagine what they might see.

"Could she show us the end of the Titans?" Eren's eyes lit up.

"Candy said twenty-five episodes and the rest are extra. I don't think we'll get that far in fifteen episodes," Ymir deduced.

"But every episode, every event that we see that will happen will be a tremendous help!" Hange squealed in joy.

"If it happens," Levi muttered cynically.

"I'm sure it will," Petra said optimistically. "Though I wonder if that's what Candy meant when she said we have a decision at the end of episode twenty-five."

"It's possible she wants us to think about whom to share our future knowledge with," Erwin suggested.

"I think I remember her saying something about a limit of twelve people." Sasha thought back to episode one. "Or something like that."

"You're right, sir," Armin said to the commander. "And by knowing the future, we can shape it how we want."

"Candy trusted the people in this room enough to share the information," Mikasa said seriously, feeling a sense of responsibility. "After we leave, it's up to us, as a group, to decide whom to let in on this secret."

"There must be a reason the twelve of us were chosen," Hange said, though she was unable to figure it out herself.

"We also have to consider how we'll sound," Erwin added. "Between us, we know we can trust each other. But letting others in, we risk exposing our advantage."

"Commander Pixis would be great," Armin said, Eren and Mikasa nodding in total agreement.

"That's if you're taken seriously," Levi said to Erwin. "You have the most authority but it's still farfetched." Occasionally he himself was having a hard time believing it and he was *living* it.

"We don't have to tell anyone," Ymir said, turning all the heads to her. "At least, not immediately. Using the knowledge to our advantage, Commander Pixis, from what I saw and Armin and the others claim, can be brought in because we'll have proof to an extent."

"I'm with Ymir," Jean pitched in. "We don't really need to tell anyone, period. But if we do decide to, we can wait and see."

"We'll have to wait two hours for the future episodes," the commander said. "Maybe we'll see something that can help prove to Pixis, or possibly Commander-in-Chief Zackly, of the legitimacy of our story. Or we could figure out a way to handle the future without involving anyone else." Erwin leaned back. "It's strange but really all we have to do is sit back and wait and we'll know everything we need to."

"Let's keep watching." Hange grinned. "So we can get to episode 17!"

Please Review~

Episode - Idol

Chapter 11: Idol

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The group discusses potential allies and how to get them on their side. Candy tells them they're one-third done and have an important decision at the end of episode 25.

The clouds flew gently over Trost, the sun shone brightly. "I'll do it! I don't know if I can plug the hole or not!"

The group snickered while Eren blushed.

"But I'll do it!" Eren said in determination, Mikasa watching him intently and Armin looking surprised.

"Well said!" Pixis smiled, patting his shoulders. "You're a real man!" He stood and walked over to the edge of the Wall, cupping his mouth with one hand and raising his other arm. "Calling all staff officers! We have a plan to put together!"

"Huh?! You can't be serious!" Armin said. "It was just some half-baked plan I came up with on the spot! We're actually going through with it?!"

"That's what I thought, too, but there's no point in doubting his decision," Eren said. "Commander Pixis must be envisioning something that we can't yet see."

"Something we can't see?"

"Doubles because you aren't drunk?"

That led to more chuckles.

"Plus, I think there's a bigger issue that needs to be addressed before we can carry out the plan. And the commander is keenly aware of it."

"That means…" Armin said.

"That the Titans aren't the only enemy." Eren's response made Armin's eyes widen.

"No, they most certainly are not. Humans are definitely your enemy."

She said humans, plural . Hange wrote. *Then we're right. The other unusual Titans, the Armored and the Colossal, are humans* . Where did they come from? Hange's eyes widened. "HOLY CRAP!" She shrieked at the top of her lungs, shocking her couch-mates.

"Time is of the essence," Pixis said, grabbing the trio's attention. They stood and faced him.

"Hange?" Erwin asked, fumbling with the remote and pausing the episode.

Levi glared, his ears ringing. "What the fuck, Four-Eyes?"

"Are you alright?" Petra asked.

"IT'S SO OBVIOUS!"

"Not to us," Jean said.

"What's so obvious?" Armin asked.

Hange shot up. And started pacing around.

"Must be serious," Christa whispered to Ymir.

"Candy said humans are the enemy. But I don't think she was referring only to the people who oppose us, the Survey Corps. There are other humans out there." Hange gestured to the side with her arm, a dazed look on her face.

"What?"

"How's that possible?"

"What are you talking about?"

"That's crazy!"

"How did you figure that out?" Ymir asked neutrally.

Hange slapped her forehead. "It's so simple! I can't believe I didn't think of it before!"

"Mind sharing with the rest of the class?" Levi said, irritated.

"Think about it." Hange addressed the eleven pairs of curiosity-filled eyes focused on her. "Eren's Titan, the Armored Titan, the Colossal Titan, they are all so different from the rest. Not just physiologically but mentally. They're smart!"

Petra nodded. "Because they're human."

"Exactly!" Hange pointed, finger inches from the redhead's nose. "Humans! Which begs the question: where did they come from? They can't have been living inside the Walls because no one's seen Titans like those in a hundred years."

"They may have gotten their powers the same way Eren did, by getting injected with some sort of serum," Erwin proposed.

"Yes." Hange nodded. "That's a possibility. But why would they break down the Walls? From letting Titans flood the inside of the Walls?

What could they possibly gain from destroying their home? Unless!"

"Unless this isn't their home." Christa's eyes were wide as saucers, much like the others in the room now.

"I can only conclude they're not from around here. There has to be another...place, humans, another *civilization* ."

The room was deadly quiet, the occupants having been stunned into silence.

"That..." Armin swallowed. "That would explain it."

"There are humans out there." Connie couldn't believe the words coming out of his mouth.

"And remember what Candy said, in the last episode?" Sasha pointed out.

"Of course!" Petra sat straighter. "That makes so much more sense now!"

"I've been writing down what Candy says and when she says it." Hange flipped the pages back in her notebook and read. "Eren is talking about how many Survey Corps members died trying to find more information when his dad had it the entire time. He says it's 'humanity only hope' and Candy says 'Well' in a disagreeing tone."

"We thought she was referring to information in the basement," Mikasa spoke with an awed voice. "When she was really referring to the ' *humanity's* only hope' part because there are other humans out there so we're *not* the last of humanity."

"It was a lie," Levi finally said as Hange collapsed back in her seat. "Us being the last of humanity."

"But why would the Royal Government lie about that?" Sasha asked in confusion.

"Nobody knows." Erwin frowned. "I doubt even most of the officials know. I suspect only the Royal family and a select few do."

"It explains why they're so set on not letting people leave, so against the Survey Corps." Eren glared, fists clenched. "They don't want anyone finding out about their *big lie* ."

"But *why?* " Mikasa shook her head. "That's the part that makes no sense. Why lie about it in the first place?"

"Who knows?" Armin furrowed his eyebrows in thought.

"Obviously the people outside don't like us." All eyes turned to Connie. He shrugged self-consciously. "I mean, they're trying to break down the Walls and let the Titans in so everyone inside will die."

"That is troubling," Petra said, wary.

Levi crossed his arms, a scowl firmly on his face. "Hmph, this is a fucking mess. Now we're stuck with more questions than answers."

"Let's get back to the episode, Candy will probably drop more hints. And stupid jokes." Jean's lips twitched.

"We might just find out the truth in the future episodes," Christa agreed.

Eagerly, they watched as Erwin started the episode.

"We're counting on you, young soldiers," Pixis said, flanked by his subordinates. Across the Wall, houses stood deceptively quiet, smoke rising in various directions.

"An operation to retake Trost?!"

On the other side of the Wall, people whispered amongst each other furiously.

"They can't be serious!"

"We have no way to plug that hole in the gate! What is the top brass thinking?!"

"Setting foot in Trost means a pointless death!"

"Since we can't block the hole, defending Wall Rose's gate is our only real option now! Damn it! They want the glory that badly?!"

"Back into that hell again?" Daz stared down, terrified. "No! I don't wanna die!" He clutched his head and screamed. "Let me see my family!" It attracted the attention of a staff officer.

"Hey, Daz! Not so loud!" Someone shushed.

"You, there! I heard that!" The man yelled. "Do you intend to abandon your duty?!"

"Yes, I do!" Daz screamed, desperate and panicked.

Ca ndy laughed.

Leading a few others to chuckle.

"There's nothing to be had or gained by this pointless act of mass suicide!"

"What do you take humanity for?!" The man clutched his sword. "Rules for?! It's within my authority to execute you on the spot, you know!"

"That's fine by me!" Daz revealed his own sword. "It's a hundred times better than getting eaten by Titans!"

A friend grabbed his shoulders. "Stop, Daz! Stop!"

"Let go! I refuse to go back to that hellhole!"

Across the courtyard, the other soldiers, including Jean and Bert, looked around, listening to the whispers. "Whoa, did you hear that?"

"Can't say I blame him."

"Hey," a brown-haired soldier whispered to her friend, "do you think any of us will be traitors, too?"

"I want to die on my own terms," she replied.

"You two!" A masculine voice growled.

"I-I was only joking!" The blonde-haired girl turned, seeing a wildly desperate man standing inches from her.

"Do it!" He leaned in, a mad gleam in his eyes.

Levi shook his head in disgust.

"Huh?" She leaned back.

"Make a scene! With as many of you as possible!" He continued while Jean watched, stunned.

"Lots of us in the Garrison are unhappy about this, too! We'll use the commotion to get out of here!"

"Coward," Eren said angrily. "Running away from his duty, letting humanity down."

"Don't be so quick to judge," Jean reprimanded.

"To get out of here and go where?" Jean asked.

"To see my daughter! They're gonna break through this Wall anyway!"

Eren shook his head in disbelief. "If you don't stand and fight, the Titans will come in and kill everyone."

"That makes sense to you but you're not a father, your first instinct isn't to think about your kid," Connie said. "He may seem like a terrible soldier because he's trying to be a good father."

"If he were a good father wouldn't he try his best to stop the Titans so they don't get to his daughter?" Eren countered.

"Not everyone's eager to jump into suicidal situations," Jean said. "And unlike you, the rest of us don't have regeneration powers that help us walk away from whatever situation our rash actions may put us in. You talked a big game during our training years, but without that serum your dad gave you, you'd be dead right now."

Eren clenched his fists, trying not to really get into it with Jean. Eren knew he was right but he also knew Jean wasn't entirely wrong either.

Jean folded his arms. "You're not completely wrong," he admitted grudgingly, "but that doesn't make doing the right thing easy."

Petra smiled. "Aw, look at them, they're learning."

"They're brats and they interrupt too much." Levi rolled his eyes. "Five more seconds and I was gonna step in." Unlike her, he didn't bother keeping his voice down.

Eren and Jean decided to try and keep their mouths shut for the rest of the episode.

"It's said that before the Titans ruled the land," Pixis told Eren, "humankind consisted of people of different races and creeds and that they perpetually fought with and killed each other."

"You have no idea."

"Supposedly someone back then said that if a powerful enemy that wasn't human ever appeared, humanity would likely cease its fighting and come together as one. What is your opinion?"

"Wishful thinking," Ymir snorted.

"That's very misanthropic of you," Hange said.

"But true," Armin said grimly.

Meanwhile, Connie wondered what misanthropic meant.

"I'd never heard that legend before," Eren replied. "Well, it seems pretty optimistic. Doesn't interest me though."

Pixis laughed and looked over his shoulder. "You have a cynical mind, just like me."

"Even now, when a powerful enemy has driven us into a corner, I would hardly say that we've 'come together,'" Eren said.

"Indeed. If we don't get our act together soon, even fighting will be tough."

They approached a station with Garrison soldiers keeping watch at the cannons. Hannes noticed them. "Eren?!" The teen blinked and turned to him as they walked by. "You're alright." Hannes smiled, it quickly disappeared when Eren made a gesture with his hand, pointing his finger down. *Focus on my work?*

Connie and Sasha laughed the loudest.

"What's so funny?" Levi asked them. "From what I've seen and heard, you were two of the biggest slackers in your class."

The two shrunk and shut up immediately.

Who does that punk think he is, bossing a superior officer around? Judging from his attitude, Mikasa and Armin must be okay, too. **Then Hannes noticed it.** ***Why is he at the commander's side?***

"He must care a lot about you if he recognized you before he noticed Commander Pixis was also present," Petra said.

"You think so?" Eren grinned happily.

Pixis pulled out a flask and took a swig. He held it out behind him. "Would you like some?"

"Thank you, sir!"

Ymir chuckled. "You just accepted it?"

"I didn't know it was booze!"

"His breath should've been your first clue."

Eren froze, face twisted in disgust. He turned his head to the side and spat it out.

"I wonder if it flew off the Wall and landed on someone," **Candy giggled *.***

The viewers laughed.

"Kill me! If you're gonna execute me, just do it already!"

Two masculine voices yelled in the plaza where the soldiers were gathered.

"Fine, I'll do it!"

Pixis stood at the edge of the Wall and cleared his throat. "ATTENTION!" His voice carried out below, quieting the crowd. "I will now explain to you the details of the Trost Recovery Operation! The objective of this operation is to seal the hole in the demolished gate!"

The soldiers stood in stunned silence.

"Huh?" Macro stared. "Seal it? How?"

"As for how we'll accomplish this, let me start by introducing this fellow! This is Eren Yeager, a member of the Trainee Corps!" At Pixis's words, the teen stepped forward and saluted.

Jean gaped at him, Ymir, Christa, and Connie staring with wide eyes nearby. "E-Eren?!" Connie stuttered.

Eren grinned smugly at the looks on their faces.

"He is the successful result of our top-secret Titan transformation experiments! He is able to fabricate a Titan's body and control it at will!"

"Umh." Connie straightened. "The commander isn't making much sense, or am I just stupid?"

"You're not* stupid. *Maybe just a few fries short of a Happy Meal?"

"Did she insult me?" Connie scratched his head. "I think she just insulted me."

"Just shut up for a minute, stupid," Ymir said.

An image of a massive rock surrounded by short houses appeared. "In Titan form, he will lift that giant rock near the front gate, carry it to the wrecked gate, and seal the hole!" The Rogue Titan was carrying the monstrous boulder.

Sasha whistled, wide-eyed and impressed.

"As for you," the Garrison commander continued, "you're to defend him from the other Titans while he carries the rock!"

"There's no need to fight the Titans?" Behind Pixis and Eren, standing on the other end of the Wall were Armin and Mikasa along with Anka and Gustav, two Garrison soldiers.

"I-I'm sorry!" Armin stood before the map. "I didn't mean to interrupt! I know I'm just a trainee."

"That's okay. Continue."

"Right. Normally, Titans respond to large groups of people by pursuing them. So if we were to use a large group to lure them to the edge of the Wall, I believe we could draw the Titans away from Eren without having to fight."

A visual appeared of several red Titan figures walking toward one edge of the Wall, toward blue humans shapes, while a small group of humans ran around the Wall to get behind the Titans to where the giant boulder was.

"Additionally, once these Titans have been lured away, we could take them out with cannons without incurring any casualties. However, we can't afford to leave Eren defenseless, so a small squad of elite soldiers would need to go and protect him." Armin pointed to the map while everyone listened keenly. "Plus, there's no avoiding any Titans that come through the hole. The elite squad will need to be able to handle them."

"It's amazing how quickly you came up with such a great plan!"

"Thanks, Christa."

"Alright, then. We'll rethink the plan around that," Gustav said.

"However, this is all based on the assumption that Eren can pick up the rock and seal the hole. I must admit I have my doubts about carrying out this plan with so little assurance to go on."

"Indeed, I have misgivings about sending so many people to their deaths based entirely on one big 'if,' but I understand Commander Pixis' assessment too," Gustav admitted.

"Yes," Anka said, "one of the issues is time. As we speak, Titans continue to pour into the town. The more filled the town gets, the worse our chances of successfully retaking it become."

"And the chances of them breaking through Wall Rose go up, too."

"And there's one other issue..." Anka began. Gustav and Armin turned to her in surprise. "People can only be driven by fear for so long."

"He's going to pick up that humongous rock? Is that really possible? Has humankind finally surmounted the Titans?"

"You're lying!" Daz screamed suddenly. "I refuse to give my life for this ridiculous bullshit!"

"I'm getting real sick of this shit-head," Levi scowled. *He should've known what he was getting into when he signed up for the military.*

"What do you take us for?!" Daz clenched his hands, his body shaking. "We're not disposable blades, you know!" Nearby, Sasha stared at her feet, trembling slightly.

"He says he's a human weapon!"

"He's obviously just lying!"

"Treatin' us like fools!"

"It is a pretty terrible lie,"* Candy snorted *. "Except for the 3D gear, there really isn't even the most basic technology. I mean, you don't even have light bulbs much less genetic engineering."

So something like that is possible. Or used to be, at one point . Hange thought longingly, trying to imagine all the amazing technology.

"Though the government is very shady and hiding some massive secrets so I guess it's not that far-fetched..."

"We know one of them to be the lie about us being last of humanity," Armin said. "What else could they be hiding?"

Erwin's face darkened.

"They're gonna make us die here today! I'm outta here!" The man turned and walked away. The two women nodded at each other and followed him.

"M-me too!"

"Me too!"

"Count me out, too!"

"Wait!" The staff officer grabbed Daz. "Don't make me execute you!"

"I'm going to spend humanity's final moments with my family!"

"This isn't good," Ian said to Rico.

"Indeed. We'll lose all order if we don't do something," she replied.

Near them, Weilman looked around crazily. "Prepare yourselves, filthy traitors!" He pulled out his sword. "I'll cut you down where you stand!"

"He's outnumbered," Petra observed, "if he attacks, it's gonna start a riot and countless will die."

Levi sneered. "I'm surprised he didn't try to sneak away with them."

"Yeah," Eren said.

"By my order, all who leave now are absolved of their crime!" Pixis said, making Weilman gape with an open mouth. "Those who've succumbed to the Titans' terror once before can never face them again! Anyone who has already experienced their horror may leave! And, those who want their family and loved ones to experience that same horror may leave as well!"

The man stopped walking. *"Daddy!"* The image of his daughter in the hands of a Titan stopped him. "I can't let that happen. My daughter…she's all I have." He turned and walked back, along with the others.

Hange grinned. "Nicely done, Commander."

***"* Let's think back four years ago! Namely, the operation to retake Wall Maria! I'm sure none of this needs saying! Calling it a 'recovery operation' gave it a nice ring, but it was essentially a way to dispose of the unemployed masses that the government couldn't support!"**

Armin's fists clenched.

"The reason no one has spoken out about it is because sending them outside is what has allowed us to survive inside these

cramped Walls!" Pixis' voice narrated while little Armin stared at his grandfather's hat with tears running down his face. "All of humanity—myself included—is guilty! Conflict never arose simply because Wall Maria's citizens were in the minority!"

A headshot of the three Walls appeared.

"But what about now?! If Wall Rose falls, humanity will lose much more than 20% of its population! Wall Sina wouldn't be able to support even half of the people still alive! If we humans go extinct, it won't be because we were eaten by Titans!"

Images of soldiers harassing civilians appeared. It was followed by a priest praying at a young woman tied to a large wooden headstone, standing in a big barrel. She had a blindfold covering her eyes, hands held up in a prayer. A hooded man stood near, torch in hand.

"Wow, what's this? Sacrifice?"* Candy wondered. *"Cannibalism? Witch trails?"

"Witch trials?" Sasha's eyed widened. "Is she saying witches are real?!"

"She was making a joke," Ymir said.

"It's why her guesses became a little more outlandish as she continued," Jean added.

"Cannibalism isn't actually all that outlandish," Hange said. "In fact —"

"We don't want to hear it," Levi interrupted, knowing she'd land on the subject of Titans and talk their ears off. Erwin seemed to agree because he continued the episode before she could speak further.

"It'll be because we killed ourselves off!"

This time the image was of soldiers and civilians fighting each other, armed with swords.

"We cannot afford to die any further inside. I kindly ask of you!" Pixis held out his arms. "Please die here!"

The soldiers on the ground stared up at him, stunned.

I don't know if I can lift that rock with my Titan ability or not. **Eren eyed the commander before staring forward.** ***But I understand what my role is.*** **Images of Mikasa and Armin, Sasha, Marco, and other soldiers flashed by.** ***Even if it's false, I have to succeed. I have to serve as everyone's hope!***

Atop the Wall, soldiers moved the cannons into place, preparing for battle.

"Looks like you're all here." Pixis addressed the three Garrison soldiers. "You have but one mission: to protect Eren Yeager and eliminate any risks that arise during the operation. It will probably be the most dangerous and difficult mission of the entire operation. It's no exaggeration to say that how you fare out there will decide the fate of all humankind."

"Commander," Rico spoke up, "may I ask a question?"

"What is it?"

"Are you really sure about this 'human weapon' of yours?"

"Quit it, Rico," Ian said.

"They might have to sacrifice themselves, she's allowed to ask," Eren said.

"You have your doubts too, don't you?" Rico asked.

"Commander," Mitabi began, "this plan is based entirely on the vague factor that is Eren Yeager. If he doesn't do as planned, many soldiers will die for nothing!"

"Troubling, indeed." The elderly man rubbed his mustache. "Are you that fond of losing to the Titans?"

That grabbed their attention.

"Personally, I hate it. I hate losing more than anything else. But, astonishingly enough, I've been on the losing side for all my life." Pixis turned to face away from them, hands behind his back. "I want to win against the Titans. I want to prevail over those oafs, no matter what it takes."

"T-The same goes for us, sir!" Rico said.

Pixis turned to them with a smile. "Then the only option is to take a gamble on him. Because what you call 'vague factor' is our one and only chance of achieving victory over the Titans."

The cannons were in place. "Sir, it's time for the decoy operation to begin."

"Mm." The Garrison commander turned fully to address the three soldiers. "Ian Dietrich. Rico Brzenska. Mitabi Jarnach. You are the very best of the best of the Garrison Regiment. The fate of humanity is in your hands."

"Sir!" The trio saluted.

"Ian, you'll lead the squad. I leave all on-site decision-making to you."

"Huh? Me, sir?"

"I have no objections," Rico said.

"Neither do I," Mitabi agreed.

"But, sir, with my ability…"

"Never fear. You have an understanding of alcohol. You can distinguish high-quality liquor from the cheap. So I leave it to you."

"Yes, sir!"

"He's kidding, right?" Connie pointed, looking at the others for confirmation.

Christa's brow furrowed. "You can't really pick someone to take the lead in a battle based on that. It's some metaphor, right?"

"With Pixis," Erwin said, "you can't really know."

Eren was watching his future escorts when Armin called his name. "Eren, I'm sorry. I didn't mean to force all the responsibility onto your shoulders like this."

"I told you before, remember? You have the ability to make the right call. I have faith in that."

"Eren," Mikasa said, "I really think I should—"

"Don't even think of coming with me," he shot her down before she could even begin. She seemed to be hurt by his rejection.

"I get you're worried about him and all, but you're not Siamese twins, you can't be attached at the hip all the time. That's just not healthy."

"See!" Eren smiled triumphantly. "Even Candy agrees!"

"Sigh-ah-meez, twins." Hange sounded it out and wrote it down. "I think I've heard of this condition..." She muttered to herself.

"You got eaten by a Titan last time!" Mikasa argued.

"And yet I'm still here!"

"Guys, don't fight." Armin sighed.

Eren didn't want to say something in anger he would later regret and Mikasa didn't want to push him away by antagonizing him further, so they both sat stiffly and quietly.

"They assigned you to the decoy squad."

"But…I can't leave you all alone!" Mikasa stepped forward. "It'll happen again if—"

"Enough, already!" Eren stepped in front of her, angry. "I told you before! I'm not your little brother or a kid!" Mikasa's face fell.

"Ackerman." Ian grabbed her attention. "Join the elite squad that'll protect Yeager." Her eyes lit up. "We'll need your skills. Let's go. It's time to begin!"

Mikasa fiddled with her scarf. Eren hadn't cared she was to come along now. Because those were the orders. It wasn't her presence he was opposed to. He didn't mind having her along if she didn't try to force herself to be everywhere he went.

See you, Armin. Don't die. **Eren ran, Mikasa by his side.**

Mm **. Armin looked back.** ***You too, Eren.***

"True friendship, right there," **Candy declared.**

The two boys grinned at each other.

Eren, Mikasa, and the Garrison elites ran on the Wall. "He called you a top-secret human weapon," Ian said, "but as long as you can seal that hole, I don't care!" The sun shone, hovering at the

edge of the Wall's rim. "We'll protect you at all costs! We're counting on you!"

"Right!"

"Eren, are you all right?" Mikasa asked.

"Yeah!"

Rico observed them.

"Eren—"

"Seriously, I'm fine!" Eren insisted. "I'm much better than when we were cornered earlier!"

Rico ran in between them. "Quit playing house, Yeager!"

"I didn't mean to…"

" *Oo-ooh.* " Connie grinned.

"Is that why you're always telling her not to see you as her brother?" Ymir said pointedly and their friends snickered.

Eren opened his mouth.

"Don't," Armin advised. "You'll only add fuel to the fire."

"I can't believe the fate of humanity rests in the hands of a spoiled brat like you…" Mitabi said and Mikasa frowned at him.

"That's enough, all of you!" Ian ordered. "We're almost to the route to the rock."

The massive rock sat alone.

"I don't see any Titans in the area," Ian said. "Their decoy tactic must be working."

On the other side, a large mass of soldiers had gathered together and cannons being fired was heard.

"Listen up! All we have to do is lure them into the corner of town!"

Titans were pressed up against the Wall, hands raised up to reach for the soldiers hanging in place, including Armin and Marco.

"Avoid any unnecessary fighting!"

What a simple yet effective plan he was able to come with on the spot . Erwin thought. *And it saved countless lives.*

"Just so you're aware, Yeager." Rico's voice grabbed his attention. "More than just a few soldiers will likely die during this operation. All for you."

Eren listened carefully.

"Our colleagues, our seniors, and our juniors. They're prepared to die, of course. They're soldiers. But, they aren't faceless pawns."

A fat, 15-meter approached a group on the rooftops. Sasha and Daz were among them.

"Steady!" The squad leader ordered. "Not yet!" The Titan's footsteps created a loud, booming sound every time they connected with the ground. "Almost!" The Titan stretched its hand toward them. "Breakaway!" They flew off in different directions.

"They have names, families, and hopes and dreams of their own. Alysha, Dominic, Fine, Isabel, Ludwig, Martina, Guido, Hans, they're all real people, flesh and blood. Some have been living under the same roof since their trainee days. And many of these people could end up dying for you today."

"I like her," Petra said. "I think she graduated the same year I did."

"Rico's awesome," Eren said.

Jean, Connie, Annie, and others watched the gate from the rooftops.

"Keep that in mind, you have a responsibility to not let their sacrifices be in vain. No matter what happens. Carve that reality into your naive heart. And fulfill your duty with your life."

"I will!" Eren promised. *I'm gonna do this! I absolutely will succeed!*

"Not once has humanity ever achieved victory over the Titans since they first appeared!" Pixis addressing the crowds came back to Eren.

The Garrison flag flew in the wind.

"For every inch the Titans have moved forward, humanity has continually been forced to draw back and give up its territory! However, should this operation succeed, humanity will have taken back land from the Titans for the very first time!"

"This is the spot!"

"Let's go!"

"That will be the first time humankind has achieved victory over the Titans!" The Garrison commander's voice narrated.

***"Despite it being the Survey Corps' mission to fight Titans and regain territory, the first victory against the Titans actually went to the Garrisons,"* Candy said in amusement.**

Hange's head snapped up. "Hey, we helped!"

"Well it *was* the Garrisons that did all the legwork." Ymir folded her arms, one finger tapping her chin. "Protecting Eren and keeping the Titans away."

"And Eren did the heavy lifting," Christa added.

Petra chuckled. "I guess we were late to the party."

"It shouldn't matter which branch was responsible for humanity's first victory," Erwin said wisely. "...Though I must admit I do find myself a little disappointed it wasn't us," he admitted, smiling sheepishly.

Hange groaned. "I'm never gonna be able to forget this!"

Levi shrugged. "It wasn't the Military Police so I don't care."

Everyone except Rico jumped off and switched to 3D gear. She covered one ear with her hand and the other with her bicep, right arm raised. She fired the flare gun.

"Green smoke confirmed," Anka looked through the scope. "Elite Squad has commenced operation!"

"Indeed, it may seem extraordinarily small when compared to what humanity has given up this far!" The group flew toward the boulder while the narration continued. "However! For humankind, that single, small step will be a great leap forward!"

Eren, face twisted in concentration and determination, bit his hand.

The viewers leaned forward, eager.

Lightning exploded.

On the Wall, Pixis, Anka, and the rest of the soldiers watched with open mouths, sounding shocked.

The group smiled, enjoying their shock.

The Rogue Titan crashed to the ground.

The elite team observed from the rooftops as the 15-meter threw its head back and roared.

From a human's standpoint, it's unthinkable to pick up that rock. **Mikasa thought.** ***But I'm sure Eren has the great strength to lead us forward.***

Even though he knew he was being stupid thinking Mikasa might see him as a weakling that she had to coddle all the time, hearing those thoughts made Eren grin. It dropped immediately when he realized what was coming next. A tense, anxious expression took over.

Mikasa then noticed it. The Rogue Titan was staring at the boulder, body still steaming. He turned. ***Eren?*** **She blinked.**

Mikasa gasped.

Half a second later, the Rogue Titan threw his fist forward, destroying the roof and sending dust flying.

Eren's fists were clenched and pale and trembling. Hearing it was one thing. Seeing it happen was another.

"Don't worry about it." Mikasa touched his arm.

"You weren't in control." Armin put a hand on the boy's shoulder. "It wasn't you that threw the punch."

His fists opened, palms pale, red crescent shapes indented into the skin. Eren released a breath. "Let's just move on," he said with a frown.

Please Review~

Episode - Wound

Chapter 12: Wound

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Hange figures out there is civilization outside the walls, shocking everyone. The group doesn't believe they're friendly.

"Over ten episodes have passed and you're an idiot if you haven't figured it out already, it all started year 845, when the Colossal Douchebag appeared along with the Armored Asshole and destroyed Wall Maria, wiping out a fifth of humanity."

"I think Candy's as annoyed narrating this part as we are hearing it," Petra giggled.

"Don't know why she doesn't just skip it," Jean said.

"I've been binging for hours, fool. You really think I need to hear it every twenty or so minutes? Who writes this crap?"

I'd assume you did . Christa thought, confused.

"Anyway, let me recap it my way really quick," Candy cleared her throat. "Shit happened, people died, Eren got eaten, and Armin cried."

Jean snorted.

"Then Eren flew into a rage, and transformed into a Titan, that took up an entire manga page…and now he has to seal the

wall? Hm, gotta work on that."

"The change in rhythm me threw off for a second," Ymir said.

"It was still good," Sasha shrugged.

Groups of soldiers were gathered together on the wall at each cannon station, peering down at the sea of Titans.

"We've successfully managed to gather most of the Titans into the corner of the city," Gustav spoke, "yet, despite avoiding combat as much as possible, around 20% of our soldiers have been lost."

The injured soldiers lay on the wall, clutching their wounds.

"No," Pixis said, "they were not 'lost.' The soldiers did not die of their own accord. I ordered them to their deaths." He stopped and looked out at the destroyed city overrun by Titans, smoke rising from several places. "Humanity is now perched on the brink of extinction. If it means ensuring humankind's survival, I'm willing to go down in history as a butcher."

"Nah I'm pretty sure they'll remember you as the cold-hearted bastard that sent people to their deaths without any consideration for them. Because the end justifies the means, right? As long as humanity survived, it didn't matter how many humans died."

"What a waste," Levi muttered. "So many unnecessary deaths..."

"Humanity's not at the edge of extinction," Petra sighed.

"We didn't know that," Eren said.

"And they want us all dead," Christa's eyes were downcast as Ymir watched her quietly.

"It's pretty discouraging," Sasha's shoulders slumped.

"We'll survive," Erwin said. "As we have for the past century."

"And don't forget," Hange smiled encouragingly, "we have Candy on our side!" That cheered them up some.

Candy sighed. "Well, I'm not in your position so I can't really judge."

She's pretty down to earth for a goddess, Armin thought.

The roof exploded where the Rogue Titan's fist smashed into it and Mikasa barely moved out of the way. A small cut appeared on her cheek and she hit the side of a chimney.

Eren's jaw clenched.

Ian ran closer, wide eyes watching the Rogue Titan before turning to the girl as it pulled back its other hand. "Ackerman!"

The 15-meter Titan threw another punch and she jumped up, using the 3D gear to reach its face and grab the long dark hair to hang in place.

"Hey! Stop, Ackerman! Get away from him!"

"You should've listened to him and run the other way," Eren said quietly, upset.

"Eren! Don't you recognize me?!" She asked in desperation.

"I just wanted to help," Mikasa said. "I wanted to try to reach you—"

"I'm Mikasa!"

It glared at her.

"And what if you'd died?" Eren demanded.

"Your family! You have to seal the hole with that rock!"

"How do you think I would've felt, waking up to find out I'd killed one of my best friends?"

Rico grabbed the red flare capsule.

Mikasa fell silent. *I didn't think about it that way* .

The operation's a failure **. Rico stood, holding the gun up.** ***I knew there was no secret weapon.*** **A trail of red smoke shot up to the sky.**

"Eren! You're human!" Mikasa screamed. The Rogue Titan clenched its fist tight. "You're—"

Ian saw the Titan ready to attack. "Dodge, Ackerman!"

Mikasa jumped off half a second before the Rogue Titan brought its fist up and smashed its face with a roar.

"What an idiot," Connie snickered. Then he looked around and said sheepishly, "Sorry, I know it's a serious scene but that was funny."

"Yeah, it was!" Sasha nodded, trying to use his flow to break the uncomfortable tension.

"I knew you were a suicidal bastard, Eren, but I didn't know you were so dumb you had a habit of punching yourself in the face," Jean said haughtily.

"Next time you feel the urge, just let one of us know and we'll be happy to help a friend out," Ymir smirked.

"Ymir!" Christa scolded.

Mikasa looked over her shoulder as she flew away. The Rogue Titan stumbled and fell backward, its face and hands steaming. It sat against the boulder, legs sprawled out, head down and hands in its lap.

"What the hell?!" Mitabi demanded. "He's just a regular, dumb Titan!"

"Eren!"

"Captain Ian!" One of the soldiers called out from a nearby roof. "Two Titans approaching from ahead! A 10-meter one and a 6-meter one!"

"One 12-meter Titan is closing in from the rear!" Another voice reported and they saw its head over the buildings, slowing making its way toward Rogue.

"Ian! We have to withdraw!" Mitabi said. "There's no way that kid's sealing the hole!"

"Yeah," Rico agreed, "we have no choice but to leave him here."

Mikasa threw them a glare, teeth gritted.

"If looks could kill," Candy giggled, "they'd be a pile of ash."

Ian caught her glare and looked away.

"That's right," Candy snickered, "obey."

"Red smoke shell from the Elite Squad! It seems the mission to seal the hole has hit a serious snag." A man next to Pixis said.

"For nothing!" One soldier was kneeling on the ground, one hand covering his face, crying. "My comrades have died for nothing!"

"Hey, look over there!"

Soldiers along the wall looked out and noticed the red smoke.

"What is it?! What's wrong?!"

Armin walked closer, nervous and disbelieving.

"Did they…fail?" Marco said next to him.

How much time do you have left now? Jean wondered. *Will we watch you die next episode? The one after?* He was intent on seeing the Titan that had killed his best friend.

"How?" Armin gritted his teeth and turned away.

Marco turned as the short boy grabbed gas canisters and ran off. "Hey! Where are you going, Armin?"

"Commander Pixis, we should go back to defending the gate immediately. Just give the word, sir."

"We can't."

"Shall I order the Elite Squad to withdraw?" Anka asked.

"No need." Pixis continued to stare ahead. "Continue to lure the Titans into the corner of town. As for the Elite Squad, I've left all on-site decision-making in their hands. They're more than just skilled. They're the best of the best, with the fate of humankind on their shoulders. Admitting defeat so easily is not an option. If we don't want our fallen soldiers' deaths to be in vain then we must struggle for as long as we live."

You'll be struggling for a long time , Ymir thought. *You have so many enemies out there you don't even know about.*

"What are you doing?" Mitabi demanded. "Make the call! Ian, it isn't your fault! This whole mission was a long shot to begin with! We all understand! It was worth a shot, and we did the best that we could! So our teams are going back up the wall now!"

Mikasa gasped, then glared, readying her swords and going after him.

"Wait!" Ian blocked her. "Wait. Calm down, Ackerman," he told her. "Rico Team, take out the 12-meter one to the rear! Mitabi Team and my team will deal with the two ahead!"

He is a fine soldier. Erwin thought. *Pixis is—was—lucky to have him.*

"What?!" Rico said.

"I was the one appointed leader!" Ian snapped. "Shut up and obey."

Levi nodded in approval.

"We can't leave Yeager defenseless!"

Rico watched him with a stunned look on her face.

"Change of plans! We're to defend Yeager from the other Titans until we can recover him!" They looked at the Rogue Titan, sitting motionless against the boulder, head slumped and hands still steaming. "He holds a precious chance for humanity. We can't abandon him just like that! Because unlike us, he can't be replaced."

"You're not irreplaceable either," Christa muttered. Compared to Eren right then, maybe, but without him, and their teams, Eren wouldn't have succeeded.

"Hundreds of people have died in this mission alone for that failure of a human weapon! Yet you want to recover him and go

through this same thing all over again?!" Rico demanded.

"That's right," Ian said. "We have to keep trying, no matter how many people die!"

It's not for nothing . Petra thought. *Even if humanity still exists outside the walls, they still managed our first victory over the Titans. Many people reclaimed their homes.* It was a win, not for humanity, but for the people living behind the walls at least. Now that they knew the truth, the hole in her chest that formed from the deaths of hundreds of soldiers who had died thinking they were defending all of humankind, shrank just a little.

Jean landed on the wall in a crouch. He ran toward Marco and Connie. "What happened with Eren?"

"Armin's on his way there," Marco answered. "It'll be all right I think."

"You think?"

"I'm sure," Marco insisted. "Eren'll pull through for us!"

Jean didn't look totally convinced.

Yes, one more episode. Jean thought. The mission would probably be done by the end of the next episode. *Soon, we'll know* .

"Gathering the Titans in the corner of town seems nothing but pointless to me," Connie said.

"A fight against a Titan always turns into a battle of attrition," Jean explained. "They're probably trying to keep deaths to a minimum right now."

Connie turned and took a few steps away from them. "So you're saying all the deaths up until this point are meaningless."

To an extent, yeah . Ymir thought.

"An all-out war is inevitable. So it makes sense to minimize our losses and preserve our forces until that time comes," Jean explained. "This was the right call to make."

"Was it really, though?"

"It was!"

"Well, let's just try not to end up being 'losses.' All of us," Connie smiled tensely at them.

Marco , Connie thought sadly. He almost felt guilty for surviving sometimes. Marco had been ranked above him. Wouldn't it have made more sense for him to have survived instead? *I just got lucky, not running into the aberrant Titan that killed him* . He shivered, the strange ones freaked him out the most. *Like the one that killed Thomas* . The Titan had only taken one bite out of Marco's side and left him to bleed to death.

"Are you serious, Ian?!"

"How is humanity ever going to beat the Titans then?! Tell me, Rico! What other way do we have of putting an end to all this? How can we defeat the overwhelming might of the Titans while maintaining our humanity and not letting anyone die?"

"Eh, call the Avengers?" Candy said. "Wait, wrong fandom."

"The Avengers?" Eren said. "Sounds cool."

"I have no idea how to defeat the Titans, obviously," Rico said.

"Exactly," Ian said, "that's why we must do this now. It's our only option. We have to lay down our lives and go down bravely for this so-called human weapon we barely know anything about!" The Rogue Titan was still immobile. "It's pathetic, isn't it?" Titans wandered in through the hole. "That this is all we humans can do. So, what'll it be? This is our battle to wage. Our chance to struggle!"

All eyes were focused on him.

"I can't accept that," Rico walked away.

Petra chuckled. "I can't believe she just said that."

"It does feel a bit strange after that deep, heartfelt speech of his," Jean nodded.

"Just wait," Mikasa said.

"Rico!" Ian called after her.

"But I'll follow your plan. I think your assessment is right." She looked at him, looking none too thrilled. "I'm going to struggle with all my might and make them taste the ferocity of humanity. Because I refuse to die for nothing. My team will handle the 12-meter one to the rear."

Without a word, Mitabi walked away. "Let's go!" Ian turned at that. "We have the two in front."

"Yeah."

"Thank you, Captain Ian," Mikasa stood by his side.

"There's no need to thank me, Ackerman. I admit I was terrified since there was no telling what you might do next."

"Rightly so buddy," Connie nodded.

"Dodged a bullet there," Armin agreed.

"Now you can act freely, as originally planned." He pulled out his blades. "That should make better use of your ability."

"Yes, sir."

"This is to protect your lover, after all."

Eren, who had been taking a sip of water, choked.

"Eren!" Mikasa slapped his back a little too hard.

"You're—hurting—more," he rasped between coughs.

"I knew it!" Sasha grinned.

"Kill me now," Jean muttered.

"Is there something you guys wanna tell us?" Connie teased.

"Remember when Mikasa and Annie fought?" Christa giggled.

"Over his idiot?" Ymir snorted. "I can't see the appeal."

Eren continued to cough.

Connie and Sasha exchanged a glance and opened their mouths, ready to sing when they were interrupted.

"Brat, I order you to stop coughing, it's annoying," Levi glared. Mikasa glared back.

"Take a deep breath," Armin advised.

"Why does everyone always think that?" Eren complained.

"You make it too easy," Hange snickered.

"It's just teasing Eren, joking between friends," Petra placated him. "No one's being serious."

Erwin smiled, "Since everyone seems to have said their bit, let's move on. Frankly, I'm surprised Candy didn't say anything."

"It does sound like the kind of thing she would be all over," Hange agreed.

Mikasa blushed cutely and looked down. "He's family."

Petra and Hange giggled while Levi rolled his eyes.

No one dared make any remarks at Mikasa, seeing the deadly look on her face.

Ian took off and Mikasa turned to the Rogue Titan. *Huh? The damaged parts haven't repaired? Is it because of his earlier wounds?* An armless Rogue collapsed to the ground, Mikasa and the others watching from atop a building.

How is it affecting Eren? In fact, what guarantee is there that he can turn back to normal at all?* She worried. *No, never mind. I won't figure anything out just by thinking.* She closed her eyes. *For now, I have to do what I can do!

On the wall, Armin ran. *Eren, Mikasa, what's going on?*

The Rogue Titan sat, Eren buried in the muscle, one eye open and distant.

Huh? What…am I…doing? Am I…sitting?* Everything was pitch black. *I can't see anything. What day is today? Where am I?* Suddenly, light broke through. Grisha was sitting at the table. Eren was wrapped up in a sheet, sleepily opening his eyes. *Oh,

***I'm home* . Carla and Mikasa were drying plates, smiling at each other and talking. *Guess I'll sleep* .**

Mikasa and Eren felt nostalgia and a deep ache in their chests.

He's in some dream-like state, almost completely unaware of what's happening outside. Hange wrote. He couldn't remember what had happened when he transformed the first time either. *Is it because it's one the first few times he's transformed?* The serum didn't just hold Titan-shifting abilities but memories as well. Was it some sort of side effect? Or was it something else?

The hook un-lodged. Armin stood on a roof, breathing heavily, staring at the motionless giant. "Eren… What are you doing, Eren?"

Soldiers hung from the wall. Titans pushed against one another, arms up, trying to reach the humans.

"Listen up! We can't let any Titans leave this corner of town, no matter what! Focus on that and keep luring them! You don't need to fight them! Is that clear?"

Behind the massive horde at the wall, a few Titan were scattered here and there.

Jean, Annie, Connie, and two others listened to the Garrison soldier carefully, hiding in a small alley.

"You'll run along the ground, three cadets per team. When you reach the wall, you leap back up. Don't die out there. If somehow a Titan goes astray, we'll take it out."

"Somehow? That's a pretty likely scenario if you ask me," Jean said.

"Permission to act independently in a life-threatening situation?" Annie asked.

Candy made a disgusted noise.

"What was that?" Armin said.

It suddenly struck her. "I think maybe Candy doesn't like Annie," Ymir answered. Unlike the rest of them, she had an idea why. *Annie is one of the Titan-Shifters, a threat to the humans behind the walls, along with Bert and Reiner, that's why they weren't invited.*

But Candy had never made any indication of her dislike of the two boys. *Marco. It has to be* . She had heard Connie mumbling about it once—survivor's guilt, she guessed—and it clicked. There were abnormal Titans, however, none left humans to bleed out. Of course, it could have gotten distracted by another human and forgotten about Marco, but Ymir trusted her gut instinct.

"That's strange," Eren said.

"Is it?" Mikasa said. "I often find her unpleasant myself."

"Maybe she doesn't like the girl's face," Levi interrupted, unwilling to risk teenage love drama unfolding and wasting time. "Erwin, keep playing."

"If it'll save your life somehow, sure."

An explosion pulled their attention to the dust from the opposite side of a nearby building.

"Kirschtein Team, move out!"

"Yes, sir!"

A Titan fell and the Garrison soldier landed a roof. When the dust cleared, he gasped at the huge hand surging forward. Mikasa came down fast, slicing cleanly. A chunk of flesh flew off and the 15-meter collapsed against the building, its face inches from the soldier on the roof.

"This is bad," Ian backed up. "Behind us!"

On the roof was a Titan, it was on its hands and knees.

"How'd it get up there?" Connie yelped.

"Those fuckers better not be learning how to climb," Levi muttered.

"One 13-meter Titan! It's headed straight for Yeager!"

Mikasa tensed, ready, when another voice called out. "We have more Titans coming through the gate!" In front of the hole, four Titans walked side by side. "Four of them, around ten meters high!"

"Ackerman, take the rear!" Ian ordered.

"Roger!" She turned and ran.

"Don't let it get to Yeager!" He looked over his shoulder. "Let's hold 'em off here!"

"Understood!" Mitabi replied.

***Elite soldiers or not, two teams can't handle four Titans at once*. Mikasa thought as she ran. She jumped off the roof, hook shooting into the nape of the Titan on the building next to the Rogue Titan. Its face slammed into the roof as her blades cut through the flesh.**

The dust cleared and she stood, surveying her surroundings. *No way… Why are there so many Titans even though there are*

so few people here? Wait, could it be that Eren is drawing them in?

"Hm, interesting," Hange muttered. When Eren had first transformed, he had approached other Titans and roared. And it seemed to have triggered something in them and made them respond to the challenge. She had never seen that happen before.

Titans were stupid and would often bump into each other in enclosed spaces, and the bigger Titans would sometimes step on the smaller ones, yet neither party would care much. *But it's different with Eren* . Was that the case with all the shifters? The Colossal and the Armored? Hange tried to get everything down as fast as the ideas appeared in her head.

"Mikasa!" Armin yelled, standing on the Rogue Titan's shoulder. "What happened to the plan?!"

"Went down the toilet like…all the other plans. Huh," Candy said thoughtfully. "The plans are brilliant but you're missing contingencies. When plan A fails, what're B and C?"

"I think they're amazing," Eren said stubbornly.

"She's not being mean, Eren," Armin explained. "And she has a point."

"Yes," Erwin frowned. He had a feeling it was aimed at the plan to flush out the traitor.

"Armin?!"

"What's happened to Eren?!"

"Get away! It's dangerous there! Eren isn't controlling that Titan! I called out to him, but he wouldn't respond! There's no getting through to him anymore!"

Armin's plans were made on the fly, there wasn't really proper time for secondary measures. Erwin's mind continued to race, only half paying attention to the TV.

"And the plan?!"

"It's failed!"

A troubling thought came to the commander. *Candy said 'when' not 'if.'* They were about two weeks away from the 57th expedition. Was it that plan she was hinting at?

"We're fighting because we can't leave Eren behind! But there are too many Titans," Mikasa looked almost panicked. "At this rate, we'll eventually be wiped out!"

Erwin was about to make a quiet suggestion for Hange to write that down as well but it appeared she had also picked up on it. He was going to have to rethink the entire plan now. A hopeful feeling surged in his chest. *Or maybe not. Maybe—no, definitely—Candy will show us the 57th expedition* . There were 13 episodes remaining. It would be a piece of cake figuring everything out afterward. *She might even reveal the traitor* .

Armin gritted his teeth and looked over his shoulder. He recalled Eren emerging from the Titan body the first time. Armin turned. "From the back of the head to the nape… One meter high and ten centimeters across…" He pulled out one sword.

"Armin!"

"I'll get Eren out of here! You just protect us from the other Titans!"

"Huh? What are you…?"

Armin walked to the middle of the nape. "Eren came out of the Titans' vital spot. My guess is that it has something to do with

the true nature of the Titans." He shot the two hooks into the 15-meter's shoulder blades. "It's okay." He gripped the sword with both hands and raised it. "As long as I miss the center he won't die. It'll just hurt a little bit!" He dug the sword deep into the Titan's nape.

"Armin!" Mikasa screamed in panic.

Brilliant . Erwin was completely in awe. *He has one of the most brilliant minds I've ever seen* . The boy had his short-comings but when the stakes were high, he never failed to come through. *What an impressive kid* .

At once, the Rogue Titan reanimated, roaring loudly and thrashing madly. Armin held on tight.

"Stop, Armin! That's too reckless!"

"Mikasa, just go do what you can! There are lives you can help save! Leave Eren to me and go!"

She gritted her teeth and ran away.

Looks like she's learned from her past mistakes . Levi thought.

"Eren! Can you hear me?" Armin's voice sounded distant to the boy inside the titanic body. "Pull yourself together! We're all going to die if you don't come out of there! Don't give in to the Titan's body! Now just hurry and get out of this meatsack!" The 15-meter was still, head bowed.

That is a huge-ass tongue, gross! Connie wrinkled his nose.

"Get out of here? Why? I'm sleepy now," Eren spoke softly.

"Eren! Come out! Hurry, Eren! Eren!" Armin breathed heavily. He slammed his fist on the flesh. "What happened to avenging your mom? You were gonna exterminate all the Titans, remember? You hate them for killing your mom, remember?"

"What are you talking about, Armin?" Eren looked at his best friend, banging on the window next to his head in his dream-like state, eyes looking sleep. He looked over to his mother and little Mikasa. "My mom's right here."

"Eren! Eren! Wake up, Eren! You're in there, aren't you?! Eren! If we stay here, the Titans will kill us! It'll all end here!"

"I'm telling you, I have no idea what you're saying, Armin." Eren turned to his family, ignoring the banging. "Why would I want to leave?" Then he blinked, awareness creeping into his expression. "Why would I want to join the Scouts?" Carla turned, looking sadly at him.

I'm sorry, mom, for everything. Eren thought sadly. *You were only trying to protect your idiot son* .

A 15-meter Titan picked up the Garrison soldier who had given Jean's team orders and brought him to its mouth. Jean watched over his shoulder, teeth gritted as he ran.

"Looks like we have no choice but to think on our feet," Annie said, running beside Connie with Jean right behind them, three Titans of various sizes on their tails.

Mikasa ran along the rooftops. A scream caught her attention. Ian rushed on and attacked the Titan that was about to eat the captured human. "You're mine!" Blood spurted out as it went slack, collapsing on the roof.

"About time you kicked the bucket, bastard!" Mitabi screamed at the Titan as Ian joined him.

Another Titan reached up, it raised its hand high and brought it down, Mitabi and Ian dodging a second earlier. "Withdraw for a

bit!" Ian ordered.

"Ackerman, reporting back!" Mikasa said. "Joining Mitabi Team!" She used the momentum from the run and jumped high, blades raised.

Connie jumped up, dodging the Titan's swipe, shooting a hook. It failed to lodge in the wall and bounced off with a soft *clink* . "What?" The Titan knelt behind him to grab him. A hook shot past its hand, cutting it and drawing the Titan's attention to the soldier behind it.

"Jean!" Connie yelled.

"Get going!" Jean turned and ran, the ground where he had been standing exploding as the Titan slammed its hand down. *No one's dying on my watch anymore!*

"Damn it Horse-Face, you're making it kinda hard to see you as lame and a coward anymore," Eren complained.

Jean, for his part, was too surprised by the words to reply.

The Titan was confused by why it couldn't move anymore, hand stuck in the ground. Jean smirked. He clicked the triggers, but nothing happened. He looked down at his damaged gear. "Damn! It's failing me now?" A fat Titan appeared behind him, its shadow falling over the teen. He quickly jumped out of the way as it attacked.

Annie and Connie reached the wall and looked over. "Jean!" He yelled, scanning the area nearby, noticing Jean running away from the Titan. "What's going on? Why isn't he using his 3D gear?" Connie gasped. "Don't tell me…it's malfunctioning?"

Jean continued to run. "I'll manage somehow!" He yelled, turning a corner. He gasped for air, sitting against the wall in an abandoned house, half eaten food still on the dining table.

"Damn, how can I afford to be dead weight?" He looked out the window, seeing the Titan at the mouth of the street. He looked down the street, eyes locking in on a soldier's body crushed beneath a large piece of rock. More importantly, the 3D gear.

A plan quickly formed in his mind. "Will this really work out somehow?"

"If it was me I'd hide there until nightfall before grabbing the gear and making for the wall," Connie said.

"How would you use the gear in the dark, genius?" Ymir scoffed.

"Well, obviously I'd wait until sunrise in a building near the wall and go before the Titans showed up."

"You could've waited for the Titan to leave the area," Eren said. "Or at least until it turned the corner so it couldn't see you if it looked back."

"What if it stepped on the gear?" Jean said defensively. "Or what if another Titan showed up?"

"Eren…" Armin said. "Eren…"

Ian gripped his sword, a creepily grinning Titan on the roof of the building behind him.

"Eren…"

Mikasa ran.

"Eren, we're supposed to explore the outside world someday, remember?" Armin said, standing outside the window. Recognition filled the boy's green eyes. "Far beyond these walls, there stretch fiery waters, lands of ice…"

The Arctic appeared with the Northern Lights.

"Aurora Borealis, the Northern Lights," Candy said.

Several gasps came from around the room. Erwin hastily paused the episode.

"Look at that," Petra said in wonder. "It's completely made of snow and ice."

"The lights are so beautiful," Mikasa said. "They look magical!"

"I can't believe it's real," Jean gaped.

"Wait until I finish drawing!" Hange told Erwin.

"The sky looks so big, too," Connie said.

"Do you think we can ever see that ourselves?" Christa wondered.

"Looks fucking freezing," Levi tried and failed to keep the awe out of his voice.

"Okay, you're good," Hange nodded a few seconds after she'd finished her quick sketch.

"…and sandy snowfields spread wide."

A huge sun shone brightly over the horizon, a few clouds in the otherwise wide blue sky over fields of sand.

"A desert," Candy said. "Scorching sun, sand dunes, oasis, and surprisingly cold nights. And cactus juice," Candy snickered. "Stay away from the cactus juice, kids. Side effects may include and are not limited to stupidity, doing the worm, dopiness, making bad decisions, and hallucinations of people on fire."

"I wanna try cactus juice," Hange declared.

"Me too!" Connie agreed.

"I don't think you need any help being stupid," Jean snickered.

Levi wrinkled his nose. "What's the matter, captain?" Petra said. "Don't like all the sand?"

"It'll get everywhere," he twitched. It'd be a nightmare.

"I wonder what kind of yummy animals they have," Sasha drooled a little, thinking about the different meats.

"Quite a few," Ymir said. And then quickly corrected. "Or not. Doesn't seem like the kind of place where much animal life would thrive."

"There could specific animals that only live there," Armin said. Ymir nodded, pretending to realize his words made sense.

"The world my mom and dad planned to venture into." An image of the sun reflecting in the water on a cloudy, rainy day appeared. The view was somewhat limited as the shot appeared through plants, a grasshopper sitting on one leaf.

"That must be the ocean!" Eren said excitedly as more gasps came from around the room.

"There's water as far as the eye can see," Erwin said in amazement.

"And it's supposed to be full of salt," Armin added happily. "So you can never run out!"

An image of dewdrops on a leaf appeared, followed by Armin's grandpa's book. "I figured you'd just forgotten, but you actually stopped talking about it because you didn't want me to join the Survey Corps, right?"

"The outside…world?" Eren's eyes were full of emotion. He stood up, blanket dropping.

"Eren, answer me. Even though just one step outside the walls lies a hellish world. And even though it might mean dying a gruesome death like my parents."

"There might be a certain gun-slinging, cowboy wannabe involved there. Three other people in the room share a connection to him as well."

"What?" Armin said. "What does that mean?" Candy didn't elaborate.

"Why did you want to venture into the outside world?"

"Why?" Eren turned. "Isn't that obvious? Because I was born in this world!" Flames erupted around him and his family disappeared.

The Rogue Titan let out a soft growl.

"Anyone else feeling super pumped right now?" Connie grinned.

"Me!" Christa's eyes were lit with wonder.

"And me," Erwin laughed, a happy, genuine laugh full of delight.

Hange let out a loud exhale, hand throbbing. "Done!"

"It all really exists!" Sasha said in excitement.

"I feel like charging out there right now," Mikasa admitted.

"Hells yeah!" Eren grinned.

"Count me in!" Armin nodded.

"I wonder what other beautiful wonders the world holds," Christa smiled.

"And dangers," Levi had to add. He was ignored in favor of the positive atmosphere.

"I bet it'd be great to take a dip in the ocean on a hot sunny day," Jean said dreamily. He hated the heat.

"Ooh, that sounds amazing!" Petra clapped.

"Who knows what kind of crap is in there?" Levi said.

"Jean that is probably the best idea you've ever had," Eren declared.

"Then we should all pack a change of clothes when we go," Ymir said.

"That's right!" Hange agreed. "Then we can play all day!"

"Sounds like a plan," Erwin said.

"And it's official!" Connie threw his hands in the air.

Anyone else wanna see Levi and Connie on cactus juice? They'd be the funniest :D

Please Review~

Episode - Primitive Desire

Chapter 13: Primitive Desire

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Erwin worries about the 57th expedition. The group is excited and awed to see some of the wonders of the outside world on TV. They make plans to have fun when they see the ocean.

"Damn," Jean breathed heavily. "How can I afford to be dead weight?" He looked out the window, seeing the ugly Titan coming down the street, eyes then going to the dead soldier's gear. "Will this really work out somehow?"

Elsewhere, Rico skidded back on a roof, in a crouch. One of her subordinates landed next to her. "We can't go on, Squad Leader!" The young woman said. Before them, a Titan with a big nose was chewing on one of their comrades. "We're the only ones left now!"

Rico gritted her teeth and yelled at her, "Let's fall back to the rock for now!"

"We're almost there," Armin grinned, filling everyone up with anticipation.

Ian and Mikasa joined the other Garrisons near the hole in the Wall. Several Titans were walking through it. "Situation report!"

"Five Titans coming from the gate!"

Jean dashed out of the house and toward the crushed soldier. "As if I'm gonna wait until the Titans are gone!"

"Why not?" Eren snorted. "My plan was better."

"To be fair, it's not like you would've waited for the Titan to leave before charging out there," Petra pointed out, making the boy pout at her while the others chuckled and agreed.

"Jean!" Connie screamed from the Wall. "So it really was his gear," he watched the teen fiddle with the gear on the ground, Annie silent next to him.

"What's going on?" Marco approached them.

"Damn it, what the hell?" Jean struggled with the belt.

"Maybe try unclipping the belt next time," Ymir said helpfully.

"It was stuck!"

"You're kidding me!" Jean screamed, continuing to struggle. A shadow fell on him as the Titan was almost upon him.

"Jean, stay calm!" Marco flew in front of the Titan.

"Marco! What are you doing?!"

He landed on the ground and took off. The Titan glared at Marco and followed. Jean turned back to the gear and finally pulled it off the body. Connie flew toward him. "Man, don't go causin' trouble for us!" He landed on the roof, Annie running almost parallel to him.

A few buildings toward their left, Jean took to the sky. He grunted as a Titan grabbed one of the wires. Deploying the gas, Jean landed awkwardly on the ground. "Why is the trigger so stiff?" He lay, eyeing the handle in his hand. Footsteps sounded behind him. The Titan approached him.

"Jean!" Connie jumped off the building, heading for the ugly giant. "Ow!" He smacked into its face and flew away.

"What the hell was that?" Ymir laughed the loudest out of the entire group.

Jean gaped from the ground.

"That was utterly graceless, Springer," Levi snorted.

"You must have a very thick skull, the Titan was clutching its face," Hange snickered.

"Shut up," Connie said under his breath, arms folded.

"What was that?!" Jean demanded.

"Same to you!" Connie rubbed his head. "Now get outta there!" He dodged a second later, the Titan's hand slapping where he had been crouching.

Jean got up and ran. He took off just as the Titan dove after him.

"That was so close!" Christa flinched. The Titan's fingers had missed the boy by inches.

Jean glanced at the Titan for a second before looking ahead. He gasped.

Several sounds of surprise and curses rang around the room.

A closeup shot of an upside-down creepily smiling Titan filled the entire screen.

A few mouths fell open in horror as Jean headed straight towards the Titan's gaping maw.

Annie's face then filled up the screen. She landed on the Titan's chin, forcing its mouth shut.

Candy muttered something along the lines of 'still don't like you.'

Jean safely passed behind her.

"Holy shit!" Hange screamed. "Did you all see that? I've never seen a Titan try to eat a human upside down and backwards before!"

The Titan crashed to the ground and Jean flew away, skidding on buildings once or twice, the three following behind him. He landed with a roll, Marco, Connie, and Annie joining him in.

Why does Candy have a problem with Annie? Jean wondered. She had claimed him to be his favorite yet hated Annie who had just saved him. He had a strange feeling in his gut.

"You guys are all insane!" Jean said.

"No, you are!" Connie yelled back. "Can't believe we made it!"

Annie looked to the side and gasped, "Look!" Jean followed her gaze, eyes widening.

Thunderous footstep boomed.

Many soldiers including Rico, Mitabi, Mikasa, and Ian turned to the source.

Hange screamed, excited to be able to see Eren close the hole.

A gargantuan boulder appeared over the rooftops. The music picked up. Mikasa gasped. Massive feet fractured the earth with every step. The Rogue Titan moved, one foot in front of the other, steam shooting out around him and eyes glowing green.

"Oh wow," Christa gasped.

"Eren," Mikasa smiled, eyes shining brightly.

"You're like the Titan Atlas," Candy said.

"Wait, what?!" Hange demanded.

"Could she be talking about other Titan Shifter?" Erwin wondered. "Hange, are you ready?"

"Yes!"

"I believe the deities from mythology are the namesakes."

"Oh, I see," Armin said. "Humans christened them Titans based on the beings from their stories."

"And Eren reminded Candy of one named Atlas," Petra said. "I wonder how so?" Was it his looks? Or the pose he had?

"Mikasa!" Armin landed a few feet from her and Ian.

"Armin!"

"Eren's in control! He's trying to fulfill his responsibility now!" Armin said. The Rogue Titan moved slowly but steadily. "Now if we just cover him until he reaches the gate victory will be ours!"

The viewers began to brim with excitement.

Ian stared in steely determination. "Defend him!" The soldiers snapped out of their stupor. "Even if it costs us our lives we must let Eren reach the gate!" The Rogue Titan was almost there. Several Titans were walking toward it.

"Do not let them stop him!" Jean ordered his team. "We gotta give Eren backup!" He jumped off.

"You two head to Eren!" Ian said. "That's an order! Understand?!"

"Yes, sir!" Mikasa and Armin replied in unison.

Ian began to run, then stopped at the sight behind the approaching Titans. "Mitabi team… What are they doing?!"

"The Titans are ignoring us now!" Mitabi said. "Our only choice is to get close enough to grab their attention!"

"Look this way, damn it! Or else we'll shove our blades up your smelly asses and kill you!"

"Relative of yours, Connie?" Jean chuckled.

The Titans stopped.

"Hey, Reiner said that, not me!"

They looked over their shoulders and glared at the humans.

"Here they come!"

"We got two of 'em!"

"Hurry! Run for the buildings!" Mitabi yelled.

"No way…" Armin said. "Setting foot down there is suicide! And they have no way to fight without horses or buildings!"

"No, we have…no other choice now." Ian swung down. The other Garrison soldiers followed immediately. "Follow Mitabi Team!"

It was suicide, they knew, and they still did it. Eren thought. Hearing about it and seeing it were two different things. *They gave up their lives for me, for humanity* . The mission had been a success, but he still had a lot of work to do.

"Armin, we need to go, too," Mikasa said.

A Titan swatted at Ian, on its hands and knees. "This way! Come get me!" The Titan stood up and followed, getting out of the Rogue Titan's way.

My body…feels like it's about to be crushed **. The right side of Rogue's face was pressed firmly into its shoulder from the weight of the boulder.**

Even with his size and strength, carrying that boulder wasn't a picnic. Petra thought. Every step carrying that massive burden on his shoulders had been extremely difficult and painful.

Mikasa, Armin, what are you doing? **Eren thought. The two ran ahead of him.** ***If you walk down there…***

"C'mon! Hurry up, you blockhead!" The soldier ran off and the Titan chased it, ignoring Rogue. "Come get me!" He had barely covered a few feet before a hand snatched him from the side.

The bald Titan brought the screaming man toward its mouth and Mitabi stopped. "H-Hey!"

Almost immediately, a hand slammed down on him.

"Mitabi!"

"Fuck!" Eren cursed.

Majority of the Titans were distracted, leaving a clear path for the 15-meter carrying the boulder.

Candy whistled. "Look at those delicious abs!"

Most of the girls in the room giggled.

Why did you want to venture into the outside world? **Armin stood at the window, voice distant and dreamy.**

A closeup of the Rogue Titan's eye appeared, clear and focused. *From the moment we're born, we're all free.*

A Titan had a young, screaming woman between its hands.

Some might try to deny that, but it doesn't matter how strong they are!* Eren recalled confronting one of Mikasa's attackers, makeshift spear in hand. He remembered sitting with Armin, pouring over the boy's grandfather's book. *There doesn't need to be flaming waters or lands of ice. Or whatever else!

Little Eren was staring at his best friend, in awe of it all. *Whoever gets to see those things will have the greatest freedom this world has to offer!*

Fight!* Ian ran, gaze shifting to the side to see one of his subordinates be captured. *If anything is worth giving your life, it's that!

It doesn't matter how terrifying the world may be!* Mikasa and Armin ran ahead of the 15-meter, watching Ian pull the man out and throw him away from the Titan's maw. *It doesn't matter how cruel the world may be!* The Titan pushed Ian into its mouth and Mikasa's eyes widened. *Fight!

***Fight!* Mikasa noticed Jean dodging a Titan. Connie ran past its feet. *Fight!* Marco looked over his shoulder.**

"There's still a Titan ahead!" Armin said. It was standing directly before the hole.

"I'll handle this!" Mikasa said.

"Out of the way!" Rico dove in and cut one of its eyes.

The two on the ground jumped away from its clumsy attack. Mikasa ran behind it and slid on her legs, shooting the hooks, using them and the gas to propel herself up. She let out a battle

cry, blades easily sliding through the flesh of its nape. The Titan fell to the side, Eren's path now cleared.

I've never seen a maneuver like that . Petra thought in awe. When they left the room, she was gonna drag the girl to the training ground for a few hours.

The Rogue Titan was almost upon the shinning hole.

Tears were in Armin's eyes. "Go for it, Eren!"

At the same time, the Rogue Titan roared, slamming the boulder in place. Dust flew and cracks appeared in the Wall from the tremendous force.

Armin, Mikasa, and Jean watched with stunned expressions, mouths open.

Loud cheers broke around the room.

Rico fell to the ground, crying. "Everyone…your deaths weren't in vain." She held up the gun and fired. "Today, for the first time in history, humanity has beaten the Titans!"

"VICTORY!" Connie jumped to his feet, hands in the air and a wide grin on his face.

"Yellow smoke shell spotted!" Anka said. "It seems the operation was a success!" The soldiers around her were shocked and awed.

Hange joined Connie in dancing in front of the TV.

"Send in additional reinforcements!" Pixis ordered. "Rescue the Elite Squad!"

The others laughed at Connie and Hange, grinning like idiots, elbow in elbow, dancing around.

They cheered and clapped, laughing and celebrating humanity's first victory and all the braves souls that were responsible for making it happen.

Once everyone was settled and calm, Erwin played the episode.

The Rogue Titan was immobile once more, steam rising out of every pore in its body.

"The remaining Titans are coming!" Rico gripped her swords, eyeing the two Titans heading their way. "Climb up to the Wall!"

"I'll withdraw after I've recovered Eren!" Mikasa responded and ran over to the Titan sitting slumped over, its back to her. "Armin, how's Eren?"

"He's burning!" Armin crouched at the nape of the Titan, pulling his best friend out. "We need to hurry and get him up the Wall!" Both of Eren's arms were still stuck in the muscles. "Part of his body is fused to it!"

Mikasa quickly joined him and Rico followed.

"I can't pull him free!"

"Then we'll have to cut it!" Rico said.

"What if you accidentally—no never mind, regeneration," Christa said.

"W-wait, please!" Mikasa said desperately.

In a single moment, Rico severed the flesh connecting Eren to the body. Armin, who had been pulling the boy, fell backwards.

"It's his butt!" Connie laughed.

"You landed right behind its ass!" Jean snickered.

"Never seen one up that close and never want to either," Ymir shuddered.

"It's a fine ass!" Hange declared.

Eren was mortified. Armin thought it was funny too, much to the Shifter's chagrin, and even Mikasa couldn't hide an amused smile.

"That is a good butt," Petra agreed, nodding at Hange.

Eren groaned, pressing back against the couch and sliding down, trying to hide.

"Really, Petra, you too?" Levi said. "Four-Eyes, I'm not surprised about but I expected more maturity out of you."

"Well, what can I say," she shrugged, "it's a really nice butt."

"Please stop," Eren slid further, face red.

"It's definitely the cutest Titan butt I've ever seen," Christa admitted, blushing.

"Someone kill me now..."

"Is that the best Titan butt anyone's ever seen or have you guys seen better ones?" Sasha asked.

"You really gonna let them continue?" Levi moved his head back to look at Erwin.

"Why not?" The commander shrugged. "There's no harm in it."

Eren stayed in his position until finally, they decided that he, the Rogue Titan, did indeed have the best butt among all the Titans. "You guys suck," the pouting boy sat up, face still warm, as the episode started playing.

A large shadow fellow over Armin and the unconscious Shifter. Two Titans loomed over them. The boy's eyes widened.

"Eren! Armin!" Mikasa called out, rushing forward. A massive hand began to move toward them. Eren slowly opened his eyes.

Levi came from above, spinning down and cutting the nape of the left Titan. A hook shot out and he swung behind them and, spinning once more, took out the second Titan.

"Dude, what are you, part Sonic the Hedgehog?" Candy laughed.

A few brave souls chuckled.

Levi's observant look was now replaced by a scowl. He didn't like being called a hedgehog, knowing the cutesy little rodents Candy was referring to.

Armin held the half-unconscious Eren in his arms. He looked over his shoulder to see Levi drop on the fallen Titan, his back to them. "Mikasa?" The girl in question landed next to him.

"That's…" Mikasa began.

Eren looked up, eyes locking in on the green cloak, "The Wings of Freedom."

Levi looked over his shoulder. "Hey, you brats. What exactly is going on here?" Behind the trio, the Rogue Titan's body continued to steam, its ribcage completely visible.

An overhead shot of Trost appeared. *"Afterwards, thanks to the Garrisons and the Survey Corps' engineers, Wall Rose once again held the Titans at bay."*

Cannons blasted down the Titans crowded at the base of the Wall. *"Taking out the rest of the Titans trapped inside Trost took a full day, during which the Wall-mounted cannons fired nonstop."* The soldiers atop the Walls had their hands pressed to their ears to block out the deafening booms.

"Most of the Titans that had gathered by the Wall were wiped out by explosive shells."* One shot met its mark true and obliterated the side of the Titan's neck. Then the Wings of Freedom appeared. " *The few that remained were mostly mopped up by the Scouts."

An image of two Titans, bound and surrounded by humans, appeared.

"During this, one 4-meter Titan and one 7-meter Titan were successfully captured alive."

Erwin paused, knowing what was coming.

"Sonny! Bean!" Hange jumped out of her seat. She ran over to the TV and threw her arms around it, sobbing. "My babies!"

Levi folded his arms and sighed, leaning back and closing his eyes. "This is gonna take a while."

"Don't be me mean, Captain, she was really attached to them," Petra said.

"Whatever."

"I swear I'll find out who killed you and they will PAY!" The woman screamed. "I shall avenge you, my babies!"

"Wasn't she experimenting on them?" Jean wondered out loud.

"I believe so," Armin nodded.

"I love you! I hope you remembered that before you were so brutally taken away from me!"

"Glad she doesn't love me," Connie muttered.

"She's getting tears on the TV," Ymir pointed.

Erwin stood up and pealed Hange off their way to look into the future.

Levi made a disgusted noise. "You better clean that up!"

"I'm mourning here, Shorty!"

Mikasa was the only one to laugh at the nickname.

A few wipes from her cloak and the screen was clear once more.

Pixis and two of his subordinates looked over the Wall.

"However, 207 soldiers were killed or missing in action and 897 were injured. And although this was the first time humanity had stopped a Titan invasion, far too many people had been lost to celebrate this historic achievement."

Jean had a sinking feeling in the pit of his stomach.

Soldiers with cloths covering their mouths carried bodies around the broken city. A carriage loaded with corpses passed by. Rows of dead soldiers were placed up and down the street.

The mood sobered real fast.

What? Where is it? Jean thought. Marco's death had happened off screen and he felt guilty for being so caught up in the previous happy scenes that his mind had forgotten about his best friend.

Jean walked down the street in long brown gloves and a mask like the others. He looked to the right, and his eyes widened.

"What?" Eren asked when his fellow former trainees fell silent. He was the only one without all the details.

It wasn't even worth enough to be shown? Jean clenched his fists.

"Hey…"

Eren's eyes narrowed, trying to see if the body was someone he knew, before widening in confirmation. *Marco?*

The right side of Marco's body had been bitten off.

"Is that you…Marco?"

The dead boy was missing half his face.

Several gasps rang around the room.

Jean's hands trembled. "Do you know his name?" A woman walked up to him, clipboard in hand.

"I wondered where he was…"

"Where *did* he go? Last we saw, wasn't he with you, Annie, and Connie?" Sasha asked.

Christa nodded, "Do you have any idea what happened?"

"I don't know," Jean shook his head. "We got separated during the battle somehow and then I found him...like that."

"Where is his gear?" Petra asked.

That's strange. Armin thought, having noticed it as well.

"Someone might've had defective gear like Jean and took it off him," Christa said.

"He could've gone with Annie," Ymir said.

"But she told me she hadn't seen him either," Connie said.

I'll bet she did . Ymir thought.

"But he's the last person who would ever…Marco…" Jean was in shock. "What happened? D-Did someone…anyone see how he went out?" He turned and started to walk toward the others.

"What is his name?" The woman asked, stopping him in his tracks. "Tell me if you know. Quickly."

He looked over his shoulder at her.

"Do you understand, Recruit? It's already been two days since the hole was sealed but we still haven't rounded up all the corpses. At this rate, an epidemic could break out. We must prevent a secondary disaster. There's no time to lament our comrades' deaths yet. Understand?"

"Member of the 104th Trainee Corps and Captain of Squad 19, Marco Bott."

"I wish we could've seen which Titan killed him," Eren glared. "Then we could've found the fucker and put it down like the beast it is!"

"But we didn't," Jean said, angry and frustrated. "Because apparently, he wasn't important enough so his death wasn't shown!"

"That's not true!" Christa's eyes watered.

"It's not fair," Sasha was clearly upset. "He was important to us!"

"Us, but not Candy or in the grand scheme of things or whatever," Connie said.

"Guys—" Armin began.

"They might show it later," Ymir interrupted. "Like Potato Girl said, he was important to most of the people in this room." Candy knew Annie, Reiner, and Bert were the enemies and, undoubtedly, she would out them as Shifters eventually. "It might be a big reveal Candy's saving for later."

"That's right," Petra added. "She kept hinting at humans still existing outside the Walls when she could've said so right at the beginning."

"Candy's probably being dramatic," Mikasa nodded, thinking back to the episode her past was revealed. What had happened wasn't shown immediately, rather it had been set up to create misdirection, suspense, and tension.

"She had better," Eren growled. "If I find the Titan who did this I'll kill it!"

Are you sure? Then Ymir thought back to the insane 9-year-old who'd killed two men to save a girl he didn't know. She wondered if he'd be able to kill someone he'd thought a true friend for having a hand in the death of a comrade. *Maybe.* She reminded herself. *There's still a chance Annie wasn't involved* .

"I'm with Mikasa," Armin nodded. "I'm sure it'll come out eventually." The lack of gear bothered him. And he still had suspicions about who had killed Sonny and Bean.

"Marco," the woman wrote down the name. "I'm glad you knew his name. Let's continue."

A couple of soldiers, including Sasha, stood around a giant red blob covered in saliva. "What…is this?"

"A Titan threw it up," a Garrison soldier said to her. At least two were visible, mouths open wide, forever frozen in mid-scream, capturing the last seconds of the horror they'd experienced right before death. "They don't have digestive systems, so they puke people out like that once they've had their fill."

"Fucking monsters," Connie muttered.

The fact that not only did Titans not need to eat humans, but couldn't keep them down once they'd had themselves a feast and vomited the people as a disgusting, unidentifiable mess frustrated them to no end.

"That's…" Sasha was stunned.

"Damn, there's no way we'll be able to identify anyone like this."

"Ah, takes me back 70 years to the one who survived," Candy said.

"Someone survived being eaten, digested, and thrown back up?" Hange demanded. "Who? How? 70 years ago she said? How come I've never heard about this?!"

"I was about to ask you," Armin said, eyes wide.

"Could it be another Shifter? The healing would explain it," Levi said.

"I don't think so," Erwin said, eyebrows furrowed in thought.

Ymir was curious as well. *No, it can't be another Titan Shifter* . She was sure the only Shifters behind the Walls were—and had only been—Eren, the traitorous trio, and herself. *Must've been a miracle* .

"I have to look into this!" Hange's cheeks were flushed in delight. She made a huge note about investigating the matter when they left.

"I'm sorry. I'm sorry," Annie stood over a corpse, horrified.

"Why is she apologizing?" Christa said what was on the other graduates of the 104th trainees class' minds.

"It's no use apologizing," Reiner said. "We need to hurry and give them a funeral."

"Maybe she was too slow to save him," Connie said. "She tries to be a loner but she saved me when she didn't have to."

"She might've felt bad about his terrible fate," Erwin said. It wasn't uncommon.

Everyone, except for Ymir, agreed. She nodded, just to play along. *She's guilty he died because her friend knocked down the gate and let the Titans in.* Ymir was becoming more and more certain Annie, Reiner, and Bert had been involved in Marco's death.

A massive fire consumed the bodies.

A small torch burned in a dark place. Eren's eyes suddenly flew open with a gasp. Two slightly blurry figures on the other side of the bars became clear. Eren blinked.

"Do you have any questions?"

Eren recognized the blond-haired man sitting in the chair. *Commander Erwin Smith, the head of the Survey Corps, and Captain Levi!* The short man was leaning against the wall, arms folded, eyes looking to the side in disinterest.

"U-umm…" Eren sat on a cot in the dark cell. "Where…am I?"

"As you can see, it's a dungeon," Erwin answered. Three small torches outside the cell were the only sources of light. Two men stood guard, rifles slung across their backs. Eren listened to

the commander in confusion. "You're currently in the custody of the Military Police. We were only just now permitted to see you."

Chains clinked when the boy shifted. He raised his hand, sheet slipping off.

He's already imprisoned, are those really necessary? Mikasa thought in annoyance. Even as she tried to understand the government's paranoia regarding Eren, did they really think those measly chains could stop him if he decided to transform?

Erwin held up a bronze key.

"That key is…"

"Yes, it's yours. I'll return it later. Dr. Yeager's basement," Erwin said calmly, "in your home in Shiganshina is where the secret surrounding the Titans lies, correct?"

"Yes, I think so. That's what my father said," Eren confirmed.

"Now see, what I don't get is why you didn't just give the key to Levi and have him and his squad sneak into Shinganshina and go to the basement? I'm sure they could get the directions from Eren or Armin. Or just take Mikasa with them," Candy said in amusement.

"The key wasn't legally in my possession, it was the government's," Erwin shrugged when all heads turned in his direction.

"Oh wait, never mind," Candy said. "The government didn't want anyone finding out the truth. Luckily Zackly ruled in your favor to snub them."

"Good thing it isn't a Noble who is in charge of all the military branches," Levi said. Anyone else would've given in to the Royal

Government's demands and sent the Shifter off to the be dissected and killed.

"You've lost your memory," Levi began, "and your old man's gone missing. Awfully convenient story, if you ask me."

"Levi," Erwin chided lightly, "we've already concluded he has no reason to lie." He turned back to the boy. "There is still so little we know, but for now, I feel the most important thing is to ask about your intentions."

"My…intentions?"

A map of the three Walls appeared, surrounded by red Titans figures, Wall Maria glowing yellow. "In order to investigate your home, we must recapture Shiganshina District along Wall Maria." The image was followed by the Armored Titan smashing through the gate.

How come it didn't show up? Armin wondered for the hundredth time, mind racing.

"Drastic measures are needed to seal the gate quickly. And that means we'll need your Titan ability. Naturally, it seems Titans will determine our fate. The Colossal Titan and the Armored Titan most likely work the same way as you. Your intentions are the key. The key to saving humankind from this despair."

"I see you, Erwin, being punny," Candy snickered.

Connie was the only one who thought the stupid joke was funny.

"I'm…" Eren recalled his father holding the key, happy memories of his home, the Smiling Titan picking through the wreckage of his home and pulling his mother out.

"It's tragic she got killed by* that *Titan."

"What? What's that supposed to mean?" Eren looked to Armin for clarification.

The blond-haired boy was just as confused as his best friend. "I have no idea."

"Candy seems to be implying—no, she said it outright," Petra corrected, "there is a story, a sad story behind that Titan and the fact that it was the one that killed your mother."

"Why can't she ever say it plainly instead of making these cryptic remarks?" Eren glared.

"I'm sure she'll reveal it in due time," Mikasa reassured, itching for the truth herself.

It wasn't just the trio, everyone else was extremely curious as to what Candy had meant, but kept respectfully quiet.

Flashes of his father with the needle and the Smiling Titan reaching up to snap his mother's spine appeared. *I'm going to exterminate every last one from this world!* The Titan brought its teeth down on Carla's slumped body. *I won't spare a single one!*

"Hey," Levi said, bored, "answer the damn question, scum. What do you want to do?"

Eren grinned madly, "I want to join the Survey Corps and slaughter every Titan I can!"

"Oh? Not bad."

"After listening to him bitch about it a hundred times now, it's fucking annoying and repetitive," Levi grumbled.

"Try putting up with that for *years* ," Ymir snorted.

"Oh yeah," Jean nodded.

"I mean I get why but every. Single. Day?" Connie shook his head.

Everyday? That is an extreme amount of rage and hate . Petra thought.

Mikasa frowned at them before looking at Eren. He was still too wound up about what Candy had said to pay attention.

"Erwin, I'll take responsibility for him. Let the higher-ups know." Levi walked over and grabbed a bar. "It doesn't mean I trust him. If he betrays us or goes out of control, I'll kill him on the spot."

Eren froze.

"I doubt anyone will complain. Because I'm the only one cut out for this. I'll accept your enlistment into the Survey Corps."

Eren stared off, unsure of the future.

"That was a great episode," Hange grinned wickedly. "We saw humanity achieve its first victory over the Titans, Eren has agreed to join us, and his Titan form has the nicest ass out of all of them!"

Eren groaned, ripped away from thoughts regarding his mother and the Smiling Titan, as they started once more. "Please just play the next episode, sir," Eren begged.

Fortunately, this time the commander took mercy on the poor boy.

Please Review~

Episode - Eyes Yet to Be Seen

Chapter 14: Eyes Yet to Be Seen

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The group watches humanity's first victory and teases Eren. The recruits ponder over Marco's death and Eren wonders about Candy's comment regarding the Smiling Titan.

The brick and marble building was beautiful. Two statues of women with wings sat on two columns, one with scales in hand and the other with a sword.

"Sina," Sasha said longingly. It was only one building but it was very impressive to her. She had given up a pretty easy life for death and tragedy, but she still stood by her decision to join the Survey Corps.

A small untouched loaf of bread lay on a cup by the bars.

Eren opened his eyes slowly, blinking to clear the fuzziness. Chains jingled and he turned his head, raising his left hand.

Elsewhere, the topic of the Rogue Titan was being discussed by the citizens. "Hey, is it true? Is there really a Titan on our side?" A masculine voice spoke.

Around him, bodies worked around in the small room. His companion pulled a large sheet of paper with writing out of the printing press.

"Wow, that's where they make newspapers, huh?" Christa said.

"It's obviously just a rumor."

"So that's what the journalists thought. And they printed their beliefs, mass produced it, and spread it around," Armin thought out loud.

"Newspapers hold a lot of power," Erwin nodded. "Whatever the journalists write, people will read and it will shape public opinion."

"The recapture could've failed, so we might see a horde of people from Wall Rose any minute now."

[Wall Sina]

In the heart of the city, men and women read the newspaper, frowning and discussing what they were reading.

"Now the sheep in the crowd will believe whatever they read without question," Ymir said.

"Say…what if that Titan sides with the people within Wall Rose to come attack us together?"

"What a tempting thought," Eren smirked.

"So if a reporter doesn't like you, you'll get slandered," Jean said.

"They're not supposed to insert their own bias but it's highly probable," Petra shrugged.

"It's Sina," Levi said, "the government has a lot of influence on what gets printed and what doesn't."

[Wall Rose]

"This is amazing news! We have a Titan on our side now!"

"We might even be able to recapture Wall Maria!"

A large crowd had gathered in one spot to see the newspaper posted on the wall.

"It's like our savior has appeared!"

Many in the crowd looked excited and were holding hands.

"Interesting contrast," Mikasa said. "In Sina, everyone had their own copy and didn't look happy. On the other side, in Rose, the people are reading one public copy and are overjoyed about the news."

Christa frowned, "The people in Sina saw Eren as a potential threat. He helped those in Trost so he might join them and help them take over. But everyone else sees him as a way to return to their homes."

"Perspective means a great deal," Armin said. "Now some will want Eren dead out of fright and others won't."

"That's why they were all scared of me?" Eren's face twisted in disgust. Not because he might eat them but because he could help others take their place in Sina. Was their first instinct, their fear, really losing their prosperous positions instead of their lives?

"Not entirely," Armin said. "But it looks like it was a big part of the reason why they wanted you dead."

Red wheels spun on the screen and a carriage approached the courthouse.

"Savior, huh?"

Erwin recognized the voice as the MP commander's.

Many MP personnel stood guard at the entrance, talking amongst one another.

"The masses are so simple-minded, no matter the era."

"Sad but true," Candy sighed.

Nile tapped his foot, arms folded. "It sounds like something the rebels could use against Central though," one of the MPs said.

"What rebels?" Connie asked

"Us, I believe," Ymir pointed to the Wings of Freedom on her jacket.

"Oh."

"We of the Military Police Brigade will dispose of Eren Yeager before that can happen," Nile answered calmly. "We won't let those eccentrics at the Survey Corps get their hands on him either." He heard the wheels of the carriage and straightened. "Attention!"

The soldiers stood at attention immediately. When the carriage stopped before them, one of the soldiers quickly opened the door. A large man with gray hair stepped out.

"Salute the Commander-in-Chief!" Nile saluted and his subordinates followed suit.

Zackly nodded, and adjusted his collar, "It's hot today."

"So that's the man in charge of all the three military branches," Jean said.

"He certainly looks the part," Ymir said.

"He's great," Armin nodded. He could only imagine how much pressure Chief Zackly must have been under to sentence Eren to death. Instead he had wisely spared the Shifter and allowed him to join the Survey Corps.

"Commander Pixis," Erwin spoke, following the old man, "some people may consider it inappropriate for you, as Commander of the Garrison, to be conversing privately with someone like me from the Survey Corps."

"Well, it seems you're as straight-laced as they say. Why fret? We merely ran into each other by chance during our morning stroll."

Erwin didn't reply but bowed his head in agreement.

"Now that we're already walking, this is nothing more than idle talk," Pixis said. "Are you aware that the Military Police are also after Eren Yeager?"

"Ooh, so you two were plotting and scheming before the trial," Connie grinned. "Not that I'm saying it's a bad thing," he said quickly. "I meant it's great!"

"Yes," Erwin replied. "They sent word yesterday. Apparently, a trial will be held."

"The decision about whether the Military Police or the Survey Corps get Eren has been entrusted to Zackly."

"Zackly? Do you mean Commander-in-Chief Darius Zackly?"

"Yes, the man in charge of all three forces: the Military Police, the Garrison, and the Survey Corps." Pixis stopped, hands clasped behind his back. "When making decisions, he considers only one method: the cost-benefit analysis. That is, whether it's profitable or harmful to humanity overall. Which means he wouldn't hesitate to execute Eren right on the spot if that were the verdict."

Erwin frowned.

"I don't want to let him kill Eren. But unfortunately, more than a few in my Garrison fear Eren's powers," Pixis pulled out his flask.

"Dude, really? In the morning? You can't even use the 'It's five o'clock somewhere' excuse because you don't know about it," Candy said.

"Either booze doesn't affect him or he's an alcoholic," Ymir declared.

"Maybe it's juice?" Sasha said.

Eren made a grossed out face, "Nah, it was disgusting, it's definitely booze."

"Then one of the highest ranking men behind the walls is an alcoholic?" Jean raised an eyebrow.

"It sure would explain his weird taste," Mikasa said, remembering his comment regarding a pretty female Titan and being eaten by her.

"No, it couldn't be," Christa shook her head. "He's a commander!"

"I don't know," Connie said, "he's a little out there."

Erwin chuckled, "I've seen him drinking from that flask a lot but I haven't actually ever seen him drunk."

"It's probably so watered down you can't even get buzzed," Armin shrugged.

"I'm more interested in the last part," Hange said, putting the pen down. "What did *that* mean?"

"It's five o'clock somewhere," Petra repeated. "How would that be possible? Somewhere where? The world? How does that work?"

"It doesn't make any sense, like half the other crap that comes out of her mouth," Levi rolled his eyes.

"You shouldn't talk so rudely about her, Captain. What if she gets angry with you?"

"What is she gonna do, throw sweets at me?"

"Five o'clock...somewhere...hm," Hange's brow furrowed in deep thought.

"We'll have plenty of time to figure that out later, let's continue," Erwin said, trying to keep them from going too far off track.

"All I can do is to argue my case against the Military Police. Do you think you can win?" Pixis asked.

"Yes. I have also prepared a proposition, but its viability depends greatly on the way the trial progresses."

"In other words, it's a game of chance?"

"It's a game we of the Survey Corps are well-acquainted with as we mainly engage in expeditions," Erwin said.

Pixis laughed, "It seems there's more to you than I thought. Thank you for such a nice stroll, Commander Smith," he waved.

"Eren's being put on trial? Why?" Mikasa asked.

"He can transform into the thing that's kept humanity locked behind walls for a century, what do you think, genius?" Levi asked sarcastically.

Mikasa clenched her fists and shot him a glare. "Nobody asked you, runt."

A few gasps and snickers went around the room. "You should address your superior properly," Levi glared with equal menace.

"Sorry, *Corporal* Runt," she smirked.

"That's enough now," Erwin interrupted before a brawl could break out.

"No, Erwin, I wanna see them fight!" Hange whined.

The commander ignored her. "You will show respect when talking to a ranking officer," he told Mikasa. She pressed her lips but bowed her head in compliance. "And don't forget, we're here for a limited amount of time. I'd like for us to have extra time to use afterward, being productive and problem-solving, not wasting it now bickering like children."

Levi turned his glare on Erwin.

"Recruit Ackerman, I believe you owe Corporal Levi an apology."

"Just do it," Armin said.

Eren nodded, "C'mon."

Mikasa folded her arms, looking an equally sour-looking Levi in the face, and spat out the words. "I'm sorry." Then she snatched an apple off the table and took a bite to get rid of the taste.

"I'm not entirely sure," Armin answered, sitting across from her in the mess hall. "I think it's about deciding how to deal with Eren."

"What does that mean?"

"They're probably deciding whether he lives or dies."

Mikasa stood, eyes wide in fear.

"Mikasa Ackerman! Armin Arlert!" An MP official asked. "Are you here?"

"Yes, sir," the girl said.

"You have been ordered to appear at the trial this afternoon as witnesses!"

Two MP soldiers stood guard at Eren's cell. The boy sat on the bed in silence. Finally, he lifted his head up. "Excuse me, may I use the toilet?"

"You just went earlier."

"Can I get some water?"

"Hey," the other guard said, "understand the situation you're in, you monster."

Asshole . The sudden, irritated thought surprised Jean.

"I don't think you're a monster, Eren" Christa smiled charmingly at him.

"Thanks," he gave her a smile in return. "But they're not all wrong."

"Yes, they are," Mikasa disagreed vehemently.

"She's right," Armin said.

"I'm with them," Petra nodded.

"Yes!" Hange agreed. "You're no monster! You're a wonderfully beautiful creature with a magnificent ass!"

"Oh for the love of Maria," Eren cringed. "Hasn't even been ten minutes," he muttered under his breath.

"Don't worry, we'll *never* forget," Ymir promised, grinning.

Monster? I guess they're not wrong about that. **Eren stared at his hands. *Is there really a need to cuff me like this?* He dropped his hands. *I shouldn't be that surprised. I don't really understand all this myself.***

He recalled the cannon pointed straight at him, along with an army of soldiers, blades at the ready to cut him down. *I should just be happy that I haven't been killed yet.*

Eren straightened. *Wait a minute!* His thoughts flashed to his best friends, refusing to leave him by himself in such a dangerous situation. *Those two weren't scared of me at all. What are they doing now?*

A memory of the rest of his comrades came to him, Sasha, Connie, Christa, and Reiner helping in the kitchen, cooking, while Marco and Jean helped Annie with the dishes. *What happened to everybody else?*

"Be patient for a little longer," Erwin had said, standing before the cell. "We'll try to sort things out."

How many days have passed since then? What's going on outside?* Eren's head dropped. *I won't have to live my whole life like this, right?

"We'd break you out, you know." Armin's words took some of his fellow viewers by surprise. They expected that kind of response from Mikasa.

"Yes," Mikasa smiled. "Between the two of us, I'm sure we could successfully plan and execute a jailbreak."

The sound of a door opening was heard, followed by footsteps.

All of a sudden, Hange gripped the bars, a crazed look on her face, scaring Eren.

"Holy shit!" Connie jumped.

"Fuck, what was that Four-Eyes?" Levi demanded.

"That was...sudden," Jean said with wide eyes.

"I was excited," Hange defended.

"Look at Eren's face," Sasha giggled.

"Can't say I blame him," Petra smiled.

"Yeah, she looks like some psycho killer," Ymir muttered.

"Don't be mean," Christa chided.

"It's true." Mikasa eyed the woman suspiciously, rumors she'd heard about the scientist flying through her mind.

"I hope you didn't terrorize him too much," Erwin looked at her.

"I'm pretty sure Mike freaked him out more than me," she said.

"True," Eren nodded.

"Mike?" Armin asked.

"You'll see."

Hange's mad expression turned to a smile. "So, you're Eren, huh? You okay?" Eren continued to look confused. "Feeling filthy? Sorry for making you wait for so long. You can finally leave this place."

Eren's shoulders sagged in relief and a tall blond-haired man joined Hange.

"That's Mike."

Hange held a pair of handcuffs through the bars. "Though you'll have to wear these."

Eren, now in handcuffs, walked through a hallway, escorted by a group of soldiers. "I'm Hange Zoe, a squad leader in the Survey Corps. He's Mike Zacharias, same goes for him."

Eren had a half-annoyed half-creeped out expression from Mike sticking his nose too close to the boy for comfort.

"What is he doing?" Christa asked, shocked.

Mikasa looked outraged.

"That's creepy," Sasha shivered.

"That's Mike," Petra said, "he's like that at first with everyone he meets."

"I'd punch him," Jean said.

"Um…" Eren twisted his neck to further himself from Mike.

"Ah," Hange explained, "he just has this habit of sniffing people at their first meeting…"

"But why?" Armin asked, not understanding at all.

Mike snorted to himself.

"No reason," Petra shrugged.

"…then snorting like that."

"I bet he just likes mind-fucking with people," Connie said.

"That's...probably true," Ymir agreed.

"I wouldn't read much into it though. He's skilled enough to become a squad leader, after all."

Eren walked in awkward silence between the two squad leaders.

"Oh," Hange said in exaggeration, "we chatted all the time away. We're already here. Well, I guess you're better off without an explanation too."

Seriously? Jean thought. *I'd throw a fit and demand they fill me in.*

The MPs grabbed the boy. "Wait," Eren looked over his shoulder.

"We don't have a choice but to trust you blindly," Hange said sincerely. "Good luck."

The doors slammed shut behind him.

Eren was staring up with wide eyes at a huge painting depicting men slaughtering each other with swords. On the wall behind the judge's bench, four insignias were placed at the top, representing the threes branches and the Trainees Corps. *A courtroom?* Eren thought. *So I was being held under the courthouse?*

An MP soldier prodded the boy with his rifle. "Move along!"

"Looks like all the important people are military," Armin noted. The benches surrounding the area in the middle seemed to make up mostly of soldiers.

"That's right," Erwin said. "In a trial for those of military affiliation, the judge, prosecution, and defense are all soldiers."

"So the civilians present are only there to see the trial?" Christa asked. "They don't have any say in the matter?"

"Yes, Commander-in-Chief Zackly makes the final decision. The others don't wield any actual power."

"Not officially," Levi said.

Hange nodded. "These types of special court-martial trials always have a more political undertone."

"Kneel down there," one of the men ordered.

Eren knelt, the other one inserted a large metal bar between the boy's hands and back and into the ground, preventing him from being able to escape.

"That just seems cruel and unnecessary," Candy said. "He could transform by will for all they know. At least in the cell, it made sense, he was underground."

"Candy makes a valid point," Petra said. "Then again, considering who we're dealing with..."

"Common sense isn't their forte," Mikasa said.

"If it had been me in your place, I'd have transformed and run away," Ymir told Eren, getting Levi's attention.

Eren's gaze shifted left and right. *Why are these people here? What is this trial even about?* He noticed Armin and Mikasa in the crowd. *Guys…*

Zackly entered and sat, folding his jacket neatly and putting it aside, sleeves rolled up, "Now then, let us begin." The whispers came to a stop. "You are Eren Yeager?" He read off the paper, adjusting his glasses. "You're a soldier who vowed to devote his life to humanity. Is that correct?"

"Yes, sir."

Sasha rubbed her hands on her lap. *It's only started and I'm nervous.*

"This is an unprecedented case. It is outside the bounds of the common law, therefore we must convene a special court-martial. The final decision will be handed down by me. We will deliberate upon whether you live or die as well."

I knew it. **Armin thought.**

"Do you have any objections?"

"None, sir."

"I'm glad you're so cooperative. I'll be blunt. Concealing your existence has proven impossible."

Hange and Mike joined some soldiers on a balcony.

"Unless we publicize your existence in some way, we will have to face another threat besides the Titans. This court is tasked with deciding which faction will take custody of you, the Military Police or the Survey Corps. First," Zackly said, "let us hear the opening statement from the Military Police."

"Your Honor, I am Nile Dawk, Commander of the Military Police. Our proposition is as follows: We will examine Eren's body thoroughly, then dispose of him as soon as possible. It's a fact that his Titan power repelled the last attack," Nile admitted, looking at the boy. "However, his character induces disturbances that may even lead to a rebellion. Therefore he shall provide us with as much intelligence as possible, then he'll become a martyr for humanity."

"He makes it sound like it's the right choice," Connie wrinkled his nose.

"He probably thinks he's doing the right thing," Jean said. He didn't feel entirely comfortable thinking he might've agreed with the MP commander had he not known Eren personally.

"There's no need for that!" Pastor Nick claimed loudly.

"It's like the trial of the century, shouldn't he be kicked out for interrupting?" Candy grumbled.

"He's a vermin that breached and infiltrated the sacred Walls by intruding on our lands," Pastor Nick pointed accusingly.

"What a joke," Ymir sneered.

Levi nodded. Worshipping walls? He just couldn't wrap his head around it.

He's from the Church of the Walls. **Eren thought.** ***Five years ago, no one even took them seriously. They've come a long way.***

"He should be killed here and now!"

"Pastor Nick, quiet, please," Zackly said calmly. The man tensed but held his tongue. "Next, let us hear the proposition from the Survey Corps."

"Your Honor, I am Erwin Smith, Thirteenth Commander of the Survey Corps. Our proposition is as follows: We will accept Eren as a formal member of the Survey Corps, and recapture Wall Maria by using his Titan power. That is all."

Surprised whispers picked up around the courtroom.

"That's it?"

"Sometimes, less is more," the commander told Jean.

"It was short and hit the main points," Armin nodded. "Commander Pixis already said what the Chief was going to weigh." It was logical and perfectly fit what Zackly would consider, no need trying to passionately convince the people. That would be up to Eren.

"Hm? Is that it?" Zackly asked.

"Yes. Using his abilities, we can retake Wall Maria. I believe the priorities are clearly apparent."

"Good job, Erwin," Candy praised.

Erwin was quite flattered and smiled.

"I see. On that note, from where do you intend to launch that operation? Pixis," Zackly looked at the Garrison Commander, "I believe the gate at Trost was sealed for good, yes?"

"Yes," Pixis said. "I doubt it'll ever be opened again."

"We would like to go through the Karanes District in the east," Erwin spoke. A map appeared beside his head, making it easier to follow his words. "From there, we will approach Shiganshina on a new route." A red arrow started from 'Karanes District' and curved down to 'Shinganshina District.'

"Wait a minute!" A civilian interrupted. "Shouldn't we seal all the gates for good now? The Colossal Titan can only destroy the gates! If we fortify those areas, they won't be able to attack us again!"

"Brilliant, except you'll be trapping yourselves in as well," Candy said.

"He looks like he's already lived half his life, he probably doesn't care about the distant future," Jean said.

"Shut up, you puppet of the traders' guild! Using that Titan strength, we can return to Wall Maria once again!"

"We're fed up with you playing hero all the time!"

"You've got a big mouth, pig," Levi said, bringing attention to himself. "Who says the Titans will wait until you can lock up all the gates? The 'we' you're talking about refers to your little friends who you plan to get fat with, right?"

"Savage," Connie grinned.

"Oh you'll see what a savage he is in a few minutes," Mikasa said darkly.

Everyone aside from Erwin, Armin, and Hange looked at the girl curiously. Levi clenched his jaw. No use defending himself. She was emotional and they'd likely see the reason behind it afterward.

Petra hadn't witnessed the beating firsthand but had heard about it. *This won't be pleasant.* She wondered if she should be ready to jump in between the two. Though it seemed unlikely the teenage girl would attack, she kept the thought in mind just in case.

"Can't you even see that people are starving because we don't have enough land?" Levi asked.

"We're only suggesting that if we sealed the gates," the man defended, "we'd be safe—"

"Enough of your insolence!" Pastor Nick yelled at him. "How dare you even suggest doing such a thing to the sacred Wall Rose, given unto us by the Goddesses?!" A shot of soldiers sitting on the side benches appeared, looking tense.

Candy burst out laughing. "What's with the raccoon eyes? Is that a fashion statement or something?"

Connie and Sasha chuckled half-heartedly, the tension from Mikasa's words still in the air.

"You look upon the greatness of the Walls, which transcends human understanding, and you still can't see?!"

"It was their fault that it took so long to fortify the defenses of the Walls," Armin said.

"You speak blasphemy!" Pastor Nick continued to ramble.

"They have plenty of money and influence," Rico said. "A real handful."

"This is no place for a priest to speak!" One man yelled.

"What?!"

Zackly slapped the bench multiple times, "Order in the court."

"No gavel?" Candy gasped. "How can you be a judge and not have a gavel?"

"What's a gavel?" Connie asked the obvious.

"Something apparently all judges should have, according to Candy," Petra said.

"Argue about your individual beliefs and opinions somewhere else. Yeager," Zackly addressed the boy, "let me ask you this: Can you keep fighting for the sake of humankind as a soldier, and also use your Titan power for the same goal?"

"Yes! I can," Eren said loudly.

"Oh? But in the report from Trost, it says: 'He swung his fist at Mikasa Ackerman right after becoming a Titan.'"

Eren's head snapped to the side in shock. Mikasa pinched her hair and tried to use it to hide the small scar.

The same awful feeling rose in Eren's stomach, leaving it in knots. As upset as he was, Mikasa kept quiet. He'd lose his temper if she tried to defend him. Even though it really, truly wasn't his fault. Eren had a tendency to run his mouth and say hurtful things because of her overprotectiveness.

But the one time she was right to defend him, she couldn't because of all the other times she'd let him off the hook for snapping at her. And that frustrated her beyond belief.

He doesn't remember that he lost control? **Armin thought.**

Mikasa gave Rico a vicious side glare. "What, you wanted me to lie in the report?" Rico asked quietly. "Humanity gains nothing from hiding such a fact."

"Is Mikasa Ackerman here?" Zackly asked.

"Yes, I am."

"You, huh? Is it true that after he transformed, Yeager attacked you?"

"Lie!" Connie yelled at the TV.

"If you don't answer truthfully, it'll only hurt Eren," Rico advised.

Mikasa was quiet for a few seconds.

"Or not."

"Yes, it is true."

People gasped and whispered.

"He's like the rest of them, after all."

I tried to kill Mikasa? **Eren thought, horror clear on his face.** ***Me?***

"But before that," Mikasa continued confidently, "he also saved my life twice while in Titan form. The first time, when I was about to fall prey to a Titan, he fought them off and defended me. The second time, he protected me and Armin from cannon fire. I entreat you to consider these facts as well."

"Yes," Christa smiled and nodded. "That was good."

"Objection!" Nile said.

"Objection to what?" Jean asked. It was her testimony and it was all true, there were witnesses to back up her claims. At least the second one.

"I believe this testimony is too emotionally-biased to be accepted in court. Mikasa Ackerman lost her parents at a young age, and she was taken in by Yeager's family. However, we uncovered some surprising details regarding those events."

He's really going to bring up a past event? Ymir thought. Was that legal? She didn't know that much about the legal system *. And it had been in self-defense too* .

"Eren Yeager and Mikasa Ackerman were nine years old at the time."

"Uh-oh," Christa said.

"When they stabbed to death three men who were wanted for robbery and kidnapping."

"Oh crap," Sasha said.

"Though it is justifiable self-defense, I can't help but feel disturbed and believe their basic human nature needs to be questioned."

"Are you serious?" Jean demanded. As disturbing as it had been to watch, he couldn't imagine living it. Those people had no idea and no right getting all high and mighty and judging them for their actions.

"Should we really trust him with the fate, funds, and manpower of humanity?"

"Yeah! He's probably a Titan who infiltrated us disguised as a child!"

"That's too far-fetched," Petra rolled her eyes. If Titans were smart and capable enough to do that, why not just climb over the walls? It'd be much easier. Humanity wouldn't stand a chance against a surprise attack like that. *Fear has completely overridden any sense and they're looking for problems, monsters, where none exist* .

"Her too!" The man who'd asked for the walls to be sealed pointed at Mikasa, shaking in fear. Her eyes widened in shock. "How can we be sure she's human?"

"You're an idiot," Sasha pointed at the man on TV.

"That's right! We should dissect her just in case!"

"What?!" Christa gasped.

"Wait!" Eren yelled. "Maybe I am a monster, but she has nothing to do with that! Nothing at all!"

"As if we could believe you!"

"It's the truth!" He yelled, Mikasa watching with a stunned expression.

"You're defending her? She must be one of you!"

Their stupidity is killing me. Connie thought, frustrated. Even if they didn't know any better, it was way out of hand.

"No!" Eren screamed, struggling against the bonds now, scaring the civilians.

They fell silent, staring at him.

"You're wrong," he said calmly. "So far, all you keep doing is blurting out convenient speculations."

"W-What did you say?" Nile said.

"First off," Eren began. *I should stop.* He thought. "You've never even *seen* a Titan!" Internally, it was different. *I can't say any more* . Still, he continued. "So why are you so afraid?" Eren demanded. *I should shut up* .

"Do you have a problem, Eren?" Jean looked at him. "Even though you're thinking you shouldn't speak, you're running your mouth anyway."

"I had to," Eren replied stubbornly.

"I think it's a real thing, isn't it?" Sasha thought out loud. "When you can't help but blurt whatever's on your mind."

"Being an idiot?" Jean smirked. "You just can't help it, can you?"

"Yeah, same way you can't help being Horse-Face."

***No, I'm gonna say it all. I'll make my stand here.* Eren decided, looking determined. "If those with strength don't fight, who will? If you're too scared to fight for your lives, then at least don't hinder me! You damn cowards!"**

"What?!"

"Just shut up and let me shoulder it all!" Eren screamed. The courtroom was dead quiet.

Nile snapped out of it first. "Take aim!"

"What?!" Connie demanded.

"You didn't think they'd let him live after blowing up like that, did you?" Levi asked.

"But...I thought it was pretty inspirational," Sasha said.

"To us maybe," Petra nodded. "They just got a verbal beating."

"And I'll be getting a physical one," Eren sighed.

A soldier aimed his rifle at the boy.

Suddenly, a powerful kick delivered by Levi sent a bloody tooth across the floor.

"Lucy Kick vs. Levi Kick! Who's better? You decide!"

"Uh, what?"

Huh? **Eren glanced at his tooth and received another kick. Levi grabbed his hair and collar, kneeing him in the face. The crowd watched with stunned looks, mouths open, as he continued to beat the boy.**

Most of the viewers watched with similar looks as well.

Mikasa's expression became violent and Armin grabbed her arm when she stood, "Wait, Mikasa!"

"Good thing Armin was there," Sasha said, "or it would have gotten real ugly!"

"I kinda wanted to see that," Ymir admitted.

"My money's on Mikasa," Jean said immediately. Levi had more experience but he had also beaten up Eren right in front of her eyes.

"That's enough," Erwin interrupted before they gained steam. "There will be no taking bets on two comrades fighting each other."

"I like Mikasa but I have to go with Corporal Levi on this," Connie whispered.

"Me, too," Sasha nodded.

Blood dripped from Eren's face. Levi brought his boot down, smashing the boy's forehead into the ground. "It's just my personal opinion, but pain is the best tool for discipline. You don't need to be educated by words. You need training," he said without a hint of compassion. "You've fallen low enough that you're easy to kick around, anyway."

He continued to violently beat the boy as the crowd was still silent.

He's crazy! Christa watched with wide eyes.

Wouldn't wanna to be on his bad side . Jean shivered.

"Hold on, Levi," Nile began.

"What?" Levi asked casually, boot resting on Eren's face while Armin kept Mikasa from launching herself at the short man.

No wonder she's so murderous towards him. Ymir thought. Anyone one would be, seeing someone they cared about beaten so mercilessly.

I knew it would be bad, but I didn't think it'd be that brutal. Petra looked at TV-Eren in sympathy.

"It's dangerous. What if he starts raging and turns into a Titan?" Nile asked.

Levi kicked Eren once more and grabbed the glaring Shifter by the hair, making him flinch in pain. "What are you talking about?

I thought you were going to dissect him."

Was it really necessary to go that far? Connie wondered.

Poor Eren. Sasha's face hurt just looking at his.

Armin and Eren monitored their friend closely, looking for any sign she might attack Levi.

Mikasa, to hers and their surprise, sat calmly, with only an irritated expression covering her face. She hadn't liked the fact that it had saved Eren from a far worse fate but accepted it. Really she had hated how utterly ruthless Levi had been. But watching the scene play out from her current position, it irked her to realize it was necessary.

The pure savageness of the beating had been what really convinced everyone Survey Corps was the safest place for them to put Eren.

"As I heard it, when he turned into a Titan, he killed 20 other Titans before his strength ran out. If he were an enemy, he might cause more trouble than that intel's worth. He still can't stand against me though. What about you on the other hand?" He turned to the civilians. "All of you who persecute him, think it over. Can you really kill him?" Levi asked.

No one had an answer for that.

Erwin raised his hand, "Commander-in-Chief, I have a proposal."

"What is it?" Zackly asked, not perturbed at all by the violence he'd witnessed in his courtroom.

"Eren's Titan power has a multitude of uncertainties and unknown elements. It is exceedingly dangerous. So why don't we put Eren under Corporal Levi's command and send them on an expedition?" Erwin proposed.

The upcoming expedition will be even more life and death for Eren. Jean thought. Even if he survived, if he failed whatever test they had in mind, he'd executed. The odds were stacked against him. *Good thing we've got the TV to help us out.*

"You'll bring Eren outside?"

"Yes. Whether Eren can control his Titan power, and whether he may be of benefit to humankind, should be decided based on the results of that mission."

"Handling Eren Yeager…" Zackly turned to Levi, "Can you do that, Levi?"

"I'm certain I can kill him. The problem is there is no alternative," he told the Chief.

Eren had his head bowed, bruised and bleeding, while Mikasa and Armin watched tensely. Levi's eyes shifted toward them.

"I've made my decision," Zackly said.

Sasha exhaled loudly. "That was intense!"

"Right?" Christa nodded. "And we already knew what was going to happen."

"If Eren can't succeed in whatever mission you have in mind, will you hand him over to the Military Police?" Mikasa asked.

"No," Erwin said bluntly. "We already have a plan in case that happens."

"Not that we need to worry too much," Petra said. "We'll find out what'll happen in an hour."

Many faces lit up at that.

"Honestly, he went overboard," Hange took care of Eren's wounds. "Does it hurt?"

"A little," Eren held a cloth to the side of his face.

Mike stood by the window while Levi leaned against the wall, opposite of the two.

"So, how does it hurt?" Hange asked eagerly.

"Give the guy a break," Connie said. "He just got his ass kicked."

"I apologize," Erwin approached them. "But thanks to that, we got custody of you."

"Yes."

"We couldn't have made that proposal go through without your tolerance." Erwin knelt before the boy and held out his hand, "You have my respect." Eren's eyes widened. The commander smiled. "I look forward to working with you, Eren."

"I'll do my best, sir!" He shook the man's hand.

Levi sat on the couch, legs crossed, "Hey, Eren."

"Yes?"

"Do you hate me?"

"N-no," Eren told him, "I understand it was necessary."

"Glad to hear."

"You took it too far," Hange chided. "You even broke his tooth. Look," she showed them a small white cloth with the boy's bloody tooth on it.

"Ew," Connie wrinkled his nose.

"You actually went back and picked it up?" Ymir asked.

"It's valuable," Hange shrugged.

"Don't pick that up. It's disgusting," Levi said.

"It's an important sample for me," Hange insisted.

"Eren, I bet you're glad you won't be dissected by freaks like her, huh?" Levi asked.

"Don't put me in the same league as them. I wouldn't kill Eren."

The poor boy looked like he had no idea what he had gotten himself into.

"Hey," Hange leaned in, "let me take a peek in your mouth."

After a second of hesitation, he opened his mouth.

She let out a noise of surprise, grabbing the others' attention. "His tooth…already grew back."

"That must be nice," Sasha said. "Healing your injuries super fast."

"I could've used that as a kid." Jean recalled breaking his arm once, fooling around with the neighborhood children.

"Just how powerful is it?" Christa asked curiously.

"Don't know," Eren shrugged.

"It's not really something you can experiment," Petra said. "That would be torture." Mikasa nodded firmly.

"I wonder if your head will grow back if you were decapitated," Armin spoke to himself.

Connie grinned. "That'd be a pretty cool magic trick!"

"It's possible the only way to cut him down so he can't get back up is by slicing the nape," Erwin said. "Just like the Titans."

"Interesting theory," Hange nodded. "I'm writing that down. I kind of have an idea on identifying Shifters..."

Ymir watched the scientist warily as the others wondered what she was scheming, refusing to share, and Levi watched her.

I think I like Lucy Kick better. The sound effect is awesome and the echoing of her voice is hilarious.

Please Review~

Episode - The Special Ops Squad

Chapter 15: The Special Ops Squad

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Hange claims to have an idea on how to identify the Titan Shifters between them. Levi notices Ymir's wariness at Hange's words.

The episode opened with an overhead shot of Trost, a few, fluffy white clouds in the sky.

It looks so peaceful and beautiful . Christa smiled.

The image changed to a map, moving up to a location marked by the Wings of Freedom insignia.

[Former Survey Corps HQ]

An old, white and blue castle appeared.

"The former Survey Corps headquarters. It's nothing more than a renovated old castle." The sounds of horses trotting were heard. "While it definitely looks impressive," Oluo said, "it's so far from the Walls and all rivers that it's completely useless to the Survey Corps."

"Who's that?" Connie asked.

"Oluo," Eren answered. "The tall blond-haired man will be Erd and the one with brown hair, Gunther."

The group moved through the forest.

"The story goes back to the ambitious early days when the Corps was formed. Who would've thought we'd end up using it again to serve as your hideout?"

Eren observed his surroundings, noticing Levi and turning forward again, still intimidated by the man.

"Don't get cocky, new blood," Oluo leaned toward the boy.

"What?"

"I don't know the deal with this crap about you being a Titan, but we can't have Captain Levi babysit—"

The horse missed a step and Oluo bit his tongue, blood squirting in the air.

Christa gasped while Jean, Ymir, Connie, and Sasha snickered.

"Idiot," Mikasa snorted.

"Mikasa," Armin chided.

"Oh no, she's right," Petra waved her hand. "He is being an idiot."

"That's what you get for talking while riding your horse," Petra stood before Oluo, who was sitting, tending to his injury, in the shadow of the old castle.

"The first moments leave the most important impression. That newbie was scared shitless."

Nearby, Eren was taking care of his horse.

"I think he was just stunned silent by how lame you are," Petra said.

A few snickers rose from that remark.

"Still, it's all going according to plan," Oluo held a cloth to his face, still trying to look cool.

"He's like the Connie of the group," Ymir said.

"Yeah—hey!"

"Man, you never used to talk like that. If by chance you're trying to imitate Captain Levi, you should really stop it. You two are nothing alike, but still…" Petra was not impressed at all.

He smiled cockily at her. "Do you want to chain me down, Petra? You're still ways to go to be fitting for my wife."

"If only you'd bled to death from biting your tongue," she said calmly.

"Make that Connie with a healthy dose of Jean because of that arrogance and unrequited love," Ymir smirked.

Jean cringed, shrinking in his seat.

"You keep on boasting about how many Titans you've killed too," Petra said.

"So what?" Oluo asked. "I've boasted about you guys too."

***Those people are the Survey Corps' Special Ops Squad, commonly known as the Levi Squad* . Eren thought.**

"You're pathetic!" Petra told Oluo.

"I think he likes you," Armin said to Petra.

She rolled her eyes, "That childish crush is his problem and he should get over it."

Petra Ral* . Eren looked at the redhead. *Took down 10 Titans. Assisted with taking down another 46.

"A total of 56?" Christa's eyes widened.

That's what it takes to join the most elite squad . Jean thought in awe.

Oluo Bozado* . Eren looked at him next. *Took down 39. Assisted with another 9.

"39 solo kills?" Connie repeated incredulously. "Suddenly I don't feel too bad being compared to him."

"I was comparing your statuses as clowns, not as Titan-slayers," Ymir rolled her eyes.

"39 solo Titan kills is impressive," Sasha said, unable to even imagine such a thing.

They are the elite of the elite.* Eren watched the other two members walk by. *Erd Gin. Took down 14. Assisted with another 32. Gunther Schultz. Took down 7. Assisted with another 40.

"I can't believe you know all that," Petra turned to Eren.

He shrugged, grinning, "You were going to be my new teammates. And you're the very best. Of course I knew."

"So you could brag about, I bet," Jean grumbled.

They are the top tier of the Survey Corps, hand-picked by Captain Levi.* Eren stared at them intently *. If I went berserk, these people would be the ones to kill me.

Petra sighed, "I'm sorry, Eren. About, you know, freaking out."

"It's fine," the Shifter said. "You already apologized. And you were only doing your duty."

"What?" Mikasa asked.

"Well—it's—we," Petra shook her head, "you'll see."

Erd looked down at the ground. "It's covered in weeds. It looks terrible."

"It's been disused for a very long time," Gunther said. "Inside, a sea of dust is probably awaiting us."

"That is indeed a severe problem," Levi approached them. "We must sort it out immediately," he said, completely serious.

Levi threw the window open, hair and mouth covered by a cloth.

"Bet he's smiling under there, probably the only time he smiles," Candy said.

"Probably," Erwin chuckled.

"Not quite the image I had of Humanity's Strongest Soldier," Ymir raised an eyebrow at the getup. Her words received her nods and murmurs of agreement from her couch-mates.

"We're done cleaning the upper floors," Eren approached the short man. "Where will I get to sleep in the building, sir?"

"Your room is in the basement."

"The basement again, sir?"

"Of course. You're not in complete control of yourself yet. If you drifted off and turned into a Titan, at least if you're underground we can restrain you right away. That was one of the conditions agreed upon for us to get custody of you. It's a rule that we must follow. I'll take a look around the rooms." Levi walked away. "You do this room, Eren."

"Yes, sir." The boy looked around, unhappy.

"Looks clean enough to me," Christa said.

"It's not Levi-level of clean," Hange grinned. "Meaning it has to be clean enough so you can eat off the floor."

"But it's still clean," Sasha muttered.

"Isn't that an abuse of power?" Jean asked. Levi glared at him and he wilted. "Never mind."

Petra came in seconds after Levi left, "You've got quite a despairing look on your face, Eren."

He quickly turned around, "I do?"

"But wait, you couldn't even see his face," Armin said. "His back was turned to you."

"His body language gave him away. Plus he had a bummed-out look on his face all morning and Captain Levi had just asked him to clean an already clean room. It wasn't hard to guess," Petra explained.

"I'll be calling you Eren. Captain Levi does the same. Here, his word is the law."

"Right, I don't mind that, but did I really have a despairing look on my face?"

"It's not surprising at all. He doesn't come across as the perfect, invulnerable hero people think he is, does he?"

"No, he does not," Sasha said.

Petra looked to where the corporal had disappeared. "The true Levi is surprisingly short, irritable, violent, and hard to approach."

"So, you were gossiping behind my back, Petra?" Levi looked at her.

The redhead smiled, "It's not gossip if it's true. And don't pretend you didn't know we were talking about you."

"That's not it," Eren said. "I was surprised how obediently he accepts the decisions of the higher-ups."

"Did you think that as strong as he is, he wouldn't care about rank or the chain of command?" Petra asked.

I thought so too . Connie thought. It wasn't uncommon to him, to meet people who were in a position of power that wasn't pricks, thinking they were above the rules.

"Yes," Eren admitted. "I expected him not to acquiesce to anyone's words."

"I don't know the details myself, but I heard he was pretty much like that originally. Before joining the Survey Corps, he was a famous thug in the capital's underworld."

Now, why am I not surprised to hear that? Jean thought.

So he was a criminal . Ymir thought. "No wonder he seems so shady," she muttered under her breath.

"But then, why?"

"I don't know exactly what happened," Petra answered. "He was taken into the Survey Corps under Commander Erwin's hands."

"The Commander?"

"Hey, Eren!" Levi appeared behind the redhead.

"Yes, sir?" Eren stood to attention while Petra moved to the side, sweeping furiously.

The recruits started laughing.

"When you're taking a test and the teacher walks by and you pretend to write to look smart," Jean smirked.

"Right?" Christa giggled.

Levi snorted, "That wasn't subtle at all."

Petra shrugged, grinning, "You didn't bust me so."

"It's no good at all. Redo it all from scratch," Levi ordered, glaring.

"So, in thirty days, we're to go outside the Walls to build a stronghold for the supply chain?" Mike stared out the window, arms crossed. "Not to mention we'll be taking fresh graduates with us too."

"If we even get any new recruits that is." Erwin was drawing plans for the formation for the upcoming expedition.

We got nine of the top ten graduates. Erwin thought, pleased.

Armin, meanwhile, eyed the plans, mind racing, trying to make sense of the drawing.

Mike turned to him, "In my opinion, this is far too hasty."

"Eren's current position is a temporary thing. We must quickly and smoothly prove his usefulness to Central." Erwin tapped the paper with his pencil. "Otherwise, sooner or later, the Police will make another move to—"

"Can't you take that mask off at least for me, Erwin?"

The commander turned to him, smiling. "You're really good at sniffing out things like this, Mike."

He sniffed loudly. "Too bad you have no scent whatsoever."

"Just make him skip showering for a few days, then he'll have a really strong scent. Huh? Huh?" Connie grinned.

"Congratulations, your jokes have reached a Candy-level of lameness," Ymir said dryly.

"I'll tell you when the time is right." Erwin turned back to his work.

The time is right now . Levi thought. They would be taking a break at the end of the episode and it seemed a good time to him. He'd have to talk to Erwin first. Episode 17 was almost here.

Crickets chirped in the dark outside the Special Ops Squad's temporary base.

Inside, they were sitting at the table, drinking tea.

"We'll probably be ordered to stand by for a few more days," Erd spoke, "but I heard we're supposed to be going on a large-scale extramural expedition. And we'll be taking the new graduates with us as well."

"Is this true, Erd?" Gunther asked. "Isn't it awfully soon? Even considering that they handled this last Titan attack quite well."

"I heard those kids' pants required multiple washings to remove the shit-stains," Oluo smirked, holding up his teacup.

"Pompous jackass," Jean rolled his eyes.

"And now you know how we feel about you," Eren grinned.

"Screw you, Bastard."

"Right back at ya, Horse-Face."

These two just can't stop taking shots at each other, can they? Levi frowned in annoyance. He opened his mouth but Petra interrupted. "Shh!"

"Did you just shush me?"

"That's how they bond!"

"Yeah, don't interfere, Levi," Hange nodded, getting an eye-roll.

"Is this all true, Captain?" Petra asked.

"I'm not involved in making our plans. It's Erwin. He's likely considering far more variables that might occur to us."

"It's true that we're in an unprecedented situation," Erd said. "On the one hand, we lost the Maria reconquest route that we established through huge sacrifices, but on the other hand, we got an unexpected ray of hope." He looked to Eren.

The boy seemed intimidated by all pairs of eyes suddenly focused on him.

"I still have trouble believing it. You can 'turn into a Titan,' but what's that mean, Eren?" Erd asked.

"My memories from that time are quite hazy. It felt like a selfless, dreaming state. It can be triggered by hurting myself. Like, if I bite—" Eren held up his hand then froze. *Wait, how do I know this?*

"Did that seriously occur to you just now?" Jean asked. "After all that time in the cell with nothing else to do?"

"Shut up, Jean!" Eren felt his face warm in embarrassment.

"He has a good point, though," Armin thought out loud. "I wonder if it had to do with those weird images we saw in the first episode when Eren was dreaming."

"Could be," Erwin nodded. "His father could have left instructions, maybe?"

"He could have unconsciously tapped into his father's memories," Hange flipped back through the pages of her notebook.

"Yeah," Eren nodded. "I'm sure those memories Armin mentioned aren't mine."

"We've been everywhere together," Mikasa added. "Whatever he saw, we have too. Of course, they could have been from before we met. But the Titans didn't invade until a year after."

"Ah-hah!" Hange read from her notes, "Grisha said something about how 'their memories will tell you how to use it.' By 'they,' could he have been referring to your ancestors?"

"Is it passed down through blood? Was he a Titan Shifter too? There are so many questions," Armin said.

"What'll really help is an insight into Dr. Yeager," Petra said.

"We gotta have a chat with Keith after this," Levi nodded.

Erwin started the episode while Eren's thoughts raced, wondering if his abilities were genetic and if his children might possess them one day. But his father had injected him with a serum. Did he get the power from it or did it activate something he had inside him the entire time?

"You guys know all of this too. We couldn't get any more out of him than what's written in the reports." Levi held up his cup by the rim. "She won't stay put though. Her meddling could even kill you, Eren."

"She? Who?"

They heard a loud slam.

"Did you run into the door?" Sasha snickered.

"It's all Levi's fault," Hange pouted.

Petra removed the wooden bar and Hange entered, one hand on her forehead. "Good evening," she held up a hand, "gentlemen of Squad Levi! Have you made yourselves at home in the castle?"

"You're early," Levi sipped his tea.

"How could I stay put now?"

"Squad Leader Hange?"

"Sorry for the wait, Eren. I'm charged with experimenting on the two Titans we caught alive in the city. I want you to help me out with tomorrow's experiments. I came to ask permission for that."

"An experiment? What am I supposed to—"

"What else but that totally awesome thing you do!" Hange was flushed with excitement, eyes wide and sweating, a mad expression covering her made and fingers wiggling eerily.

"Wouldn't want to be alone in a room with her," Connie shivered and Sasha nodded in agreement.

"What a freak," Ymir said.

Christa gasped. "That's was uncalled for, Ymir!"

"What? It's true."

"Uh…" Eren leaned away. "I can't give you permission myself. I don't have authority over myself, you see."

"Man, look at Gunther's face," Eren grinned. The man in question was sitting inches from Hange's face.

Petra giggled, "He looks so uncomfortable."

"Levi, what are Eren's plans for tomorrow?"

"Cleaning the garden."

"Even that Oluo guy's making the same face," Armin muttered, amused.

"Okay then, it's decided!" Hange clutched the boy's hand. "I'll be counting on you tomorrow, Eren!"

"Probably for the best he's not cleaning the garden. He'd just yank out the good ones and leave the weeds behind," Candy said.

"That's true," Mikasa admitted, getting an indignant noise out of Eren. "Remember that time we were making a bouquet for one of your mom's friends, the one who had just given birth, and half the flowers you pulled were Dandelions?"

"They are bright yellow and look flowery," Eren crossed his arms in defense.

"You're still convinced they're not weeds, aren't you?"

"Yup. And nothing anyone says will ever change that."

"Yes, ma'am. But what exactly are these experiments on the Titans?" Eren asked.

"Hm?" Hange tilted her head up, light reflecting off her glasses.

Eren cringed.

"You had to ask, didn't you, Eren?" Levi said.

"Uh… What exactly are these experiments…" Eren repeated.

"Stop that. Don't ask her," Oluo whispered fiercely.

"For once I think you should have listened to him," Petra said.

"No Petra dear, not you!" Hange cried out.

"Ah, I knew it," Hange stared at him with a dopey expression. "You just had this expression like you wanted to know."

Levi stood up without a word and walked away, his squad following silently after him.

"Now that's teamwork," Candy chuckled.

"What about no one gets left behind, huh?" Eren looked accusingly at Petra.

"Sorry sweetie, you asked, you were on your own for that one."

Levi nodded, "You were warned, brat."

"Oh stop now," Hange waved her hand. "Don't pretend like you couldn't walk away."

"Not for a lack of trying," he grumbled. Every time he had tried to excuse himself, her voice would get higher and she'd lean forward, sometimes grabbing his hand in excitement.

Eren looked confused and a little like he wanted to go after his team.

Hange let go of Eren's hand and took Gunther's vacated seat. "Were you *that* interested? Then I've got no choice. I guess I've

gotta tell you what I know about those pretties we caught earlier."

"I hope Candy reveals the killer's identity!" Hange spoke passionately. "Oh, the things I will do to them..."

"She is one scary lady," Sasha shivered.

"First," she began, "we repeated the experiments we'd done each of the five prior times we had Titans to play with."

"Hello." Hange greeted a tied up Titan while soldiers stood a few feet behind, ready to intervene if necessary.

"First, we attempted communication." Hange's voice narrated.

"How are you feeling? What's your name?" She asked.

The blond-haired Titan was sitting on the ground, a dozen thick, black cords wrapped around its neck and big nails were embedded through its shoulders and its arms to keep them pinned to its sides and the ground. The Titan didn't seem to notice, wiggling around to get to the humans that stood before it.

"Does it hurt anywhere?" Hange leaned in, less than a yard from its face.

"Squad leader, you're too close!" Moblit said.

"Hello." She greeted the second Titan with the brown hair. It was tied up and pinned down as well, lying on the side of its face. "Isn't the weather wonderful today? Are you hungry?"

Its head surged forward and it attempted to bite her.

"I think that's a yes," Ymir said.

"Whoa!" Hange jumped back "Whoa-whoa, that was close!"

"Squad leader, it's too dangerous!" Moblit yelled, worried.

Poor Moblit . Petra thought sympathetically. The guy probably had high blood pressure from working under her.

The scientist inched toward it and was forced back when it tried to eat her again.

"Sadly, communication proved impossible this time as well."

Hange sniffed. "Oh my poor Bean, always trying to take a bite out of me..."

Pale, yellow-orange rays shone down on the almost tired looking brown-haired Titan.

"But for me, interacting with the Titans was so enlightening that it made me completely forget my everyday fatigue."

"A long, long time ago, there was a tribe who ate people." Hange walked back and forth before the two giants. "They weren't Titans like you. They were humans."

"Wait, is she telling them a...a bedtime story?" Armin asked.

"Uh, I-I think so," Jean gaped.

"They hid out in caves in the mountains, attacked travelers who happened to tread the roads nearby, robbed them of their valuables, killed them, and ate their flesh."

"Gross," Sasha wrinkled her nose. Then leaned in, "But interesting."

"She's started another one of her naming ceremonies," one of the soldiers said to his comrade. "What did we end up with last

time?"

"Chicacchironi and Albert." The other one replied.

Hange gasped, remembering them. She pulled out a handkerchief and blew loudly.

"Gross," Levi leaned away. "That's a bathroom right there!"

"Sorry," she wiped her nose.

"They kept up their resistance for 25 years. During that time, over 500 people became their prey. That might be more than the humans you guys ate. They also experimented with various ways of preparing their meals."

"They also partook in incest, that's how many of the grandchildren were conceived," Candy added.

"And I thought they couldn't get any more disgusting," Petra shuddered.

"I didn't know that! That's going in the notes!" Hange said excitedly.

"Turning the buttocks into steaks," Hange continued. "Cutting the thighs up into cubes and cooking a stew with them. They minced, kneaded, and fried the hard meat."

The soldiers around her looked ill, one almost ready to throw up.

"Out of fat and innards, they even made sausages. That's right. They knew the concept of 'cooking.'" She stood and pointed at the Titans, "That's how they were different from you."

One soldier was puking in the background.

"I feel you, man," Connie looked green.

"But then those cannibals made a mistake, and they were all caught and executed."

"The men were castrated and had their hands and feet severed, left to bleed out. The women and children were burned alive after they'd watched the men die."

"Fascinating!" Hange looked awed.

"But why burn the children?" Christa wondered. "Sure they were raised to be cannibals, but at least give them a quick death."

"That's the same as you. You made the mistake of attacking humankind, and you were caught. So I'll name you after the man who led that clan.

"You're Sonny," she pointed to the blond-haired Titan.

"You're Bean," she pointed to the brown-haired Titan.

"But don't worry," Hange smiled. "I won't have you executed."

"But I let you die," Hange said, almost in tears. "And I will avenge you!"

"Nice to meet you, Sonny. You too, Bean. Let's try to get along."

"Thus I named the 7-meter class Bean, and the 4-meter class Sonny."

Soldiers used tents to cover the two Titans.

"Next we tried denying them sunlight. The Titans are clearly less active during the night. These experiments tried to prove that they gain some kind of power from the sunlight."

Armin leaned forward, very much interested in the experiment and the results.

"There was a huge variation between individual Titans."

"You've worked hard, Sonny," Hange spoke to the 4-meter. "Good night. See you tomorrow."

"Sonny's activity dropped an hour after we denied them sunlight. In contrast…"

"You really like to stay up late, huh, Bean?" Hange sat on the ground. "It's okay. I'll stay here with you."

"Bean stayed lively for three hours."

"I wonder why that was," Armin said. "I guess I shouldn't be surprised about the variation. Titans are very different and no one is the same."

Hange perked up, "Do you have any ideas?"

Armin looked a little shy. "They're just theories. Just like humans metabolize food differently, Titans are probably the same with sunlight."

"I was thinking along the same lines as well," she nodded.

"They always manage to surprise me," Hange told Eren. "They don't need water or food. They have vocal organs, yet they don't need to breathe. All they need to stay alive is sunlight. To be honest, I'm curious what would happen if we denied them sunlight completely, but they're such valuable experimental subjects, I can't risk them dying."

"Why not capture one more Titan to test just that theory?" Ymir suggested. "Not like there's a shortage."

"We had to fight a lot with the government just to let two in," Erwin explained. "We need two, at the very least, for proper comparison so that's how many they okayed to be allowed within the walls."

"We killed the previous captures by accident. I accidentally hit the nape of the neck when we tried cutting their heads off," she said sadly.

Eren looked like he wasn't quite sure what to make of that.

"Their names were Chicacchironi and Albert. They had such beautiful smiles. I feel bad about what I did to them." She was silent for a few seconds. "I don't want that to happen again… I'm sorry."

"Squad leader Hange…"

Aw, I kind of feel bad for her. Christa thought. *She really, truly cared for them.*

Suddenly, Hange was in the boy's face, "And then, I moved on to the next stage, testing their sense of pain by actually touching them!" She looked up, fingers twitching, a crazed expression on her face.

"Hwaaaaahhhhh!" Hange screamed, blood and steam coming off the twitching Titan from the spear she had dug into its eyes.

"Squad leader, you shouldn't be the one screaming," Moblit stood by her.

"How could I not scream, doing this?!" She snapped at him. "Bean is in so much pain!" She had tears running down her face. "Don't give up, Bean! Hang in there!" She ran at it, spear in hands.

"I can't believe I'm saying this but I kinda feel bad for the Titan," Sasha said quietly.

Eren stared at Hange in shock, eyes wide and mouth slightly open.

"We had to confirm whether they had any weaknesses besides the nape of the neck." Hange looked solemn. "It was really tough work."

"Sonny? I just pierced your heart." Hange wiggled the spear stuck in the Titan's chest. "Doesn't it hurt? How does it feel?" The blond-haired Titan just stared stupidly at her.

"Compared to Bean, Sonny was a lot quieter. He hardly reacted at all."

The Titan groaned.

"Hm?" Hange moved forward. "What was that?"

"That is disturbing," Mikasa muttered.

The Titan's mouth almost filled the screen. It chomped down, Hange barely dodging in time.

"Squad leader, fall back!" Moblit yelled.

"Haha," Hange laughed in delight, clutching her stomach, "that was really close!"

"You're gonna end up actually dying!" Moblit said in a panic.

Eren was looking at his lap, quiet.

"Bean isn't very good at expressing himself. He just keeps trying to bite my head off."

"Um, Squad leader…"

Hange looked at him curiously.

"How can you stay so carefree in front of the Titans?" Eren asked.

"I just assume she's a nut-job and move on," Ymir shrugged.

"Why are you being so loud?" Christa asked.

"Don't worry," Hange waved. "I've heard worse."

"I'm not apologizing," Ymir said stubbornly, arms crossed when the smaller girl opened her mouth.

"They're our natural enemies," Eren continued, "who drove us to the brink of extinction. I'm sure you've had to face their threat a number of times before yourself too."

"That's right. I've had countless comrades murdered by them right in front of my eyes. Back when I joined the Survey Corps, I fought them, fueled by hate. But then one day I realized It was when I cut off and kicked the head of a 3-meter class."

Hange seemed surprised, watching the head bounce away from the decapitated body.

"It was light. Unnaturally so. Their bodies are light."

Eren looked at her in surprise.

"Normally such huge bodies shouldn't even be able to stand and walk on two legs. It's the same with every Titan. Their cut-off body parts were much lighter than they should have been for their size." She recalled holding up the Titan's severed arm. "I heard that when you turned into a Titan, that body appeared out of thin air. I considered that maybe the things we see are not the things that are actually there."

Eren's mind flashed to his two transformations.

Hange poured a cup of tea and placed it before him, then poured one for herself. "I tried fighting the Titans out of hatred for decades."

That's very hard to picture . Mikasa thought. Hange not loving Titans was as strange to imagine as Eren not hating them and wanting them all dead.

"Now I want to try looking at them from a different point of view than everyone else. It might prove to be futile. But still, I'll do it," Hange said seriously, getting a stunned expression from the boy.

Since I entered the Survey Corps, all I get are surprises.* Eren picked up the teacup and took a sip. *It's not just Squad Leader Hange. They're all weirdos.

The recruits started laughing.

"Is that what you think of us?" Petra chuckled.

Levi raised an eyebrow, daring him to answer.

"I threw my lot in with you so I'm in the same boat here."

"Good answer," Hange laughed.

It's like a haven for freaks. **Eren thought.**

Jean laughed especially loudly.

"What's so funny, Horse-Face?"

"The irony. You used to lose your shit every time someone called the Scouts freaks and eccentrics and here you are doing the same."

"But I don't necessarily mean it in a *bad* way..."

But it's also a group of people who demand change **. Eren thought.** ***That is the Survey Corps.***

"See!" Eren pointed triumphantly at the TV.

"Squad leader Hange, would you be so kind as to tell me more about your experiments?"

"Really?"

What a waste of time. Eren crossed his arms, slinking back into the couch.

"Yes. I think it might prove useful in tomorrow's experiments if I learn as much as I can."

"Right," Hange nodded, cheeks pink in delight. "I did skip over some of the details in my summary earlier. Let me tell you everything then. It may end up taking quite a while though."

"That's fine."

"What else is there?" Armin asked curiously. "Everything the Survey Corps knows, we do too."

"Maybe we should have him on the team," Levi said to Petra. "Least he won't go around asking stupid questions he already knows the answers to and acting like a brat in general."

"Only if we get Mikasa too."

Levi's face pinched. The girl really wasn't a fan of his, which made him slightly uncomfortable thinking she might be his blood. "That's not—"

"I'm already drowning in enough testosterone as it is." Petra crossed her arms. "I think I deserve to have another girl in the group if we're getting another boy."

"I'm in," Mikasa said immediately.

"Frankly I don't see anything wrong with it," Erwin added. He'd be thrilled to have their strongest soldier training someone with the capacity to even surpass him.

"Stay out of it, Erwin," Levi said. "It's my team, the best, handpicked by me. That's what we agreed upon, remember?"

"And that's why she's perfect," Petra insisted.

"Petra, you just said you wanted her because she's a girl. And anyway, don't we had a limited time or whatever?" He looked pointedly at the commander.

"True," Erwin admitted. "We can save the discussion for later."

"When we first captured a Titan, I made a hypothesis," Hange said as the shot turned to the night sky outside the castle.

The night turned into morning.

"So you've learned nothing new from what I told you, right? You should have learned all this as a trainee. You knew it all, right?"

"Yes. There was nothing new." Eren said tiredly, looking exhausted with dark bags under his eyes.

His face prompted laughter from the viewers.

"So let's go over it again, and this time I'll add my personal opinions and assumptions!"

Eren's startled and slightly afraid expression had them laughing again.

"Run, dude," Connie snickered.

"Um," Eren's face and posture clearly said he was grasping for an excuse to flee, "I think we—"

"First of all, the Titans—"

Moblit threw open the doors and barged in, "Is Squad leader Hange here?!"

"The experiment subjects... Both of the Titans were killed!"

Hange cried out as two skeletal Titan remains steamed.

"Sonny! Bean! This can't be for real!" She clutched her hair, falling to her knees. "Someone tell me I'm dreaming!"

Hange sniffed, dabbing her eyes.

Eren watched a grimace, wearing the hood of his cloak.

"Yeah, that doesn't make you look conspicuous or anything," Candy chuckled.

Mikasa snorted. "Whose bright idea was it? He's the only one with a hood on, makes him stand out like a sore thumb."

Eren coughed, looking sheepishly at her. "I thought it was pretty smart at the time. But now that you mention it..."

"Those experimental subjects were very valuable," Gunther said. "Was it a soldier?"

"Yes," Erd looked over at the woman freaking out. "The culprits are still unknown. Both Titans were killed before sunrise. When a guard spotted them, they escaped using their 3D Maneuver Gear."

"So it was a premeditated move by at least two people?" Gunther frowned.

"Sonny!"

"Check it out! Squad Leader Hange is losing her shit," Oluo said.

Petra narrowed her eyes and immediately jabbed her elbow painfully into his ribs, making him cry out.

"Thank you, Petra," Hange beamed at her.

"You're very welcome," she smiled back.

"What on Earth…" Eren muttered.

"Let's go," Levi said. "This is the jurisdiction of the Police." He walked away.

"Yes, sir."

Erwin approached the boy and leaned in, speaking quietly, "What do you see there? Who do you think is the enemy?"

"Excuse me?"

He was silent for a few seconds. "Sorry, don't mind me." He turned and joined Levi.

Eren watched the back of the commander's head as he walked away, stunned.

"Who do you think killed them? It couldn't be one of us since Candy trusts us," Sasha said.

"It could be anyone," Jean's brow furrowed. "One of the trainees or one of the Scouts."

"The question is, who isn't here," Connie said.

"There are only 12 of us here out of hundreds," Mikasa pointed out. "That makes discovering the traitors through the process of elimination rather difficult."

"It might be someone we know."

"You think so, Ymir?" Christa looked worried. "I don't really like the idea of one of our comrades being responsible."

"Whoever killed Sonny and Bean are traitors," Eren said, resolute. "They sabotaged humanity's chances of learning more about the Titans."

"I'm with Ymir," Armin nodded. "We already reasoned it's someone who was present on our side when the Colossal Titan showed up. The only ones present then were the trainees and some Garrisons."

"We were staying pretty close to the Survey Corps' HQ where the Titans were killed," Jean said. "The common factor in the two situations is the trainees."

"Holy shit," Connie's eyes widened. "That narrows the suspect pool a lot."

"But it's not impossible that a Garrison might have pretended to be a Scout and snuck it," Sasha said.

"That's true," Eren said. "It's not like they have anything valuable someone might want to steal. The only guards that were present 24/7 were the ones during the daytime when the Titans were awake."

"Or it could've even been a Scout pretending to be a Garrison soldier at the wall that day," Mikasa added.

They exchanged lost looks.

Connie scratched his head. "This is hard."

In another corner of the room, Levi talked quietly with Petra. "There's something you need to know."

"Okay?" She said curiously.

"It's about the 57th expedition. No one, with the exception of a handful of soldiers, knows the real purpose behind it."

"It's not a test for Eren?"

"It is, partially," Levi nodded. "But the main objective is to discover the identity of Sonny and Bean's killer." He quickly summarized the plan, lying about Eren's position in the formation and the trap setup when the culprit transformed. "Our killer will likely come after the boy once we're outside the walls and out in the open."

"Why didn't you share with the rest of our team? No wait," she closed her eyes for a second, mind racing. "The Colossal Titan first showed up 5 years ago and then the Shifter infiltrated the military. We, myself and the guys, joined up after."

"Erwin figured the ones who were already soldiers at the time were clean. Since you're here, he gave me the okay to fill you in."

"Does that mean we aren't telling the others?"

"It's unlikely any one of them is a mole, but, since we can't be sure, it has to be a closely kept secret." He paused, before asking, "Does it bother you I withheld crucial information from you and the guys?"

"Of course it bothers me." Petra sighed. "We're expecting the regular Titans and maybe stopping Eren if he goes berserk. Not a human spy who could be anyone and transformation at a second's notice with who knows what kinds of abilities. But," she crossed her arms, "we're also the elite team, capable and expected to handle whatever's thrown at us. So I can understand and accept the reasoning. Just doesn't mean I have to like it."

"I didn't expect you to," Levi replied.

"Are we telling Eren?" Petra looked at the teen in a deep discussion with the rest of his friends.

"He'll find out soon enough. I thought you at least deserved the courtesy of learning it from me, instead of finding out like that," he nodded at the TV. Levi thought she looked like she was going to make a barbed comment, but refrained.

"Okay." Was all she said before returning to her spot.

After everyone had stretched, used the restroom, and had a snack, or grabbed more in some cases, they settled once more to continue on to episode 16.

Please Review~

Episode - What Needs To Be Done

Chapter 16: What Needs to Be Done

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The recruits brainstorm, trying to discern the identity of Sonny and Bean's killer. Levi fills Petra in on the true purpose of the 57th expedition.

A finger traced the lines on the paper with the MP Bridge's logo stamped at the top.

A 3D gear, without the gas canisters, lay before it.

"When's the last time the shaft was replaced?" The MP soldier asked.

"Six days ago, after the clean-up operation," Sasha answered.

"That matches the records," a female MP soldier scribbled on her clipboard.

"Okay, next." The man moved on. "You are?"

"Krista Lenz of Squad 42."

"We'll inspect your gear next."

Around the room, 3D gears were placed on the tables with two soldiers standing at attention behind each table.

"Who'd have thought killing Titans was a punishable offense," one trainee said.

"It is when it hurts humanity," Eren said. He loathed the Titans but even he could understand the benefits.

"It does seem ironic, but those two were valuable test subjects," his comrade said.

"Even so, why are they searching for the culprit among us trainees? We just finished cleaning up the battlefield today."

"Yeah, everyone's exhausted from the cleaning."

Nearby, Armin heard them talking. "The culprit must've really hated the Titans," Connie said from the boy's left.

Or was a traitor . Sasha thought. *A spy for the enemy.*

Armin looked to him, "Yeah. But in this case, they ended up helping the Titans instead. They may have fulfilled their personal desire for vengeance, but the net result is a major setback for humanity." He looked straight ahead.

"I think I get why they did it because I can be an idiot myself."

"No arguments there," Jean snorted.

"At least he's honest about it," Ymir said.

"You guys seriously suck," Connie complained, pouting.

"Ignore them," Christa patted his shoulder. "They're just rude jerks."

"We're only teasing, you know," Jean said. *Guess we should tone it down a bit* .

Connie's words grabbed Armin's attention. "Before I'd ever seen a Titan, I was certain I wanted to enlist in the Survey

Corps. But now, I never want to see another one. And today, we all have to decide which branch to join too." He glanced over to his left.

Jean's fist was clenched tight, trembling slightly by his side.

Is Jean seriously… **Connie thought.**

The trainees stood around three circular pyres.

Connie cried, squatting on the ground, his hands clutching the sides of his face.

Everyone's regretting it. **Jean turned his gaze from the boy to the others, Ymir, Christa, Sasha, all with despondent expressions on their faces.** ***If I'd known it'd be this hellish, I'd have never chosen to become a soldier.***

Reiner, Annie, and Bert stood together, blank-faced.

Everyone else looks exhausted or devastated or both. Ymir thought. She wondered if anyone else noticed it as well. Or maybe it was apparent only to her since she already knew they were the Titan-Shifters. *Is it out of respect?* She wondered. Did they think the least decent thing they could do was not to pretend to be sad when they were indirectly the cause of the others' misery?

Now I'm so burned out, **Jean thought** ***, I can't think of anything else.***

He walked toward the crackling flames, kneeling before the scattered little pieces of bones. "Hey, Marco," Jean stared at the white shard in his palm, "I can't even tell which are your bones anymore." His mind flashed back, standing before Marco's mutilated body.

The 104th trainees stared at the flames in silence.

If I hadn't become a soldier, I wouldn't have to keep wondering who'll be on that pile next. **Jean closed his eyes.**

Levi shared that sentiment, having found himself in the same position many times over the years. He was sure every Survey Corps soldier had a moment in their lives when that thought crossed their minds.

"Will we abandon the progress made through countless sacrifices and let the Titans devour us all?" **Eren's passionate words from the graduation party came to him.**

I get it. I know we have to fight. **Jean thought.** ***Still…not everyone can be a reckless idiot like you*** **.**

Footsteps were heard.

Jean looked up and was surprised at what he saw. Or rather who.

Marco smiled, surrounded by light.

Most of the 104th class became emotional at the sight.

It still hurt and pissed them off to think he wasn't worthy enough to be given screen time and shown his death.

"I hope you won't get upset when I say this. But you aren't a strong person, Jean. So you can relate to the feelings of the weak." **Marco told Jean as the two of them were filling up their canisters.** ***"What's more, you excel at sizing up any situation. Isn't that why you already know what needs to be done?"***

Jean's gaze hardened. He stood, staring into the flames, "What…needs to be done…" He turned to his comrades, looking almost ill. "Hey, guys. Have you decided where you're going to enlist? I've made up my mind."

Connie looked up at him curiously.

"I'm…" Jean clenched his hand, "I'm—I'm joining the Survey Corps!"

"That was very brave of you," Petra smiled at the teen.

"I looked ready to throw up," he grumbled.

"Courage means doing something in the face of fear."

Damn it **. Connie eyed Jean's shaking fist. "Hey, Annie. What do you think? Even Jean said he's joining the Survey Corps."**

"Huh? Jean said that?" Armin turned to him.

"Nothing really," the girl answered.

"You're set on joining the Military Police, right? Maybe I should too, shouldn't I?"

She's the only one who didn't join. Erwin thought. But if she had, wouldn't that have been something? The entire top crop of the 104th class, in the Survey Corps.

"If someone told you to die, would you do it?" Annie asked.

"What? Of course not," Connie replied.

"Then why not make your own decision?"

"She's right," Levi said. "It is a decision you have to make yourself." He could still clearly remember that day, after that awful storm in the wide open fields outside the walls, when he had made his resolution.

"Armin," Annie said, "what about you?"

"I think if you know why you have to die, there are times when you must lay down your life. Not that I want to die," he admitted.

"I see," she sighed. "You've made your choice."

"Yeah. I chose where I'd enlist a long time ago."

You're a good person, Annie . Armin thought. No matter how much she pretended to have a cold heart, she wasn't as indifferent to her comrades' safety. As proven by her subtle concern for him and risking herself to save Connie.

"Seriously? Armin, you too?" Connie's head fell.

"You're weak, but you've got guts," Annie told Armin.

"Th-Thank you. Annie, you're actually pretty nice, aren't you?"

Annie turned to him, surprised.

"It seems like you don't want us to join the Survey Corps. Do you have a reason you want to join the Military Police?" Armin asked. Connie was looking seriously ill beside him.

"Not really. It's just…I want to survive."

Well, she's definitely got Armin convinced. Ymir thought. She wondered if his personal feelings would cloud his judgment and prevent him from seeing the truth.

If anyone made a play for Eren, it would either be Annie or Reiner. Bert's Titan was not a combat type. She wasn't entirely sure how they could take Reiner down. *Eren could, maybe* . Annie though, she wasn't sure what kind of Titan the blonde-haired girl could transform into.

Ymir was more concerned about her own status as a Shifter being revealed. The closer they got to the future episodes the more nervous it made her. Even if the focus wasn't on her—she would be

a side character if it were a book or a play—she was still a Shifter. Hopefully they wouldn't react too badly since Candy trusted her enough to invite her.

That was a strange thought. Her loyalty wasn't to these people, except for Christa. She knew herself well enough to know she'd change ties if it meant a better deal for her. *What's it mean that Candy, some kind of goddess, places me in this group?* Was it a divine sign? *Should I tell them about me?*

That would seriously shift the odds, level the playing field for now. Two vs. two Shifters. The Colossal Titan she was sure Squad Levi could handle. Eren's Titan was bigger and muscular than hers, and the boy had some decent background in martial arts. He could be trained further, improve under his squad. Reiner may have his armor but it also slowed him down. Eren had the potential to bring him down. Her own Titan, on the other hand, was small and very agile, she was sure she could take Annie with the element of surprise.

Am I seriously considering this? But if they were to find out, Ymir would much rather be the one to tell them. The Scouts had Candy on their side. Surely that meant they were going to win, didn't it? The more she thought about it, the more convinced she became. *Now when do I tell them?*

Ymir didn't want to say anything quite yet. Currently, no one knew about her. Once it was out, it was out. There was no taking it back. She wanted to be completely sure about it. But if she waited too long, the TV might out her. She had no plans to let anyone know. So far, the focus was still on Eren and Sonny and Bean's killer as far as Shifters were concerned. *I'm sure I can watch closely and figure out when future-me will reveal the truth* . Still, she didn't want to wait too long.

Maybe after episode 20? When they would take their next break. That was less than two hours away. It felt way too early. Maybe she'd do it after the main episodes ended. If it was possible, she would try. Her secret gave her a big advantage, one she wasn't willing to lose

until necessary. *I still have time.* There was no rush. She'd watch and act based on what she saw.

At the old castle where Eren was currently hiding out with his new squad, a horse raced with its rider.

"It looks like they couldn't find any soldiers who used their Maneuver Gear without permission," Gunther sat, holding a mug. "Then who did it?"

Erd took a sip from his mug. "No idea. Right now, I'm more worried about the upcoming induction ceremony. How many of the new trainees are actually crazy enough to join us?"

"Hey, Eren," Gunther called out. "Are there any people in your class who'd join us?"

Eren was standing by the horses, holding a bucket up to one, "There are some. No, there were some. I don't know about now."

Would Marco still have joined the Police? Jean thought curiously. Unlike him, the freckled boy wanted to join the MP Bridge out of good intentions. And he would have done some good there. Jean knew it was the most corrupt of the three branches. Or would he have caught Crazy and jumped the wagon with the rest of the idiots who'd picked the Survey Corps?

Seeing his best friend again had brought back that feeling of loss. Jean knew he had made the right decision by enlisting in the Corps. And Marco's death was a contributor in making that choice.

The sound of hooves was heard and Erd and Gunther immediately put their mugs down, with the the Special Ops Squad's second-in-command yelling, "Attention!"

Levi stopped before the duo. "Get ready to leave. We're heading out on patrol."

"Yes, sir!" They replied in unison.

Eren quickly raced toward them and saluted, "Good morning, Captain Levi!"

"Listen, Eren, never stray more than two horse-lengths from me. Don't forget that the only reason you're not locked up is because I'm watching you," Levi told the Shifter.

"Yes, sir!"

"Let's go."

The four galloped on their horses.

"Where are you and the Pompous Jackass?" Connie asked Petra curiously.

"I stayed with Hange's squad instead of returning with my team. There were some last minute details to work out regarding my part in the upcoming expedition since I will be the one relaying messages and such for Captain Levi," Petra explained.

Levi made a face, "Bozado had to clean the kitchen. It was his turn to cook and he made a huge mess."

Reiner, Ymir, Bert, and Christa were waiting together in the courtyard along with the other trainees. Soon it would be time to pick a division.

Annie, Armin, and Sasha were leaning against the wall, Connie crouching next to them. They looked up when Jean approached them.

"Jean," Armin said. "You're really joining the Survey Corps?"

"Yeah," he confirmed calmly.

"Why the change of heart?" Sasha asked. "I mean… Aren't you scared?"

Jean had his hands on his hips. "Huh?" He tilted his head. "Of course I don't want to join the Survey Corps."

"You're an odd one, Kirstein," Hange said.

Why is she of all people calling me odd? Jean wondered. "I'm just an honest person."

"Th-Then why would you?" Connie asked.

"It's not that the Titans don't scare me anymore either. And I won't spout nonsense like, 'The best belong in the Survey Corps.' I'm not as eager to die as some are."

"You mean Eren?" Connie looked down. "He's already joined the Survey Corps."

"Trainees, line up! Line up in front of the stage!"

They began moving, following the man's directions.

"Line up before the stage!"

Jean stood with his friends. "You know, I'm not risking my life because someone convinced me. This is a job you can't do unless you decide for yourself." He turned and walked away as Connie stood up.

"Hey Eren, despite your contestant prattling about joining the Survey Corps and killing all the Titans, I think I'm the one who convinced the others to join without even trying," Jean smirked arrogantly.

"Don't be ridiculous," Eren scoffed. "Didn't you just say it's a decision you have to make for yourself?"

"Yeah, but, I gotta admit, it did influence my decision," Connie said.

"Especially after getting us to the HQ so we could get the gas and save ourselves," Sasha added.

"Ha! See?" Jean smiled triumphantly.

"Come to think of it, Eren's non-stop whining made me not want to join the Corps out of sheer annoyance," Ymir said.

"Stop exaggerating," Eren rolled his eyes. "I couldn't have been that bad, right Christa?"

"Um," the beautiful girl hunched her shoulders. "Well, I knew you lost your family and home to the Titans so I could understand."

"Even Christa can't deny how annoying you were," Jean pointed. "She's just being nice about it."

"Alright," Erwin interrupted when neither teen looked ready to back down. "Once again, a discussion that can be saved for later."

The sun had set, the night sky now dark. Torches lit up the courtyard as the trainees stood at attention before the stage where the tall, blond-haired man stood.

"I am Erwin Smith, Commander of the Survey Corps. Today, you will choose a branch of the military. Putting it bluntly," Erwin peered down at them, "I'm here to persuade you to join the Survey Corps. During their recent attack, you learned how terrifying the Titans can be, as well as how limited your own strength is."

Some of the trainees, including Armin and Mikasa, stood blank-faced while others, including Sasha and Connie, were staring nervously.

"However," the commander said, "that battle brought humankind closer to victory than ever before. The key was Eren Yeager."

Said teen was riding with his team.

"By risking his own life, he's undoubtedly proven himself a great ally to humanity. With his help," Erwin glanced to his right, "not only did we stop the Titans' advance, but we've also obtained a key to discovering their true nature."

That grabbed the trainees' attention, with the looks and sounds of surprise everywhere in the crowd.

"We believe that the basement of his old home in Shiganshina District holds answers about the Titans that even he doesn't know."

"And so much more," Candy teased.

"I really wish she would just tell us," Mikasa sighed.

"That'd make it too easy," Eren said. "No, I take that back, we are about to watch the future so I guess it is easy."

"And it'll ruin the fun, too."

"The fun?" Mikasa raised an eyebrow. She could not understand how it was remotely 'fun.'

"What?" Ymir shrugged. "I'm trying to think of it from Candy's point of view. It's like a story for her. She could have started off with Eren's transformation, instead we watched Eren, Mikasa, and Armin struggle."

"That's right!" Sasha said. They would have known it was legit without watching all the earlier episodes.

"Yeah," Armin nodded, eyes wide. "Losing our home, joining the Trainee Corps, the Trost battle, and soon the 57th expedition."

"They're the main characters of this narrative," Petra said. "And we're watching them grow."

"I cannot imagine what kind of power it takes to do all this," Erwin gestured to the food and the TV.

"Yeah, it's not so far-fetched to believe she's put it together like a story," Hange nodded.

"We're like ants to her," Levi frowned.

"That's creepy," Connie shivered. "Not that I think you're a creep or anything," he said worriedly to the ceiling.

"I don't think she's offended," Christa assured him. "She seems very...laid-back."

Ymir snorted, "She calls herself Candy of all things. I don't think she intends for us to take her *that* seriously."

"Well, if no one else has anything to say, let's get back to the TV," Levi said.

"Oh yeah!" Hange beamed. "Next episode is the future."

Dismissing the story-style format, the group quickly focused their attention, eager to get to the 57th expedition.

"If we can reach that basement, we will find clues to ending this century of Titan domination," Erwin said.

A quick flash of the wrecked Yeager house appeared on the screen. Half the structure had collapsed. Sunlight shone

through the hole and on the still standing door that was a part of the stone wall.

"And now we have confirmation the house didn't collapse and bury the basement," Hange said.

Whispers picked up.

"The basement?" Reiner said. Bert was looking very surprised next to him.

Others began to speak.

"We've already advanced that far?"

"If we learn what they are, we can end this!"

***No matter how much he needs recruits, I can't believe he's publicizing this information* . Armin thought. *Or…does he have some hidden motive? What is the commander trying to smoke out?* Erwin was looking around, observing the trainees' reactions.**

He really is very sharp. Erwin thought. *Maybe Levi was on to something, having the boy join his squad. Or maybe Hange's.*

"We aim to reach the basement in Shiganshina District." The commander looked where Hange, Petra, and Mike stood with two other Scouts. "However, that requires us to retake Wall Maria. In other words, our objective remains the same. But with the Trost gate sealed for good," at Erwin's nod, Petra and Mike unfolded the map and held it up for display, "we'll have to take the long way around from Karanes in the east."

Jean laughed, "Why are the shortest and tallest people from the group holding up the map?"

"It's lopsided," Christa giggled.

The others chuckled as well. The trainees hadn't really noticed at the time, too distracted by Erwin's words and the atmosphere.

Petra rolled her eyes, "Well *apparently* the two guys had very bad stage fright and refused to do it. And Hange—"

"Thought it would look hilarious!" The bespectacled woman grinned.

"The four years we spent laying a route for a full-scale army have gone to waste. In those four years, more than sixty percent of the Survey Corps lost their lives," Erwin told them. An image of Petra and Levi with the wounded man from an earlier episode appeared for a second. "Sixty percent in four years. An insane figure."

Petra clutched the folded map in her hands, grim.

"Those of you who join us will participate in our excursion beyond the walls next month. We expect thirty percent won't return. In four years, most will be dead." Whispers had picked up once again. "But those who make it through will become superior soldiers with a high survival rate."

No one looked eager to join.

"Now you know the discouraging facts. Any of you still willing to risk your lives, remain here," Erwin said.

Mikasa stared ahead, expressionless, while Armin looked determined. Sasha and Connie didn't look too terribly thrilled. Annie was stoic as usual and Jean's expression appeared slightly anxious.

"Ask yourselves: Are you willing to offer your beating hearts for humanity?"

The trainees were mostly intimidated.

"That is all. Anyone who wishes to join another branch is dismissed."

"Commander," one of the Scouts took a few steps forward.

Stage fright my ass . Petra folded her arms.

"Don't you think that was too much? You might have scared them all off," he said worriedly.

Many trainees, including Annie, began to leave. Bert watched them nervously.

Jean shifted his gaze from the ground…and was stunned. It looked as if everyone around him was leaving. His comrades were experiencing the same thing.

Damn it* . Jean stood rooted to his spot as a sea of trainees passed him by. *Come on, you've already made your choice!* His legs were frozen. *Don't make me hate myself any more than I already do.

***I have to get away now, or else…* Sasha thought, scared.**

I left the village to join the Military Police.* Connie gritted his teeth. *My Mom would be so happy. If I join the Military Police, the whole village would think better of me.

The trainees continued to leave.

The three were torn and clearly distressed.

We all know.* Jean thought. *We've already seen it.

Sasha squeezed her eyes shut. *How the Titans…*

… *eat humans!* Connie was trembling, eyes closed.

An image appeared, their worst nightmare, Jean on the ground, helpless, as Titans clutched Sasha and Connie and other comrades, about to eat them.

Jean opened his mouth and let out a primal scream, full of anger and fear and doubt.

Eren grimaced. He hadn't realized how hard it was on them to make that choice. *And they still did it. Scared, utterly terrified, but they still did it.* He subtly watched them, noting the emotional expressions on their faces.

It felt like everyone *was leaving* . *Yet they stayed strong.* Petra thought. She could identify with that feeling. As if a massive wave was washing over her, an invisible force pushing her to be washed away with them. And that was before she'd ever seen her first Titan. The pressure on them must have been far worse.

"Could you…die if you're ordered to?" Erwin asked.

"We don't want to die!" Someone yelled.

A few of them who were brimming with emotion chuckled.

"I see," Erwin smiled. "I like the looks on your faces." Then his voice became louder and stronger, "Now then, I welcome all of you to the Survey Corps! This is a true salute! Offer up your hearts!" He saluted.

"Yes, sir!" The newest members of the Survey Corps saluted.

"Guys…" Armin looked at the ones who had stayed.

"This is the pits," Jean said. "The Survey Corps…"

"I'm scared," Sasha whimpered. "I want to go home."

"Well I'm sure if you took off running right now you might make it," Candy giggled. "You can claim it was only temporary

insanity, not permanent, as your defense."

"You do need a certain type of mindset to join," Christa nodded.

"Even a lot of the Scouts have admitted it's practically a requirement," Armin agreed.

"Can't deny that," Hange shrugged.

"I don't even care anymore," Connie said weakly.

Reiner was standing silent and Bert was sweating bullets.

"If you're gonna cry about it, you should've left," Ymir told Christa, who appeared frightened.

"You've done well to endure your fear," Erwin spoke. "You are brave soldiers. You have my deepest respect," he told the less than two dozen that remained.

Ymir looked around. Bits of that fear still reflected in her fellow recruits' faces while the veteran Scouts looked on with pride. Except Levi, who looked bored. "What's with those faces?" She couldn't believe the words that were about to come out of her mouth. They would lift their spirits even more than usual if they'd been said on a regular day. "We have Candy."

That cheered them up.

"No way we can lose," Connie grinned.

"She can't stop us from being eaten," Mikasa pointed out.

"But if we do get eaten, we'll know when and where so we can avoid it," Sasha smiled.

"That's right, we have a goddess on our side," Hange said.

"Don't get arrogant," Levi warned.

"Levi's right," Erwin nodded. "We must still remain vigilant. Growing lax will get us killed out there."

"Even if you survive against the one that was supposed to kill you, that doesn't mean you won't get killed by something else later on." Petra's words were met with solemn looks and nods of agreement.

"We can't let our guard down, no matter what," Christa said seriously.

Humanity's future may be assured by watching these episodes and careful planning, but our individual lives, they could be snuffed out at any given moment. Armin thought.

Four horses were seen on the screen.

"Did you know, horses aren't colorblind? They can see yellows and greens better than purples and violets," Candy said.

"Wow," Christa said.

"That's amazing," Hange said. "I have to experiment that! Sounds like something fun I can do in my downtime!"

How's that relevant? Levi wondered.

"Salute!"

Mikasa, Armin, and the others saluted.

"I'm Squad Leader Ness," the man in the white bandana said. "And this is Charlotte, my horse. She loves to chew on people's hair, so be careful or you'll wind up prematurely bald. Nice to meet you all!" At that moment, the mean-faced horse grabbed his hair. "H-hey! S-Stop it, Charlotte! Someone grab her!"

No one moved.

"Hey, Jean—"

"So help me Candy if you make a horse joke, Yeager."

"The training that began the next day, instead of practical training, was mostly memorizing the long-range scouting formation Commander Erwin had devised."

Ness was lecturing at the head of the class, the formation displayed on a long sheet behind them.

"Strangely,"* Candy continued, *"although the formation was written out in precise detail, Eren Yeager's position was nowhere to be found."

Ness used a long stick to tap spots on the map. "You new recruits will be here, in between the recon support team and the supply wagon escort team. Your jobs will be to ride alongside the spare horses and relay messages." Armin took notes.

Levi was petting his horse while most of his team was gathered around the small map.

He's even shorter standing next to his horse. Connie tried hard not to snicker. He didn't want Levi beating the crap of him. Unlike Eren, his teeth weren't going to grow back.

"Like Tallahassee says, appreciate the little things," Candy said. "Now hug a short person."

"Don't you dare," Levi glared at Hange.

"I was reaching for Petra I'll have you know," she sniffed. "Who'd wanna hug you?"

Sasha and Ymir squashed Christa and Connie between then, ignoring the boy's complaints as the girls giggled.

Armin was glad none of his couch-mates tried to embarrass him.

"We of the Special Operations Squad will be here," Gunther pointed, crouching, with the paper on the ground, "standing by in the center of the last ranks."

"We're pretty far back," Eren noted, Petra looking over their shoulders.

"It's the safest place in the formation. We're even more heavily guarded than the supply wagons. We don't have a real objective this time." Gunther turned to him, "This expedition is so brief because it's a practice run for your journey to Shiganshina."

"Um, I still don't know what this power should be used for," the Shifter said.

"Did you understand what the commander's question meant?"

***"Who do you think the enemy is?"* Erwin's question came back to him.**

"Did you all understand?" Eren asked his teammates.

It's so obvious now . Eren thought.

"No," Erd answered and Petra shook her head.

"It would be an overstatement to say I understand it all," Oluo looked over his shoulder, standing by his horse.

"Is this guy still trying to act cool?" Jean rolled his eyes.

"That said, I—"

"But I think it's possible this mission has another goal," Gunther interrupted, rolling up the paper, completely oblivious.

The group snickered.

"But the commander has decided it'd be best not to reveal that objective. So we should just focus on getting there and back. Trust in the commander."

Levi was confident no member of his squad was a traitor.

"Right," Eren said.

"That's all the training for today. Prepare to return to base."

The sun was setting when the squad returned to the castle.

Eren finished mucking the stables and came outside. Oluo was leaning against the wall, drinking from his mug. "Guys," Eren noticed his best friends walking by. "Oluo, may I go talk with my friends for a bit?"

"Jeez, just go already."

"Hey, Mikasa! Armin!" Eren ran after them.

They turned, Mikasa gasping, "Eren!"

"It feels like it's been forever!" He smiled.

"Oh Mikasa," Sasha chuckled.

Mikasa was staring at the Shifter with wide eyes, disbelieving, hands halfway up as if to snatch him. "Eren," she grabbed his

hands, "did they do anything bad to you? Like expecting every bit of your body."

"What do you take us for?" Petra asked, half amused, half serious.

Mikasa fiddled with her scarf. "I was...worried. I was there during the trial, remember? And I've heard about that one," she nodded at Hange.

The scientist pouted, "I wouldn't do that to Eren...without permission."

"You don't have it!"

"That's not up to you." Eren was not surprised at being ignored.

"Did they psychologically torture you?" Mikasa asked, distressed.

"No, nothing like that," Eren reassured her.

Mikasa's face became dark and furious. "That midget bastard crossed the line. Someday, I'll make him pay for it."

All pairs of eyes turned to Levi to see his reaction. He didn't seem too worried. Internally it really stung. His only potential relative and she hated his guts. How the hell did that happen?

"Given some time, I bet she could take him," Ymir muttered.

"You don't mean Captain Levi, do you?"

"Like Godzilla vs. King Kong," Candy snickered.

While Eren's friends greeted him, Levi took his horse and walked away.

"I wonder who's who?" Armin said. They sounded like monsters. Appropriate, considering Levi and Mikasa practically were monsters

compared to the rest of the humans.

"Yo, Eren!"

"It's been so long!"

"What? Everyone's here?" Eren looked at all the familiar faces. "But if you're all here, then… Doesn't that mean all of you joined the Survey Corps?"

"Why else would we be here?" Connie smiled.

"Then the only ones who picked the Military Police were Jean, Annie, and Marco?"

Jean walked up behind the Shifter.

Eren noticed them looking behind him and turned. "No way… You too?!"

"Marco's dead," Jean said plainly.

"What…did you say?" Eren looked like he was in denial. "Did you say Marco's dead?"

"Not everyone goes out in a blaze of glory. I don't even know how it happened," Jean's head bowed. "He died alone, without anyone seeing or knowing."

"Marco…" Eren was stunned, his comrades equally down.

"Hey, newbies!" Ness called out, the man next to him holding folded cloaks with the Wings of Freedom insignia. "Get over here! Your uniforms are here!"

The new recruits pulled on the cloaks. Eren watched their backs, the Wings moving in the wind. One turned around, revealing himself as Marco.

Yeah . Jean smiled at the TV. *He would definitely have joined with us.*

"Are you really…" Eren began.

"Yes, we'll all be participating in the mission too," Mikasa said. They were indoors, speaking in private.

"Hey, Eren," Jean said. "I heard that when you turned into a Titan, you tried to kill Mikasa. Mind explaining yourself?"

"That's wrong. Eren was trying to hit a fly—"

The ridiculousness of the response made the group burst out in laughter and Levi raise an eyebrow.

" *What?* " Petra choked out between giggles.

"That's a terrible excuse!" Hange chuckled.

"I didn't ask you. That wound on your cheek looks pretty bad," Jean tapped his cheek. Mikasa clutched her hair to hide it. "When did you get that?"

Eren looked down. "I think it's true. When I became a Titan, I tried to kill Mikasa."

"So you don't really remember it, huh? In other words, you didn't even know you had this Titan power, and you still don't have the means to control it."

"Yeah, that's right."

Jean exhaled and turned to address the rest of them. "Did you guys all hear that? That's the situation. Humanity's existence,

and our lives, depend on him. We'll probably die just like Marco, without Eren even noticing."

It's what Armin was saying earlier. Eren thought.

"Jean, what's the point in asking Eren these questions now?" Mikasa demanded.

"You know, Mikasa…" Jean looked over his shoulder. "Not everyone can blindly die for Eren like you, without anything in return."

Mikasa didn't like the reply but couldn't say anything in return.

"We deserve to know what we're dying for. Otherwise, we'll hesitate when the time comes. We expect something out of Eren. Let's see what he has to offer us. And whether it's worth our lives." Jean walked up to his rival and grabbed his shoulders, looking rather intense. "So, Eren, we're really counting on you, okay?"

"Yeah…"

Bells rang out loudly.

"Here it comes!" Christa gushed.

"Commander, it's almost time."

The soldiers were ready, waiting at the gates.

"We've driven all the Titans out of the area."

Levi and Petra were staring straight ahead.

"Thirty seconds until we open the gate!"

Eren's attention was pulled to the side by children's voices. A boy and a girl were watching from the window of their home.

"It's the Survey Corps!" The little girl said.

"They call that emblem on their backs the Wings of Freedom!" The little boy explained.

"So cool!"

The group beamed at them.

Eren smiled at them before looking forward with a look of determination.

"It's time! Humanity will take another step forward."

Mikasa and Jean appeared on the screen.

"Show us what you're made of!"

Sasha, Christa, and Ymir appeared next.

The soldiers held up their swords, letting out a loud battle cry.

It was all the group could do not to jump up and scream along with them.

"Open the gate!"

The gate began to rise, showing the silhouettes of the commander, Hange, and Mike.

Hearts began to pound furiously in anticipation.

"Forward!" Erwin commanded, his horse racing on. "We will now begin the 57th expedition beyond the walls! Onward!"

Cheers broke out around the room.

"Whoo-hoo!" Sasha jumped up. "Yeah!"

"We're here!" Jean and Armin high-fived.

The exhilarating atmosphere from the episode and the excitement that they'd made it to the future was overpowering, causing everyone to yell out and grin.

"The future!" Christa tugged Ymir's arm hard repeatedly, thrilled, and the dark-haired teen laughed, nodding.

"I'm so excited and nervous!" Petra placed her hand over her racing heart.

"I can't believe we're about to watch the future," Mikasa said in awe.

Eren was grinning widely. "I can't wait to see how much ass we kick!" He was impatient to see his first expedition and hopeful he might have a chance to kill some of the ugly giants. It wasn't likely considering Gunther's words but he was still optimistic since he had yet to kill a Titan as a human.

"Finally, we're at the good part." Levi had an eager expression on his face, eyes bright.

"Soon, my babies!" Hange cackled like a maniac. "Soon!"

Erwin was so overjoyed he was unable to keep the massive smile on his face down. "If everyone could calm down, we'll—"

"Onward to episode 17!" Connie pointed at the TV dramatically, standing.

His declaration was met with cheers and the first future episode began.

*I'm gonna have so much fun ruining their happiness and devastating them in the Female Titan arc ^_^*

Please Review~

Episode - The Female Titan

Chapter 17: The Female Titan

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Ymir decides she will reveal herself as a Titan-Shifter soon. The group is excited to move on to their first future episode.

"Hello, beautiful viewers, Candy here with a quick message before this episode begins."

"Is she raising the episode count again?" Mikasa wondered.

"I hope so," Sasha said excitedly. "It could mean more future episodes!"

"You have finished watching the past, events you have already lived through or knew about. So I will try to keep my commentary to a minimum from here on out."

"Oh, too bad," Sasha said.

Christa pouted. "But I really liked the stuff about the ocean and the desert and the Northern Lights."

Connie nodded. "And it was funny too!"

"Her commentary was so helpful," Hange looked disappointed.

"Hopefully she'll continue to do that," Erwin said.

"But let's be honest, I'll still keep running my mouth because I run this show."

The group perked up at her words.

"Now, have fun!"

A large dust cloud rose above buildings, the sound of countless horses running echoing through the broken, abandoned city. The horses galloped, the Wings of Freedom flying on one man's cloak.

The loud members of the group let out shouts of joy. They were too excited to contain it.

Leading the charge were Erwin, Mike, and Hange. Mike looked to the side and Hange turned her head as well. "10-meter approaching from the left!"

The brown-haired Titan with a large, protruding belly was seen through the buildings.

"Wow, it looks pregnant!" Connie said.

"I am very interested in seeing what's inside its stomach."

Two Scouts flew toward it.

"But I'll leave it to the support team!" Hange said.

The ugly giant tried to swat the first man and missed. He quickly flew by its nape, a small chunk of flesh flying. "Shit! Not deep enough."

"Defend the formation!" The other Scout yelled. The Titan tried to grab him and he dodged. It swatted at the rooftops to try to get him, looking frustrated.

Sasha whimpered, flinching.

"Stay strong!" Her squad leader grabbed her head, turning it forward. "Leave it to the support team, and keep going!"

Keep calm . Sasha inhaled and exhaled. *Deep breaths!* She couldn't tell if her heart was pounding out of excitement or fear. Likely both. *You're okay!*

The soldiers raced straight ahead.

"Onward!"

Mikasa, Jean, Bert, and some others appeared in the shot.

"Onward!"

Connie was seen followed by Armin and Reiner.

Levi's squad appeared next.

The formation chart was open on the ground.

"The support teams will only accompany us to the old city area," Gunther said with Eren and Erd sitting beside him and Petra leaning down to look at the chart. Oluo was standing lazily against his horse. "Once we're past that, it's completely Titan territory. The long-range scouting formation devised by Commander Erwin is our only hope."

Eren listened intently.

"We, the special ops squad, are here."

"Oluo, sir, can they…do you think the recruits can beat the Titans?" Eren asked.

"What have you been doing the past month? Listen, brat, the most crucial part of an expedition is in how you *avoid* fighting Titans—" Oluo bit his tongue.

The group began laughing.

"Serves him right," Mikasa muttered.

The soldiers had reached the outskirts of the city.

Erwin threw out his left arm. "Go into long-range scouting formation!"

Groups of soldiers began to split off from the main host.

"See ya, Armin," Reiner moved away.

"Even if you run into a Titan, don't piss your pants," Jean said, falling back on the short teen's left.

"Right! Same to you, Jean."

Jean's stomach was in knots. *Will we make it? How many will we lose? Who won't be coming back?* Even if they could learn when and where someone would die, watching it happen was not going to be pleasant.

An overhead shot of the Survey Corps appeared, the squads all becoming a drawing, represented by horses. One horse was red, while the rest were white, signifying a person's location in the formation.

The formation was made up of five parts. The vanguard, row 1, in the front. The center, row 5, the safest place, with communication on either side, rows 2 and 3. Between

communication and the center were the supply carts, row 4. Each of the rows was further split up into sections.

Row 3/3: Communication: Mikasa's current location.

"The vanguard is to spread out in a semi-circle. But stay within visual range of one another," Erwin commanded.

Row 5 Center: Standby, Eren was between Petra and Oluo.

He's not too far from me . Mikasa thought. Having learned her lesson, the burden of responsibility for the lives depending on her, she wouldn't abandon her post to go to him. It was just reassuring to know he wasn't across the formation and too far out of reach from her.

"Position yourselves at fixed intervals."

Row 2/5 Communication: Reiner, Bert, and other Scouts appeared in the upper right of the formation.

"Extend the recon and communication range as far as possible."

Row 3/4 Communication: Jean's present location on the right side.

Row 2/4 Communication: Armin, in the northern part of the formation.

Armin's not too far either. Mikasa thought. Though she wished he was closer.

A lone building, a few trees, and the Wall in the distance, everything became sharper. Armin looked around, breathing audible. His horse let out a huff. There was a second horse tied to his. Two birds took off to the skies and his head snapped up.

Armin clenched his hands. He unclenched them and wiped his clammy palms on his thighs. *I'm too anxious. I need to calm down.*

It's fine. **Armin assured himself.** ***Calm down!*** **A shot rang through the air. He watched a red flare go up.**

"It's primarily the Scouts of the first row, the recon squads, that will encounter Titans." A flashback of Ness' lecture appeared, the man tapping the top of the formation.

1/8 Vanguard: The soldier noticed the approaching Titan and loaded up a flare.

"As soon as one is sighted, they'll fire a red smoke round."

Noticing the red smoke, another Scout shot a flare of his own.

"Anyone who sees the flare should fire the same round to relay the signal," **Ness narrated.**

Center: Erwin's location.

"When the commander sees it, he'll fire a green smoke round, and show the formation where to go."

Multiple trails of red smoke were drifting up to the sky. Erwin shot up a green flare, signaling a change in direction.

"Thus, the entire formation can advance toward the goal, while avoiding Titans."

Row 2/3 Communication: Sasha looked at her surroundings nervously.

"But—"

Sasha groaned quietly. *Why does the but have to be for me?!*

"—sometimes, due to terrain or obstacles, a Titan won't be sighted until it's within the formation."

A Titan scurried between the wreckage, appearing before the brown-haired teen at the end. She yanked the reins and her horse took off, away from the giant lunging after her.

Sasha sat stiffly on the couch, oozing off tension in layers, face pale. *I'm going to die! I'm going to die!*

"Red flare! Red flare!" She fumbled with the capsule and ended up dropping it.

"Sasha!" Christa cried out in panic.

Stupid brat. You had one *job.* Levi thought.

"Way to go, butterfingers," Ymir snorted, hands gripping her biceps tightly.

"How the hell did you drop it?!" Connie screeched.

"You idiot!" Jean yelled, face contorted in fear.

"I'm going to die!"

The capsule exploded in red smoke under the Titan's hand.

"Sasha, this way!"

She looked over, seeing two soldiers. One shot a red flare.

"Damn it! One got through! We gotta draw it away!"

"Blaus, get over here!"

"Why is it crawling like a stupid spider!" Sasha wailed. That made it even more terrifying.

"Shut your trap," Levi snapped. "It's not real. At least not yet. So pay attention and don't make the same mistakes again."

"Yes, sir," she whimpered.

The Titan chomped down, barely missing the screaming girl. The two soldiers raced by and it followed them.

I'm alive! I'm safe! Sasha almost cried. *For now!*

"I'll handle it! Split off!" The older man ordered.

"Yes, sir!" He moved away, the Titan now only chasing after his superior.

It crawled after the man with freakish speed. The soldier cried out and pulled away at the last second, the Titan running into the tree face first.

"Nice one," Petra chuckled with the others.

Sasha slowed, breathing loudly, "sir!"

"Back into position! It ran out of gas." The two hurried away.

A scarlet haze tinted the light blue sky with the white and grey clouds.

Something's wrong.* Armin had a solid grip on his flare gun. *It's been a while since we saw the red smoke round, but the formation is still off.* He stared in the distance, noting the clear skies. *It can't be…

"However, this strategy only works on normal Titans, whose behavior can be easily predicted."

A shot rang out.

"Hange, make a note when and where there's trouble in the formation," Erwin said suddenly.

A black smoke round? **Armin thought.**

"Way ahead of you." The scientist noted the appearance of an aberrant Titan near Armin's location.

Is a Titan ignoring the nearby humans and heading for the formation's center? **Armin held up his gun and fired off a shot, traces of black smoke near his hand.** ***It has to be!***

Two soldiers came out of the forest, followed by a Titan. It walked straight but stiffly as if the soldiers chasing after it weren't there at all.

"That's an aberrant!" Armin said.

"It's only necessary to fight aberrants, whose behavior is unpredictable."

"Damn, we'll have to fight it," Ness cursed. "Siss, go for the neck! I'll stop it!"

"Roger!" Siss yelled from the other side of the Titan.

Ness pulled out his blades. ***Using Maneuver Gear on flat terrain is a huge disadvantage. It almost never works. But I can't let it disrupt the formation.*** **He glanced over.** ***I think that's Arlert over there. I don't want one of the new recruits to run into it.*** **He carefully stood on his horse.** ***I have to stop it here!***

The hook embedded into the Titan's heel and the soldier surfed on the ground, using the momentum from the aberrant to move. With a thrust of gas, he surged forward and severed the tendons, causing the giant to fall.

"Awesome!" Eren said, holding up his fists. He simply could not wait to see himself in action.

"Now, Siss!"

The younger man wasted no time launching himself at the exposed nape and slicing off the flesh, killing the aberrant.

"You did it, Squad leader Ness!" Armin smiled widely.

"Yeah!" Connie grinned.

"Great teamwork!" Sasha beamed.

"That's an effective method," Jean nodded, keeping in mind to practice a similar move before the expedition. It would be helpful if he ran into an abnormal Titan.

Armin's smile dropped when he noticed something.

The group's smiles dropped as well, their expressions becoming serious, anxious to see what had grabbed the boy's attention.

"Did I get him?" Ness wondered. A mean-faced horse came to him. "You came for me? That's my partner." He quickly mounted her. "I love you, Charlotte!" The horse galloped by the steaming corpse. In the distance, a figure was moving toward them.

"What's that?" Christa squinted. "Something's...it's running."

"Judging by how big it appears from a distance, it has to be a 15-meter," Petra said.

"Another aberrant? You sure are lucky!" Hange told Armin.

"That's not the word I'd use," the boy muttered.

The sound of footsteps was heard. Ness and Siss looked over their shoulders. "Again? What is the right flank recon squad

doing?" Siss said.

"If it ignored them and came this way, it must be another aberrant. We've got no choice then…" Ness pulled out his blades. "Let's do it again, Siss."

"Right!"

Something felt off. Levi couldn't quite put a finger on it. Something about that Titan wasn't right. And...

"But we've got the worst luck, doing this twice in a row. And I think it's at least a fourteen-meter class. This one will be tough."

The music. Levi realized. It was dark and foreboding. *Shit's about to go down.*

The footsteps were almost upon them and Ness looked over his shoulder, gasping at the sight.

The Female Titan raced toward them, passing between the two horses.

"HOLY SHIT!"' Hange screamed, out of her seat. "IS EVERYONE ELSE SEEING THIS?!" She stood ramrod straight, utterly shocked.

"It's got TITS!" Connie yelled, pointing at the TV.

"What the *fuck?* " Jean gaped.

"What's going on?!"

"What is that thing?!"

"Is it female?"

"There's never been a female Titan before!" Petra looked on in amazement.

Annie . Ymir's eyes were wide. *I should have known it would be her* . Reiner's absence would be noted and hard to explain. Annie, on the other hand, she could easily slip in, disguising herself as a Scout and hunting Eren without fear of exposure. *So, this is her Titan form, huh?* It was very muscular and fast. And the girl was an expert at martial arts as well. Ymir wasn't sure if she liked her odds if she went up against the other female Shifter. *I'm gonna need that element of surprise.*

Too many people were speaking at once, causing a ruckus.

"She looks scary, I hope I don't run into her."

"What do you think she wants?"

"I get the feeling she's not friendly."

"Could she be like Eren?" Armin wondered.

"SWEET SINA!" Hange broke out of her frozen stupor. "I've never seen a female Titan before! Who is she? Where did she come from? What does she want? What can she do? I'm using SHE as a pronoun for a TITAN! Oh, Pixis would DIE of jealousy right now!" She ran up to the TV, hands on the screen, practically drooling.

"Hange—" Erwin began.

"My PRECIOUS! Once I get my hands on you..." She laughed like a B-movie mad doctor.

Levi made a sound of disgust. The screen was made of glass and it would smudge. "Get your goddamn hands OFF the TV, Four-Eyes! You're ruining it!"

The woman was too thrilled, shrieking like a banshee, babbling away.

"Hange, please, I think you—"

"—maybe she wants to MATE with our EREN!" Hange yelled, looking like she was on the verge of a seizure from pure joy.

Silence.

Erwin sighed, face in hand.

"Um, ew..." Christa made a face.

"That's gross," Ymir looked disgusted.

Sasha shuddered. "Why would you say that?"

"Is that even possible? Cause he's got no, you know..." Connie trailed off.

Petra winced. "Oh Rose that image."

"Ugh, great, now it's in my head!" Jean complained.

Eren was horrified and Mikasa looked irritated.

The voices picked up once again.

"Where the hell did she come from?"

"Who do you think she is?"

"It's gotta be a Shifter, right?"

"Does she really wanna mate with Eren?"

"Stop SAYING that!" Eren screeched.

"What else could she be?"

"I'll kill her!"

"I mean it could be an aberrant."

"No way. That doesn't make as much sense as a Shifter."

"Hey, so what if it really does want to mate with—"

" *Nobody* is MATING with me! Ever!"

"I'm just saying, man. I mean, she's pretty decent looking, for a Titan."

"Yeah, at least she's got a nice ass."

"Then you can fuck her, Horse-Face!"

"ENOUGH!" Erwin ordered loudly. The room fell silent. If they continued like this every future episode, he didn't think they'd have any time left over. Maybe the extra time Candy had given was because she had predicted such reactions from them. "Now, Hange, please remove yourself from the TV and sit back down." The scientist did as she was told, pouting.

"You smudged it!" Levi immediately pulled out a handkerchief and went to the front of the room to clean.

"Everyone, please calm down so we can get back to the episode and move on."

A few dirty looks were exchanged before the grumblings quieted.

Once the corporal returned to his spot, Erwin hit play.

Armin fired a black smoke round. "What's that?" His arm dropped limply by his side. "It's too fast!"

"Don't let it reach Arlert! Siss!"

"Yes, sir!" He jumped off his horse and flew toward the Female Titan. Coming in a wide arch, he cried out, blades ready.

The Female Titan ducked her head and caught Siss. She clutched the wires in her other hand and spun Ness and smashed him into the ground along with Siss. A body bounced once, bloodied and completely broken.

This won't end well. Sasha felt uneasy.

Everyone had fallen silent, the charged and happy atmosphere now solemn and heavy.

The Female Titan planted her foot in the ground, skidding to a stop. Armin watched the tall figure with an open mouth.

"RUN!" Eren screamed in panic.

Then she started moving. Startled and afraid, he pulled at the reins.

Mikasa clutched the blond-haired boy's hand, staring at the TV with silver eyes full of fear.

The horse galloped away.

The Titan's footsteps thundered behind him.

"Lose the other horse!" Jean yelled.

"No… No…." His face was twisted into an expression of disbelief. "That's no aberrant. It's intelligent! Like the Armored or Colossal Titans, or Eren… A human in the body of a Titan!" The Female Titan continued in pursuit. "B-But who? Why? This is bad! What should I do?"

She was close now.

"I'm going to die, too. I'll be killed!" He looked at the reins in his left hand. "Go! Run away!" He yelled at the second horse. It split off and fell back.

A massive foot came into his peripheral vision. Armin looked straight up. The Female Titan was above him now, her face blocked by the sun.

What does it… **The boy thought. Her hair fell like a curtain across her face.** ***No, what do they… What do they want?***

The foot came down.

A battleground appeared, Titans picking at the numerous corpses scattered around.

"NO!" Mikasa gasped, heart skipping a beat.

"Where is it?! What happened?!" Eren demanded.

"I'm dead," Armin's eyes glazed over, body slack.

"You're not!" Petra said sharply. "It looked like her foot was to the right of you. And we didn't see it happen!"

"We didn't see Marco either," Sasha's shoulders slumped, her expression downcast.

"Petra's right," Ymir said. "You're important, remember? Candy would make a show of your death, without a doubt."

"Th-thanks," Armin swallowed with difficulty, heart racing.

"Someone tell them…" An injured Scout said. "That the right flank recon squad has been wiped out…"

"All of them? She killed them...all?" Christa whispered, horrified at the wrecked bodies with pools of blood littered around the ground.

"Bitch," Jean gritted his teeth, scowling.

"A female Titan brought a huge Titan army!" The lone survivor spoke, blood covering his eyes, his right leg in the hands of a Titan.

"What? How?" Sasha gasped.

"Did they mindlessly follow her?" Christa wondered. "Or did she lead them?"

The Titan picked him up and opened its mouth. "Is anyone there?"

The Female Titan's foot came down next to him and Armin gasped, the force knocking him off his horse and to the ground, his hood falling into place.

"See?" Connie said in relief. "You're fine! Well, not fine..."

Armin's arms trembled as he pushed himself up. A loud crash and the ground shook when the Female Titan landed in a crouch near him.

"She hasn't any sex organs either," Hange stared. "So maybe she doesn't want to mate with Eren."

The Shifter was too worried about his best friend to care at the moment.

Long and slim white fingers reached out to the frozen Scout.

"Her fingers are made of bones!" Hange gasped. "Fascinating!"

Armin felt his hood being lifted. He looked up at the Female Titan. Dirty blonde hair, blue eyes, thin lips, an angular jaw.

How do they not see it? Ymir thought. *It's so obvious.*

Armin watched her, stunned, as she stood up and took off.

"You're safe," Eren's shoulders slumped in relief.

Why did she leave him be? Jean wondered.

"What?" Armin mumbled.

"He's alone," Mikasa fretted. *And he doesn't have a horse!*

Armin sat, staring at her retreating form, with no idea about what was happening. "It's not going to kill me? What just happened? It removed my hood…to, to look at my face?" He touched his face, body trembling.

As we thought, she's trying to find Eren . Erwin folded his arms.

"Armin!" Reiner reached him, a second horse in tow.

"Reiner!"

"Thank goodness!" Christa smiled, glad one of their top graduates was there. *He's safe! Reiner's there! Everything will be okay!*

"Hey, can you stand? You won't last outside the Walls unless you're on horseback. Hurry!"

"Yes!"

The two galloped after the Female Titan.

"I saw the smoke round signaling an aberrant. Was it that one there with the nice ass?" Reiner asked.

The Scouts laughed.

"I love this guy," Connie grinned.

"Still the wise-ass," Jean folded his arms.

"I must say, I really like him," Petra said. "He's amazing! I'd love to meet him."

"Yeah, Reiner's great!" Eren beamed.

Mikasa nodded, a small smile on her face. "I think he'd really like you too."

Meanwhile, Ymir wondered what Annie's reaction would be if she found out Reiner was checking out and talking about her ass.

"That's no aberrant," Armin replied. "It's a human in a Titan body!"

"What?" Reiner said in surprise.

"Wait a second. We need to fire a smoke round first." He loaded up the gun, talking to himself. "H-Hurry! I must signal them about the emergency over there."

A shot was fired by a soldier coming up behind them.

"Wait," Reiner looked back. "I think Jean fired it."

Another shot was heard.

"It came from the right flank. Does that mean we're so compromised, we can't continue the mission?" Reiner wondered.

Jean caught up to them, "Looks like the right flank recon squad was partially wiped out by Titans. I don't know all the details but they all attacked at once and they were fast. They're doing what they can to hold the Titans back, but recon is no longer possible."

Armin and Reiner listened to him quietly, grim.

"We've taken heavy losses, and if we aren't careful, we'll be annihilated."

"It came from the same direction," Armin said. "No way… Was it leading the Titans?"

What if she has that power? Erwin's brow furrowed in thought.

"So she can somehow attract Titans to her," Petra thought out loud. "Is it because it is likely female or because that is its 'special ability?'"

"I believe it may be the latter," Hange said. "We're gonna have to be careful about that."

Connie groaned, "Because they weren't hard enough to defeat when they were just stupid fucks."

"That?" Jean looked at the Female Titan. "Why is a Titan over there? Is it an aberrant?"

"No, it's different. It's a human in a Titan body. Someone with the same ability as Eren."

"What?"

"Why do you think that, Armin?" Reiner looked at the blond-haired boy.

"The Titans only eat us. We're just killed in the process. Killing us isn't their goal. But when its weak spot was targeted, it caught the soldiers and smashed them into the ground. It killed to kill, rather than to eat."

The Female Titan continued to run.

"Its nature is different from the others. When the Colossal and Armored Titans destroyed the Walls, it must've been the one that brought that army of Titans. They worked together and their goal has consistently been to attack all humanity!"

It was because of her. Eren gnashed his teeth, fists trembling, glaring fiercely. *They followed her in and Mom—*

Rage overpowered any sense of thought and his vision tinted red.

This fucking bitch! He thought viciously. *It's all your fault!* Blood rushed through his veins, heart hammering against his ribcage, he couldn't wait for the 57th expedition, knowing she would be there. *I'm going to tear her limb from limb and rip her fucking head off!*

The idea of sinking his teeth into her skin, the sound of flesh being torn, bones shattered, and the metallic taste of blood in his mouth, it was intensely satisfying to imagine.

Eren relished at the thought of yanking the traitor out of the wrecked Titan corpse and twisting her in his hands, making her scream in unimaginable pain, then brutally severing her at the spine into two bloodied halves. He wanted nothing more than to make that violent fantasy a reality, body shaking slightly in anticipation of inflicting agony on the Female Titan the likes of which she'd never forget.

***No, maybe not…* Armin thought to himself. *It felt like it was looking for someone. If that is the case, could it be looking for…* Then it hit him. "Could it be looking for Eren?"**

I fucking hope so . The male Shifter thought.

"Eren? Eren's with Squad Levi on the right flank, where it came from," Reiner said.

"The right flank?" Jean turned to him in surprise, along with Armin. "The plans I got had them to the rear of the left flank."

"Mine said they were near the front of the right. But there's no way they'd be on the front lines," Armin said.

Everything clicked in Armin's head. "That's your target, isn't it?" He blurted out.

"Armin, what are you talking about?" Mikasa asked, still clutching his arm.

"I'm not surprised you figured it out," Erwin replied. "To answer your question, yes. The real purpose of the upcoming expedition isn't really to test Eren, but to catch the traitor in our midst."

"So you knew about the Female Titan?" Sasha asked.

"Why not warn the soldiers?" Christa added. They could have lived if they'd known what was coming, instead of approaching her like they would any other Titan and getting killed.

"We didn't know who the traitor was," Levi answered. "If too many people knew, it could have tipped our hand."

"So you set a trap, huh?" Ymir said. "How did you know it would work? That you could catch her."

"We didn't know exactly what kind of Titan she was," Hange admitted. "But we are fully prepared—"

"Really?" Ymir looked skeptical. "How could you possibly be fully prepared without knowing the full extent of a Shifter's abilities?"

"We studied Eren's transformed state in great detail for the past few weeks," Hange answered.

Ymir was not impressed. "Eren didn't even know he was a Titan-Shifter until he transformed by accident. And it seems to me that every Shifter is different. Even if Eren, without any memories, somehow managed to figure out everything about his Titan-form, it doesn't mean the same goes for the others. What about that surprise ability of hers to call Titans? You didn't know about that. What if she fell into your trap but you didn't take that power into account because you had no knowledge of it and she used it to flee? What then?"

"Then we'd take care of it," Levi answered. "There isn't a Titan that we haven't been able to kill. The same goes for her."

From the lack of expression on Petra's face, Ymir wondered if she'd known. Because if she hadn't, the female Shifter wasn't convinced even the most elite squad could get away unscathed. "I suppose," she agreed casually, "your team would know what was coming and be prepared to deal with an intelligent human inside the body of a Titan."

"Did you guys do some training exercises with Eren in his Titan-form?" Jean asked curiously, unintentionally continuing Ymir's needling to drive in—and find out—just how unprepared they really were.

"That must've been really tough but really helpful!" Connie nodded.

Eren, who had been silently sulking at not being in on the secret though not all that surprised, spoke up, "Well, no, we didn't. I didn't know, to be honest."

" *What?* She's coming for him and you didn't even bother warning him?" Mikasa scowled. "And how are you prepared to fight an unknown Shifter without any practice whatsoever?"

"Your entire plan is based on the unlikely assumption all Titan-Shifters are like Eren," Jean's expression clearly stated just how little faith he had in it.

"We thought out the trap very carefully—" Levi began.

Mikasa wasn't deterred. They were supposed to be protecting Eren. But how could they when they were so unprepared? "What exactly have you been doing the past few weeks?" She demanded.

"Obviously Eren isn't the traitor," Christa shook her head. "Why not take the opportunity to learn? I don't think there is any way fighting a

regular Titan is anything like taking on a Titan-Shifter. They have the best of both worlds," she pointed out.

Petra kept silent. After all, Levi was the one who had chosen to keep it from the rest of their squad so he could address the teens' very excellent questions and observations. "You're underestimating my squad. It isn't solely their skills as individuals but as a team that makes them so strong. You wouldn't have these doubts if you'd ever seen them in action. I'm confident in their abilities to handle anything that's thrown at them," Levi repeated the redhead's words from earlier.

Jean was the one to pick it up. "Wait, does that mean you didn't even tell your own squad?"

Me, I can understand, but the others? Eren thought. If Levi really had as much faith in the rest of his team as he claimed, he wondered why the man hadn't let them in on the secret. Did he not trust them enough to keep it to themselves?

"Captain Levi is right," Petra said. "That is our job. To eliminate any obstacle that stands in the way of the goal. It's not our place to know everything. Our job is to follow orders, not make them."

"It's because they joined after the attack on Maria, right?" Armin had been thinking it over.

"The fate of humanity depended on the real plan not being found out," Erwin nodded.

"Except it doesn't," Sasha muttered. Because humans weren't on the verge of extinction like they'd been lead to believe.

"I'm still not convinced," Ymir shrugged.

"I suppose we will find out," Levi glared at her.

He's just pissy because we called them out on how foolish their half-baked plan really is. She thought. They could have easily explained the training with Eren's Titan to the Special Ops Squad as practice for the Armored Titan since they would likely be the only team capable of taking it down, and Eren was the closest substitute. Instead, they were going in blind. *They're so screwed.*

"So where is he?" Reiner asked.

"He must be in the safest place in the formation," Armin answered. "Which means in the center, and towards the rear."

"Armin!" Jean said. "There's no time to think. The smoke rounds aren't enough to communicate how much of a threat this Titan poses. At this rate, it'll wipe out the commander's troops. Then the formation will fall apart, and we'll all die."

"What are you trying to say?" Reiner asked.

"I mean, at this range, we may still be able to draw its attention. We can buy enough time for their escape." Jean looked down. "Maybe. Just a chance."

Christa couldn't believe this was the same guy who had openly claimed his desire to join the MP Bridge to live an easy life.

"But it really is intelligent," Armin said. "To it, we are nothing but insignificant insects. It'll just crush us."

"Seriously?" Jean smiled sarcastically. "That's scary," he chuckled.

"Hey," Reiner said, "are you really Jean?"

"My thoughts exactly," Eren muttered.

"The Jean I know never thinks of anyone but himself."

"Don't be an ass." Jean stared ahead, "I just don't want to be disappointed by the ashes of the people I never knew. I…I know what I have to do now," he said passionately. "And this is the job we chose. So help me!"

"Admit it," Jean smirked, looking at his fellow recruits' awed faces. "You think I'm cool."

"I might have," Mikasa said, "if you hadn't opened your mouth just now."

Jean made a face and cursed internally while the others giggled.

"Put on your hood. As far forward as you can so that your face is hidden from it." Armin's words took Jean by surprise. "I don't think it will kill us until it knows who we are!"

"I see," Reiner grinned, pulling up his hood. "It won't kill someone who might be Eren. That's reassuring enough. Let's just hope it has poor eyesight!"

Reiner's words once again made them chuckle.

"Armin… I thought it was creepy how you always clung to Eren. But I've always thought you had it in you," Jean pulled up his hood.

Connie snorted, "Seriously dude?"

"What? It's true."

Eren was tempted to defend his best friend but then realized that would only prove Jean right.

"Um, thanks. But 'creepy?' That's really mean."

The trio came closer to the Female Titan, nodding at one another.

Armin went to her right. ***It's going much more slowly than when I first saw it. Is it tired? If it runs at that speed again, we'll be too late! Now's our chance! We have to do it now!***

Reiner was behind her with Jean riding on her left. ***Remember what I said.*** **Jean thought.** ***Try to draw its attention for as long as possible, to give the formation time to withdraw! Keep it here as long as you can.***

The Female Titan's legs came into view.

If we could cut its Achilles tendon, that'd be more than enough . But don't do anything stupid. Don't try to kill it! **Jean knew it would attack if they tried, instead of ignoring them.**

It's aware of the weak spot on its neck. **Armin thought.** ***It's totally different than other Titans. It is impossible to kill. At least, not by any normal human being. However…*** **His thoughts turned to Mikasa and Levi.** ***But those two might be able to…***

"Hells yeah! Mikasa could do it!" Connie cheered.

Jean nodded, "Those two are probably the only ones who could possibly survive single combat with that thing."

"Can you imagine them teaming up?" Christa said in excitement.

"No," Ymir said dryly. "Because one would kill the other."

Jean held up his sword. He stood on his horse and jumped. Armin noticed the Female Titan looking over her shoulder at them. Jean shot his hook to her legs and she dodged, sending the boy flying straight back by the force of the swipe of her hand. Another swipe of her hand and Armin was knocked off his horse, losing his sword and gear, bouncing off the ground before his body slid to a stop.

Jean's eyes widened and he ran toward the boy.

If she killed him! Eren and Mikasa's thoughts turned murderous simultaneously.

Reiner ducked as Armin's horse flew by .

Armin weakly opened his eyes. They became impossibly wide, seeing the Female Titan crouching before him.

"Armin!" Jean shot a hook into the back of the Titan's shoulder. Immediately she turned to him. *It's way more agile than the others!* He flew toward the giant. *Damn it!* She spread her knee out and budged her muscles, dislodging the hook. *I…I underestimated it!* She swiped at him and he ducked under the arm, flying behind her back.

The Female Titan covered the back of her neck with her left hand.

***It's protected its nape?!* Jean's hook embedded below the hand.**

"Jean!" Reiner yelled, watching the teen unable to do anything but hover in midair.

Shit! I can't get away! I'm going to die!* Jean looked panicked. *It'll grasp my wire and kill me!

A few strangled gasps escaped Petra and the recruits, and the veterans tensed.

Fuck. Jean's eyes were wide and terrified. *I'm done for now.*

Armin pushed himself up, head down, hair covering his face, upper body parallel to the ground. The Female Titan swung her fist toward the teen in midair.

"Jean! Avenge the Suicidal Bastard who rushed to his death!"

Armin?* Jean noticed the Titan's arm. *It stopped?

"What the..." Jean gaped, amazed he wasn't a mess of skin and bones on the ground.

The others held their breaths, bodies stiff with tension.

"That's the one! That's the bitch that killed him! Avenge the guy who rushed to his death on the right flank!" Armin screamed. The Female Titan was still.

Jean crashed to the ground. *What's going on?*

They exhaled, bodies easing now that the tall boy was out of immediate danger.

He stood up and ran to a tree, one arm leaned against it. *Is he going crazy from the concussion? This isn't the time for that!* He turned his head to the side. "R-Reiner?"

"What is he doing?" Sasha gaped. "Is he going to try to kill her?"

Armin meanwhile wondered what he was doing. He knew he wasn't sprouting nonsense but he couldn't figure out why. *I'm missing something!*

"It crushed my best friend! I saw his body under its foot!"

Reiner jumped off his horse and shot a hook toward the Female Titan's neck. *He's going straight for the neck?* Jean thought. Reiner flew toward her, blades ready. *No, it's working! While it's distracted by Armin!*

The group's excitement lasted for a micro-second.

The Female Titan looked at the teen, smirking.

A knot formed at the pit of Armin's stomach. *No...*

Casually she caught Reiner.

Jean and Armin gaped, mouths open.

Their utterly stunned expressions were mirrored by the viewers.

"I-It can't be," Connie stuttered.

"No fucking way." Eren was unable to believe it.

"Not him," Petra gasped.

Erwin stiffened. *She's too strong!* There was no way any Scout but Levi's squad and Mikasa could stand up to her.

She won't go down so easy. Hange grimaced.

Reiner struggled in her grasp.

Maybe I'm wrong! Armin thought optimistically.

She pressed her thumb against his face and pushed him in, squeezing her hand.

The sound of tearing flesh was heard and blood squirted around the big fist.

Christa let out a cry.

"What the hell..." Mikasa stared, shocked.

The corner of Levi's lips turned down. He had really thought Reiner, of all the new recruits, would make it. *Just goes to show how unpredictable it is out there.*

"Reiner," Sasha's eyes filled with tears, along with her comrades.

I don't buy it! Ymir scowled fiercely.

"H-Hey…" Jean stumbled back, in shock. "Come on Reiner, no…"

Blood sprayed up and Reiner spun out of the open hand, blades broken and covered in blood from the Female Titan's severed fingers.

Armin's breath caught in his throat.

Screams of joy and cheers erupted around the room.

"I should've known!" Eren jumped up.

"You stupid, beautiful bastard!" Connie yelled, jumping up as well and wiping away the tears. "You're too stubborn and too awesome to die! I mean Jean, sure—"

"Hey!" But Jean was grinning widely.

"Thank the goddesses!" Christa sniffed.

"He's alive!" Sasha threw up her hands.

Knew it. Ymir thought. "He's too good to die so early," she said for their benefit, a big, fake smile plastered across her face.

Petra exhaled in relief, "I really thought he was dead!"

Another potential candidate. Levi thought. The 104th class was impressive, filled with many talented soldiers.

Jean gaped as Reiner flew down and grabbed Armin, running fast.

They cheered him on.

The Female Titan watched her steaming palm.

"Ha-hah! Surprise, bitch!" Connie laughed. "You can't believe it either, can you?!"

Reiner pulled it off!* Jean ran away. *Mikasa was around so I forgot. But he's really reliable and insanely skilled too!

"We've bought enough time!" Reiner yelled, running with Armin tucked under his right arm.

Some giggled at the sight.

"Let's get the hell away from it! If it isn't a man-eater, it won't follow us!" Reiner looked over his shoulder. The Female Titan stood up. After a few seconds, she took off running in the other direction. "Look! That big bitch got scared and decided to go home!"

The group burst out into laughter, Reiner's words making even Levi chuckle.

Huh? Why?* Armin looked over his shoulder to see her running away. *It's headed towards the center rear… Is it heading for Eren?

The joyful atmosphere dimmed once again.

"Did she give up on them?" Christa asked worriedly.

"Or did she figure out where Eren is?" Petra frowned.

"Maybe," Hange said. "But not to worry! For everything is going according to plan!"

Armin's heart sank. Was it really what he was thinking? *How is it possible?* The proof was undeniable. *I could still be wrong!* He thought desperately. He really hoped he was. *Maybe the TV will prove me wrong!* Deep down he knew he was right. *I hope it proves me wrong...because otherwise...*

Please Review~

Episode - Forest of Giant Trees

Chapter 18: Forest of Giant Trees

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The group is shocked by the Female Titan's appearance. The recruits learn about the plan to capture her and don't have much faith much in it. Armin figures out who she is.

A whistling sound echoed as the shot displayed the green, grassy field with a few groups of small trees. Jean stood on a rock, whistling, with a horse standing obediently beside him. Behind them, Reiner knelt behind Armin. "How's your 3D maneuver gear looking, Armin?"

"It's fine," Armin sat still. "The clasp released like it was supposed to, so it seems it's not broken."

"I see," Reiner unrolled a bandage. "I'm glad to hear it. But what do we do?" He looked over at Jean, who was still whistling loudly. "We only have one horse. If Jean's horse comes back, the three of us can move, but…"

***What the hell?* Jean glanced at the horse beside him. *Reiner's horse returned, so why didn't mine? We can't stay here any longer.* Fingers in his mouth, he began whistling again. The field before him lay empty and peaceful, no sign of life. He pulled out his fingers, coated in saliva.**

Levi wrinkled his nose. *That's disgusting* . He had an urge to wipe his own hands and to tell the teen to clean his fingers.

"Maybe you should try neighing instead," Eren snickered.

Jean flipped him off in response.

Worst comes to worst, we'll have to leave someone here* . Jean looked behind him. *But how would we decide who to leave?

Why do I get the feeling I'll be stuck making that decision? Jean's stomach twisted.

Eren's smirk fell and he and Mikasa looked between the real and the TV versions of the teen anxiously. Surely he wouldn't leave a comrade behind?

***Armin, since he's wounded? Or Reiner, since he's big and would have trouble riding with someone else? Or should I run and try to find my horse?* Jean looked down. "Shit!" He cursed. *Why the hell do I have to think about this? We all made it through that fight alive. But now we have to leave one person behind?* He began whistling for his horse once more.**

Armin was staring at the ground, silent, remembering laying on the ground, eyes widening when the Female Titan's face came into clear view.

While everyone else stared intently at her face, Ymir, sitting at the farthest left, subtly studied them instead. *He knows!* Her eyes widened. *Smart boy* . Unlike most of the others, Armin wasn't looking curious, but grim, resigned almost. Jean and Hange had odd expressions as well.

"She looks kinda familiar, doesn't she?" Ymir said offhandedly.

"She does," Jean's brow furrowed at the face frozen on TV. Erwin was watching them curiously, wondering if they could possibly know her.

"And that expression too," Christa nodded.

Mikasa, who had been holding onto the blond-haired boy tight, noticed him stiffen. "Armin, what's wrong? Do you recognize her?" She could see the wheels turning behind his eyes.

Everyone was suddenly staring at him. Armin's eyes shifted left and right. "Well," he licked his dry lips and cleared his throat. "I...may have a guess."

"Who is it?" Eren demanded immediately.

"Is it someone we know?" Connie asked.

"Well, um..."

"Spit it out," Levi snapped, earning a glare from Mikasa.

He took a breath. "I think it's...Annie."

" *What?!* " Eren stared at his best friend, gobsmacked.

"No way!" Connie cried out. "I don't believe it! She wouldn't do that!"

"It can't be Annie!" Sasha gasped. "I, I don't believe it!"

"But... *why?* " Christa's eyes were impossibly wide in disbelief.

"Makes sense to me."

Now all eyes were on Ymir. "You can't be serious!" Sasha gasped.

"You think that too?" Christa frowned.

Ymir held up a finger as she listed her reasons, "Let's see: she's blonde, she has blue eyes, she's not part of the Survey Corps so she could easily infiltrate and move around without raising suspicion—it would've raised a lot of flags if she was the only survivor while the rest of her squad and the squads wherever she'd been told Eren was had been annihilated."

She was interrupted before she could finish. "That's bullshit!" Eren glared. "She's fucking *blonde* ? Are you *serious* ?!"

"Yeah," Sasha nodded. "That's just...I don't think it's her. She's our *comrade* ."

"She wasn't invited," Erwin said.

"But neither were Reiner and Bert," Sasha pointed out. "And the other members of Squad Levi."

"Candy doesn't like her either." Petra recalled Annie saving Jean, whom Candy had claimed was her favorite, yet their host still expressed dislike of her.

Ymir nodded, "She did almost turn Jean into a pancake just now."

"No! It isn't her! It isn't Annie!" Eren insisted. "There has to be a mistake!"

"Are you really that dense, Yeager?" Jean demanded. "Or are you just that in denial you can't even see the obvious?" He hated the fact as much as anyone else of the 104th class, but that didn't make it any less true.

"I have to agree with Eren," Connie said. "Annie saved my life. She could've let that Titan kill me if she really was a traitor."

"She's my friend! Annie is *our* friend!"

"Armin, are you sure?" Mikasa ignored the male Shifter's babbling. She wasn't a fan of the girl. But she wasn't quick to condemn a comrade either. Then again, considering who the accusation was coming from...

"I'm pretty sure," Armin answered, not happy. "It wasn't just the things that they said that convinced me. Specifically, it was when the Female Titan froze when I yelled she had killed 'that Suicidal

Bastard' on the right recon flank. She stopped because she thought she'd accidentally killed her target and was calling my bluff. But..."

"How would she know who the 'Suicidal Bastard' was?" Hange looked grave. "Unless she was a part of the 104th class."

"Yes," Armin nodded. "Who else could have recognized that nickname? If you take everything else into account, it fits."

"But..." Eren said helplessly. "She's—"

"Don't you fucking dare utter the word *friend* , brat," Levi warned. "The proof is right before our eyes. She slaughtered countless Scouts," his face darkened, "and almost killed one your friends. If you make excuses for that bitch because you wanna bone her I swear I'll—"

"That's enough now," Erwin held up a hand, trying to stop the snowball from gaining more momentum and getting out of control. "Right now, it is looking like Annie Leonheart might be the Female Titan. However, we have no need to fight among ourselves. We will find out soon enough, without a shadow of a doubt, who the new Shifter really is."

While everyone quieted, looking uneasy and unsure, Armin tried not to let his mind race, trying to follow Erwin's words. There was one more piece of evidence that convinced him, which he kept to himself. Ymir, Hange, Levi, and Jean were pretty convinced while Eren, Sasha, and Connie weren't. And Petra, Christa, Mikasa, and Erwin were trying to remain neutral so far. But if he dropped that particular bomb on them...

Armin decided he would keep his suspicions about Annie's hand in Marco's death to himself and let the TV reveal the truth without his comrades tearing at each other's throats over his theory, arguing if it was true or false.

"Armin… Hey, Armin!" Reiner's voice snapped him out of his stupor. "You still dizzy?"

"Yeah, my head's still a bit fuzzy."

"I see." Reiner stood. "But we must decide. It's a hard choice, but someone will have to stay behind."

Jean stopped whistling and looked at them.

"Wait!" Armin stood up. "First, let's fire a smoke round. If the formation continued straight ahead, the 4th row's 3rd team should be nearby."

A purple flare shot up to the sky. Some horses were seen running fairly close to the trio.

"It looks like there's someone riding one of the horses," Petra squinted. They may have lucked out. She hoped they had and none of them would be forced to stay behind. That would be a cruel twist of fate, surviving the cunning, murderous Female Titan only to potentially die because they were one horse short.

"That's the signal for an emergency," Jean put his flare gun away. "But I can't imagine they'll understand our intentions just from that," he walked away.

"Armin, we can wait another three minutes. By then, we must decide—"

"I'll stay," he said strongly, taking Reiner by surprise.

Armin was half expecting his friends to protest. A small smile formed on his face when he realized while they weren't thrilled about him offering to stay behind, they had enough faith in him as a soldier not to claim he was crazy and scold him, saying Jean or Reiner should be the ones to stay behind instead.

"But there's something I want you to tell them for me. Preferably to Commander Erwin alone."

"No, Armin. You should tell him yourself."

They could hear the smile in Jean's words and their hopes went up.

"Looks like someone's coming," Jean had his hands shading his eyes, trying to see in the distance. "And with two horses!"

Jean relaxed. They would all be okay, thanks to their savior.

"That's Christa!"

"You're a lifesaver," Jean looked over at the blonde-haired girl. She beamed, blushing slightly and feeling warm as everyone smiled at her, their eyes bright.

"Is everyone okay?" Christa rode toward them.

"That's my horse," Jean said when they came to a stop. "Whoa, whoa. Calm down, Buchwald."

"He ran toward me, terrified. Did you engage the Titans?"

"All the horses are trained not to bolt in the presence of Titans. How'd you screw up yours?" Connie snorted.

"It was his first expedition!" Jean said defensively. "He's never been around a Titan before and that titanic bitch is fucking terrifying."

"Armin, what happened to you? Are you okay?" Christa asked.

"Yeah, I think so."

"I can't believe that smoke round brought you here," Reiner said.

"I was nearby, and I already had Jean's horse."

"Even horses like you. You're an extremely nice person. You saved our lives."

There were tear in her eyes. "But I'm so glad that the worst didn't happen to you." Christa wiped her eyes. "I really am glad you're alive and well," she smiled cutely at them and sunlight suddenly struck her, with heavenly music playing in the background.

Most of the viewers chucked at the sight.

The three boys gaped at her with almost identical expressions of awe.

God… **Armin thought.**

A goddess… **Jean thought.**

I want to marry her. **Reiner decided.**

That made the group burst into laughter.

"And me!" Connie declared.

"Yup," Sasha said.

"Can't blame them. I'd wanna marry her too!" Hange grinned. Petra nodded, giggling, and even Eren tilted his head in agreement, smiling.

Ymir sighed, "Why do you have to be the most beautiful human ever? Look at all my competition."

"Stop teasing," Christa pouted, now very red, though feeling as peaceful and light as a cloud in a pretty blue sky. She was glad the tension had eased and the atmosphere wasn't as stifling now.

She didn't know the other short blonde girl well. Annie had mostly kept to herself and had rarely talked to her. Christa had no idea what

to think of the situation. She hated the idea of one of her comrades, someone that was supposed to be their friend, was a traitor and responsible for causing so much misery.

"Well, we should rejoin the formation as soon as possible," Christa said.

"Yeah," Jean agreed, "there should be orders to retreat." The four quickly rode away. "To think we've been pushed back, less than an hour out of the Walls. This isn't a good start. And for some reason, that monster didn't go for command up front either."

"Monster?" Christa repeated.

Suddenly, green flares flew toward the sky in front of the forest to their left.

"Green round?" Jean said, startled.

"Looks like they're continuing the operation, only changing course," Armin said.

"What? That wasn't a retreat command?" Christa asked.

"What is Commander Erwin thinking?" Jean demanded.

"We can all see when an operation is impossible to continue. Did command not see our smoke round somehow?" Reiner said.

"There's still only one thing for us to do. Follow the order!" Armin fired a green smoke round.

They're both smart, but , Erwin thought, *Arlert is more practical while Kirstein is more...humanistic* . Armin was more like him. When it came down to it, he would make decisions based on how likely it would fulfill the objective while Jean's decisions would be based on which would be least likely to get his comrades killed.

"Smoke round. Green." Levi looked in the distance. "Oluo, you fire it."

"Roger."

For now, everything seems to be going fine **. Eren watched his senior firing off a green flare.** ***But is it really? We may already have casualties on the front lines.***

"Reporting in!" A Scout neared them. "Attack from the rear!" He told Levi. "Right flank recon has been destroyed!" Eren looked horrified. "Our recon system is partially inoperative. Pass this on, to the left."

"Did you hear that, Petra?" Levi turned calmly to her. "Go."

"Yes, sir," the redhead veered off to the left.

The right flank? I think that's where Armin is. **Eren thought.** ***But Armin and the others should still be closer to the center. The Titans can't have made it in that far.*** **He reassured himself.** ***A black round?*** **He heard the shots and saw the dark smoke. "Abnormals!"**

"Eren, you fire it."

"Y-Yes, sir!"

"What a mess. They managed to reach this deep into our formation," Levi muttered.

Eren fired off the round. ***The Titans are so nearby. Beneath those smoke rounds, someone's fighting.***

The Female Titan appeared, running, with Scouts chasing after her.

They're going to die . Ymir grimaced.

The hook shot in front of her and a soldier flew by, causing her to cover her nape.

"Shit!" Darius, a soldier on the ground on horseback, cursed. "Look over here." He pointed his flare gun at her. "You damn monster!" He fired off a shot and she tilted her head to the side and dodged it. "Now!"

Three Scouts were flying toward her from different directions.

"Three separate attacks at once. You're pretty smart, but you can't possibly protect all three targets! Spine, Achilles tendon, it doesn't matter! Hit one, and we will slow it down. Go!"

Levi and Petra in particular paid close attention.

Hange was ready, as well, to write anything of importance that could help them capturing her easier and more effective or win against her if it came to a fight.

"Damn you for causing so many deaths!" He went to her legs.

"We'll make you die a slow, painful death!" A different Scout came at her from above.

The Female Titan grabbed one of the wires and jumped.

"It jumped?"

She looked down at the soldier in midair and came down on him, squashing him beneath her foot. One soldier landed on the ground and skid back and she kicked him against the building.

"Wha—" The last of the trio stared fearfully at her, voice shaking as she held him by a wire, watching him. "L-let me go!"

Darius looked ill, seeing her approach, spinning the young man as if he were a toy.

"His insides must be scrambled," Jean flinched, face pale.

"She could have killed him easily but she's playing with him instead," Christa looked sick.

Annie wouldn't be so cruel and low. Eren thought.

"She's intelligent, coming up with a way to avoid all three," Petra noted. "And her reflexes are fast. She was immediately able to pull off the maneuver."

Levi grunted in agreement. "She might even be harder to take down than the other two in combat. The Armored Titan has a protective layer but it makes him slow. The Colossal Titan is even slower, its height making balance, even only standing up without help, virtually impossible. In theory at least." They weren't one hundred percent sure the Colossal could support its weight and be mobile.

"But it is easier to trap her and keep her restrained," Hange said, feeling confident. "We'll get her."

The Scout yanked the reins, turning around to race away. She followed him, releasing her grip on the wire and sending the soldier's body flying.

They glared at such an offensive display.

There was no need for that! Jean thought angrily.

That piece of shit is fucking sick and needs to die! Eren gritted his teeth.

Darius raced across a small wooden bridge and continued on. "I need to report this immediately. Who would've foreseen a Titan like that? I need to tell everyone!" He looked over his shoulder and cried out in fear.

A massive reddish-pink foot appeared behind him, launching both the soldier and the horse into the sky. Two Scouts noticed her.

"An abnormal?"

"It got in all the way here? We'll take it out!"

"We can't let it get further in!"

The two raced toward the standing female giant.

Row 3/1 Wagon, the upper part in the middle of the formation.

"The right flank's been wiped out? But we aren't withdrawing? Why?!"

"No idea. The commander's orders. Just relay the message to the left!"

The Female Titan glanced up, over half a dozen bloody patches on the grass around her. She then took off.

"You're going to come up with a new plan, right?" Sasha asked.

"At the rate she's going, she'll annihilate half the Survey Corps before she finds Eren!" Jean said.

"It should be easy, now that you know where there's going to be trouble," Christa said. "And, eventually, who she is."

"We definitely plan to fix all our mistakes and make the plan as foolproof as possible, resulting in the highest chances of success and the least amount of deaths possible," Erwin told them.

The expedition is only days away . Mikasa thought. It was too late to make any significant changes. They would have to go through with the plan and make sure they could improve it in the next few days.

Two unseen Scouts on the left flank spoke.

"What's going on? We keep heading east."

"Our goal is supposed to be south, to the old city."

1/5 Vanguard, on the upper left side of the formation.

"Right now, our formation's on a collision course."

"Yeah. You can see it now. The Forest of Giant Trees."

It's the perfect place for an ambush . Petra thought. The large trees served well for escaping out of Titans' reach—to rest and strategize or wait in safety if injured, all depending on the situation—and it made utilizing the 3D gear very easy. They could hide the cannons and other weapons as well as soldiers high up in the looming trees. *If they lured her in deep enough, we could easily give chase and stop her from escaping if she tried* .

The location was ideal and, knowing Hange, the trap and the weapons would be effective as well. Eren was bait and, with Squad

Levi guarding him, they'd bring her in and spring the trap. Everything was perfect up until then. *But if she escapes, it'll be up to us to stop her.* And they had no idea what she could do.

Already not knowing her abilities to call other Titans would cause a headache for their future-selves on TV, she just knew it. Petra didn't like their chances of catching the Female Titan if she sent an army of giants their way as she ran off. What else could she do? *If we're going to defeat her, we have to think of her as basically a 15-meter human with the ability to regenerate.* And if she really was Annie Leonhart, they'd be in even more trouble because of her expertise in hand-to-hand combat.

"Seems Titans passed through here. There's nothing growing on the road," Erwin noticed. "We can bring the carts through, too." They passed by a few broken, single-story buildings, sitting before massive trees. "Send word to the rear that only the central cart guard should enter the forest."

"Yes, sir!"

Two Scouts split off, leaving the three to go deeper into the forest.

Sasha watched them disappear and turned to her squad leader. "Excuse me, sir. The center row appears to be entering the forest. Wouldn't the rest of us collide with the forest?"

"We're going around."

"Yes, sir!"

"Hey, what are we doing at this tourist spot? We're totally off from both our original destination and our return point," Jean said, riding beside Armin.

"I don't know. I don't know, but the order came from Commander Erwin, after all. He must have a plan."

"What kind of plan? Are they planning to hold a welcome party for us new recruits at a tourist spot?"

That remark elicited some snorts and chuckles.

"The MP Brigade's new recruits have a welcoming ceremony," Connie said quietly to Sasha so Levi wouldn't overhear.

"I bet they have meat there," she replied dreamily.

"No," Armin answered, "I don't think so."

"That was a joke," Jean said. "Anyway, that giant woman's following us. No matter what his plan, we can't stay here. The only thing I can imagine is that we're passing through on our way to somewhere else."

"Everyone, halt!" Their squad leader began explaining once they'd dismounted their horses and tied them to the trees, "Listen up, recruits, and listen well. We will now enter ambush formations. Draw your blades, and wait above in the trees. If any Titans try to enter this forest, stop them at all costs!"

That's not gonna work . Hange thought. *We didn't anticipate the Shifter being able to draw Titans, making them ignore humans and follow her without a second thought.* If the Female Titan used her ability, the giants would rush into the forest all at once. *And we'd be the ones who get ambushed.*

There was no way for them to make all the Titans in the vicinity follow the soldiers and get them far, far away from the forest. That was too dangerous and would reveal their trap. *But if I can find out how she can call the Titans to her, then maybe we could prevent her from getting help* . The scientist thought.

How did she call them? *She is most likely female. So she may be able to secrete a pheromone that can trigger abnormal behavior in normal Titans.* If that were the case, they were screwed. Hange hoped it was something they would be able to prevent.

"U-Um, sir, what do you—"

"Shut up and follow orders!" Their squad leader flew up to stand on a sturdy branch on the tree behind him.

"Seriously?" Jean said. "What the hell's going on?" His comrades, Armin being the exception, looked on in silence, unsure themselves.

"H-Hey," Connie turned to Mikasa, "it looks like only the center line went into the woods. What happened to the formation?"

"The formation's gone." At her words, an image of a round cluster of trees appeared with some blue horses heading into the opening in the front while the rest went around. "The forest blocks our advance, so the left and right flanks will have to skirt the forest. We've lost our recon ability. "

"Why didn't we change course to avoid this forest? Did Commander Erwin read the map wrong?"

They chucked at his words.

The veterans, having known the man the longest, found that especially funny.

"I don't know," Mikasa replied. "Perhaps we tried too hard to avoid the threat on the right flank and ended up here."

Elsewhere, the edge of the forest appeared, beautiful and peaceful. One soldier stood per tree, everyone standing almost the same height as one another. "This is insane. We've abandoned the original mission of establishing an outer Wall base." Jean's voice was heard.

One by one, shots of the others appeared: Christa, Ymir, Bert, Reiner, Mikasa, and Sasha, all listening quietly, looking out at the open field.

"And when we abandoned it, we should've turned tail and run. But instead, we're forging ahead to a tourist trap. And now, we're just standing here, to stop any Titans that enter the woods?" Jean looked to their superior. "Damn asshole… Giving a stupid order."

"Technically he's following the commander's orders," Hange teased. "Are you calling Erwin an asshole and an idiot?"

"I haven't said anything yet!" Jean defended. They couldn't punish him for badmouthing his superior when it hadn't happened.

"He'll hear you," Armin said.

"And this no real explanation thing is innovative, too. Of course, I'm sure he's not feeling too safe either."

"What do you mean?"

"They say a leader who's lost all respect from his team quite often succumbs to a mysterious attack from behind," Jean held up one of his swords. "I'm just saying it wouldn't surprise me."

All eyes were now on the ash-haired teen.

"What? I'm not being serious."

"Sounded pretty serious to me," Mikasa said.

Jean rolled his eyes. "Didn't you guys hear?" He pointed at the screen. "I was just *saying* . It's not like I'd ever do that."

Some of them looked skeptical. Erwin knew he wouldn't. He doubted the teen had it in him. *At least, not now* . If the situation were really critical, and countless lives were on the line, he wondered though.

"Jean, what are you going to do?" Armin asked almost nervously.

"Don't be so serious. This situation's got me a bit worked up, that's all. What am I going to do? Obey my orders, and keep Titans out of the forest. You also think it's the right move, don't you?" Jean asked, the other teen straightening at his words. "Ah. You look like you know something."

"Well…"

"Five-meter class incoming!"

Why bring the formation here? What is Commander Erwin thinking?* Armin thought. *No, that isn't what we should think about. The Female Titan is pursuing Eren. And the commander knows that. Assume those two things, and see what you can deduce.

"Captain!" Eren called out. "Captain Levi!"

"What?"

"What do you mean 'what?' We're in the middle of the woods! If the center enters alone, we won't know if Titans are approaching! It seems something's approaching us from the right. How are we supposed to dodge the Titans or protect the carts?"

We can't . Eren thought. It was so obvious. Why was he asking such stupid questions and embarrassing himself by freaking out?

"Don't go on and on about the obvious," Levi drawled. "We can't do that anymore, of course."

"Th-Then why?"

"Look around, Eren. At all these big-ass trees. It's the perfect environment for 3D maneuver gear. And try to use that tiny brain of yours. If you don't want to die, think."

"Yes, sir!" Eren replied. *I see. I just can't keep up right now because I'm still new. He won't just tell me the answer. I have to figure it out for myself. I'm sure that's how they all learned to fight.* The Shifter looked to his comrades and was surprised that they didn't seem to know either.

"What the fuck? Seriously? Damn it all. What the hell is going on here?" Oluo mumbled to himself.

That better be the trap of the century. Ymir thought. Otherwise she couldn't see how they would survive if Annie managed to reach Eren.

Eren looked around, Petra was staring ahead, nervous and unsure, while Erd and Gunther looked apprehensive. *Wait! Don't tell me… No one…knows what's really going on?* He stared ahead at their captain. *Maybe…not even Captain Levi?*

"Wrong," Levi rolled his eyes. "I'm in charge of you, of course I would know. Don't be such an idiot."

The Female Titan is after Eren* . Armin thought. *If I'm right about that, then there's only one reason to come here. This is where Commander Erwin intends to deal with the Female Titan.

"Damn Armin, you're so smart!" Connie said. "Even Jean didn't figure that out."

"Shut up, not like you did either."

"Armin," Jean's voice snapped the boy out of his thoughts. "Our orders were to keep the Titans out of the forest, right?"

Armin followed his gaze, startled to see a dozen Titans clawing at the trees, trying to get to them, just between the two of them alone.

"That's fucking creepy," Connie said.

Sasha shivered, "Very creepy."

"In other words… There's no longer any reason to fight…right?"

Around them, the rest of the recruits watched the giants with various expressions, some nervous, some blank-faced.

An overhead shot of the treetops appeared. A spark and suddenly, there was a trail of black smoke reaching toward the sky.

"A black smoke round!" Eren spotted it first.

"It's from directly behind us!" Gunther said.

"It's that thing that's been chasing us from the right," Erd looked over his shoulder.

"Draw your blades." Levi pulled out one of his swords. "If that thing decides to show itself, we won't have any time." His words caused tensed expressions to break out on his team's faces.

The music's so freaky! Christa thought. The music and the nervousness were causing her heart to pound like crazy.

A Scout shot out of the trees, looking at something hidden in the greenery.

"What's with the music?" Sasha asked nervously.

Mikasa tightened her grip on her boys.

Suddenly, the Female Titan appeared, swatting the soldier and racing forward. Eren gasped at the sight of her.

"Run!" Levi ordered.

Petra watched the Female Titan, running almost parallel to them.

Eren cried out when she lunged toward them, breaking a tree that was in her way.

Some let out noises of surprise as well, everyone oozing tension.

Eren was looking utterly terrified as she smiled a creepy smile of triumph, having finally found him. "It's fast!"

"We can't get away in this forest!" Gunther said.

"It's catching up to us!" Erd yelled.

"Captain, can we switch to maneuver gear?!" Petra asked. Levi didn't reply, looking silently over his shoulder. "Captain!"

"Say something!" Mikasa whispered harshly under her breath.

"You won't escape!" A Scout emerged from behind her.

"Reinforcements from behind!" Petra said.

By now the viewers knew better than to get their hopes up.

The Female Titan tilted her head to dodge the hook and grabbed it, yanking it to bring the soldier close and rammed her shoulder against a tree with him between them, crushing him. Another soldier attacked and the Female Titan grabbed her wire and threw her over her shoulder.

"Captain, your orders?!" Petra cried out in panic.

Everyone in the room was leaning forward, anxiety at an all-time high.

"Let's go for it!" Oluo yelled. "That thing's dangerous! We should kill it!"

"I'll turn it into mincemeat!" Erd pulled out his sword, looking furious.

That fucking idiot walked straight into hell.* Eren looked at the Female Titan. *You're chasing a group of master Titan killers!

It was then the recruits understood. *They're scared but not frozen in terror!* Mikasa thought. *They're waiting for their orders!* Surely, that must mean they were confident in their abilities to kill the Female Titan, didn't it? If it had been her, she'd have attacked already.

Eren turned back to their captain, who hadn't spoken a word. "Captain Levi?"

"Captain!"

"Give us your orders."

"At this rate, it will catch up with us!"

"We'll kill it here. That's why we came to this forest! Right, Captain?"

"Captain, your orders!"

Levi finally looked at them, "Everyone, cover your ears." He pulled out his flare gun and fired off a round.

Everyone took a few moments to catch their breaths and get their heartbeats under control.

"Everyone's alive so far," Petra said optimistically.

"Let's hope it stays that way," Mikasa nodded.

"I can't believe you didn't take off," Connie said to Petra.

She wasn't exaggerating or trying to be cool when she said their job is to follow orders and eliminate threats. Ymir thought. Despite their obvious terror, the Special Ops Squad had stuck loyally by their captain's side and waited for instruction.

"I would've been like *see ya, suckers! I'm out!* and high tailed it outta there!" Connie's words were met with giggles.

Sasha nodded, "I would've been halfway out of the forest!"

They began to joke, each one more ridiculous than the previous.

"The forest?" Jean snorted. "I would've been halfway home!"

"I've been halfway around the world!" Ymir joked.

"I would've been halfway to the moon!" Christa giggled.

Jean's words about soldiers turning on their superiors in a seemingly hopeless situation suddenly popped back into Armin's head. *They didn't abandon him or curse him or anything* . *No wonder they're such an elite team* . They trusted him to lead them well and he had faith in them to rise to the challenge.

I need to learn to transform at a moment's notice and control my Titan . Eren thought resolutely. Training by fighting with the other Scouts, he could save so many soldiers without fear of accidentally killing them instead. His fellow squad members were all extremely skilled and he needed to master his own abilities so they could become a truly formidable team.

"Everything's going well," Hange smiled. "The plan's working so far." Hearing that soothed the new recruits. Who knew how many had been killed but it seemed it wasn't total chaos. They would accomplish the mission objective.

Despite the fact they and the people they cared about were surviving, worry gnawed at Levi's stomach. He simply could not shake the feeling something was inevitably going to go wrong because, in his life and experience, something usually did. *We can stop it.* He thought. *If something goes wrong, we'll know and we have the power to change the future* . With Candy on their side, fate might not be able to screw him over like it always has.

"Let's see if she falls for our trap," Erwin said.

The person who copied my story on AO3 has taken it down. I was upset but I would like to say sorry for not acting like an adult and

sending others to fix the issue on my behalf. I do thank you for your support! It was nice to know you had my back :)

Please Review~

Episode - Bite

Chapter 19: Bite

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Armin explains Annie might be the Female Titan. Some believe him, some don't, and some try to stay neutral. He keeps his suspicions about Annie's part in Marco's death to himself.

Levi fired the gun into the sky.

There was a loud, pitched noise. Everyone had their ears covered, flinching. "A noise grenade?" Eren said.

"What is your job?" Levi looked at his team. "To just let your emotions overwhelm you?"

Petra cringed, images of herself panicking and babbling running through her head. *I should've figured Captain Levi wasn't acting without a plan in mind* . It had galled her to see herself acting like a headless chicken while their captain had remained calm. She wasn't a new recruit, green as grass. *I should've pushed the emotions aside and focused on my orders and stayed quiet!*

"No, it's not. Our squad's job is to keep the brat from getting a single scratch on him." Levi turned back. "Even if it costs our lives."

It wasn't to keep watch on me? **Eren thought.**

"We keep going on our horses, got it?"

"Yes, sir," Petra answered.

"Keep going? For how long? And it's right on top of us," Eren looked back. The Female Titan continued in pursuit. "Again?!" Two Scouts reached her and she covered her nape.

They're going to die even though Eren's elite squad is right there . Christa thought sadly.

"The reinforcements! If we don't help, they'll be wiped out again!"

"Eren, eyes on the road!" Gunther yelled.

"Sir!" Eren said in protest.

"Keep your pace, full speed!" Erd said.

"But, Erd, why?! If Squad Levi doesn't defeat it, who will?" Eren demanded.

"My sentiments exactly," Jean muttered. Even though he had faith in Mikasa, he wasn't sure she could take the Female Titan down. *Not yet at least. But if she'd trained with the elite squad, Mikasa would've gotten stronger and then she could have defeated her* . His eyes flitted momentarily over at the right couch where the commander sat. *Hell, if even Eren had trained to transform and fight in that form, he may have had a slight chance too.*

Jean didn't believe Eren could defeat the Female Titan if it came down to just the two of them. *Especially if—because—it's Annie.* His jaw clenched.

Not only was Eren completely closed off to the idea, despite the proof, she was a better martial artist than him. Than all of them. *And she's got experience as a Shifter.* Eren's Titan's abilities—nonexistent that they were compared to the Colossal and Armored he suddenly realized—were known to her. *Eren can't win and I'm not*

sure Squad Levi is properly trained for this. If that trap fails, they're fucking dead .

One of the Scouts flew at the Female Titan and she slammed him against a tree with the palm of her hand.

Eren gasped, "Another one's dead. And maybe we could've saved him!"

The squad kept silent, staring ahead. The Female Titan tried to swat the second man and he dodged.

"One's still fighting. We could still make it!"

"Eren, eyes back on the road! Keep going!"

"Are you telling me to look away? To abandon my comrades and run?!"

"Yes, that's right!" Petra said. "Obey the captain's orders!"

"I don't understand why we're leaving them to die! Or why he won't explain! Tell me why!"

Come to think of it, why hasn't he said a word? Sasha thought. Was he afraid of being overheard if he tried to reassure them? Or was he being paranoid and still thought a member of his team could be a potential Shifter? She noticed Hange leaning forward in her seat. Sasha's eyes widened. *I get it! They're about to spring the trap!*

"That's because the captain decided the reason should not be explained," Oluo responded. "You just don't understand because you're still green! If you get it, then shut up and obey!"

Eren gritted his teeth in frustration. Then he seemed to come to a realization. *Wait…* He put away his blades, right hand inching toward his mouth.

Levi, Hange, and Erwin stilled.

"But we're so close," Hange whispered fiercely.

Do it. Ymir thought.

***I can fight on my own.* A fast, fleeting memory of his Titan form punching another 15-meter, saving Mikasa, flashed through his mind. *Why am I relying on others?* Eren wondered. *I can just fight on my own.* Eren stared at his hand. He opened his mouth, having made up his mind, ready to bite.**

Fuck . Levi mentally cursed. *He's going to wreck the plan when we're almost there.*

"What are you doing, Eren?" Petra interrupted.

Eren faltered.

"Just a little further," Hange encouraged.

"You're only allowed to do that if your life is in danger. You promised us!"

The Shifter looked hesitant.

"Eren!"

"You aren't wrong," Levi said, grabbing their attention. "If you want to, do it."

Eren looked startled by his words.

"Wait, what?"

"Really?"

"I don't get it..."

"Is it a trick or a test or something?"

What's he doing? Eren wondered. Was he trying to stall for time? Distract him? After years as a trainee and especially as a member of the elite squad, obeying orders had been mercilessly drilled into his head. There had to be an ulterior motive or reason.

Defying orders in the Survey Corps is practically a sin . Mikasa thought. It was clear just how much it was ingrained in their brains having watched Levi's Squad panic but not make a move going against their orders.

"I can tell," Levi continued. "It's a real monster. And it has nothing to do with its Titan power. No matter what power you use to suppress it, no matter what cage you put it in, it will never submit to anyone."

"I just want to slaughter the Titans," Eren said, sitting behind bars.

"Eren, the difference between your decision and ours is experience. But you don't have to rely on that. Choose."

Eren stared ahead, wide-eyed, mind racing.

"Believe in yourself. Or believe in the Survey Corps and me."

The rest of the team listened, looking surprised.

"I don't know the right answer," Levi admitted. "I never have. I can believe in my own abilities or the choices of companions I trust. But no one ever knows how it will turn out. So choose for yourself whichever decision you'll regret least."

Eren looked back at the Female Titan again, watching her swipe at the Scout, trying to decide. He brought his hand up.

"Eren!" Petra called out. "Believe in us!"

He stared at her imploring expression.

"I wouldn't," Ymir's words came out louder than intended.

"What?" Christa looked at her, surprised.

"Before you start jumping down my throat," she held up a hand, catching Eren's eyes, "I wasn't trying to be a bitch."

Could've folded me . Levi was really starting not to like her.

"Then what?" Eren asked rudely.

"It's just...well, let's not forget what happened to the last elite team that tried to protect Eren. Only one walked away."

"No disrespect to the Garrison but you can't compare their elite team to ours," Erwin said.

"We may have them beat on technical skills and teamwork, but the threat level is much higher too," Petra pointed out. A number of surprised pairs of eyes turned to her.

"You don't think we can take her?" Hange looked disappointed. "That our trap won't work?"

"Honestly? I don't know," she shrugged. "Based on what I do know and they," Petra gestured to their TV counterparts, "don't, I'm not feeling too optimistic."

"The trap will work." Sasha tried to remain optimistic.

"Yeah, it probably will," Jean agreed. "And then we'll get fucked because we're in a forest surrounded by countless Titans she can spur into ambushing *us* instead."

"Oh shit," Connie's face fell.

Unease settled in their stomachs.

And then Eren will really be in serious danger, facing an opponent with little knowledge and no preparation. Mikasa thought, distressed.

Armin was having similar thoughts beside her. *There are too many things that can go wrong.* But he knew that was the case most of the time. *And it'll be okay even if the plan is a massive failure. It hasn't happened yet* . He relaxed. In fact, the best thing that could happen was for everything to go wrong. *That way we can be properly prepared for the absolute worst.*

"I came up with a way that'd only half-kill you," Levi said, standing in front of the classroom, chalk in hand. Hange was sitting on the desk nearby while the rest of Squad Levi stood in a half circle.

"What?" Eren stood between his team and their captain.

"I said I'd only be able to stop you as a Titan if I killed you. But this method would only badly wound you," Levi began to draw on the chalkboard. "Of course, it relies on the squad's skill. The idea is to cut you right out of the Titan's neck. We'd end up cutting the ends of your arms and legs off, but they'd just grow back like a lizard's. How disgusting."

" *Totally cool* , you mean," Hange grinned.

"Wait a minute," Eren said. "I don't know how they grow back. Is there some other way—"

Levi narrowed his eyes. "So you're saying you don't want there to be any danger or sacrifice?"

Ideally, no . Eren thought though he knew that was only wishful thinking.

"N-No…"

"Then just resolve yourself. We will, too. The danger for us is that you might kill us. So don't worry."

"Yes. I understand."

"So, that means I can do experiments, right?" Hange asked, light reflecting off her glasses.

"It's very risky," Levi replied. "But that doesn't mean that we can't use him to investigate."

"I can be in charge of planning this, right? Eren, if there's something you don't understand, learn to understand it. It's well worth any risk to our lives."

Levi and Hange stood outside near a well. "Ready, Eren?" A rope was extended down into the well. Hange looked in. "When it's prepared, I'll use the smoke round to notify you. After that, any decisions are up to you."

The recruits watched intently, interested to see what information could be gleaned from the experiment.

At the bottom, Eren raised his right arm, "Understood!"

Hange nodded, eager. "This dried-up well could hold even a mindless Titan." She imagined Eren's berserk form stuck in place, only one arm and the head free and aboveground. "Probably!"

Jean snorted. *Probably she says* .

"That's the signal." Eren saw the green flare shooting up to the sky. He looked at his hand. *Since I sealed the Wall, I haven't*

tried to control the Titan. If I lose control, Squad Levi might kill me this time. **He bit down on his hand.**

The well remained calm, quiet, and undisturbed.

"Uh, what?" Connie wasn't the only one confused.

"Nothing happened," Christa muttered. *He cannot transform at will.* It was sporadic, his control over his abilities.

Hange and Levi sat on their horses nearby, waiting. "Did he not see the signal?"

"No," Levi answered. "We weren't even that sure of his ability in the first place." They moved closer to the well. "Hey, Eren! We're calling it quits for now." Levi, now back on the ground, approached the well.

"Is something wrong?" Hange joined him, looking in. They looked startled at the sight down below.

Blood stained his mouth and hands. "Hange…" Eren looked up, a helpless expression on his face. "I can't become a Titan."

"Wouldn't it be better to use a small blade?" Sasha pointed out. "Instead of biting your hands all the time."

"Now that you mention it," Eren crossed his arms. "That sounds a lot less painful and gross. I mean," he looked at the commander, "if that would be okay, sir."

"It's fine," Erwin shrugged.

"The MP won't have any problems with it, will they?" Connie asked.

"All he needs is a small nick," the commander said. "Since you can transform without any weapons, or use your environment if necessary, there's really no point in not allowing you to carry a small blade."

"Besides, he already carries sharp, deadly swords," Christa pointed out.

"And it doesn't even have to be a small blade. To transform, the two requirements are intent and a wound. A safety pin or even a needle could work," Petra suggested.

"Yeah," Armin nodded. "Safety pin would be good. Easier to carry and hide."

The Scouts were taking a break outdoors, enjoying a cup of tea. Eren sat with his squad while Levi stood nearby, holding his cup. "So your self-inflicted bite wounds on your hands aren't healing, either?" The corporal glanced over at the teen.

Eren clutched his bandaged hands, "No."

"If you can't transform into a Titan, our main goal of sealing Wall Maria is off the table. This is an order. Make it happen." Levi walked away with that.

"Yes, sir," he replied despondently.

"Don't let it get you down, Eren," Erd spoke while Petra went to talk to their captain.

"But…"

"Well, it just means you're more human than we thought," Oluo said, grabbing his attention.

"That's a nice way to think about it," Sasha smiled.

"Better than rushing into something and getting killed. This isn't meaningless," Erd said.

"Yeah," Gunther agreed. "We can't be too careful."

Why is everyone so calm? **Eren looked around. *Are they okay with my being unable to turn into a Titan?* He picked up his teaspoon and winced. It fell to the grass.**

"Are you okay?" Erd asked.

"Yes." Eren reached down for the spoon. It was a little too far out of his reach and he stretched farther. Golden-orange lightning cackled as soon as he made contact. Eren's eyes widened as a small explosion erupted, causing Levi and Petra to freeze and his teammates to cover their faces from the hot steam and jump back.

A few Scouts stared, shocked.

"Hey! What happened?"

"What was that explosion?"

The thick steam faded away, revealing Eren with part of his arm stuck in red muscle, struggling to break free. "Why now?!" He panicked.

"Calm down," Levi said.

"Captain Levi!" Eren looked over his shoulder. "This is…" It was then it hit him.

"I said to calm down," Levi said, his back to the Shifter, addressing his squad. "All of you."

Eren gaped. His squad was standing in a half circle before their captain, blades in hands, looking ready to cut Eren down at the drop of a pin.

"Wow," Christa's eyes were wide.

They reacted so quickly while the rest of the Scouts stood by staring . Jean thought. Strangely, it reminded him of the time Eren transformed to save himself and his friends and Reiner, Annie, and Bert had taken off while everyone else stood around, gaping and confused, unsure what to do.

Easy to see now why they were chosen to watch over him. Armin thought. *And take him down before anyone else even had a chance to gather their bearings.*

As much as it displeased her, Mikasa had to admit, without the short corporal there, his squad may have dismembered Eren.

Two figures, Hange and Moblit, came running from the trees. "Huh? What was that sound?" Her expression turned from surprise to delight as they neared the Special Ops Squad. She screamed, jumping up.

They chuckled, unsurprised by her reaction.

Eren looked nervously as his squad had him surrounded while Levi looked on calmly.

"Eren! What's the meaning of this?!" Erd demanded.

"Sir?"

"Why now? Without permission? Answer me!"

"Erd, wait," Levi said.

"Answer him, Eren!" Oluo yelled. "What are you thinking?"

"Buddy, I do not envy you right now," Connie said to Eren, causing Petra to smile sheepishly.

"No, that can wait," Gunther walked closer. "Prove you're not our enemy—humanity's enemy!" Eren was frozen, unable to answer. "Prove it! Now! That is your responsibility!"

"I dare you to make a single move with that arm!" Oluo yelled from behind him. "I'll cut off your head! I can do it I'm serious! Want to try me?"

Mikasa's face darkened.

"Oluo, I said to calm down."

"Captain, get away from Eren! You're too close!" Petra yelled.

"No, you're the ones who should get back."

"Why?!"

"My intuition," he replied.

"What's wrong, Eren? Say something!"

"Like I said—"

"No sudden movements! Prove it to me, Eren!"

"I said I'm not sure—"

"Answer us!"

"You think we can't kill you?"

"I'm serious! Do it now!"

"Are you even listening?"

"Okay, let's do this! Are you humanity's—"

"Please shut up for a second!" Eren screamed loudly.

Silence fell.

The viewers burst into laughter.

"Eren!" Hange screamed, dashing to him. The excited woman shoved Gunther and another Scout out of the way.

That made them laugh even more.

"Can I touch that arm?! It's okay, right?" Drool leaked from a corner of her mouth.

Levi wrinkled his nose at the sight.

"Right? Just let me touch it!"

"Hange!" Eren's eyes were wide. "Wait a second!"

The woman touched the red flesh and steam rose, the sound of sizzling in the air. Hange skipped away. "It's hot!" She slid to her knee, both arms up in the air. "Without the skin, it's really damned hot! Unbelievably hot!"

"She's crazy but pretty damn amusing," Ymir said.

"I can't believe she just touched—on second thought, I can," Jean said.

"Squad Leader, you're too reckless!" Moblit cried out.

Everyone else just watched her with either weirded out or unsurprised expressions on their faces.

"Hey, don't you feel it's hot, Eren? How does it feel where the right hand connects?" Hange asked him. "I really want to see!"

That's right. **Eren looked down.** ***If I just pull out this hand.*** **He gritted his teeth. "Stupid thing!" He yanked with all his might.**

"Hey, Eren! Don't do anything rash!" Oluo said. The muscles ripped away from his fist. The momentum sent him tumbling backward.

"Huh?!" Hange clutched her head, jumped impatiently. "Wait, Eren! That was too fast! I still wanted to…!" She stopped, noticing the spoon between the steaming hand.

"How come it didn't melt and bend from the steam and the pressure?" Connie asked.

"You'll find out soon," Hange replied.

Eren breathed heavily, "Captain…"

The corporal stood beside him, looking down at him, "How do you feel?"

Eren took a few seconds to reply weakly. "Not…so good."

Night had fallen and Eren was sitting at the bottom of the steps to the basement, Levi leaning against the wall beside him with his arms crossed.

"Until I saw that they were actually ready to kill me, I didn't understand. That they had such little faith in me…"

"Of course, stupid," Jean rolled his eyes. "What would you do if you were in their place?"

"And it's not like they knew you didn't do that on purpose," Sasha said. "I'd have acted on instinct too."

Eren opened his mouth but Ymir beat him to it. "You probably would've wanted the Shifter's head on a spike."

"No, I wouldn't!" He defended immediately.

"Your hatred of Titans is well-known," Christa said. "Honestly, wouldn't you have reacted the same way?"

"I wonder if you'd have even bothered demanding an explanation before going in for the kill," Connie said.

"Eren's a hothead but I don't think he'd have screwed it up for all of humanity because of personal vengeance," Armin shook his head.

"Eren?" Mikasa worried their comrades' words may have hurt him unintentionally.

"I'm just thinking." Eren stared at his hands in his lap, a slightly troubled expression on his face. "I was so quick to judge everyone who judged me but realistically, if I was in their place, and I didn't know me, seems probable I'd have had the same reaction."

"We all know how much you hate the Titans. But there is one thing that surpasses that, your desire to be free. It's what we've always talked about since we were kids and your original and primary reason for wanting to join the Survey Corps," Armin said.

"He's right, Eren," Petra smiled. "It was that desire for freedom that led you to snap out of your berserk state and control your Titan. Now stop making yourself crazy for no reason and get out of your head."

"Yeah, okay," Eren smiled back.

"Obviously," Levi said. "That's why I chose them."

Eren's eyes shifted to him.

"People say you only truly become a full member of the Survey Corps after making it back alive from a mission. But whenever you fight the Titans, you never have enough information. There are too many situations you just can't anticipate, no matter what. They've had to cultivate the ability to take quick action

and to make ruthless decisions by assuming the worse case scenario. But that doesn't mean they've become heartless. It's not like they felt nothing when they turned their swords on you."

That's true . Christa thought. They had seemed upset, not just angry, that he'd transformed without permission.

"Captain Levi," Moblit came down the stairs, "Squad Leader Hange wants to see you."

The rest of Squad Levi was waiting for them in the room with Hange and Moblit.

"Take a long crap?"

"Wow, your sense of humor is complete shit," Candy joked.

Several voices groaned while only a few laughed.

"Candy's not that much better in the humor department," Armin said.

"I don't know," Sasha grinned. "That song when Eren's Titan came out of—what did she call that Titan again?"

"San-Titan," Petra provided helpfully, earning an eye-roll from Levi and a snort from Hange.

"Yeah! That one! That was great."

"It was good," Jean agreed.

"I wonder if she finished it," Christa said.

"Let's just get back to the episode," Eren urged before they came up with the brilliant idea to finish the song themselves.

"She is correct though."

"Just play the damn episode, Erwin," Levi said.

"Actually, it was pleasantly quick," Hange replied. "I wasn't sure what to tell the brass. Well, for now," she took out a handkerchief and placed it on the table, unfolded it and revealing the spoon. "Look at this."

"A teaspoon?" Eren said.

"Yes," she picked it up and held it up to them. "The right Titan hand Eren created was holding this. Like this, between its index finger and thumb. It's hard to imagine that was an accident. And for some reason, the heat and pressure didn't warp the spoon at all. Anything come to mind?"

"I was trying to pick it up. I transformed right after," Eren answered.

"I see," Hange stared at the teaspoon. "That may explain why you couldn't transform earlier. Kill the Titans. Block the cannon shell. Lift the boulder. In each case, you had a clear goal before you transformed. My theory is that your self-inflicted injury probably isn't the sole trigger. You may need some goal, as well."

So that's why the teaspoon wasn't bent . Connie nodded to himself. That wasn't his intent.

Eren looked at his hand, "It's true that when I turned into a Titan this time, it was like when I blocked that cannon shell. But turning into a Titan to pick up a spoon…" His hand twitched. "What the hell is this?"

"In other words, you didn't deliberately change without permission?" Gunther asked.

"No, sir."

Gunther sighed. Then the four members of the Squad Levi nodded at each other.

They each brought up their left hands and bit down without hesitation.

"Whoa!"

"Ouch!"

"What the?!"

"What're you guys doing?"

Mikasa smiled, realizing the meaning behind the gesture and appreciating it.

"You'll understand in a second," Petra said.

"Huh?" Hange looked around, completely confused. "Uh?"

"Wait, what are you doing?" Eren asked.

Levi watched the scene in silence, expressionless. "That hurt," Gunther said.

"This isn't easy," Erd looked at his hand. "I'm amazed you can bite through, Eren."

"We made the wrong decision," Gunther looked at the teen. "This is a small price to pay. Not that it makes a difference."

"Keeping you under control is our job. And there's nothing wrong with that. So don't get cocky!" Oluo told him.

"I'm sorry, Eren," Petra apologized. "We've been so jumpy. You must be disappointed in our stupidity," her eyes shifted away in

shame for a second. "However, even so," she looked him in the eyes, "we're going to rely on you. And we want you to rely on us."

Eren watched his squad, floored.

"So… Have faith in us."

"You guys really didn't have to," Eren said, embarrassed.

"Of course we did," Petra insisted.

Back in the Forest of Giant Trees, Eren's eyes fell to Petra's hand.

"I can't believe you actually bit hard enough to leave a scar," Sasha said.

"Eren, I hope you know I consider you a close comrade and dear friend," Connie began, "but I am never biting my hand to show you how much. That shit looks *painful* ."

"Yeah," Christa nodded, rubbing her hand.

"And do you know how many germs there are in the human mouth?" Ymir crossed her arms and turned her head. "Not happening."

"Thanks, guys," Eren said dryly. "Nice to know how much you care."

"You're welcome," Jean said.

A Scout flew toward the Female Titan and she glanced at him.

"Eren!" Levi yelled. "You're taking too long! Decide!"

Eren closed his eyes and gritted his teeth before declaring his intentions, "I'll go forward!" His teammates watched him, shocked.

"Let me go!" The Scout in the Female Titan's hand screamed. She wiped him on the trees as she ran before tossing her hand back to throw away whatever was leftover from the body.

She can easily crush them in her hands or smash them into a tree. Christa thought. If her purpose was to eliminate anyone that got in her way, she could get rid of them quickly and move on. *But...*

The bitch enjoys killing them in cruel ways. Jean glared, jaw clenched.

Armin watched sadly. *Annie...*

Levi, meanwhile, was taking careful account of every person she killed and how to make her suffer for each of their deaths when he got his hands on her.

Eren forced himself to look forward, eyes squeezed shut. *I'm sorry!*

"Target is accelerating!"

"Faster!" Levi ordered. "We will outrun it."

***It's impossible to outrun it* . Eren glanced over his shoulder at her. *If we keep running away, it'll stomp us all flat!* He looked at his captain's back. *But… We might all die, but everyone chose to go on, even if it meant abandoning our comrades. Captain Levi has been looking forward this whole time* .**

Petra and Erd were tense and nervous but staring forward as well. *And the rest of the squad believes in him, and put all their trust in him.* Eren's expression became determined. *I'll believe in them, too.* He leaned his head completely back, looking at the

Female Titan staring piercingly down at him. *Like they believed in me!*

The squad rode by two men hiding behind wooden slats.

The Female Titan skid to a stop, surrounded by soldiers in trees.

"She fell for it!" Hange squealed.

Everyone's hearts raced in excitement.

The Female Titan and Levi's squad looked shocked.

"Fire!" Erwin ordered, hanging from a tree.

The soldiers covered their ears and immediately yanked the rope in their hands. Hooks began to launch out and the Female Titan covered her ears, head slightly bowed, caught off guard and put on the defensive.

"Fuck yeah!" Connie screamed. "Take that, bitch!"

The booming of the special target restraining weapons continued as dozens upon dozens of steel wires with arrowheads pierced her entire body.

"She's caught!" Jean exclaimed, a look of awe on his face. It didn't stay long. *But will she stay caught or escape?*

"We did it!" Christa yelled, thrilled.

"There must be a hundred wires," Mikasa watched, stunned.

"There is no way she can possibly move after all that!" Petra said, eyes wide.

Finally, the last one fired and smoke rose.

Squad Levi kept going, dust and thick smoke blocking out the view behind them.

"We've got her," Erwin said in satisfaction.

"And you were all doubting us so much," Hange laughed happily.

Ymir wanted to point out she could still possibly call Titans and have them ambushed but even she was hopeful one of the arrows had pierced Annie's jaw and wired her mouth shut so she couldn't make a sound.

Eren looked back at the result.

"Ooh let us see!" Hange begged.

"Advance a bit farther, tether the horses, and switch to maneuver gear," Levi said. "You guys will be off on your own for a while. Erd, lead the squad." He got ready to jump off. "Once you're a good distance away from the Titans, hide Eren. Take my horse." With that, he flew back toward the other Scouts.

Eren watched him with an open mouth. "Could they be…"

The Female Titan was stuck, countless, shiny metal wires locking her in place.

"…capturing that Titan alive?"

"Wow," Connie's eyes were wide.

"Look at her," Jean gaped.

Christa gasped. "No way she can even twitch a muscle, forget trying to escape!"

"An animal is always the most dangerous when cornered," Sasha said. "But what can she do stuck like that?"

"Congratulations, looks like you'll all survive your first expedition," Petra smiled and they laughed in delight.

Is this the end? Did they do it? A part of Armin wanted the mission to end in success even though he knew it would be better for them if the mission had some hiccups just so when they left for real they would be fully prepared.

Levi was tense and silent, unable and unwilling to celebrate just yet.

Will she escape? Erwin thought. *Will she use some trick? Like calling other Titans to her rescue.*

Eren looked at Petra then Oluo.

"Well, Eren? See that?" Gunther asked. "We caught that Titan!"

"This is the power of the Survey Corps! Don't underestimate us, fool," Oluo said.

"Well?" Erd said as the Shifter looked at Petra's smiling face and began to grin. "Do you get it now?"

"Yes!" Eren said happily.

Erwin stood on a branch and Levi joined him. "Looks like it's stopped moving."

"We can't lower our guard," the commander said.

The Female Titan tried to move and the wires creaked but they weren't budging.

"She really is trapped," Armin said.

"And she won't be able to escape no matter how hard she struggles," Hange said confidently. *Not by herself anyway.*

"But you did well, leading it here."

"We were able to thanks to the rearguard squads that died buying us the time we needed," Levi told the commander. "We couldn't have done it without them."

" **Is that so?" Erwin continued to stare down without an expression.**

"It is. Thanks to them, we'll be able to see who's inside this thing," he looked down at the Female Titan. "I hope they haven't pissed themselves."

The episode ended with a shot of Female's Titan's face, looking panicked.

"That went well," Christa said.

"It all happened according to plan," Hange said, grinning so wide her cheeks hurt.

"Let's hope it doesn't go to shit in the next episode," Ymir said grimly.

"Must you be such a downer?" Connie grumbled. He was trying hard not to be pessimistic. He really didn't want to jinx it.

"She's right," Levi said unhappily. "We're not safe until we're back behind the Walls."

They nodded. Still, they couldn't shake off the feeling of success. The Female Titan was captured and surrounded by Scouts.

But Ymir had a feeling things were going to go to hell soon.

Please Review~

Episode - Erwin Smith

Chapter 20: Erwin Smith

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The Scouts are excited to see the Female Titan captured. But they worry she'll break free using her ability to call Titans.

The Female Titan gritted her teeth, one visible wild eye taking in the scene, trapped.

"An Abnormal…" Eren watched her. "Or is it like the Colossal Titan?" He looked ahead, muttering to himself. "Wait, did Commander Erwin actually—"

"Hey! Quit spacing out!" Oluo scolded.

"Eren! You can think later! We need to get further ahead!" Petra said.

"Right!"

The five continued to ride on, leaving the rest behind.

Good. Get as far away from her as possible. Erwin thought. If the plan did fail and she managed to escape, their best hope at freedom would be away from the epicenter.

"Well, if the shit does hit the fan, at least you're not in any immediate danger," Connie said.

Levi pulled out another sword. "Wait, Levi," Erwin said. "We need to be cautious. Squads 2 and 3! Fire!" Hooks and wires once again began shooting out and piercing the immobile Titan. "Use the reserves too!"

"Better safe than sorry," Hange nodded. "Even if she does call the Titans to her, she's still trapped."

"What if they cannibalize her?" Petra asked suddenly. "They tried to with Eren, after he killed that Abnormal that ate his friend. Do you think she might try to escape in the chaos?"

"It's possible."

"Hm, I wonder what happens if a Titan eats a Titan-Shifter," Connie thought out loud.

"They transform in the stomach and rip their way out, duh," Jean rolled his eyes. "We've already seen it happen."

"Oh yeah..."

Levi leaned back and glanced at Ymir, eyes narrowed. She was staring at her hand, mind on Marcel.

On the outer edges of the forest, the recruits waited in the trees. Three Titans crawled on the ground. One Titan grabbed a branch with one hand and gripped the tree with the other, inching its shoulder up, attempting to scale the tree.

"Reminds me of Connie trying to do a pull-up on the first day of training," Jean snickered.

"Ha, ha."

The former 104th class giggled.

Christa glanced down. "Umm, they're starting to climb up."

She's safe . Ymir relaxed. And if the Female Titan did call the Titans, they would ignore all the humans and run toward her instead.

"Indeed," Nanaba replied. "If they make it up this far perhaps I'll step out of the way. Although I suspect we'll soon be given orders to withdraw anyway."

"Does it have something to do with those explosions inside the forest?"

"Maybe."

Elsewhere, Sasha looked up, listening to the sound of the cannons. "Mikasa, what do you think those sounds are?" She turned to the stoic teen. "Are cannons being fired inside the forest?"

Mikasa was silent, listening keenly.

***I didn't see them bring any cannons in though* . Reiner thought.**

"There's a real racket coming from inside," Ymir said. "Hey, Bertolt, do you know where Christa is?"

She's worried about me. Christa smiled, subtly glancing at Ymir, feeling warmth that someone cared enough about her to do that.

"Sorry," Bert replied. "I don't."

Nothing makes sense anymore. **Connie sighed, sitting against the tree.** ***What are we even doing now, and why? I wanna go home*** **.**

"We're almost done," Connie muttered. "Please don't let the shit hit the fan..." He and the rest of the recruits had survived so far and the expedition would be over soon. *Almost there. Don't anyone die before the order to retreat comes.*

The booming of the cannons continued through the air.

"Let's move away, Armin!" Jean said.

"Okay!"

The two jumped off and flew away, trying to put some distance between them and the Titan awkwardly struggling not to fall.

"It actually climbed up," Sasha was somewhat freaked out.

"It won't hold out for long," Mikasa noted the trembling in its limbs. *Tree climbing is not a part of their daily routine . We're were the stimuli. Our presence is spurring them on.*

"Looks like the bastard's gotten the hang of it. It's gotten better and better at tree climbing," Jean observed.

"The scary thing is that this means they have the capacity to learn," Armin watched the Titan struggling to hold on.

His words sent shivers down their spines, until...

"Hey, I wonder if we can teach them other things! Like how to fetch!"

"They're not dogs, Four-Eyes."

"Although I'm sure it's probably different for each Titan."

"Armin, they seem to be up to something inside the forest, and I think I've figured out what it is." Jean looked back. "They lured that female Titan here to capture her. Or, more precisely, to capture the human inside."

Inside the forest, Erwin and Levi stared coldly down at the restrained Titan.

Hange chewed the pen nervously. Would the Female Titan call Titans to her? She knew that was almost a given. *Question is, how will she do it? Will she secrete a pheromone that will drive them to find her and cannibalize her like those Titans tried with Eren's body?* Hange really hoped not. How were they to counteract that?

Pheromones had to do with the sense of smell. She wondered if there was a way to mask the scent to prevent the Titans from reacting. *Maybe a powerful smelling chemical? Hydrogen sulfide in gas form, perhaps?* The amount they would need would require protection for the eyes, nose, and mouth. *It's very flammable too. Don't want the entire forest accidentally burning down* .

"That was Commander Erwin's goal from the very start!" Eren stood on a tree branch, his squadmates standing nearby. "Wasn't it? Still, I can understand keeping it from us rookies, but you guys too?! You've been Scouts a long time!"

"Shut up," Oluo said, "you're annoying!"

"Are you suggesting the commander and the captain don't trust us?!" Petra demanded.

Well, yeah . Mikasa thought. Then her thoughts turned to Annie. They may have been rivals during their trainee years, but she never

dreamed the girl would be a traitor. *Maybe they were right to keep the information hidden from everyone* . But she still believed her fellow recruits were right about not having Squad Levi prepare by training with Eren's Titan-form being a bad call.

"N-No, but that's what this means, doesn't it?!"

"Petra!" Oluo whipped around, pointing his sword at Eren. "Knock out his teeth! Switch his front teeth with his back ones!"

"No, Eren's right," Erd stood, his arms crossed. "The captain must've had a reason for not trusting us implicitly."

"Like what?" Gunther asked.

"There's only one reason he couldn't trust his comrades. There's someone in the regiment who can either turn into a Titan or is working as a sort of spy for them."

I wish we'd figured that out sooner. Petra sighed internally. *Then maybe we would have been given permission to train with Eren's Titan* . The idea of facing an intelligent Titan was fascinating. She could already see the various types of exercises they would do and the benefits that could result from such a training regimen.

Would their usual maneuvers still be effective? Her team did not use verbal communication to get messages across. *If the maneuvers are executed fast and relentlessly, not giving him a chance to recover, we should be able to defeat him* . If Eren was smart, he would use his environment to his advantage. That was another thing they would have to watch out for, along with his martial arts. Squad Levi was well-versed in hand-to-hand combat. *But avoiding rocks and tree branches being hurled at us, we don't have experience with that* .

They not only had to train to learn how to fight *against* an intelligent Titan but fight *with* one as well. Petra was curious to know what it would be like fighting beside Eren in his transformed state. One of

the biggest problems during expeditions was being stuck in flat terrain. *If he's close enough, we can use him to utilize our gear* .

Eren had no practice killing Titans with Scouts fighting alongside him. Petra winced, imagining the Rogue Titan throwing a punching while a solider was using his arm as an anchor and sent flying into the ground or the hands of a Titan. *We only have a few days to get as much training as possible before the 57th Expedition* . Could they do it?

"You think so too, right?" Jean looked ahead. "That there's someone in the regiment…"

"Yes," Armin agreed. "I think there is."

These two have a bright future in leadership . Hange thought. *That is, if they survive* .

"A spy? Are you really sure?" Gunther asked.

"At the very least," Erd said, "the commander must believe so. I assume the only soldiers informed of this operation were the ones who survived five years ago."

Images of Mike, Hange, Levi, Erwin, Nanaba, and a few others appeared.

"I see. So, that's why," Gunther said.

"That's gotta be it. You understand now, Eren?" Oluo looked to the Shifter. "That's what's going on."

"Mm. In that case, it couldn't be helped," Petra agreed.

"Yeah…" Eren glanced at her.

Levi was grateful they weren't upset with him for withholding crucial information, but understanding the circumstances. Though he wondered if the mission hadn't been a success, how their reactions would have differed. He felt uneasy. His insides were in knots. Jean's words came back to him. *We're still surrounded by Titans.* If she somehow managed to get Titans to ambush the Scouts without ignoring the humans, it would not end well.

"Five years ago was when the Wall first fell. Could they be using that fact to narrow down suspects on the assumption that's when the spy got inside?" Petra wondered.

"Does that mean this person killed Sonny and Bean too?" Erd added.

Hange sighed at the mention of her babies. *Soon, my loves, soon. I will know your murderers and plot my vengeance!*

"The commander asked me something after that happened," Petra admitted.

Eren's eyes widened, recalling Erwin's questions.

"What do you see here? What do you think the enemy is?"

"Is that what that meant?" Eren muttered to himself.

"We might've been allowed to join the operation if we'd known the answer to that question. I can't think of anyone, though," Erd said.

"Well, I knew. But I decided not to say anything," Oluo said. "Do you guys know why?"

"Why?" Petra asked.

"What, you mean you don't know? I guess guys like you wouldn't know, huh?"

Petra did not look impressed at all.

They giggled at her expression.

"You're nowhere near my level yet, after all," Oluo claimed cockily.

"Seriously, are you still trying to imitate Captain Levi? He doesn't talk like that."

If this succeeds, we might actually learn the truth about this world. Still,* Eren's thoughts turned to all the soldiers who had been killed by the Female Titan, *even for that way too many people have died.

"Do you think the commander was wrong to do this?" Erd asked him.

The Titan fell to the ground, landing on its ass.

The Scouts laughed at the silly position.

"He wasn't in the right; I'll tell you that." Jean stared down. "If we'd actually been told that a Titan had inside info, we would've handled things differently. Your own squad leader, for example…"

Images of Dita smiling alongside his beloved horse appeared, followed by the Female Titan smashing him into the ground.

Erwin was curious to know Armin's response.

"No, it wasn't wrong."

"Huh? How can you say that? Do you know how many soldiers have needlessly died?!"

"Jean, in hindsight, it's easy to say what should've been done. But," Armin gave him a hard look, "no one can tell how things will turn out. Yet, at some point you have to make a choice. The lives of a hundred comrades or the lives of everyone inside the Walls."

The path was littered with the bodies of deceased soldiers, their blood splattered everywhere, leading up to the Female Titan with long metal rods imbedded into her skin.

"The commander chose."

Erwin stared at the scene before him coldly.

"He chose to throw away the lives of a hundred comrades."

The recruits felt awe and fear of the man in whose hands they would place their lives in every expedition.

"I could never be a leader," Sasha said. "I could never send so many people to their deaths. Even if I did, the guilt would kill me."

"Yeah," Connie nodded.

Christa listened to their conversation silently. *Being a leader, you aren't just forced to sometimes make the call to sacrifice the lives of others, but your soul as well* . The burden of leadership, of lives on one's shoulders, was immense. Suddenly, her thoughts turned to the king, who was responsible for the lives of everyone behind the Walls. *Heavy is the head that wears the crown* . Christa thought.

"Eren, if you didn't know already, you'll soon learn why Erwin Smith was put in charge of the Scouts, of humanity's hope," Erd said.

"It's why he even has Captain Levi's trust," Petra smiled.

"That's assuming you survive long enough, of course," Oluo added.

"I don't have much life experience yet but I do know one thing," Armin explained to a silent Jean. "If there's anyone who can bring about change, it's someone capable of giving up what matters most." His thoughts turned to Pixis and Ian. "In particular, people who are capable of abandoning their humanity when forced to rise above monsters. Those who can't abandon anything can't change anything."

Erwin nodded in approval. *He's proven himself to be smart and willing to do what is necessary* . Maybe he would consider asking the teen for his opinion in strategic matters. As far as the commander was concerned, Armin had earned it.

"Fire!" Erwin ordered, pointing his sword.

Hange placed one foot against the barrel and yanked the rope. Seven cables with arrowheads shot out and dug into the Female Titan's left ass cheek.

Better safe than sorry I suppose . Erwin shook his head, amused.

Connie roared into laughter. "Did you just shoot her in the ass?!"

"Of course, she did," Eren said, looking stunned.

Ymir was snickering uncontrollably. "This is hysterical!"

"I can't believe she just did that," Christa tried to muffle her laughter to no end.

Sasha didn't bother hiding her joy, laughing openly.

She just shot Annie in the ass. Jean gaped, along with Armin.

"Typical Hange," Petra chuckled. "Gotta love her."

"Whoo!" Hange cheered, delighted. "Take that! Pain in the ass, isn't it?" She cackled, her pun getting laughs out of a few.

Even Levi and Mikasa smiled at her antics.

"How do you like that? Now you can't scratch a single itch or move a single muscle. And you probably never will again." Hange had a mad expression on her face. "The more your wounds heal, the stiffer your joints will get!"

"When she heals, the hooks are lodged even more firmly into her skin," Christa sounded impressed. "That's very smart."

"Why thank you."

Hange giggled creepily before her voice became serious, "Still, why haven't they extracted our esteemed guest yet? What are Levi and Mike doing?"

Levi and Mike attacked the Female Titan from above. A beautiful blue crystal suddenly covered her fingers. Levi glared, shards of his broken swords flying around him.

Gasps of surprise came from around the room.

"Fucking shit!" Jean's eyes bulged. *As if it wasn't bad enough she's able to control Titans to some extent now she can make her skin impervious to our swords too?!*

"What the hell?" Eren gaped. How did she do that? Could he do that too?

Hange began taking notes. *Thank you, Candy!*

"Can she cover her entire skin like the Armored Titan?" Mikasa wondered.

"If she can, that'll be a problem," Petra had a troubled expression on her face. "We can still see her skin under the...crystal. It's not bulky and won't weigh her down which means she'll still be very fast."

"Armor and speed, not a good combination. Any ideas on how to beat that?" Ymir raised an eyebrow.

"Simple," Levi crossed his arms. "Be faster. Attack before she has a chance to harden her skin."

"What if she attacks with her skin already crystalized?" No one had a reply for Christa's words.

Mike landed on a branch near Erwin and shook his head, holding up his broken swords.

Erwin studied the Female Titan. *So, she has the ability to cover portions of her body with hardened skin, huh? Much like the Armored Titan I've heard about.*

"Phew, she can't cover her entire body," Connie said.

"Doesn't look like it. But it's not a certainty," Sasha said.

The crystal began to crack and fell away. *Will it weaken if we continue an assault with the 3D gear?* The crystal had now

completely crumbled away. *There's no time to test it out. In which case…* Erwin held up him hand.

Keiji landed next to him, "sir!"

"Prepare to blast it. Blow off the target's hands."

"Yes, sir. However, there's a risk the firepower could potentially kill the person on the inside as well," he pointed to his own nape.

"Then let's attempt to sever the wrists." Erwin walked up to him, placing a hand on his shoulder, "Fire an all-out salvo on my signal."

"Understood!" Keiji went to the ground and waved to the soldiers, exchanging a nod with another group.

"Hey. Just come out already, will you?" Levi stood on top of the Female Titan's head. "We don't got time for this. Say, what do you think's gonna happen to you now? Do you really think you can get out of this situation?"

The Female Titan remained silent and expressionless.

"I wish you'd pay some thought to the trouble you've caused us. You killed our soldiers in all sorts of different ways," he had a dark expression on his face.

Things are not going to end well for her if they bring her back . Ymir thought.

"She deserves whatever she gets for everything she'd done," Eren muttered darkly, the deaths of all his comrades and his mother still on his mind.

How will he react when it's confirmed to be Annie? Armin's stomach felt heavy with dread. And if that wasn't bad enough, his thoughts turned to the two he suspected were the Colossal and Armored

Titan. Logically, he knew they were never their real friends, only pretending to be their comrades despite being responsible for the deaths of so many people who had lived in Maria. They were loyal to their own people and cause. But he still felt the harsh sting of betrayal.

"Was it fun? Well, I'm having fun now. I take it you're the same way. If there's anyone who knows how I feel, it's you. Oh, right. There's something I need to ask. Will you be fine if your arms and legs get cut off?"

Fear was visible in her eyes now.

Levi was satisfied at her reaction to his words. He was going to deliver on his promise to get her back for all the deaths she caused.

"They'll go grow back, right? I'm talking about your actual body. Can't afford to have you die on us, after all."

The Female Titan inhaled. Levi was startled for a second. She opened her mouth and roared, causing waves in the air, forcing Levi and the other Scouts to cover their ears.

Good. Give it your best. Erwin thought. *Show us everything you've got* .

"Oh no," Christa said anxiously. She did not want to watch her friends get killed even if they could prevent it.

The sound echoed throughout the entire forest.

"The shit is going to hit the fan now," Ymir muttered.

It's okay. We're learning. We won't repeat our mistakes . That only slightly reduced the ball of nerves and dread in Armin's stomach. *She's going for Eren* . He knew Annie would win if they ended up fighting. He could only imagine the chaos Eren's capture would

cause. And what it would mean for the people living behind the Walls.

Petra was confident if they couldn't kill the Female Titan, they could at least cause enough damage to give Eren plenty of time to escape. *But her hardening ability* . She hoped the Female Titan used it early on and they could take that into consideration when they attacked her. *Once we see her, we have to attack quickly, like Captain Levi said* . She had a feeling it would end in one of two ways. *We'll either kill her or we'll die trying* .

Eren and Petra, Armin and Jean, Christa and Nanaba, Connie and Reiner, Sasha and Mikasa, everyone looked startled.

"But we were so close," Connie moaned. *Why did Corporal Levi have to fuck with her like that?*

"She's going to escape." Mikasa wondered if it was too much to ask for that Annie was eaten accidentally.

If the Female Titan comes near my squad, I'll kill her. Eren glared furiously at the TV.

Then it was quiet once more.

Everyone collectively held their breaths, waiting for the ambush.

"Damn. That was quite a scare," Levi said.

He's being too careless . Sasha fretted, "This is so, so bad."

Hange gawked, Moblit standing by her and removing his hands from his ears and asking, "Were those her death throes?"

So, it's sound . Hange felt quite relieved. *That's something we can deal with easily* . A well-placed shot to wire her mouth shut would do the trick. Or a rod through her voice box. If she was immobilized, she would not be able to pull it out and when she healed, it would be

stuck in there. Once that was done, they could secure her human body, pump her full of sedatives, restrain her, and take her back.

"Erwin," Mike joined him. "I smell them."

"Direction?"

"All directions, all at once! Lots of them!"

I fucking knew it. Jean scowled. Sometimes, he really hated being right.

"What the hell?!" Jean said. Armin gasped at the sight. "They're rushing into the forest all at once!"

Below, multiple Titans ran by, all heading in one direction.

"Why are they suddenly ignoring us?!"

"What?" Ymir knelt on her branch as the ground shook, Bert beside her.

"Does this mean they're all Abnormals?!" Connie chased after the Titans with his squad.

"Doesn't matter!" One Scout said. "Don't let them through!"

"Engage the enemy!" An order went out.

This is going to be such a disaster. Hange's face had lost all of the previous cheer.

Mikasa pulled out her swords, "What was that all of a sudden?!"

"Please, wait!" Sasha stopped her. "I've heard screams like that before." She looked frightened. "In the forest where I'm from… It's the sound a cornered animal makes when it's ready to give up everything! I was taught the end of a hunt is when you have to be most careful!"

"So I should be careful?"

"Please be twice as careful than normal! You will die if you don't take the forest seriously!"

The recruits shifted nervously at her words. They knew Sasha's instincts were rarely wrong.

"I'm from the mountains too, actually," Mikasa said.

"You're a vegetable farmer! You wouldn't understand!"

They chuckled half-heartedly.

"I see." Mikasa looked away. *Sasha's hunches are often right. And more so when it involves danger* . Sasha was looking quite scary behind her. *Armin said Eren might be in the rear of the center rank, didn't he?*

Titans rushed through the forest.

"Hurry the explosives!" Erwin ordered.

"Erwin!" Mike said. "They'll come from the east! They're getting close!"

"Wagon defense squad, intercept them!"

A group of Scouts charged straight at them. The Titans passed them by.

"They're ignoring us?! Are they Abnormals?!"

"At least none of our people are dying," Connie said optimistically.

"Three Titans have broken through!"

Erwin had an almost terrified expression on his face.

It left the recruits a little unsettled.

"Corporal Levi!"

"Hey," Levi continued to stomp on the Female Titan's head. "You just did something, didn't you bitch?" With a sigh, he readied his swords.

Why is he holding them like that? Mikasa eyed the strange way he held the swords. Was it significant or just a quirk of his?

A hook shot out and Levi cut the napes of two Titans, spinning.

"Like a human fidget spinner," Candy snorted. "Ah, I just couldn't resist that one."

They felt a strange sense of relief wash over them, hearing her voice. But their hearts still continued to race anxiously.

A short Titan ran and grabbed the Female Titan's leg and bit the flesh covering her ankle. Erwin looked horrified. *They're targeting her?* With a choked gasp, he looked up to see the chaos around them.

"Titans coming from all directions!"

There were Titans everywhere, surrounding the Female Titan, far too many to count.

"All soldiers, commence combat!" Erwin said.

Levi, Hange, Moblit and the rest of the Scouts prepared to attack.

"Defend the Female Titan at all costs!"

Soldiers charged at the Titans attempting to devour the Survey Corps' target. The sounds of flesh being cut and blood spurting out through the air was heard. Levi sliced off more flesh. Erwin watched the gory mess tensely.

The visceral scene continued but their efforts were futile. Titans had the Female Titan surrounded, ripping into her flesh.

We've lost . Erwin felt calm. They had learned a great deal from watching their failure and he was thankful Candy had given them the chance to make sure the 57th Expedition would not result in such a loss.

Now we just need her identity. Once they had that, they could come up with a less bloody plan to capture her. The world was far bigger than anyone of them had ever imagined. And they had enemies out there who would not hesitate to do whatever it took to win.

And neither would he.

"It's no good!" Hange said.

They continued the slaughter. Titan blood splashed on Erwin's cheek and dissipated without him noticing. He closed his eyes. "All soldiers, retreat! Redeploy the formation! Return to Karanes District!"

A horde of Titans was gathered over the remains of the Female Titan while bodies of decaying others were littered around

them. Thick steam filled the air. Hange, Moblit, Mike, and other Scouts watched the scene in defeat.

"We've been bested," Erwin said.

"What's with that pathetic look of yours?" Levi wiped Titan blood off his face and looked at him, hanging against a tree. "Don't tell me you—"

"This goes to show that the enemy was prepared to throw away everything. I never imagined our target would resort to Titan cannibalization to avoid leaking information…" Erwin watched as the meat was entirely eaten away from the Female Titan, leaving a bloodied ribcage behind.

"So she's dead?" Sasha asked.

"Yes. At least, that's what it appears like," Petra answered.

"I bet she's not. Annie always struck me as far too selfish to—" Ymir began.

"It's not Annie," Connie insisted.

She eyed him, Sasha, and Eren. "You three still aren't convinced?"

"I won't be until I see her emerge from the carcass," Eren declared.

It's going to hurt that much more when he finds out after he's been defending her. Mikasa thought.

"After all that blustering we did in the courtroom," Levi said, "this is how it turns out. If we waltz back there now, who knows what'll happen to Eren or us."

"Forget them. The civilians will chew us up and spit us out before that," Jean muttered.

Christa winced. *We were so excited.* She could never have imagined the mission was going to end in a mess. *So many lives lost...*

"I swear if some assholes bitch about drain on taxes or any of that shit I'm gonna lose it," Eren growled.

"But it *was* a waste. All those dead soldiers, it was all for nothing," Connie said glumly.

Is she really dead though? Armin wondered. Something, instinct, told him she wasn't.

"We can think about that once we've returned. We need to focus on returning without sustaining any further losses. For now, at least." Erwin studied their environment. *The steam is impairing visibility. It could hinder smoke signal communications* .

An image of the Colossal Titan appearing and disappearing, steam around it, appeared momentarily.

Armin and Erwin suddenly reached the same conclusion.

"What is it, Armin?" Mikasa noticed his reaction, almost seeing the wheels turning in his head.

All eyes turned to him curiously.

"The Colossal Titan-Shifter used a steam cover to escape."

"We didn't see her die," Sasha gasped. "She's still alive!"

"Told you," Ymir muttered.

"I'm afraid it's not over yet," Hange said grimly.

"C'mon!" Connie groaned. "You know what? No. I refuse to get caught up in this. Because it hasn't happened and it won't." He crossed his arm. "I am not going to stress myself out over this."

"You're right," Christa nodded. "We have the power to change the outcome for the better."

"Yeah," Jean perked up. "It's just hard not to get caught up."

"Squad Levi could still beat her," Erwin said. "But yes, we have cause to remain optimistic."

"I'm going to get my squad."

"Wait, Levi," Erwin stopped him. "Replenish your gas and blades first."

"We're short on time and I have enough on hand to last. Why?" Levi asked.

"That's an order. Obey."

"Whatever you say, Erwin." Levi looked forward and paused for half a second. "I'll trust your judgment."

A blue flare went up.

Levi wanted to believe his squad could defeat her. But they were severely handicapped. She knew exactly who she was dealing with. *Do they even know what's happened?* If they had followed orders, which unquestionably he knew they would have, they were too far to hear the ambush. And seeing the blue flare they would think the Female Titan was captured and the mission was almost done. *They're expecting me* . Likely the female Shifter was heading for them, disguised as a Scout. *They'll think it's me* .

He had been fairly confident they could take her before. Now he wasn't so sure. *We underestimated her* . She was more dangerous than they'd ever imagined. He desperately hoped he'd find them before she did.

Levi did not want history to repeat itself and lose another squad. Even if the future wasn't set in stone yet. *We can prevent it. And we*

won't underestimate her this time .

More blue flares were shot as the Scouts acknowledged the order.

"The retreat signal. We're all to withdraw and return to base on horseback," Nanaba told Christa.

"Right!"

"What? Is it all over?" Jean said.

Armin was quietly looking at the sky.

Across the forest, Ymir and Bert, and Sasha and Mikasa were staring at the flares as well.

"Yes! We can go home!" Connie said in relief, with Reiner nearby.

What in the world is going on? Is Eren okay? **Mikasa thought.**

"Looks like it's over." Gunther looked at the blue flare and turned. "Let's get back to the horses! Prepare to withdraw!"

"Guess so," Oluo stood up. "Let's go see what the bastard riding inside it looks like."

Eren tapped his gas canister. "Did they really find out who it is?"

"All thanks to you!" Petra smiled, checking her equipment.

"Huh? But I didn't do anything."

"You trusted us, remember? Things turned out this way because you chose to stick with us. Making the right call is a pretty hard thing to do, you know!" Petra explained as he stared at her with an awed expression on his face.

How differently would it have ended if Eren had transformed and attacked her? Sasha thought.

"Was it really the right call though?" Eren thought out loud.

"We'll never know," Mikasa replied. "No point beating yourself up over something that's happened. Or will not happen."

"Hey, now. Quit babying him, Petra. How was he any help?" Oluo had his hands on his hips, posing haughtily. "All he did was whine like a pathetic little brat. I guess making it back alive might be considered praiseworthy, but only after the mission's done and over with. Just so you know, twerp, an expedition isn't over until you're back home."

"He tries way too hard," Jean rolled his eyes.

"Jeez, I get it already," Eren said. Neither he nor Petra were moved at all by his words.

"Oluo! Petra!" Erd looked back at them, flying through the air. "For a couple of soldiers who cried and pissed their pants during their first battle, you've really grown!"

"What?"

"Really?"

"You did?"

"No way!"

"Even elite soldiers are humans I guess."

The recruits and Hange giggled and Petra groaned. "He never misses an opportunity to bring that up. Ass."

"Did you really?" Eren asked her.

"Yes," she shrugged. "See? No need to feel too embarrassed," she told Sasha. "I had an embarrassing incident on my first expedition and everything still turned out okay."

The memory of apologizing to a Titan still made Sasha wanted to rip her hair in frustration. "Yeah," Sasha smiled gratefully.

Petra cried out in mortification. "Don't tell him that! Are you trying to make him lose all respect for me, Erd?!"

"Whoa, she really did?"

"It's the truth. And just so you know I never pissed myself, Eren."

They laughed.

"You idiot!" Oluo made a face. "I'll have you know I have the highest kill count! I'm the best, you moron!"

"There's more to a soldier's merits than just kill counts!"

"Shut up, you idiot!"

"Petra, does that mean it sprayed everywhere in midair?" Eren asked.

The viewers burst into laughter.

"Eren," Mikasa chided, but she was smiling.

"Sorry." Eren did not look or sound apologetic at all.

Petra crossed her arms and sighed, blushing lightly. *At least they only heard about instead of watching it* . She cringed. That would've been mortifying. *Well, now that my most embarrassing secret is out, I suppose I won't have to worry about anything else coming up* .

"Knock it off! Are you on a picnic or something?!" Gunther demanded. "We're outside the Walls, you know!" He looked ahead. "Also, I never wet myself either, Eren!"

"I never wet myself either," Jean snorted, grinning.

"He's not missing a chance to rub it in either," Christa giggled.

A hooded figure in a Survey Corps cloak loaded a flare gun and fired.

"Is that Corporal Levi?" Connie squinted. "I can't tell."

Gunther noticed the green smoke in the distance. "Oh. That must be a message from Captain Levi. We're rendezvousing with the captain! Save the chatter until we're home!" He landed on a branch and fired off a flare in reply.

The hooded figure dropped the flare gun and pulled out the swords. The gun dropped to the ground and the owner took off.

"Who is that?" Eren tilted his head, trying to look under the hood.

"Why would he wear the hood all of a sudden?" Jean asked. "Or is that some fashion statement you like to make?"

Levi's face clearly stated it most certainly was not.

"There's no reason for him to cover his face. Why would he want to hide his identity from his squad? Especially considering the situation. Only one person has the motive to conceal their face. The Female Titan-Shifter," Christa concluded.

Nervously, they watched quietly.

Horses raced through the Forest of Giant Trees, with Erwin, Mike, and Hange in the lead.

"Erwin, why did you have Levi replenish his supplies when there's no time to waste?" Hange looked to him.

"The female was eaten. But did you see the person inside get eaten?" Erwin stared straight ahead. "I didn't."

Hange gasped. "Are you saying?!"

"Yes. If, as you hypothesized earlier, we're dealing with a type that can move to an extent after transformation."

They were right . Hange thought, upset. Eren had been a Titan-Shifter—aware of his abilities and using them—for too small amount of time to make proper assumptions off of him regarding the others. *She's more experienced. Her body can better handle the strain of transforming and she can still move and Shift again* .

"We should have prepared for this possibility, just as a precaution," Erwin frowned at the oversight.

The Shifter had almost caught up to the Special Ops Squad.

"And,"* Erwin narrated, *"if this person had equipped themselves with 3D gear in advance that means they're now wearing one of our uniforms…"

"Captain Levi?" Gunther did not look sure, eyeing the figure flying parallel to them. "No, it's not! Who are you?!"

They're not fooled! Christa's eyes lit up. Her relief was short-lived.

The mysterious figure immediately launched toward him, slicing him with her swords. Gunther's body hit the tree, hanging

upside-down limply.

They gasped in surprise and horror.

"Shit!"

"No!"

"Fuck..."

"Gunther," Petra's eyes widened. *No way...*

Levi's chest tightened painfully, hands clenching into fists in his lap.

"The shit is about to hit the fan again," Ymir said unhappily.

"Gunther!" Eren yelled in shock. "Hey! What happened?! Gunther!" He stared horrified, hovering before the dead, bloodied man.

Levi and Petra looked particularly pissed off.

I fucking hate her so much . Eren was furious.

The hooded figure continued to fly through the trees.

"…and have blended in with the rest of us soldiers."

All eyes turned to Erwin, waiting for the next episode. "We're taking a break." They had agreed to do so every five episodes or so.

"But sir—" Eren began in protest.

"He's right. We need to rest up and make sure we don't miss anything," Hange put in.

Even if they were dying to get to the next episode, the recruits nodded in understanding and broke up, moving to different parts of the room, stretching and talking.

"It's okay," Armin reassured his two best friends. "I know it's awful to watch but this is good. If we know all that can go wrong, we can be better prepared when we're out there."

"She snuck out and found us and she'll transform again, I just know it," Eren said, convinced.

"That's possible yes," Mikasa nodded. "The only thing we can do now is wait and watch and make sure that bitch regrets ever fucking with us."

The two looked at her in surprise. Mikasa rarely swore.

"But what are they gonna do?" Connie looked over at the right couch where the veterans sat. "They're down one teammate."

"Whatever maneuvers they know, they'll have to adjust to attacking as a trio instead of a team," Christa said.

"They have to adapt quickly or they'll die," Jean crossed his arms.

"Or stall until Corporal Levi shows up," Sasha said.

"She's killed all the other soldiers in a matter of seconds," Ymir pointed out.

"I don't know how long we can hold her off," Petra admitted. "She can do things Eren can't. It's as you said, Captain. We have to be fast, attack before she can harden. But she has to reveal what she can do first before we can figure out how to overcome it."

"I'm sure you can figure it out," Levi nodded. *I hope I make it in time* .

Since you guys love no pairing stories but hate that you can't find any, here's a great one: Rogue *by* RedCoaster . *It's in my favorites.*

Please Review~

Episode - Crushing Blow

Chapter 21: Crushing Blow

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The group learns about the Female Titan's abilities. They worry, seeing the plan fail spectacularly but try to remain hopeful. They take a break, anxious about the next episode.

The Scouts raced through the Forest of Giant Trees.

C'mon! Show us the other scene! Eren stared hard at the TV.

" When the Colossal Titan vanished," Erwin began, "whoever was inside had been wearing maneuver gear, so that they could escape in the steam. Don't you think the same possibility applies here?"

It has to be him. It fits. Armin frowned. *Bert's gotta be the Colossal Titan* . Some of the things he had seen in the previous episodes had hinted strongly at the identity of the Armored Titan. He thought about their physical traits. *Three of them* , *and three Titans like Eren, the Female, the Armored, and the Colossal.*

" But at the time…" Hange said. "Based on what we saw when Eren emerged from the Titan, we concluded it would be impossible."

An image of Eren coming out of his Titan form appeared.

" His equipment was destroyed, and his uniform was gone."

Mikasa hugged Eren close to her on the roof, surrounded by Armin, Reiner, Bert, Annie, and Jean as Hange narrated. "Above all, Eren was so weak, he couldn't even stand unassisted."

" The Female Titan was able to attract other Titans with her cry. We failed to predict this, and the operation failed. If Titan abilities vary depending on skill, it was a mistake to use Eren, a total novice, as the basis for our assumptions."

It's so painfully obvious now, after watching this . Hange thought, frustrated. *Then again,* she glanced at the rookies. They had figured it out with the same amount of knowledge. *They saw the huge flaws in our logic almost immediately* . *Maybe we should have them go over the plans for any holes or mistakes* . She snorted quietly herself. *We're getting old* .

Erwin shifted his eyes straight ahead. "If we are to outwit our enemy, we'll need to think outside the box."

Horse hooves were heard on the outer edges of the forest.

" If we're withdrawing, does that mean the mission succeeded?" Jean said to Armin.

If only . Armin thought.

" If so, then we may already know who was inside the Female Titan."

"That we do," Jean said.

Eren shot him a dirty look.

The group continued.

" I'd like to see who it is… But why was the commander so sure that the enemy would come after Eren if he left the walls?" Jean wondered.

" I think it's because, for some reason, they suddenly stopped their advance in the midst of the last assault. Even though they managed to break through Trost's gate," Armin's thoughts turned to the Armored Titan breaching Wall Maria, "they didn't even try for the inner gate. And when Eren sealed the gate," the Rogue slammed the rock into place, "they let him. It could mean that they now have bigger concerns…"

" Bigger concerns?"

" Something more important to them than breaching the walls. Something unexpected that happened," Armin tilted his head at his fellow Scout.

I hope Candy will reveal where their powers came from . Erwin thought. Was it the same way Eren received his? Through some sort of serum?

Jean's eyes widened, "Eren's transformation into a Titan?!"

" I think it's the only answer."

" Then… That means…" Jean came to the same realization. But he was unable to wrap his head around it. "Wait… So…"

Someone who was there, who saw Eren transform, is the Titan. **Armin concluded, grim.**

It's one of our comrades. Sasha felt uncomfortable. *Is it really Annie?* She could not believe it, not without concrete evidence *. But everything Armin says has been right on the dot. And he hasn't been wrong ever before.* How could they spend years training together, becoming friends with a person, never realizing their true nature?

Everyone collectively tensed.

The cloaked figure moved away as Eren hung in mid-air, staring at the dead body in disbelief, "Gunther!"

"Move, idiot," Ymir said. "You're a sitting duck."

" Eren," Oluo grabbed him and pulled him along, "don't stop! Onward!" He gave the teen a shove.

Eren watched their deceased comrade be left behind, "But Gunther!" He gasped when the intruder suddenly appeared in his line of sight. "Who's there?"

" Protect Eren! Damn it," Oluo looked over his shoulder, "what do we do? Erd, where should we go?"

I'm so stressed! Connie fanned himself. *So much for refusing to get caught up in this!*

" There isn't time to reach the horses! Head for HQ as fast as you can!"

Sunlight broke through the foliage, making the forest look deceptively peaceful.

" Is it from the Female Titan?" Oluo looked back as they flew away. "Or is there more than one?"

" Damn you…" Petra glared. "How dare you?!" She turned her body toward the intruder, enraged. "Come at me! I'll defeat you, even if it kills me!"

"Don't be so reckless," Levi chided, overcome with dread. *I've already lost one member* .

"I know, Sir." Petra could imagine how difficult it would be controlling her temper after seeing her close friend and comrade be killed. She was angry just watching it happen on screen.

The Female Titan? Impossible… **Eren thought, panicked.** ***Why? Didn't we catch it?!***

The cloaked figure fell back.

Squad Levi was silent, looking back, waiting for what they knew was coming.

The atmosphere in the room thickened in anxious anticipation.

Erwin's voice echoed, ***"If the enemy has some way to retain its strength, it may be able to transform once more."***

Mikasa's jaw clenched, her expression cold. *Annie...if you lay a finger on Eren I will crush your skull with my bare hands* .

A massive explosion boomed across the forest, sending shockwaves through the air.

" I knew it… It's coming!" Erd yelled. "The Female Titan!"

The Female Titan emerged from the steam, running at them.

Their heartbeats started picking up with the music.

" Damn you…" Eren turned around to face her. "How dare you! This time, I will defeat it!" He brought his hand up.

"Yes!" Several voices screamed.

" No!" Erd stopped him.

"No *you* !" Christa pointed at the TV.

" The three of us will kill the Female Titan. You will continue to head straight for HQ at top speed!"

The Female Titan continued to charge at them silently, a deadly expression on her face.

" Here's what I have gleaned from this battle," Erwin told Hange. "If we only focus on making the best moves, we will never get the better of our opponent. When necessary, we must be willing to take big risks, and be prepared to lose everything.

" I'll fight, too!" Eren yelled.

"Fucking do it!" Jean said.

" No! This is the best move. Your power is too risky!"

He could lose control and make things worse . Levi nodded. *Then again, considering the situation, if he does go berserk, she's the biggest opponent and he'll go for her first.* It was logical but also very convenient to a mindless Eren rampaging as a Titan. But while that scenario may save his squad it would not save Eren so they would never go for it.

" What? Do you doubt us?" Oluo demanded

" Do you, Eren? Do you find it that hard to trust us?" Petra asked, eyes pleading.

Eren stared, undecided.

"No, no, no, no, no," Connie shook his head. "It's not that he doesn't *trust* you," he began explaining, gesturing with his hands, "he doesn't

want to lose you."

"You do realize they can't hear you, right?" Armin said.

"It helps me, okay?" Connie crossed his arms.

"It's cathartic," Christa nodded.

" Unless we change how we fight, humanity cannot win," Erwin said grimly.

Eren needs to learn how to fight with the Scouts. Hange's eyes twinkled at the thought of fighting alongside the Rogue Titan. She wondered if he'd let her hitch a ride on his shoulder sometime.

Eren finally lowered his hand and moved past them. *I believe my squad will be victorious. Good luck!*

"You guys had better not die now," Sasha said to the TV.

Petra smiled, and Oluo and Erd smirked, nodding beside her. The three turned back to face the Female Titan.

"Here we go," Petra said.

Eren watched the trio fly at the Titan. Erd raised his arms up with a battle cry, ready to slice her. The Female Titan made a grab at him.

The viewers gasped, then let out sighs of relief when he released steam to stop his momentum and block her view.

Petra and Oluo shot forward as soon their teammate moved back. Their hooks lodged next to the Female Titan's eyes, who was shocked at their appearance.

"The distraction worked!" Eren's were lit up in delight, hands clenched into fists in excitement.

Petra and Oluo attacked successfully. And blood exploded as they spun away.

"Fuck yeah!" Connie cheered.

"Finally!" Christa grinned.

"Turn her into mincemeat!" Jean yelled.

Eren gasped, mouth slightly open.

"Maybe you should have had them take her on from the get-go," Ymir said.

About time she was forced to go on the defensive . Hange thought.

Eyes covered in blood, the Female Titan fell back, covering her nape with one hand.

"Kill her!" Sasha pumped her fist in the air.

"Smart move taking out the eyes," Armin nodded, smiling. *Maybe they can do it after all!*

"It's not over yet. There's still her hardening ability she's hiding," Petra said.

Levi agreed, "Can't celebrate yet." But even he couldn't stop the sliver of hope from spreading as the scene continued.

We took its sight. **Erd thought, an intense look on his face.** ***For at least a minute, it'll be in total darkness!***

A whole minute. Plenty of time. Erwin knew if they attacked her continuously, and rapidly to counter her hardening of her body parts, they wouldn't even need the whole sixty seconds to defeat her.

Kill it during this time! **Petra thought.**

Screw capturing it… **Oluo gritted his teeth.**

Kill it now! **Erd thought.**

Die here without honor! **Petra glared.**

Make that bitch of a Titan pay! **Oluo thought.**

"Holy shit," Eren gaped. *They're awesome!*

"It's fascinating to see them think as they attack," Hange said. It was interesting compared to how she was used to watching them surround a Titan, kill it, and move on to the next target with little to no communication.

"They're thinking in sync while attacking with speed and precision without getting in each other's way," Mikasa stared incredulously. *Almost like a hive mindset . How can they do that?*

"It's why they're the best of the best," Erwin smiled. It was good to have solid proof their most elite team was trustworthy. *If they all know the truth they have a good chance of winning against her* .

The Female Titan stood with her back against the tree.

We won't let your eyes regenerate! **Erd pointed his left elbow up, tapping his sword against the under part of the arm.**

Petra and Oluo understood, flying toward the motionless Titan. Hooks embedded into the tree. They launched an attack from above, flying down on either side of her, taking out some of the muscles.

Pink flesh and blood flew as Erd sliced off more.

They can do it! Eren thought. *They can kill the Female Titan!* He only wished he could help them tear her up.

We'll shear off so much muscle around your shoulders you won't be able to keep your arms up! **Erd focused on her face. He sliced up several muscles and fell back, letting his squadmates get at her.**

Hange felt something needle her in the back of the head.

They began slashing relentlessly as a team.

The room exploded into cheers and shouts of joy and encouragement.

"Skin her!"

"Make her pay!"

"Serves the bitch right!"

Petra carved off more skin. ***Shear it off!***

"I've been waiting for this moment!"

"No mercy! The cunt didn't show any when slaughtering our comrades and deserves to be butchered like the animal she is!"

Make its arms… **Oluo attacked next.**

… fall! **Erd thought.**

"YEAH!"

"Don't stop! Keeping going!"

"You messed with the wrong people!"

"I am LOVING this!"

The Female Titan's arms collapsed uselessly from the assault.

The rookies started to whistle and clap, some standing up, unable to stay in their spots.

"Whoo-hoo!"

"Yes! Yes, yes, yes!"

"You did it!"

"I knew you guys could do it! I never had any doubts!"

"Yeah right, Connie."

Petra bit her lip. *Does she want us to go for the nape?* Her arms were useless. Was she going to harden her weak spot and wait for her eyes to heal? *We'll be within in reach then and she'll attack once she's recovered* . They had to end it soon, before the minute was up.

But what if we miss our time window and the Female Titan starts using her hardening abilities? Where could they attack to do the most damage? Petra didn't think the previous distraction was going to work twice. *The Achilles tendons, maybe. And the muscles behind her knees, her hamstrings.* With her mobility impaired, it would buy Eren precious time to put more distance between them.

" They're down!" Erd ordered, "Now the neck!"

" Shear off the muscles that support its neck!" Oluo yelled.

" And we can strike its weak point!" Petra readied her blades.

"Yeah! Fucking finish her!"

Wait a second. Hange's eyes narrowed.

Erwin had also caught on. *So she can do that as well.* They needed to try quite a few things with Eren it seemed.

The trio moved on the Female Titan together.

Levi frowned, feeling like he had missed something. And it was making him jittery.

They're so strong. **Eren thought, watching his squad.** ***The Female Titan is totally on the defensive. How can they launch co-op attacks like that without even speaking to each other?***

An image of Squad Levi standing talking with each other appeared.

I bet it's only possible because they believe in one another. They've overcome many hardships that way. That's why they're so strong, even right after losing Gunther. **Eren turned, staring ahead in determination.** ***I'll go forward… If I go forward and believe in them, without turning back, then…I'm sure that's the right answer. I finally understand!***

Levi's cloak flew, leading his squad through the forest. ***"I don't know…"***

Eren's eyes widened, recalling his words.

" I never have. I can believe in my own abilities or the choices of companions I trust."

" I disagree. Trust yourself and your comrades. What's stronger, five fingers or a fist?" Candy asked.

"That's what we said before," Ymir nodded. "For Eren to learn more about his abilities, training and fighting alongside his squad. There is no way she could have stopped them all working together like a real team."

"But who knows, they could still win," Christa said optimistically. "They've backed her into a corner."

" But no one ever knows how it will turn out."

Levi felt inexplicably uneasy, hearing his own words.

Why does this feel so foreboding? Armin subtly checked his fellow recruits' reactions for a second, noticing the happy, exhilarated smiles on Jean, Ymir, and Mikasa disappearing, turning into frowns instead.

A terrible thought was growing in Hange's mind. *The steam...it was rising only from one eye. Could that mean...*

Eren looked back with a strangled gasp.

"Why is he making that face? Why are you making that face?" Connie asked worriedly.

Eren didn't answer, looking apprehensive.

The bright smile disappeared from Christa's face. "Oh no..."

The charged atmosphere muted and became dull with nervousness.

It's like Corporal Levi said earlier, they can inflict damage long as they move faster than Annie can harden a body part, and they're fast. Jean thought they could, theoretically, defeat her, before she had a chance to use her ability. He wanted to believe that would come true. But he wasn't optimistic by nature.

" Strike the neck, now!" Erd went for it.

The Female Titan's head shot forward and she took a bite.

"Holy shit!"

"What the fuck!"

They flinched, jerking back away from the screen, some hands flying to mouths and heads in shock and horror.

" Erd!" Petra screamed.

"No," Connie's eyes widened.

The Female Titan spat out part of his body. Eren wailed, swinging around and heading back toward his squad.

The viewers watched in dead silence, disbelieving and despondent.

" H-how?" Petra moved away, almost parallel to the ground. "It can't possibly see! It hasn't even been thirty seconds."

Levi and Armin suddenly had the same thought: *The steam had been rising from one eye.*

The Female Titan's right eye came into focus.

The feeling of impending doom began to grow.

" Only one eye? It prioritized one eye to accelerate the healing… Is that even possible?"

"Oh fuck," Ymir said quietly.

The Female Titan moved, running at her.

"No, no, no, no, no," Christa began, eyes watering.

" Petra!" Oluo said.

"RUN!" Sasha yelled.

" We need to regroup!"

Get out of there! Jean thought frantically.

The Female Titan charged full-speed.

Snap out of it, you idiot! Petra thought furiously. *You need to protect Eren!*

" Petra, now!"

Levi felt hopelessly powerless, unable to do anything but sit and watch his squad be annihilated.

The Female Titan slammed Petra at the base of the tree with her foot.

The Scouts flinched, letting out strangled gasps and screams in dismay at the scene.

Petra felt a strange sensation go down her spine, causing her to sit ramrod straight. It was such a morbid and surreal feeling, watching oneself die. *Huh, thought I'd last a bit longer, how disappointing* .

"Fuck! Are you kidding me?!"

"No way!"

"What the hell!"

"That's not supposed to happen!"

They continued to yell in anger, frustration, and despair.

"She's destroying another squad, killing more of our comrades..."

"They should have killed her! She should have died! This is fucked up!"

"Why? Why won't that piece of shit fucking die?!"

"I officially hate her more than anything. She's trumped the bed bugs."

Erwin didn't say a word, waiting for the angry grumblings to quiet down.

Suddenly, a macabre thought popped up in Petra's head: *At least my dad will have a body to bury. At least they can bring back more than an arm or leg* . The scene began to replay in her head and she felt

anger welling up from deep inside. *I failed! I let them all down! Eren and Captain Levi and the Survey Corps and humanity!* She felt like a failure. Her throat closed. The shame and disappointment made her want to cry. *What a disgrace* .

Eren cried out in distress.

He felt a burning ball of rage and pain. It took every ounce of self-control Eren had not to throw the table at the TV, shouting in anger.

A familiar feeling of bloodlust overrode his senses, causing the world around him to disappear. He could almost imagine the sickening sound Petra's spine must have made when it broke, recalling with perfect clarity how it sounded when the Smiling Titan broken his mother in half. *The Female Titan Shifter...* He glared, feeling the hate take hold of him.

The heated emotions made him almost dizzy. *No mercy.* His fingers began twitching almost uncontrollably. He took a long, shaky breath and focused himself. *...I'm going to turn her into a pulpy mess of broken bones, blood, and torn flesh, nothing but an ugly stain on the ground.*

Oluo quickly overcame his grief and stared in resolve.

The group quieted, watching in silence, with enraged or grim expressions on all of their faces.

A hook shot into the base of Female Titan's exposed nape. "Hey… Die!" Oluo went for the kill. The blades broke, the shiny crystal cracking. "How?" He said in disbelief. "My blade can't pierce it…"

The Female Titan kicked him, destroying his gear and killing him instantaneously.

The Scouts flinched at the sudden attack.

Levi felt like someone had taken a sledgehammer to his chest.

I should have been with them! He was beyond angry with himself. *Second time my squad needed me and died because I was absent.* It was incredibly frustrating and the urge to rip his hair out and scream was immense. He wasn't needed once the Female Titan was captured. She was immobile. Mike, their best soldier second only to him, was there with his squad and Hange and her squad were there as well. *My presence was completely unnecessary* . *I should have been with them instead* . Levi's head pounded. *I failed my squad again* .

The Female Titan landed in a crouch and the ground shook.

Eren stared at the scene, mouth open, an expression of horror and denial on his face. *I…*

A shot of a vacant-eyed Erd appeared, his body just below his shoulders not there.

Petra appeared next, her front side pressed against the tree, her back bent at an impossible angle.

Tears filled Eren's eyes. "I will…"

Sniffs were heard around the room and eyes were wiped to get rid of the moisture.

Oluo lay in a puddle of blood in the grass, unmoving.

The members of Squad Levi wanted to hurl.

Annie, they'll never forgive you for this. Ymir thought.

" I'll kill it!" Eren shot toward the crouching Female Titan, biting his hand. There was a loud explosion and brilliant golden-orange light.

The viewers cried out, screaming in joy.

Steam blew across a big, intense green eye.

The cheers became louder.

The Rogue Titan roared, feet digging into the ground, heading for the enemy.

The group's shouts and cheers were the loudest they'd ever been.

Their blood was pumping, hearts racing, feeling the adrenaline kicking in. The powerful roar and music left them feeling exhilarated. This time the tears shining in their eyes were from exuberance.

"Rip her head off!"

"Crush her!"

Erwin looked up, startled.

Rogue roared again, sounding almost anguished.

"You're gonna get it now, you giant fucking hag!" Christa yelled, much to their surprise and delight, causing her friends to chuckle.

" Eren?" Mikasa's head snapped in the direction of the roar and she flew away without hesitation.

They couldn't help but laugh, not at all surprised she ran off to chase after Eren.

" Wait, what?" Sasha reached out. "Mikasa?"

"Fuck yeah," Jean said gleefully. "Mikasa will kick her ass!"

"I certainly hope I get the chance," Mikasa answered, eager at the prospect.

Eren daydreamed deliriously about the violence he was about to unleash on the Female Titan.

That voice… **Levi's eyes shifted to the side. *Don't tell me…* He swung around and turned back.**

"Yeah! Go corporal!"

"I hope all three of them tear her to pieces!"

"This is going to be so fucking awesome!"

Levi hoped savagely his TV counterpart flayed the murdering bitch.

"Tear her a new one!"

"Make her regret ever existing!"

Sasha threw up her hands, "This is gonna be so *gooooood!* "

Please don't die, Eren, Mikasa. Armin thought.

"Clash of two Titan-Shifters! I'm so excited!" Hange shrieked happily, wiggling in her seat.

Can Eren overcome her hardening ability? Will the fight result in the emergence of the same power in him? Or a new one unique to him? Erwin leaned forward in anticipation.

The Female Titan's body steamed as she watched the Rogue Titan run wildly at her.

Eren...you haven't completely lost control, have you? Mikasa felt nervous. There was a certain feral quality to his movements.

Meanwhile Armin and Erwin weighed the pros of Eren losing the fight. If the Female Titan took him back to her civilization, they could gather unbiased intel without jeopardizing anyone. Their biggest failures would give them valuable information. But they could prevent those disasters when the time came and have a great advantage over the enemy.

The Female Titan weakly stood up. The Rogue Titan threw a wide swing and she dodged easily, putting some distance between them.

"Too wide," Ymir chided.

"Don't give her an opening to counter!" Sasha added.

Rogue skid back, salvia bursting out of his mouth from her fierce kick to his gut. Bracing with his knees, he came to a stop and took the opportunity to grab her leg and push her. The Female Titan stumbled, her upper back hitting the tree behind her. One blue eye glinted in resolution.

"Don't give her time to recover! Continue the assault!" Connie yelled.

Rogue breathed loudly, arms up in position. The Female Titan waited, her shoulder steaming. Rogue made the first move, throwing punch after punch.

Several people began yelling instructions.

"Don't let her put distance between you!"

"Aim for the liver!"

"Grapple her!"

"Headbutt! Do a headbutt!"

One punch connected and sent her to the ground but she quickly rolled to a crouch and took off. Rogue growled, chasing after her. The sound of fists meeting flesh was heard as a low angle shot of the trees appeared.

"Rogue's growling but you can't tell who's hitting who," Christa's brow furrowed with worry.

Levi flew through the air, a blank look across his face. He passed by Gunther's hanging corpse.

Pity rose in their chests for him.

How many times have you experienced this nightmare I wonder? Ymir thought.

Despite her negative feelings toward him, Mikasa found herself feeling sympathetic.

Poor guy, almost his entire squad's been decimated . Connie shuddered, imagining what that could be like. Losing Marco had been devastating, he didn't even want to think about losing an entire squad.

Tears blurred his vision. Eren hung his head in shame. *This is my fault.*

At the sight of Erd and Oluo's corpses, Levi's face closed, head bowed slightly, shadows covering his expression.

Hange and Erwin, knowing the man best out of everyone in the room, could easily imagine the real heartbreak he had to be feeling despite his lack of reaction.

He's still got his shit together in the face of his dead, mangled squad . Jean knew he wasn't heartless, they had all seen hints of his compassion; reassuring a dying soldier his death would not be in vain. *How much tragedy does it take that such a sight doesn't elicit an immediate and violent reaction?* Jean wondered if he would reach such a state if he survived long enough in the Survey Corps.

Levi continued, landing gracefully on a branch, taking in the sight of Petra's body awkwardly forced against the tree in an unnatural position. Blood from her nose and mouth marred part of her face and hair, her normally warm amber eyes listless. Levi blinked slowly, his stoic expression unchanging.

Eren wiped his tears, looking mourningly at his female squadmate. *She died. I was right there and she died right in front of me. I can't believe it...*

"Don't cry. It's okay," Petra said gently. "As a soldier in the Survey Corps, you have to be prepared to die at any given moment out there."

"It doesn't faze you at all?" Ymir asked.

"I'd be lying if I said no," she shuddered. "I'm a little freaked out." She could feel the goosebumps breaking out across her skin again, replaying her death scene. A shiver went down her spine.

"Now that you know, you can change it," Sasha said. "So it's okay!"

"That's right," Christa nodded. "The future can be changed!"

"Yes, I won't fail again." Petra clenched her hands into fists.

"We were thinking more along the lines of *don't die* but sure," Connie said.

"We know what's really coming now," Armin leaned over and placed a reassuring hand on his best friend's shoulder. "When it happens, we'll be prepared to handle the worst."

Eren nodded, "Yeah..." He wiped away the tears, setting his jaw. *No use crying about it. Take a deep breath* . He would do better. *This time I won't hesitate to crush anyone who dares harm those I care about* .

Rogue went after the Female Titan, throwing fast punches but she evaded easily, until she lost her balance and fell back. She attempted to get up but he held her down, pinning her with his legs. Rogue lifted one arm high, poised to strike.

He's got her pinned down but she still hasn't used her abilities. Erwin observed. What was she planning?

I made the wrong choice… **The memory of his squad asking him if he trusted them appeared.** ***I wanted to believe in my companions… Because of that, everyone died!*** **Rogue brought his fist down and she moved her head to avoid the hit.**

Rogue's shoulder was dislocated with part of his arm broken from the impact. ***If I had believed in myself from the start and fought… If I'd only killed it at the beginning!*** **The Female Titan twisted her neck again to dodge another punch. The ground shattered and dust flew.**

I could have saved so many Scouts from dying . Eren gritted his teeth in frustration. *Even if she had beaten me, I would have at least tired her out!* She would have been easy picking for the others then.

Rogue loomed over the Female Titan, steam rising from his two arm stumps.

The Female Titan kept silent, staring, her left eye steaming.

"She's waiting for her eye to finish healing," Hange frowned. "Monocular vision. Her depth perception is impaired but functional. That's why she kept backing away and only threw that kick when he was directly in front of her."

"She's buying time," Erwin nodded, understanding. "If Eren does not finish her quickly she'll recover and then the fight will truly begin."

Back then, **Eren thought back to the Female Titan chasing his squad, *if I'd turned into a Titan… No… If I'd fought even before that…* His thoughts turned to first entering the Forest of Giant Trees with the Female Titan on their heels. *Captain Levi was there, too. We would have won. Maybe we could've captured it* .**

" You aren't wrong. If you want to do it, do it."

***I… I made a choice* . A side view of Petra's corpse appeared. *And it killed everyone. It's my fault they died* .**

No. You made the right choice. Levi's entire body felt heavy from misery. *The Female Titan was captured. Maybe if I hadn't provoked her...* Either way, he should have gone with them.

But despite all that… It's still your fault!* Rogue roared, shoulders shaking. The Female Titan shifted her face away, Rogue's face hovering inches from hers, screaming. *I'll tear you apart…

Eren nodded, glaring.

***Once my hand heals, I'll rip you apart…* Rogue's head was spasming.**

"What's wrong with him?" Christa's voice was wary.

"He's experiencing extreme emotions, it could be that," Hange answered. "They're overwhelming him."

Tear you to shreds… Rip you into tiny pieces!* A green eye was twitching wildly before rolling to the back of the head. *And eat you!

They nodded in agreement, anger clear on their faces.

Eren was covered in red muscles, inside his Titan.

Hange gasped in delight. Unfortunately, she didn't get to see more of the inside view of a Shifter in his Titan body.

A blue eye opened suddenly.

Well that's not good. Petra thought.

The Female Titan gripped his arm and twisted her body, forcing his knees apart, giving her room to move and sit up. Rogue attempted to grab her and earned himself a kick to his ribs, sending him sliding back into a tree. She was almost upright when he attacked and she leaned back, grazed by the wild swing. Rogue used his free arm to aim a punch at her face but she evaded. She went rolling to the ground, arms protecting her head.

Missing the target, the momentum of the swing caused Rogue to fall. The Female Titan stumbled back on her hands and feet but Rogue was on top of her immediately, roaring, his entire body twitching slightly.

"I don't like this," Jean said.

The Female Titan looked afraid. A fist came right at her and she dodged quickly, arms up in position.

"She can fight back now," Christa said.

"Just hold on," Mikasa said, stressed.

Now the Female Titan did not stumble, carefully avoiding Rogue's punches. She narrowed her eyes when he threw his arm back in preparation. The skin on her left hand and arm was suddenly coated in shiny crystal. The punch landed on Rogue's jaw, knocking out some teeth and sending droplets of blood in the air.

Many winced.

The Female Titan's eyes widened when Rogue came right for her, jaw locked on her arm and teeth sliding toward her.

"Ouch." Sasha wasn't the only one cringing at the sound of Rogue's teeth on the armored skin.

"That made my jaw tingle," Christa rubbed her cheeks.

Coming from a low angle, the Rogue Titan swung up with his entire body, punching her in the gut and sending her flying up in the air.

"Now that's what I'm taking about!" Connie grinned.

Rogue charged and the Female Titan quickly moved out of the way, the knee meant for her face hitting the tree instead. He placed an arm on the tree, hunched over, breathing loudly.

He was too angry, too wild. The surge of emotions gave him a boost but he's out of steam now. Levi thought. *He's tired himself out* .

"What's taking so long?" Mikasa muttered, frustrated. *How far am I still from them?* Soon Eren would no longer be able to fight.

The Female Titan stopped. There was an almost resigned look on her face before her hair covered her expression, and she slowly turned to face him.

"Uh-oh, I don't like that," Hange said.

Rogue looked exhausted and yet still brought up a shaking fist. Then he stopped, eyes widening when a pink foot stepped forward.

"What's with that stupid face?" Levi frowned.

Eren's face appeared, half obscured by muscles, his expression that of pure shock.

"Uh..." Connie scratched his head in confusion.

"What?" Christa looked around, unsure, wondering if she missed something. "What's going on?"

"Is she revealing another ability?" Erwin wondered.

Lighting fast a blow ripped apart Rogue's face and broke the tree in half.

"No!" Mikasa cried out.

"What just happened?" Petra's eyes widened. "Why didn't he dodge or protect himself?"

"Why did you just stand there and take it?" Hange asked.

"I don't know," Eren answered, gaping. *What the fuck?* He was supposed to beat her nearly to death, not stop fighting and let her rip his face off. *Are you fucking kidding me?*

"No way," Armin's eyes widened. He had a good idea why Eren had frozen. *He knows* .

"Is she going to take him now? Have we lost?" Sasha said with a surprisingly serious look on her face.

Ymir was on the same page as Armin. *He must've recognized her stance.* She didn't bother pointing it out, knowing the ones who did not believe Armin's theory would argue and refuse to listen to her. "There are still four more episodes. I don't think we've lost just yet."

The severed heard went flying. The Female Titan's body spun to face him, arm steaming.

From the way it showed her right after the punch and the way she just came to a stop, the punch or kick was thrown using her body's weight. Levi noted. It had to, it would take a considerable amount of force to do what she just did. So why did Eren not dodge? He was

adept at hand-to-hand combat, he had to know the lethal power such a move would carry.

Levi imagined the position she must have taken. *Knees bent, left arm forward, right back.* He glanced at Armin, thinking back to Annie beating Eren and Reiner. *The girl he said was the Shifter, she could deliver that kind of hit in her unique stance* . It explained why Eren froze. More evidence in favor of Armin's claim.

Rogue's decapitated body fell to its knees.

Eren clutched his head. "I'm such a fucking useless loser!"

"Yeah, you are. You couldn't even hold her off until Mikasa or Corporal Levi got there."

"Jean!" Sasha scolded.

"Well, he's right," Ymir said.

"You're not helping," Christa crossed her arms.

"First I did nothing and everyone died. Then, when I had my chance, I was blinded by rage and had my head knocked off!" Eren slammed his fist down on the couch's arm. It was humiliating and maddening. *What the hell is wrong with me? Why am I so damn pathetic?*

"Eren," Mikasa said, "she's got years' worth of experience as a Shifter and you've only known about it for what, a month and a half?"

"And as far as our deaths go," Petra put in, "that's not you. We engaged with her to protect you. You never should have had to fight her but we failed our mission. We asked for your trust but we couldn't extend you the same courtesy."

"Can't say I blame you. First time I transformed by will I attacked Mikasa. *Mikasa.* And she's one of my oldest friends."

"There's no point in getting so worked up and punishing yourself," Hange said. "It's not happened yet and long as we learn from the mistakes and not repeat them, that's what's important."

"I guess." It still rankled him and he felt like he had swallowed a lemon, a sour feeling in his chest. *They just feel like excuses for constantly fucking up* . Eren swore it would be different when he was out there. He felt the same impatience growing. *I hope her identity is revealed soon.* She knew who he was and he couldn't wait for the playing field to level. *Bitch won't know what hit her when she comes for me* .

The Female Titan crouched before the headless body, grabbing the shoulders and opening her mouth wide, her jaw stretching unnaturally. She bit the flesh and ripped it out. Eren's upper body appeared in the skin. He was semiconscious, his expression dazed.

" Eren!" Mikasa cried out.

Eren shrank at the despair and pain in her voice.

Mikasa watched as the Female Titan bit the teen right out in front of her. She stared in wide-eyed shock, mouth open. The Female Titan swallowed. Mikasa was unable to believe her eyes.

"Is he dead?" Sasha asked hesitantly.

"I doubt it. Remember how careful she was not to kill anyone who's face was covered because it could have been Eren?" Armin pointed out.

The ground shook as the Female Titan ran off.

" W-wait… Eren…" Mikasa's expression was that of hopelessness, her voice broken from anguish. "Don't go…"

Eren didn't think it was possible to feel any worse for his failure to not only save his team but avenge them as well, but he was wrong. *How many times am I going to be so weak and unless, needing to be saved and worry those I care about?*

Then Mikasa's expression turned to fury. Engaging her gear, she flew swiftly after the Titan.

"Now destroy her!"

"But don't die!"

"It's on you Mikasa!"

"You got it!"

"And the Bitch Titan must be tired after fighting Eren. That's what I'm calling her from now on," Connie informed them. "And the other two are Armored Bastard and Colossal Fucker."

"I dare you say that to their faces," Ymir smirked.

"Hey, I'm the comic relief. Eren's the suicidal one."

The Female Titan glanced back, covering her nape.

" Give Eren… Give him…" She flew extremely fast. "Give Eren back!" Mikasa slashed her cheek. The Female Titan swiped at her. Mikasa cut up her bicep and thigh next. She came right at the Female Titan's face, dodging the giant's attempts to grab her, slicing the flesh above her right eye.

The Female Titan slowed, moving slightly off balance, her several injuries steaming.

"I can't believe you're defeating her by yourself! No wait, I can! It's you!"

"At this rate Corporal Levi won't even be needed!"

Blood covered Mikasa's eyes. "Give him back!" She charged at the Female Titan once more, aiming for her legs.

The Female Titan stumbled, landing on her hand and knees.

"Dude, you're so awesome!"

"You brought her to her knees!"

"You've made a fan out of me," Petra grinned.

"You've made me an even bigger fan," Sasha said.

Eren was disgusted with himself for feeling jealous. *You incompetent idiot, like you have any right* . He turned to face her, "You really are the most talented soldier in our generation."

"Thanks," Mikasa smiled warmly at the praise.

The Female Titan looked scared. "Give him back!" Mikasa went to finish her. Her swords shattered into multiple pieces.

Christa gasped, "Be careful!"

"She's got plenty of blades," Armin reassured her.

Immediately Mikasa flew away, slamming the broken sword into the tree, hanging, "Why won't my blade penetrate?"

The Female Titan turned her head to look at her.

" I know that he's alive…" She replaced the blade with a fresh one. "I know that Eren's alive!" The blood evaporated from her eyes and clothes. "No matter where she goes, I'll kill her, rip her apart, and get you out of that filth." Mikasa promised with a crazed look in her lone visible eye. "I'm sorry, Eren… Just wait a little longer…"

He's so lucky . Christa glanced at Eren and Armin. *They're both so lucky to have someone who would move heaven and earth to find them and save them* .

"Seriously, I am so glad she's on our side," Hange grinned.

She's so loyal to him. And she hates me still for the trial. Levi wondered how Mikasa would react when she found out they were related. He could imagine what a disappointment it would to her, finding family after so long and it turned out to be him of all people.

The Female Titan struck suddenly. The place where the teen had been a second earlier exploded.

"Phew," Connie's shoulders slumped in relief. *I thought she had her for a second there!*

The Female Titan stood up and ran.

" Wait!" Mikasa screamed, looking wild.

But she was held back, prevented from madly chasing after the Female Titan by Levi.

"You made it," Erwin said.

"Took you long enough," Hange said.

"Shut up."

" Wh-what are you—"

" Fall back for now," Levi said.

Mikasa did not look pleased but refrained from charging after the Female Titan. They followed her at a calmer pace.

" Maintain this distance. It may be tired. It does not appear to be going very fast."

The Female Titan was moving considerably slower than when she had first appeared.

"Okay, no way is she gonna win now," Sasha declared.

"Are you sure you should be saying that?" Jean raised an eyebrow. "Considering how many times we thought we had her and were confident victory was ours only for everything to royally blow up in our faces."

"Good point."

Christa nodded, "Let's not jinx it."

" He seems to have been bit right out of the neck. Is Eren dead?" Levi asked.

Mikasa stared ahead in fury and determination.

Connie let out a loud breath. "This *episode* ." He fell back against the couch, sliding partway down.

"Agreed," Christa stretched, loosening her muscles.

"It was a wild one," Hange said. "So many emotions, so many ups and downs."

"We were screaming in excitement one minute and silent from the horror of it the next," Jean nodded.

Sasha began loading her plate with food. "That made me kinda hungry."

Ymir nodded, "Me too." She snatched up some bread, taking a bite and chewing as she contemplated the best time to bring up her

status as a Titan-Shifter and making their heads explode with the information about Marley, Eldia, and the rest of the world.

"I feel too sick to even think about eating," Eren said, breathing deeply. *I need to calm myself.* He didn't want to miss anything because he was too blinded by his emotions.

"It was an intense one," Erwin admitted. "I suppose we can take a minute to collect ourselves."

"Yes," Petra closed her eyes, leaning back.

"I need to splash cold water on my face," Levi excused himself.

"Armin," Mikasa said, "you don't think she'll succeed, do you?"

"I don't know. I don't think so."

That was not the answer she was hoping for but it wasn't unexpected.

"But I don't see how it could possibly get any worse."

"It could." Mikasa's face darkened, "Things can always get worse."

Armin smiled, happy to provide a hopeful answer to an otherwise normally correct statement. "Yes. But we can shape the future now and create an outcome favorable to us."

Soon . Ymir thought. She felt confident her secret would not be revealed just yet. But she decided the sooner she did it herself the better. *Maybe after the main episodes end* .

Until early-December. I'm pretty much over my cold so I'm feeling much better, thanks! Also, Happy Halloween! [Edit: 10/31/17]

Please Review~

Episode - The Defeated

Chapter 22: The Defeated

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The group is devastated when Squad Levi is killed. Eren swear no mercy against his enemies. Ymir decides to tell them about her after episode 25.

" He seems to have been bit right out of the neck. Is Eren dead?"

" He's alive," Mikasa answered, not a hint of doubt on her face, voice steady. "Our target seems highly intelligent, and capturing Eren is apparently her primary goal." She recalled the Titan ripping the teen out of the body. "If she wanted him dead, she could've crushed him in her jaws. Instead, she's carefully holding Eren inside her mouth while fighting to escape."

" Eating Eren may also have been her goal. If so," Levi said, "he would've ended up in her stomach. It makes more sense to assume he's dead."

Mikasa stayed true to her belief. "He's alive!"

He glanced at her. "I hope you're right."

She frowned lightly. "If only you'd protected Eren, this never would've happened!" Mikasa said accusingly.

Eren shook his head, "It's my own damn fault for freezing."

"You shouldn't have had to fight her in the first place. It only happened because we failed," Petra frowned.

"You guys only failed because you were misled about the threat and went in blind," Christa said.

"If anyone's at fault here—"

"Let's not play the blame game," Erwin interrupted Jean. "We're here for a limited time. I know it's easy to get caught up but we've been over this. Judgment calls were made and this is the result. We control the outcome now. Or at least this," he gestured to the TV, "gives us a high chance to turn the tides of this war in our favor."

"The deaths of the soldiers who have died on this expedition, and will die, will not be in vain. We will learn and we will prevent that from happening," Hange said.

" Now I see…" Levi turned to face her fully, realization dawning on his face. "It was you back then. You're Eren's close friend."

Mikasa looked at him skeptically.

" We'll focus all our manpower on one goal. First of all, forget about killing the Female Titan."

The two continued to fly through the forest.

" But she killed so many of our comrades!"

Eren, Mikasa, Christa, and many of their fellow recruits nodded.

" So long as she can crystallize her skin, there's no way we can kill her. Trust my judgment. We'll keep hoping that Eren is still alive, and attempt to rescue him before she leaves the forest. I'll hack her up…" Levi readied his blade. "You draw her attention!"

Their heartbeats began to pick up simultaneously in excitement.

"Yes! Tag team!"

"She's finally going down!"

"My heart can't take another loss!"

"Don't let us down!"

"You guys are the biggest badasses! Let's go!"

The Female Titan ignored them, continuing to run.

Mikasa had almost caught up to her, staying close to the ground and watching as Levi approached the giant from above. The Female Titan was aware of him closing the distance between them.

Levi's eyes glinted with bloodlust. He switched his hold on his right sword, the blade pointing back instead of forward.

He's holding it the wrong way again. Jean was confused.

"Why do you hold it like that, Corporal Levi?" Armin asked curiously.

He shrugged. "Feels more comfortable."

"That's right. He didn't learn how to use the gear in the Trainee Corps," Connie remembered.

Christa nodded, "He's self-taught."

Sasha looked at her hands, thinking about holding swords the way Levi did. "I can't imagine doing that. That's so weird."

"We've had the normal way ingrained into our heads and muscle memory for years," Ymir pointed out.

Mikasa wondered about the differences in the style of holding the blades in his unorthodox manner. How did it affect aerodynamics?

The way he maneuvered? Or when he was going in for the kill? *Is that how he executes his spinning attacks?*

The Female Titan's hair bounced in slow motion.

They tensed in anticipation.

Suddenly, she turned, right fist shooting forward. Levi met her attack straight on, cutting up her arm.

The viewers began cheering him on.

"Go Corporal!"

"You can do it!"

"Tear her up!"

"Fillet her like a fish!"

"I don't think you know what that means, Connie."

"Gut her!"'

"That works."

With a flip, Levi landed on her arm and used the momentum to push off, reaching her face and digging his swords into her eyes. Droplets of blood flew out as the Female Titan's head tilted back.

"Keep going!"

"Don't give her time to crystallize!"

"Fuck her up!"

"Just put this bitch *down* already! I'm fucking sick of her!"

Levi yanked his arms back. Flipping back into the air, he took out fresh blades and spun down, slicing her down to her ankles. He came at an arch, not giving her any time to recover and continuing the assault. Blood burst up from behind her head. She slid, falling on her rump, hand still covering her nape.

"Fuck yeah!"

"That's Humanity's Strongest Soldier for you!"

Levi winced at the title.

They continued to yell and cheer.

He's fast… **Mikasa observed him shoot up and fly straight down, attacking relentlessly.** ***He moves so quickly that she can't get a chance to harden her skin!***

Levi continued to carve her up, showing no chance of stopping.

Finally, the Female Titan's hand fell from its protective position.

The recruits were screaming their lungs out in encouragement and victory.

So noisy . Levi thought. But he felt quite gleeful at the scene and agreed with their sentiment.

Mikasa gasped. ***We can go for her neck! She's tired…*** **The nape was completely exposed.**

"Don't do it!" Sasha screeched suddenly.

Their eyes widened. They held their breaths, flashes of the deaths of Squad Levi and the rest of the Scouts replaying in their minds.

Eren and Armin had stilled and Mikasa prepared herself for the worst.

Levi's hands clenched into fists. *Don't let her die* . She was likely the only family he had.

I bet she can't move! **Mikasa gritted her teeth.** ***I can kill her!***

A hook dug into the Female Titan's shoulder. Her eyes stayed closed.

The viewers weren't fooled for one second, horror building up.

Levi took notice and yelled, "Stop!"

Mikasa charged in, letting out a battle cry.

The Female Titan's fist lifted in slowed motion.

"NO!" Eren screamed

"Mikasa!" Armin cried out.

Levi crashed into Mikasa, shoving her out of the way.

They exhaled loudly.

"Almost gave me heart attack," Jean muttered, chest still aching.

Levi's shoulders dropped the slightest.

The relief was palpable in the air.

Armin placed his hand on his forehead, the dizziness fading.

That was too fucking close . Eren swallowed, his mouth still tasting funny.

Mikasa was—grudgingly—grateful. *I owe the midget my life* . It still didn't mean she forgave him for hurting Eren. But she'd get there. Eventually.

Levi's ankle twisted from the impact and he grunted from the pain.

They gasped.

Gritting his teeth, he shot toward her mouth and sliced it with his swords.

The Female Titan's jaw fell open, revealing an unconscious Eren cocooned in saliva.

" Eren!" Mikasa called out.

Mikasa hadn't lost faith for a second. Still, it was a great relief to see the Shifter still alive and unharmed.

"Ew," Connie wrinkled his nose.

"You're going to need ten showers after this," Petra said.

"More like twenty," Eren replied.

Levi snatched the unconscious teen and flew away.

Hange laughed at the look of revulsion on Levi's face next to her.

He shuddered, resisting the urge to wipe his hands on the couch. "Disgusting," he muttered under his breath.

Mikasa landed on a branch, watching Levi do the same a few trees over.

" Hey! We need to get out of here!"

"I was kinda hoping for more." Christa wasn't the only one disappointed.

"Yeah."

"Me too."

"Same here."

"It can't be helped. Captain's injured and they are both likely in need of a gas refill," Petra reasoned.

"I guess."

"It's not smart to risk it," Jean agreed. "She'll heal fully within a minute or two and she's got her hardening ability."

The other recruits nodded.

"At least she got her ass kicked and we got Eren back," Armin said.

"True."

Eren was still disappointed. More with himself than the situation. *I need to get stronger. I can't keep having others save my ass all the time* . He was supposed to be the one taking on the biggest opponents. Even Humanity's Strongest Soldier did not have regeneration powers.

The rest would settle for that victory for now.

" Eren," Mikasa said lightly, smiling.

" I think he's okay. He's alive. Filthy, though. Don't worry about anything else." Steam rose from the blood around Levi's eyes. "We're pulling back." He glanced at the Female Titan, sitting at the base of the tree, giving off waves of steam. "Don't lose sight of your primary objective. Is it more important to get the revenge you deSire? Isn't he a dear friend of yours?" He took off.

" No, I…" Her gaze fell downward.

Levi flew through the air. Mikasa soon joined him. His eyes widened and he looked started, seeing the slack-jawed Titan crying.

That's right, bitch. You'll be doing a lot of that soon. Eren's expression darkened.

"Oh look, I think her feelings got hurt," Jean sneered, thinking of the dead men and women and remembering the cries of despair of the people who had lost loved ones during the Battle for Trost. His TV version would soon be subjected to that horrid, broken sound once again courtesy of the Female Titan.

"Considering how much pain and suffering and tears she's caused," Christa glared, "this is nothing. She deserves far more."

She's a bad person. But she's not pure evil. The others would happily and vehemently disagree, she knew. Not that she blamed them. But Ymir felt a twinge of sympathy for Annie. It was easy for them to think the worst of her. She was the only one who knew the whole story, they didn't. *They will soon* .

Trost appeared peaceful and beautiful from an aerial shot.

"The civilians are gonna eat us alive," Hange sighed. She was not looking forward to the return home.

The rest of the viewers looked unhappy, knowing there were bound to be hecklers in the crowd.

" They're returning already?"

" What happened?"

People were standing around near the gate, waiting.

" No clue. I'll bet they're coming back with a heap of corpses again, though."

"More like heaps of corpses," Ymir muttered.

The soldiers on horses and carts appeared on the horizon, the Forest of Giant Trees in the distance behind them.

Eren lay asleep in a cart, a bandage wrapped around his head, covered by a cloak. One of the cart's wheels bounced hard on the rough terrain.

A small part of him wished he remained unconscious so he wouldn't have to hear the crowd's barbed comments. The larger part of Eren believed he deserved their disdain for failing.

A brown-haired young woman stared outside the window, waiting.

"Ooh, she's pretty," Connie said.

A middle-aged woman entered the room. "Erd is coming home."

The young woman gripped the basket of clothes in her arms and turned, "I see."

"That's his fiancé," Levi said quietly.

Oh no... Petra bit her lip. *Dad...* She did not want to see his reaction to her death. Having come back in one piece almost every expedition, he was likely expecting the same outcome this time too.

"Here it comes," Armin said. *The worst part of every expedition* .

An image of a family appeared, washing clothes.

" You think Oluo will have time to come home?" The oldest boy asked.

" It couldn't hurt to make dinner for him, just in case," Oluo's mother said, cooking. The father smiled, watching her.

Who's going to tell them their children, the love of her life, they're never coming back? Sasha thought sadly. Someone would likely have to break the same news to her father one day, she realized.

" Gunther's coming home," a hunchbacked woman said.

The elderly man in the chair opened his eyes. "I see."

There was a sharp, piercing ache in Eren's chest. *It's like losing them all over again* .

The Scouts were resting, some tending to their horses while others kept watch for Titans.

Eren continued to lay unconscious. A shadow fell over him. Mikasa stood by the cart, mournful. She looked to the side at the pairs of the boots.

Corpses lay wrapped up in white sheets, tied by rope, with blood soaking through.

I wonder which one is mine . Petra thought, feeling slightly queasy.

An arm wasn't tucked into the white sheet of one of the bodies. A bite mark was visible on the small hand.

It's one of them. Who is it? Petra? Oluo? Eren wondered. Erd's hands were bigger and Gunther's were darker. The nails were

slightly longer than the skin. There was only one female member in his squad. Eren was immensely glad she was covered.

Levi felt the same irritable itch he did when he saw a mess, feeling a compulsion to tuck the arm in properly. The thought of it being pinned under other corpses or flapping around in a moving cart bothered him greatly. He couldn't bring them back alive. *It's the least I can do to properly handle their bodies and escort them back to their families* . But he knew what task his TV version would be focused on. It was a tradition of his, when he lost soldiers close to him.

Mikasa took in everything in silence. Soldiers on horseback lowered wrapped corpses to their comrades to join the other deceased Scouts. A blond-haired young man sat silently with his back to the screen.

A pair of boots stopped before a body. Levi knelt, moving the white sheet aside to reveal the Wings of Freedom stitched on the pocket of the jacket.

Levi had hoped he would never have to do that with his own squad.

"What's he doing?" Mikasa whispered.

Eren didn't have an answer.

Petra had a fairly good idea, having seen him do it before. *He's taking our insignias as mementoes* . She felt the sting of failure again. He wouldn't have to be doing that if only they'd stopped the Female Titan.

Levi's shoulders moved under his cloak but his actions remained hidden.

The scene changed to a bare tree with the sun behind it, causing it to look black.

Armin and Jean placed a corpse over a row of corpses in a cart.

" This is the part I just can't get used to," Jean stared at the pile before him.

And you never will. Hange thought.

"Do you ever get used to it?" Sasha glanced toward the veterans.

"No," Erwin answered as Petra and Hange shook their heads.

The grim expression on Levi's face was answer enough. *It never stops being any less painful no matter how many times you've been through it .*

" Nobody gets used to it," Armin said.

" How are my friends going to die? How am I going to die? It's all I can think about."

" I try not to dwell on it. If I imagined the way I'm going to die, I doubt I'd be able to fight at all."

" Yeah." Jean moved to the end of the cart. "You're right." He crouched by the corpse and Armin joined him.

" How much longer will I be alive?" Connie was holding a small bucket up to his horse.

Sasha stood behind him, her back to him, feeding her horse. "You're living now, aren't you?"

" For the moment."

" Isn't that a good thing? You're alive!"

" How can you say that in front of the corpses of those who died?"

Sasha didn't reply.

I never thought it'd be this hard. Connie believed surviving meant victory in the Survey Corps because of their deadly mortality rate. *I'm alive. But it feels so shitty.* He had survived. *This time* . But what about next time? Or the one after that? Or the one after that? *Our chances increase a lot over time but...* It wasn't a guarantee. After all, Squad Levi was composed of elite soldiers and they'd survived numerous expeditions. *If they can be killed, so can we* .

Plants blew softly in the wind.

" I'm not even sure I can go home anymore…" Connie said.

Hange observed the severe expressions on all of the recruits' faces. She was glad they could experience their first expedition this way. They would learn and get perspective without actually losing someone. *Then again, they went through something no trainee class has ever gone through before* . The Battle for Trost. But now, they knew they would be going out on more expeditions like that *. Maybe not all as deadly as this one. Still, they will make friends and form bonds and know what it feels like to lose people on a monthly basis* .

" We're almost done. There were five casualties we couldn't recover."

" Not even any parts of them?" Erwin inquired, holding a clipboard.

" We couldn't get close enough because of the Titans," the brown-haired man said. "It's probably better for the families if we don't bring those back."

Several people nodded in agreement.

They found the idea of receiving a part of the body far more unsettling than no body at all.

" Report them as missing."

" Yes, Sir. We've sighted several Titans near the forest, but none are headed in our direction yet."

" We're moving out now. Inform the squads," Erwin handed him the clipboard and walked away.

" Yes, Sir."

" I refuse to accept this, Commander Erwin!" A voice suddenly said from behind him.

What now? Erwin raised an eyebrow as the rest murmured.

" Hey, you—"

" We should recover them!" Dieter insisted, looking somewhat unhinged. "Ivan's body was right in front of us!"

" There was a Titan right next to him!" A Scout present said. "We'd just end up losing someone else!"

"They want to risk more soldiers over a dead body after all this?" Ymir said incredulously.

"I can understand where they're coming from. But I wouldn't want anyone to be put in harm's way if it were me. If my body was among those left behind," Christa said.

Everyone in the room agreed.

" If they attack us, we can just take them out!" Dieter argued stubbornly.

" Ivan and I are childhood friends from the same village!" Jurgen said more calmly than his friend. "I know his parents." Erwin did not look pleased. "If nothing else, I'd at least like to bring him home!"

" Stop being selfish!" The brown-haired Scout yelled.

" Quarreling children?"

They turned to see Levi.

" Captain Levi!"

" If you confirmed he's dead, that's enough," Levi said, his bland expression unchanging. "Whether or not you have a body, dead is dead. It doesn't change a thing."

" That's…"

"That's harsh, man." Connie felt a little bad for the two even though he disagreed with them.

"Captain Levi doesn't pull punches, ever," Petra said.

"I'm not their damn mother."

He could still stand to be gentler, Christa thought. He was the famed soldier. Everyone looked up to him. She was sure if he explained a little more nicely they'd understand.

" We'll say Ivan and the others are missing. That's my final decision. Leave it at that." Erwin walked away, Levi following.

Dieter watched them leave disbelievingly. "Don't either of you possess any human feelings at all?!"

It sure comes off like that at times. And it probably is true occasionally. But that's what it takes . Armin thought.

" Hey, Dieter! You're getting too far ahead!"

Dieter was still fired up. Erwin hadn't reacted to the words, continuing to walk.

Don't do anything stupid, kid . Levi knew that look in his eyes. He was still determined.

The Survey Corps was heading back to Wall Rose. Mikasa rode alongside Eren's cart, keeping an eye on him. Behind her were carts carrying the corpses. The shot focused on a blond-haired young man sitting in one of the carts, barley two feet from half a dozen pairs of boots.

Sasha shuddered, "Creepy."

The young man sat up, more alert, and yelled, "Titans!"

Mikasa saw two Titans, a skinny Abnormal one hugging itself and another one with a large belly, racing after two soldiers on horseback. A close-up revealed them as Jurgen and Dieter, each riding with a body behind them.

"Fucking imbeciles," Jean cursed them. "They're gonna get someone killed."

"Or they're gonna get themselves killed," Hange frowned. "The Titans are moving fast."

"Was nobody watching them?" Eren said.

"They probably didn't think anyone one would be that suicidal, or stupid enough to put others in danger," Christa replied.

The other soldier in the cart stood, "That's…" Dieter had a body slumped against his, riding as fast as he could. "Dieter!" He

pulled out a flare gun. "That fool…"

A trail of red smoke went up in the air.

" The rear guard has sighted Titans!"

" Full speed ahead!" Erwin ordered.

" I don't see any tall trees or buildings," Levi said from next to him. "It will be difficult to fight out here."

" We're better off trying to outrun them to the wall."

Exhaling irritably, Levi fell back.

The Titans continued their pursuit. Dieter saw a hand in the air. He ducked as it swiped at him. The corpse of his friend fell and landed on the ground face first, causing him to cry out.

"I fucking knew it," Jean grumbled.

"It was for nothing," Armin said.

To his left, Dieter saw Jurgen being grabbed. The Titan brought him closer to its face.

"Now that dumbshit's gonna die too," Levi growled.

Petra sighed, "They made the situation worse for everyone."

Dieter quickly yanked the reins on his horse, stopping to face the direction of the fat Titan and deployed his gear. A hook latched into the Titan's collarbone and he jumped off. The Abnormal one went toward the main host.

" They're gonna catch us!" Armin observed.

" Will we have to fight?" Jean asked.

" The 3D gear has limited functionality in open areas! And look…" In the distance, three Titans were running parallel to them. "They just keep coming!"

" Then what'll we do?" Jean demanded.

" We…" Armin focused on the pile of bodies and Jean followed his gaze, somewhat shocked.

He thinks like I do . Erwin thought.

Hange fumed in her seat. *It's all because of those two!* Their loyalty to their friend was commendable but they should have understood the situation.

Levi warily wondered what Petra would think about the order he would soon give. He was in no shape to fight. Their best chance of survival was to make it to the walls. To do that, they needed to get rid of the extra baggage.

Jurgen's legs wiggled out the Titan's mouth and it slurped him in like a noodle. Mikasa watched the Titan grab Dieter. It opened its mouth and the man cried out. Mikasa attacked, causing blood to shoot out from its nape. The Titan toppled over in a loud crash and she landed on the ground in a crouch.

"That's our Mikasa!"

"Always such a badass!"

"It's extremely hard to kill a Titan on such terrain but you did it!"

She really is like Captain Levi . Petra looked at the girl admiringly. *Not only in skills but in the way she inspires those around her like he does.*

Levi felt something akin to pride. *Titan slaying runs in the family.* He remembered young Mikasa's words when she had killed the man choking Eren. Was there something special about their bloodline?

The Ackerman family . *Her father, my mother, Kenny, and us...* He had to know more. But Kenny would be impossible to track down. If he was still alive. *Checking into her father should be easiest.*

Dieter came out of the Titan's fist, holding his limp left arm. He noticed the scene before him and quickly averted his gaze .

"You're responsible for it. So own up to it," Christa said in disgust.

The Abnormal Titan chased after the carts, showing no signs of stopping.

" No! They'll catch us!"

" I'll circle behind them! When I draw their attention, you—"

" No," Levi rode alongside the cart. They moved their heads in his direction. "Just abandon the corpses. Otherwise they'll catch us."

" B-but—"

" On past expeditions, dozens of bodies never made it back." Levi continued without emotion, "These guys will be no different."

The man in the cart gaped at his words.

Most of the recruits mirrored his expression.

"He can't be serious," Eren said, wide-eyed.

"There's no other way," Armin said.

Sasha watched disbelievingly, "This is just..."

" Are we doing this?" The other Scout said, crouching over the bodies to keep them in place as the ground shook from the

Titan's thunderous footsteps. "We're seriously dumping them?!"

Levi was frustrated, glaring at the scene behind him. He touched his left leg, "Damn it…"

This is my fault. Mikasa thought, hands clenched into fists in her lap. If she hadn't let her emotions interfere, he wouldn't have gotten hurt trying to save her. Now he couldn't kill the Abnormal and they were forced to leave the bodies of their comrades behind. She leaned forward slightly to catch the saddened look on Petra's face. Quickly, Mikasa looked away guiltily.

The man's expression finally changed from shock to angry determination. "We have no choice!" He crouched.

The first body fell to the ground, tumbling toward the oncoming pair of feet.

Armin and Jean grimly watched them toss the next one.

The Titan crushed it under its foot, causing a small cloud of dust to rise.

They flinched.

With tears in his eyes, he picked up the next one as Levi watched.

Ginger hair whipped around the face. There was a trail of blood reaching up from the mouth.

The slowed time gave them plenty of time to figure out who it was and fall into uncomfortable, dead silence.

The body hit the ground harshly and rolled off to the side.

They were glad it at least wasn't trampled upon.

Despite how calmly and easily he had given the order, the anguish was clear in Levi's eyes just then.

This feels somehow worse than watching them die. Maybe, Mikasa wondered, if it was because she felt partially responsible.

"Her arm was out," Armin said quietly. *It was her body Corporal Levi approached earlier.*

They glanced at Petra, gauging her reaction. But she kept her eyes glued to the TV, not at all distressed.

Forgive me. Levi's mind replayed his team's death and the heartless disposal of their bodies. *I couldn't even bring your bodies home* . He was too afraid to check how his subordinate sitting right next to him felt.

The Titan began to fall behind.

Petra finally smiled a little. *Our one last contribution to the Survey Corps* . It broke her heart to think of her father. She was all he had since her mother had passed away long ago. Would he be able to properly mourn for her? At least burying a body and holding a funeral would have allowed him to grieve and have some closure.

" Okay! Keep on going!"

Finally, they were able to outrun the Abnormal.

Green smoke was trailing up in the air. The Survey Corps was resting once more.

" As soon as we ascertain our location, we'll depart."

" Stay alert! We'll have to take a slight detour to the east…"

Nearby, Dieter stood, dazed.

"Well I hope he's proud of himself," Christa crossed his arms.

"If only he had the sense to listen," Jean scowled.

"He lost more because of his decision than anyone else," Levi interrupted before the others could jump in and pile on the hate.

What about what we lost? Eren thought. What about the families of their squad?

"Not only did he lose his friend's body, another friend of his died because of a choice they made. I'm sure he's punishing himself far more harshly than we can."

I can't believe he's actually defending him, considering his reaction to Petra's body being thrown away because of the actions of that idiot . If I were in his place and that was Christa or Connie or that annoying Potato Girl, hell even if it was Jean who was dumped... Ymir certainly would not have been so understanding and forgiving.

A horse approached him and Levi dismounted.

" Captain Levi," Dieter turned to him. The short man was rummaging through his jacket's pocket. "I…"

" This proves that they were alive. To me, at least."

Dieter trembled, holding the Wings of Freedom patch torn from a jacket.

" This was Ivan's."

No one believed him.

He was never shown near the man's body. It could have been off screen. But Sasha highly doubted it.

Connie was surprised. *He's nicer than he wants to let on.*

The Titans would have started chasing him and nobody would have missed him going back. *Not to mention* , Armin thought, *why would he bother going back for some stranger instead of his own squad?* Based on his observations, he was almost certain the patch was Petra's.

You're a better man than me, Captain . Eren would have slugged the guy instead of giving him something so precious.

It pained him to see it but Levi knew he had done the right thing.

Dieter began to cry, shoulders shaking, "Captain…"

Without a word, Levi mounted his horse and left.

An order was given out. "We're leaving!"

A beautiful blue flower swayed gently. Footsteps were heard. A young Eren was carrying firewood silently.

" Eren, you should give up on joining the Survey Corps."

The two children were on their way back home.

"Isn't this from the first episode?" Jean asked.

"Wonder why it's showing us this scene again," Sasha thought out loud.

" What? You're going to tell me it's stupid too?"

" That's not it…"

A bell began to ring in the distance. "The Survey Corps is back! The front gate's opening!" Eren grabbed her hand. "Let's go, Mikasa! The heroes have returned!"

The children climbed up the crates. The smile fell from Eren's face.

" Only this many made it back?"

" The rest of them must've been eaten. That's what you get when you venture outside the Walls."

The boy glared, overhearing them.

Eren felt a wave of nausea.

" It's like all our taxes are spent fattening up the Titans."

Eren picked up a stick from the ground. "Eren?" Mikasa said. The boy was frozen. Her eyes widened, noticing his shaking shoulders as he lowered his arm. "What is it?"

He squeezed the stick tightly. It was no longer the child Eren but the teenager, dressed as a Scout.

I see. He's on the other side now. Christa thought. *But he's still watching the procession through the crowd's eyes, like he did when he and Mikasa were kids . Only this time...*

This time he can't bring himself to defend the Survey Corps . Mikasa felt her heart go out to him, understanding.

Jean felt the same way as well. *We failed* . The sacrifices were for nothing. *So it really is like what they're saying* . With the mission ending in such great loss and no gain, their taxes had essentially gone to feed the Titans.

They felt sick knowing what the men had been saying was true.

We can't justify all those deaths . Hange felt terribly sad. They had died for nothing. *All we learned was we know a lot less than we think we do* . While their enemies knew all about them and were more powerful. And acquiring that knowledge had cost them countless lives.

Little Mikasa stared at his back. "Eren…" The camera focused on the Wings of Freedom on his cloak before slowing shifting up to his bowed head, shoulders still trembling.

" Eren!"

He woke up with a gasp.

If only it was a nightmare. Sasha perked up. *Wait! It pretty much is!* It wasn't real.

The cart shook gently. They were still outside the Walls. Mikasa sat beside him. "Eren…"

He sat, still covered by her cloak.

" Don't try to get up yet. Rest up."

" The Female Titan?" Eren asked desperately.

" She escaped."

" Why? What happened to others?" His voice trembled slightly. "What about the plan?"

" It failed. Lay still for now," she said calmly.

" What's going on? Did you save me again?"

Mikasa didn't answer, touching her scarf.

Levi sighed. *Childish brat* .

"Seriously?" Christa shot Eren a disbelieving look.

"Not the time for pride, buddy," Connie said.

"I know," Eren replied, feeling ashamed. He really hoped it wasn't because of his ego but because of the promise he had made to protect Mikasa. *I'm the one who's supposed to put my life on the line and—* He remembered Mikasa's last conversation with Carla. *No, we're both supposed to have each other's backs* . And that wasn't possible if he kept being such a weakling.

"She wouldn't need to keep saving your sorry ass if you grew a pair," Ymir said bluntly.

"Yes, you're right," he said solemnly before his friends could jump in. He was a soldier. He was sworn to protect the people behind the Walls no matter the enemy. Be that Titan or human. *Hesitation means death* . It had been just the two of them, him and the Female Titan, this time. Next time the two clashed he could get his comrades killed. *No more being weak, complaining and whining* .

As soon as they were out of there, Eren planned to throw himself into training as a Titan-Shifter. Even if the expedition was only days away, he was determined to make the most of the time available. The image of his squad being killed brought back the sickening feeling. His thoughts turned to the Female Titan. She was the enemy. *Friend or foe, I won't hesitate* . He wouldn't let more soldiers die in vain again.

" We're almost to the Wall," Mikasa finally said.

In another cart, the floor smeared with blood, sat three despondent Scouts, including Dieter, who was clutching the patch Levi had given him.

Erwin, Hange, and Mike led them.

The people were whispering as the downcast soldiers walked in silence, looking somewhat dazed.

"Here we go," Connie said.

The others braced themselves for the worst.

" Aren't a bunch of them missing compared to this morning?"

" Man…"

" Far fewer…"

" How horrible."

Eren lay quietly.

" Just this morning they left to raise hell, but now they're back already? What was the point?"

" Who knows?"

Mikasa listened to them nervously.

" But judging by those gloomy expressions, they managed to gobble up more of our taxes…"

The group stared at the TV, upset and annoyed. Listening to their comments, even if they weren't entirely wrong, still hurt.

Eren glared, starting to sit up.

" Eren, just bear with it."

He lost the anger, noticing a grinning young boy standing with a little girl. Mikasa watched, unsure.

" So cool!" The boy's voice was full of excitement and awe. "The Survey Corps are so awesome! They get their butts kicked, but they keep on fighting!" He told the girl with him.

Eren sat back down, shaken.

Jean walked with his head bowed, Reiner with him. Armin's face was covered by his hair. Ymir observed the crowd as she walked beside Christa, who couldn't bear to face them. Sasha and Bert wore matching disheartened expressions.

" Captain Levi!" A brown-haired man approached him.

Petra stiffened. *No way...* She had thought she'd gotten lucky when the TV didn't show her father earlier when her teammates' families were shown. This was worse.

" My daughter is in your squad. I'm Petra's father."

"Aww..."

"The poor man..."

"This is gonna be heartbreaking."

Hange gave Levi a pitying look.

"If I were him I'd wanna crawl under a rock right about now."

" Before I see her, I wanted to talk with you. She sent me this letter," Petra's father held up a white envelope. "She said you respected her skills enough to allow her join your squad. She swore she'd to devote herself to you. Well, I guess she's too starry-eyed to consider her father's feelings! Anyway, as her father, I think it's still too early for her to marry."

"Huh?" Petra gawked. "Marry?" Confusion seeped into her tone.

Levi looked devastated.

"Yikes."

"Poor Corporal."

" She's still so young, with so much left to experience!"

"Dammit Father!" Petra blushed. "Way to blow it out of proportion! That is *not* what I meant!" She wanted to sink into the couch in embarrassment. Her hair fell like a curtain, hiding her from Levi. She was horrified by what he might think of her.

Some of the others snickered.

"Trust me, I get it," Jean nodded, smiling. "Every time I mention a girl, my mom gets all excited and demands to know everything about her future daughter-in-law. And I'm only fifteen!"

"Glad my dad's not like that," Sasha shivered.

"My parents are pretty cool," Connie grinned. "I think they'd be pretty thrilled though."

The rest of the room was quiet and their smiles fell, realizing the others were likely all orphans.

" Commander Erwin! Answer us!" Men and women yelled, looking furious.

Erwin walked, holding his horse's reins.

" Did your expedition learn anything worthwhile to justify the body count?" A female voice demanded.

" Do you really believe the dead leave no regrets?" Another man yelled.

Erwin's face remained blank. The people continued to yell.

"What's gonna happen now?" Christa whispered.

"We're screwed," Ymir said. "Especially Eren."

" *The costs and casualties of the failed expedition were easily enough to discredit the faction that had supported the Survey Corps," Candy narrated.*

The Survey Corps hasn't been in this terrible a position in decades. Hange shifted uneasily.

Lying in the cart, an arm covering his face, Eren cried. A tear ran down the side of his face.

Mikasa held his hand.

What'll happen to Eren? There was a heavy ball of dread in Mikasa's stomach.

Armin was equally anxious. What would the Military Police do to the Shifter now that he had failed to prove his worth to humanity? *He'll just be a liability in their eyes now* .

" As those responsible, including Erwin, were summoned to the capitol, it was decided that Eren would be handed over. "

To who? Eren thought dumbly. The Military Police, of course. He felt numbed, terrified of what the future held for him.

Mikasa let out a strangled gasp. *Maybe he was right. Maybe we should have taken our chances and runaway* . With her skills, Armin's intelligence, and Eren's ability, they could have survived in Titan territory.

"That's not good," Connie said.

"Is it any surprise?" Jean said. "The whole thing was such a disaster."

"What're they going to do to Eren?" Sasha looked alarmed. "Are they going to dissect him?! Will they subject him to torture or—"

"Now hold on," Erwin interrupted, "we wouldn't let them take him so easily."

"He's right," Hange said.

The recruits didn't look convinced. The mission had failed. The people were against them. What could they do?

While the commander reassured them, Levi spoke quietly to Petra, "I'm sorry I couldn't bring your body back to your father."

"It's okay. I understand. No point in being deadweight, literally, and dragging down those who're still alive." As much as she believed it, and believed it was the right thing to do, it still hurt to see her body being discarded.

He nodded, "If I hadn't been injured..."

"I know. I'd like to think it was my last contribution." Petra didn't want him—or Mikasa, whom she'd noticed looking at her when Levi had cursed his leg—to feel any worse and kept her expression neutral. "I'm just glad I didn't have to see my dad react to it." She'd have cried for sure. "And I'm sure the guys would've understood too. Right now, I'm a little more worried about Eren."

"Erwin will think of something. If not..." Levi wasn't exactly a stranger to breaking the law and doing things illegally.

"There are still three more episodes left. Things could still turn out in our favor," Armin said optimistically.

"Things can't get much worse than this I guess," Jean replied skeptically.

I'll be back mid-January! Happy Holidays, everyone!

Please Review~

Episode - Smile

Chapter 23: Smile

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The 57th Expedition is over and the viewers are disappointed by the failure. Ymir sympathizes with Annie. Eren wants to get training as soon as possible.

The sun shone brightly in a forest. There were several freestanding punching bags, dirtied and gray. "Keep it up, Annie!" A masculine voice said.

Annie kicked the punching bags, arms up in a guard position.

Why is it...? Eren looked on in confusion. Why was it showing Annie all of a sudden?

This does not look like a good sign . Mikasa frowned.

Jean verbalized as much. "Does it mean to show she's the guilty party?"

"Don't jump to conclusions," Christa said. "Wait and see."

The shot focused on the mouth of Annie's father. "That's my daughter!"

She stopped, breathing deeply. "What are you doing?" He demanded. "Don't stop!"

Hange and Erwin were disappointed they didn't get to see more of the surrounding environment, giving them a clue as to where they were.

Annie's sleeping face came into view.

"Oh, it was a dream," Sasha said.

"Maybe it's showing what she was doing when the expedition happened," Petra suggested.

Opening her eyes, hair messy from sleep, Annie sat up in the bottom bed of a bunk bed, leaning on her elbows. Curtains were pulled aside and sunlight poured through the window, the sound of birds chirping audible.

[Wall Sina — Eastern Wall City]

A beautiful shot of brown-roofed cream-colored buildings appeared.

" Huh? Didn't you hear?" A male voice said. "The Titan boy and his companions were summoned by the king."

"So it's post-expedition then," Erwin muttered.

[Stohess District]

The shot changed to two well-dressed men standing by a stone barrier standing between them and a canal. "They'll be passing through the city today," the brown-haired man with facial hair said.

" I see," the man with the glasses replied. "He's gonna wind up getting dissected for sure this time."

How can they speak so casually of a human being dissected? Christa had a hard time wrapping her head around it. Then again, it was likely they didn't even consider Eren a person. He was a weapon. Just a monster if he couldn't prove his worth so it was okay to cut him open and study him.

Two other men stood a small distance away and a third was holding a newspaper behind them, eavesdropping. "Either way," the first man said, "I just hope things work out so they'll seal the gates."

A man nearby was shaking as he overhead them. The bag in his hand dropped to the ground. "What?" He walked toward them, disbelieving, wearing a golden accessory around his neck. "Did you just say *seal the gates* ?"

"He's a wall-worshiping lunatic," Ymir declared.

" Do you want to further defile our goddesses with lowly human meddling?!" The fanatic grabbed the man with wispy facial hair by the shoulders.

"Called it."

The brown-haired man gasped, noticing the thick, golden band necklace with the outline of three women that the fanatic wore.

The image of the three Walls and their insignias appeared as he spoke. "Maria! Rose! Sina! How dare you even suggest desecrating our three sacred goddesses?!" The fanatic raised his arms up, a crazed look on his face, sweating. A group of four had surrounded him, listening reverently.

" He's one of those crazies who worship the Walls as gods," Glasses put his hand on his friend's shoulder. "Just ignore

him."

"Don't make eye-contact," Connie nodded.

"You'll only encourage them by giving them attention," Armin agreed. He could not understand how people could believe in something so fictitious and ludicrous.

Eren shook his head at those who were listening to him. *They're weak-minded and pathetic, buying into that nonsense* . To him, they were even worse than those who opposed leaving the Walls at all. Wanting to hide behind the safety of the Walls, living like cattle, as much as it disgusted him, he could understand their fears. *At least they understand why mounting defenses atop the Walls is necessary, unlike these religious nutjobs.*

" I see." The dark-haired man with a mustache, who had been holding a newspaper, turned away. "Those freaks still exist…"

" It's the Walls!" The fanatic continued to screech. "The Walls and nothing else are our protectors!"

" Damn," the brown-haired man cursed, walking away.

[Stohess — Military Police Brigade Branch Office]

Connie whistled. "So much nicer than ours."

"We have a castle," Eren felt the need to point out.

"Yeah but it's so old and rundown."

Annie walked down the wooden steps.

The uncomfortable atmosphere was back.

" You're finally up," Hitch said. Other MP recruits were standing against the wall in silence, arms behind their backs. "You looked so scary in your sleep nobody dared to wake you up. Sorry, Annie."

Marlo stood to Hitch's right, speaking without looking at them. "You've been slacking off a lot recently."

Annie stood silent, not looking like she was paying any attention.

She could be exhausted. Hange thought. *Feeling the effects of Shifting twice and all the fighting she did* .

" What? Are you mad?" Hitch continued. "How are we supposed to get along?"

" Leave her be," Boris spoke up from Marlo's right. Annie took her position beside Hitch. "She's from Trost, remember? She's the only person in this branch with any actual combat experience. Of course she can't smile cheerfully when she's just returned from hell."

" Oh, I get it. So you like her? I wonder what you see in her."

" Hitch, there's only one way a dimwitted chick like you gets into the Military Police."

"How?" Eren wondered curiously.

" Oh, and what might that be?" Hitch said innocently.

Everyone turned to Eren with raised eyebrows or *are you serious?* looks on their faces.

"What?" Eren asked.

" I wouldn't know. Spit it out," Hitch said bluntly.

Erwin paused the episode, knowing there was a small discussion coming.

Ymir snorted, "He's so damn clueless."

"What?" Eren demanded, glancing around for an explanation. "How'd she do it?"

"By doing her superior," Jean rolled his eyes. "Obviously."

" *What?* " Eren gaped.

"It's not unheard of," Petra said. "Some trainees, well they uh..."

"Fuck the person in charge?" Levi provided.

"Yes, or use bribes to make sure they get placed in the top ten."

Eren was utterly outraged, much to their amusement. "And everyone knows about it?!" Annie's words about the hypocrisy of placing their best Titan-slayers furthest from Titans came back to him. Once again, he felt so ignorant about the system.

"People suspect it happens." Hange shrugged, "Though it's not as common as you might now be thinking it is. It'd be pretty obvious if your 3D gear skills suck."

"It's people with above average skills making sure they get a spot, a low rank in the top ten, but it's good enough to get you into the MP Brigade," Armin said.

Eren looked even more disgusted at his words. *Then they should focus on doing their best and trust themselves* .

" Shut up, you two," Marlo hissed as footsteps were heard.

The recruits saluted as one.

" Don't bother," the MP officer said.

Hitch and Annie dropped their hands. Marlo didn't.

At least he's not completely without discipline . Levi thought.

" Today you'll be doing something other than your usual chores," the man read from some papers, one hand pressed to the side of his head, shoulders slightly slumped, a shadow of a stubble across his face. "That's why I ordered you to assemble here."

"He doesn't even bother presenting himself properly," Petra eyed his lazy attitude and physical state in distaste.

Mikasa snorted, "Wouldn't surprise me if he's hungover."

"He certainly looks like he is," Christa said.

" A unit from the Survey Corps has been summoned by the king."

Annie finally showed mild interest.

" They're passing through the city's main street today. Escorting them to the capital is Military Police HQ's responsibility, so we only need to accompany them as they pass through town. The use of 3D maneuver gear will be temporarily permitted within city limits."

An image of MP soldiers following several horse-drawn carriages from the sky appeared for a few moments.

" You will guard the convoy in tandem with their own security. You'll travel by barge to the mission starting point."

Marlo placed his arms behind his back. "May I ask a question?"

" Hm? What is it?"

" What are we protecting the convoy from?"

The MP officer looked up with tired, disinterested eyes.

" I'm unaware of any people within this Wall who'd oppose the monarchy. Even if we've overlooked some petty criminals," Marlo explained, "truly organized opposition would be unimaginable, unless they had a stronghold outside the Wall. Why would anyone even try such a thing in the first place?"

"He has a good head on his shoulders, I like him," Hange smiled.

"Huh, the MP isn't completely full of idiots," Levi said.

Why did he join? Erwin wondered. *He must have some noble goal in mind* .

" Oh, well aren't you clever? I'm putting you in charge," the MP officer tapped the stack of paper against Marlo's chest. "The details are all here," he released the stack. The teen gaped as their superior went to a closed door across from them. He paused at the door. "We officers are really busy. You can handle this yourselves." He opened the door. "Just don't screw it up."

Four other MP soldiers were sitting around a table, drinking, smoking, and playing cards. "Sorry for the wait, guys."

"Unbelievable," Petra muttered. "They've no shame whatsoever."

" Where were we? Whose turn is it?"

Marlo stood there, gaping.

"That's what you would've turned into Jean. You're welcome," Connie said.

"Why the hell are you taking credit for my joining the Scouts? Anyway, didn't you want to join the MP too?"

" Those damn bastards!" Marlo cursed.

The MP recruits were hanging around a fountain in the middle of a courtyard.

" Well, the Military Police is even more rotten than I imagined. That's why I picked being an MP," Hitch said, hands on her hips, "but still... They force us rookies to handle everything. I didn't expect that."

" Scumbags. They can't think of anything but themselves. Fucking scumbags…"

"Did he really not know that before joining?" Connie wondered. *Even I knew they were lazy bums* .

" What are you talking about, Marlo?" Boris was sitting at the fountain. "You joined too. You're no better."

Marlo scowled at him before answering, "I'm not the same. I'm not scum like you guys." He placed his fists on his hips. "I came here to correct the Military Police!"

"Ah, so that's why," Christa nodded.

But can he do it? Jean knew the answer even as the question came to him. Changing an entire faction would take years, possibly decades of work. Or get rid of all the old ones and replace them with new men and women who haven't been exposed to the corruption and grown into the bad habits.

" Impressive, Marlo!" Hitched clapped. "So that's how you roll?"

" And how will you fix things?" Boris asked.

" I'll have to work my way to the top. When I'm in charge, I will enforce the rules and punish corruption. It's that simple."

No, it's not. The corrupt went too deep. Erwin knew it would take drastic measures to get the results the teen was hoping for.

"I don't know," Sasha said skeptically. "I think it's going to take more than one man."

Or a certain kind of man . Levi thought.

" I'll make the Military Police a place for normal people again. That's all. The way humans are meant to be!"

Annie kept silent and blank-faced.

A good dream. But in the end, that's all it is, a dream . Hange thought.

Hitch fell to her knees, laughing. "Holy shit, you're the real deal! Here I thought you were a total bore!" She clutched her stomach, slapping the ground. "So sorry!"

" What a noble goal you have." Boris stood. "Good luck with that."

" I wonder…" Annie finally spoke, grabbing their attention. "If a 'good person' like you controlled the system, that'd be the end for us, I think."

" What? You can actually speak?" Marlo said.

" I think you're right. You say all the correct things. I know another person much like you." A flashback of Eren talking at the graduation party appeared. "You need a lot of courage to go against the greater flow. I can respect that. But that doesn't mean you're not an idiot."

That's Annie . Eren smiled, amused. *She'll praise you and insult you in the same breath* .

"I wouldn't say he's an idiot," Armin said. "Just...ignorant of the difficulty and complexity of the task."

" Maybe it's just that the other person you know is an idiot. I'm different from him!" Marlo declared.

"Yeah," Eren snorted, "I'm not a mushroom-head."

" We've wasted too much time talking. Let's move out!"

He has potential . But Mikasa wasn't sure if he had what it took to see his goal through.

The canal appeared again. The water was a beautiful light blue in the sunlight.

" The convoy will pass through the outer gate in forty-five minutes." Marlo led the group, walking along the water. "Once we're there, everyone confirm your designated positions." He looked over his shoulder at them. "Got it?"

" Yeah, yeah." Hitched lifted her arms, stretching. Marlo stopped and she ended up running into him. "Hey!"

A few yards before them, three MP soldiers were standing near a large crate with a unicorn logo. A man stood on a boat near them, watching them.

" What's going on? Aren't those ours?" Hitch shielded her eyes.

" They must be taking them to the Inner District," Boris said.

" Even so," Marlo observed, "having the merchants involved is unusual. What are they…"

The merchant handed them a bag that clinked, clearly full of coins.

"His first test. I wonder how he will react and approach this situation," Erwin said curiously.

One of the policemen pulled out a coin with a woman's face imprinted on it.

Marlo grew furious. "They're selling our emergency backups on the black market?!" He walked toward them with a purpose.

" Wait, what about the mission?" Boris said.

" Holy shit, he really is the real deal!" Hitch said.

" Well, we still have time, for better or for worse… For now," Boris said, "let's just enjoy the show."

Annie simply watched them.

The ship began to move.

" Let's grab a drink then," one of them said. They turned and noticed Marlo.

" What is it, rookie? What do you want?"

" E-Embezzling emergency backup supplies is a crime!" His voice shook.

They winced.

"Well, he's not like Eren now," Mikasa said. "Eren would have started yelling and angrily demanding an explanation if not throwing punches."

"Hell yeah. I wouldn't have acted so meekly like that."

"You still have to give him credit for standing up for what he said. I half expected him to chicken out," Jean admitted.

Ymir agreed, "Yeah, it's easy to make claims about doing the right thing, much harder to actually follow through when you're put in that situation."

" So what?"

" Emergency goods are paid for by the people's tax dollars and —"

The dark-haired one started to laugh. "Jeez, you think you can lecture your superiors, rookie?" He pulled out a coin. "I look forward to your future." He put it in Marlo's jacket pocket. "For now, go buy yourself a hooker and chill the fuck out."

"Look how confident they are, doing illegal shit in the middle of the day and laughing off the witness—another MP at that if even they are recruits. Just goes to show how deep the corruption really goes," Jean said.

" H-Hold it!" Marlo ran after them. He grabbed one's shoulder. "Embezzling is—" He fell back, taking a rifle to the gut.

The man raised his gun and brought it down on the teen's head. Marlo's rifle fell and scattered away. He glared at Marlo, who was on the ground, in pain, while his friend watched, a little surprised.

Hitch and the others winced as he kicked their fellow recruit. They watched in silence as the sound of a beating continued.

The recruits were disgusted.

"Are they seriously going to just stand there and watch it happen?" Sasha demanded, angry and a little nauseated.

"Always knew the MPs were pathetic and cowardly but seeing it another thing," Eren said.

"How is the world supposed to be a better place when the people who are supposed to catch criminals are breaking the laws themselves?" Mikasa said. "And in broad daylight at that."

"Unfortunately, we have more pressing matters banging on our doors," Hange said.

Still, someone needs to do something about this. Christa thought. Even if they did defeat the Titans, would they really be saved with people like them in power?

Annie was the first to move.

She'll kick their asses. Sasha was confident.

I knew she's not a bad person . Eren thought.

" Hey!" Boris said when she passed him by.

" We'll have you arrested for insubordination and treason." The man said, his friend yawning.

" Don't be ridiculous!" Marlo said. "You can't get away—"

" Yes, here we can." He brought up his rifle to hit Marlo again.

Then Annie was holding his bicep, stopping him.

She can't really be the Female Titan, can she? Connie couldn't see how a person who took pleasure in killing those soldiers could also stop someone from getting beaten senseless. *It doesn't make sense* .

" I think that's probably enough."

He glared at her but she remained stoic.

Hitch ran over. "Sorry if this retard was causing you trouble." Marlo gaped at her. "We'll make sure he learns his lesson. Unless…" Her gaze drifted to the side where civilians were standing. "You'd prefer to make a bigger scene?" Some of them looked a little worried. No one was smiling.

" We'll let you off this once."

" Yes, sir!" The recruits said.

The two walked away. "Well, let's go grab that drink now."

" Yeah, we really earned it, after all."

Hitch sighed.

"Guess she's not as bad as she seems," Hange said.

Marlo looked frustrated. Then he noticed his rifle. With shaking fingers, he reached for it.

" Why not do it?" Annie said. "Weren't you going to punish corruption? If you want, I'll help out."

"What does she mean by that?" Eren asked.

"Maybe she said it to prove to him he doesn't have what it takes to get the job done," Armin said. "If he can't get his hands dirty, despite his noble goal... Well, it's probably for the best that he doesn't act without thinking again."

The two MP officers continued to walk.

" What did you wanna get?"

" What else? Meat!"

That normally would have made Sasha perk up but she couldn't help the foul taste in her mouth.

Marlo stared after them. Finally, he slammed his fist on the ground. "Damn it!"

"He couldn't do it," Ymir said. *He doesn't have what it takes* .

The crowd was watching Hitch.

" We know you're working really hard!" A civilian said.

" Oh, I'm not worthy of your praise."

Marlo was on the ground, head bowed. "That guy you know… That idiot you mentioned earlier... Would he have done it?"

" Maybe."

" Then I'm also a piece of trash caught up in the world like you said earlier, right?"

" Who knows?" Annie looked up. "But isn't that what normal human beings do? I don't care if I'm swept along by the flow, as long as I'm still considered a human."

So what, is she saying she's going with the flow of the world too? Doing things she doesn't want? Are they all? Armin wondered. He burned to know about their situation with the outside world. The ignorance of the world outside was their biggest weakness. *How many people are out there?* There had to be many different countries and cultures. *What do they think about us?*

The commander was having similar thoughts. *What is our standing with the rest of the world? Do the Titan-Shifters' people have powerful allies?* What kinds of weapons did they possess? Could they be swayed? Erwin wanted to know it all. *We've always thought the war was between humans and Titans. But it's been between humans and other humans, we've just never known about it. And that's been our disadvantage* . But that was quickly changing.

The innermost gate was open, allowing in carriages led by the Military Police commander. Members of the brigade, including Annie, stood on the sides, fists over their hearts. After the carriages passed, they jogged after them.

" Annie!" Armin's voice called out softly.

She stood and waited as two soldiers ran by. Then she turned and ran into the alley.

" Hey." Armin stood, wearing a coat covering most of his body, hood up. Her eyes grew wide in surprise. "You're fitting in well with the Military Police."

" Armin… What's with that look?"

"I bet we're busting out Eren!" Connie declared excitedly.

"And she's our inside informant!" Eren nodded enthusiastically.

Sasha perked up. "She can't really be the enemy if we're seeking her help!"

Or it's a trap for her. Mikasa thought. The skeptical look on Armin's face beside her said as much.

" I disguised myself as a porter. I'm using this raincoat to hide my 3D maneuver gear." He lifted up the long coat to reveal the machinery. "See?"

" What for?"

Armin removed his hood, "Annie, would you assist me in letting Eren escape?"

"You were right!" Christa said.

"I knew it!" Connie beamed. "Oh, this is going to be so awesome!"

Ymir didn't look too convinced.

" Escape to where? Where could you go inside these Walls after disobeying the monarchy?" Annie asked.

" We'd just hide out for a while. We don't intend to go against them head-on. It'll be reported as a rebellion by a portion of the Survey Corps. We need to buy time. Time to collect proof that could overturn the court-martial. We will succeed."

" Overturn the court-martial? Does something so convenient even exist? Any leads?"

" Sorry, but I can't say."

Annie sighed, "I'm sorry too, but I can't help you like this. But I won't say anything either. So good luck with whatever you're doing." She walked away.

"Wait, what?" Connie said in surprise.

No! She refused? Eren thought. He wasn't entirely shocked by her answer. But he was upset because it was a chance to show them she wasn't the Female Titan by helping Armin and the others out. *To show them she's on our side* .

" Annie! Please! They're gonna wind up executing Eren!" Armin's words stopped her. "Ignorant people will push humanity down the path of extinction just for personal gain, without even realizing it!" He said passionately. "I know my reasoning isn't all that convincing. But even so… Gambling big is our only chance at this point! Of course, we'll do our utmost to avoid causing trouble for you. But to get through the security inside Wall Sina, help from the Military Police is crucial. We have no other choice."

" Say…" Annie looked over her shoulder. "Do I look like such a good person to you?"

" A good person? Well, I don't like that term. To me, it seems like the meaning of 'good person' is really a person who's good for you. In that sense, I don't think any individual can be 'good' in everyone's eyes. So if you don't help us… Then, in my eyes, you'd be a bad person, right?"

Or just selfish. Looking out only for herself first. Petra thought. *Not necessarily a bad thing.* A sudden thought occurred to her. *On the other hand...*

Annie looked at him silently before glancing down. She removed her rifle, holding it before her, then sitting it against the wall. "Fine." He gasped, gaze shifting to the side. With her back to him, she slipped on a ring. "I'm in."

Hange had a feeling that ring would cause trouble later.

I can't believe I actually had my doubts! Sasha was relieved.

"See? You shouldn't have doubted her." Eren told Armin. "She's going to help."

But doesn't that make her more suspicious? Jean thought. By agreeing to help, she may not look selfish in their eyes and be a good person. But if she had refused to help them, letting Eren die, it would have shown she wasn't the Female Titan-Shifter. After all, the Female Titan had gone through a lot of trouble to try and capture Eren alive. It would have been completely counterproductive to suddenly let the Military Police kill him. *Either she's a great friend or she's trying to fulfill her mission by not letting her target die* .

They might think Armin's expression is like that because he called her a bad person if she didn't help but now that she agreed, he feels ashamed or something . Ymir thought. *I bet it's because he knows it furthers his theory about her being the Shifter* . An innocent person, albeit one more concerned with her own welfare, would have said no and left.

Mikasa and Eren appeared, hoods on. Armin walked beside them in the empty street with Annie in the lead.

" We made it through more easily than I expected," Eren said quietly.

" Shh!" Mikasa shushed him.

He continued, "That's the Military Police for you. You can tell how hard they work."

They snickered at his words.

" Stop glancing around so much," Mikasa chided.

" Let's just hope they don't discover Jean's taken my place." As Eren spoke, Jean appeared, sitting in a carriage, hair dark and gritting his teeth. "I doubt that cover will last long."

The viewers burst into laughter.

"Are you serious?" Eren gaped.

"What the fuck?" Jean spluttered at the same time.

" We look nothing alike, after all," Eren said seriously.

"I don't know," Petra giggled. "You looked pretty similar to me."

The two teens looked rather offended by that while the others agreed.

"You even have the same angry looks on your faces right now," Christa pointed out.

" Don't worry," Armin reassured. "You both share a villainous glint in your eyes and similar evil-looking face."

That sent them roaring into even more laughter.

"Armin, you," Sasha couldn't even finish her sentence.

Even Erwin and Levi were chuckling at the comedy.

" I don't have a horse-face like him!"

"Yeah!"

"Fuck you, Yeager!"

" Hey, if I didn't agree to help, how were you planning to get over the Wall?" Annie asked.

" We were going to use the 3D maneuver gear to break through," Armin answered.

" That's reckless. Wouldn't it have been less troublesome to escape before you reached Stohess?" Annie replied.

She's right . Hange thought. *It wouldn't make sense unless they had a different objective in mind.*

An overhead shot of them walking appeared, the streets to their left and right empty.

"Why here?" Annie said. "Why now?"

"Hey, where are all the people?" Christa asked curiously. Normally, every time they saw Sina, there were people walking around the beautiful, well-paved streets.

Hange and Erwin shared a knowing, wary look.

Oh no. She's going to figure it out. Armin thought. Annie had spent enough time in the Military Police to go out on patrols and become familiar with the streets. She'd know when something was different. Especially something as obvious as the complete lack of people around them.

If the desertion stands out enough to warrant even the casual viewer's attention , Levi thought, *then it will be blatantly obvious, a red flag, to her.*

" I thought the dense layout of the urban area would give us a better shot at swapping Jean for Eren," Armin explained. "Plus, pretending to follow obediently instead of opposing them outright will buy us more time to flee."

No, no, not good enough . Armin frowned worriedly.

" I see," Annie said. "That makes sense."

Eren and Mikasa looked at each other. The group was silent.

" There it is!" Armin veered off to the right.

They ran toward an entrance plunging into darkness.

Annie approached it, looking at the stairs going underground. "Here?"

" Yeah. We'll go through here. It's the abandoned remains of an underground city they planned long ago." Armin went down first and his friends followed. "This leads as far as the outer gate."

" Really? That's amazing." Eren stopped and looked behind him. "Annie? What are you doing? You're not about to tell us you're scared of cramped, dark places, are you?"

Don't push it . Ymir thought.

" In fact, I am afraid," Annie did sound a little scared. "I doubt a brave, borderline-suicidal guy like you could possibly understand the feelings of a frail girl like me."

Petra had a feeling they both were onto each other. *They're just going through a charade . Who will crack first?*

" Someone who can fling a big guy head over heels in midair with ease can't call herself a frail girl." Eren continued to descend the stairs. "Stop joking and let's get moving!" Armin and Mikasa followed.

" No, I'm not going that way."

Eren froze

" It scares me. If we don't travel above ground, I won't help."

What's happening? Eren didn't want to believe it. *She's...* Maybe she really was scared like she said. He didn't really believe it though.

" What are you even saying?!" Eren yelled at her. "Get down here already! Stop screwing around!"

" Eren, don't shout," Mikasa said.

" It shouldn't be an issue, right, Mikasa?" Annie said.

"She's figured it out," Levi said.

"Figured what out?" Connie asked.

"Why there aren't any people around to overhear them so it doesn't matter how loud Eren is. Because it's a trap," Petra said. "For her. She's the Shifter."

"Not a well-thought-out one," Jean muttered. *But they couldn't put civilians at risk. And with the limited time, they had to come up with something and making it happen before the MP figured out I'm not*

that idiot... If it hadn't been for the time crunch, they could have come up with a better plan and captured her.

" For some reason, there haven't been any people nearby for a while now."

Scouts were hiding on the rooftops. Some were hidden in the alley behind Annie, dressed in civilian clothes. And a few more watched her from around the corner.

" Honestly," Annie said. "I'm hurt. When did you start looking at me with those eyes, Armin?"

Holding a flare gun, hidden from her view, Armin's hand trembled. "Annie, why? Why…" He thought back to the inspection after Sonny and Bean's death. "Why did you have Marco's 3D maneuver gear?"

"She took it off his dead body? To pass the inspection, right?" Sasha said.

Jean saw the flaw in her reasoning immediately. "Except she wouldn't know she needed it to pass the inspection until *after* she returned and learned the Survey Corps had captured two Titans." His face had fury written all over it.

Slowly, the realization began to dawn their faces as the full meaning of his words hit them.

"Could she have taken it off after the expedition?" Mikasa proposed. "When the bodies were being rounded up to prevent sickness?"

Petra thought back to his half-eaten corpse. "Wasn't he bitten in half though?"

"If Marco was wearing the gear when the Titan attacked him," Hange began, putting all the pieces together for everyone, "it would have been destroyed when the Titan bit him in half. Which means he

wasn't wearing it when he was attacked. There is no way she would have gotten it after he was killed. Annie took the gear while he was still alive and left him."

"She stole his gear..." Sasha was horrified. "And when that Titan came for him.." Marco, friendly, helpful Marco, who never had anything bad to say about anyone and was always polite to her. *They were right* . She had wanted them to be wrong. A wound inflicted by a stranger hurt. A wound inflicted by someone they knew and considered as one of their own, there was no comparison. Tears leaked from her eyes.

Poor Annie . Ymir thought. They were all going to blame her for Marco's death. She was sure Annie had played a part in it but Reiner and Bert were also likely responsible. The Shifter eyed the other recruits with sympathy. It was a huge blow to them. And they didn't even know about the Armored and the Colossal also being comrades of theirs. Maybe once they learned the whole truth from her, they would understand their situation and motivations better. For now, the treachery would eat away at them.

Is this for real? Connie felt his eyes fill with tears. *No way...* He felt sick. *Marco... I defended his killer.* But why had she saved him back then? When he had failed to kill his assigned Titan. He felt confused and upset and didn't know what to think. The only thing he knew for sure was that his trust had been shattered.

How could she look them in the eyes? Christa looked at the three from Shinganshina. The idea of getting close to her victims, eating with them, talking with them, and becoming friends with them after what she did to them, Christa didn't think she'd ever be able to do that. *Just what was so important she was trying to accomplish?*

"Why would she do that?" Eren said helplessly. Everything Armin had said was true, there was no denying it after what they'd seen. *But Marco?* That didn't make any sense to him. "Why him?"

"If I recall correctly," Erwin thought back to the Battle for Trost, "he was with her, Jean, and Connie during the battle, yes?"

"Yeah. During the chaos, we were separated," Connie nodded, glancing at Jean.

"As TV-Armin said a few episodes back, the Female, the Armored, and the Colossal all worked together to overtake Wall Maria. The Colossal did his apart, it's possible she was sneaking away to meet up with the Armored Shifter. As they did before, he'd destroy the gate and she'd lead the other Titans in with her cry."

"In the heat of battle," Levi said, "it wouldn't be hard or suspicious to be separated from your squad. But maybe your friend managed to find her. Maybe he saw or heard something he shouldn't have. And he became collateral damage. But that's just a guess," he shrugged.

The recruits looked at him, stunned.

When no one spoke, Erwin hit play.

" I recognized even its tiniest marks and dings because we repaired our equipment together." A flashback played. Armin stood by the table as Marco worked on his gear, all the parts scattered around before him. "That's how I knew."

" I see…" Annie didn't look at him, staring off to her right. "Well, I happened to pick it up."

Lying, back-stabbing murderous bitch. A vein throbbed in Jean's forehead. *She killed my friend. I'm going to wring her fucking neck* .

I trusted her. Eren gritted his teeth. He had believed in her. "She betrayed us." His chest ached fiercely. "She's...a traitor." It was true, yet still so difficult to say.

"Well, she's not really a traitor," Petra said. "She was never on our side to begin with. She's loyal to her own people."

"I suppose being a fraud is a step up from treacherous bitch," Jean spat out.

"That's irrelevant to me," Mikasa said coldly. "Facts are facts. She killed our people, our friends, our families. Now she wants Eren. Let her come. I'm going to string her up and gut her."

But she's our friend. She— Eren forced himself to recall all the misery she—and her partners—had caused. *Doesn't matter what she once pretended to be* . He would kill her first, and then her cohorts. *For Marco, for Petra and the rest of our squad, for Mom...and the tens of thousands of lives that have been destroyed* .

But a small part of him wondered if he really could bring himself to forget about their bond and do what was necessary when the time came. He pushed that thought away—that weakness—back in anger. *If I don't, all the people who've died because of her, it would mean their deaths were meaningless. That their lives didn't matter* .

Armin's heart squeezed painfully at the looks on his friends' faces. As deeply as this revelation hurt them, they still didn't know about Reiner and Bert. *Finding out about one is devastating. Finding out the other two are also comrades whom we trained and grew up with...* He knew to fight monsters, sometimes one had to become one. It was easy to say how you might act in a certain situation. *But when he faces them out there for real, will Eren be able to throw away his humanity?* The three of them did, for their cause. *We have to do the same.*

Levi observed Ymir's neutral, if a little discomforted, expression. Why wasn't she as broken up over it as the rest of her friends? Maybe they weren't as close. Considering her personality, looking out for number one—and Christa—it wasn't entirely implausible she wasn't as affected because she never bothered to become close with the rest of her class. *Still...* Something about her expression didn't sit well with him.

" Then you killed those two Titans we captured alive?" Armin said.

Sonny and Bean appeared, restrained and surrounded by Scouts.

" Who knows?" Annie replied.

Hange let out a loud, furious cry, rage in her eyes.

Everyone in the room flinched at the sudden scream, some covering their ears. They stared at her with wide eyes, surprised and a little scared.

Hange had a manic look about her. "I'm going to fry that little murderer! I'm going to—I'm going to—I'm going to cut her up into little cubes and make strew!" Her fingers twitched. "And make sausages out of her insides!" She continued to ramble.

"Isn't that what the cannibals did?" Petra said to Levi.

"Four-Eyes, you're not planning to eat the bitch, are you?" He made a disgusted face.

Hange paused and actually seemed to consider that for a moment, creeping them out.

"You'll probably get indigestion," Mikasa muttered.

"No, I won't eat her but I'll feed her to my future Titan babies!" Hange vowed.

A Titan eating a Titan-Shifter . Eren felt a deep, piercing ache in his head. He winched, touching his forehead. He didn't understand why he suddenly felt cold dread at the thought. There was something he needed to know. And it was so close. All he had to do was reach out... But the episode started and he was distracted, the memory slipping away.

" But if you suspected something a month ago, why didn't you act?" Annie asked, still not looking at him.

" Because I couldn't believe it!" Armin said strongly. "I still hope it's just some misunderstanding! But…because of that... Since you didn't kill me back then…" He remembered laying on the grass, looking up as a large shadow fell over him. "That's why this is happening right now."

They were quiet. The wind blew, ruffling her hair. "Yeah," Annie finally turned to them. "I'm pretty sure you're right. I never expected you to corner me like this. Back then… Why… I wonder…"

Sometimes she acts like she has some decency, some goodness to her. When she was the first to move and save Marlo from the MP officers. Petra frowned. *Other times she's so cruel and vicious* . How she seemed to enjoy killing the Scouts in unnecessarily gruesome ways. *She's a complicated girl* .

Levi observed as the recruits' expressions wavered, going between betrayal and confusion. Ymir was the only one who seemed to be eyeing the girl with something akin to pity. *What do you know? What're you hiding?*

" Hey, Annie!" Eren moved up a step. "There's still a chance that you've just got a sick sense of humor, and you're just going along with whatever Armin says because you're an idiot." He went up a few more steps. "So get down here now! If you come underground, that alone proves something! Come on and prove it!" He yelled.

Eren felt incredibly frustrated with himself. She had all but admitted to being the Female Titan in her exchange with his best friend. And he was still acting like a desperate child instead of a soldier. A light bulb went off in his head. *No wonder she beat me in the forest!* He had to have figured out it was her. *She must have used her martial arts!* He remembered how resigned she looked before she did it. *And*

I realized who she was and still I! He felt horribly incompetent. She had killed his squad and still, he'd hesitated. *Mikasa wouldn't have hesitated* . Levi wouldn't have either. Or his squad. They all would've reacted. Done their duty.

Maybe Dad should've given this power to Mikasa. Or Armin . They wouldn't have let it go to waste. *The only thing I managed to do with it was lifting a stupid rock. And that was after losing control and attacking Mikasa* . His friends were smart and disciplined. *She wouldn't have gotten away if it had been either of them* .

His father had left him the Titan power to protect Mikasa and Armin, and all the people behind the Walls. And Eren wanted to do that so badly. He wanted desperately to keep his comrades safe. *Even if it means fighting someone who I once counted as a friend* . He looked at his hand. *I don't want this power to be a waste* . Or worse. Continue being weakling and letting it fall into enemy hands and be used against his people.

" I can't go down there. I've failed…to become a warrior," Annie said.

" I'm telling you, this isn't funny!" Eren screamed at her.

" Tell us, Annie!" Armin joined in. "We can still talk—"

" That's enough." Mikasa stepped up. She tossed her coat. "I can't listen to another word of this." She pulled out her blade. "It's pointless. I'll tear you apart once again…Female Titan!" Mikasa glared at her with a dangerous look on her face.

Wow... Hange thought. *I've got chills* .

Levi nodded in approval. *At least one of them there has some sense of the situation* .

Annie began to laugh. The trio simply watched as she continued to laugh.

"That's a little creepy," Connie muttered.

Did she crack under the strain of her mission and her emotions? Ymir wondered.

Finally, Annie stopped. "Armin, I'm glad I could be a good person for you. Your gamble paid this time. But this is…where my gamble begins!" She said madly and brought up her hand.

Amin immediately fired the flare gun. A group of people ran toward her. Many Scouts in civilian clothes suddenly rushed at her from every direction, surrounding her. One of them used a white strip to gag her before she could bite down on her tongue.

" Eren!" Mikasa put up her hand and stopped him as he attempted to approach them.

Glaring, Annie revealed the blade in her ring.

"Fuck."

"Oh shit."

Mikasa gasped and yanked the two further down the stairs.

" Mikasa!" Armin cried out.

" We were too late!" Mikasa glanced back to see Annie staring down at them.

Good thing all the people have been evacuated . Christa thought.

Every time we think we have her and she's always one step ahead. Erwin was eager to see the tables turn once they were done watching all the episodes.

Annie swiped her thumb over the blade and droplets of blood squirted out. The explosion sent men and women and rocks

flying. Civilians watched the massive light in the distance in shock as they were escorted by the military.

"Let's see who wins round two," Levi said. At least if Eren failed again he would have the rest of the Survey Corps there with him. *The kid needs a lot of training before he is truly a member of my squad* . Mikasa was far more suited to be a part of the Special Ops Squad, based on her skills and instincts. But she often ran off on her own where teamwork was imperative in his squad.

The recruits were quiet.

They look so miserable . Petra felt bad for them.

Hange finished making a note about the ring—and other possible hidden objects—and nodded, "Let's move on then."

Please Review~

Episode - Mercy

Chapter 24: Mercy

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The Female Titan's identity is revealed. They believe she had something to do with Marco's death. Levi observes Ymir. Hange vows revenge and Eren almost has a revelation.

" Armin, I'm glad I could be a good person for you. You've won your bet." Annie said with a mad look on her face. "But this is where my gamble begins!" She brought her hand up to her mouth.

Armin instantly shot off the flare gun. Scouts surged from their hiding places, surrounding her. Annie nicked her finger with the blade in her ring and lightning burst out.

Eren stopped running, glancing back to see the Female Titan's body forming, eyes wide and mouth open in shock.

Erwin's voice narrated. "We've identified the person likely to be the Female Titan." The Female Titan opened an eye, staring down at Eren. "Her name is…"

" Annie!" Eren said.

She was absorbed into the nape and the Female Titan stood tall.

Eren quickly turned and ran as rocks fell.

[A Few Days Earlier]

The former Survey Corps HQ appeared.

" They're late." A small candle lit the almost empty mess hall. "Erwin and his damn folk are making me wait. Our Military Police escorts are gonna arrive first." Levi took a sip of his tea. "Maybe he's constipated again."

"There's that shitty sense of humor again."

"Connie, just don't," Mikasa sighed.

"I'm just trying to lighten the mood. Everyone's been feeling really crappy because of the last few episodes."

"Really, dude? Puns?" Jean rolled his eyes.

"You're just annoyed because I'm the funniest one of the batch and you'll always be number two."

Several people groaned.

"We've been here for hours and watching TV. I guess I can't expect you guys to fully appreciate my sense of humor when you're so pooped."

That brought another round of groans.

"Alright, alright," Connie held up his hands, "I'll stop. From the looks on your faces, I can tell you're dung with me."

That earned him more dirty looks but the veterans seemed mildly amused.

"Sorry. Had to get one last one in. Continue, sir," he told the commander.

" You're quite talkative today, Captain," Eren commented, sitting at the far end of the table.

" Cut me some slack. Talkativeness is in my personality."

The recruits chuckled.

They were silent.

Levi put the teacup down and winced. He touched his injured leg, letting out an annoyed grunt.

" I'm sorry," Eren said quietly, looking down. "It was all my fault."

"It's not your fault. That's on me," Mikasa said.

" If only I'd made the right decision…" Eren's fists trembled in his lap.

Eren took a deep breath. *Don't get frustrated. Just do better. It hasn't happened. I won't let it* .

" I told you," Levi said. "No one could have foreseen the outcome."

Several people coughed pointedly.

"Yes, you all saw the cracks in the plan," Hange said. "But the outcome wasn't etched in stone. We could have still caught her..."

"Cracks? More like gaping holes," Ymir muttered under her breath.

The door creaked open. Eren stood up.

" Sorry for being late." Erwin's voice was heard.

" Not at all," Eren said. "You guys…" Armin, Mikasa, and Jean were among the people standing with the commander. "Uhh…"

" We've identified the person likely to be the Female Titan," Erwin spoke, his words surprising the Shifter. "This time we *will* catch her."

Armin, Mikasa, and Jean stood silently.

The recruits looked on skeptically.

She transformed. I'd say the plan has already failed. Again . Christa hoped they had a back-up in place this time.

" The operation will begin the day after tomorrow," the commander said.

A map of the Walls was open on the table before them.

" The location is Stohess, where we'll be passing en route to the royal court. This is our one and only chance," Erwin said, Eren and Armin sitting across from him. "If we can't escape there, you'll inevitably fall into the hands of the authorities."

Levi and Mikasa sat blank-faced.

" Then it'll be even harder to pursue those who scheme to destroy the Walls. Humanity's annihilation will become even more imminent."

Not all of humanity. But our people definitely . Petra thought. It was still mind-boggling to think there were other civilizations—or at least one—still out there. It completely changed their perspective on the war. *Human vs. human* . She wondered why the Shifters had attacked the people of the Walls. *We've been locked in here for a century.* What had happened back then that they couldn't let it go even after a hundred years?

" We must bet everything we have on this operation."

Eren nodded, face grim and serious.

" The plan is as follows: While we're passing through Stohess," the commander traced the route with his finger, "Eren, you'll act as bait to lure the target to this tunnel. If you can bring her into its depths, then even if she transforms, she won't have the space to utilize her power. But if by any chance she transforms before then, we'll have to rely on you, Eren."

" Yes, sir."

"Try not to fuck up again," Jean said.

Eren gritted his teeth but kept quiet.

"I'm not trying to be a dick," he said after a pause.

"I know. I've bungled up enough already."

Aw . Petra smiled. *They're not tearing at each other's throats* .

" Are we certain our target is in Stohess?" Eren asked.

" Yes. She's in the Police."

" The Police?"

" Armin figured it all out," Erwin said and Eren looked at him. "She's also suspected of killing those two captive Titans. She might be your former fellow trainee from the 104th."

" Hold on now!" Eren's eyes bugged out. "The 104th?!"

" The name of the woman suspected to be the Female Titan is…"

" Wait…"

The explosion sent several Scouts flying.

The Female Titan stood, transformation complete.

" Annie Leonhart," Erwin's voice finished.

Blood had splattered the walls of the tunnel. Armin and Eren stared at the crushed and bloodied bodies.

" Shit!" Armin cursed when a massive arm came in.

Mikasa yanked Eren and the three ran away as the hand came after them.

Sasha shivered. *Creepy* .

" Damn! The way she was acting… She must've seen through me right away!" Armin said. "She knew we were gonna ambush her underground!"

The large hand searched for them blindly.

" There must've been some other way to do this!"

Another way . Erwin thought about the flaws in the plan they had used. Primarily the blatant lack of people and leading her underground. *But if that's how she's expecting to be ambushed, it wouldn't raise her suspicions if they traveled above ground* . And if they were surrounded by people, he didn't think she'd be suspicious then. *But plain-clothed Scouts pretending to be average people won't be enough* .

They would need actual civilians, including children, to be mixed among the soldiers, but they couldn't risk that. *Most civilians wouldn't put themselves in danger like that—or be good enough liars to put on a convincing show of going about a regular day—much less put their children in the middle of it* . But Erwin didn't intend for it to reach

that far. He planned to successfully capture the Female Titan in the Forest of Giants Trees. The TV had already provided them with plenty of info and shown where and how things could go wrong. But he had also learned not to underestimate their foe. Just to be safe, he'd make contingency plans on contingency plans.

The commander glanced over at the middle couch. Already he had some changes in mind for the 57th expedition. Starting with Mikasa's placement in the Special Ops Squad. If she really was like, she needed to be trained by the best. Regardless the hostility she felt toward Levi, he was sure she would not pass up the chance to join the same squad as Eren. *She certainly has the credentials for it* . No one could deny her skills. She'd killed more Titans during the Battle for Trost than most Scouts had in their entire lifetimes.

" You'll have time to think about that later. What should we do now?" Mikasa asked.

Armin took a second to think. "First of all, we need to rendezvous with Team 3 on the surface then according to the backup plan, fight Annie…the Female Titan." He looked to the Shifter. "Eren, you'll have to transform and assist with her capture. That okay?"

" Yeah," Eren looked ahead.

" Hey!" A Scout waved ahead of them.

" It's Team 3!"

" Did your capture attempt fail?"

"Why do I have a feeling they're going to die?" Christa said.

" It did!" Armin replied. "Move on to the next station!"

Suddenly, a giant foot came down, smashing the two Scouts.

Some flinched.

"I was hoping I'd be wrong."

The three stopped and a gust of wind hit them, sending dust flying. They lowered their arms when it cleared somewhat.

Armin gasped. "She kicked it in?!"

The large foot lifted, revealing the mangled bodies crushed against the stones.

" We have to help them!" Eren said.

"Dude, it's too late," Connie said. "They were crushed! Save yourself!"

" Eren! Back!" Mikasa grabbed his hood and pulled him away.

The Female Titan's outline was seen through the hole.

" Hey, Mikasa!"

" That bitch wouldn't mind killing Eren?" Mikasa released her hold on him.

They turned to Armin when he spoke, "She risked it… She smashed open the tunnel hoping she wouldn't kill you. It's crazy, but that just makes her even scarier!"

Well, that's just fucking great. Levi thought.

" Annie will be trying as hard as she can to catch you!"

" What should we do?" Armin spoke, kneeling alongside his friends. "She cut off our escape. Even if we jumped out using our gear, she'd ambush us the instant we surfaced. On the other hand—"

There was an explosion down the tunnel on his left side, the dust extinguishing the sconces.

He protected his face with his arm and lowered it once the dust cleared away. "If we stay here, it's just a matter of time until we're crushed."

" I'll handle this!" Eren stood. "Like that time with the cannonball!"

An image of Eren's transformation at the base of Wall Rose appeared, the half-skeletal half-muscular Titan catching the iron ball.

"That might work!" Sasha nodded.

"Good thinking," Hange said.

" Come here!" Eren pulled them close. "Let's do this! Stay close to me!" Looking at his hand, he brought it up and bit down, causing blood to spurt.

Mikasa and Armin closed their eyes.

"Where's the explosion?" Hange was a little disappointed. It was always such a pleasure watching the Shifters transform.

Eren cried out in pain as the sound of teeth scraping flesh continued.

Petra winced, rubbing the bite mark on her hand, knowing all too well how painful that was.

" Not again!" Blood stained the corner of Eren's lips. "Why now?!" He took a step back and fell to his knees. "Why now?! It hurts!"

Mikasa watched him silently.

" So you can't transform unless it's for a specific, concrete reason? Clear your mind! Focus on it again!" Armin said.

" I'm trying!" Eren bit his hand again.

"I don't understand. What's wrong?" Christa looked worried.

Sasha bit her lip. *He hasn't lost the ability, has he?* She thought panicked, mind jumping to the worst-case scenario.

More blood pooled out of his hand as Eren continued to rip his skin apart with his teeth, grunting in pain.

" Aren't you really," Mikasa knelt, looking him dead in the eye, "just hesitating to fight Annie?"

" Eren?" Armin said.

"What?" Connie said disbelievingly.

That's what I was afraid of . Armin thought.

"You're shitting me," Jean shook his head, face incredulous.

Mikasa's expression turned deadly. "Don't tell me that you still refuse to accept that she's the Female Titan?"

Ymir raised a skeptical eyebrow. *Eren isn't that big a dunce. He knows it's her* .

" *How?* " Sasha said.

"Oh c'mon!" Christa stared at the TV, dismayed.

"No way!" Eren yelled at the same time. "I'm not blind!"

Mikasa's lips turned down in displeasure. It wasn't his eyes that were the problem but his heart. His heart was wavering. *He still considers*

her a close comrade, a friend . He couldn't bring himself to attack her.

" What just happened right before your eyes?" Mikasa leaned closer, the crazed look still in her eye.

"Yikes. She looks terrifying."

" That bitch killed your comrades! You still refuse to accept that __"

Eren squeezed his eyes shut. "Shut up! You're not helping!" He bit his hand and the sound of skin shredding was heard again.

Eren's voice was heard as the screen went dark. "Annie's the Female Titan?"

Erwin remained stoic.

" Why? Why would you say that, Armin?"

"For shits and giggles," Levi said sarcastically. "Why do you think, dumbass?"

" She knew your face from the beginning," Armin answered. "Not to mention," a shot of the Female Titan stopping her fist as Jean was suspended midair flashed on the screen, "she reacted when I referred to how you 'sought to die so soon,' which nobody outside the 104th would understand. And mostly because I'm pretty sure she killed Sonny and Bean," the image of the two Titan appeared, first tied up, then as steaming corpses, "the two experimental subjects."

Hange growled.

" But why?"

" One would need quite the skill to kill those two. The culprit would've used their own 3D maneuver gear since they'd be accustomed to it."

So that's why we had a gear check? But Annie wasn't caught," Eren pointed out.

" Because she brought Marco's to the check."

A flashback of the inspection appeared with Armin staring at Annie's gear.

The expressions on the faces of the recruits darkened or became stoic.

" That's how she passed."

" What?" Eren looked at him in surprise and confusion as Jean watched them. "What does Marco have to do with this?"

Mikasa frowned. *That's what we'd all like to know. Where does Marco fit into all of this?*

" I don't know."

Everyone around the table sat quietly, listening. Levi was reading the paper in his hand.

" Are you sure you're not mistaken?"

" No, I'm pretty certain."

" I got that, kid." Levi interrupted their conversation. "Do you have any other evidence?"

" I don't."

" In my opinion," Mikasa turned to him, "the Female Titan resembles Annie."

She does . Sasha thought. *Based on her physical features, you can narrow it down to the blonde-haired, blue-eyed women of the 104th. Then based on skills, it had to be someone in the top ten.* Not just anyone could kill the two Titans and successfully attack Squad Levi. *It had to be either Annie or Christa* . Sasha couldn't even begin to imagine sweet, kind Christa as a cold-blooded killer. *Annie definitely fits the bill on that one, going off their attitude alone.*

Eren stood up, indignant. "What? What are you even saying?!" He demanded. "Is that all you—"

" So we've got no proof," Levi spoke over him, "but we'll still do it."

" No proof? What? Then why? What if it isn't Annie?" Eren asked.

" If it's not Annie, then she'll be cleared of suspicion," Mikasa answered.

" True, we'll have put her through a terrible ordeal. But if we do nothing," Armin continued, "you'll be sacrificed to MP Brigade's whims."

" It's just not right to doubt Annie…"

Eren felt so blind and naive.

It's obvious in hindsight . Armin thought.

Mikasa eyed the male Shifter in her periphery. It wasn't so easy for him to shake off a bond forged from three years of blood, sweat, and tears. *He's always been too emotional* .

" Eren, after hearing that it might be Annie, has anything come to mind?" Mikasa asked.

Eren's breath caught in his throat.

In a flashback, Rogue froze as the Female Titan took up a fighting stance. Inside the green-eyed giant, Eren stared at the sight before him in shock.

"That's her special stance," Ymir said. "Pretty unique I'd say."

How did he not put two and two together? Then Jean wondered if he could have had he been in Eren's position. He would have, he knew he would have. But he wasn't sure if his reaction would have been any different: frozen in shock.

" You fought the Female Titan in hand-to-hand combat. Did she use any of Annie's typical moves?" Mikasa questioned.

Eren imagined Annie taking over the Female Titan's image, in her fighting pose, and the kick she used. The Female Titan used the same technique, swiping her leg out and kicking Rogue's head right off his shoulders. He could still remember the expression on the other Titan's face, mirroring Annie's.

" You know it too."

" Annie is the Female Titan. So why aren't you fighting? Are other feelings holding you back?" Mikasa eyed him intently.

" What?!" Eren gasped out.

Eren glanced guiltily over at Levi and Petra. Levi was looking unsurprisingly pissed while Petra seemed disappointed. His heart fell. *Forget even failing to avenge them, I can't even bring myself to*

Shift and attack her . He felt crushed by his own inability to fight. *They must feel so betrayed.*

Whatever happened to that psychotic, violent little boy who killed two grown men to save a girl he didn't even know? Jean wondered.

Armin suddenly pulled out a sword, "I've got a plan! Mikasa and I will exit that hole," he pointed to his left, "and the entrance," he pointed to the other side, "at the same time. Annie will have to follow one of us. That should buy you time to run the other way!" Armin pulled on his hood and ran, halting when Eren spoke up.

" Wait! That means one of you is going to die!"

They tensed at the words.

Eren was horrified. Now one of them would die because he couldn't save himself, much less anyone else.

Mikasa pulled on the cloak and Eren looked between the two of them.

" If we keep sitting here, it'll be all three of us! Mikasa! On my mark!"

" Okay! I'll go that way!"

Eren watched her take off. "Mikasa!" He glanced at the other boy. "Armin! How? How can you fight?! How?!" He yelled.

"What do you mean *how* ? What, you expect them to roll over and die?" Jean looked very irked.

"Really, Eren," Christa frowned. "That is very unlike you."

That expression is very unlike you, too . Connie thought. *Even she's annoyed by his pathetic behavior* . Not a word he ever thought he'd used to describe Eren Yeager.

"It's not me," Eren protested weakly.

"Technically it is," Hange said.

Ymir nodded, "You need to get your shit together."

"Took the words right out of my mouth," Levi scowled.

Mikasa turned to the male Shifter, "You're the one who taught me: fight to win, remember?"

Eren sighed loudly, "It's *not* me. I haven't done that—"

"Yet," Sasha added.

"—and I *won't* ."

"He's right," Armin spoke up. "This hasn't happened," he reminded them yet again. It was too easy to become emotional and caught up. "We won't let it get this far."

"Exactly, no reason to gang up on him," Petra nodded and he smiled gratefully.

"Correct. So," Erwin said sternly, "let's not lose focus here."

Mikasa's eyes shifted to the side and she stopped, looking over her shoulder at him, "We've got no choice. It's a cruel world out there." She put on her hood and ran.

Eren's surroundings started to shake.

"Uh-oh."

"That's not good."

The ceiling opened, collapsing over him. And Eren was buried under a rockfall.

Hange gasped, "What if his nape got crushed?"

They waited, looking anxious or scared.

The Female Titan stood aboveground.

" Eren!" Armin ran out into the sunlight, mobilizing his 3D gear and flying toward him.

The Female Titan turned her back on him to see a hooded figure exit out the other side and take to the skies. She surged forward and caught the person in her fist.

They stiffened, automatically waiting to hear the crunch of bones.

Mikasa severed the Titan's fingers.

"Yes!" Connie cheered.

"Phew," Christa lagged back in her seat.

"I got worried for a second there," Sasha exhaled.

" Annie!" Mikasa reached the ground and shot toward the Female Titan. "I'm not letting you have Eren!"

" Eren!" Armin landed near the mess. "Eren! I'm coming for you!"

Eren was lying face down, unconscious, half buried under the rubble.

" Eren!" Armin grunted, plying off a large piece of the wreckage. "Wake up!"

The Female Titan looked over and started moving. Mikasa flew after her, letting out a battle cry. The Female Titan covered her nape with her left hand as she ran and threw out her arm to swipe Mikasa, who dodged the attack, one sword digging through the skin of the arm.

"Yeah! Nice dodge!"

"Fuck yeah!"

"Now carve her up again!"

The roofs of the buildings the giant's fist connected with exploded. Countless rocks flew, one of them hitting Mikasa and sending her rolling to the ground. The Female Titan took in her unmoving form and continued.

"Oh fuck!"

"No!"

"Mikasa!"

"I'm sure she's only unconscious," Petra said.

"What?" Eren gasped at the scene. *Did she just knock-out Mikasa? No way!* He didn't even bother to consider the other option. Mikasa couldn't be killed so easily.

" Don't let the Female Titan get away!" Three Scouts chased after her. "We can't let her out of here!"

The Female Titan held up her fingers as they finished healing completely.

Not too far away, the MP whimpered, watching the smoke rise.

" What's going on?! Backup team!" Nile yelled at the soldiers, Marlo and Hitch, atop the roofs. "Leave this to us! Go check it out!"

" Yes, sir!" Marlo raised a sword in response. Then he, Hitch, and Boris took off.

"I hope they don't die. They're not that bad," Christa said.

" This is weird. That explosion and—"

" Nile!" Erwin stood by a carriage, Levi standing nearby with his arms crossed. "Dispatch all of your soldiers. It's probably a Titan."

" What are you saying? This is Wall Sina! There can't possibly be Titans in here!"

"Well, there is now," Petra muttered.

Behind them, Jean jumped out of the carriage on the side of the street.

" Stop!" An MP soldier grabbed his shoulders. "Don't move, Yeager!"

" I'm tired of playing dress-up!" Jean yanked off the wig. The man gaped open-mouthed, startled back.

Everyone snickered.

" Never call me that again, asshole!"

They burst out laughing.

Jean ran toward Erwin. "Commander, I'll go as well." He pulled on his cloak.

" Get your gear from Team 4."

" Yes, sir."

" Having a fiery spirit is good, but don't forget how to stay alive," Levi said.

" Yes, sir."

He's so different compared to when we first saw him as a trainee . Hange thought.

Nile gaped at the scene, watching Jean runoff. "Erwin, what—"

"He looks like a poor confused fish," Sasha said.

" Commander, here!" A Scout landed behind Nile and opened the brown trunk, revealing the 3D gear.

" Thank you." The commander quickly suited up.

" Hey, Erwin—"

" All those who can move, mobilize!" Erwin began giving out orders. Levi stood by without a word. "We must assist with the capture of the Female Titan!"

" Erwin, stop!" Nile confronted him, rifle in hands, looking very angry. He cocked the gun at Erwin and the other MP soldiers followed suit. "What you're doing is a clear rebellion against the king!"

A few people gasped.

"Let's hope he doesn't have itchy fingers," Ymir said.

" No," Levi said bluntly. "Is your head as hollow as that gun barrel? You haven't a clue what's going on, by the looks of it."

They snickered.

"Maybe don't insult the man pointing a gun at you?" Connie said, but he was grinning widely.

" Dismantle your gear, Erwin!" Nile demanded.

If this doesn't work out, the commander will be a lot of trouble for defying the military. Armin thought.

Meanwhile, civilians panicked and ran as they caught sight of the Female Titan.

" A Titan!"

" There's a Titan!"

" How did it get here?!"

Above them, on the roofs, the MP soldiers simply stared at the sight in disbelief. "Dude… That's a Titan."

So useless. Mikasa thought.

" But how?"

" Outta my way!" Jean ran through the crowd. *Just standing around, dammit!* He glanced at the soldiers standing by, not doing a thing. *I wanted to be one of them* . He looked ahead. "What about now? Shit!"

"Now you're in the most badass division," Sasha said.

"Hell yeah," Connie nodded.

A group of Scouts approached the Female Titan.

" Don't even try taking it down! It'll be enough if we can just hold it back!" One of them yelled. He flew over her, avoiding her fingers, and grabbed another Scout's hands. The two of them spun and he threw the other Scout.

"Whoa!"

"That's so cool!"

"I wanna learn how to do that!"

He yanked out his swords but the Female Titan, one hand still covering her nape, grabbed the wire in front of her and pulled it down, causing the man to crashed into a building.

"Dammit!"

"No!"

"But it looked so badass..."

The Female Titan grabbed the wire of the other Scout and yanked it, making him crash into her bicep, impaled by his own swords.

" It's hopeless!" A Scout said. "It can see right through the movements of the 3D maneuver gear!" He quickly moved away from her.

Mikasa flew a few feet above the ground and rounded the corner. "You won't get rid of me so easily!" She cut the Female Titan's Achilles' tendon.

"Go, Mikasa!"

"I should've known you wouldn't go down so easy."

"Always such a badass!"

Armin removed another piece of the wreckage. "Eren! Answer me! Eren!"

" Hey!" Jean landed behind him. "What are you doing?!"

" Jean! Eren's under here!"

" What?! Wasn't he supposed to transform into a Titan?"

" He couldn't! Probably because the Female Titan was actually Annie."

" What?!"

" We have to get him out!" Armin turned back to Eren. "Help, Jean!"

" He couldn't?!" Jean's expression of disbelief quickly turned into anger. "What the fuck were you thinking, Eren?!" He knelt by the unconscious teen and yelled at him. "I told you we'd all be counting on you! Is this our payback for placing humankind's future and our very survival in your hands?! Marco…" His head fell, shoulders shaking. "Marco…"

Eren's shoulders slumped. *Oh yeah, yet another person I let down* .

Petra eyed him sympathetically. *He hasn't actually failed anyone but he's really beating himself up over it* . It did hurt that he couldn't bring himself to fight the bitch who had killed their squad and the other Scouts. The thought their deaths had been in vain, they hadn't meant enough to warrant beating her down to a bloody pulp, it hurt a lot. *But he's known her for years and we were barely a team for a month* . He was still thinking of her as a comrade, not as their enemy.

The boy needs to grow the hell up . Levi thought. *He needs to start acting like a soldier.* It was a war. And there was no place in war for whimpering about traitors who were former friends. *Crush her before she kills more of your real friends* .

Eren's eyes opened weakly.

A rock flew into the building across the street and the debris from the destruction flew at them.

Jean and Armin jumped out of the way, Armin rolling and skidding to a stop. Down the street, the Female Titan fought an unseen person. Armin looked over at the Shifter. "Eren?"

" Shit!" Jean cursed, standing behind him. "We've gotta bitchslap that skank first!" He removed his sword and ran toward her.

Levi snorted at the choice of words.

Jean didn't hesitate. He went right for her . Eren thought, brooding.

" Eren, there's something I told Jean before."

One of Eren's eyes shifted toward Armin.

" You can't change anything unless you can discard part of yourself too. To surpass monsters, you must be willing to abandon your humanity. Annie can do that, I bet."

Annie swiped at the Scouts buzzing around her as civilians watched.

" I don't know what her goal is, though. But whoever can pull it off, wins!" Armin said with conviction and stood.

Eren lay still, a pipe sticking through his body.

A Scout charged at the Female Titan, flying from the ground up, cutting her shin. She caught him with her free hand, the other spinning another Scout, and smashed them both into a building beside her.

" Annie!" Armin glared. "If you don't kill me now, next time you won't have time to place your bet!"

The Female Titan turned to look at him and Jean attacked from behind. But she covered her weak spot with crystalized fingers.

"Too slow, damn!" Jean growled.

Jean retreated and yelled over his shoulder, "Armin, this way!"

" Roger!" Armin ran by the Titan and took off using his 3D gear.

Jean was in the lead with Armin behind him and the Female Titan following last.

Hange was grinning insanely, clutching a rope, body trembling.

Hange squealed in excitement. "Avenge our babies!" She screeched.

" Coming… She's coming…"

" Squad Leader, your eyes are glowing maniacally," Moblit said worriedly.

They couldn't help but laugh.

"Look at her face," Christa laughed in delight.

"She looks like a cat that got her hands on the cream," Petra said.

"That's right~" Hange's fingers wiggled in anticipation.

As Jean and Armin raced by, Hange stood, placing her foot on the barrel. The Female Titan turned to look but it was too late.

Hange yanked the rope and fired. Dozens of wires flew, wrapping around the giant's body. She tried to swat Jean and

Armin but they dodged. The wires continued to fire, trapping her in place. Her legs and arms were locked in place.

"For Sonny and Bean!" Hange screamed.

The Female Titan glared in fury.

They tensed, afraid she'd rip free.

More wires shot out from behind her and yanked her down. She fell with a boom, causing dust to rise.

They leaned forward, not speaking as if it might break her free.

Scouts unrolled and tossed a metal net with arrowheads over her.

On the ground, dust floated around the many wires. Armin landed by the Female Titan, who was pinned underneath the net.

" Okay! I didn't think we'd need another backup plan, but you're just insane." Hange stood on the roof with other Scouts, spinning a wire. "Commander Erwin is quite the guy. Now then…"

Hange walked forward and dropped to the ground. Using her 3D gear, she landed gracefully.

"That was a cool landing," Sasha complimented.

"Why thank you."

" Be a good girl for me, will you?"

Mikasa stepped out from behind a contraption holding six barrels.

Hange placed a hand below the Female Titan's eye. She held a broken sword just before her eye, making the pupil shrink. "You can't summon other Titans to eat you either this time."

"Whoa, she's pretty cool," Connie said.

Hange cackled like a manic, almost drooling imagining what she would do the Female Titan.

"Never mind. She's nuts."

" But don't worry…" Hange looked down rather psychotically.

"Holy shit."

"Wow..."

" I'm going to devour you instead. I'll make sure to digest every bit of intel I get from you."

"So, is it time to celebrate?"

Suddenly, the Female Titan swept out her leg, destroying the barrel holders.

"Spoke too soon."

Hange and Moblit jumped back. Mikasa landed in a crouch beside them, "She broke free?!"

"I'm getting real tired of this shit," Mikasa scowled fiercely. She just wanted to run out and bash Annie's face into the ground.

"You aren't the only one," Jean said.

" There weren't enough traps?! Don't let her escape!" Hange ordered.

The Female Titan ran, wires still stuck in her with the barrels attached on the other end flying behind her.

Jean and Armin gave chase.

***" You can't change anything unless you can discard part of yourself too."* Armin's words echoed in Eren's mind.**

I know* . His eyes were unfocused. *My friends are out there. I can't fail them now.

Mikasa and the other Scouts charged at her and she swept out her arm.

" Remember…"

Mikasa dodged the rocks artfully.

The corpses of Squad Levi flashed quickly, followed by the death of his mother.

That's right. Remember what she did . Levi thought.

Erwin smiled. He had a good feeling.

Eren blinked, eyes clear. He began to pull himself up. Blood squirted out. *I'll annihilate her.* Eren gritted his teeth, covered in blood. *No… I'll kill her!*

"Yes!"

"Fucking finally!"

"There's the crazy bastard we know."

"Now beat her down!"

"Don't get your ass kicked again!"

"You've got the other Scouts this time to back you up! No excuses!"

"There's only one more main episode! Let's win this for real now!"

Mikasa came at the Female Titan from above. The giant attempted to kick her and she dodged but the wind sent her flying back.

" I don't have time to worry if it's right or wrong."

Mikasa tired to use the gas to slow her momentum.

" You can't hope for a horror story with a happy ending!"

Mikasa hit the ground running before she fell and rolled to a stop.

"Ouch!"

"That had to hurt."

" Yeah!"

" Mikasa!" Armin yelled.

" It's a cruel world out there."

Eren screamed and blood shot out as he lifted himself up.

"It's about fucking time!"

"Holy shit! Holy shit! Holy shit! Holy shit!"

"Here it comes!"

Lightning exploded.

And so did the room.

Even Petra and Hange jumped to their feet and joined the recruits in unintelligible screaming.

" What is it this time?!" Nile demanded, looking over his shoulder.

Erwin stared hard at the lightning.

The Female Titan stood still.

A cat napped on stone steps.

Then the ground began to shake and the sound of thunderous footsteps was heard. Some Scouts on the roofs turned to the source. Windows shattered when the massive body ran by.

The Female Titan turned and caught a fist in the face from the roaring Rogue Titan. She was sent flying back into a building. Rogue steamed, his lone visible eye glowing green.

Levi winced, covering his ears to protect them from everyone's screams of excitement. He smirked, heart racing wildly in his chest.

"Get her," Erwin grinned widely.

" Eren!" Armin called out.

Jean watched without a word, crouching on a roof.

Mikasa lifted her head, "Eren?"

The Rogue Titan bent his knees, arms up, and charged at the Female Titan, roaring as he ran.

The group screamed along with Rogue.

"Yes! Yes! Yes! Yes! Yes! Yes! Yes! Yes! Yes! Yes! YES!" Christa fell back into her spot, arms still up.

"Holy Rose, Maria, and Sina! That was fucking epic!"

Hange and Sasha screeched together.

"You're going to beat her this time," Petra told Eren.

"I fucking will!" His eyes were shining.

"You better," Levi threatened. "Or I will—"

"Start the next episode already!"

"Yeah!"

"Let's go!"

"I'm so fucking pumped!"

Erwin had wanted half a minute to have a quick discussion with Levi and Hange but everyone was clearly too riled up. "Very well then." He hit play.

Please Review~

Episode - Wall

Chapter 25: Wall

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Connie makes poop puns. Erwin has changes in mind for the future, including Mikasa's induction into Squad Levi. The group gangs up on Eren for his lack of action.

"What choice do we have?" Mikasa stood, looking over her shoulder.

The dead bodies of Squad Levi and Eren's mother's death flashed on the screen.

"The world is a cruel place!"

Eren's eyes widened, fully alert. *I'll annihilate her.* Gritting his teeth, blood squirting everywhere, he began to pull himself up. *No… I'll kill her!* He screamed.

Lightning crashed down to earth.

Some of them squealed in excitement.

"On that day, humanity received a grim reminder," Candy narrated. "They lived in fear of Titans, disgraced to cower within the cages they called Walls."

The Female Titan stood still.

You're about to get it now. Hange giggled gleefully.

The ground shook and the Scouts turned to look.

Windows shattered as Rogue ran by.

The Female Titan turned, getting a fist in the face by the screaming Rogue Titan and sent back into a building.

That was very satisfying watching a second time . Petra thought.

"Eren!" Armin called out, flying through the air.

Jean watched from atop a roof.

"Eren?" Mikasa lifted her head, lying on the ground.

Rogue's lone eye glowed green as he steamed, a low growl coming from his throat.

"That is so HOT," Hange moaned.

Levi made a sound of disgust and the others giggled.

Eren wondered if he should feel flattered but mostly he was just uncomfortable.

The inside of a church appeared with the image of the three goddesses.

"Ugh," Connie rolled his eyes.

"Let us pray for our three goddesses: Maria, Rose, and Sina. For their continued well-being…" A pastor spoke, with two others dressed in the same black robes beside him. He

addressed the congregation standing in a circle before him. "And for our peace and safety…"

"Why do we have to watch this?" Christa looked irritated. She wanted to watch Eren fight.

Pastor Nick stood with his eyes closed, arms out. "You must not doubt the sacred Walls! The gleaming Walls, bequeathed to us by God, will grow stronger through our faith and devotion."

Everyone was wearing the golden necklaces representing the goddesses.

"Is it rude for me to hope they all get crushed?" Mikasa muttered.

"Yes," Eren replied. "But it's kinda their fault for being so annoying."

"An innocent heart…"

"Anyone hear that?" Jean leaned forward.

"…wholly devoted to God…"

Everyone followed his motion. The could faintly make out some rumbling in the distance.

"…offers ours only protection!"

"Are they seriously deaf?" Sasha said as the rumblings became audible.

"Our only hope…"

"How do they not hear that?" Christa said incredulously.

"…of keeping them at bay—"

Suddenly, the Female Titan came crashing in.

They jerked slightly, startled even though they'd half been expecting it.

Mikasa winced, feeling an iota of guilt. She hadn't truly wanted them to die.

"They were annoying and foolish but they were innocent people," Petra said.

"It's an unfortunate part of war but innocent people die," Erwin said.

The commander's words made them somber as the full meaning of what he meant sunk in.

A battle between Titans. Levi disliked what was about to happen, even if he wanted to see the Rogue Titan put his squad's killer in her place. *How many civilians will get caught up in the chaos?*

A troubled look crossed Eren's face. In a purely logical way, he knew it was in everyone's best interest to engage her in combat and defeat her. But the thought of civilians being caught up bothered him. *Like Armin said, sometimes you to become a monster to defeat one* . He would hate it but it was a necessity. *We already tried a plan without putting them in danger.* Eren thought grimly. It was a burden he would have to shoulder.

Outside the church, the Rogue Titan stood, exhaling steam.

Pastor Nick opened his eyes, arms guarding his head. His eyes widened at the sight of the Female Titan lifting her head. "A Titan? How'd it get *here* ?"

Snuck in through the gate . Erwin thought. *We have those kinds of enemies now* .

The Female Titan sat up, jaw steaming. She looked down at the bodies beneath her hands, vacant-eyed and lying in pools of blood.

Maybe there's some decency in her after all. Not that Hange planned to take it easy on the Shifter once she had her in her clutches. *But I might feel a little bad about it* .

Rogue charged at her.

They couldn't quite will up that thrilled feeling from minutes earlier and get as pumped up, knowing the two of them battling it out in the middle of the city was going to result in the deaths of countless civilians.

The Female Titan stood. "No!" Pastor Nick watched her run. "Stay away from the Walls!"

"Gotta hand it to him for not turning into a total chicken at the sight of a Titan," Sasha admitted. "I can't believe he's still worried about the Walls at this point."

"He's nuts," Ymir said.

"Fanatics," Connie agreed.

"Our Walls!" Pastor Nick turned to see Rogue rush by, the force sending him tumbling backward.

Many pairs of running feet appeared along with the sound of terrified screaming.

Civilians on a wide road watched as Rogue gave chase to the Female Titan. He brushed by a building and they began to scatter. Inside a home, a woman fell and a man grabbed a cupboard as Rogue passed by, causing the ground to shake.

The Female Titan continued to run and Rogue pursued.

Three Scouts landed on a building the two Titans raced past, observing them. "Looks like he's retaining control this time," Hange spoke.

"Yes. Even so, Eren's never been able to defeat the Female Titan before."

Eren knew Armin was only stating a fact but it still stung.

Hange turned to look at Armin.

"Since he chose to transform, I think he's ready to fight her for real," Jean said.

"Do my ears deceive me or is Jean kinda defending Eren and saying he believes in him?" Ymir said, amused.

"Don't get used to it," Jean said.

Armin looked at his best friend. "I didn't mean to imply you're—"

"It's okay. I know."

"He won't go down so easily—"

"Willpower alone cannot win battles!" Armin interrupted. "You of all people should know that, Jean. Defeating Annie will require much more…"

Rogue continued to chase the Female Titan.

"An open area!" Two Scouts landed on a roof and observed the area that lay ahead, "The Female Titan's headed out into the open!"

"We can't use our 3D maneuver gear there!"

Hange landed nearby, "Split into two teams and go around!"

"Roger!"

Armin and the other Scouts took off.

On the ground, two civilians in an alley panicked, screaming as the Female Titan ran by and sent them flying back.

He's like a rabid dog . Erwin hoped Eren's instincts took over and eliminated the threat, a Titan, the things he vowed to end once in for all. *We can't even engage her much less defeat her on level ground* .

Meanwhile, the MP struggled to put on their gear.

"C'mon, c'mon, c'mon!"

Shadis would eat them alive for fumbling around and taking so much time . Jean thought.

"Son of a bitch! Where'd they come from?"

The soldiers yelled out and scrambled out of the path of the two behemoths. The Female Titan turned, sliding back, throwing out an arm into a building to slow her momentum. Several soldiers without gear fell out.

The two Titans stood facing each other, staring the other one down.

Annie, always so cynical… **Rogue glared.**

So he's still in control. Erwin thought.

Flashes of Annie during the trainee years appeared. ***"Like every little thing around you was pointless. Nothing worth a second look."***

The Female Titan pulled up her arms, getting into a fighting stance.

"Every now and then, though, I could see through the act… Especially when you were showing off your fighting skills."

Annie stood in the same position and attacked Eren. ***"You said such skills were pointless in this era, but I could tell deep down, you didn't believe that."***

Rogue stood in a fighting stance as well. ***But I just figured you were a shitty liar… Tell me, Annie… What are you even fighting for? What could possibly be worth all the lives of those people?!***

Armin wondered the same thing. *What kind of a danger could we possibly pose? What could Annie's side gain from killing the people of the Walls?* He could not think of another reason for attacking a group of people out of nowhere. Especially after a hundred years of one side not even knowing the other existed.

I can't imagine our territory is larger than theirs . They could have more resources because they could expand. Surely it couldn't be that, could it? *Maybe it's hubris* , he suddenly thought. Armin considered that for a moment. Her people wanted to prove themselves superior and gain control of more land. If humans outside the Walls were anything like humans inside the Walls, it didn't at all outlandish.

And we posed little to no threat to them until Eren . Armin's brow furrowed. Until Eren got his powers. From his dad. Where did Grisha get the serum? His eyes widened at the most obvious answer. *Could Eren's dad have been one of them?* Lightning fast, thoughts flashed through his head. Maybe Grisha stole it for whatever reason—and Armin could imagine it was a powerful weapon—and they wanted it back. *And that could be why they need Eren alive* . Did everything that had happened in the past five years occur because Annie's people were trying to flush out the traitor who stole something priceless?

Eren's dad didn't use the serum until after they breached . Armin tried to make sense of it but it was difficult to make everything fit together. *Why did he do it? Why come here?* And how did a human cross Titan territory?

Countless thoughts, questions, and assumptions rose in his mind. He had a feeling he was missing a lot of clues and pushed the thoughts out of his mind for the time being. He was interested to pick Erwin and Hange's thoughts about the various theories running around in his head.

Rogue surged toward her, throwing the first punch. The Female Titan blocked using a crystallized elbow, the resulting force causing damage to the buildings around them. His fist slipped downward and he stumbled forward slightly. She attempted a kick but he crossed his arms, blocking, before latching onto her leg. Picking her up, he threw her above a building behind him.

It's a flying Titan! Connie snickered to himself.

The Female Titan crashing back into a tall building, sliding down, leaning against it. Rogue charged through the building between them, arms out, and she hastily moved out of the way.

"Whoa!" Hange gasped.

Eren's frown deepened.

"What on Earth?"

Scouts watched the destruction from rooftops.

"Squad Leader," Moblit said, "I hate to say it, but the city'll be debris and corpses even *if* we manage to catch her."

"We're doing this regardless," Hange replied. "Erwin's decision is final. Be ready to capture her."

Armin listened to them silently.

"Right."

Mikasa pushed off the ground, sitting up. "Eren…"

"We didn't sign up for this." Hitch stood next to Marlo.

They're finally getting a proper dose of reality . Levi thought.

"Why are there Titans fighting in the streets?"

"What's going on here?" Marlo said, confused.

"Titans fighting each other?" Nile and his subordinates stood surrounding Erwin, rifles aimed.

"Yes, sir."

"The city's collapsing like a house of cards. It's just it's horrifying. Casualties are mounting, both civilians and military."

Gritting his teeth, glaring furiously, Nile held up his rifle. "Erwin! Was this your plan all along?"

Erwin was rather curious to see what his old friend would do now.

"That's right." Erwin stood calmly as fleeing, screaming civilians in a different part of the city were crushed by rocks. "I acted entirely on my own authority. And I offer no excuses."

Damn, he's got some serious balls. Ymir thought.

I'd be so pissed. Jean figured he'd probably punch Erwin if he were in Nile's place.

"Why are they all there?" Christa spoke up. "One man and one rifle are all you need. Shouldn't they be focusing on the bigger issue at hand and try to do something about it instead?"

Mikasa snorted. "They can't do much."

"They're not even trying though," Petra said.

"So the Military Police is not dealing with the real problem and fucking around somewhere away from the danger, sounds about right," Levi rolled his eyes.

Nile lowered his weapon and grabbed Erwin by the collar. "You knew what would happen if you executed such an operation within the city! You son of a bitch! Why? Why would you still do it?"

Clouds blew in the wind, covering the sun and casting a large shadow on the destruction.

"For humanity…" Erwin's voice was heard.

A blonde-haired little girl walked down the street, tears pouring down her cheeks, eyes wide and dazed.

They watched with stoic expressions.

"…to lead us to victory."

"Bullshit!" Nile aimed the rifle at Erwin once again. "You're nothing but a traitor! I should kill you right here and now! None of the higher-ups would even give a shit!"

Levi said nothing, only watching the exchange, arms crossed.

"Fine by me. However," Erwin said seriously, "you'll need to assume command."

Nile let out a surprised sound, lowering his rifle slightly.

He can't do it . Armin thought.

"That's pretty clever," Ymir said. "Because he obviously doesn't have the balls to shoulder something like that."

"The Female Titan must not escape. Paehl's in charge of formations. Vyler oversees supplies. Work with them closely, and push her to the eastern Wall at all costs—"

"H-Hold…" Nile threw out his hand. "Hold on!"

"Let me take notes," Connie joked tentatively, earning a few chuckles.

"Do…do you really…"

An image of the city burning and smoking in several areas appeared.

"…believe this is for the good of us all?"

"I have faith it's a step forward."

A bead of sweat rolled down the side of Nile's face. Finally, he closed his eyes and brought his rifle down. "Everyone, lower your rifles. Place this man under arrest."

"Sir!"

"Deploy all troops immediately. As of now focus on rescuing and evacuating civilians."

"Yes, sir!" The soldiers quickly ran down the street.

"Finally."

"About time."

"Took him long enough."

"Erwin, I hereby wash my hands of you and leave you to the high court."

Two MP soldiers finished handcuffing Erwin. "I'll accept their judgment. Thank you, Nile. Levi," the commander turned to Levi as he began to follow the other soldiers, "for now, stay here. You dislike unnecessary deaths, don't you?"

"Yeah. I hate it. It's truly loathsome, no matter who dies."

He surprises me again . Jean had expected the man to have similar views to the commander. That people died, it was just how it was.

Armin, Jean, and three other Scouts flew toward the two Titans, landing on buildings near them. *If you're not willing to make sacrifices yourself* , Armin's expression was severe, *you'll never be able to change anything!*

Rogue and the Female Titan prepared to square off once more.

" *To rise above monsters…"*

Rogue moved first and she crystallized her right shin.

"… *we have to abandon our humanity."*

To what extent though? Sasha wondered. How far would they have to go to protect themselves from this threat? *We're letting two Titans brawl in a city that's not even close to being fully evacuated* . At what point would they become just like the people they were fighting? *If we keep going down this road there won't be much difference between us* .

The impact of her kick connecting with his leg torn it off his body and sent shockwaves through the streets.

"That's certainly something Annie can do."

She's doing what she has to for her side , Hange glanced at Eren, *he's gotta learn to do the same* .

Rogue still charged at her on one leg, connecting his fist with her face and sending her skidding back, before falling to the ground.

"Annie…" Annie's father knelt before the young blonde-haired girl.

"Annie!" Her father's voice rang through her head as his face, covered by shadows, flashed through her mind. The Female Titan's eyes turned cold.

A worried look crossed Petra's face. *Now she'll be attacking to get back to her father instead of just escaping to live* . She could imagine reuniting with her family was going to be a more powerful motivator than anything else.

So used to killing mindless Titans whose only purpose was to kill, it troubled her slightly to have an enemy like this. Petra couldn't forgive the Female Titan for killing her comrades but the thought of the little girl at same the refugee camp as Eren and his friends weighed heavily. *She was a child sent off to war.*

Rogue, crouching on the ground, pushed off but was met with a powerful right kick. Hange and the others braced themselves against the resulting force. Rogue had caught her leg between his jaw, several teeth missing.

"Damn," Levi muttered.

Crazy bastard . Jean could feel his teeth ache just at the sight of it.

Crystallizing her right fist, the Female Titan brought it down on his head several times.

"Annie…" The memory flashed again.

Blood flew up as she continued to hammer his face.

"Oh shit," Connie muttered.

"I believe in you." Her father embraced as she looked on with surprise. "I'm always on your side."

Screaming, she slammed her fist painfully against Rogue's bloodied and messed up face. Rogue sat motionless, his lifeless face steaming. With one last look to confirm he would not give chase, the Female Titan ran.

Rogue sat still. *I will…kill the Titans…* Inside, with the upper part of his face covered by the muscle, Eren spoke, "Every single fucking one!" He grinned creepily.

"Wow," Christa's eyes widened while Ymir raised an eyebrow.

Levi nodded in approval.

"Damn," Connie shivered, "I just got chills!"

There's the little psycho who killed two grown men as a kid. Jean thought.

The Female Titan turned to look behind her.

Screaming in fury, Rogue went after her, veins flowing red and parts of his upper body on fire.

"WHOA! IS EVERYONE SEEING THIS?!" Hange jumped up and screamed.

"Yes," Levi replied irritability. "No need to—"

"He's on fire! Literally *on fire!* " Mikasa gaped.

"There's something you don't see every day," Ymir commented in surprise.

"So fucking insane!" Connie yelled.

"Is it some new ability?" Petra thought out loud.

Eren perked up.

"I think it might have to do with his regeneration," Armin said.

"I agree! It's likely got something to do with his healing factor! Normally Titans steam when they heal but he's on fire!" Hange theorized, a little calmer now, writing furiously as she spoke. "His wounds should have taken longer to heal but his regeneration accelerated to a point that fire is coming out instead of steam."

Rogue moved like a mindless beast, stumbling into buildings, falling, scrambling after his prey. Jumping off the side of a building he tackled her from above, wrapping his right arm around her neck and sending them both crashing to the ground, sliding forward.

"I think he's actually going to take her down now," Christa said.

Sasha nodded. "And the Scouts should be able to help now that they're near buildings and the Wall."

Erwin shook his head. "There's a risk he won't recognize friend from foe in this state. Better to let him defeat her and take him out while he's tired if he has truly gone berserk again."

Please defeat her. Eren prayed.

"Eren!" Mikasa flew over some buildings and landed next to Hange.

The scientist stared, "That's…"

"Eren!"

"Stop!" Hange took a step forward. "We don't know if Eren can recognize you now…"

Mikasa looked over to see Rogue pinning a terrified Female Titan to the ground, roaring intimidatingly. She pushed him off, forcing him on his back but he quickly sat up and grabbed her face.

"Is he going to rip her face off?!"

"Holy crap!"

"That's fucking intense!"

"I wanna see what she looks like without a face!"

"That's disturbing, Hange."

Rogue began to squeeze.

"Her eyes are bulging out to their sockets!"

"Holy fucking Maria!"

"Ewww!"

The side of Rogue's body appeared as he growled and suddenly, blood splashed everywhere.

"Did he just pop her face like a zit?!"

"Dude, that's gross."

Nile and his subordinates looked on with fear and shock. "H-Hey…"

Erwin watched on calmly behind him. The Female Titan screeched in agony, elbows up, clutching her face as Rogue sat behind her, crushing her head. His arms finally lowered and she

quickly elbowed him in the face with her crystallized elbow. She turned, on her back, dodging his swipe and kicking him.

Rogue flew back into a building and Armin, Jean, Mikasa, Hange, and Moblit braced themselves as the ground shook.

"Man, she does not look good."

We've got her now . Erwin thought. With Mikasa and the other Scouts present, even if Eren couldn't stop her they would.

With her fingers crystallized, the Female Titan ran toward the Wall.

Rogue went after her.

"She's headed up the wall!" Jean yelled.

"She's trying to escape!" Hange ran forward.

We've got her on the run. That means she doesn't think she can win! Christa thought hopefully.

The Female Titan jumped up, fingers penetrating the Wall. Looking very desperate, she pulled herself up. Rogue reached her and latched onto her leg. Trying to hold her while missing his right leg and part of his left arm below the elbow, he bit her. The Female Titan, looking afraid, crystallized her upper left foot and kicked him hard. Rogue fell, taking a part of her right leg with him.

"No! She's going to get away!" Armin's voice was heard as she continued to climb. The Female Titan was almost at the top now.

But we're so close! Sasha thought.

"I won't let her!" Mikasa flew up almost parallel to the Wall.

"Well, she's not going anywhere now."

"Mikasa's got this!"

With fearful eyes, the Female Titan watched her soar above her in an arch. Mikasa severed the Titan's fingers below the hardened parts of her first hand then the second, glaring at her as she fell.

"Between Eren and Mikasa, they've got her."

"Honestly it's about fucking time."

"I can't wait to experiment on her!" Hange cackled like a maniac.

" *We* don't have her yet, Four-Eyes."

Mikasa descended, landing lightly on the Female Titan's forehead. "Annie," she said calmly, wind blowing through her hair, "fall."

"I wish I could do that. That looked so badass," Connie said.

"Too bad you don't have the hair," Sasha teased.

They giggled.

"Hey, not cool!"

Mikasa jumped off. Mouth open, the Female Titan watched the clouds in the sky as she fell.

"Annie." Her father knelt on one knee before her, hands on her shoulders, as they stood outside a house surrounded by trees. "I'm so sorry. I don't expect you to forgive me."

A young Annie listened silently, eyes wide.

"But please… There's one thing…I want to ask of you."

What is he talking about? Armin wondered.

Ymir glanced at the recruits, noting the vaguely uneasy looks on their faces. *Easier to hate someone when they look like a monster* . It wasn't so easy when they were humanized, realizing they were also someone's daughter and had a family waiting for them to return.

The Female Titan crashed to the ground. Rogue pounced on her immediately.

"You can make an enemy of the entire world…"

Roaring madly, he began to tear her up, bringing his fist down. Her arm went flying off to the side, landing a few feet from Erwin who barely batted an eyelash while the MP fled in terror.

He's got nerves of steel . Connie thought, impressed. *He didn't even flinch!* The commander was pretty cool.

I'll destroy this whole fucking world! **Rogue's both arms were steaming, missing above the elbows, as the Female Titan's headless body lay beneath him.**

"Oh no, he's completely lost his head."

"Don't eat her Eren! We need her alive!"

"He can't hear you."

The Female Titan's wrecked head lay against a broken building, spattered with blood, face frozen in an expression of fright.

Their jaws dropped.

"Damn, so brutal."

"Now is it safe to say we win?"

"But even if the entire world hates you…"

Rogue's header began to dip.

Hange gasped. "Oh, shit! He's gonna eat the girl inside!"

"Eren, don't!" Jean yelled.

"Eren!" Mikasa called out.

"We need her alive." Armin worried the Shifter would not be able to stop himself. *Someone needs to stop him* .

"What's the matter?" Mikasa asked worriedly. "Are you feeling okay?"

Eren rubbed his forehead, "Nothing. A fleeting thought. It felt like something important but it just slipped through my fingers." He had a strong feeling he needed to remember what it was.

I am free… **Rogue brought his face down, opening his mouth.**

"Promise me you'll return…" Annie's father said. "That's all I ask."

A tear rolled down against a black screen.

They watched in awkward silence.

Rogue tore off the skin with his teeth, revealing the human inside. Surrounded by muscle, a green eye widened at the sight. Inside the bloody flesh, Annie lay with eyes closed, crying. Rogue was completely still.

Petra sighed internally. Only a month ago, things were simpler, black and white, humans were good and Titans were bad . Now the giants were no longer just mindless monsters that needed to be killed, but humans with complicated pasts and reasons and emotions.

Jean felt a twinge of sympathy watching the scene and shoved it back, as if he were betraying their fallen comrades by feeling bad for

their killer.

"What happened?" Hange said.

Suddenly, there was a release of steam and bright light and Rogue jerked his head back.

Did I just let my guard down and get fooled again? Eren wanted to punch himself. If she got away from him because he had frozen again he was going to lose his head.

"Son of a bitch!"

The Scouts brought up their arms to shield themselves from the light.

Armin gasped, "Are they merging?!"

"What?!"

"Oh fuck."

"Move Eren!"

"I don't think he can!"

"This is really bad."

"The hell is she doing?"

The flesh began to melt and flow and Rogue threw his head back, screaming in pain. He noticed the crystal growing over her body.

"Wait a minute! Is she covering her entire body?!"

"Where's Hange?!"

"Are you kidding me? We'll never get her out! This whole thing would've been for nothing!"

"This is so frustrating!"

"Every single fucking time I swear..."

Erwin frowned. *Of course, she's willing to do whatever's necessary, burying her secrets and taking them too far out of our reach.* He should have expected as much. *A real soldier to the end* .

"Eren!" Mikasa reached the ground, running toward him.

"Hurry Mikasa!"

"Quick, get him out!"

Mikasa stopped, noticing Levi coming in from above, cutting Rogue's nape and releasing Eren.

"Oh thank goodness!"

"Phew! That was close!"

"Awesome Corporal!"

"Nice!"

"Even injured you're still a badass!"

He could've caught her if it hadn't been for my recklessness . Mikasa thought broodingly. And she was always chiding Eren for letting his emotions overrule his better judgment and rushing into things.

"It's not a good idea to eat our key witness. You idiot."

"So cool."

"I want him to go totally apeshit and see what that looks like," Ymir said to Christa.

"Yeah," she nodded, grinning. "He must be crazy strong."

"I wonder how many solo Titan kills he's got," Armin said.

"I don't know," Eren said. He had gotten the stats on the rest of Squad Levi from the other Scouts but none knew about Levi. *Maybe Petra knows.* He shrugged. "Mikasa killed a bunch in succession during the Battle for Trost and he's better than her." Eren paused to see her reaction but Mikasa just shrugged.

"Didn't you say that guy Oluo has 39 solo kills? Corporal Levi's gotta be double that, easily," Jean said and they nodded.

Petra overheard them and turned to the man in question. "How many solo kills do you think you have, Captain Levi?"

"I told you. Never kept count."

"I meant as estimation—"

Hange leaned forward and said, "I bet he *does* keep count but he's just trying to look cool."

Levi used one finger to move her head back. "Shut up."

Erwin cleared this throat loudly. "If we're all done?" Smiling sheepishly, they quieted down.

"I wonder if he's upset cause no one ever asks how many Titans he's killed," Sasha whispered. "Everyone only wants to know about Corporal Levi and his squad."

Connie nodded, giggling.

The two Titans were almost skeletons. There were holes in the Wall where the Female Titan's hands had punched through to

grab a hold and pull herself up. Levi, Hange, and Jean stood with other Scouts as a large amount of steam rose from the titanic bones. Nearby, several Scouts surrounded the large crystal.

Mikasa pulled Eren into a sitting position, Armin beside them. The Shifter was unconscious, red markings around his eyes.

Eren opened his eyes.

"Eren…" Mikasa leaned in.

"Mikasa?" He turned to her. "Where's Annie?"

Eyes downcast, she looked off and he followed her gaze. Armin stood before them. A few yards in front of him, Jean was taking his anger out on the large ovular-shaped crystal.

"Damn…" Jean slammed his sword over it. "What the fuck?! All the shit we've been through and this is what we get?" He continued to bring his sword down and it broke, bit by bit.

They watched in complete silence.

"Annie! Wake up! Come out and finish what you started!"

Armin, Eren, and Mikasa said nothing as they watched.

"Annie! Annie!" Jean raised his arm.

"That's enough," Levi placed a hand on his shoulder. "It's over."

Levi could imagine how frustrated the boy must feel. He would have felt the same sense of annoyance and anger and despair. After years of watching soldiers die, it turned out they may not even have been fighting the real enemy. And when they finally came close to the

answers they sought so desperately, they were out of reach once again. It was enough to make him want to punch someone or something.

Hange held up a black cable. "Someone get me a wire net! This thing belongs deep underground!"

"Roger!"

If we can't get any answers out of her, then what was the point of all this?* Hange stared the unconscious girl in her cocoon. *We caused so many deaths. And yet, despite all the lives we've lost, so many mysteries yet remain. What have we accomplished?

Hange tightened her grip on the notebook. They wouldn't have to feel that awful feeling of failure, disappointment, and loss of hope this time. *We've been losing for a century now.* They were done being kept in the dark, and ignorant. They were done being the losers. *It's our turn to win now* .

Levi walked away, heading toward Erwin who had Nile and a dozen MPs behind him. He stopped, "I don't suppose we can call this operation a success…"

"No. Though we've ensured the continued survival of the Survey Corps, if by the skin of its teeth."

"I hope so."

A group of MP soldiers stood surrounding the trio.

"Erwin…" A beautiful blue and white building appeared. "I have several questions about this operation of yours."

The commander sat at one end of a table, hands folded on the table, two MP soldiers behind him.

Will they punish him? Christa wondered. She doubted any of the cowards could understand the magnitude of Erwin's decision. They would never be able to make the tough calls necessary for all their survival.

"If the target's identity was beyond all doubt," a dark-haired man, the mayor of Stohess, sat across from the commander, "why would you neglect to request aid from the Military Police?"

"Discretion. We had reason to believe she was operating in conjunction with other insiders. I felt it was necessary to involve only those well above suspicion, sir."

"Yes. And the price of your 'discretion' was the near obliteration of Stohess. Well done."

They winced.

"Even our best efforts were not enough. You have our sincere apologies," Erwin said.

"Do you think apologies are enough?!"

"If we'd left her alone, the Walls would have been destroyed, and far more would have been destroyed."

Several heads nodded in agreement.

Absolutely no one was happy but they all knew it had to be done to avoid a bigger tragedy.

"I see. After all the deaths resulting from this operation, do you have any proof that it actually forestalled humanity's extinction?" The mayor asked and Erwin's expression

darkened. "I can't imagine Annie Leonhart will be giving us any intel now."

"No, that seems unlikely."

The MP soldiers made sounds of surprise.

"In other words…it was all for nothing?"

That must suck . Sasha felt sympathy for all those who had lost their homes. She couldn't believe there was a time she had condemned refugees. *How is the commander gonna talk himself out of this one?*

A vase with purple flowers sat, taking in the sunlight coming from the window as the curtain blew gently. "Eren…"

Eren blinked, seeing Mikasa sitting by his bedside, Jean leaning against the wall next to the window. Armin stood by her. They were in a small room with a bed, couch, and dresser, all of them in civilian clothes.

"Are you feeling better?"

"Yeah," he sat up. "It's creepy how quickly I've recovered."

Hange was curious about how far Shifters' regeneration went. Did it make them immune to disease too? *What about poison?* Drugs would be quite useful in subduing a Shifter if they worked. And if they did, how long would the effects last? Would their abilities help them recover faster? If they did decide to use it, she'd err on the side of caution and assume recovery time was twice as fast for other Shifters. *I wonder if they'll let me experiment with that* .

"I heard Annie is still stuck in that thing."

Mikasa hummed in confirmation.

How could we stop her from doing that? Erwin imagined the two Titans' flesh fusing. Did she need more body mass than her just own to create enough of the crystal to cocoon herself? Or could she do it with her own flesh and she was just trying to trap him as well? *If she needs another Titan, then we may be able to do something* . The priority was to capture her in her human state without raising her suspicion. *But if plan A fails, we'll need B, C, and D as Candy put it* .

"Damn…" Jean had his arms crossed over his chest. "We got nothing out of the entire operation."

"I can't believe how far she'd go to prevent us from getting any intel," Armin said.

"Yeah, she got away from us."

"Eren's the one who let it happen. Isn't that right, Eren?" Armin asked.

Eren braced himself for cries of outrage and various insults and accusations. He was surprised when no one said a thing.

"You hesitated for an instant…"

"Yeah," Eren's eyes fell to his lap, "you're right, Armin. I couldn't do it." He remembered her crying face. "When I saw her face, I just froze…"

"They're thinking they would have frozen too," Mikasa said when Eren glanced to check their reactions. "That's why no one said a thing."

"I see." Eren felt a little relieved.

The room fell into silence.

"Armin Arlert," a soldier stood in the doorway, holding a clipboard. "Jean Kirstein. It's your turn to be questioned."

"Yes, sir," Armin replied.

"They're starting with us?" Jean said.

"See you later, I guess," Armin said.

"Yeah…" Eren replied quietly.

The two boys left. Jean paused in the doorway, glancing at the two, head lowered and expression covered. Then he left.

Connie leaned over, whispering, "You've got no chance, buddy."

Jean glared, flipping him off.

"At the time," Eren spoke after a few seconds of quiet, "it felt kinda good…" Mikasa's eyes widened.

"Huh? What?" Christa was a little confused.

"I think he's talking about when he went berserk," Petra clarified.

"Oh, thanks."

"Even when my body was getting torn apart. I even thought I wouldn't mind dying."

Some gasped.

"Well damn," Ymir muttered.

"Eren!"

Eren gasped as if coming to his senses. Finally, he looked at her. "I don't feel like that now."

Mikasa reached out, taking his hand between hers, head lowered and hair covering her face. "I'm just glad…you came back."

Several grinning faces turned to Eren.

He blushed. "Don't you guys start again!"

They snickered.

"It's not nice to make your girlfriend worry like that," Hange, of course, had to tease him.

"How come you jerks always pick on me?" Eren complained.

"What are you talking about? We've picked on Connie and Jean too," Sasha replied.

"Why don't you say anything to Mikasa."

Everyone quickly returned their attention to the TV.

"That's what I thought. Assholes."

Jean and Armin walked together. "I can't really understand it. Abandoning your humanity to overcome monsters. Is that really the only way to win?"

"It's one possible way humanity could defeat Titans. I think Eren can do it."

"Tell me… Even if he became that monster, even if he destroyed all the Titans, would that victory really be for humanity?"

The group was quiet, asking themselves the same question.

A black feather floated past Armin. He looked up to see a pair of birds flying in the beautiful golden sky.

"Eat," Mikasa said.

Eren held a small loaf of bread, a tray of food in his lap.

The two birds flew over the Wall.

Armin finally answered, "It won't be easy to overcome…"

The commander smiled in approval at the answer.

The scene changed back to Erwin. "However, I believe we have gained a tremendous opportunity to ensure the survival of humanity."

Eren bit into the bread.

"Considering how recently it was unimaginable to us that humans could transform into Titans, the mere fact we've captured one of the enemy is a *giant* leap forward. Indeed they're out there."

Erwin's words combined with the hopeful music began to make their heartbeats pick up.

Eren continued to attack his food.

"Might wanna take it easy there," Jean said.

"Don't forget to chew," Petra giggled.

Levi snorted. "That'll be a kicker. Our best weapon bites it stuffing his face in after finally growing a pair."

"We'll track them all down."

The men, including Pastor Nick, listened without a word.

"Every last Titan within the Walls. It's our turn to attack now!"

"Hell yeah, it is!" Connie cheered.

The Wings of Freedom on the back of Erwin's jacket came into focus as he walked, flanked by two Scouts.

"The Survey Corps' recall to the capital and Eren's incarceration were rescinded."

The group began to clap and laugh.

"Custody of Annie Leonhart was also granted to the Survey Corps…"

Levi and Hange stood before the crystal, held in place by a dozen or so black wires.

Their enthusiasm dimmed slightly.

Six of the recruits were riding on horses, in civilian outfits, with a stone building and forest behind them.

"…her holding cell deep underground. Sadly, however…"

Immediately, they felt their stomachs drop.

"…much more time and sacrifice would still be required before humanity learned…"

It showed Connie, then Reiner and Bert, then Ymir and Christa.

"…what it was that truly held them captive…"

Sasha looked somewhere off behind her.

Mikasa quietly took the tray away while Eren slept and the camera stopped on his key before finally fading away.

"Wow, just...wow," Hange said.

Before they could react further, white letters appeared on the black screen.

"Hello, my loves, before we get to the final scene, I have something to say," Candy said. "You have now finished the main episodes. If you remember, I mentioned at the end of episode 10 you will be hearing an important message after the end of the main episodes."

They leaned forward, listening intently.

"Going forward, you have two options. Option A: After you leave here, you can use the knowledge to change the future and make sure everything goes your way."

They knew it was possible, still, listening to Candy confirm they could change the future uplifted their spirits.

"Option B: You will be invited back in two days' time and if you choose to return, you can keep watching more future episodes —shall we call it season 2?"

Their jaws dropped.

"More future episodes?!" Connie squealed excitedly.

"Of course, the future you will be watching will be the original timeline."

Meaning if we make too big changes, the future episodes won't be of as much help . Armin's mind raced. They'd get a lot of information but the events could be completely different. Some may not even come to pass.

Erwin frowned, thinking. *We'll need to make changes that benefit us but also keep the things close enough to the 'original timeline' as Candy put it so we can keep watching and use the future knowledge to the fullest advantage* .

"You have some time before you have to come to a decision. That is all. When you are ready, hit 'Okay' to see the final scene. Enjoy!"

"If we come back and keep watching, we'll not only know how the expedition will turn out and control the outcome but even further than that *before* we even take a step outside the Walls," Eren said in amazement.

"Remember, we still need to be careful," Mikasa warned. "Of being too complacent out there."

Armin nodded, "And we can't alter the future too much."

Hange held up her notebook. "After we watch the next set of future episodes—season 2—we can see which events had a significant impact and make sure to follow the original timeline to make those happen."

Petra's brow furrowed in worry, "Does that mean I and the rest of the squad will have to sit out the rest of it? Since we didn't make it in the original timeline."

"Maybe," Mikasa said. "I imagine your presence—"

"We have time to discuss that later," Erwin interrupted, "after we leave. For now let's take a minute or two to stretch and use the facilities. Then we'll finish the final scene and move to the next episode." Not that they would really need to think about it too much. He had a feeling everyone's vote would be the same regarding season 2: *Yes* .

"Where do you think we were while this happened?" Christa asked.

"If Eren, Mikasa, and Hange and the rest the veterans couldn't take her out, I doubt we could," Sasha shrugged. "No point in have the entire Corps decimated at once."

"Yeah," Christa said, "none of us were in uniform."

"We're probably on standby or something," Ymir agreed a little distractedly. She excused herself to the bathroom. She wasn't really sure how to bring up her Titan-Shifter status. She couldn't exactly jump up and yell: *Guess what? I'm a Titan-Shifter too! Surprise!* She had to be careful about it—her secret gave her a major advantage. Even if their reactions were going to be pretty funny if she blurted it out of nowhere.

There's no reason for them to doubt Eren's devotion to the cause . But she had made no effort to hide the fact her allegiance was to herself and Christa. Ymir did not want to end up strapped to a table with Hange poking and prodding to her heart's content. She'd have to bring it up delicately. *I need to gather my thoughts and have a good explanation ready first.* Then, when the opportunity presented itself, she would tell them.

"It'll be nice to have a two-day break." Connie stretched his neck. "What do you think the extra episodes are gonna be about?"

"She mentioned something about getting to know each other," Jean answered, trying to remember what Candy had said. "More of our trainee days maybe?"

"I really hope not," Levi grumbled. He did not want to sit through two-and-a-half hours of idiotic teenage romance drama. *Anything but that* .

"Let's watch the final scene," Erwin said when everyone was done. He pointed the remote at the TV and hit *Okay* .

The black screen lightened to reveal Stohess, covered by shadows. The sun was setting, leaving the sky dark with some golden-orange light in the distance. The camera moved toward the Wall.

The group was immensely curious.

Cracks in the Wall caused by the Female Titan came into focus.

Armin wondered if it was some sort of symbolism. *That the Wall will —*

The pieces fell, revealing the eye and part of the mouth of a Colossal Titan.

Erwin was stunned speechless, jaw falling open.

And the room exploded.

Everyone began yelling, their voice jumbling together.

"What the fuck is *that* ?!" Levi's eyes grew wide.

"A TITAN!" Hange screamed, "There's a TITAN inside the *Wall* !"

"Holy shit!" Connie grabbed his head. "Holy fucking shit! Holy *motherfucking* shit!"

Christa gasped, "Are you guys *seeing* this?!"

Ymir nodded, too shocked to speak.

Mikasa was dumbstruck, unable to think. "Where did it come from?"

"It must be...a colossal-type," Armin answered, completely gobsmacked.

"But inside the *Wall* ?" Petra gaped. "How long has it been there?!"

"And how the hell did it get there in the first place?" Hange asked.

Sasha gasped, "Do you think there are more?!"

The group stopped and imagined that: the three Walls, made entirely out of colossal-type Titans standing together. It was mind blowing.

"No fucking way," Jean said, dazed. "Does that mean...we've been protected by Titans this entire time?"

Mouths hanging open, looking baffled, they glanced at each other for an explanation.

"What the fuck is going on?" Eren demanded in anger and confusion.

"We need to keep watching!" Erwin finally snapped out of his stupor.

Everyone immediately shut up, ready for an episode.

"But all the future episodes are done."

"Fuck!"

"Dammit!"

"Are we seriously ending it here?!"

"This is so sadistic of Candy!"

"What a cock block!"

"NOOOOOOO!" Hange cried out dramatically. "But I want to *know* !"

"And we will. We'll finish the extra episodes and come back for season 2," Erwin declared.

Power to Strive is staying a reaction fic. Maybe after this story is finished I'll write a spin-off with the Scouts using their future knowledge (doubtful). But I don't want to get sidetracked.

Please Review~

Episode - No Regrets Part I

Chapter 26: No Regrets Part I

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The group is shocked by the Titan in the Wall. Some begin to think more about their situation and better understand Annie's. They decide they will definitely come back for season 2.

The group took a minute after Erwin's declaration to take deep breaths and calm themselves. They doubted they'd need to pay as much attention to the extra episodes but it was still intriguing and they didn't want to miss out on anything.

" Hey, quick message. You will be watching the extra episodes focusing on some of the other people in the room. You have the option to skip but these first two episodes will be un-skippable because fair's fair."

"What does that mean?" Sasha wondered.

Christa's heart lurched. She really hoped it wasn't what she was thinking. *I'm not that important* . There hadn't really been much screen time with her as there had been with the rest of the 104th crew. Surely the TV wouldn't play out her past. A feeling of dread began welling up. She really didn't want to relive that and she especially didn't want it revealed to everyone else.

"The last time Candy declared an episode un-skippable it was..." Armin trailed off, looking at Mikasa, her face closed-off at the reminder.

"And it was fucking unnecessary," Eren glared accusingly at the TV.

"We could be watching someone's personal life experience again," Petra agreed.

Suddenly, everyone paled thinking about their worst or most humiliating memories and hoped fervently Candy wouldn't show them to everyone.

Soft, easygoing music played as the shot opened to a blue sky. A bird flew by over a beautiful city, losing a white feather which floated gently down toward the ground.

"That's Sina," Hange observed curiously. "Mitras, if I'm not mistaken."

The feather landed on a small gutter drain on the side of the street.

The commander glanced at Levi and noted the somewhat uneasy expression on the short man's face.

It slipped through the space between the bars and continued to float down. This time it came down from the dark and brown rocky ceiling instead of the light-filled and blue beautiful sky, to the city below .

Levi's breath caught up in his throat.

"Is that the Underground city?" Armin leaned forward in interest.

"I've heard of that place," Jean said. "The city below the capital. It's the safest place from the Titans, behind the three—two—Walls and under the ground. But most of it is also overrun with criminals and vagrants. The cesspool of Mitras." A thought occurred to him. *Come to think of it, isn't Corporal Levi from there?*

Christa shuddered. "Living barely seeing the sun, that's awful." While she may not have had the ideal childhood, at least there was always

food on the table and the warm sun on her skin and the fresh, clean air to breathe. She was immensely happy the episode wouldn't be focused on her.

Levi's not gonna be happy about this . Erwin thought. Candy must've known he'd try to skip and made it impossible beforehand, taking the option away from them. *I can see why she would* . Levi was a private person, but they'd watched so many of the others' deep, personal thoughts and experiences.

He'll be forced to relive his loss just as the others have. Hange grimaced, having the same train of thought as the commander.

Petra was tempted to look at her captain to gauge his reaction. But she refrained, knowing having someone stare, regardless of the expression, would only piss him off. A sweep around the room confirmed some had a clue as to whose life they would be watching.

It's only fair we can't skip Captain Levi's tragedy when we couldn't skip Mikasa's. Eren thought. He still felt some irritation, remembering episode 6. He was intimidated by the man and held a great deal of respect for him but when it came to Armin and Mikasa, he wouldn't care if it was Humanity's Strongest or not, he would not stand for anyone hurting his family. *It's gonna suck though* . He swallowed with difficulty, thinking back to watching his mother die again.

Three pairs of feet clambered by, grabbing the attention of a middle-aged man, "Huh…?"

His face was a blank canvas but Levi's insides were churning, leaving him feeling sick to this stomach. A part of him badly wanted to see his friends again but the idea of seeing them die and experiencing that pain again was horrifying.

Wires shot above their heads and three figures flew by, the last one knocking over boxes of merchandise. The men on the ground ducked as apples and packets of food spilled

everywhere. A young man reached down to grab one of the packets and took off running.

Levi's heart hammered at the familiar scene, the memory playing out in his head, losing the last shred of hope he had that the episodes weren't going to focus on him.

" Hey, hold it!" The merchant yelled as the man ran away.

" Bastard!"

" They had us! It's those pests again!" The merchant yelled.

" There they are," another man pointed. "Someone call the Military Police!"

Levi, Farlan, and Isabel flew away. "Yahoo!" Isabel grinned.

"They're pretty good," Connie said. "For a bunch of thieves."

Farlan ran before taking off, following after the leader.

Which turned out to be a familiar face to the viewers.

Several people gasped, eyes going wide.

Connie shrank. "Uh..."

They began whispering.

"Is that Corporal Levi?"

"We're watching his past?"

"Oh, he's gonna be pissed..."

"I'm just glad it's not me."

"Yeah, me too."

No one dared to say it out loud but everyone—aside from Erwin—was very curious to learn more about the origins of the famous Humanity's Strongest Soldier.

The three flew through the air with ease. Farlan looked over his shoulder, "Levi! They're here! The pursuers!"

Levi looked over his shoulder to see the multiple figures in military uniform chasing after them.

" Heh," Isabel smirked. "The Military Police again? Haven't learned their lesson, have they?" She turned forward. "Hey, Levi! What I said was a cool line, wasn't it, big bro?"

They must be close if she's referring to him as her brother . Petra thought.

It was so familiar. His self-proclaimed sister's smile and her tendency to seek his approval. It was so strange. Nice but also strangely unsettling watching someone who had died.

" Are you an idiot?" Was Levi's response.

" Yeah," Farlan said, "they haven't yet and are still sending those elite soldiers."

" Those merchants must have alerted them," Levi said.

" Most likely." Farlan smiled. "Last time, we got quite a bit of a *donation* from their safe."

Mikasa watched with arms crossed. Levi had been the worst when the scene her past was revealed had come up. At least Erwin and Hange believed it was important to their cause, feeling sympathetic for her, and Petra had tried to figure out a compromise. He had been the least sensitive, not showing any compassion.

Now he'll really understand what it feels like . To have his most tightly guarded memory, a moment in his life that helped define him, when

he was most vulnerable, it was only fair he experience what it was like for that to be revealed to everyone without permission.

A part of her felt guilty and horrible about it. The more she thought about it the more it grew and she stubbornly pushed it back. *But it wasn't my decision* . She had no control over the situation. Still, she had a feeling she wouldn't be enjoying it as much as she thought she would.

" We saved them from getting any fatter and further ruining their health," Isabel said. "They should be grateful."

Levi was quiet for a few seconds. "Farlan, Isabel, let's go!"

" The Underground district," Candy narrated. "It's located under the safest land, that is being protected by the three Walls."

"So this is before Wall Maria fell," Armin said.

"Levi joined in 844, the year before the breach," Hange said.

That's only six years . Eren had thought for sure Levi had been part of the Survey Corps for a decade easily.

The Underground city appeared with its rocky ceiling sky.

" An abandoned underground. Left over from the sealed Immigration Plan."

Four children sat against a dirty wall in the desolate city, bleak expressions on their faces.

What a truly awful place to live . Christa thought. Deep inside though, Historia didn't care too much. It almost felt good to know she had it better than many others. Christa shook her head to get rid of the thoughts. *Everyone deserves to feel the sun's warmth and smell the clean air!* Especially children.

" In this land cast aside from the light, it is not rare to find those who are born and raised here to rot away without even having seen the surface once."

The bird flew off the statue of a headless angel missing one wing.

That's so sad . Sasha couldn't imagine living in such a place. It made her feel suffocated just thinking about it. When she thought of home, images of trees, the sky, the sun, the forest, and the animal life came to mind. *No wonder Corporal Levi never smiles. He hasn't had much reason to until only recently* . Up until six years ago, he'd lived down in that hellhole. *If it were me I'd take every chance I got to smile and laugh* .

A whistle echoed through the worn and dirty brown buildings. A dark-haired boy sat limply against a wall while another one smoked on a roof. A building with red roof tiles appeared. Inside, Farlan divided up the cash in his hands, "Here, sorry for the wait." He handed it to the three young men sitting on the couch and they cheered. "Payment for both last time and this time."

Levi sat nearby at a roundtable, cleaning his knife with a white cloth.

" Here," Farlan handed a share to a downcast young man sitting by himself.

" Ah, thank yo—" Jan noticed the extra money rolled in half to hide it.

He was always kinder than he let on . Levi thought. Nervousness bubbled in him, thinking about Farlan and Isabel's deaths. What if the TV showed their deaths really were his fault. He shook the

thought out of his head. *No, the Titans killed them* . He thought about Eren's mother's last moments, crying for them not to leave her. What if it showed him something similar, something heartbreaking. He didn't know how he'd handle it.

Farlan glanced at the other three, "You guys better not spend too much even if it's a mistake. We're being observed."

" We already know. Let's go guys."

" Yeah!"

Levi continued to clean his knife as the sounds of the door opening and footsteps leaving was heard. Jan was the last to leave, pausing once before leaving.

" Jobs have been a lot easier since we got our hands on the 3D Maneuver Gear. Everyone's shares has increased too."

Levi inspected his weapon, "It seems one has increased more than the others."

The recruits exchanged looks, wondering how he was going to react.

" What's the reason?"

Farlan looked down, "His…Jan's leg has gotten worse again… You've noticed, right? Medicine is really expensive. The price went up too. Seriously, these damn Underground merchants." He glanced over at his friend. "Have you heard? The Stairway Toll also went up."

" Yeah…"

Stairway Toll? What's that? Jean was tempted to ask but thought better of it. Levi was probably upset and he was not going to risk making himself a target since Candy was not an option.

" With that, it's even less likely for the poor to ever see the sunlight," Farlan said.

Pay to see sunlight? That's fucked up . Eren frowned. Not that he was entirely shocked to learn of such a thing. In some aspects, he knew humans were worse than Titans.

***" We have to buy our way up no matter where we go."* Farlan's voice narrated.**

A man handed money to some men who were guarding the base of a large set of stairs going up, all of them wearing the same expression of hopelessness.

" Even if you manage to pay and get outside, without citizenship you can't stay for long."

Two boys sat in an alley, wearing blank expressions.

Petra's heart was full of sorrow at the depressing situation. It was no way to live. A life without purpose. *They're not living* . They were barely even surviving. *They're just...there* . It was heartbreaking.

" Apparently the lack of sunlight causes people's legs to go bad."

A man with lifeless eyes sat, leg out before him with a crutch leaned against the wall next to him, as people continued to walk by.

" It's not like knowing it will change anything though."

This is just depressing. Ymir thought. It left her unsettled, bringing up old, painful memories of living not too different on the streets of Marley. She didn't even have a name until that man had found her and given her an identity. She had worn it proudly, even until they had injected her and shoved her off the wall to let her roam as a mindless beast. She glanced at the other viewers. For years, she

had vowed to live only for herself and had kept silent about Marley and Eldia, refusing to be used again and getting dragged in the middle of their conflict.

" Your mother's was the same, wasn't it?" Levi asked, not looking up. Farlan didn't answer. "So…that's why. Even so it still looks like a large sum."

" It's compensation. It…might already be too late. At the very least, I hope he finds a good hospital."

" I see."

Isabel should be barging in soon . Levi couldn't rip his eyes away from the TV. He never thought he'd see his friends again. And he would get to watch them die again. And so would everyone else in the room. It made him angry and sad but he was powerless to do anything about it. He glanced at Mikasa, Eren, and Armin, now truly understanding how uncomfortable it was having your life put on display for everyone.

Farlan looked at the money in his hands. "How much more do we need…to be able to live up there?"

There was a noise outside. "Hm?" Levi stood up and started walking over. He stopped when someone or something hit their door. He exchanged a glance with Farlan.

Knife in hand, Farlan wrapped his hand around the doorknob and looked at Levi, who nodded, switchblade ready. He threw the door open and Isabel fell in with a surprised yelp, arms wrapped around her waist, landing at Levi's feet.

"I was wondering where she was," Hange muttered.

"I think this is when they first met," Erwin guessed.

" What? It's just a kid," Farlan walked over. "That surprised me."

" Not…a kid…" Isabel breathed loudly. "I'm not…a kid!" She glared at them.

" Is that so?" Levi said. "I won't feel bad for kicking you out then. I'll let the fact that you dirtied the floor slide."

Some of them couldn't help but snort.

" Get out now."

" What? You can't even move?" Farlan asked.

" Of course I can!" Isabel replied aggressively.

Armin noted the mark on her cheek, "She looks hurt."

" Don't look down on me." With one hand, Isabel began struggling to stand up. A little bird was revealed in her left hand.

" What a strong-willed kid," Farlan said.

" Over here!" A man's voice came from outside.

Isabel's eyes widened. Still struggling to sit up, holding the bird close to her chest, she lost her balance and tilted to the side, back hitting the door.

" Hm, bastard," Levi said, **"you're being chased?"**

Farlan looked at him and asked, "What should we do?"

Outside, three men came to a stop outside their house. "Shit! That brat…she really bit me," he looked at his hand.

"Why do I have a feeling he deserved it," Christa said.

"He probably did," Sasha said.

" When she's caught, I'll be the first to have fun with her."

The viewers exchanged disgusted looks.

"Filthy beasts," Eren muttered darkly.

Mikasa glared at the TV, fists trembling. She wished so badly men like that would come after her now. But she knew they wouldn't. *They always pick on the small and the weak. The vulnerable* . They'd never go for someone who could and would fight back.

"I hope you guys beat the shit out of them, Corporal." Sasha's words were met with nods.

Levi and Farlan stood leaning in the door, watching them.

" There's no fun or anything on a brat like that," another voice said.

The boss chuckled, grinning.

Petra looked revolted. *He actually likes that she's not a grown woman!*

The anger and disgust grew on their faces.

The man noticed Levi and Farlan, "Hey, there's a dirty little kid over here, right?"

" Those are the only kinds around," Farlan replied.

They chuckled at his words.

" Huh? You guys are the thugs in this area?" He stopped at the base of the stairs.

" Which of us are?" Farlan muttered.

He noticed Isabel sitting against the door. "Hey… I've found her."

" I thought as much." One of his lackeys said. "Are you guys friends?"

" Not at all," Farlan said.

Eren clenched his fists, glaring. It's not what he would have said.

Mikasa scowled at the TV. They were going to help her, weren't they? Else her fist was going to fly right into Levi's face, consequences be damned. She took a deep breath. *Of course they're going to help. They become friends later* .

" Then hand her over to us," the second lackey said. "You'll be sorry if you cover for her. After all, she tried to get past the 11th Stairway without paying."

That grabbed Levi and Farlan's attention.

" You guys should know, the 11th stairway is under the jurisdiction of one of the nobles, Lord Lobov. Anyone who tries to pass there without paying is prosecuted."

Isabel sat, head bowed, as one of the lackeys spoke up, "Of course you guys will be charged too for being her accomplices." Her head snapped up in surprise at his words.

" I don't care anymore. Move away from her!" The boss said, walking up to them. He placed his hand on Levi's shoulder as he stepped through the doorway.

Quickly, without so much as blinking, Levi brought up his arm and sliced the man's hand. Blood coated Levi's knife and the pervert stumbled back in surprise and pain, holding his bleeding hand, red covering his pinkie.

"That was cool!"

"Served that creep right!"

"You go, Corporal!"

They cheered him on, grinning.

He looked up and his eyes widened when Levi went straight for him.

The sounds of a beating, fist meeting flesh and sounds of pain, was heard as Isabel watched, gaping, while Farlan's face remained uninterested.

The group continued to smile, nodding in satisfaction.

It definitely helped improve his standing in Mikasa's eyes.

Levi grabbed the man's collar, glaring down at him. "Don't touch me with your filthy hand. I might get dirty." He shoved the man back down the stairs and into his lackeys who barely caught him.

They couldn't help but laugh. And Mikasa had to roll her eyes.

"Oh, Captain," Petra giggled.

He's so fucking cool. Eren thought in awe.

"He doesn't it even try," Ymir said.

I wish I could do that . Jean thought, admiration all over his face.

" You can't do it like that," Farlan began, smiling, as Levi cleaned his knife. "We always prioritize hygiene. Wash your hands and come again."

They burst out laughing.

"I like him," Christa smiled.

Sasha nodded, "He's funny."

" These guys are dangerous. Let's go!"

The lackeys left, carrying their boss.

Isabel stared at Levi, awestruck. He turned to her, "Hey, how long are you going to hold it to your stomach?" His words broke her out of her stupor. "It'll die, you know."

" B-But…I thought it'd be warm." Isabel held up the cloth with the little bird looking around.

" What's with the bird?" Farlan asked.

" It got lost on its way here. Probably through some duct. So I thought I'll bring it up to the surface."

Farlan appeared surprised by her answer. "Don't tell me you tried to break through the Stairway just for that?"

She probably won't survive . Neither will he. Ymir had a feeling everyone at least suspected it but no one wanted to voice it.

" This guy would want to fly in the sky instead of being here underground," Isabel stroked the bird's back gently.

" Well, that's fine, but," Farlan knelt by her, "its wing is injured, you know."

" Really?!"

Farlan sat on the long gray couch and finished bandaging the bird's wings. Isabel leaned forward in her seat, smiling, "You're really good, you know. That's right, what's your name? I'm Isabel."

" I'm Farlan…and that's Levi."

" Farlan… and…" Isabel looked over to where Levi sat on a chair. "Levi, big brother."

" Big brother?"

" Listen! Please…let me become one of you!"

" What?" Farlan looked at her.

" You guys have been using 3D Maneuver Gear, right? I've seen it before!" Isabel recalled standing in the street and watching them fly above her. "I felt really envious. You guys flying around like birds. Please, I want to try it too!"

" What do you think?" Farlan asked Levi.

He stood and started walking to the door.

" Please!"

" If you stay here, learn how to clean before you learn 3D Maneuver Gear."

They snorted.

No surprise there . Eren glanced at his right. "When he first assembled the squad, did he make you guys clean too?"

"Yes," Petra chuckled. "You can imagine how shocked we were."

"All too well."

" Huh?" Isabel turned to see him leave. "Huh?" She turned to Farlan for an answer and he smiled, nodding. "Thanks, big brother!"

Levi walked down the stairs, passing by some young people who were hanging out there.

The scene closed with a young man playing the guitar.

A montage of Isabel learning to use the 3D gear appeared: excited to try it on for the first time and hanging upside down in the next one with Farlan and Levi standing by with arms crossed.

"Look familiar, Eren?"

"Shut up, Connie."

Isabel held the fully healed bird happily and Levi threw open a window, white cloths covering his head and most of his face. The three stood around, holding brooms. Isabel did not appear too pleased, the bird hanging out on her head.

The group giggled at that.

Isabel tore into her bread as the three sat outside. She coughed and beat her chest before offering the loaf to Levi. He pushed her face back, ruffling her hair.

Levi felt his heart fill with joy at the good times and pain from the loss. Knowing what was going to happen, the wait, was the worst. But he also didn't want to reach that scene either.

They're going to die. Mikasa recognized the look on his face. She could not bring herself to feel any satisfaction knowing he would go through the same thing she and Eren had gone through. Being forced to live through her tragedy, knowing what was going to happen, she may have wished it on him in the heat of the moment when they were watching her story but she didn't know. *It's just cruel.*

Isabel flew, a little awkward, over the cheering group of men with Levi and Farlan following. She held out her arms, eyes

closed, a smile on her face. The three stood below a massive hole in the ceiling through which sunlight shone down. Isabel released the bird. A white feather floated down and landed gently in a dirty puddle.

The trio was walking toward their home when they stopped, noticing a tall, well-dressed man checking his pocket watch. He put it away and saw them. "What's the deal, old man?" Isabel asked. "You want something?"

" I've come for a job request."

Disappointment and dread filled Levi's stomach. *Already?* He was hoping to have more time with his friends.

" Didn't you get the wrong house? This is not a handyman shop," Farlan said.

" I promise you a reward."

Levi replied immediately, "Go home!" Though a little taken back, Isabel and Farlan followed him without a word.

" I've already paid the deposit though."

That grabbed their attention.

Jean had a bad feeling about it. He recalled how emotionless Levi had been, discovering his dead squad. The expedition, the threat of the Female Titan, had forced him to damper his emotions and prioritize recovering their biggest asset over avenging his team. How he was going to react after his friends died when he hadn't dealt with death on a monthly basis, he found himself curious to know. *This is from six years ago* . He wondered if within a few years, he too would become apathetic after all the death.

" You're kidding, right?" Farlan said. "This is the first time we've seen you."

" That's true. But you should already know…" The man turned his head to look at a red and yellow carriage across the street. "…about him." A man brought Jan to the carriage where the other man waited.

" Jan!" Farlan called out.

" His leg is already at its limit. He needs to get treatment at a hospital on the surface… Isn't that right, Levi?"

" What's the meaning of this?" Farlan demanded.

Ymir's eyes narrowed, "I smell trouble."

"Maybe it's good," Connie offered optimistically. They looked at him skeptically. "...Yeah I didn't really think so."

"After all..." Armin trailed not, glancing at Levi. *Isabel and Farlan. Petra never mentioned them when she was telling Eren about Corporal Levi's past* . He hadn't said a word about them either. And from the expressions Levi had been sporting, a mix of astonishment, joy, and sorrow, it wasn't difficult to guess the two had passed away.

Petra was having similar thoughts. *Not to mention, Candy said fair's fair* . Which meant since they weren't allowed to skip parts of the episode with Mikasa's history, they couldn't with Levi's. And likely it was for the same reason. *Poor Levi. He just saw us die and now he has to watch his friends die again* .

" I told you, didn't I? It's a deposit for the job. You'll listen to the details now, right?"

" Fine, then," Levi said.

The two men in hats carried Jan into the carriage.

The gray-haired man led them up the 11th Stairway in silence. Light poured onto the platform before them as they neared the exit. Hands up, they shielded their eyes for a few seconds. A carriage waited at the top of the stairs a few yards before them. "Are these the guys?" A deep, masculine voice asked.

" Yes, I've heard they're excellent."

Inside the red carriage with a golden lion figure on the side, a hidden man with a small mustache sat.

" Who the hell are you?" Levi asked.

" It's understandable that you're wary of me. But you'll learn it's okay to trust me."

Farlan scoffed, "How could we?"

" The fact that I'm here says everything. I'm at great risk just by being here. Have you received the deposit already?"

" I don't know how things work on top, but in our world it's called taking a hostage."

" That's just a contingency plan we laid in place. When you have successfully completed the job, you won't only be getting a large sum of money… But also, citizenship on the surface."

Isabel and Farlan gasped.

"Is that how they reach the surface and become part of the Corp?" Christa wondered.

"I don't know but I'm not sure about this guy," Eren said.

"Do you ever regret accepting the offer, Levi?" Hange asked him.

"At the time, we were convinced we'd regret not taking the chance."

"Do you now?" Erwin asked but received no reply.

The three checked their gear and a man left, pulling on his coat.

" Levi, everything's ready," Farlan said.

They walked through the street.

" We got confirmation on Jan. He's in a first-rate hospital. The identity of that man is also confirmed. This job is the real thing!" Farlan said.

" We gonna do it, Levi?"

Levi was scowling.

A flashback to their meeting with the nobleman appeared.

" I'll tell you one thing…"

Levi and the others stopped.

Regardless of whether you accept this job or not, the target will still make contact. In other words, you can't remain unrelated in this matter."

" Big brother…" Isabel said as they walked through the streets.

" Carry on as normal. But if, they appear just like he said they would… We'll start the job."

A cute black dog appeared on the screen. "Come here," a man said and the dog looked over. He crouched, "Here… Huh?"

They giggled when the dog turned and walked away instead.

Was it a part of the plan? Hange mused. Send in a cute dog to distract one or two persons, moving them away from the cart and making it easier for the ground crew to snatch the goods and flee.

" What the hell are you doing?" A man demanded, standing next to a cart loaded with crates.

" I'm sorry," he said sheepishly.

"I see," Petra said. "Now we're at the point where the episode began."

What's this job they're supposed to do? Jean thought.

They leaned forward, curious to see where it would go.

Three pairs of feet ran. They flew over the cart and knocked the cargo to the ground. Apples and packets of food fell out. A young man snatched some up and ran off.

" Hey, hold it!"

" Bastard!"

" They had us! It's those pests again!" The merchant yelled.

" There they are," another man pointed. "Some call the Military Police!"

Levi, Farlan, and Isabel flew away. "Yahoo!" Isabel yelled.

Farlan looked over his shoulder, "Levi! They're here! The pursuers!"

Levi looked over his shoulder to see the multiple figures in military uniform chasing after them. Behind the MP soldiers that were following them were four cloaked figures.

Petra gaped, "I bet they're Scouts!"

" Heh," Isabel smirked. "The Military Police again? Haven't learned their lesson, have they?" She turned forward. "Hey, Levi! What I said was a cool line, wasn't it, big bro?"

" Are you an idiot?"

The group laughed at the bummed out look on Isabel's face.

If they are Scouts, can they beat them? Eren wanted to know how good they were even before they'd had formal training. *If Captain Levi trained them they must be really good* .

Levi executed a maneuver and turned a corner and the Military Policemen fumbled midair to keep up.

They rolled their eyes.

The cloaked figures followed them with ease. Levi's fingers moved in quick, precise movements.

"Whoa!'"

The hooks shot into the walls on either side of him and Levi stopped and drew back as two figures flew past him.

"That is so fucking cool!"

Levi flipped back and flew away, joining his friends.

" Those movements…" Farlan looked behind him. "They're not the Military Police!"

" Yeah… No mistake," Levi said. "It's them. The Wings of Freedom crest…" He recalled Erwin turned to look at him, his face mostly hidden by the hood. "The Survey Corps!"

"Commander Erwin!"

"You're the target," Armin said.

The four Scouts came after the trio.

"What? Really!"

"Shh!"

" Heh," Farlan smirked. "As people who battle the Titans, they're as different as expected."

" You guys… You know, right?" Levi said.

" Of course," Isabel replied confidently.

" It's the job, right?" Farlan said. Then he and Isabel split off.

Two Scouts chased after them and the other two followed Levi.

Faces eager, they glued their eyes to the TV, wondering if he what amazing maneuver he could perform in a city.

Now then, let me see how good… **Levi began his evasion.** ***…the Survey Corps really is!*** **He flew close to the ground before moving up and over a railing, through a crawl space, running in the dark path, and jumping out of a hole in the wall.**

"That's so fucking crazy!" Eren yelled.

"Yes." Mikasa couldn't keep the impressed look off her face.

Jean gaped. "How did you do that?!"

"Maybe he's not really human," Armin said jokingly.

"He's got his own level of badass," Sasha declared.

"Can't argue with that," Ymir agreed.

"He's so amazing," Christa gushed.

Connie had stars in his eyes. "He's totally my hero!"

Petra turned to Levi, "Looks like you're going to have some very devoted fans after this."

Levi snorted.

"Just you wait," Hange winked at Petra.

Erwin thought back to their first expedition, smiling in amusement, as he resumed the episode. *They haven't seen nothing yet* .

Levi jumped out the building's window. Erwin ran out of an alley before him, surprising him, and he quickly shot up and over the building across from him. He glanced back to see Erwin land on the roof of the building he came out of before looking forward, flying under the cover of a wooden structure.

Suddenly, it collapsed over him as Mike attacked.

"Did he get him?!"

"No way!"

Mike forced Levi in a downward arch and sent him into a cart stacked high with empty crates. He skidded on his feet as the fallen crates broke around him.

Levi slid on his back. He brought his hands up, springing himself and flipping back to his feet. Hand shooting behind his

back, he flicked out his knife, grabbing it as it spun and swiping at Mike.

A few people actually squealed.

Mike snapped his head back to dodge, making a surprised sound when the next attack sent his sword flying.

"Did he just disarm him with a *knife* ?!"

"Shush!"

Mike brought up his other sword and Levi gripped the knife with both hands, charging. Erwin came down from above, blocking him. He pushed Levi back and went right for him, holding his sword to the short man's face. Levi's scowl deepened in determination as he grunted.

" Stop it. Take a look around you."

Levi's eyes darted to the side, seeing a male and female Scout escorting a subdued Farlan and a struggling Isabel.

" Let me go…you bastard!" Isabel cursed. "Damn it all!"

" Levi!" Farlan yelled.

Levi shifted his gaze back and slow released the grip on his knife, letting it fall to the ground. He and Erwin stepped back. "You're quick at reading the situation."

Levi glared at him.

"This was all just part of the plan, though, right?" Armin said.

"Probably. No way would he have been able to defeat Corporal Levi otherwise," Connie boasted.

Sasha elbowed him, "Er, no offense, Commander."

Erwin didn't reply.

Jean snickered, "I think he took offense."

Probably it was part of the plan, getting captured. Mikasa found it a little suspicious how quickly the fight was over. Fighting and then pretending to lose, no it was much easier to let it play out this way, fighting but not losing and only giving in because his friends were captured.

Mike placed the black handcuffs on Levi and stepped back. Isabel and Farlan were on their knees to Levi's right. Erwin stood before them. "I'll ask a few questions." He held up the handle of his 3D gear. "Where did you get this?"

None of them said a word.

" You guys are skilled with 3D Maneuver Gear. Who taught you all that?"

Again, the three kept silent.

Erwin walked toward Levi, "You're the leader, right?" Levi didn't say a word, head bowed, hair covering his face. "Were you trained in the military?"

Levi glared at him. Mike grabbed the back of his head, bring him and slamming his face down into a dirty puddle.

Farlan and Isabel gasped and she said, "Bastard!"

"Jeez," Petra muttered. Next to her, she noticed Levi was less than pleased at having his face shoved into the disgusting, black water. *He probably scrubbed it three times the first chance he got.*

" I'll ask one more time. Where did you learn to use the 3D Maneuver Gear?" Erwin asked.

" Not from anyone!" Farlan finally spoke. "We learnt it by ourselves!"

"Really?"

"Shouldn't be surprised really at this point."

" Self-taught, you say? I don't buy it."

" It's just so we're able to rise even a bit in this dirty garbage place! People like you guys who're used to sunlight won't understand."

Farlan's words gave them pause. They had never really thought about how much we take the sun for granted.

To these people, it's a privilege . Armin agreed with Eren that they were trapped in the Walls. *But for the people living in the Underground, we're living the good life* . *Free* . It put things into perspective.

When you think about it, we've had it pretty good . Eren had never really thought about.

" That's enough! Let big brother go! Don't be cocky just because you're soldiers!"

Erwin's eyes moved away from them. Levi glared furiously, one side of his face in the dirty water. Mike pulled him up. Water dripped from his face.

Levi felt the urge to wipe his face.

Erwin knelt in the puddle, "My name is Erwin Smith. And yours is?"

Ymir caught it immediately. They thought the commander was looking down on them. *But he knelt, in the same dirty puddle, reaching their level and talking to them as equals* . Did he really

mean to state he didn't think he was above them or was he just being clever?

" Levi."

" Levi," Erwin said. "Why don't we make a deal?"

" A deal?"

" I will let your crimes go unpunished. In return, lend me your strength. Join the Survey Corps."

"How could you get their crimes dismissed?" Armin asked the commander.

"They weren't dismissed per se. The MP were happy to make Levi and his friends the Corps' problem. Worst crime they committed was stealing."

Levi didn't bother correcting him on the last part. It might be the worst his friends did. Not him.

"I really doubt they could have caught the three themselves," Hange said. "The Military Police was probably happy to let the Corps catch them and deal with them. Levi and his friends couldn't cause trouble anymore so as far as they were concerned, the headache was taken care of and they could close the case."

"So joining the Survey Corps was punishment?" Petra asked.

"I can see them looking at it that way, yes," Erwin said.

"They probably assumed the high mortality rate would take care of it," Ymir said.

Levi and the others looked somewhat surprised. "And if I refuse?'

" The Military Police will have you. Considering your crimes, you and your friends," Erwin stood and walked away, "won't be treated nicely." He stopped and turned to them. "Choose whichever you prefer."

" Fine." Levi spat, shaking the water from his hair, and glared furiously. "I'll join the Survey Corps."

The scene closed with the two of them staring each other down.

I'd probably change my offer. Worried he might kill me in my sleep . Connie thought.

"There's one more part, right?" Eren said.

"Yeah," Petra nodded.

They were all looking forward to seeing Humanity's Strongest Soldier on his first expedition.

Everyone except Levi who was bracing himself.

Please Review~

Episode - No Regrets Part II

Chapter 27: No Regrets Part II

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The group begins watching Levi's past. It puts some things into perspective for the recruits. Their hero worship for him grows. Mikasa feels sympathy for Levi.

The episode opened to the image of a beautiful white castle with a blue roof, chirping birds, mountains in the background.

A Scout slammed his fist on the table. "Quite frankly, this is humiliating."

The commander sat at the head of the table, arms crossed, silent.

Sasha scrutinized the stern-faced man. "Hey, it's Shadis."

"He looks so young, younger than he did in the first episode. It's a little weird," Christa said.

" Are you honestly telling us, who have always held formality in high regard, to accept a bunch of criminals?" Farlan, Isabel, and Levi were pulling on the Wings of Freedom jackets as Flagon spoke. "Our soldiers' morale will be tainted if we allow those Underground scum to join our ranks."

"I get it," Eren muttered. He would have felt the same way. He took great pride in being a member of the Survey Corps. But it was

already difficult enough trying to prove themselves without it spreading around that the Survey Corps let criminals in.

Mikasa could understand where the man was coming from. *People already look down on them and they don't need to give them more ammunition.*

" I am in agreement with Flagon," a man next to him said. Erwin and another man across from them. "And to suggest we take these criminals with us on the next expedition?"

"The Military Police is extremely lazy and do underhanded deals, giving out special favors, and they treat rules and regulations as something flexible," Armin said. But the Scouts were the complete opposite. Discipline was a big thing among Scouts. *And then Commander Erwin does what the MP would do* . And he wasn't even the commander at the time.

"Yeah," Jean crossed his arms. "It'd rankle my feathers too."

" I understand your concerns," Erwin said. "But I can personally vouch for their 3D Maneuver Gear skills."

" The new formation that Erwin has been working on is quite groundbreaking," Keith spoke up. "It empathizes importance not on how best to kill Titans, but how we should best avoid them. I believe our casualties will be greatly reduced."

" This formation is likely to be accepted as the norm for our forces."

" What those scum lack are discipline and manners," Keith said.

Levi glared at the TV.

"He doesn't mean that in a derogatory manner. At least, not in the way you're thinking," Petra said. "It's in the same way he addresses the new recruits at the Trainee Corps."

"Precisely," Hange nodded. "It's just his way with the new blood!"

Flagon gritted his teeth, looking less than pleased, staring at Erwin.

" It should only require a short amount of time. They don't appear to be idiots. Right, Erwin?"

" Correct," he answered while still holding Flagon's stare.

" We'll end things here for today," the commander stood up.

"He wasn't looking too happy," Petra said.

"Flagon was upset because he worked hard to establish himself and took a great deal of pride in being a Scout," Erwin said. "It was offensive that a bunch of thugs from the Underground were allowed in and without having even gone through official military training first like everyone else had."

"I see how that would make him jealous and annoyed, them being deemed worthy without going through what he did," Christa nodded.

Eren glanced at Mikasa. It still stung a little that despite it being his childhood goal of becoming a Scout, Mikasa, who had the least intention of joining the Corps, easily took the number one spot in their class. It could be maddening and it was a little unfair.

" Attention, all!" Keith yelled.

"Man, I almost jumped into a salute," Connie said.

"Yeah."

"Same here."

The Scouts stood, feet apart, hands behind their backs. Hange, Mike, Flagon, and Erwin were at the front of some of the lines of soldiers.

"There's me! And Moblit and Mike. And there's Erwin!"

"Again with the announcing thing," Levi grumbled.

" From today, these three will be fighting alongside you all!"

Levi stood in the middle, arms crossed, while Isabel had a hand on her hip to his right. Farlan was the only one standing at attention like the rest of the soldiers.

" Introduce yourselves!"

It was silent for a second before Levi spoke rudely, "The name's Levi."

Petra wasn't the only one to giggle. She had never seen him act so obnoxiously in the face of authority before. "If Eren or I or any of our squadmates tried to give you attitude like that, Captain, you would have thrown us knee-deep in horse manure."

"Damn straight."

Hange and the rest of the Scouts gaped at him.

" Levi…the first thing you'll need is some goddam discipline," Keith said. "Next!"

Connie made a face. "He always grabs my head and squeezes it over less disrespectful stuff and you didn't even get a proper scolding? So unfair."

His friends chuckled, not denying it.

Isabel stepped forward confidently, pointing her thumb to herself, "I'm Isabel Magnolia. Nice to meet ya!"

Farlan bumped his right fist over his chest, a casual salute, "My name is Farlan Church!"

The Scouts whispered.

" Flagon, these three will be assigned to your squad," Keith said. "Look after them."

The recruits started to laugh.

"This is going to be great."

" M-My squad, sir?"

" Are you dissatisfied?"

Flagon's shoulder slumped, "N-No…" His gaze shifted to the left. "But, shouldn't Erwin…"

" Erwin is tasked with the soldiers' formation. The new recruits will be your responsibility. Is that understood?"

Flagon did a rather unenthusiastic salute.

The action made them chuckle.

" Yes, sir. Understood!" Flagon glared at Levi up on the stage, who stared back down rebelliously.

Flagon opened the door, "These are the barracks."

" There are quite a few," Farlan entered, carrying a sack over his shoulder.

Isabel came in after him with Levi behind her. "Yay! We're all in the same room!"

" Women have a separate section."

" What?! But I wanna stay here!"

Flagon ignored her and turned to the bunk beds in the corner. "You two men will sleep here."

Levi walked up to the beds and touched the underside of the frame. Little black crud fell and he rubbed his fingers, his expression hidden.

"Ew."

"That's clean?"

"Even Eren's room wasn't that dirty," Mikasa said.

"Hey!"

"It was a compliment."

"Uh-huh."

" You lot have been living in the dumps of the Underground," Flagon said carelessly, "but do try to keep this place clean."

They gasped.

"How rude," Petra said.

"Oh he's gonna get it now," Ymir said.

Fastest way to piss off Levi. Hange thought, amused. *Insult his cleaning habits and call him a slob* .

Levi stilled and turned to him with a challenging look, ready for a fight. Farlan and Isabel looked comically alarmed.

"Their faces," Christa giggled.

" Wh-What's with that look?" Flagon said as Levi stood before him, glaring fiercely. "How dare you approach a superior officer with that attitude—"

Farlan quickly rushed in, throwing an arm between them. "Sorry! Got it! We'll try to keep the place clean!" He saluted incorrectly.

" Hmpf!" Flagon grunted. "You'll begin training first thing tomorrow, got it?" He walked away. "Your hand's upside-down!"

Farlan looked down and corrected it. He turned back to his friends, "Don't pull any more stunts like that, Levi!" Levi was cleaning his fingers with a white handkerchief. "We've got enough eyes on us already!"

" Did you not hear what that piece of shit was sprouting out of his piece of shit mouth?"

Wow, what a vocabulary . Mikasa rolled her eyes.

Jean snorted as his fellow viewers laughed. *Eloquent as always* .

" We weren't just caught by accident, you know." Farlan place his hands on his hips. "I hope you haven't forgotten why we're here, Levi."

So weird to see the captain being scolded . Eren thought. They must have been really good friends for Levi to let him do that.

" Yeah, I know."

The image flashed back to the nobleman in the carriage. "The Survey Corps will likely come after you. Be sure to put up a little resistance. There are two things I'll have you do for me…"

Back in the present, Levi looked up.

A carriage was riding down an open road in the middle of the city.

" The expedition budget, which had been put on hold, was finally approved." Keith's voice was heard.

" I see," Erwin said.

" You're not surprised?"

" I'm just relieved."

Keith sat across from him, arms crossed.

" I had already begun my preparations, after all."

" It appears that the leader of the faction which so vigorously opposed the expeditions suddenly came around."

"Wait." Armin's mind raced. *Is he*—

" Nicholas Lobov, I take it." An image of the same man who had hired Levi and his friends flashed through Erwin's mind.

"I knew it."

"Ooh, it's the same guy?" Sasha said.

" So you knew, after all. A while ago," Keith said, "you told me that you were certain the expeditions would be approved, which is why you began preparations… Erwin, could it be you forced Lobov to change his mind through some indecent means?"

"What's going on?" Connie said. "What indecent means?"

"Politics," Ymir answered.

The scene changed back to Levi, Farlan, and Isabel.

" *There are two things I'll have you do for me."* Lobov's voice narrated.

Levi was glaring into space, going over the man's words.

" First, you'll obtain a certain document which is in the possession of Erwin Smith."

" Lobov appeared to have dealings with the Lang Company," Erwin began, "which provides goods for the Military Police. It seems he was planning to redirect the expedition funds to them."

Keith appeared surprised by his words.

" The information is reliable. I've already obtained evidence of this fact." Erwin stared intently.

"Did he blackmail him into giving in and letting the expedition go ahead?" Mikasa thought out loud.

"Maybe," Armin said. He had a feeling it was more than that.

" And secondly, to kill the Survey Corps' Squad Leader Erwin Smith."* The words rang through Levi's head. *"Those are your jobs."

Sasha gasped. "Wait, what?"

Petra turned to Levi, eyes wide, "You were hired as a hitman?"

"Were you going to kill the commander?" Eren asked.

"Obviously things didn't go as planned."

Their jaws dropped. *Does he mean to imply he was actually going to do it?* Christa thought.

Whoa, Corporal Levi, a contract killer . Connie shook his head.

"A friend of his way being held hostage," Armin began hesitantly.

"You don't need to defend me or my actions." Levi wasn't going to make himself a victim so he could look morally decent in their eyes. "I wanted to kill him and I tried. I made my choices and I will live with them. Don't make excuses for me."

They were silent at that.

At least he owns up to it . Mikasa thought. *And doesn't try to dress it up as something less severe* .

Ymir was the first to break the silence. "We do what we have to to survive. Everyone's got a past."

And what's in yours, I wonder. Erwin thought. But he was patient, willing to wait. It would come out eventually. Either from the TV or Ymir herself if she wanted to show she was trustworthy.

Hange stared at the girl. *She knows something.* Hange went over some of the things she'd heard Ymir say. *Come to think of it, she was the first one to start criticizing the plan for the expedition* . Her mind went back to the Titan in the Wall. Did she know something about that? Someone had to. If the Walls were built from colossal-type Titans, it wasn't exactly subtle, she doubted it could happen without someone knowing. And the knowledge would be passed down. *Someone had to know the truth* .

"Well, we know it'll fail," Jean said. "He won't kill the commander."

They nodded, glancing at Erwin. He didn't seem to care so they didn't think too deeply into it and let it bother them too much.

The carriage stopped and the Scout saluted, "We've arrived, sirs!" He opened the door, "Please."

" So…" Keith paused in the doorway. "What do you plan to do, Erwin?"

" Please don't ask me any further. I'm acting on this independently."

" Go down a dangerous path, and you may never make it back out." He stepped out and started to walk away.

" Commander," Erwin called out. "It was only after joining the Survey Corps and coming face-to-face with a Titan, that I came to understand just how frail humanity is." He stood up and took a step out of the carriage, holding the side. "Wealth, and power… Noble ideals… All that would count for nothing if the Titans were to make it past the Walls."

The group nodded along with his words.

"Which is why we…"

The screen flashed to Erwin on an expedition, watching a comrade about to be eaten.

"… will use any means necessary to ensure that the expeditions and our efforts to take back this world from the Titans are not abandoned!" Erwin declared strongly.

The viewers straightened up, impacted by his words.

The commander's been carrying the Survey Corps more than anyone. Armin thought. Erwin was the reason they had made it as far as they had. *Much of the recent success and headway they've made is because of him* . From the politics to get the expeditions funded to the strategies used to ensure the survival of as many soldiers as possible, it was all thanks to him. Armin couldn't really see Lobov outsmarting Erwin. *Corporal Levi defected to his side instead* .

Keith stood there, gaping.

" For the future of humanity!"

It's already so strange to hear them say that. It surprised Sasha how quickly her brain adjusted to from 'humanity' to 'our people' that she felt the need to automatically correct it.

They stared for a few seconds before Keith looked down. Erwin came to stand by him and saluted before walking away. The commander glanced over his shoulder. *For the future of humanity, huh?* He walked away.

Erwin looked up, slightly surprised seeing Levi approaching. Face set, he continued. They walked by, eyes shifting to the other man.

Levi recalled his face being shoved into the dirty puddle, tied up and on his knees with Erwin towering over him. *The one to kill him…will be me.* He stopped and glared back.

It's just...weird . Petra thought it would be uncomfortable or horrifying, Levi talking about murdering the commander, but mostly she just found it odd. *He has so much trust in Commander Erwin now* .

"So, you were really going to do it, huh?" Hange was curious to see what had happened to change that.

"Well, Corporal Levi is a huge clean-freak and he got his face shoved into dirty water, of course someone's gonna get killed," Connie joked, earning amused looks.

Two birds flew in the beautiful sky. Down below, Isabel was on her horse, yanking the reins and riding around a brown-haired female Scout. "I'm surprised. Did someone teach you how to ride a horse?"

" Nah," Isabel smiled, petting her horse's mane. "But I've always been fond of animals. This guy says he likes me too."

" No way!" She said in amazement.

" I'm serious!" That said, Isabel took off riding.

Levi smiled slightly, a warm feeling in his chest. He hadn't been there for her first time riding a horse and committed that happy moment to memory.

"I love animals too." Sasha patted her belly. "Especially in my stomach."

Christa chuckled, "I don't think that's quite what she meant."

Levi pulled out the sword and held it.

" What the hell do you think you're doing?" Flagon had his arms crossed, standing behind him, with Hange and Moblit close by, looking surprised and curious. "Those blades weren't designed to be held like that."

So he holds them that way because that's how he taught himself. Mikasa thought.

" Do you want to die the moment you step outside the Walls?"

Levi turned his back to them. "That might just happen to you."

Their jaws opened in shock.

"Jeez."

"Holy crap."

"Wow..."

"We'd be so dead if we said something like that to Shadis."

" What did you say?"

" All I have to do is slice the neck, right?" Levi turned his head to look at them. "I'll do it my way."

Flagon clenched his hands, irritated, as Levi left. He took off in the forest, maneuvering with ease.

" Was he given formal training?" Hange observed him.

" No," Moblit answered, "I don't believe so."

" Good. Very good." Her voice pitched, that crazy familiar grin on her face. "Everything from the way we search for Titans to the way we take them down is dependent upon individual methods." Hange squealed. "This is starting to get interesting!"

"Of course she makes it about Titans," Jean said.

"Uh, yeah, hello," Hange waved, smiling widely, "have you met me?"

They laughed, amused by her self-awareness.

A Scout was waiting in the forest, ready to operate a Titan dummy. "Do you really think…that you can take down a Titan without any preparation?" He yanked the wire.

The Titan dummy suddenly fell into Levi's path. Levi flipped in the air, going under its chin, shooting a wire up and moving above the dummy.

" What?" The sandy-haired Scout gaped.

The recruits grinned widely, feeling giddy. They knew how good Levi was but that Scout had no idea.

Hanging upside-down against a tree branch, Levi switched his hold on his sword and pushed off, slicing off the nape.

" What's with that incredible speed?" The Scout stared, wide-eyed.

It was very fun for them, watching him be so shocked. The recruits couldn't wait for the expedition. The Scouts were going to be blown away by Levi's insane Titan-killing skills and it was going to be incredibly entertaining seeing the looks on their faces. Just the thought of it made them shift eagerly in their seats for when he annihilated any Titan that got in his way.

Flagon swung to a nearby tree, hanging there and watching Levi's kill. The short man gave him a sideways glare as he flew by. *So this is the 'reform' that Erwin was talking about?*

"… and that's how we'll relay the direction, I take it?"

" That's right."

" How will we communicate the level of danger?"

" The color of the flare will distinguish that."

As the meeting continued, Isabel and Levi stood watch while Farlan searched through Erwin's office. *Dammit, where is it?* He

checked a drawer. *I thought this would be easy considering how little equipment there is.* He went through the bookshelf.

"He's looking for the letter, isn't he? I would hide it in the trash," Connie said.

"What if you forget or someone takes the trash out while you're gone?" Christa asked. "Or you throw out something wet or sticky that ruins it?"

"Oh yeah..."

There was a bird call. Farlan froze, looking left and right.

Erwin came around the corner and unlocked the door, stepping into his empty office.

In another part of the castle, Levi leaned against two stacked crates, arms crossed while Isabel sat on a crate beside him.

" We won't find it no matter how many times we look," Farlan said, standing before them. "It's probably best to assume it isn't in his room."

" Then where could it be?" Isabel asked.

" What do you do with something you really want to keep safe?" Farlan replied.

She grinned, puffing out her chest, and declared, patting her stomach, "Inside my stomach, of course."

The group burst into laughter.

Ymir looked over at Sasha. "Just like you."

"I agree. Sounds like a smart plan to me," Sasha nodded, smiling widely.

Isabel seemed surprised by Farlan's look. "Now," he said, "I don't know if Erwin wears a stomach band, but it's highly likely he's carrying it with him. And so I was thinking… We could use the expedition to our advantage."

Everyone had the same thought: *They're not gonna survive* .

" Outside the Walls, Erwin and the others will be concentrated on the Titans. We just have to wait for an opportunity."

" I see! Great idea!" Isabel said.

Sure, if you want to end up dead . Ymir thought. Keith had hammered it into their heads distraction meant death.

" You okay with that, Levi?" Farlan asked.

" Sure." Levi thought back to his friends when they had been captured to force him into compliance. He moved to stand in front of them, arms still crossed over his chest. "But I'll be going alone."

He's really worried for them. Petra thought it was for good reason. It was quite foolhardy, their plan. Surviving an expedition was hard enough, pulling off a heist and an assassination on top of that without being caught was beyond dangerous. *Especially since they've never even laid eyes on a Titan before* .

" What?" Farlan and Isabel said simultaneously.

" You two, just think up any excuse and stay behind."

"I'm guessing that won't go well," Christa said softly.

" Bro… Why?" Isabel demanded.

" We haven't even seen a real Titan yet, and it'll be our first time outside the Walls. It may take all we've got just to make it back alive." Levi uncrossed his arms. "But if I go by myself, I'll manage somehow."

" But—"

Farlan held up his hand to stop her. "So what you're saying is that we can't handle it, right?"

" That's right. At least, that's how I feel."

Well, no one ever accused him of sugarcoating things. Sasha thought.

"Ouch. Guess he's painfully blunt like that with everyone."

"Jean, you're not so different in that regard yourself," Armin pointed out.

Isabel jumped off the crate and went up to him. "How can you say that? You won't know until we've at least tried. What's wrong? This isn't like you."

" If you won't stay behind, then we're done talking!" Levi's words surprised her. "We'll wait for a different opportunity." That said, he moved past her and Farlan, leaving.

They had never seen the corporal so emotional before. At least not in the worried and nervous sense. Even when he had become raged over the death of his squad or when he had been comforting the dying soldier, it was still how one would expect Humanity's Strongest Soldier, the people's hero, to act. Noble and strong and persevering. Unlike now, when he was doubting their plan and hesitating in moving forward.

Levi had never felt quite as human to them as he did just then. It was oddly both scary and comforting.

Gritting his teeth, Farlan twisted around, calling after him, "Levi!"

" Wait, bro!"

Mikasa knew where Levi was coming from. No matter how hard she had pushed Eren not to join the Scouts, he'd had his way in the end. *Doesn't matter what we want, it's their choice* . Even if Levi knew it could get them killed, he couldn't very well force his will on them. As with Eren, Farlan and Isabel too had gotten their way and potentially ended up being eaten. Unlike her friend, neither had Titan-Shifting powers to help save their lives.

Levi stared up at the night sky, sitting on the edge of the castle roof. He turned his head when he heard footsteps approaching.

" Bro." Arms folded over her chest, Isabel looked very unhappy and irritated.

" Levi. Let's talk about this. I can't agree with you going alone. That's still just as dangerous for you!" Farlan said strongly.

" You said that when we first step outside, it'll be the three of us all at once. Have you forgotten?"

Levi's turned away from them, head bowed, "It's the same." They straightened at his words. "When you can't see the moon or stars, the sky up here is just the same as the sky down there."

They looked up at the thick clouds in the dark sky. "The color of the sky, sure," Farlan said. "But…"

" But it's different." Isabel's words caught him by surprise. "We know that there's no ceiling. It's completely different!"

The recruits smiled, happy for them.

At least they won't die in the Underground, without first having seen what lay outside the Walls. Eren had always thought if he died out there, having only lived a short life, he wouldn't regret it than if he had inside after living a long life. To him, dying outside the Walls wasn't a tragedy. *Especially since they've lived their whole lives below the surface. Not being able to see the sun without first having to pay a fee.* But they would be free outside the Walls so dying out there, over something that was meaningful, was preferable to him.

" That's right," Farlan agreed. "The sky is endless. It may be just as dark, but it's far different from the Underground."

" Look!" Isabel pointed up and they followed her gaze. The clouds moved away, revealing the moon. "The moon is so bright!" Isabel took a seat to Levi's right and Farlan sat on his other side. "There's a difference, isn't there?"

" Yeah," Farlan smiled. "We're not underground."

They looked up and Levi followed their gaze. The clouds continued to drift away from the moon and the three sat in silence, admiring the view.

" We'll never go back down there," Farlan vowed.

They're all watching this . The stupid thought popped up in his head, reminding Levi just how uncomfortable it was, knowing everyone was watching personal parts of his life. But he shifted his attention, focusing on the voices of his friends instead.

It was easy to remember what they looked like. The color of their hair and eyes, their smiles, the creases in their brows when they were confused or annoyed. But their voices were harder for him to recall. Slightly unsettling as it had been at first, it was amazing now, being able to see and hear them again. Especially when they were filled with such happiness and optimism.

Levi another bothersome thought hovering at the edge of his consciousness and chose to keep his mind off that, trying to ignore it. He was going to watch them die. Before a torrent of questions could flood him— *Did they blame him? Had they cursed him? Cried out for him to help them?* —he glared hard at the TV, intent on taking in every precious moment he could of them still alive and well, trying to memorize it in as much as detail as possible.

" He's right, bro. The three of us always pull through, right?" Isabel smiled at him. "It'll be the same with the Titans. Let's do this together."

" Levi, believe in us," Farlan said.

Levi was surprised by their words. He lowered his eyes, thinking. The sky above them was full of countless twinkling stars. Levi thought back to Isabel releasing the healed bird, letting it fly away into the sun. "Alright."

" Yay!" Isabel cheered and Levi smiled while Farlan chuckled. "Bro sure is a stubborn one, ain't he?"

"A smile from Levi! What a rare phenomenon we have been blessed to witness," Hange said. "Praises to Candy!"

The recruits cheered, snickering.

"Shit, the TV didn't break, did it?" Jean said, making them laugh even more.

"No, but a puppy might have died somewhere." Despite her words, Mikasa's tone didn't have a bite to it.

Levi rolled his eyes at their antics. "Idiots." But he was content to let them run their mouths and have their fun for now. He'd get them for it later once they left.

The bell rang loudly and Keith's voice was heard. "Open the gate!" Survey Corps soldiers filled the street, carts stocked and ready. "Today, we take another step forward!" A shot of Flagon appeared, followed by Erwin. "Show me the fruits of your training!" Keith looked back at them as the gate began to rise. "Show them the strength of humanity!"

The soldiers raised their fists and swords, letting out battle cries. Wind flew out of the open gate. Isabel petted her horse, Farlan and Levi to her right with serious looks on their faces.

" We will now begin the 23rd Expedition beyond the Walls! Forward, everyone!" Keith yelled. He led the charge and they followed, going through the gate.

Sunlight hit Isabel as a bird cried out above. Completely awed, she watched the beautiful sky full of fluffy clouds.

Farlan was equally awestruck.

They grinned, leaning forward, eager to see Levi's expression.

Isabel smiled brightly, cheeks pink. "Wow!"

" Yeah." A gorgeous image view of tree-covered hills appeared with thick ethereal looking clouds above them, with beams of sunlight shining down through them. "Not bad at all," Levi said softly, looking in wonder.

Smiled covered all their faces. Knowing they were born and grew up in the Underground City—a dark, sullen, and depressing place—it was a joyous sight seeing them so taken in by the beauty of the world outside the Walls.

It made Erwin eager to see how the rest of the population would react to that view. *We're going to do it* . The Scouts had Eren. They were watching the future. Secrets were being brought to light.

Humanity's—the freedom of the People of the Walls, it's feasible . They could do it. A shiver of peasant shock went down his spine. Within his lifetime, they would be able to leave the Walls. He had known it logically and made plans and run scenarios in his head, thrilled and anticipating, but now it was truly sinking in emotionally. Erwin took a deep breath as his heart raced, the amazed look never leaving his face.

The trio admired the view.

They need to get their heads out of the clouds . Levi didn't think they had been as bad as the dumbest of the recruits who let themselves get completely caught up in the view on their first expedition.

" What are you doing?" The brown-haired female Scout rode up to them. "Don't lose focus. We're not out here to sightsee. There's no telling when we could run into a Titan."

" Hah!" Isabel smirked. "If we do see one, we'll clean it up right away for you!"

" Idiot!" Isabel flinched at the reprimand. "You wanna be the first one to die?"

" What's your problem?" The girl grumbled.

" You're only able to talk like that because you've never seen a Titan before. You have no idea just how many good soldiers have been eaten…"

Eren nodded seriously. "That was pretty arrogant." Titans were no joke.

Jean brought up his fist and coughed pointedly. The others giggled. "I think the phrase is: *the pot calling the kettle black.* "

Eren blushed, slinking back into his seat and his friends laughed.

They were never going to let him live his arrogance as a trainee down.

" Titan sighted!" A dark-haired Titan with a crazy looking expression appeared, its arms up in the air. "Ahead and to our right! One 15-meter class right ahead!"

" That's…a Titan?" Farlan observed nervously as Isabel watched with an open mouth next to him.

" Two 10-meter class Titans are heading toward us from behind!"

One Titan had long black hair while the other had hair the color of sand. Isabel gasped.

" They're too close for us to slip away. Prepare for combat!" Keith ordered. "Equip your 3D Maneuver Gear!"

Three soldiers employed their gear.

Erwin glanced over his shoulder. "Flagon, shoot your flare!"

" I know!" He pulled out his flare gun and shot up a red flare.

" Commander, let's tighten our formation," Erwin said. "It looks like it's going to rain."

I thought he just referred to himself in the third person . Connie laughed quietly to himself.

Two Scouts flew over Erwin and Keith, who were at the head of the formation. One of them ended up flying straight into the Titan's mouth as it jumped up and caught him with its teeth, its arms still in the air.

" Dammit!" Flagon jumped off his horse and flew toward the Titan, going behind it and killing it.

"Hey, not bad."

"He's pretty good."

"Yeah. I half expected him to suck."

The Titan fell, its nape bloody. "Incredible!" Isabel said.

" They're more impressive than the Military Police!" Farlan commented.

The sound of footsteps came from behind them.

" They're here!" Isabel yelled.

" Two of them!" Farlan said.

Flagon returned to his horse. "You two, stay your course!"

Levi passed the two by, heading toward the Titans. "Levi!" Farlan called out.

The group laughed at Levi's plain disobedience. Their eyes were glued to the screen, anticipating what was no doubt going to be an awesome display of his Titan-slaying skills.

" Let's do this, Isabel!"

" Right!"

They went after him.

" Are they trying to get killed?" Flagon said in frustration.

They laughed.

"Here it comes!"

"Shh!"

Levi jumped back off his horse. The hook shot straight between the two Titans running toward him, embedding into a tree. Flying close to the ground, he went around behind the Titan and then up to cut its nape.

"That's one down!"

One small miscalculation and he would have been seriously hurt . Petra thought. It was never tiring watching her captain coming up with and perfectly executing a maneuver in a short span of time.

He had to time it perfectly . Mikasa knew if he had been too fast the Titan could have stepped on the wire, sending him crashing face-first into the ground. Or if he had been too slow, the wire would have wrapped around the Titan's ankle and he would have been yanked back. Either way, it would have ended badly had he made one mistake.

The Titan went down, the force of its body hitting the ground sending a cloud of dust up. Levi surged up and watched the second Titan rush toward his friends. Swords out and ready, Farlan and Isabel went toward it. The Titan caught one of Isabel's legs with its hand.

They tensed.

She won't die . Levi's stomach was full of knots. He felt nauseous. At least not here. Not yet.

Levi surged forward. With a cry, Isabel cut off its finger, freeing herself.

"Nice!"

"Good job!"

Christa nodded. "She didn't panic."

"I had a little heart attack for a second there!"

The Titan began to twist its head, noticing Farlan behind him. He brought his swords down, killing it.

"Oh I can't wait to see the others' reactions to that."

"They're going to be so shocked!"

"And it's their first time too!"

Levi landed on the ground, swiping his sword through the air to rid it of the blood. The two Titans steamed and the soldiers raced by their corpses.

" All the Titans have been wiped out!"

" Everyone, regroup!"

" How's that, Levi?" Pride was clear in Farlan's voice. The three were back on their horses with the Titan he had killed steaming a few feet behind them. "We took down a Titan all by ourselves!"

" We did it, bro! We did it!" Isabel yelled excitedly.

"Hell yeah they did!"

They giggled as Levi watched them celebrate their first kill, his mouth open.

" Yeah… You guys did well," Levi praised them.

" Squad leader, those three…"

" Yeah. I'm beginning to understand why Erwin was so insistent on having them join," Flagon said.

"So he's not totally stuck-up," Eren said.

"But man, they're better than I was expecting," Connie admitted.

"Yeah," Ymir nodded. She had thought Levi's instincts were right when he thought they shouldn't be out there. *But they're very good.* Skilled, smart, level-headed. *So how did they get killed?*

" Indeed," Erwin joined the trio, "that was impressive, considering it was your first time. But you used too much gas. You need to be especially conservative out here."

Farlan opened his mouth to protest but Levi held up a hand. "You're expecting me to take priority of my equipment over the lives of my friends?"

The recruits grinned. It was strangely pleasing hearing Levi admit to caring so much about friendship.

" You're performing a lot of unnecessary movements." Erwin narrowed his eyes. "Are you beginning to have doubts?"

Levi's eyes widened.

" If you are, that'll be the death of you very soon."

"He's onto them," Armin said. "I think he knows they plan to kill him and take the document."

"Really?" Eren said. "Was that what he meant?"

Levi watched Erwin leave, a shocked expression on his face, his back to his friends.

" Damn him!" Isabel cursed, glaring. "He'd better watch his back when he's alone!"

" Shh!" Farlan hissed. "He'll hear you!"

Too late, he already knows . Armin thought. "How far in advance did you know about their plan?" He asked the commander.

"You'll see."

Levi continued to look on with wide, startled eyes.

Corporal Levi just can't believe it. Sasha thought. *The commander's really smart.*

It began to pour within a matter of seconds. Gray clouds covered the sky, soaking everything underneath them as a thick mist covered the landscape. The soldiers continued to ride on. *It's difficult to see* . Erwin thought. *If the storm gets any worse, the flares won't be of much use* .

Is this why? Ymir wondered. The poor visibility was a massive disadvantage. Titans were affected by it as well but not nearly as bad. *It'd be easy to get ambushed and slaughtered.* But with Levi there, she couldn't see them dying. At least not both of them.

" Should we reduce our speed?" Someone asked.

" Yes, though I'd like to get away from this open area as soon as possible." Erwin shot out a green flare.

That's right! Christa thought. It was bad enough they couldn't see well but... *Now they won't be able to use their gear to defend themselves if they're in a particularly bare part of the land and a Titan attacks.*

The others could all see how, despite their skills, Farlan and Isabel would likely face their demise.

Sasha frowned. *It's just dumb rotten luck a storm hit on their first expedition and they're in an open area.*

Elsewhere, Levi, Isabel, and Farlan rode, their hoods pulled on. "I didn't know rain could be this heavy!" She watched it coming down on her cloak.

" Yeah," Farlan replied. "We won't be able to see any Titans before it's too late!"

" This is our chance," Levi said, a dark expression on his face.

He's looking especially murder-y here. Connie thought.

" We'll use this rain as cover and get close to Erwin."

Farlan and Isabel gasped. "Levi!"

" Are we gonna go for it, bro?"

" Yeah. But it'd be suspicious if all three of us were to break away at once."

Jean's eyes widened. "Oh don't say—"

" I'll go alone."

"Dammit, I knew it!"

Eren wanted to yell *don't split up!* even though he knew it was useless.

Does it bother him? It would have eaten Mikasa alive if her choice had gotten Armin and Eren killed. And it would have been beyond frustrating and awful having to see it again.

" True, it's probably best not to carelessly move around," Farlan said.

" Alright, fine. We're counting on you, bro. Go and secure our surface citizenship!"

Petra and Hange could feel the tension coming from the man sitting between them.

They chose to separate. Petra thought. He hadn't tried to convince them that he had to do it alone and pushed them into splitting up. *Still...* If it had been her, she would haven beaten herself up over it regardless.

Levi faced them. "If anyone asks, tell them I went to survey the terrain."

" Got it!" Farlan answered.

Levi sped ahead. He looked back to see Isabel waving and saying something but was unable to hear.

Levi felt a strong desire to know what she said. It was probably something generic like 'good luck' or 'see you soon' but suddenly it was all he could think about.

The mist and rain quickly concealed them from his view. Grabbing his hood, Levi kept going, recalling Erwin's words. *"Are you beginning to have doubts?"* Then he thought back to what the man had said when he and friends were 'captured' in the Underground. *"Choose as you wish."*

***Just you wait, Erwin Smith* . Levi glared. *I'll kill you with these two hands!* He moved through the mist, passing by the outlines of two Titans in the background.**

How did I miss them? Levi went over his memories of that day. Was it because he had been too caught up in his own emotions that he had missed them?

The brown-haired female Scout noticed something moving in the trees. There was a sudden movement.

The group was completely silent, knowing what was coming.

Levi yanked the reins of his horse and stopped, looking at the massacre around him. Bloodied, mangled bodies lay unmoving

on the ground as the rain fell harshly. "What the hell…happened here?" He said in shock.

A black flare was shot behind him. He turned to see an alive but gravely injured Scout lying by a tree. The soldier pointed, gasping out, "The Titan…" Was he managed before he went still.

" No way," Levi gasped in horror, noticing the footprints heading in the direction he had come from. "Did we pass each other?"

"Don't just stand there! Move," Sasha hissed.

Gritting his teeth, Levi raced back. He noticed a hand on the ground. Mist and rain sprayed in his face, blinding him as well as his horse. The animals neighed, slipping on a corpse and falling. Levi grunted, skidding with his horse, splashes of mud on his face. His eyes grew wide in horror.

The viewers held their breaths.

Levi clenched his fists tightly in his lap, face white. There was only an ounce of relief he had been sparred any new horrible details.

Isabel's head lay a foot from Levi, covered in splotches of blood and mud and soaked with rain. Her decapitated head was in a puddle of red where her neck would have been. Her eyes were wide open, blank; her expression frozen in a mix of shock and terror.

Most of the group flinched, some gasping as hands flew up to mouths.

The atmosphere was thick with sadness and horror.

A Titan with long black hair growled, bent over, almost on all four. It bit into something—someone—and turned its red,

almost demonic gaze on Levi.

"There is one creepy-ass Titan," Connie shivered.

"It looks fucking evil," Jean said.

"I've never seen such a scary Titan before." Sasha was looking a little pale.

"Yeah," Petra agreed, disturbed. She had never encountered a Titan with such malicious eyes.

It was human once . Ymir knew the Marley government punished any Eldian traitors by injecting them with the Titan serum and letting them roam freely in a state of limbo. A shudder went through her, remembering her own experience. *Wouldn't surprise me if this one, in its past life as a human, was some bloodthirsty freak* .

The Titan clenched its jaw and sent Farlan's upper body to the ground.

Even knowing it was coming didn't lessen the impact of their deaths.

They felt a surge of fury at the loss and heartbreak for Levi. But no one looked in his direction, knowing it would only make it worse. It was the least they could do, giving him the little privacy they could.

Bad enough we're watching their lives without permission. Connie's face was uncharacteristically serious. *It's the only decent thing to do in this situation* . If it were him, he'd be sick to his stomach knowing people were watching him as he saw one of the worst moments of his life play out before him.

Meanwhile, Levi almost felt detached, watching the scene.

Levi was on his knees, one visible eye wide, completely stunned. A gust of wind covered him with mist and rain. The Titan made a rumbling noise, focusing on sword near where the man had been.

They were wondering where he had gone when it happened.

There was a sudden burst of blood.

The group jumped back, startled.

The Titan looked around madly, steam rising from its jaw. Levi came diving from the sky and cutting its ear. The Titan tried to swat him but he was too fast. He cut the side of the Titan's torso next. It threw its head back and screamed. Looking furious, Levi tore open its back and continued to shred away at its skin, screaming the entire time.

Whispers picked up around the room, speaking furiously.

"This is so fucking insane!"

Mikasa stared, eyes wide and disbelieving. *I'm nowhere near his level.*

"I think he's gone nuts."

He's devastated . Petra thought sadly.

"Wow, he's unstoppable."

Levi was mostly numb. The TV seemed so far away all of a sudden.

Flashes of Levi's face, blood, and parts of the Titan flashed on the screen.

A few eyebrows began to raise and they looked at each other.

Levi continued his ruthless assault, slicing and shearing off the Titan's skin.

Stunned silence filled the room as they watched, unable to comprehend the level of violence they were seeing.

The annihilation of the Titan continued, the images moving far too fast now, Levi's tormented screams playing against the unbelievable carnage on screen.

Jaws hit the floor. They were completely blown away. And the dam broke.

"He's still going!"

"Is there *anything* even *left* ?!"

"What the hell IS he?"

"Holy mother of Maria he's just—! It's just—! *Fuck* !"

"This is the bloodiest most beautiful thing I've ever seen!"

"Is he really *human* ?!"

Their hearts were galloping, slamming against their ribcages.

"Dude, what the FUCK?!"

"I just...there are no words...I can't even..."

"It's totally obliterated! It has to be! Totally cut to ribbons!"

"He's a fucking monster!"

The Titan's head went flying. Its headless body with multiple cuts sprayed out large quantities of blood everywhere.

"What?!" Connie threw open his arms, utterly gobsmacked. "I mean just WHAT?! What?! *What* ? Holy fucking mother Titan WHAT?"

"I just think his mind just broke."

The Titan made a pathetic sound, holding its hand up. The hand was slashed at lightning speed and completely ripped apart,

shredded down to only blood and gore. Levi sliced up the Titan's arm, finally going for the nape. The Titan fell, dead. Levi stood by it, head down, crying, covered in blood.

The group was rendered speechless, unable to think or say anything, only watch with massive eyes and open mouths.

Horses came up around the Titan. Erwin said nothing at the scene before him.

The Titan had skeletonized. Levi stood a few yards behind Mike, his shoulders bowed, Isabel's head still at his feet. "So, you're the only survivor now," Erwin said. "How pathetic."

They gasped, fully expecting to the commander's head to fly, liberated from his body.

Levi's head snapped up and he charged somewhat sluggishly at Erwin. Mike turned, ready to intervene but stayed put. Levi struggled, trying to push his sword toward Erwin, who held the now blunted blade with his bare hand, resisting easily. "I'm going to…" Levi breathed deeply. "…kill you! That's why I'm here!" He screamed.

Reaching with his free hand, Erwin pulled out something from his jacket pocket and tossed it to the side. Levi looked at the sheet of paper tied around a wooden cylinder with a thin piece of rope. "These documents revealing Lobov's crimes," Erwin said, "are a fake."

"I'm sorry WHAT?" Sasha blurted out.

"He really knew all along," Armin said.

Does that mean it was all for nothing? Christa felt so bad for them.

" The real ones have likely reached Darius Zackly by now. Lobov is finished."

" You knew everything right from the start!" Levi accused, glaring. "You knew we were after you, and yet you—" He shoved forward but Mike wrapped his arms around his shoulders and pulled him back. Levi struggled but Mike pushed him back. He stopped moving and the hands fell from his shoulders.

A second later, Levi collapsed to his knees, letting out a sob.

Sadness and sorrow filled their chests.

There was a look of shock over Levi's face.

The shot focused on Farlan's body. *"Believe in us."*

Isabel's head was shown next. *"We're counting on you, bro!"*

An expression of guilt appeared on his face. "Don't," Erwin said. "You'll regret it." Levi blinked, looking up. "If you begin to regret, you'll dull your future decisions and let others make your choices for you. All that's left for you then is to die."

This is... Eren recalled Levi's words when the Female Titan had followed them into the Forest of Giant Trees. *This is the same advice he gave me then* .

The Titan continued to steam behind them. Bloodied swords and bodies lay around them.

" Nobody can foretell the outcome. Each decision you make holds meaning only by affecting your next decision. We're going to continue the expeditions." Erwin turned and began walking away, "I expect you to come with me."

Levi sat, watching him. Erwin stopped his horse near Flagon's body which, much like Farlan's body had been, was severed at

the waist.

He's dead too? So everyone but the man who was supposed to die ended up dead. Ymir couldn't help but think maybe fate really did not like Levi. *His second squad also got slaughtered while he was elsewhere, arriving only in time to attract the Titan who responsible but not save them.* But the mental strength it took to get up from that and still keep going forward was nothing short of inspiring.

Erwin looked ahead and continued on.

Levi was stunned, looking at him trot away with weapons and bodies scattered around him as steam drifted up to the sky.

" I don't understand."* Levi's voice narrated as a white bird flew through the sky. *"I've never understood. Even if I believe in my own strength…"* Shots of buildings inside the Wall appeared. *"Even if I believe in the decisions of my trusted friends…"

A bird flew out over the Wall.

" In the end…"* The Scouts were ready, in the streets, waiting for the start of another expedition. *"…nobody…"* Levi sat on his horse, looking ahead. *"But…"* Erwin was positioned with three other men ahead of Levi. *"…this man is gazing at something that I can't even see. Fine. I will follow you, Erwin Smith."

This is why he's faithful to the commander . Hange thought.

" Forward!"

The soldiers raced forward and through the gate. Levi glanced up. Sunlight hit his face as he left the Wall. He looked at the pair of white birds circling up in the beautiful sky, admiring. *"I will*

never regret this decision…" **He sped up.** ***"…for as long as I live."*** **The soldiers raced into the land.**

The two birds flew up higher in the sky and the sun shone down brightly in the final shot.

"That was one of the most intense episodes yet," Armin said. "At least towards the end."

Eren nodded, "Yeah, no kidding."

"I still can't wrap my head around that scene," Jean shook his head.

"Me too."

"That was pretty fucking unreal."

Mikasa's eyes wandered over to the bathroom door. "I wonder if he's okay." She caught them exchanging a look. "I'm not heartless," she said, a little hurt they looked so surprised that she was worried.

"We know," Eren said quickly.

"We're just glad," Armin added. "I've seen Commander Erwin looking at you and Corporal Levi with his thinking face and I'm guessing he wants you to train under him."

"Exactly!" Jean said. "So it's a good thing you don't hate his guts."

Mikasa sighed, "No, I don't." It was hard not to feel empathic, knowing what he had been through and having experienced some of the same tragedy herself. *But I'm lucky. Eren came back safely both times.* She thought about the Battle for Trost and the 57th Expedition. *And Armin's safe too* . Their little family had survived and would continue to. With Levi, history had repeated itself. *No, the future won't mirror the past this time* .

"Ymir, you alright?" Christa asked. "You're quiet. It's not like you."

"Yeah," Connie nodded, putting his food down, a little concerned himself. "You look anxious." He had never seen her anxious.

"I'm fine," she said.

"Are you sure?" Sasha asked. "You've been tapping your foot. It's a nervous tic."

Ymir was spared from answering when Levi emerged from the bathroom. Everyone immediately and pointedly looked everywhere but at him. *He looks tired* . Aside from that, she didn't think there was anything different. She thought he'd be grateful soon as she was about to call all the attention to herself. *Do I want to say this sitting down or standing in front of them?* She debated internally.

"Here," Petra held up a glass of water when Levi returned to the couch. He accepted it, grunting his thanks.

"How are you feeling?" Hange asked.

Levi sighed, "I'm fine. Don't start coddling me." The grief had been overwhelming for a minute there but he was calm now. It had hurt but he wasn't about to cry like a child. "I'm not some fragile piece of china that'll break over nothing."

"No," Erwin said, "of course not. You're Humanity's Strongest Soldier."

Levi, hating that title, made a sound of disgust, making them laugh.

"Okay, then."

"Okay what?" Christa said.

Ymir stood up and moved to stand before the TV. She wanted to be able to see their faces. And it gave her room to dodge if they pounced.

"Good," Erwin said. Levi, Petra, and Hange turned to him and followed his gaze.

All their eyes were on Ymir. Most of them looked confused or curious. But seeing the ranking officers eyeing her in interest made her glad she had decided to speak up because it seemed like they were almost half expecting it. "There's something I have to say..."

Please Review~

Ymir Speaks

Chapter 28: Ymir Speaks

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Ymir tells the group she has something to say to them.

"There's something I have to say..."

"What is it?" Connie asked curiously.

Ymir crossed her arms. "I thought a lot about this and I came to a decision. I'm coming clean."

"What're you talking about?" Confusion laced Eren's voice.

Christa looked concerned. "Ymir, what's going on?"

She exhaled. "Okay, here goes: I'm a Titan-Shifter."

They gaped at her.

"You *what* ?"

"Is this a joke?"

"Are you serious?"

Ymir pulled up the sleeve of her jacket and dug the butter knife across her arm. *Actions speak louder than words.*

The words died on their lips at her action as steam rose from the wound and the flesh knitted together before their very eyes. Seconds later her arm was healed, completely unmarked. Their eyes were still glued to her clear skin, brains short-circuiting.

Erwin was the first to react. "Speak."

"You know by now that we're not the last humans. There are other civilizations still out there. I came to the Walls five years from one of those civilizations. Well, human me. Titan me wandered outside the Walls for sixty years before that." The faster ones—Armin, Hange, and Erwin—had already made the connection. At her next words, the rest of the group joined in, blood draining from their faces as their expressions twisted into that of horror and denial. "That's right...Titans are humans."

Protests and accusations erupted immediately.

"That's bullshit!"

"Is this some sick joke? Cause it sure I sure as hell ain't laughing."

"What's wrong with you?"

"Ymir, what is this?"

"How can you say that?"

"It's the truth," Ymir talked over them. Her eyes settled on Hange. She was taking it the hardest.

"But that means..." Hange's stomach churned. Her skin had taken a green tint. She felt sick to her stomach.

"Explain," Levi demanded. "Everyone else, shut your damn mouths and keep them shut."

"I'll start from the beginning. Watching the episodes triggered my memories. Before, I only knew bits and pieces. I'm from a country

called Marley. It's where the all the Shifters are from. And Eren's father I suspect."

Eren nailed her with a fierce look. A muscle in his jaw twitched but he kept quiet, adhering to Levi's order.

Standing before them all was awkward. But if she'd stayed seated they would have gathered around her and stared down at her. That would have kicked Ymir even further out of her comfort zone so she kept going. "I was a poor, starving, nameless orphan. Until one day, a man found me and gave me the name Ymir Fritz."

The group perked up. Questions began appearing in all their minds. Mainly regarding the royal family name "Fritz."

"A cult was born and they worshipped me as a goddess."

Levi, Hange, and Erwin's thoughts turned to the content of Ilse's journal. The Titan had referred to Ilse as "Lady Ymir."

It's all finally coming together . Hange thought.

This is it . Erwin's heart pounded. A tingling sensation went through him. More questions being answered.

"Eventually, we were discovered and arrested. Oh wait, I should give you some background about the goddess thing. Not sure if you all know the story. Basically, it goes likes this: A long time ago, Ymir Fritz obtained the power of the Titans. She was the original Shifter. The progenitor Titan."

The founder . Eren's head ached at the thought.

She had made a deal with the devil . Christa was startled by the thought. She couldn't recall where she had learned that. *Was it in a book?*

"And with her powers, she accomplished great things. Building roads and structures, raising bridges, cultivating lands, bringing good

fortune to her people, and all that. When she died, her powers were split nine ways, nine Titan-Shifters."

They knew of four: Eren Yeager, Annie Leonhart, the Colossal Titan, and the Armored Titan. *Five counting her* . Petra thought. What could the other four do? What abilities did they possess? And why were the Shifters sent to eliminate them?

That's just what we need . Levi thought irritably. More enemy Shifters.

"What happens when one dies?" Despite the order to stay quiet, Armin's curiosity overwhelmed him.

"It gets passed on to another person. An Eldian, specifically. Only they are able to inherit this power. Only *they* can be turned into Titans. And the only Eldians, also called the Subjects of Ymir, left in this world are the people of the Walls and those kept in a segregated area in Marley called Liberio."

The rug had been swept out from under their feet once again. First, learning they were not, in fact, the last humans left. And now this. This was even worse.

We can be turned into Titans. Sasha stared at her hand in disbelief. How was that even possible? It made her feel ill, thinking about the Titans she had helped take out. *They were all people* .

Are we murderers? Connie felt dizzy thinking about that. *But we didn't know...* He thought helplessly.

It was suffocating. Levi's whole body felt like lead. *All this time I thought I was doing something good* . Thought human bloodshed under his hands was over. Turned out he was dirtying his hands further still. *I thought I was done. But it was just more of the same.*

Ymir felt bad for them, watching the truth tear them up inside.

So many lives were lost because of her. Petra was glad she was sitting down. Otherwise her knees might have given out as the world spun. Guilt gnawed at her. *What if we could have helped them some way?* Maybe they should have taken Hange's approach, trying to study them and learn more about them, to *understand* , instead of simply killing them.

Hange's eyes were wide, terribly unsettled by the truth. *Have I been experimenting on humans? Sonny and Bean...and the other Titans.* Was she a monster for torturing them? Her experiments, she hadn't meant to hurt a person. Truly she had felt their suffering as she exposed them to violent methods to study their regeneration. Surely that meant she wasn't really an awful human.

"In Marley," Ymir continued, "the Eldians are treated as second-class citizens and considered to be beasts. And the Marleyans are not the only ones. Sorry to burst your bubble about the grandeur of the outside world but the truth is, they hate all us Eldians. They think we're devils and would like nothing more than to wipe us off the face of the planet. And they would have if it weren't for the Titans roaming out the Walls."

Jean couldn't help the chuckle that escaped him. "So this entire time, the things we were raised to fear and hate, thinking they had enslaved us, were actually the only things standing between us and a world that wants us dead. The fucking irony, man..."

Everything we've been fighting for, what was it for? Mikasa's thoughts turned to Ian and Mitabi and the others Garrison soldiers who had sacrificed their lives to help Eren close the hole. *No, Titans still eat people so that was at least helpful to the Trost residents. But everyone who died trying to kill a Titan outside the Walls, thinking they were furthering humanity's cause...* The truth just made their heroic acts worthless. Worse still, their actions were counterproductive, removing an obstacle that was protecting the Wall citizens.

It was so outrageous, the idea that Titans were protecting them this whole time that Eren almost felt like throwing up. *They still killed Mom.* Titans were still monsters who killed without discrimination. *They're still enemies.* Just not the main enemy. But Titans were also human. Or they used to be. It was getting so complicated.

Christa hated this. Things used to be simpler. Humans were good. Titans were bad. They were mindless beasts that needed to be killed. Now it turned out they were once human, too. And the world they had been fighting to see hated their guts and just wanted to see them all be exterminated.

Erwin was the only one to take it all in stride. For a few seconds, it had stunned him. A crushing sense of defeat and horror had set in—all the atrocities he had committed in the name of saving humanity from extinction, then telling himself it was okay because he didn't know and it was to save the people of the Walls—it hit hard before his composure returned. Because everyone else was likely experiencing the same feeling, being shaken to the core, and needed him to be the picture of the ever phlegmatic and self-assured commander. "Keep going," he told Ymir.

"Look, I can tell from your stricken faces what you're thinking, but don't let the guilt eat you up. You didn't know. Those sixty years I spent as a Titan..." Ymir's voice took on a haunted note. "It was like a never-ending nightmare. Trust me, you're showing them *mercy* by killing them."

"But if you were turned back, why can't they?" Petra asked.

"Only way to turn a Titan back into a human is by making it into a Titan-Shifter."

"How did you become a Shifter?" Armin asked.

"I ate one."

All eyes snapped to Eren. "No, that can't be!" There was a look of distress on his face. "I didn't eat anyone! How would I even become a Titan in the first place?" His mind answered that question as he said it.

Mikasa gasped. "The injection. The serum your father gave you. But that means..."

"Holy shit," Levi muttered.

"Your old man had to have been a Shifter," Ymir said. "There's no other way a normal human could have made it from the wall at the edge all the way inland, crossing Titan territory."

"Are you saying we're on an island?" Sasha gaped.

"The ocean," Armin said longingly. "It's closer than we thought."

"Yeah." She gave them a moment to process that before getting back to the subject. "Now you see the problem with killing the Titans."

"Yes." Hange frowned. "We're also weakening a barrier protecting us from the outside world."

"Who did you eat?" Erwin's eyes narrowed. "A friend of the Female, Armored, and Colossal Titan's I take it."

Ymir felt a pang of sadness. "Yeah. His name was Marcel."

"You know the identity of the Shifters, don't you?" Levi leaned forward.

"Who are they? Tell us," Christa encouraged.

"You might want to brace yourselves," Ymir warned.

The 104th crew was all sporting an *Oh shit, not this again* expression.

"The identities of the Colossal and Armored Titans are...Bert and Reiner."

Jaws hit the floor.

At first, they were robbed completely of words.

Denial and disbelief then broke out once again and they jumped to their feet.

"Reiner? Reiner fucking Braun? *That* Reiner?" Connie demanded incredulously. "Are you shitting me?!"

"No way. There's just no way." Sasha shook her head. "No, no, no! That's just—" But hadn't she thought the same about Annie? *Look how that turned out* .

Armin was the only one not blind-sided by the revelation. There was only a look of confirmation and acceptance on his face.

Mikasa couldn't even begin to wrap her head around it. *But he's always been there for us.* She shook her head. "How could he be..." There had to be a mistake.

"I would never have suspected him," Petra said in astonishment. *I've never even met him and I feel betrayed* .

Hange nodded, equally blown away. "Fuck, that's *not* what I was expecting."

Even Erwin couldn't hold back his shock. "He fooled everyone expertly." Absolutely none of his comrades had any clue or indication. The commander glanced at Armin. Or maybe not. The boy was being oddly silent while everyone else was verbal in their surprise.

"What you'd expect from a perfect spy," Levi muttered. *And the other one, he flew under the radar, too. Acting like some shy, mild-mannered boy* .

"That son of a bitch!" A vein pulsed in Eren's forehead. "How the fuck could he act all friendly like that with us? How? With me! After listening about the shit we went through, knowing it was their fault they still—" Eren was too choked up with fury to finish.

"First Eren. Then Annie. Now Bert and Reiner." That was four graduates from the top five in their class. "Mikasa, you're not secretly a Titan-Shifter too, are you?" Jean was only half joking.

Mikasa knew it was a rhetorical question but still felt compelled to answer. " *No* ."

"I never imagined he would turn out to be a traitor." And here Historia thought she was the expert when it came to deception and hiding behind a mask.

Tears stung Eren's eyes, the knowledge of the betrayal making his chest constrict. "All that time he spent trying to be our friend, acting like everyone's big brother... That's even worse than Annie."

His words were met with nods and frowns.

"At least she never tried worming her way into our hearts," Jean said angrily. "Acting like a hero, going on like we were all pals and he didn't play a part in the massacre that destroyed so many of lives and ripped apart families."

"He's despicable," Mikasa spat out.

Petra shook her head. "What kind of sick person does that?"

"Did you know?" Erwin's voice had everyone turning to Armin. "Or I should say, when did you suspect."

"Armin?" Mikasa turned to him.

"I've been suspecting them since the episode the Female Titan showed up in," Armin confessed, "Reiner, at least, for being the

Armored Titan. Then Bert I wondered by association and it made sense."

"I want to hear your reasoning," Erwin requested.

"Well, I wasn't one hundred percent positive about it so I kept quiet. Especially after revealing my theory about Annie had already caused so much dissent."

"Armin, what are you saying?" Eren asked.

He sighed. "Remember how everyone was given different info regarding your position in the expedition?" His best friend nodded. "The Female Titan came from the right flank. Where Reiner was told you and your squad were."

"You're right." Hange was flipping between her notes. "She doesn't head in the right direction until after running into you guys." Her eyes widened. "That means at that time..."

"Yes. Reiner told her where I deduced you would have placed Eren. He carved it into her hand when she 'caught' him after he tried to kill her."

"She wasn't shocked he managed to hurt her." Petra's eyes widened. "She was reading the message he left her!"

"Exactly."

"Then you were spared for Reiner's sake," Levi said thoughtfully. "After her violent and absolute slaughter of all the other squads she ran into, we'd suspect him immediately had he been the only one to survive."

Armin nodded. "I thought that, too."

"Come to think of it," Jean said, deep in thought. "When Eren transformed to save himself and Mikasa and Armin from that idiot Garrison captain, everyone else stood around confused while they

ran towards the explosion. I didn't think much of it at the time, but when we were watching it on TV, it stood out because Annie was all about survival and Bert always came off as meek and a little cowardly. It struck me as weird because they didn't hesitate to run straight towards the explosion."

"Their physical features," Hange said. "Eren and Annie's Titans look like them. And the Armored and the Colossal, they look like Reiner and Bert."

Everyone paused to imagine that.

"They also argued to protect Eren—or his Titan, I should say—when those Titans were eating him. Because then whoever had consumed Eren would have regained their human form," Armin explained.

"They wanted us to remain ignorant," Sasha said.

Ymir interrupted. "You regain the memories of the person you eat. That was their primary reason."

They finally seemed to remember she was there.

"If we could get back to what I was saying..." If they hopped on the hate train it'd be near impossible to get them to listen.

The group quieted at once. Each one of them was desperate to know, to understand the reasons. What could justify everything that had happened?

Ymir took a second to recall where she'd left off. "My Titan-self found them while they were camping, on their way to the Walls, and Marcel sacrificed his life to save Reiner. They became frightened and ran. After that, I snuck into Sina, surviving as a thief before joining the military in order to ensure my survival. Then I got roped into joining the idiot division with the highest mortality rate," she snorted.

The explanation Ymir had offered wasn't a complete lie. But she was not about to disclose the specific reason for joining the military. Christa would only reject her identity. Especially now when everyone was so upset about friends lying about their real selves. And Ymir felt it wasn't her secret to tell.

"Why did you keep silent until now?" Levi asked.

"Because I was a beggar, I was no one. I didn't even have a name until that man came along. When the authorities got wind of an Eldian girl being paraded around as Ymir Fritz, we were all arrested. They pointed fingers at me. Placed all the blame on my shoulders saying I lied and tricked them. That I was the mastermind."

There were looks of anger or sympathy on their faces and it felt nice seeing them feel that way on her behalf.

"I just thought *Fuck 'em all.* I would take this name they gave me and wear it proudly. I did what the cult wanted me to, acted how they wanted me to act and parroted things they wanted to hear. And they turned on me. Tried to throw me to the wolves to save their own asses. I decided to take pride in my name, regardless of what anyone thought. From then on, I was done trying to please everyone. I was *done* being a puppet to further everyone else's agenda. I was only going to live for myself. If I had told you the truth when I first came here—well, first of all, I'd be silenced by some shadowy Military Police squad. Or I'd get stuck as your weapon. Again my life would have ceased to be my own. So I kept my mouth shut and lived every day with the choices I made."

It wasn't difficult understanding her motives.

Still, a part of them had wished she would have come clean sooner. She could have made such a big difference. So many lives could have been saved.

But knowing how they reacted to Eren... Mikasa thought maybe it was for the best a Titan-Shifter from the outside world, holding all the

knowledge the Royal Government was desperate to keep secret, kept her head down and stayed in the shadows.

"I also felt indebted to them," Ymir admitted. "If it hadn't been for their friend, I would have spent who knows how long in that miserable existence. I guessed it compelled me not to expose them, as a small token of my gratitude and guilt."

"That means they know there's another Titan-Shifter here. Do they know it's you?" Christa asked.

"No. I don't think they have any idea."

"I wonder," Hange began slowly, "we know Titans don't actually need to eat humans. Is the impulse something subconscious? Maybe they're acting on a deep instinct to return to their human form." She could sense the atmosphere in the room shift at her words. "But they can't unless the person they eat is a Titan-Shifter. So they just keep going gluttonously."

"Is that why they tried to cannibalize Eren at the Battle for Trost?" Mikasa thought out loud. "And the Female Titan in the Forest of Giant Trees?"

"It's a theory."

"You said we're on an island," Jean spoke up. "If you were captured by the Marley Police—the authorities, whoever—how did you get here from your country?"

"By receiving the worst punishment the Marleyans have for Eldian criminals: turned into Pure Titans and left to roam in an endless purgatory." An unconscious shiver went through Ymir.

"That's where the Titans are coming from?" Christa said in horror.

"That's so cruel," Petra said.

Ymir shrugged. "Committing atrocities is easy for people when they see you as less than human."

"What did the Eldians ever do to deserve such treatment?" Sasha asked.

"The Eldian empire was built upon slaughter and bloodshed. The Subjects of Ymir used Titans to decimate large populations and raze the lands and take it all for themselves. The Eldian Empire was founded on extreme destruction. Eventually the fighting turned inward and they destabilized. The Marleyans overthrew them with the help of a sympathetic Eldian family who still holds the power of the War Hammer Titan. The Eldian King took as many of his subjects as he could and moved them here, on this island, a hundred years ago."

"So it's just one long, endless bloody war that's been waged for a century?" Armin said. That was what this was all about. "We just didn't know about it."

"It's not just about annihilating a group that oppressed them—not unlike how they're now oppressing Eldians. This island is also full of resources you can't find anywhere else. Iron bamboo and iceburst stone, for example. But like I said earlier, I grew up poor and uneducated." Ymir shrugged. "Later I was put on a pedestal and kept ignorant so I'm sure my information is lacking or not totally right."

"So they want to kill us and take our resources and land like our ancestors did," Connie concluded succinctly.

"Yup." Ymir could tell they weren't quite sure how to take it.

On one hand, they could understand the desire for vengeance. And the motive of human greed was a familiar one. On the other hand, how could they be held accountable for something they hadn't even been born to witness much less take a part in?

We can stew over the philosophy later. Erwin thought. "What are the other Titan-Shifters?"

"There are five on this island including me. There's a noncombatant type, I think. And the War Hammer Titan, passed down the Tybur family, is the most famous in Marley so even I know about it. Not sure about the other two. I don't have all of Marcel's memories. It's a mess." Her fingers brushed her forehead. "I think it's easier between blood relatives so they try to keep Shifters in the family. Easier for the successor to access the previous Shifter's memories that way."

It brought the attention back to Grisha. "So this entire time, Dad knew." Eren's brow furrowed. "I've been getting headaches and weird feelings watching the episodes, does that mean..."

"I experienced the same thing before my memories came back," Ymir said.

"This is good," Armin said hopefully. "If they're being unlocked, we should know everything your dad knew."

"Is there any way to make it go faster?" Levi asked.

"I don't know. Maybe."

"What else can you tell us?" Erwin leaned forward. "What about other countries?"

Ymir told them what little she knew. "There are many Asians still alive," she said, glancing at Mikasa, "you're not the last one."

"That's great, isn't it?" Eren smiled. *Finally, some good news.*

"Yeah." It made Mikasa eager to learn more about them. Her mother's people. Maybe it'd help fill the hole her parents' death had left in her just a little.

"The Eldians in Marley," Ymir began somberly, "they're treated horribly. They're branded like animals, forced to wear armbands

identifying them as Eldians, and forced to live in a segregated area the Marley government confines them to. They're used and disposed of by the military in their wars. The civilians face constant discrimination daily. It's a sad way of being forced to live."

Somehow Levi didn't feel at all surprised to hear what Ymir was saying. Growing up in the Underground, he knew too well the kinds of things humans were capable of doing to each other. He was sure if they asked her for some examples of the treatment Eldians received, it'd make their stomachs turn.

They don't feel all that different from us . Petra thought. Trapped in place with no better future in sight. *No, they have it worse than us.* Aside from some entitled assholes who believed those from the outer Walls were inferior, everyone here was considered pretty much equal.

"Our entire lives we were raised to think of ourselves as *less* . Everyone is told that you, the inhabitants of this island, are filthy devils."

Jean rubbed his face. *This is such a fucking nightmare* . Just when he thought they knew everything, an even uglier truth was revealed.

"You think you're the good guys, they think they're the good guys. Everyone always thinks *they're* the good guys and the opposition is bad. That's how war works."

The room was dead silent as they took in her words.

There was no such thing as good guys and bad guys. Erwin thought everyone was a different level of "bad." Some were worse than others. Like Armin had told Annie, it was subjective, depending on who you asked.

"I know this doesn't excuse the actions taken by Reiner, Annie, and Bert, but I hope it gives you a little insight. They're not monsters. They're not evil. They're just soldiers following orders, like you. They

were raised hating you all like you were raising hating Titans, and given this mission to help out their people because they grew up fearing you and it was ingrained in their heads you're a threat to the entire world."

Christa's heart fell. *They were so much easier to hate before* . As much as she, and the others, had been burning to understand their motivations, it was making it hard now.

"And being a Titan-Shifter is the only thing that can bring Eldian families some honor. It's the only reason they would be treated decently by Marleyans. So it's a source of pride. The only pride Eldians are afforded."

This is making my head hurt. Connie felt overwhelmed. It had hurt beyond words, their friends' betrayal. But he had gotten over it. He had hated them for it and all the tears and pain they'd caused. Now he knew this. How was he supposed to feel about everything now?

Sasha couldn't help but think again about her harsh feelings regarding the refugees and how they were taking up her and her people's resources. And they were still her own people. It was easy to see how the Marleyans could feel hostility about the people of the Walls. How easy it would be to manipulate them against those they knew nothing about.

"Everyone's a hero in their own story," Armin said quietly.

"That's right. You found it easy to despise those three because you didn't understand them. I'm with you whatever you decide to do with them." Ymir's gaze shifted to the commander. "But I just hope you keep my words in mind."

That went pretty well I think . Ymir stared at her reflection in the mirror. He words had everyone thinking. And no one had condemned

her for keeping her mouth shut so long about her Shifter status. Or the other three's. When she stepped out of the restroom, Hange was on her immediately. "What is your Titan called? How big is it? Does it have female genitals? What unique abilities does it have?"

Eren and Petra were waiting with her. "Tell me everything about being a Titan-Shifter," he said.

"We only have a few days before the 57th Expedition, so you'll be staying with our squad and training with us. Especially Eren," Petra said.

"Can you do multiple transformations in a row?" Hange fired off question one after another. If she immersed herself fully in studying Ymir, she wouldn't have to think about Sonny and Bean. "How many? What kind of training exercises did you—"

"Okay, okay," Ymir said, feeling a little ambushed. At least they weren't glaring at her or looked like they didn't trust her. *Thank you, Candy* .

"Hange," Erwin called the woman over.

"Aw," Hange pouted. "Here." She handed the notebook and pen to Petra. "Write down everything."

Ymir leaned against the wall, arms crossed. "Fine, let me see..."

Hange plopped down between Levi and Erwin. "What'd you wanna talk about? Who we should tell this little secret to?"

"Pixis is the first and obvious choice. Maybe Zackly. But that's not what it's about," Levi said. "We can hold off on that until after the second season. Might give us more info about them. Or anyone else we can trust."

"I've been thinking," Erwin said, "about how we could get a third Shifter on our side."

Hange perked up. "Oh? What'd you have in mind?"

"Well, if we deviate too much during the 57th Expedition and the mission afterward in Stohess that we saw on TV, then most of our knowledge of the future will become obsolete. Which means we can't go after the Armored or Colossal Shifters yet."

"Yes." Hange nodded.

"We also know now how a Titan-Shifter is created. Grisha Yeager turned his son into a Titan and had Eren eat him. Which means he must have the formula, or notes about it, in the basement of his house."

Realization dawned on Hange's face. "I see. We can get our hands on some of that serum if there is any. Or replicate it somehow if Eren's dad left any clues. Then we can turn one of our own people into the new Female Titan-Shifter."

"If we do that, maybe we can get better information on the enemy without resorting to unpleasant means." Levi didn't need to clarify what *unpleasant means* meant. "It's easier to access memories if they're related, but maybe the new Shifter could learn new things Ymir doesn't remember yet."

Before Ymir's explanation, Hange might have thought a quick painless death like that too good for Annie. "It's a good plan." Her mind raced. "We can try to seek allies. Use the resources we have that everyone wants." If there was one thing humans could be relied on, it was their greed. "But that can come later. One thing at a time. Do you have anyone particular in mind to become our new Shifter?"

"Sasha or Christa," Erwin answered. "We don't know if Leonhart's Titan can only be passed to females but best not to take any chances."

"Ymir is obviously out because why have only two Titan-Shifters fighting for us when we can have three," Levi pointed out. Much as

he disliked the thought of lives being wasted, he had to be pragmatic. Even if they weren't planning to go to war with Marley—which was something that went beyond even Zackly, the monarch needed to be involved for it to happen—they still needed to be able to defend themselves. The Marleyans had hated them and tried for a hundred years—and were still actively trying—to eliminate them. They needed all the power and protection they could get. Which meant they needed another Shifter on their side.

"Neither Sasha nor Christa possess any particular talents that would be wasted if one of them were to become a Shifter," Erwin explained. "They don't have your intellect, Hange, or Petra's and Mikasa's battle skills. This way we can utilize everyone's talents efficiently."

"Now the question is," Hange said, looking over at the two girls, "which one of them will become our Female Titan."

"I gotta say, it's pretty disheartening knowing what the world thinks of us," Jean said. Ymir's words were fucking up everything he thought and confusing him. "And Reiner and Annie and Bert..." He shook his head. "I don't even know what to think about that."

"I think Ymir is right," Christa spoke up. "They're not all evil. But they're still our enemy. We're not wrong to defend ourselves against their assault. But it'll serve us well to remember they're human, too. Blindly hating them is useless. Instead we'll be hurting ourselves. I think it's right to understand our enemies. Otherwise we'll be no different from the Marleyans."

Armin smiled. "That was well put, Christa. I just wish there was a way we could resolve this without any more violence." He still couldn't help but feel bad about what the officers were likely planning for the Marleyan trio. Especially Annie. He knew Reiner and Bert were untouchable right now because any interference there could cause the whole future to change dramatically and it would spiral out of their control. Annie's future they already knew so her fate was pretty much sealed.

"I know what you're thinking," Mikasa said, pulling Armin out of his thoughts. "You still feel bad for them."

He hung his head in shame. "I'm sorry. I know their actions put you and Eren directly through hell—"

"It's okay. I'm not judging," she assured him. It took a kind of strength to feel empathy for people who wronged you.

"If only they could join us," Connie, who hadn't been paying attention, said. "Never mind. I take that back," he said quickly.

But Jean had already started. "And say what? 'Hey, we know you guys did a lot of unspeakable things, things we're sure you're not proud of, all for the sake of your friends and family, your country. But we forgive you for all the death and destruction you've caused! Now forget about your loved ones you did all this shit for and come join our side!' Get real, Connie, would you abandon your family for strangers? Even if you knew they were good people."

"And even if you managed to do that," Armin said, "won't their families be punished for treason? Or what if they decide to play us and only act like they've had a change of heart?" Just because he still felt for them, didn't mean he would allow his feelings to cloud his better judgment.

"Would you really be able to trust someone who could stab their own people in the back?" Christa added.

"They might betray us again when they're confronted with their people even if they do truly switch sides," Mikasa said. "Ymir said Eldians are used in war because they're considered disposable, so Reiner and the others will have to kill those they grew up with, their friends and family. All that for our sake? People they've known for all of three years?"

"I know, I know, I know! It was a dumb and naive thing to say," Connie said in frustration. "I just wish we could go back to when we

were all friends, there was only one side, the humans, and Titans were only monsters."

"That's not how the world is now," Christa said in resignation. "We either kill or get killed."

"Fight to win?" Sasha offered with a small smile that Mikasa returned.

"Still, gotta agree with Baldy. I liked it better when humans were on the verge of extinction," Jean said longingly. "Those were the days."

The other murmured in amused agreement.

Erwin had taken Ymir's spot in front of the group, hands folded behind him. "I would like to thank Ymir for stepping forward and telling us everything. I'm sure it wasn't easy for her." His eyes landed on her and she nodded. "And I'm sure everyone's still reeling from everything we've learned today, in the last half hour especially. We were given a lot to think about. What was once a black and white situation has become shades of gray."

The Scouts nodded grimly back at him.

"The truth about what we're up against is terrifying. It's a daunting situation. More than that, it'll also a complicated situation. It's not what you signed up for but this is the situation now. We're under attack and we must defend ourselves. The enemy has the numbers, the Titan-Shifters, technology more advanced than ours, including weapons, meanwhile the rest of our people think there's no human threat out there."

"I completely forgot about that."

"Shit, you're right."

"No one else on this island knows what we're really facing."

How could they mount a proper defense like that?

"And we must keep it that way," Erwin said strongly. "We cannot risk this information getting into the wrong hands. Recent revelations has made it clear not everyone we trust is trustworthy."

Their faces fell, Bert and Reiner's faces coming to mind.

"I'd also like everyone to think about this. We walked into this room with one Titan-Shifter, ignorant and ill-prepared. We'll be leaving with two Titan-Shifters, new knowledge, and the ability to control the future. So do not lose hope. Don't feel overwhelmed. We're very much in this fight and we can still win."

That had the effect Erwin had intended and the group lightened up.

"And the biggest thing we should all remember is..." The commander smiled. "...we have Candy."

Never had such an absurd phrase ever inspired such hope and determination.

The group broke out into cheers, laughing and clapping.

That's the stupidest thing I've ever heard. Levi rolled his eyes, but couldn't fight back a smile.

I don't know how someone with Internet access could not know this but, the time of day is different depending on where you live. So if you live in a different **TIME ZONE** than me, this story will update at a different time for you. Because I'm going according to *my* calendar and clock, not *yours* . It's on my profile I'm in the U.S. (west coast). Adjust your own expectations accordingly.

Thank you to everyone else for all your support and understanding and patience! YOU guys are what really keep this story going! Give yourself a cookie!

Please Review~

Episode - Ilse's Notebook

Chapter 29: Ilse's Notebook

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Ymir tells the group she's a Titan-Shifter and about the world.

After using the facilities, and snacking and rehydrating, plus another few minutes of chatter and amazed looks at Ymir—which she pointedly ignored—the group was finally ready, settled in, and considerably more relaxed and ready for an episode.

" In the year 845…" Candy began.

Little Eren, Mikasa, and Armin stood with a crowd.

"It's been a while since we've had this opening," Connie said.

"It's kinda nice," Christa replied. It was familiar and comforting. She was glad for the break after all they had learned. She ignored her own truth. *I'm no one. I'm unimportant* .

"… due to the sudden appearance of the Colossal and Armored Titan, daily lives of the humans in the Walls crumbled along with the Wall."

The Colossal was peering over the Wall, the Armored had broken through the gate, and the Smiling Titan ate Carla.

" Stop!" Eren cried out, being carried over Hannes's shoulder.

Lips pressed together, they stared grimly at the TV.

A map of the Walls appeared, surrounded by Titans. *"Humanity abandoned Wall Maria, lost twenty percent of its population, and a third of its territory…"*

Despite everything they had learned, it was hard not to feel a deep ache at the loss and a rush of anger as a result.

A Garrison soldier stood on a building, watching Titans enter through the hole. *"…and were confined behind Wall Rose in one moment."* The Survey Corps flag appeared. *"However, humanity had not lost to the Titans just yet."* A regiment of Scouts roared, swords raised.

They smiled. It quickly disappeared when they remembered exactly they were going out to kill.

No, Ymir said they're suffering. Hange told herself there was nothing to be done.

Everyone else told themselves the same thing.

***" The Garrison was tasked with guarding the Walls…"* The Walls were fortified with cannons. *"…and young recruits were being trained in techniques and knowledge to fight with Titans.* " Eren stood with other trainees. In the next scene, he was slicing the nape of a dummy Titan. Jean appeared next, sparring, surrounded by fellow trainees.**

To think we were trainees only a month ago. Eren felt so much older. *It's like being in this room has added a year to me.*

He wasn't the only one thinking that. "That feels so long ago," Sasha muttered. Had it really only been a month?

"Feels like it's been forever," Christa nodded.

" Around that time…"

[Year 850]

"… the soldiers of the elite Survey Corps were attempting, once again, to set foot into territory of the Titans via the Trost District."

The soldiers waited at the foot of the gate.

"So this is before the Battle for Trost. The Scouts are going to a mission while we're still trainees," Jean said interestedly.

Curious, the recruits leaned forward. Having, at least second-hand, experienced only one expedition—a rather disastrous one—they wanted to know what a normal venture beyond the Walls looked like.

The bell rang. "Thirty seconds until the gates are opened!" Erwin said loudly. "All personnel, prepare to depart!"

" Geez," Hange groaned, leaning her head back. She was on her horse between Levi and Mike. "I'm tired of waiting. Hey, Levi—"

" No."

" I haven't said anything yet."

" You want me to help capture a Titan with you, right? That's a waste of effort. I'll have no part in it."

Hange looked to her left. "What about you, Mike? Want to give it a go?" Mike just grunted. She sighed, smiling to herself. "The same old boring answer from the same old boring men."

" The 49th Expedition beyond the Walls begins now! Forward!"

Hange couldn't smother her squeal. No one batted an eyelash at her excitement, assuming it had something to do with Titans.

Huh , Levi thought, *what do you know.* He glanced at Ymir then Hange.

"Yes, yes, yes," the scientist cheered under breath.

"You were right," Erwin said.

"I can't wait to see their faces," Hange gushed. Candy had told them the extra episodes would help the group better understand one another. Two of the five had been about Levi. The only other most mysterious person in the room was Ymir. And after her reveal, Hange had wondered if one of the episodes might have something to do with their newest Titan-Shifter.

She had begged Levi and Erwin not to mention the expedition, eager to see their reactions to the contents of Ilse's notebook. And she was right. The episode was about the 49th Expedition. *I can't wait to see how they'll react!* This was going to be so fun.

The horses charged. The Survey Corps had left the Walls, Erwin in the lead. Then Hange raced past him, cheering.

The group burst into laughter at Erwin's gasp as Hange left him in the dust.

" Hange!"

" All you Titans out there," her cheeks were red as she gushed, "I'm on my way to meet you!"

It was a hilly area covered with green grass and a forest in the distance. There were abandoned houses behind a Scout keeping watching while a few more raced somewhere on their horses. Nearby, soldiers were unloading the carts, pulling out

supplies including cylinders as large a man to refill their gas tanks.

Hange's voice came from inside a tent. "Think about it, Erwin!" She slammed her hands on the table.

The commander stood, reading a clipboard, with two other men beside him as Moblit stood nervously behind his squad leader.

" I understand that setting up supply bases takes priory, but uncovering the true nature of the Titans has always been our primary objective!"

Can't say a part of me doesn't regret knowing . Mikasa thought. Out of everyone in the room, with the exception of Levi and Petra, she had probably contributed to the most Titan deaths. Eren hadn't been fully conscious while he had raged in his Titan form so she didn't count him.

" I'm sure you're aware of that!" Hange glared.

" Squad Leader…" Moblit began. "It's probably not a good idea to talk to the commander in that tone—"

" Shut the hell up!" She snapped at him. "We need to capture a Titan alive above all else! I know that it seems impossible. After all, the last time we took one alive was more than fifteen years ago, and more than twenty people died in order to pull it off."

"Wait, really?" Christa looked astonished. "That seems like a lot."

"It might. But you have to remember," Erwin said, "this was before we had soldiers like Mike and Hange and Squad Levi. There have been some improvements in the gear too since then. Not too significant but still. And you are, undoubtedly, the most impressive class to ever graduate so it may seem like a lot to you."

The younger Scouts beamed at his praise.

"Don't discount yourself, Commander. You're the only who came up with the strategy to use flare guns to greatly reduce mortality rates," Petra pointed out.

The recruits nodded and chimed in, and Erwin took the compliments with a humble smile.

" But we cannot get any intel if we are afraid of making sacrifices!"

" So, pay extra attention to our offenses and defenses," Erwin told one of the men, completely ignoring Hange.

" Understood," he nodded and left.

" Do we really have to go through this again?" Erwin said to Hange. "We don't have the manpower to spare for a capture mission. Even getting this far cost us far more than ten men."

" I know that, but—"

" Hange." The commander's expression said it all before he said the actual words. "Your proposal is rejected."

" Hey," she ran after him. Outside the tent, Petra knelt on the ground, checking her gear, while Oluo stood with his arms crossed. "Wait, Erwin!"

"She's persistent. And brave." Connie would have shut up and shrunk in his spot after being on the receiving end of that stern glare.

" It's no use, Hange," Oluo said.

"Oh no, this guy..." Armin said. "He's gonna run his mouth."

" We put our lines on the line just trying to kill the damn things. There's no way we can take one alive."

Suddenly, Hange grabbed his collar while Moblit and Petra's mouths fell. "Think about *this* , Oluo. Let's say Levi's coming and dead set on killing you. What would you do?"

"Hide behind Mikasa!" Connie blurted out.

The group burst out into laughter. Hange especially laughed the loudest.

Mikasa shrugged, playing along, "Go ahead."

"I'd play dead!" Sasha said.

And it turned into a game.

Jean crossed his arms, "I'd try and bribe him with something he likes."

"That's smart," Armin nodded. "I might do that, too."

"I'd make a mess and hope he gets distracted long enough for me to run away and hide," Petra said, making them chuckle.

With a good-natured smile, Erwin considered that and said, "Might work."

"But it's only good if you're fast and good at hiding, otherwise he's even more pissed now," Ymir said.

"Ooh, good point," Petra said.

"I would point out someone he hates even more," Eren shrugged.

"That's smart, too," Christa said.

"If you're *done* ," Levi interrupted, rolling his eyes, not letting his amusement show.

" Can you fight him and survive?"

" Of course not!" Oluo rasped out. "Hey, I can't breathe."

" Want me to tell you how you can win that fight?"

That grabbed the recruits' attention.

There was a hint of madness in Hange's eyes. "You do your homework. The place he works, the food he hates, his taste in women, the number of times he takes a piss… You find out everything you can about him."

"So basically, stalk your prey!" Hange declared. "Learning everything and go for the jugular!"

"It was kinda like what we had in mind," Sasha said.

Oluo was lifted so far he was balancing on his toes.

" Once you know him, you can find a weakness that you can exploit. If you don't do that before you fight, you will die for sure."

" Hange!" Petra said.

" Squad Leader, you're going to too far!" Moblit said.

Hange exhaled, and let Oluo go and he fell to the ground, "Ah, my bad," she said with levity. He massaged his neck while she walked away. "But you get my point, right?"

" Squad Leader!" Moblit chased after her.

" Fuck, she damn near killed me," Oluo glared. "That bitch is insane. She belongs in a nuthouse."

"You poke an agitated bear with a stick, you better be prepared for what comes next," Petra said.

Petra huffed irritability. "You know," she placed her hands on her hips, "you're a part of the Survey Corps, so could you do something about that barbaric way of speaking?"

" Huh? Why do *I* get a lecture?"

"Like you said, she's crazy. You don't mess with crazy," Connie wagged a finger.

Erd walked up the stone steps beside them, "Petra, are you done restocking?"

" Y-Yes, Erd! I'm almost done!"

On the small building next to them, Mike stood on the roof, eating. Suddenly, he began sniffing and moved to the other side of the roof. He focused on the forest and sniffed again, one hand reaching behind him to grab his flare gun.

In the forest treetops, birds took off and a tree tilted over. A shot went out and grabbed Erwin's attention.

" There's movement in the forest!" Mike yelled, red smoke billowing behind him.

Would they get to see him fight? They had yet to see the Survey Corps second best soldier in combat.

Soldiers started running as Erwin ordered, "All personnel, prepare for combat!"

" Squad Leader," Moblit's voice was heard, "it's too dangerous to go alone!"

"This poor guy," Jean shook his head. "How does he deal with her?"

"He drinks," Peta replied.

"Understandable," Mikasa nodded.

Erwin looked to see Hange jump up on her horse. "Erwin! I'm going ahead!" She declared as she raced away.

"I had a feeling she was going to do that," Eren said.

" Hange, wait!" Erwin called out after her but she kept going. "Levi!"

" That idiot," Levi grumbled, on his horse. He yanked the reins and went after her.

Inside the forest, Hange's horse ran toward the Titan. "Oh, found ya!" It was blond-haired and blue-eyed, approximately six meters in height. Growling, it watched her pass by. "Hey, there! Nice weather we're having, huh?"

The Titan came after her. Hange looked over her shoulder and laughed, "That's good."

Only Hange . Eren thought.

" Say, once we're done with our walk, wanna come inside the Wall with me? What do you say?"

The Titan attempted to snatch her and she dodged.

" That was close!" Hange's voice didn't hold a hint of fear. Rather, she sounded almost like she was having fun. Suddenly, the Titan ran into a tree. "Oh, no. Are you okay?"

The Titan, grunting loudly, came after her. Its shoulder hit a tree and it spun but continued to follow Hange.

Ymir felt something needling at the back of her mind. It was an old memory. She ignored the feeling, knowing that thinking about or focusing on it would only make it harder to grasp. It would come easier if she let it be.

" Come this way!" Hange left the forest and it crashed after her, quickly climbing to its feet and continuing the chase. "Atta boy."

A red flare suddenly flew diagonally in front of it and it stopped. "This way, moron," Levi said. The Titan's head followed Squad Levi.

" Hey, stay out of my way!" Hange yelled.

The Titan let them go and went after her instead. There was a strange look in its eye. And it began to fall behind.

" Huh? What?" Hange yanked her horse around.

The Titan looked around. Then it turned back and ran away.

" Hey, wait up!" She went after it. "Hey, where are you going?"

"Why do you keep asking it questions? It's not like it's gonna talk to you," Mikasa said. Though she figured that's just how Hange was.

Hange was reduced to giggles by Mikasa's words and confused looks were exchanged.

"What a weirdo," Jean said.

Squad Levi went in after them. "What's that shit-face up to? Is it running back home?" Oluo bit his tongue.

"You'd think this guy would learn," Ymir shook her head.

"I'm surprised he hasn't bitten it clean off already," Eren said.

" Even if it's an Aberrant, there's something strange about it," Petra said.

" Yeah," Erd agreed, "its movement patterns are like nothing that has ever been reported."

" No," Gunther said, "they're called 'Aberrants' *because* they don't behave normally, right?"

The group nodded.

" I couldn't care less." Levi pulled out a sword. "We're taking it down here."

The Titan ran with an almost distracted look on its face, Hange right behind him. "Hey," she said, "wait up!" It weaved through the trees.

"Is it just me or does it look like it's going somewhere specific?" Christa glanced around.

"There's almost a purpose to its movements," Armin observed.

Is it heading toward a specific place?* Hange thought. *Even if it is an Aberrant, can a Titan do something like that?

Now their curiosity was piqued.

Hange followed the Titan into a clearing. It was a circular area full of dark green grass and white flowers, surrounded by trees. Toward the other end of the clearing was a lone tree. The Titan was staring into it. The 6-meter seemed rather emotional at whatever it was staring at.

"What is she doing?" Ymir muttered without thinking.

"Am I crazy or does it look like it's making facial expression?" Sasha asked.

"I was thinking the same thing," Eren frowned.

Suddenly, the Titan began ramming its head into the tree. "What?" Hange dismounted. "What's wrong?" She took out a hand bar but there was no blade. "What are you doing?"

No blade. She doesn't want to kill it but now she can dodge if it attacks. Mikasa thought.

" Is this the place you wanted to go?" Hange took hesitant steps forward. The Titan launched itself at her, trying to stamp her out with its hand. "Whoa," she retreated to the top of a nearby tree, "that was close!"

The Titan was gritting its teeth, looking angry and frustrated.

"See!" Sasha pointed. "There it goes again!"

Hange landed on the ground. "What is it? What's wrong?" She approached it slowly. "I'll hear you out."

A hook pierced the Titan's exposed nape. Oluo appeared behind it, swords ready to slice. "I've got this!"

" Oluo, don't do it!"

"Don't distract someone in the middle of battle," Christa's words rang out in alarm.

Oluo stopped at her words, "Huh?"

The 6-meter took the opportunity to grab him and Oluo freaked out, screaming, legs flailing wildly as he was caught firmly in the Titan's hand.

They flinched unconsciously, before remembering he'd make it.

In the blink of an eye, Levi severed the Titan's arm before quickly taking out the nape.

This never gets old . Eren thought, grinning.

Jean was having similar thoughts. *I could watch Corporal Levi take out Titans all day.*

When they remembered the reality of the Titans' true origin, the smiles fell. It seemed less entertaining now. Somehow, it didn't feel right deriving any sort of amusement from it.

A chunk of flesh flew up and the Titan tilted to the side before it fell on its back while Hange watched.

C'mon . Ymir still felt that intangible itch in the back of her mind. *I almost had it.*

Erwin watched the frown deepening on her face. *She hasn't figured it out yet* .

Levi started cleaning the steaming blood from his handle with a cloth and glanced at Oluo. "You okay?"

" Captain…" Oluo lay in the Titan's hand, tears down his cheeks, snot leaking from his nose, and a line of saliva dripping from his mouth. He sniffed, "I'll follow your orders forever!"

Oluo's words reduced them to giggles.

" This child was to be…an important specimen." Hange fell to her knees by the steaming corpse." Levi put his swords away. "If we could have captured him, humanity might have taken the next step forward."

Levi walked to her and grabbed her collar, glaring down at her, "Shut up, your four-eyed bitch! If you want to end up as Titan shit, I won't stop you. But don't you dare endanger the lives of my men!"

Saw that coming. Jean thought. Even though he agreed with Hange, there was a proper way to go about it. *One that doesn't get soldiers unnecessarily killed* .

Hange stared, mouth open, before offering: "Titans don't defecate."

The group couldn't help but snicker.

"I don't believe this," Armin said, gaping.

Levi couldn't seem to believe it either.

His look of disbelief sent them into laughter.

She really is crazy! Connie thought. *No sane person would say that to Corporal Levi in response to what just happened* .

" They don't have a digestive system."

Sometimes, I wonder how her brain works. Erwin shook his head, smiling slightly.

Gritting his teeth, Levi shoved her back with a disgusted sound.

Petra, who had been watching the scene in silence, looked down before shifting her gaze. Something grabbed her attention. "Um, Captain…" She spoke up, unease clear in her voice.

" What is it?" Levi looked up to see her step back.

Curiosity had the recruits leaning forward.

"What?" Eren glanced between Petra and the TV. "What is it?"

"You'll see."

" Did a Titan do that?" Petra had her hands together, over her chest. "But… It *can't* be…"

Now Christa really wanted to know. " *What* can't be?"

What did the Titan do? Sasha wondered.

" What are you talking about?" Levi asked.

Petra pointed to the tree the Titan had been bashing its head against.

They squinted, trying to get a better look.

There was a hollow space in the tree where a headless body had been placed in a sitting position.

Connie's scared shitless look mimicked Oluo's on screen, face going almost gray. "Dude, what the fuck!"

"Is there a person without a head?" Sasha shuddered

Jean looked a bit freaked out. "That's fucking creepy."

"Did a Titan do that?" Mikasa unconsciously repeated Petra's words. "But that's doesn't make any sense."

"Why?" Eren mumbled. What was the point? Did the Titan bashing its head into that tree it have something to do with it?

Hange climbed up to inspect the decapitated body. She moved the cloak aside to looked at the insignia on jacket's side. "The emblem from the 34th Expedition. This soldier died a year ago. The soldier's name was… Let's see…"

Levi looked around and spotted something. It was a notebook, dirty, old, and brown.

" Ilse Langnar," she said as Levi picked up the notebook. "I can't believe it. Why would a Titan do such—" Hange noticed what was Levi was doing. "Levi, what's that?"

He flipped a page, looking amazed. "It's the fruit of Ilse Langnar's labor."

Variations of *What the fuck's going on?* went through the recruits' heads.

The notebook appeared against a black screen. Loud breathing was heard along with the sound of running. Ilse appeared, writing as she ran.

The veterans were immediately pulled into the scene.

"Is that her?" Petra gasped. "Will we actually see what happened?"

"I hope so!" Hange squealed happily. She really wanted to see a Titan talk.

" My name is Ilse Langnar,"* she narrated what she recorded in the notebook. *"I am part of the 34th Expedition beyond the Walls. Second Battalion, in charge of the perimeter defense."

A flashback appeared. In a small village, three Titans were eating Scouts. Wailing and sounds of pain were heard as the giants tore them apart. *"On our way back, we encountered some Titans."*

Ilse watched them eat her comrades, in a shallow stream nearby. She stood up and snuck away. *"I lost everyone in my squad, and even my horse."* She unclipped her equipment. *"My gear was damaged, so I had to leave it behind."*

With a panicked look, Ilse pulled out a small brown notebook from her breast pocket and began writing and the flashback ended.

In the distance, over her shoulder, the evening sun hovering, casting orange rays across the land. *"I am running due north."*

They watched in silence as one of everyone Survey Corps soldiers' worst nightmare played out before them. They had all considered this scenario before, imagining what they would do, what kinds of

challenges they would face, how they would beat the odds and survive.

But it was one thing pretending they would keep their wits around them and make it back alive, it was another to live through it. Would they really be able to do it?

The group was fascinated to see, to almost live vicariously through her, even knowing how it would end.

Hange was sitting at her desk, in front of a window. There was a small, lit candle, with a bookcase to her right. She kept reading. *"I have lost my horse in the lands ruled by the Titans."*

Back with Ilse, it was nighttime. *"No human can outrun a Titan on foot."* Rain poured down on her as she sat, hood pulled up, at the base of a tree. *"I have no comrades left to rely on."* Tears filled her eyes, slipping down her cheeks. *"My chances of returning to the city are despairingly low."*

"And she still has the willpower to keep moving," Mikasa said, impressed. It would have been so easy to just give up and hide away, losing hope.

Jean recalled the trainees who had hidden away, scared of the Titans that had invaded the supply room, abandoning their duty. *And here she is, facing worse odds, and still trying to do what she can for humanity* . Maybe it wasn't fair comparing them to a Scout. But he felt his respect rise for the woman.

" However, if I can avoid contact with the Titans, I might be able to reach the Wall."* The sun was setting directly behind her. *"That's right. Right now, I must not give in to fear."

A bright, full moon lit up the night sky and the forest below. *"I have been prepared for this scenario since the day I joined the Survey Corps."* Ilse was crouching, pen still moving across her

notebook. *"I am the wings of humanity, making its last stand. I am a member of the Survey Corps!"*

There was a rustling sound behind her and she looked over nervously.

" I will fight to the end, even if I end up dying! I have no weapons but I can still fight!" Ilse continued to make her way across the forest, passing by a small waterfall. "I will record my experiences on this paper, and do everything I can!"

Christa couldn't keep the look of awe from her face. If she died, she hoped she had half the courage the woman on the screen did and her death would carry meaning. That it would have an impact on the future.

" I will not give up!"* Ilse entered a clearing with white flowers. *"I will not…give up!"

Armin's heart fell. Despite knowing it was coming, he still couldn't hold back a disappointed slump of his shoulders.

Ilse passed by the lone tree in the clearing and time slowed as she looked up to see a 6-meter Titan hiding behind it.

The group sucked in their breaths.

A look of complete terror came across her face. The Titan lunged after her and she barely rolled away, still clutching her notebook and pen tightly.

"I don't want to see this," Sasha said sadly. But if she looked away, it would almost seem like an insult.

Ilse shook, whimpering slightly, back against the tree as the Titan growled on all fours in front of her. It was breathing deeply, its breath making her hair move. She cried, hand trembling, and said, "I will not…give up!" She continued to

write. *"I have encountered a Titan. It's a seven—no, six-meter class. It didn't attack me right away. Is it an Aberrant?"*

Ridiculous as it was, some of them were holding their breath, as if they dared breathe the Titan would attack her.

The Titan's nose was less half a foot away from her. *"This is the end of the line. This is as far as I go."* The 6-meter was on its toes, hands flat on the ground. *"I have lived a whimsical life. I haven't done anything for my parents yet! I feel sick! The end."*

" Ymir's…people," the Titan awkwardly managed to get the words out.

The mouths of all the recruits were on the floor now.

Even the veterans, who had been expecting it, were amazed.

"Did that thing just talk?"

"Everyone heard that, right?"

"What just happened?!"

"No, but it can't be a Shifter! That doesn't make any sense..."

Hange couldn't enjoy their reaction, too absorbed in the scene herself. *His voice is so sexy!* Her joy was dampened slightly by the knowledge the poor bastard was probably in misery.

The Titan backed up and Ilse stared wordlessly. *It just spoke.* Her hand seemed to move without her noticing. *"The Titan just spoke."* It was watching her now. *"No way."*

" Lady Ymir," it said reverently and bowed, head touching the ground. "Welcome."

"I see you've figured it out," Erwin paused the episode.

"Yeah," Ymir frowned. "She was one of my followers in the cult."

"Come to think of it, Ilse looks like you," Christa said. "The hair, the eyes, the skin, the freckles."

"So it mistook her for Ymir," Connie said.

"And you guys have known about it this entire time," Sasha looked over at the veteran couch.

"Yes. Imagine our surprise when we learn someone by the name of Ymir was invited," Erwin said. "We've been keeping an eye on you."

"Why didn't you say anything?" Ymir asked. She was extremely glad now to have told them everything. If she had been outed by this episode, it would have made earning their trust harder.

"We didn't know how Candy would've reacted to us confronting you. More importantly, we had hoped—correctly—that the TV would explain without us intervening. You did well to speak before we started this episode."

"Also, Four-Eyes wanted to see your reactions so she whined at us to keep quiet about it after you came clean," Levi said.

"But I missed it cause I was staring at the TV," Hange pouted.

" The Titan is speaking words that I can understand. 'Ymir's people.' 'Lady Ymir.' 'Welcome.' There's no doubt. This Titan is showing facial expressions. It appears to be showing respect to me." **Ilse wiped one side of her face.** ***I can't believe it! For the first time in the history of humanity, I'm conversing with a Titan?!***

"I'm so jealous!" Hange said dramatically. She was still fascinated by them, even if it wasn't the same level and type of obsession.

"If you want, I can transform and talk to you," Ymir offered, smirking. "Can't promise it'll be easy to understand—"

The scientist shrieked in delight, eyes practically sparkling, cheeks flushed, "Would you?!"

"Hey, Hange," Eren grinned, "I can give you a ride on my Titan's shoulder if you want!"

The screaming went up an octave.

"Shut the hell up, you two. My eardrums can't handle another horrid screech," Levi complained.

"I'm holding you two to that!" Hange pointed at them.

Ilse swallowed and asked hesitantly. "What…are you?" She wrote: *"I asked this Titan about his nature. Instead of talking, it is moaning."*

"Sounds like he—she in pain," Jean said.

"Maybe it needs to take a shit," Levi said.

"Connie, don't you dare start with the poop puns again," Eren spoke quickly when said boy opened his mouth, a mischievous smile on his face.

" Where did you come from?" Ilse asked and the Titan kept moaning. *"I asked for a location. He didn't respond."* Its body was trembling. "Why do you eat us?" Ilse asked in a louder voice. *"I ask him for a motive."*

The Titan was clutching its face, still moaning and shaking.

"Aw, poor baby," Hange cooed. "She's really hurting!"

Petra nodded, "She's crying."

"Do you think it's cause she's fighting the impulse to eat her?" Armin said nervously.

"Oh shit," Jean muttered, eyes widening.

" Why do you eat us?!" Ilse demanded angrily. "You don't even die if you eat anything!"

"No, no, no, no!" Sasha said worriedly, waving her hands. "Don't *yell* ."

" Why?!" Ilse screamed. "Go back to the nothing you came from! Disappear from this world!" She gasped when the Titan looked at her, fingers digging into its face.

She must have been one of the true believers. The ones who got conned. Ymir thought. If she didn't truly believe her to be Ymir Fritz, she would not be trying so hard not to eat this 'Ymir' before her.

" What's going on?"

The Titan ripped the skin below its eyes and blood spurted out.

They winced, some rubbing their faces at the tingling sensation.

Petra couldn't help but feel bad for the Titan. *She's trying so hard, to the point of self-mutilation, but it's a losing battle* .

Ilse ran while it continued to tear at its own skin. The Titan followed her with its eyes. She was breathing loudly as she sprinted away. "What are you doing?" She yelled, sprinting. "No good. It's chasing me."

The Titan lunged after her and caught her.

They all knew what was coming and felt pity for both human and Titan alike.

" No!" Ilse screamed. Her head was between its teeth now. "He has me between its teeth. I can feel its teeth upon my skull," tears kept pouring from her eyes as she spoke what she wrote, "like the pressure of a—"

A loud snap and her body went limp. And the notebook slipped from her lifeless fingers. The Titan appeared almost guilty, Ilse's blood covering its face.

Knowing it was going to happen didn't make it easier.

Silence filled the room, in shock and in respect for a fallen comrade.

Hange closed the notebook and leaned back, sighing. She contemplated in quiet. Then she started a letter. *"Erwin Smith. Subject: Resuming attempts by the Survey Corps to capture Titans alive. A glance through the enclosed notebook makes one thing clear."* The shot focused on Ilse's notebook. *"We are still ignorant about the Titans, I would say."*

We were very ignorant. Hange thought.

" The Titan that Ilse Langnar met spoke a recognizable language, and appeared to show her respect."

The scene returned to the 6-meter taking Ilse's body, her notebook remaining on the grass.

" Also, instead of consuming her body, the Titan stored it inside a hole in a tree. This seems to be a reasonable assumption."

The Titan sat before the tree and stared.

I would have peed myself if I was her. But she kept writing until the end . Sasha thought in wonder. It would have taken an inordinate amount of courage and resilience to stay dedicated to her duty while right at death's door.

" Although this is obvious, such a case is a first in all the history of humanity."

Erwin was reading a paper when someone entered his office. *"We have a responsibility to make use of the information Ilse gave us, recording it to the last moment of her life."* Hange placed a small stack of papers on his desk. With a salute, she turned and left.

" We cannot let the effort she put in toward finding some truth behind the Titans go to waste."

Eren nodded firmly. *Otherwise her death will have had no meaning.* They had a duty to honor their fallen comrades by continuing to move forward.

"Hey, wait," Christa began, "so when the Titan was beating her head against the tree, do you think she was punishing herself for killing Ilse? And trying not to eat the rest of her body?"

"That was what we believed," Petra answered.

"Now that we know where Titans come from, the question is, how come she was the only one that talked?" Erwin said. "Before, it was just a mystery, when we thought they were an entirely different species. We didn't know enough then to postulate a theory about that."

"The formula in the serum has to be the same. So," Armin said thoughtfully, "maybe the person's own biology also plays a part."

"That'd be my guess," Ymir shrugged.

"That would explain the Aberrants," Hange said. "They were abnormal humans originally."

In town, Hange walked by a shop. Oluo, carrying a white sack across his shoulders, noticed her and Petra followed his line of

sight. Behind them, Levi was inspecting a broom and looked at them. *"We have to continue."* Hange arrived before a door at the end up an alley. She knocked and a man opened the door.

Inside, Hange sat at the table, unwrapping what she had brought, Ilse's parents across from her.

"Are those her parents?"

"Yes."

"That's gotta be rough."

***" No matter how little intel we can gain from such missions, it will not be in vain."* She handed them a folded, bloodied cloak. Ilse's mother began to cry.**

" I firmly believe it will play an important part in humanity's fight against the Titans."* Hange pulled out the notebook from the inside of her jacket pocket and handed it to Ilse's father. *"Captain of the second squad, Hange Zoe."

She's pretty cool. Christa thought. When she wasn't being a total nut-job. But that was part of the charm, she supposed.

Outside, Hange was walking when she noticed Oluo blocking her way, Levi and Petra behind him. "Uh, Hange…"

She placed her hands on her hips, "You followed me here? Can't say I appreciate your manners."

" I'm sorry about last time. If not for my mistake," his head was down, "we might have captured it. And it might have helped humanity. If I had to give my life for that, it's not too high of a price—"

Hange grabbed him by the collar. She looked down, "No, I am the one who should apologize. I nearly got you killed. I'm sorry. But never say that your life is cheap again."

"Aww..."

Hange smiled, lifting her head.

Oluo's tongue was out, drool coming out from a corner of his mouth, unable to breathe.

The group broke out into laughter.

Hange yelped and dropped him. Oluo fell, a little blood flying out.

"Did he bite his tongue again?" Christa covered her mouth, giggling.

The scene had them in stitches.

The shot focused on the roofs of the buildings in the evening time.

" Hey, are you okay?" Hange asked worriedly.

" Oluo, what the hell are you doing?" Petra's voice was heard.

" By the way," Levi was walking in front of the group, Petra and Oluo who was holding his jaw, behind him, "Erwin has come to a decision."

" I see," Hange said, behind Oluo and Petra. An ecstatic smile began to scratch across her face. She jumped and yelled, "Hooray!"

And they cheered along with her.

" Twenty days later, Squad Leader Hange gained the support of the Special Ops Squad led by Corporal Levi, and succeeded in

the organization of the first ever expedition beyond Wall Maria to capture a Titan."

Four Titans appeared, trapped in a thick net, surrounded by Scouts with spears.

" For that mission, a new method of capture proposed by Squad Leader Hange was used, and not a single human life was lost."

The Scouts cheered and clapped in celebration.

IMPORTANT NOTE! Because season 2 threw my plan out of whack (this story was meant to end after *The Torturous Curse of Youth* so I never planned for season 2), I'm taking liberty with Ymir's memories so canon doesn't apply **.** I didn't want to give away ALL the good stuff and it wouldn't mesh well with the lighter OVAs.

Please Review~

Episode - Distress

Chapter 30: Distress

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : The recruits learn the veterans have been keeping an eye on Ymir. Ymir finds out the Talking Titan was one of her followers.

" As intended…"* A brown wheel was spinning, seemingly belonging to an overturned carriage. *"…the exercise wasn't supposed to be that difficult."

Two bruised jaws appeared.

A curved blade was held to a blonde-haired female's neck.

"Hey, I think I know when this is taking place," Armin said.

Sasha, Connie, Armin, and Mina stood behind Jean and Eren, their knees low, shoulders leaning forward, tensed looks on all their faces.

" If they'd left the forest, eventually everyone would come back."

Christa's hands were tied in front of her, a large man holding her hostage.

"It's *that* training exercise," Eren frowned.

"What happened?" Hange raised an eyebrow.

"You'll just have to wait and see," Connie said quickly. "This time *we* know what's going to happen and you guys don't."

All recruits quickly masked their expression, unwilling to give anything away.

"What's the point? We already know everyone makes it out okay." At Levi's words, they deflated.

Sasha pouted. "Oh yeah…"

" That…"* Eren and Jean were glaring fiercely. *"…was their only instruction."

Eight horses ran across a relatively flat rocky area with limited trees near rocky formations. Armin looked up from a clipboard. Marco and Eren ran along with him with Sasha, Mina, Connie, and Christa behind them, and Jean at the very end. *"That time, the 104th Trainee Corps were split into two groups."*

Levi was a little disappointed. A part of him had been hoping there might be something about the Ackerman family. He still wasn't sure how to confront Mikasa about this theory. Would've been easier if the TV revealed it clearly to them. But he'd take not having his own private life be put on display for them again.

" They were to make a roundtrip to their target location and record their progress within a given time period."* A drawing appeared, showing a group of horses crossing the flat land and heading toward a red medal with a gold star and returning with it. *"The journey to the destination goes about 40km."

Marco was leading the group. ***"Marco was their group leader, while Armin was in charge of record-keeping."***

Still gets me . Jean thought. He tried not to dwell on the sour feeling in his chest. It'd only put him in a bad mood for the rest of the episode and longer if nothing distracted him.

" The team on the other side was led by Thomas, with Mikasa as their record-keeper." **The group, led by Thomas with Mikasa on his right, was going around a bend in the mountain, Reiner, Bert, Annie, and a few others behind them.** ***"Both teams set out at the same time, and proceeded toward the huge forest."***

How are we supposed to face them? Dread was making Sasha seriously regret stuffing herself. How was she supposed to act around Reiner and Bert? What if she failed? What if they made her? *Oh man, I'm not ready* .

Mikasa couldn't help but feel anger and some pity rising in her chest, looking at the three of them.

Connie and Christa were also conflicted by it. The three grew up in a crappy environment and were only doing as they were told. But that didn't mean the people they killed weren't worth it. They were completely innocent. As sympathetic as they felt toward the Shifters, they couldn't forget those people's deaths and their families' suffering either.

The entire thing's just fucked up . Ymir thought. Despite her reassurances, she was sure even dealing with Titans wasn't as black and white for them anymore.

" They were to trade information at the target location and return to the starting point, completing a loop." **The drawing showed the two groups meeting in the forest.** ***"The objective of this exercise was to evaluate everyone's ability to sustain themselves in the absence of a crisis."***

Armin checked on his group. Everyone looked bored to tears. Jean was even yawning.

That put smiles on some of their faces and even got a chuckle or two from the group.

" That's all." Keith stood on a rocky platform with a large map behind him. "Straightforward and simple. It could be thought this training is one that even you cowards could easily pass, but it's not!"

Marco, Jean, Annie, and a few others stood side by side.

" In any situation, do not forget your will to fight!" Sasha and Mina were standing behind Christa. "Emergency or not, a soldier is always a soldier!" Bert and Reiner appeared.

Eren felt a deep urge to jump into the TV and punch both their teeth out and scream at them, an all too familiar rage simmering under his skin, flashes of the Armored and Colossal destroying his home running through his mind. But his anger faltered as the images were replaced by the reliable, big brother-like Reiner and quiet, shy Bert.

" Don't succumb to peaceful boredom!" Thomas, Mikasa, and Armin appeared individually next as Keith continued to yell. "Never stop exercising your hands and feet! This training is also a battle!" Eren appeared last. "Do not forget that!"

" Yes, sir!"

" So…" Marco looked to his left. "We're not allowed to rush this?"

" R-Right," Armin replied.

Almost in a single file, the group was moving at a slow, steady pace.

" We'd also be stupid if we did," Jean said. "We can take our time." Behind him, Connie had his head titled up while Sasha, at the end of the line, was slumping forward.

" You don't know your lower limit. Jean, if you're going to take it slow, then I'm going ahead." Eren began to speed up.

"Ah, so familiar," Connie grinned. "Eren picking a fight with Jean over nothing."

"He's picked fights with me over the same reason too," Eren grumbled.

"More like Jean's mouth has no filter and you get offended by what he says and go looking for a fight," Ymir corrected him.

" Wait, Eren…" Armin said.

" But," Marco held up his hand, "the formation group… What do we do, Jean?"

" Like I care!" Jean answered immediately and bluntly.

"Good old Jean, so carefree and doesn't give a shit," Sasha said.

"Yeah," Jean said. *I miss him too.* Especially after the last hour or so.

Jean continued, "Extra effort here won't get me into the Military Police."

" That's not true…" said began. "In any case, let's get on with the exercise."

" It's useless," Jean said.

" Hey, hurry up will you?" Marco said.

" Don't you have any endurance for this?" Eren asked rhetorically.

" It doesn't matter if I'm complaining," Jean replied.

" It would be great if time passed faster in that case." There was a sluggishness in Connie's voice.

" You got that right…" Sasha agreed. "We have a long road ahead of us."

" This is so tiresome," Jean grumbled.

The second group was in the shade, standing between two massive rock formations.

" If that's true, we may not be able to get there before nightfall."

" Then we should head eastward a little?" Mikasa proposed, holding a map.

" On the other hand, it may also be too shady." Thomas took long swigs from his water-skin.

Something seemed to have altered Mikasa and she looked up. A bird flew off.

Not for the first time, Erwin was reminded of Levi as he watched Mikasa's reaction. *Same keen instincts* . But she was still young. She held great potential but she was not at Levi's level who was twice her age.

Knowing what was waiting for them off their shores, the commander was now more motivated than ever to have Levi train her. *Quality family time.* He thought, amused. Though he was very much interested in how she would take the news the two were related.

Probably better now after those two episodes about Levi and his friends.

" What is it, Mikasa?"

She blinked and turned back to Thomas. "It's nothing. It's just me…"

Reiner, Bert, and Annie, who were taking a break looked over at her words.

An iguana was moving parallel to group one and Jean took notice. "The lizard's joining us on the same route, huh…"

" It's rare to see that," Marco commented.

" They're delicious, you know," Sasha smiled.

" What?" Christa said.

" They really are. My family and I used to eat them. They taste like chicken."

Jean smiled and asked, "You can cook?"

" Of course I can! Piece of cake!"

To the veterans' shock, not only the recruits but Candy also started laughing.

" Cooking! Oh just you wait until the next episode…"

"I have a feeling I know what the last episode will be," Ymir snickered.

Christa gasped, looking utterly delighted. "You don't think..."

"Oh I hope so!" Armin declared with a big smile.

Eren chuckled and asked. "Hey, how do you think they'll react?"

"I can almost imagine the looks on their faces," Mikasa smiled.

Meanwhile the veterans were left to exchange confused and eager looks.

"Ooh, what? What is it?!" Hange asked.

Petra nodded, "We know wanna know too!"

"I can't wait to see their reactions to final judgment!" Connie began laughing hysterically, sending his friends into a laughing frenzy as well.

"Wait a minute," Erwin brought his hand up to his chin, "does this have something to do with a cooking contest? I heard some outrageous rumors about it. Pixis was the judge, yes?"

"You guys are gonna lose your shit," Sasha snorted from laughing, only making her friends laugh even harder.

"I want it to be the next episode now," Petra sighed.

"Yeah, it'll be nice to end it on a happy note," Hange said.

We're almost done . The thought startling. Levi couldn't believe they were almost at the end. Though he was eager to leave and stretch his limbs properly and digest everything they had learned in peace and quiet.

Jean had a slightly evil look on his face. "Alrighty, then!"

"Hm," Mikasa turned to Armin, "I see what you meant when you said Eren and Jean have villainous glints in their eyes and evil-looking faces."

"Mikasa!" Eren gasped, looking betrayed, while everyone else laughed.

Jean's horse shot out. "H-Hey," Marco called out.

" If hunting for food is part of the exercise, then what's better than getting that lizard?"

" Don't do that!" Christa said.

" I'm going ahead," Eren declared.

The lizard kept running and Jean grinned, pulling out a sword. "Gotcha!" He swung it down. There was a sound of metal hitting metal. The lizard sat there with another sword protecting it from Jean. It ran off and Jean and Eren moved back. "What are you doing?" Jean demanded.

" This isn't a game," Eren retorted.

" We don't even have an instructor! This training won't get us anywhere."

Marco dismounted from his horse. "Stop it!" He approached them. "You're acting like brats!"

" I don't want to hear this from you!"

" Jean! Get a hold of yourself!"

" That's not important right now."

" If we delay, it will have to be recorded!" Marco looked back. "Please, don't record this yet, Armin."

" G-Got it."

Armin exhaled wistfully. *Things were so much easier and simpler then* . Worst thing they had to worry about was incurring Keith's

wrath and getting a poor grade. Mostly because Jean and Eren had to butt heads.

" Write down: "Jean Kirstein tries to find food during the exercise, but gets interrupted by Eren Yeager," Jean said.

" What did you say?" Eren growled.

" It's delicious!" Sasha screamed louder all of them.

Jean let out a startled sound and everyone stared at her.

Silence fell.

Marco sighed, "Let's go."

" O-Okay." Jean's horse started moving and Marco walked away.

The group started moving while Sasha pouted to herself, "Given its size, it could've fed all of us…"

"Aw, poor Sasha, she was so looking forward to it," Petra said.

Hange snickered, "Don't you mean Potato Girl?"

Sasha whined as they started with that joke again. "Will you guys ever let me live that down?" She complained.

"Never," Ymir declared cheerfully, getting hoots and nods in agreement.

While at the same time, Christa added with a smile, "You'll never be free of it!"

"Oh no Christa, how could you!" Sasha groaned.

The woods appeared along with an orange, evening sun. The second group was near some fallen trees. "Are you sure?" Mikasa knelt at the base of a tree, another trainee beside her.

" There's no doubt about it," Daz said. "This was where we put it. Everything that we kept safe here…"

" Our 3D maneuver gear is gone," Thomas stood behind them.

"Was it stolen?" Hange wondered. "By the man in the beginning! Of course!"

" Over here," Annie's voice called them over. She gestured to a campfire.

Reiner knelt on one knee, checking the ash. "They've been gone for quite a while."

Christa couldn't help but make a strange observation. *Mikasa is the only trustworthy one there.* At least one who was still alive. *She's surrounded by enemy Shifters and dead men. Though in all fairness we don't actually know what happened to Daz* . But the picture still struck her as odd.

" It's the same as we found over there," Mikasa said. "How many people are involved?"

" Also…" Annie said. "Over here too."

" Carriage tracks," Reiner said. "And there's a few of them…"

" There is no information about residents inhabiting this area," Annie said.

" It must be a gang of thieves." Someone let out a surprised sound at Reiner's words. "It seems they found out where the weapons were placed, and stole them during the night."

Daz looked frightened in the background.

"Why is your class so damn troublesome?" Levi asked. "Titan-Shifters, Walls breached after graduation, and now this."

"We don't go looking trouble, but trouble just has a way of finding." Jean sighed, "I think we're cursed."

There was some niggling at the back of Ymir's mind. Another one of Marcel's memories, she could feel it. It surprised her. She wondered if Candy had something to do with it. *Is she messing with my memories?* Can she do that? *Probably. Why not?* But why wouldn't she just release all of Marcel's memories? The answer came easy enough. *Wouldn't be as much fun for her. Candy loves being crypt when dropping hints.*

" They gather 3D maneuver gear equipment and make black market deals," Reiner said.

" So we're being targeted?" Thomas asked.

" If they got caught, we would have been helpless to stop them. You should be happy you're still alive," Mikasa told him.

"Not as helpless as you think," Levi muttered. Between Mikasa and three Shifters, the bandits would've been the ones in trouble.

" Should we stop the training and report this?" Thomas asked.

" No," Reiner said, "our target is right ahead of us. Speed up and tell Marco and his team about this, and then get back to the training grounds."

Mikasa nodded in agreement.

The sunset had set and darkness fell. A pot cooked while horses were tied to trees nearby. "So this is what squad

supplies taste like…" Jean said.

" It would've been better if we'd caught the lizard," Sasha's voice sounded like she was speaking while eating.

The group had two campfires going, two trials of smoke drifting up. "Enough," Jean said. "I've heard enough about lizards."

" Weren't you hunting one just now?" Eren sat with his back to Jean.

Jean stopped, about to take a bite of his food and brought his hand down. "Well, we *are* supposed to hunt Titans right?"

"See? Now he's trying to pick a fight with me," Eren said.

Jean snorted. "You make it so easy."

"But in all fairness, you brought up the lizard thing," Armin pointed out.

" And what do you mean by that?" Eren stood up and turned to him. "Why did you even join the Trainee Corps?" He yelled.

" To live something better than a humble life, at the very least," Jean smirked down at him.

" What did you say?! Some things can be tolerated, and others can't!"

"I don't know," Connie crossed his arms. "I feel like more insensitive things have come out of Jean's mouth."

The recruits murmured in agreement.

"Not that you could much tolerate most of what Jean said," Armin added.

"Seriously, whose side are you?" Eren whined.

Armin picked up the clipboard and a pen, looking like he was considering what to write, "U-Uhm…"

" It's fine, Armin!" Marco said hastily. "It's just a chat during mealtime."

Jean chuckled and smirking snobbishly, said. "You think when a real Titan shows up the results of training hard will pay off?"

"See?" Connie nodded. "More insensitive."

" Good jo—"

" That's enough from you!" Eren grabbed his collars.

" Stop it!" Christa stood.

" How about we actually hunt lizards?" Sasha suggested. "You'll feel better after that!"

Sasha's words made them laugh.

"Buncha school children," Levi grumbled.

" That's my line bastard!"

" Shut up!"

Movement in the shadows between trees caught Christa's eyes.

" Let go!"

" You won't be able to do anything anyway!" Jean yelled.

" Then what are you able to do?!" Eren yelled right back.

" Hey, guys…" Christa tried to get their attention.

Jean and Eren were struggling and Jean said, "I'm so much better than you!"

" Shut up! I'll beat the crap out of you!"

Connie sighed, hands on his hips, as he watched on the sidelines with Sasha.

"You guys aren't even going to step in and help?" Petra glanced at the left couch.

"Lady, this was practically a daily thing for three years," Connie replied. "We got used to it."

" Hey, you two," Marco said. "Enough, already!"

Christa looked back at the trees.

" We probably should hunt for lizards after all!"

The moon was full and bright. In the forest, Marco's group was a sleeping soundly in their sleeping bags. Nearby, sitting next to a stream, Christa kept watch. She rubbed one eye, looking a bit tired. Her horse moved close and she pressed her face against the animal, smiling and giving him a rub. A branch snapped loudly.

Christa and the horse looked into the dark trees. A small animal ran across some bushes. Her gaze was focused on a specific tree. Suddenly, a man with a long cloth covering his face appeared behind her.

A few of them actually jumped in surprise.

"Fucking creepy."

"He came out of nowhere…"

Eren's eyes shot up as Christa screamed and horses ran through the woods. A rifle was pointed at his face. "Don't move." The masked man wore a red vest over a long-sleeved black shirt. There were three other gunmen there.

"Your class seems to have bad luck following you around." Petra paused. "Then again, you've survived it all so you're luckier than me I guess." The memory of that moment in the Forest of Giant Trees still sent a shiver down her back.

"It's not happening again," Eren said obstinately.

" Gather their 3D maneuver gear. Hurry."

"So they're the ones who stole the other group's stash," Erwin said. *How did they know where they hid it?* Were they spying on the group? Had it been their presence Mikasa sensed earlier?

The trainees were frozen.

" What will you do with them?" Eren asked without a hint of fear or nervousness on his face.

"Eren, are you pathologically incapable of getting scared?" Hange inquired.

Eren shrugged cooly.

"That's nothing to be smug about, idiot," Levi said. "A little fear is a good thing."

"You forget who you're talking to, Corporal. The infamous Suicidal Bastard of the 104th class," Connie said and they chuckled.

" There are certain people who will pay handsomely for these. You can't beat the Titans anyway, so what's wrong with taking useless equipment?"

Everyone was thinking it but no one had the guts to say it.

They also tried very hard not to look at Levi.

Levi knew what they were all thinking and rolled his eyes.

Eren glared angrily, teeth gritted.

"I know that look," Petra said.

Suddenly Eren grabbed the rifle.

"Knew it."

The bandit pulled back and Eren was on his feet, forcing the rifle to point up, "Everyone, now!"

" Eren!" Armin inched toward him but one of the men cocked his rifle at him.

With an armed bandit behind them, Connie and Sasha were directly in his line of fire and unable to move. Mina was unable to move as well. Jean sprang to his feet and ran, grabbing Eren's attention. A shot went off, grazing Jean's right cheek, stopping him.

The man in the red vest hit Eren's cheek with the butt of his rifle, knocking him into the dirt. Armin attempted to move but the rifle trained on him kept him in place.

" You better think twice before you move. Don't make a sound."

Jean's leg was twitching. He watched the scene over his shoulder. Eren was on the ground, clenching his fist tightly.

A wolf howled somewhere in the forest at the full moon. The bandits loaded up the gear, and one carried Christa over his shoulder into one of the carts.

" We won't take your lives. We'll release you at some point. But if you dare come after us, we'll kill you. Understand?" The boss in red vest told them, long blade in hand, two lackeys flanking him with their rifles pointed.

The carriages left the trainees with slumped shoulder behind.

" Everyone…" Eren began and they looked up. "If we attacked as a team, then we could do *something* !"

Jean was the one to speak up. "That's your opinion. I don't agree," he said strongly. "Actually, because of your crazy behavior, everyone was in danger."

"I still disagree," Eren declared.

"Of course you do," Jean rolled his eyes.

"But they kept their faces covered," Petra said. "Although they did take Christa..."

"To keep the rest in line maybe," Levi said. "So they don't do something stupid."

Marco tilted his head down. "This exercise is over."

" It is," Armin agreed.

" Are we abandoning Christa?" Eren asked.

" That's not it. But with just us," Marco said, "we can't do anything. That's why we should ask the instructor…"

" What if we don't make it?" Eren glared over his shoulder. "I won't accept this as it is! I'm going to save Christa for sure!" A

small tear welled up in a corner of his eye. "I'll go alone!"

Christa couldn't help but feel touched.

" Eren…" Armin said. Eren walked away. "Eren!"

" Wait!" Jean went after him. "All our horses were released!" He grabbed Eren's shoulder. "How are you going to find her?"

Eren shoved off his arm. "It's none of your business!"

" It is! I'm going with you!" Jean declared with the same determination. Eren was surprised by his words. "I'm not going down in this undignified manner." The others joined them, standing behind Jean.

" You guys…" Eren said, seeing the lack of hesitation on all their faces.

There's still a big red blotch on his face. Hange tapped her chin. Flipping back to the observations, theories, and notes she had in her notebook, she stopped at episode 3. *I thought we might be able to test for a Shifter through a small injury but…*

As the Female Titan had revealed, Shifters could focus on a specific injury and accelerate the regeneration process. *Stands to reason the opposite is probably true.* One could will the wound not to heal like a Titan's would, thus blowing the Shifter's cover. Hange wasn't too disappointed her idea wasn't likely to work. *We already know all the Shifters on this island* . Though she might still approach Eren and Ymir about it.

Erwin noticing her tapping her pen and read the note, reaching the same conclusion. *Reminds me we need to have Eren—and Ymir—outfitted with a small, blade that won't catch anyone's attention.* They had brainstormed about using a needle or a safety pin. Maybe he'd take a page out of Annie's book and have rings fashioned for their two Shifters. No one would suspect it could be used as a weapon.

Even when bound, the only mobility Eren and Ymir would need was to wiggle their fingers. *Hidden in plain sight* . It was perfect.

The carriage passed by a tree where Jean and Eren hid, high up in the branches. The scene returned to the group gathered to plan an attack. "In any case, how are we gonna find those guys?" Connie asked.

" We might not make it even if we split up," Mina said.

Sasha gasped as she got an idea. "In that case," they turned to look at her, "we'll just climb to a higher place!" She pointed up.

A shot of them climbing higher up appeared. "When you get lost in the mountains, climb upwards! If you get lost in the forest, climb a tree. That's what my father told me," Sasha smiled, hands on her hips as they stood on higher ground.

" Hey," Jean pointed to a plume of smoke.

"We're about to see some amazing teamwork, aren't we?" Petra clapped. "I'm so excited to see what you all have cooked up!"

Ymir snorted. "It'll be nice to know how it actually happened, instead of the ridiculous tale Connie spins that get more and more outrageous after every telling."

"He does have a tendency to exaggerate," Mikasa nodded.

"I don't exaggerate. I *embellish* ."

"That means almost the same thing, Chrome Dome."

"I mean I add a little more flavor. Horse-Face!"

"Don't you start with that shit too!" Jean's complained loudly.

"Hey, if I'm never living down Potato Girl, you'll never live down Horse-Face either!" Sasha told him.

Through the lens of a telescope, Christa was shown to be escorted at gunpoint while other men, now unmasked, carried boxes. "We're heading out as soon as we've loaded everything!" The boss said, holding a shotgun over his shoulder. "Hurry!"

Eren, in a crouched position, passed the telescope to Jean. "What do we do?"

" We'll be too late at this rate," Jean replied.

" They have rifles on them," Marco said. "We're gonna get shot."

" I have an idea," Armin spoke up. The group retreated lower to stand up without being seen and gather around Armin. "They're probably going to sell the stolen goods." He held open a large paper in his hands. "If that's the case, they'll probably find a wide exit around this area." Connie took the map and he and Marco studied it. "We'll ambush them before they get there."

" It'll be hard since we have to horses," Connie said.

" It's possible if there's a wide exit," Sasha said. "If we leave the forest."

"How are you—" Erwin began to think out loud but stopped, smiling. "I see."

" Wheee!" Sasha slid down the rocky incline, a green sack over one shoulder. The others followed suit.

"That looks so fun!" Hange said. "I wanna try that!"

The carriages began to leave. Christa was tied to one, with a blond-haired man in a hat, holding a rifle, keeping watch.

" After clearing the forest, the road divides into two routes." **The shot moved to the split in the road as Armin continued.** ***"One of the roads goes to the wider exit, and once they enter there, we don't stand a chance. So…"***

Mina noticed the carriages approaching and quietly said, "They're here!"

Connie gripped the rope tightly. "Here goes!" He swung across and Sasha, standing on a branch on the other side with a rope tying her to the tree, caught his hand and pulled him up. With the rope attached to the top of a tree still in his free hand, Connie jumped forward, now using both hands and utilizing his weight to pull the tree down. The tree lay parallel to the ground and the carriages took the other road.

"Smart," Petra nodded. "Cutting off one of their routes and sending them to your chosen place of ambush."

"Yes! Brilliant!" Hange clapped. "What's next?"

" And if it goes well?" Jean asked.

" Which carriage are Christa and the 3D gear in? How can we tell?" Eren asked.

" If we hear a rattling sound, we'll be able to tell," Marco said.

Back in the present, Marco and Armin lay in a long ditch alongside the road, Marco holding a long rope. ***"If the equipment is in the first carriage, I'll pull once."*** **The rope was tied through the tree, two metal cans were attached to the end**

near where Eren and Jean waited. *"If it's the rear one, then twice."*

"Using the ropes was a good idea," Erwin praised.

Using tools that were available and coming up with a plan to retrieve their equipment and rescue their friend in a short period of time was impressive. "Yes, it was very resourceful," Levi nodded.

They beamed at the praise.

The first carriage approached. Eyes closed, Marco listened closely as the wheel bounced. When the second carriage hit the bump, his eyes shot open and he yanked the rope as he heard the sound of metal hitting metal, the crates of blades bumping into each other.

The cans rang on Eren and Jean's end.

" And at that point…"

" You're late!"

The two crashed through the flimsy roof of the carriage.

"I might be tooting my own horn here but that was a pretty cool entrance if I do say so myself," Jean said.

"For once, we're in agreement," Eren said.

" Who the hell are you?" One of the men demanded and lunged for Jean. Jean ducked, ramming his shoulder into the man's chest, grabbing his knees and throwing him out the cart.

His screams caught the attention of the first carriage's occupants. "What's going on?"

" You bastard!" The other man cursed.

Eren quickly dispatched him, knocking him to the floor while Jean went after the driver, wrapping an arm around his neck. "You do this every time you get defeated!" Jean said and Eren threw the second man out the carriage.

" That brat!" Christa's captor took aim. Jean released the driver and the carriage hit a rock, causing Christa to fall and the shooter to miss. The bullet hit one of the second carriage's wheels and the driver dove out. "Damn," the man in the hat took aim again, "next one won't miss!"

" Stop!" Christa threw her arms over the rifle, forcing it down.

" Christa!" Eren yelled.

" You!" The man struggled against her and fired. Weakened by a second bullet, the wood splintered, sending the carriage spinning without one of its wheels before crashing against a tree, sending up a cloud of dust.

Marco, Sasha, and Connie appeared, taking in the scene. They took off running toward the carriage.

Jean grunted, sitting up, "Are you alright?"

" Yeah," Eren sat up, "somehow…"

" Jean! Eren!" Marco arrived with the others.

" We're alright! And so is the 3D gear."

Eren stood among the equipment. "But Christa is still…"

" After them!" Marco said.

"Time for some 3D action!" Hange cheered. "Those bandits are done for now!"

Mina and Connie, fully hooked up to their gear, took off. "Sasha, do you have a signal flare?" Armin asked.

" Y-Yeah, I do…"

" Can I borrow it?"

A green flare shot up to the sky.

Erwin nodded, approving, "Calling for backup." Once the other group arrived, they could arm themselves as well.

" This bitch!"

The boss looked back to see Christa still struggling against the gunman.

" I said quit it!" He knocked her to the ground. She lifted her head and he pointed the rifle at her.

" Don't kill her!" The boss ordered. "She's our bounty!"

He glanced at the man then back, a leering smirk on his face. "So that's how it is."

"Disgusting, perverted son of a bitch," Ymir glared at the TV.

Mikasa clenched her jaw.

The words had sparked a familiar anger in them, remembering the events of Mikasa and Eren's first meeting.

" Thanks to your friends we've lost our score! You'll have to take responsibility," he told her.

Christa stared back defiantly.

A hook shot out and knocked the gun from his hand, sending him to the floor.

" What?" The boss said in surprise.

They grinned, eager to watch those men have their asses kicked.

Eren and Jean pursued the carriage through the air. The boss snapped the reins, urging the horse to move faster, while his lackey tried to shoot them down. "Damn!"

Jean dodged. The gunman discarded the rifle for a longer one. Eren and Jean took out their blades, maneuvering expertly and dodging another bullet. They flew on either side of the carriage and slashed at the reins as the boss watched dumbfounded. The horse neighed and ran off.

"That was some beautiful flying and teamwork," Petra told them.

"Thanks."

"It was nothing."

The carriage spun, flipping over on its slide, the wheels flying off, and skidding to a stop against a tree. The two boys landed before the crash, their friends joining them a few seconds later.

Christa's hands were tied in front of her. The boss had his blade to her neck, looking furious, his lackey also present, rifle pointed at them. "Stay away!" The boss yelled.

" Throw away your weapons!" The gunman ordered.

" Do as I say, and hand over the 3D maneuver gear! Hurry up!"

The trainees stared, their bodies tense. Something caught Armin's eye and he looked up, a relieved smile on his face.

"That would be the backup, I presume?" Levi asked.

"Yup."

Eren glanced back at Jean. They began removing their gear and the others followed.

" Shit, you've got to be kidding me…" The boss muttered. "How did this happen to me?" Christa turned her head to listen to him. "Even if we run away from the Titans… What can you do out here where nothing can be risked? Don't burden others."

His words took the many of them by surprise, confusing them slightly.

With wide eyes, Christa listened, understanding.

" I should have taught my daughter that much."

Realization dawned on their faces.

"Wait," Eren frowned, "is this why you..." He turned to Christa.

"Yeah," Christa nodded. "I don't believe he had evil intentions. His daughter must've been a part of the Survey Corps and died at the hands of a Titan."

"And he took to stealing the equipment the soldiers needed," Erwin said. "Without it, they can't confront them. The soldiers would have no chance."

"So in a small way, he was trying to protect the soldiers," Petra said thoughtfully.

"What was that about using Christa as a bounty?" Mikasa asked.

"Probably a bluff," Levi spoke up. "To keep the man from shooting her and killing her on the spot."

The gunman took a step forward, "Hurry up!"

Annie and Mikasa suddenly appeared, Annie knocking the rifle out of the gunman's hands and Mikasa knocking the blade out of the boss's hand, freeing Christa. "What?" The boss stumbled back in shock.

" Mikasa!" Eren said, startled.

Mikasa spun and brought her sword to the boss's neck. "Don't kill him!" Christa screamed.

With an utterly blank expression, Mikasa tilted her head. "I see." A drop of blood went down the man's neck and she retracted her blade, letting him fall to the ground.

Annie removed her sword from the other man's face and he fell to his knees. "Looks like you went through a lot of trouble."

The trainees gaped at the scene before Sasha nudged Armin with her elbow, praising him and causing him to blush. They looked over to see Thomas waving as his group came over.

The criminals were led away by the Police while Marco saluted an MP soldier as the rest of the trainees talked and ate. *"In the end, the gang of thieves was arrested by the Military Police."*

Christa watched them with Armin as Jean, beside them, looked irritated at Mikasa who held a white cloth to Eren's displeased face.

The group giggled that quick shot.

"Ugh," Eren rolled his eyes. "You are so overbearing."

"But you were hurt," Mikasa protested.

"I'm a Titan-Shifter."

"I didn't know that then."

"Well you do now."

Mikasa opened her mouth to retort and stopped. "Fine."

Eren hoped that meant she would stop suffocating him with her 'care' so much.

" Without taking any casualties, the incident was over."

" Although the exercise was suspended, they still had to submit their records of the incident, in all honesty and without pretense."

Armin stood before Keith, saluting, the report open on his desk.

"Remember how Marco kept trying not to get you to record Eren and Jean's constant squabbling?" Sasha giggled and they joined in.

Hange threw up her arms and stretched. "This was probably the least action-packed episode of them all. Kinda boring in comparison but it was nice to give our brains a break."

"There's still a little bit left before *that* ," Connie grinned.

The recruits dissolved into giggles again.

Hange gasped. "That's right! Erwin, hurry! I wanna know what happened!"

" May I ask a question?" Armin asked.

" What is it?"

" Should we have turned back at the time when our 3D gear was stolen? Or were we right pursuing those thieves?"

" There's no need to answer that," Keith said without looking up. "But…" Armin straightened. "Whether you're a soldier or a regular civilian, we all decide how to respond in the face of distress. Go back, or go after the criminal…" He looked up. "Which one is most important in your opinion, Arlert?"

" T-That…"

" Armin couldn't answer it. Perhaps… Meeting those thieves during the process was imposed upon on them as part of the exercise."

"Come to think of it, it would make sense how they knew where Thomas's group stashed their weapons," Jean said.

"What about the MP showing up and taking them away?" Connie asked.

"Might be a part of the exercise. Who knows," Sasha shrugged. "Maybe they turned traitor."

"Did it happen with your class too?" Christa turned to Petra, who was the most recent graduate aside from her friends.

"We didn't have this exercise so I don't know."

"You can ask Shadis yourself," Eren said to Armin. "We have to talk to him about my dad."

"That's right."

"I wonder what his story is," Ymir said, thinking about Grisha.

Keith is the former commander of the Survey Corps . Erwin couldn't believe it was a coincidence he and Grisha were acquainted. Could they have met outside the Walls? He shook his head. *No point in speculating.* He'd ask Keith himself and get the answers straight from the source.

Marco climbed the stairs to the watchtower, two mugs in hands. "I shouldn't have accepted the group leader position." Marco held a mug out to Eren.

" Really?" Eren accepted it. "It seemed to me that it fits you."

I will have to disagree there. Erwin still thought Armin and Jean were better fit to be in a position of leadership.

" Nah, I'm not suited to be a leader. Jean's more suited for the job."

" Jean?! Leave me out then."

The group chuckled with Marco.

"Hm," Jean crossed his arms, tapping his chin, "I seem to recall someone asking me what to do when the bandits were loading up Christa and the stolen goods."

Eren mirrored his pose. "I seem to recall *Armin* being the one to come up with the plan to rescue Christa and get out stuff back."

"Shh!" Hange said loudly. "Don't you two get into it now. I really wanna get to the funny episode!"

" You'll understand someday."

Eren rested his elbow on the edge, face in hand, "I wonder about that…"

" I wonder what kind of soldiers everyone will become," Marco smiled.

The mood darkened in sadness immediately.

" That was in year 848…when they fought their first battle, two years ago."

"The exercise was very beneficial," Petra began, noticing their grieving expressions. It had only been a month since they lost Marco. And he was one of their first friends who died. Adding on to that was who the culprits likely were, it wasn't easy to handle. "It was an ordinary day, a boring mission when disaster struck. Much like the Battle for Trost."

"Shadis's training really did come in handy," Mikasa nodded.

They really are a talented group. Survivors . And Levi truly hoped he wouldn't have to see them die before him.

"Let's watch that funny episode now!" Hange urged, smiling when their eyes lit up in joy once again. *Distraction successful!*

"You guys will love it!"

"Pixis like you've never seen before!"

The recruits cracked up.

"Well, I am thoroughly intrigued and excited now." Erwin hit play.

Do you guys wanna see Petra back for season 2? I'm down either way.

Should I hold off on the Curse of Ymir secret reveal until season 2? It wasn't a thing when I planned this story. I thought I'd end it on a happy, optimistic note. Then I realized this revelation will clash with the most laid-back episode ever. I figured there'll be more time to explore in season 2. Though the Beast Titan reveal is definitely

coming. I'm leaning towards waiting until season 2 for the curse reveal but I was curious about your thoughts on it.

Season 3: I won't be doing season 3. It'll be 24 episodes long and I'll end up abandoning the story so I won't even go there.

I just want to reiterate: This story was supposed to end with *The Torturous Curse of Youth* so adding season 2 derailed my plan. Thus the transition between seasons won't be as smooth as it could have been.

Thanks for all your wonderful support!

Please Review~

Episode - The Torturous Curse of Youth

Chapter 31: The Torturous Curse of Youth

Disclaimer : I do not own Shingeki no Kyojin

Previously : Erwin decides to have rings like Annie's made for Eren and Ymir. The group is excited to end it on a funny episode.

Mist rolled through the silent city.

***" That day, the young man remembered something,"* Candy began ominously.**

Confusion swept through the room and they tensed automatically at those familiar, sinister words.

"I thought this was a funny episode," Petra said.

"Maybe we were wrong," Ymir said.

Beads of sweat covered Jean's face, eyebrows knitted in an intense expression. Stairs creaked under a pair of feet, the legs seemingly belonging to a woman in a pink skirt.

" The fear of being dominated by them…"

Jean was sketching something intently.

Jean cried out suddenly, grabbing his hair, causing some of them to jump, startled.

"What the hell, man," Connie grumbled.

"What's wrong?" Armin asked worriedly.

A droplet of sweat landed on the drawing. It was a girl's face with dark hair and eyes. Jean's bedroom appeared. Pairs of shoes, books, and scrunched up pieces of paper were strewed across the floor.

"… and the shame of being a prisoner in a cage."

"Why, Candy? I thought I was your favorite!"

"You know it's not that embarrassing—" Christa began.

"Shh!" Sasha grinned, whispering. "It's funny cause he's embarrassed about it!"

"You know, she looked kinda like you," Eren said to Mikasa.

Feeling slightly awkward, Mikasa hid half her face behind her scarf.

"No wonder he developed a crush when he first saw you, you're his type," Hange teased.

"Please stop," Jean begged. He almost said *I've already given up on that* but that might cause them to start teasing him again.

The woman kept climbing up the stairs.

With a glint in his eyes, Jean's head flew toward his bedroom door as his mother barged in. Hastily he yanked up the blanket to hide himself and his drawing.

"If it was me I'd think you had your hands down your pants," Hange said, making them laugh.

" How many times do I have to tell?" Mrs. Kirstein yelled. "It's lunchtime!"

" Knock before you come in, hag!" Jean screamed in angrily. "Why did you bring that thing up here?"

In her hands was a pan with an omelet. "You wouldn't come down, no matter how many times I called you, so I had to come all the way up here!"

" Just get the hell out!" He jumped up and rushed her out of his room. "You rotten old hag!" He slammed the door shut.

" What's with that attitude?" His mother's voice was heard from the other side.

"Teenagers," Levi crossed his arms. "No manners."

"Jean, how rude, you shouldn't talk to your mother like that," Mikasa chided.

All their mothers seemed to be better than hers. If Christa could have switched with any of them she would have. It made her feel a little guilty. A nice person wouldn't think something like that about their own mother.

"Really Horse-Face, you should have more decency."

"Yeah! You were such a dick!" Connie added.

"Oh shut up," he grumbled. "Not like you haven't ever acted like asses to *your* parents."

Jean looked at the wrinkled drawing in his shaking hands, now ruined. "Damn it all!" He ripped it up and threw it in the air, stomping over to the window and slamming his hands on the ledge. *I will have it for sure! A safe and exhilarating life within the inner Walls as a member of the Military Police!* His dramatic scowled deepened. *I will definitely get it!*

With a brown sack over one shoulder, he walked away, leaving his mother and father behind by the house. *"With that*

determination in his heart, the young man left home and survived the strict training."

Jean's mother wiped her eye.

"It's like Eren's story," Hange said in amusement. "Just as dramatic but less serious."

Erwin nodded, "It's almost satirical."

Quick flashes appeared: the trainees standing at attention, Jean's fight with Eren that first evening, and Mikasa walking by and joining Eren. *"All manner of humiliation only made him stronger."*

Eren, feeling like being a douche, laughed loudly while everyone else giggled. Or at least had the decency to attempt to smother their snickers.

Jean sank into the sofa, arms crossed over his chest, wishing badly for a pillow to suffocate himself with and spare himself more humiliation.

[Year 849]

A hilly green field appeared with trees to one side, the trainees were walking carrying large packs while the instructors rode on horses. *"After two years, the young man returned."* Wearing a serious expression, Jean looked ahead. The trainees were traveling toward a gate. *"To the cage he had supposedly escaped from."*

A drawing of a large boar with a small man holding a spear and a shield appeared on the screen.

" I heard it's shown up again."

Civilians were gathered around, looking at the drawing nervously.

" Someone should go and get rid of it already."

" We can't even work in peace with that thing around."

" This is awesome!" Behind the crowd, Connie walked with his friends, all wearing a green pack over their shoulders. "I've never been in a Walled city before!"

" There are all sorts of tasty things here!" Sasha said happily.

Armin and Marco were glancing around, taking in the sights, flanking Jean, who looked rather disinterested. "You guys!" He got their attention. "If you can join the city Garrison, you can stay here as long as you like. And I'll come to check up on you when I join the Military Police," he laughed loudly and they all made a face.

"That was so lame of you," Sasha said.

"So much for that plan, huh," Ymir looked at him.

"Yeah."

"I can't imagine any of us elsewhere," Christa said.

" Hey Jean, where do you live?" Armin asked.

" Does it matter?"

" You're going to visit your home, right?" Marco began, earning an irritated look from his friend. "Thomas said he was going home."

" I'm sure your mom would be happy!" Armin said.

" Shut up already! It's none of your business!" Jean yelled. They quieted at that.

That was definitely uncalled for. Jean thought. "I didn't think I was that immature."

"Oh, you were that bratty," Eren reassured.

" Listen up, you swine!" Keith addressed the trainees in a flashback. "During tomorrow's training for the upcoming attack on Trost, Commander Pixis, who is in charge of the southern region, will be present.

The scene switched over to the present with trainees perched up on roofs. *"Show him how much closer you vermin are to becoming soldiers after these two years!"*

Wooden Titans dummies with fleshy-looking napes were placed in the streets. Annie, Jean, and Armin were standing on a roof, blades out.

" Yes, sir!"

The bell rang and the trainees charged, letting out battle cries. In the streets, the civilians ran. "Please follow directions and evacuate safety!" A Garrison soldier directed.

Mrs. Kirstein stopped and looked up.

" Make sure you only bring what is absolutely essential!"

Someone grabbed Jean's mother's hand and they ran with the other escaping civilians.

On the roof, Jean was running in the lead with Armin and Annie following. "Jean, is it okay to move this far ahead?" Armin

asked. "Our orders were to hang back and deal with the Titans that break through—"

" We can't afford to be so laid back! Soldiers are meant to cut down Titans!"

The trio jumped off the roof.

"I can bullshit!" Eren declared.

" Aren't you more concerned with getting a high score?" Annie asked.

"I knew it!"

A Garrison soldier, Anka, was observing through a telescope and said, "Commander, Team 21 has abandoned their post." There was a snoring sound. "Commander?" She looked up to see Pixis snoring, standing straight, arms crossed over his chest, cheeks pink.

"That's a skill I need to master," Connie said.

Anka stood and spoke loudly in his ear, "Commander!"

Pixis woke up and looked around groggily, "Is it chow time?"

Sasha laughed, "That's what I would say!"

" You just ate a little while ago," Anka said. Before Pixis could open his flask, she snatched it out of his hands and went over to her teammate. "He's far too relaxed."

" He hasn't had time to loosen up lately," Gustav replied.

Pixis pulled out a second flask.

They giggled.

Sly old fox . Erwin thought.

"That's Commander Pixis, always anticipating and prepared," Armin said.

" Just leave him be."

The commander took a sip. "I wonder what we're having for dinner."

Jean narrowed his eyes, sighting a dummy Titan. "Found one! I've got this!" Immediately a hook shot out behind him and Mikasa flew by, taking out the nape. The severed 'flesh' flew off and Jean watched her pose in the air in awe. *Awesome, as always.* He grinned. *You really* are *the only one who can surpass me.*

"Her and *five* others," Eren said pointedly.

"You're all Titan-Shifters, you guys don't count!"

" You guys, this way!" Jean ordered. He, Armin, and Annie approached three other Titans. "This time for sure!"

" Thanks a bunch, Jean!" Connie flew above them, smirking. "Gotcha!" He took out one of the dummies.

" Damn you!" Jean went around the 'dead' Titan and screamed, "Quit screwing around!"

Swords flashed and there were two more strikes.

Reiner landed on a stone roof. "Sorry, Jean."

" Whoo-hoo! Yay!" Sasha cheered, standing on the dummy Titan she had taken out.

" You've improved," Connie said as Jean landed on the ground.

" I've always been this good!'"

" You're still no match for me, though!"

Jean glared furiously.

" That's cheating, you thieving scum!"

" Huh?" Connie, sitting back against a stone wall, about to eat a small loaf of bread, looked up. Sasha sat beside him with Reiner to the side and Armin and Annie nearby.

Jean stood before Connie and Sasha, "I found those targets first!"

" Cheating? I didn't expect you to sound so petty, Jean," Sasha taunted. "There are no rules when it comes to hunting." She took a bite of her potato.

" Keep your hunting logic to yourself, Potato Girl!"

" *Potato* ? I thought everyone had forgotten around that!"

"Guess again!"

"Connie, you used to be on my side!"

The others joined in.

"It'll be engraved on your epitaph."

"Yeah! Here lies Sasha Blouse: Potato Girl to the end."

"Hey, instead of flowers, should we bring potatoes to your grave?"

They cracked up.

Sasha sulked and Jean took pleasure from it. Happy that he wasn't the only one suffering.

" That's cruel," Sasha shot to her feet.

Connie jumped up next to her. "She's right! Apologize to her!"

" We were assigned to that area, not you," Reiner said.

" That's right!" Connie said. "You're acting strange today. All this shouting and everything. Are you that anxious to see your mommy?" He mocked in a babyish voice.

" Oh, is that it?" Sasha asked.

" Hello no!" Jean brought up his fist, ready to knock them both out.

The two broke out into silly fighting poses, Sasha with her arms in a U-shape and left knee up, and Connie with a knee bent and the other leg out, arms in an awkward mantis-like position.

"What kind of stupid fighting positions are those?" Levi said.

"We made them up," Connie answered proudly.

" Stop that, you two!" Reiner walked over. "You too, Jean. Or you won't make it into the Military Police."

Jean straightened up. "Let's settle this at training tomorrow! We'll see who takes out the most targets!"

" That sounds like fun!"

The trainees nearby, sounding surprised, quickly moved apart and saluted. Pixis walked through them, arms behind his back.

After freezing for a second, Jean saluted hastily and Connie and Sasha followed.

" Commander Pixis," Jean said.

" Allow me to put that on hold. Your tireless spirit is wonderful indeed, but settling scores during training is outrageous." He took multiple swigs from his flask.

"I can't believe he chided us while drinking on the job himself."

"And right in front of us too."

" Do your fighting in the kitchen."

" Sir?" Jean said, the others leaning in with slightly dumbfounded looks.

" You will compete to see who is the better chef!" Pixis declared.

"Where does cooking come into all of this?" Hange wondered.

"He's obviously been day-drinking," Levi said.

Jean gaped, mouth open, while Sasha had stars in her eyes, "Cooking?"

" Yes, cooking." Pixis held out his arms and said grandly, "We will have a cooking competition!"

The trainees began muttering in confusion.

" Cooking?"

" Did he say cooking?"

" Why cooking?"

"I bet he was just looking for an excuse not to eat military rations," Ymir said.

" We should have confiscated *all* of his alcohol," Gustav said and Anka nodded.

"He's probably got another bottle squirreled away somewhere," Christa said.

" My apologies, Commander Pixis," Jean began. "We are soldiers, not chefs—"

Sasha shoved a golden potato right in front of his face. "Jean, what do you know about cooking?"

" That's right!" Connie egged him on behind her, "I bet your mom cooked all of your meals!"

" I will teach you what cooking is really like, Little Jean!" Sasha declared and took a dramatic bite of her potato.

Jean stared at her, tensed. Sasha glared, chewing, bits of potato around her mouth.

Trembling fingers curled into fists. "Bring it on!" Jean threw out his arm to the side. "Whether it's cooking or cleaning, it doesn't matter."

"Would have been more entertaining if it was a cleaning competition," Levi said.

Absolutely no one agreed.

"Where's the fun in that?"

"You're the only one who would have like that, Corporal."

"Chores, ugh."

But Hange was the only one to say it loud enough for him to hear, "Levi, that's so lame."

" If I win," Jean pointed at her, "you stay out of my way from now on! Potato Girl!"

" It's settled. The showdown will take place tonight," Pixis said. "Each of you will prepare a course for dinner. Bring your best dishes to the table!"

All the trainees cheered.

" A cooking showdown between Sasha and Jean!"

" We can't miss this!"

" I won't be able to sleep tonight!"

" More like, we won't let you sleep!"

Meanwhile, Eren stood away from the crowd, holding a small basket, Mikasa next to him with a small wooden crate in her hands. "What's that about?" Eren looked confused.

" No idea," Mikasa said.

"It's almost like Jean is the main character in this episode," Petra said.

"Huh," Jean sat up. "I do like that idea."

"Don't get a big head, it's only one episode," Eren told him.

"At least I won't go running around like some impotent loser always in need of saving."

"What did you say?" Eren demanded, eyes blazing angrily.

"You heard me, dumbass."

"C'mon, you two, it's the last episode," Armin said. They still looked ready to throw down. "You don't want to annoy Corporal Levi, do

you?" He whispered. That silenced them.

An open green field with trees appeared. Threes horses with riders were racing across the grass. They each had a rifle strapped to their back.

" Alright! I can see it!" Jean said.

" Why are we going hunting?"

" We have no choice, Annie," Armin said. "We were ordered to work as a team."

" I used to play in that forest often." Jean eyed the thick forest before them. "It's famous for being the habitat of a giant boar. If we managed to get that meat, we'll win for sure."

" What about honing our cooking skills?" Armin asked.

" Like we have time for that!'

" Oh my, what a coincidence!" Sasha's voice was heard.

" You guys—" Jean glanced to his left and saw Sasha, Connie, and Reiner riding parallel to them. "Why?"

" Sasha says she got wind of some good meat," Reiner answered.

" I won't let you have all the good meat yourself!" Sasha snapped the reins and her horse moved faster.

" Dammit!" Jean cursed when they took the lead.

" Let's go, Jean!" Armin said determinedly. "This place is like your backyard, right? We have the terrain advantage!"

"Wait! Any bets on who's going to win?" Connie called out.

The teens all looked over to the veterans.

Erwin decided to humor them. "I think I'll place my bets on Ms. Blouse."

"Give me a second, hm," Hange said. "My money's on Jean!"

"Don't care," Levi declared, looking bored.

"I'll go with Jean," Petra smiled.

Jean, Armin, and Annie walked through the forest in a line. Armin looked around, unsure. "Jean. Are we lost—"

Levi snorted.

"Damn, should have gone with Sasha. She's the hunter and knows how to cook," Hange muttered.

" We're not."

" But I'm sure we already came this way—"

" No, we haven't!" Jean pointed ahead, "Look at that damaged tree." The tree had a large U-shape scar with a smaller tree fallen in front of it. He put one foot on the fallen tree and touched the scarred thicker one. "Sure, we saw one that looked similar earlier, but I'm sure we're getting close!"

Armin looked hilariously unconvinced while Annie tucked her hair behind her ear in the background.

The image brought smiles to their faces.

"Armin, you sure lost faith quick."

"We were circling the same spot for half an hour, Christa."

"I thought you used to play in that forest so much you knew it like the back of your hand?"

"Shut up, Eren. Those were Armin's words, not mine!"

" Hey," Reiner's voice was heard as tree branches appeared on the screen. "There's no way we'll be able to find anything if we just keep strolling around."

Sasha was in the lead and the three walked at a slow, steady pace.

" We're trying to track game in a place without snow. We'd need five or six days at least—"

" There it is, Connie!"

Many of them leaned in curiously.

A pile of shit filled the TV screen.

Sasha and Connie laughed at the way their faces fell or twisted up.

The two were crouched beside it and Sasha poked it with a stick.

" That's big," Connie said.

" Yes, it's massive. And it's fresh too."

Momentarily forgetting about the situation with him, they laughed at the look on Reiner's face.

" Its nest must be close," Sasha said.

" There are times when luck may be on our side," Reiner said. "But things won't always go so smoothly—"

" There it is!" The two were standing on a large rock, looking at what was on the other side.

Again they chuckled at Reiner's expression.

The boar was snoring loudly, sleeping soundly.

" That is one big pig!" Connie whispered, lying between Reiner and Sasha, rifle in hand.

" Yeah, it is," Sasha had a quiver on her back. "It would probably make it into the colossal class."

" Alright," Reiner said with conviction after gaping at the boar in stunned disbelief. In the next scene, he was walking away. "Let's go home. Challenging that is impossible."

"Well he's quite the actor," Levi said. "Like he couldn't crush it under its foot with ease."

Watching this it's impossible to tell he's a traitor. Petra thought. The recruits seemed to be having a hard time with it as well. Had the three really not felt even an ounce of camaraderie with their fellow trainees? Somehow she found it difficult to believe. Especially after watching their interactions. Maybe it was just because it was Reiner. He was so amiable. And she'd yet to actually see him turn on them. Not to mention he hadn't been the one to kill her and her teammates, making it easier for her to regard him less harshly.

Sasha ran up in front of Reiner, and slapped him. Then she punched him with her elbow. *She hit me with her elbow?* Reiner thought.

"Wow," Eren said. "Didn't expect that..."

"Certainly was an interesting technique," Erwin raised an eyebrow.

Hange held up an elbow and tried to emulate how one would punch someone with it.

"Get that out of my face," Levi slapped it away.

" How can you say something like that?" Tears filled the corners of Sasha's eyes. "That makes me sad! Can you hold your head up and before your ancestors with that kind of attitude?" She covered her face with her hands. "Can you connect the world?"

"Uh, what?"

"I'm not really sure what's going here."

"Me neither."

"What's with that inspirational music?"

" I'm sorry, Sasha," Reiner stood. "I don't understand what you just said, but I was wrong."

"We don't get it either."

Connie looked over at them.

" It's fine, long as you get."

"Didn't he just say he *doesn't* ?"

" Let's go! Dedicate your heart to getting that meat!"

Reiner saluted her. "Right!"

Sasha wavered for a second, wondering if he really was the Armored Titan. Mentally she shook her head at the wishful thinking. A part of her hoped season two wouldn't have more of these episodes from their trainees days. She was confused and twisted up inside about

the situation enough as it was. Seeing all the good times they'd had was only making it more difficult.

" You guys!" Connie called out.

Now awake, the large boar stood on the rock, glaring down at them, a scar over its left eye.

"Oh, he looks mean," Petra said.

Hange laughed, "He looks like Levi."

" Let's do it, Sasha!" Reiner said.

" Yeah!" Sasha pulled out an arrow and placed it in the bow.

" You take the lead!"

" You got it!" She charged at the boar with Connie beside her, holding out his swords, while Reiner was much further behind them.

"He sure kept his distance," Sasha said.

"Wait a minute!" Hange gasped.

Levi moved his head away, startled by her yelling. "What?"

"Something just occurred to me!"

Erwin knew that *Aha* expression on her face well. "What is it?"

"I had this idea about testing for a Shifter by inflicting a wound to see it would heal."

Ymir and Eren immediately stared at their hands, wondering.

"But the Female Titan made her eye heal faster by prioritizing it." Petra wasn't ever likely to forget that anytime soon.

"That's exactly what I thought," Hange nodded. "But now I just realized something else. Remember when Eren had his limbs eaten?"

"Hard to forget," Mikasa said.

"His regeneration kicked in while he was unconscious."

"So, what? Knock them out first then see if they heal?" Armin said.

"Actually no, I hadn't thought of that. I thought maybe since the healing factor is automatic and unconscious, he'd have to *consciously* resist any injury repairing itself."

"If that's true, he couldn't hide a serious wound for long because it might require too much mental effort," Christa concluded.

"Bingo."

"That's why Reiner's keeping his distance?" Jean said "Because he's worried about seriously hurting himself and getting exposed?"

"It makes sense," Eren nodded. "If Hange's theory is right."

"But it doesn't really matter now, does it?" Connie asked. "We already know who all the Shifters are."

"There are two more, their names are at the tip of my tongue," Ymir said. All eyes focused on her. "Don't stare!" She snapped. "That makes it harder!"

Everyone quickly turned their attention back to the TV and Erwin hit play.

On a grassy cliff, Jean heard the sound of the boar roaring. He saw and heard the explosions of dust rising in the forest. Jean

screamed as the realization hit him.

Inside the forest, the boar ran as Sasha held tightly to the wire embedded in its body, Connie and Reiner flying behind her. "Meat! Meat!"

It's like Hange with Titans. Levi shivered.

" It's the boar!" Jean said, flying toward their target. "And the others!"

" It's fast!" Armin said. "We'll never catch up to them!"

Digging her fingers in its fur, Sasha pulled herself up on its back. "Stew! Steak! Sausage!"

That brought a smile to their faces.

Armin held out a cluster of red potatoes in his hand, flying before the boar. "Over here, Sasha! I have potatoes!"

No one could hold their laughter at that.

"You tried to lure her with potatoes?!"

"Armin, I never knew you were so funny!"

"I can't breathe!"

" Smoked! Minced! Cutlets!" Sasha chanted as she continued to climb the beast.

" No good! We can't overcome the power of meat!"

Armin's complete seriousness kept them laughing to a point that Erwin had to pause the episode to let them catch their breaths.

"That felt so good."

"I feel so much better now."

"Armin, you comedic genius, you!"

"I really needed that."

Jean's eyes widened as Sasha stood, an arrow aimed at the boar. "There are so many ways to cook it! The most delicious thing in the world!" She leapt up and did a flip in the air. "It's gotta be…" The boar continued to run. "MEAT!" The arrow flew and met its target, hitting the animal right between the eyes.

The boar went down, sliding to a stop, laying on its side.

"Really, guys, I change my mind, can I bet on Sasha instead of Jean?"

"Too late, no take-backsies!"

A large gathering of civilians lined the street as they paraded through on a large cart. "Behold!" Connie held up an arm. "Colossal boar passing through!"

Sasha smiled, sitting on the boar, its fur in her hands like the reins of a horse, singing as she swayed, "Meat! Meat!"

" Out of the way!" Connie said.

The civilians watched them leave. Behind them, Jean stood with Armin and Annie. "You bastards!" He screamed, voice echoing.

A bell rang in the distance.

It was evening and Eren was struggling to unload a crate from a cart. Mikasa walked over carrying three with ease and put them as he stared open-mouthedly.

"Whoa," Hange's eyes widened. "She's really strong." Her eyes flickered over to Levi. *Runs in the family* .

Mikasa attempted to take the crate Eren was having trouble with but he pushed her. "Hey, stop that!"

" But—" She tired again.

Again he pushed her away. "But nothing! Just stop it!"

"Eren, you're too weak. Just admit it and let her help!"

"Everyone knows she's stronger."

"Hey, I do my fair share!"

Petra stared at the girl, puzzled. "She shouldn't be able to lift three if he's having trouble with one."

Levi shifted at her words.

"Isn't that right, Captain? They're the same size and he's trained too. Simple biology dictates he should be stronger than her."

"Yeah..."

If it was Armin Petra might have understood. He just wasn't built for physical strength. But that wasn't the case with Eren. *Then again, Captain Levi's very short and skinny for a man and he's by far the strongest person I know.* She looked over at the teens, apparently used to seeing such a display and teasing Eren about it.

Levi wondered if their abnormal strength was something he could use as evidence to prove to her their potential blood relation. While he doubted she'd think he was lying about having experienced the

same moment they all saw she had before killing the man strangling Eren, it was still undeniable proof.

"So, are you going to tell her?" Hange snapped him out of his thoughts. "About your theory about the two of being cousins or something."

"Maybe. I wanna wait for season two. There might be more clues."

" Umm…"

Eren and Mikasa turned to see Jean's mother.

" Is Little Jean—"

They snickered.

"Oh shut up, like your moms never had any embarrassing nicknames for you!"

Envy stung Christa but she ignored the feeling. Her mother had names for her, but none stemming from endearment and maternal love.

" I mean, is Jean Kirstein around here?" His mother asked, a basket in her arm.

Inside the mess hall, Jean sat at the table, across from Annie. *The battle begins tonight. I need even better ingredients in order to beat Potato Girl's meat!* He brought his hand up to his head, the action causing his mug to spill. With a small huff, he straightened it.

" Is Jean Kirstein here?" A Garrison soldier asked.

Jean approached the man standing at the small platform at the end of the stairs. "Yes, sir, that's me!"

" Your mother is here to see you."

" Huh?" Jean said, surprised and embarrassed.

" Little Jean!"

"Are you assholes seriously gonna giggle every time she says that?!"

"Yup!"

"That's right!"

" Why didn't you come home, Little Jean?" His mother walked to him, speaking worriedly. "Even Thomas, from the Wagner family, made sure to visit!" Her voice carried out across the mess hall as everyone fell silent and listened.

Jean looked mortified as trainees around them mumbled and some chuckled.

"This is giving me secondhand embarrassment."

"Just remember it's Jean and enjoy."

"Screw you, jerks."

" You're such a problem child. Did you spill soup or something on yourself? You're hopeless." Jean's mother pulled out a handkerchief and attempted to dab the wet stain near his crotch, inciting more laughter.

It was at this point the group collectively lost it.

Jean slithered down the couch again, face red. *I should've known Candy would show this!* He hadn't thought that scene could've ever gotten any worse. *I was wrong!* Now he had his superiors and elite soldiers watching him be made a fool of and act like a total jackass in return.

" Stop that!" Jean yelled. The mess hall was completely quiet.

" But Jean—"

" Just go home already!" He pushed her back, Eren standing a few feet behind her.

She turned to Eren and pulled out an apple. She began placing them on the table, "These are for everyone."

" We don't need them!" He knocked them off.

"I'd be dying of embarrassment too but you didn't need to be such a prick about it."

" Jean!" Eren said and bent to pick them up.

" Little Jean!" His mother said. "Everyone!" She looked around. "He's a little rough around the edges, but please be nice to him!"

What I wouldn't give to be in his place . Eren paused and reconsidered that thought. Maybe not exactly like that. Eren couldn't help but smile, picturing it. Instead of fussing, his mother would have chewed him out good for not visiting and probably yanked his ear like a naughty kid.

Apples in his hands, Eren stood next to Mikasa. Jean's mother reached into her basket. "That reminds me, Jean, I brought your favorite—"

" Just freaking go home!"

The door slammed shut.

Jean stood before it at the top of the stairs, breathing deeply.

" You should be nice to your mom, Little Jean," Eren said. Jean growled at him. "I mean, Jean."

"As embarrassing as it was, you made it worse by acting like such a jerk."

"Yeah, yeah, I know."

A palm opened to reveal a small golden key.

"So there's a key involved here, too?" Erwin smiled.

Armin stared at it, shocked and horrified. "Are you serious, Jean?"

There was a manic look in Jean's eyes. "I hear they've got beef in the officers' storeroom. I'll make use of that." Annie stood next to him, hands on her hips.

Armin took a few steps back, stuttering, "No way! I can't steal! I've always been clumsy!" He looked like he was having a mental break. "I've always placed last in races. Even when we played hide-and-seek I couldn't hold my laughter in!"

" Armin…" Jean said.

Mikasa gasped, "You broke him!"

" And you expect me to steal?" Armin turned and ran away. "I can't do it!"

The group started giggling.

" Hey, where are you going?"

In a panic, Armin ran up the stairs. His foot slipped and he landed on his shins. He lay on his back, screaming loudly, spittle erupting from his mouth.

They couldn't suppress their laughter at his hilarious freak-out.

"I know...we shouldn't be laughing," Petra's shoulders were shaking badly, hands covering her mouth.

"But it's so funny!" Ymir laughed.

Christa nodded, giggling, "We need more Armin and Jean comedy!"

Two heavily bandaged legs appeared. "I'm sorry, Jean." Armin lay in a bed, Jean sitting on a bench beside him while Annie leaned against the wall. "I don't think I can help you with my body in this state."

Annie pushed off the wall and walked to the center of the room. "Count me out too. I can't risk being branded as a thief."

" But I thought you wanted to join the Military Police too, Annie!"

" I'm sorry." She left.

Jean watched her leave, unable to do anything. Then his eyebrows furrowed into a look of resolution.

"You're not really going to steal, are you?" Petra asked.

"You'll see."

I need beef.* Jean walked down the hallway, a hand on the wall. *I need the best beef if I'm going to beat Potato Girl.* He continued to wall down the long corridor full of torches. *I am a desperate man who will use any means necessary in order to win! I'm not incompetent Little Jean anymore!

He peeked around the corner. Two Garrison soldiers walked by, laughing. It seemed to make him lose his nerve.

" Kirstein!" The voice startled him. Jean stood ramrod straight as a Garrison officer came over. "I've been looking all over for you." He held up a small package in a red cloth. "Your mom asked me to give this to you." Jean accepted it. "What are you doing all the way down here?"

" Umm… The bathroom."

" What are you saying? The bathroom's *that* way," he jerked his thumb over his shoulder.

Birds flew in the golden-orange sky with thick, fluffy clouds drifting by. Jean crouched outside by a pillar and unfolded the note from his mom.

" Dear Little Jean,"* his mother's voice narrated. *"Eat this and keep working hard. Don't cause too much trouble for everyone, okay? Love, Mom."

He crumbled up the paper and stuck in his jacket's inner pocket.

"Good, I thought you were about to throw it away."

"I wasn't *that* much of a dick, Christa."

Jean opened the package, eyes widening in surprise. The ovular box held an omelet with some vegetables packed next to it.

A flashback appeared.

A toddler Jean sat the table, knife and fork in hands, chanting happily, "Omelet! Omelet!"

"Aww..."

"How cute!"

"You look so adorable!"

His mother walked over, plate in hand, "Yes, it's ready. You really like omelets, huh, Little Jean?" She placed the plate before him and the toddler Jean smiled toothily.

"Look at those little chubby cheeks!"

"I could eat you up!"

" I can't understand if you're crying, Little Jean."

An older Jean, still a kid, stood in the doorway of his house, stains over his clothes.

His mother knelt, wiping his tears with a handkerchief, "Tell me what happened."

"Wow, your face is so fat!"

"Did you get stung by bees? Is why it's so swollen and you're crying?"

"You look kinda like an eggplant!"

"I hate you guys."

Jean, now a preteen, carried a tray to the bed where his mother lay, coughing. "How are you feeling? Do you think you can eat?"

She sat up and accepted the tray, "Thank you. You're such a sweet child." Jean looked down, embarrassed.

"That's so sweet," Petra grinned at this blushing face.

"You're really not so bad, huh, Horse-Face," Eren said.

"Taking care of your mother when she's sick, such a good son!" Christa cooed.

"Still secretly a mama's boy at heart, aren't you?" Sasha teased.

The flashback ended. Jean stared down at the omelet and said emotionally, "Mom."

Hange smiled, "Even now your mom is still watching over you."

"She just stopped you from stealing and gave you a chance at winning the competition," Erwin pointed out.

"Moms are the best," Jean said, smiling widely.

"Yes," Eren said, "they really are." He wasn't the only one missing his parents just then.

Armin and Mikasa were smiling sadly beside him while Ymir and Christa wondered, not for the first time, what it was like have and miss loving parents.

Meanwhile, Sasha planned a trip home to visit her father the next time she had time off. *It's been a while since we went hunting together* . She was excited to tell him how his lessons had helped her and her friends out in a bad situation.

We're really lucky, me and Jean, we have both our parents who love us so much. Connie thought. It really made him appreciate his own mom and dad more.

"You know," Jean said casually, "you're welcome to come with me the next time I go home and try the omelet yourself."

"Really? Can we?"

"I still gotta face my parents about joining the Survey Corps. Just so you know, that's the *only* reason I'm inviting you guys so you can act like a buffer, okay?"

"I'm down!"

"Sounds like fun!"

"Thanks—"

"But no calling me Horse-Face in my own house!"

Flames erupted across the screen and the competition was off with a fiery start.

Jean cooked, letting out a battle cry. Armin watched, on crutches, while Annie held plates in her hands.

" Meat!" Sasha screamed, pieces of meat flying, large knives in each hand. Connie was studying vegetables as Reiner cut the meat.

On the side, away from the dramatic cooking match, Mikasa trained.

"I have never seen anyone so dramatic over something so ridiculous," Levi muttered.

Hange was too amused by the cooking battle on TV to point out Levi's own dramatic obsession with something as mundane as cleaning.

Jean continued to scream and Mikasa did crunches.

Connie and Jean blushed at that last shot.

Sasha was sweating, "Meat!"

Sweat flew off Mikasa's body and she finished shadow boxing.

Lit torches provided them with light as the sun had set and night fell. Trainees were gathered at the same courtyard where Erwin had delivered his speech to potential recruits. Up on the stage, Jean, Armin, and Annie stood on the left with Sasha, Connie, and Reiner across the stage from them. Before each trio was a cart with a covered dish.

" Hm," Pixis looked between them. "Looks like you both brought your best skills to the table!" There was a wine glass and a bottle on the table in front of the commander.

To Pixis's left stood Keith Shadis. "The cooking competition between 104th Training Corp members, Jean Kirstein and Sasha Blouse, will now commence!"

The trainees cheered loudly.

"Pffft! Cooking competition! Shadis must be dying inside!" Ymir said.

"I'm impressed he managed to keep his face straight," Erwin nodded. He half expected his former commander to make a disgusted face at the notion of his trainees cooking it out.

" Starting things off is Sasha Blouse!"

" Yes, sir!" Sasha wheeled the cart over and placed the dish on the table. "Here you are!" Steam rose from the steak as she lifted the cover.

" Huh?" Pixis looked down at the juicy piece of meat.

" Whoa!"

" Meat!"

" That's meat!"

" What kind of meat is it?"

" That looks delicious!"

Feeling hungry, everyone reached for the food on the table as they watched.

Jean and Armin seemed to be feeling the pressure and Jean tightened his grip on the cart.

" Let's put it to the test." Pixis cut up the meat and took a bite. His eyes flew open and his body began trembling. Anka reached out, unsure of what was going on. The ground began to shake.

"Hey, what's going on?" Hange asked.

" Commander," Gustav called out.

The shaking grew stronger and the trainees began mumbling in confusion and panic. "What's that?"

Fissures appeared around the table.

"I don't remember this happening."

"I don't either."

"What's going on?"

"I think we're seeing what went through the Commander's head, maybe," Armin said.

"You think so? Damn, Candy's great."

" It's… It's…" Pixis's eyes grew red and he shot up to the sky like a rocket. "It's delicious!"

They all stared, mouths open.

Pixis flew around and dodged two Titans. "Is this boar meat? It's boar meat, right?" He took out two Titans with his 3D gear.

"Such fine texture!" A Titan attempted to grab him but he flew over it and reached its nape, killing it. "The more you chew the tastier it gets!" Pixis flew toward the moon, there was a bright light, and he landed on two houses, crushing them.

"What the fuck!" Ymir started to lose it.

Connie began laughing. "Is he a Titan now? He's huge!"

Christa snorted, giggling, "Eating a colossal boar turned him colossal-sized!"

Pixis took out a flask and drank. "The alcohol removed the smell of the wild animal, and only the delicious taste of meat remains!" He ran toward five trainees standing on the roof.

Levi's mouth was slightly open, a hilariously stunned expression on his face.

Mikasa, Jean, Armin, Christa, and Connie brought up their hands. "Leave it to us!" Connie declared, biting his hand.

Five Titans appeared on the screen.

Erwin paused, knowing what was coming.

"Look at Mikasa's Titan! Like a buffer version of Eren with Mikasa's face!"

"That's not cool!"

"Check out Connie!"

"Why am I so tiny?!"

"You're like a little frog in comparison!"

"Dude, Armin, your head is *huge* !"

"At least he doesn't look like he's dying! What was fuck's with my Titan?!"

"I don't know, Jean, seems fitting to me!"

"Christa looks the BEST!"

"So beautiful with golden hair and pure white wings! Truly betting the 104th Class's Goddess!"

"It's Pixis's dream Titan girl!"

"She can eat me anytime!"

"Oh stop! You guys are embarrassing me!"

"At least you don't look like a man."

"I wonder what my Titan-self looks like," Petra thought out loud.

Hange wailed loudly, "I wanna see my Titan form too!"

Erwin whistled loudly. "Alright, everyone, settle down now."

They took deep breaths, faces flushed from laughter and wide smiles, eager to see more.

Christa's Titan's eyes glowed brightly, beautiful shades of blue and white, sending Titan-Pixis flying back. *"I have…never had…"* Pixis was floating above the moon, asteroids hovering around. There was another planet past the moon and the sun shining in the distance. *"…such good alcohol…before!"*

White light filled the screen.

"...Damn, that's some potent shit," Levi said.

Pixis stared, eyes wide open, frozen, while everyone watched worriedly.

" What's wrong?"

" He hasn't moved an inch!"

" What in the world?"

Connie spoke up, "Look at that! He's in a peace of mind state!"

" We can win this," Reiner said.

" It's your turn now, Jean," Sasha said loudly.

Jean and Armin exchanged a nod. He wheeled his dish over. Pixis watched him place it before him. "Here you are." The omelet was revealed.

Pixis looked down, "Hm?"

Sasha and Connie stared, surprised.

" What is that?"

" An omelet?"

" He's trying to win with that?"

" Oh, this is pretty cute," Pixis said.

" Please. Try it, sir," Jean said.

They watch tensely as the commander ate. Once the omelet was finished, Pixis sighed, wiping his mouth with a cloth.

"What? No crazy over-the-top reaction?" Hange was disappointed. "That's not looking good Jean."

"Your faith in me is astounding."

" The commander isn't saying anything," Connie said.

" That means we've won," Reiner said.

" Yes!" Sasha smiled confidently. "Nothing in this world is tastier than meat!"

Pixis stood. "I will now announce the result. In this cooking contest," Jean's team was looking serious while Sasha's team appeared confident, "the winner is Jean Kirstein!"

Sasha, Connie, and Reiner stared in shocked disbelief while the rest of the trainees broke out into cheers, some hugging each other.

"I bet on him!" Hange declared loudly. "I knew he'd win!"

"Sure," Jean said, "I'll just pretend you weren't doubting me ten seconds ago."

"Your mom's omelet won out in the end!" Petra said.

"Yeah, it did," he said happily.

" Jean won!"

" He won against meat with an omelet!"

" Traditional house cooking wins!"

Armin placed his hand on Jean's shoulder, who was still frozen and gave him a thumbs up. Sasha ran over to the table, slamming her hands on it. "I can't accept this! Why? Why did meat lose?"

" Tell me, young trainee. What exactly is meat?"

" Meat is meat!"

" That's right. Meat is meat." Pixis had a prominent blush on his face. "It is nothing more than that." The sun rose over the Wall.

"Meat is just meat." Sunlight fell across his face. "That is why you lost."

Tear poured out of Sasha's eyes and she fell to her knees, crying, "I'm so embarrassed."

" That made sense to her?" Reiner muttered.

"Anyone else not get it either?"

Everyone aside from Sasha shook their heads.

"I'm surprised you don't, Four-Eyes. This kind of lunacy seems right up your street."

"I understand the passion but not my area of expertise."

Pixis smiled dazedly at the sunlight as Sasha talked. "I completely forgot about the potatoes and carrots I had until now, and tried to win just cooking meat." The commander left and she cried into the tablecloth.

"You forgot to add your signature potatoes?" Petra teased. "I'm shocked."

"It's a part of your identity. How could you forget?" Hange grinned.

"Now even the veterans are mocking me," Sasha whined.

" You don't need to be embarrassed." Jean held out his hand, a serene look on his face.

"What's with that stupid face?"

"You're a stupid face, stupid face."

" You're not the only one who did nothing but roast."

" I'm sorry, Jean." Sasha placed her hand in his.

" No problem," Jean clutched her hand.

Pixis walked, flanked by Anka and Gustav. "When you eat that late at night, you get sick in the morning. Compared to that, that omelet…"

They leaned forward, wondering how his reaction to Jean's omelet would compare to Sasha's boar meat.

" Leaving the taste aside, it was a great late night snack."

Confusion covered their faces.

"What's he mean?" Jean asked. "It wasn't that good?"

"Why didn't Sasha win then?" Christa asked.

"This is confusing," Connie shok.

"I bet he was just shit-faced drunk the entire time."

Mikasa nodded. "Ymir's probably right."

The sun was shining brightly. Jean stood before Sasha, with Connie and Reiner smiling behind her. Jean looked off into the sky, the same peaceful smile on his face. *Maybe I'll go see how my folks are dong at home tomorrow.*

Jean's mother stopped knitting and looked up, smiling.

On Jean's bunk, next to his pillow, an apple lay on the note from his mom.

"It's over."

"I can't wait to get out of here!"

"Me too, I need some fresh air!"

"I'm going straight to bed."

They stretched.

On the TV, the screen switched to black and white letters appeared as Candy spoke, ***"Congratulations! You've reached the end! Hoped you had fun and took lots of notes."***

"That I did," Hange patted her notebook.

" The door's now open but you've got about ten more minutes so feel free to stick around a little while longer. You'll get your invitations for season two within two days. Until then, relax and think about everything that has come to light and how you wish to proceed with the knowledge you have been given. Candy, over and out!"

"I know I'm beating a dead horse," Erwin said, "but I will say it anyway: Don't tell anyone about this." Everyone nodded. "The TV is our greatest weapon," he pointed to the flatscreen device and they eyed it reverently. "We can't risk its existence getting out under any cost."

"What do you think we'll see in season two?"

"I don't know! But I'm excited!"

"No matter what happens, we'll be better prepared!"

"I hope I don't die. That'd suck!"

"If I die it better be epic."

"I remember the other two Titan-Shifters," Ymir said casually. She thought they'd talk over her up but everyone shut up at once and focused their attention on her. "I don't know what kind of mojo Candy performed but it's impressive." Suddenly a strange look crossed her face. Her eyes snapped to Eren.

He tensed. "What?"

"Give us the main points, we can go into details tomorrow," Erwin said.

"Well, one of the Titans is the Cartman, her name's Pieck. It's the non-fighting type I mentioned but she's highly intelligent. Not someone you want to underestimate."

Hange added that to her notes under a section titled Titan-Shifters. Every scrap of info was valuable. "Go on."

"The other one, he's one of the strongest Shifters. It's called the Beast Titan and..."

"C'mon, out with it," Levi said impatiently.

"His name's Zeke Yeager."

Eren's eyes nearly bulged out of their sockets. "What?!"

"Are you saying they're related?" Mikasa asked.

"I'm not saying that," Ymir said. "But... Holy shit, he looks a lot like your dad." There was gonna be lots of family drama in Eren's future, she thought.

"If Eren's father is from outside the Walls, it makes sense," Erwin nodded.

"The question is where he got the Attack Titan's power—that's your Titan's name, by the way," Ymir told her fellow Shifter.

"And why he came here," Petra added.

"I don't know about him but Reiner and the others, their mission was to find something called the Coordinate, whatever that is."

While they began brainstorming, Eren was lost in his thoughts. *I have a brother? Or an uncle?* Why hadn't his father ever told him? *He kept so many things hidden. Dumped all this Titan-Shifter shit on me without any warning. And I'll never know why.* He thought bitterly. *Unless...* Unless the answers were in the basement. His father had promised him. Eren itched to run out, transform, and make his way home, needing those answers. *I have to be patient.* Candy might reveal everything in the upcoming future episodes.

"You can *what* ?!" Jean said loudly.

Armin looked equally shocked. "Why didn't you tell us?"

"Well, actually, I already told them," Ymir jerked her thumb to the side, pointing to their superiors.

"Yes, Ymir told Petra and Eren who told us her Titan, the Jaw Titan, can destroy the Titan armor utilized by Reiner and Annie," Hange said.

"Then," Christa gasped, "that means she has the power to take down the Armored Titan!"

"That's correct," Erwin nodded. "We plan to have Ymir take him down while Eren will defeat the Female Titan and Levi and his squad will bring down the Colossal." He wouldn't yet mention about using any Titan-creating serum they may find in Eren's basement and use it to get any Titan-Shifters' power to their own side, if possible.

"So, who's the ninth Titan-Shifter?" Petra said.

Ymir shrugged, "That even I don't know anything about. I don't know it it's cause Marcel doesn't either or Candy's holding it back." Though

she was sure there was quite a bit more still buried in her mind and had yet to surface. "But it's someone on the island."

"It's gotta be a member of the royal family, right?" Armin said.

"You are probably right," Erwin agreed. He had quite a few thoughts regarding that subject. "But we can't do anything about that yet. Hopefully season two will provide us with more clues. Give us a better idea on how to proceed."

"More future episodes!" Christa gushed.

"This is so great!" Connie couldn't wait. As nerve-wracking as it was —What if they had to watch more of their friends and comrades die? —he was also pumped to see more.

"It certainly feels like we're going to beat the odds, thanks to Candy and the TV," Mikasa nodded, feeling a rush of optimism.

"Don't leave me alone with *them* ," Connie told Jean and Armin. "I don't know if I'll be able to keep them from getting suspicious."

Eren was glad he would be staying with his squad, leaving little to no interaction with Reiner and Bert. He wouldn't do anything rash but he'd rather not risk it.

Sasha nodded, "I don't trust my acting skills either."

"Is that so," Levi spoke up. "Lucky for you, I've been meaning to clean up this floor, I'm happy to hear you two volunteer." Their faces fell a little at that. "Any other volunteers?"

"Count me in," Jean said.

"Me, too," Armin nodded.

"I think I'll join to you guys," Christa said.

"So will I." Mikasa shrugged. "I can keep a decent poker face." An understatement, they all thought. "But I'd rather spend the time with you guys."

"I'll have you all assigned chores separate from them. You'll only see them before turning in for the night," Erwin said.

"What about me?" Ymir asked. "How to explain my suddenly hanging out with Squad Levi?"

"That's right! You two promised me a ride!" Hange said, thrilled.

"I'll think of something. And I'll need to know your ring sizes so you can carry a tiny, concealed weapon." Eren and Ymir nodded. "Well, I think that should be everything." Erwin stood, "I guess it's time we left." The others followed his lead.

"After watching the future episodes, we should have a better idea on how to proceed with the 57th Expedition and the following battle in Stohess," Levi said. "Depending on what happens in season two will also determine what to do with the squad," he told Petra and Eren.

"I have a feeling we're getting sidelined. But," she sighed, "we can't risk disrupting the future too much."

"What can we do to get the others temporarily out of the picture?" Eren wondered.

"I have this concoction that can give you food poisoning," Hange said.

"You mean your cooking?" Levi jibed.

"We can slip the squad some after the 57th and before the battle for Stohess."

"Okay but I'm not eating it. I'll just pretend to get sick. What about after that?" Petra asked.

"We'll deal with that when we get there," Levi said.

Erwin was about to close the door when Connie and Sasha suddenly yelled, "Stop!"

"Wait just a minute, please, Commander," Sasha said.

Then the two dashed back inside and loaded their arms up with food.

"Unbelievable," Jean rolled his eyes while the others giggled at their antics.

"Okay," Connie said as they emerged, grinning, arms full of food. "We're good."

Petra : Is returning for season 2

Curse of Ymir: Will be revealed in season 2

Lost Girls : After the season 2 main episodes

Season 3 : One or two pricks aside, you guys were so wonderfully sweet and supportive I decided to give myself 6 months to rest up after I finish PoS II and *consider* season 3. If I don't feel up to it they'll at least react to the trailer **Power to Strive II:** Back to once-a-month updates. First chapter will be up October 21. I'll let you guys know here when it's uploaded **Until Next Time!**